

The Age of Dubhan

LINN AN DUBHAIN

The Legendarium of Dia-tìr

— The Age of Dubhan

(An Aois Dhubhain)

being the Books of the age, the Annals of its years,
a Gazetteer of its towns, and the Appendices
the Dubhan Era, DE 1 – 27

Dubh an gual, 's dubh an dubhan, / ach cò leis an teine?

Black the coal, and black the dubhan; / but whose is the fire?

a rhyme of the Tuathaich north

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CHAPTER ONE

Of the Fire Banked in the North

DE 1

Part One • Of the Fire in the North and the Five Lights

Loiscidh e, tha faileadh dheth, agus chan e gual a th' ann. It burns, it
stinks, and it is not coal.

— the surveyors of Comhairle nam Mèinnean, DE 2

I

Of the Night near Midsummer

So the old people of the north tell it, in both their tongues, and they tell it the same way at the harbour wall of Caol mhòr and at the hearths of the hill farms: there was a man who had failed for ten years.

Every season had seen him fail. He had tried the spoil that the pits tip down the hillsides, the grey waste that will not burn for the stone in it, and the black slurry that settles in the sumps, and the dust swept up from the floors of the coal-sheds. These things he had boiled and dried, pressed them and baked them, mixed them with this and with that, with things the tellers do not name because they do not know them. Most of what he made would not light. What would light went out, or smoked a room blind, or cracked in the fire and threw its sparks across the floor. The tellers give no count of his trials. They say only that for years nobody thought to ask how the work went, because the answer was always the same.

Nobody in the south knew his name that summer. Nobody at Cathair dhearg was watching him, and the clerks of Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹, who counted

every sack that came up out of the vein, had no line for what went down the tip. His name was Dubhan. His people were the Tuathaich, whom An Dealachadh² had pushed to the island's northern edge, and the coal had never been theirs to inherit. What he had to work with was what the kingdom threw away.

The summer of that year came in dry and dear. In the north, at midsummer, the sky never goes wholly dark: the light goes down behind the hills in the north-west, and it runs along under the rim of the world as a green-grey band, and it comes up again in the north-east before a man has properly slept. On such a night, near the longest day, he banked his fire for the night as he had banked it on a hundred nights before. He set his crucible in the heart of it, packed with pit waste, and covered the whole with ash and turves so that it would burn low and long. Then he lay down beside it and slept.

That is all the telling gives of the night. There is no speech in it. The tellers do not say what he hoped, and they will not guess.

In the morning he raked the ash away. The crucible had not cracked. In it, where the waste had been, lay a cake of something black and close-grained and heavy for its size, with a dull skin on it like the bloom on a sloe. He broke it with a hammer on the hearthstone, and it broke clean. He laid a piece of it on the embers.

It took the fire slowly, the way good coal takes it, and it burned with a low red heat and a thick yellow smoke that stank of tar and bad eggs. There was no cracking and no spitting. At last it fell to a fine grey ash, and the ash was cold before the man had moved from where he knelt.

So, the tellers say, he broke another piece and laid it on, and watched that burn too.

The north keeps the day as the day the fire came. The years of this age are counted from that morning, which was 19 an t-Ògmhios, DE 1. It was a rough thing, what lay in the crucible, and it was no trade and no wealth to anyone. Nobody bought it or sold it. It was one man's answer to a need that the people who ruled the island had not yet looked in the face. In the north they still say of a thing that works at last after long failing, *thàinig an teine*, the fire came, and a child who is slow to walk and then walks is said to have banked his fire.

1. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

2. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

II

Of the Dry Summer and the Fourth Floor

Of the kingdom as it stood that summer its own record has a great deal to say, and none of it is cheerful.

Mairead reigned at Cathair dhearg. She had come to the throne heir to a kingdom whose wealth was plainly running out, and the running-out had not stopped for her crowning. The lowest galleries of An Sloc Mòr¹ lay under water, because the pumps cost more to run than the coal beneath them was worth; the minute of Comhairle nam Mèinnean² called it a pause, and the pause was now in its tenth year. The yield of the upper galleries fell each quarter by a little. Its clerks entered the little in a firm hand.

Coal-fuel was dear everywhere. At Fèill Muileann òg³ its price had doubled in the autumn before, and the court of the fair had fixed a ceiling it could not hold. All that summer the dealers sold above it, and the court fined them, and the dealers paid the fines and put them on the price. At Cnoc fhiadhaich, in the pit country, the households still went up onto the spoil-heaps at dusk with baskets to pick out the black among the grey, and the watchmen posted there, being men of the town, still saw nothing.

In the capital the street-lamps that the humans had set up, which had burned coal since they were raised, were lit later in the evening that year and put out earlier in the night, and the lamp-men lit fewer of them in the lanes behind the fish-quays and under the walls. The poorer streets were darker than they had been in the memory of anyone living in them. People who had to go out after dark in those streets went in twos.

At Achadh dhomhain, where Comann nan Gualadairean⁴ kept its hall, the day of binding came round in the spring as it always had, and the masters sat in their places in the long room with the oath-stone on the table in front of them, and no family brought a son or a daughter to be bound. It had happened first in the year of Mairead's crowning, and in more years since than not. That first year the masters had waited until noon. This year they waited an hour, and then the

1. the great pit at the mountain

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

3. the fair at Muileann òg

4. the Guild of Hewers; lit. 'the fellowship of the colliers'

clerk wrote the day into the book with nothing under it, and the masters went home.

The census had been published seven years before, openly, for the first time in the kingdom's history. It had changed nothing in the frame of things, except that the north now knew in print what it had known already.

In the north, Tional nan Tuathach⁵ sat at Caol mhòr under Daniel Frayne, as it had sat under one speaker or another since the first years after An Dealachadh⁶, with no standing in any court of the kingdom and minute-books that ran unbroken from its first wet evening. It met that summer on its usual days. Its minutes speak of the herring, of the wool, of a roof at the school at Doire ghlas and of the price of coal. They say nothing of any fire in any crucible, because nobody had yet brought word of one to Caol mhòr.

And at Muileann chaol, in the eastern hills, the record of all these things was kept.

Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁷ stands above the river on the edge of the narrow mill town that has lived on it since the new kingdom was young. The old building, where the keeper and the chronicler have their rooms, is of the grey hill stone, with small windows and deep sills. The new wing, raised when the shires' chests were called in, is of stone from An Sloc Mòr, and it is darker, and it has four floors.

The shires' chests filled three of them. The fourth was empty. It had been left for what had not been sent, and in the summer of that year it was still waiting.

Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh, who was Seanchaidh na Rìoghachd⁸ and had been since Tormod Pinn died at his desk, worked in the old building on the side that looked over the river. She was a woman of some fifty years that summer, small and straight, with ink in the creases of her right hand that no soap had moved in twenty years. The room had been Tormod Pinn's and still had his chair in it, which she did not use, and his inkstand, which she did. From her window she could see the paper-mill's wheel turning in the race, and beyond it, a mile down the valley, the ford at Àth dhomhain, where every reader bound for an Leabharlann⁹ crossed.

5. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

6. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

7. the Library at Muileann chaol

8. the royal chronicler

9. the Library at Muileann chaol

It was her habit, and she had made it the office's habit, to write at the foot of each year a note of what the year had kept from her. Her first such note had been about the census. The census clerks in the northern shires had been given their figures and had not counted them, and the figures they had been given were the figures of Tional nan Tuathach. The kingdom's first honest census had been honest in the north because the Tuathaich had done the counting for it. She had written that down in plain words, and nobody in the council had written to her about it, which she took for leave to go on.

In the months of that summer she was doing the thing that a chronicler does most of the time, which is reading. The shires' chests had come in over half a dozen years, and the copyists had been at the work of listing them ever since. That summer they finished the last of the lists. Ailig mac Thormoid, the eldest of the copyists, a thin man with a cough he blamed on the new wing's dust, brought her the tally on a single sheet in the second week of an t-Iuchar.

"One thousand and six chests," he said. "Every shire has sent something, except the ones that haven't."

"And the one that burned its chest in the yard."

"We've put Seann Tarr down as sent, keeper's orders. Sent to the fire." He laid the sheet on her desk. "The fourth floor is as it was."

She went up with him that afternoon, because she had not been up there since the spring. The stair in the new wing was steep and the treads were still sharp at the edges. On the first three floors the chests stood in their rows with their shire marks painted on the lids, and the air smelt of dry wood and old paper and a little of mice. On the fourth floor there was nothing. The windows had shutters and the shutters were closed, and the light came through their slats in bars across a floor that had been swept and had nothing on it to sweep. Their feet were loud on the boards.

"Mòrag used to say we would fill it in her lifetime," Ailig said.

"Mòrag used to say a great many things." Beathag walked the length of the room to the far wall and back. Nothing had been sent from the north. The minute-books of Tional nan Tuathach were at Caol mhòr, and the schools' registers were in the schools, and the vigil-books of Baile chrom were wherever the people of Baile chrom kept them, and no one had asked for any of them. That was the fourth floor, and the kingdom had built it on purpose. She had understood that from the first, and it still made her tired to stand in it.

On the way down Ailig said, "The carriers are late this week."

"The carriers are late every week."

"They say it's the price of fodder. Everything's the price of something."

III

Of the Carrier's Word

Dòmhnall mac Ailein carried on the library road. He brought up paper and ink and lamp-oil from the landing at Ceann dhomhain, and the letters of the capital, and in winter the ration of coal for an Leabharlann¹, which grew smaller every year and dearer every quarter. He was a big slow man with a big slow horse, and he had been bringing things up the hill to Muileann chaol for longer than Beathag had been chronicler. Talk came out of him while he unloaded, and nobody at an Leabharlann had ever found a way to stop it.

It was he who first brought the word, on a hot afternoon in an Lùnastal, while he stacked reams against the wall of the yard.

"There's a thing in the north," he said, "that the Tuathaich have got hold of."

Beathag was in the yard because the carrier's cart was the nearest thing to news that came up the hill, and she had learnt long before to be there when it did. "What sort of thing?"

"A fire out of spoil." He set a ream down and straightened his back. "Out of the tip. I had it off a drover at the landing, and he had it off a boatman who'd been up the coast. There's a man up there, a Tuathach, has made a fuel out of what the pits throw away, and it burns."

"Everything burns if you put enough under it."

"That's what I said." He looked pleased at the agreement. "But the drover said no, it burns on its own, like coal. Stinks worse than a tannery, he said, but it burns."

"Who is the man?"

Dòmhnall thought about it. He was an honest carrier, which meant that he did not like to give a thing he had not been given. "The drover had a name for him. Dubhan, he said, or near it. It might have been Dubhain. The boatman said it one way and the drover another, and I've said it both ways since, so I couldn't swear."

1. the Library at Muileann chaol

"And where in the north?"

"The drover didn't know. The boatman had it from Caol mhòr, where some pedlar had a cake of the stuff on the market, but that's only where the boats are." He lifted another ream. "They'll tell you anything, the Tuathaich, in their own tongue, and nothing in ours. Or the other way about. I never know which."

She wrote it down that evening in her day-book, which was her own and not the kingdom's: *Dòmhnall mac Ailein: a fuel of the north made from pit waste, said to burn like coal. A man's name given with it, Dubhan or Dubhain. From a drover, from a boatman, from Caol mhòr.* She looked at it a good while, then underlined *from* three times, and went to bed.

The next week she asked Dòmhnall whether he had heard any more. He had not. The week after, he had heard that the fuel was made of tar, which she did not believe, and the week after that, that it was a trick of the Tuathaich to sell their spoil to fools, which she believed less. By the end of an Lùnastal the story had come up the library road four or five times in different mouths, and in every mouth it was a little larger and no nearer.

She said as much to Raghannall mac Mhuirich, the keeper, when she met him in the yard at the end of the month. He was three years younger than she, a tall stooping man who had been Mòrag nic Coinnich's deputy for most of his working life and had become keeper the summer before. He was still getting used to the room, and he spent his days as he had always spent them, in the stacks with a pencil behind his ear.

"The carriers have a fuel in the north," she said. "Made of spoil."

"So I hear. Ailig told me. Ailig tells me everything, eventually." Raghannall took the pencil from behind his ear and looked at it, as if it might have news of its own. "Have you seen any?"

"No."

"Has anyone you trust seen any?"

"Dòmhnall mac Ailein trusts a drover who trusts a boatman."

"Then there's nothing to keep." He put the pencil back. "Beathag, if there is a fuel, someone will write it down. Comhairle nam Mèinnean² will write it down, or the court of the fair will write down that it was sold, or the Tuathaich will write it in their minute at Caol mhòr, and one day, if anyone sends the writing, it

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

will come here and we will keep it. That is what we are for. An Leabharlann keeps. It does not chase."

"I am not an Leabharlann," she said. "I am the chronicler."

"You are the chronicler in an Leabharlann." He said it kindly. "It comes to the same in the end, when the council reads the bills."

IV

Of the Pedlar at the Ford

The market of Muileann chaol is held in the yard of an Leabharlann¹, as it has been since the town was given its charter, and on the market day in the middle of an t-Sultain the yard was full of stalls under the chestnut trees: paper and pens and binders' thread, eggs and cheese from the hill farms, knives, pots, a man selling ribbons, a woman selling honey out of a crock with a spoon for tasting. The copyists came down from their tables to buy, because the market was the only day in the month when anyone came up the hill with anything but paper.

Beathag spent the morning at her desk with the shutters half closed against the sun, going through the letters of the northern maoir for the year, and she did not go down until the afternoon, when the stalls were being packed.

Ailig mac Thormoid met her at the foot of the stair. He had a slip of paper in his hand, one of the narrow slips the copyists use for marking a place in a chest, and he was excited, which was rare in him.

"There was a Tuathach at the market," he said. "A pedlar. Needles and pins and buttons, and a bit of lace from Doire ghlas. And he had a cake of the black stuff wrapped in sacking, the stuff Dòmhnall talks about."

"Where is he?"

"Gone. He went at noon. He was for the landing, he said, and the boats south." Ailig held out his slip. "He burned a piece of it for us, on the flagstone by the pump. He wanted a penny a look, and then he didn't, because everyone was looking anyway. I wrote down what he called it."

1. the Library at Muileann chaol

She took the slip. Ailig wrote a good copying hand and a poor hurried one, and this was the hurried one. It gave the name of the fuel, or of the man, it was not clear which, spelled a third way, different from both of Dòmhnall's.

"Is that how he said it?"

"That's how I heard it. He said it quick, in the northern way. I asked him to say it again and he said it again and it sounded different. Then he laughed and said we could call it what we liked, it'd burn the same."

"Did it burn?"

"It burned," Ailig said. "Slow. Red, with no colour at the edge, not like ours. And it stank." He wrinkled his nose at the memory of it. "The whole yard stank. The honey-woman packed up. The ash is still there by the pump, if you want it."

She went and looked at the ash. It was a small grey heap on the flagstone, fine as flour, and when she crouched and put her finger in it, it was cold and left a grey mark on her skin and nothing else. It smelt of old smoke. Anything in the world might have made it.

Then, because she was Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh, she put on her boots and went down the valley to the ford.

It is a mile from an Leabharlann to Àth dhomhain, downhill all the way, on a road that the carts have worn into two stony ruts with grass between them. The afternoon was warm, and the dust of the road came up round her skirts, and the river on her left ran low and brown between its stones after the dry summer. At the ford the ferryman's boy was sitting on the bank with his feet in the water. Yes, he said, a Tuathach had come down with a pack, round about noon. He had waded over, because he said the ferry was dear, and gone on along the far bank towards the landing at Ceann dhomhain. He'd have caught the evening boat if it went, and it went most evenings.

"Did he have anything with him? A black thing, wrapped in sacking?"

The boy shrugged. "He had a pack. I didn't look in it. You don't, with the Tuathaich." He considered her. "He gave me a button."

She stood on the bank for some time, looking at the far side of the ford, where the road went up between alders and out of sight. It was three miles to the landing and the boat would have gone. She was fifty years old and she had come down in her indoor boots. She turned and walked back up the hill to an Leabharlann, and it was dusk when she came into the yard, and someone had swept the ash from the flagstone by the pump.

V

Of the Letter to the Maor and the Foot of the Year

In the first week of an Dàmhair she wrote to the maor of Caol mhòr. She wrote it three times before she was satisfied, and the copy she kept is the third. It is a short letter and a correct one. It says that the chronicler of the kingdom has heard report, from carriers and from a pedlar of the north, of a fuel made from the waste of the pits, burning in the manner of coal; that the report names a man of the north, whose name is variously given; that she has not seen the fuel and can find no one who has seen it made; and that she would be grateful if the maor, or any clerk of his, could send her a piece of it by the carrier, with a line to say where it came from and who had made it, so that she might set down in the record what was true. She signed it with her name and her office, and sealed it with the office's seal, which was pressed with coal ink as every seal of the kingdom was, and gave it to Dòmhnall mac Ailein for the landing and the post north.

"Caol mhòr," Dòmhnall said, looking at the direction. "That's a long way for a letter to go and come back."

"It is sixty miles and more. A letter can do it in ten days."

"A letter can," he said. "An answer's another thing."

No answer came in ten days, or in twenty. At the end of an Dàmhair the rains came in from the west, the first of the autumn, and the library road went to mud, and for a week Dòmhnall's cart could not get up the last hill and the reams came up on a sledge. The coal for an Leabharlann¹ came up with them, the first of the winter's ration, and it was less than the year before and had cost the council more. Ragnall called the copyists together in the long room of the old building and told them that there would be no fire in the reading-room before the middle of an t-Samhain, and none after dark at all, and that anyone who wished to copy in the evenings could do it at home. Ailig coughed and said nothing. There had never been a fire in the stacks, and never a lamp, because of the old condition on the first loft of papers that nothing in it should be burned. The town had kept that condition when it had kept little else.

Beathag asked Dòmhnall each week whether there was a letter from the north for her, and each week he said there was not.

"They don't answer letters, up there," he said. "Not ours."

1. the Library at Muileann chaol

"The maor is the kingdom's man."

"Then he's a kingdom's man living among Tuathaich," Dòmhnall said. "And that's a man who has learnt not to answer letters."

In the middle of an t-Samhain she went to Ragnall. He was in his room, which had been Mòrag's, with a shawl round his shoulders and a book open on the desk in front of him, reading by the last of the daylight at the window. It was a little after three in the afternoon. He had not lit his lamp.

"I have had no answer from Caol mhòr," she said.

"I had not thought you would." He closed the book on his finger. "You want to write the fuel into the year."

"I want to write the year. The fuel is in it. Or the talk of the fuel is in it. I don't know which, and I don't know how to find out from here, and I don't know who else will, because Comhairle nam Mèinnean² has sent no one north and its clerks will not write down what they have not counted. If I leave it out, the year is short by a thing that half the carriers of the library road are talking about. If I put it in, I am putting in a drover's tale."

"You can leave it for next year. If it is real it will still be real."

"And if it is real, the record will begin a year late, and someone at this desk after me will want to know why."

Ragnall looked at her over the book and said nothing. The light was going out of the window behind him while they talked, and his face was growing hard to see.

"You will not write what you have not seen," he said.

"No."

"And you will not leave it out."

"No."

"Then you had better find a way to do both," he said. "It is your office, Beathag, not mine. I only keep the rooms." He opened the book again, though he could scarcely have read it in that light. "Write what you have. Write that it is what you have. That is what the note at the foot of the year is for, isn't it? You invented it. Use it."

She wrote the note on 21 an t-Samhain, DE 1.

That was the day the office closed the year's record, as it did every year a month before the shortest day, so that the copyists could make the fair copy for

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

the council before the roads closed. It was a still, grey day, and raw, with the smoke of the town lying flat in the valley and the mill-wheel stopped, because the dry year had left the race too low to turn it. By the middle of the afternoon the light in her window was gone. She lit her lamp early, an oil lamp with a glass chimney that had been Tormod Pinn's, and the room smelt of hot oil and of the damp coming through the shutters.

The year's record lay in front of her in its loose leaves, forty-one pages in her own hand. Mairead's reign, and the council's sittings, and the orders of Comhairle nam Mèinnean, and the price of coal-fuel at the fair and the ceiling unheld. The day of binding at Achadh dhomhain with nothing under it. The chests counted, one thousand and six, and the fourth floor empty. The watchmen at Cnoc fhiadhaich. The coal ration. The rains. It was a thin year, as the years had been thin for a long while, and every page of it was about something running out.

She turned to the foot of the last leaf, where the note would go, and sat a long time with the pen dry.

She had three spellings of the name, and she did not know which of them was right. There were Dòmhnall's two, as the drover said it and as the boatman said it, and there was Ailig's slip with the pedlar's word, written in a hurry by a man who had heard it said quick in the northern way. No letter had come from the maor. All else she had was a cold grey smear of ash that someone had swept away. She had not seen the fuel, and she had not seen it burn, and she had not spoken to anyone who had seen it made.

In the end she wrote two lines. The first says that a fuel made without the vein, from the waste of the pits, is reported out of the north this year, and that it is said to burn in the manner of coal, and it gives the name that goes with it as Dòmhnall's drover gave it, and then as his boatman gave it, and then, in the second line, as Ailig took it down from the pedlar at the pump. The second line says that the chronicler has not seen it.

Among the spellings she did not choose. She could not, and would not pretend to. All three she let stand side by side in the kingdom's record, the one word three ways in two lines, so that whoever came to the desk after her would know how the word had come up the hill: late, in pieces, by the mouths of carriers, with no one to vouch for it.

That is the first mention of dubhan in the royal record. There is no earlier one.

When she had written it she sat back and read the two lines over by the lamp, and then she read the whole leaf, and then she sanded it and laid it on the pile.

The lamp was smoking a little and she turned the wick down. Outside the window it was full dark, though it was not yet five o'clock, and down in the town the few lamps that were lit made yellow points in the valley, and past them nothing, all the way to the north.

She thought of Ragnall in the stacks saying that an Leabharlann keeps and does not chase, and of the ferryman's boy with his feet in the water, and of the pedlar going along the far bank of the ford between the alders with his pack on his back and the black cake in it wrapped in sacking. She thought that somewhere in the north, far past the reach of her letters, a man whose name she could not spell had made a fire that burned.

A chur san Leabharlann, they say on the island: to put a thing in an Leabharlann is to settle it. She had put this in, and it was not settled at all.

She left the lamp to burn down, which she never did, and went to bed.

CHAPTER TWO

Of the Two Surveyors

DE 2

I

Of the Order and the Northern Road

The order came down to Seumas mac Eachainn in the second week of an t-Sultain, in the drawing-room at Cathair mhòr where the surveyors of Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹ kept their tables, and it came folded twice under the seal of the mine office. He was twenty-four that summer and had been four years a surveyor. He had measured the flooding in the lowest galleries of An Sloc Mòr² with a weighted line and a lantern, and had written in his book, as he was told to write, that the water stood at a pause. In all his life he had never been north of the capital.

The order said that it was reported from the north that a fuel was being made without the vein, and burned; that two of its surveyors should go into the Tuath-aich country and learn whether it burned as men said; and that they should report under their hands to Comhairle nam Mèinnean at Cathair mhòr and, by a fair copy, to the council's clerk at Cathair dhearg. It was signed by the master of Comhairle nam Mèinnean and countersigned by a clerk of Comhairle na Rìoghachd³, and that second name was what made the older surveyors look up from their tables when Seumas read it out.

"The council wants it," said Iain Ruadh mac Nèill. "Then the council can wait for it."

1. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

2. the great pit at the mountain

3. the royal council of twelve

Iain Ruadh was the other surveyor named. He was fifty-seven, and the red that had given him his name had gone the colour of wet sand, except in his eyebrows, which still stood out on his face like two coals in ash. He had been a surveyor since before Seumas was born. In his time he had gone down every open shaft on the mountain and some that were not open, and he held that there was nothing on the island that could be learned about fire that the mountain had not already taught.

"It is pit waste," he said, "cooked in a pot by a man with time on his hands. They have been at it in the north since the humans went. It smokes, it cracks, it goes out. We will ride two days to watch it go out."

They rode for the capital the next morning, because the northern road began there, and lay a night at Cathair dhearg in a lodging-house near the bridge. Seumas's mother lived in the lanes below the bridge-foot on the south bank, and he went to her for an hour after dark. She asked him what the mine office wanted with the Tuathaich, and he said it wanted to know about a fire. She said the lamp-houses were talking of leaving half the streets dark for the winter, and that the lamp-lighter two doors down had not been paid since Lùnastal. He told her the price of coal was not his masters' doing. She said she had not said it was.

In the morning they rode out past Cathair dhomhain and its harbour, with the stubble of the barley on either hand. It was a mild grey day with the wind in the west and rain in it now and again, never enough to wet a man through. The road was the old one, broad, rutted by carts, walled here and there where the farms were Dia-thìrich and the fields were worth a wall. At Ceann gheal they watered the horses and ate bread and cheese standing up. After that the country rose into long bare ridges with the road going over them one by one, and the farms grew smaller and farther apart, and the walls gave way to banks of turf with gorse along them.

Iain Ruadh rode a big bay mare that knew the road better than he did and let her choose her pace. He talked when he wanted to and was silent when he did not, and Seumas learned by the middle of the afternoon that the silences meant nothing. What the old man talked of was the mountain: which galleries had been good in his father's time, which seams had gone thin, how the colour of a flame told a surveyor what a coal was and where it had been cut. Coal of An Sloc Mòr burned with a dark edge to its flame, blue and green and a red like a wound, and a man who had seen it would know it anywhere.

"That is what they cannot make," Iain Ruadh said. "They can make a thing that burns. Any fool can make a thing that burns. They cannot make the edge."

They lay that night at Tobar dhomhain, which was a well, a farm, a smithy and an ale-house, and the ale-house had one room for travellers with a bed in it and a bench. Iain Ruadh took the bed. Seumas lay on the bench under his coat and listened to the wind in the thatch and thought of the order in his saddle-bag and the second name on it.

They crossed the boundary stones in the middle of the next morning.

Seumas had known they were there, as everyone knew. Stones had been set on the north roads in the first year after An Dealachadh⁴, where the Tuathaich country began, and no wall had followed them. He had thought there would be more to see. There were two stones, one on either side of the road, grey, shoulder-high, rough-dressed, with lichen yellow on their northern faces and nothing cut in them at all. A sheep was lying in the lee of the western one. It got up as the horses came near and walked a little way off and lay down again.

Iain Ruadh did not look at the stones. His mare did not slow. Seumas reined in, because it seemed to him that a man ought to, and sat for a breath or two between them, and then felt foolish and rode on to catch up.

"I crossed here the first time in my twenties," the old man said, without turning his head. "I thought there would be someone to ask my business. There never is."

North of the stones the road was the same road. The ridges went on. The farms were no poorer than the farms behind them, though they were built differently, with the house and the byre under one long roof and the doors painted, and the walls whitened with lime. At Àth fhionn a woman was lifting potatoes in a field by the ford, with two children picking behind her into a basket. Seumas called a greeting in Dia-thiris. She straightened and answered him in Dia-thiris, civilly, and when he had ridden past he heard her speak to the children in the humans' tongue, and the elder of the two laughed.

II

Of the Harbour at Caol mhòr

4. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

They came down into Caol mhòr in the evening, with the light going copper over the sea to the west and the strait below them full of it. The town lay along the shore and up the slope behind, grey houses and white ones, and the harbour was crowded with boats come in for the night, their sails brailed up and their masts rocking together. There were three church towers that Seumas could count from the road, square and plain, and as they came down a bell began in one of them and was taken up by the second and then the third, not quite together, so that the sound came down the hill in pieces.

"Evening prayer," said Iain Ruadh. "They keep hours like a druid school."

They found a lodging at an inn on the harbour front whose sign was a painted boat. The landlord was a big soft-spoken man named Harker who spoke to them in Dia-thìris and to his wife in the other tongue, and who gave them a room over the tap with two beds and a window on the water. Seumas asked him, as they sat to their supper, whether he knew anything of a new fuel that was burned in the north.

Harker considered the question. "I know there's talk of one," he said.

"Have you seen it?"

"I've seen a good many things." He took their plates. "There's more fish if you want it."

That was the first answer, and it was the pattern of the rest.

They spent four days at Caol mhòr. They went first to the maor, An Crùn's officer for the shire, a thin Dia-thìreach of the south who had held the post eleven years and plainly meant to hold it no longer than he must. He received them in a cold room above the harbour office with a fire of driftwood in the grate. He had heard of the fuel, he said. An Leabharlann had written to him about it. He had asked, and been told nothing. He doubted they would fare better; they were welcome to try, and he would give them a letter.

The letter got them into places and got them nothing there. They went to the harbour master, who showed them his book of dues and said there was no line in it for any fuel but coal and turf and wood. They went to a cooper's yard, a smith's, a rope-walk along the shore. On the second day they went to the market, because Iain Ruadh remembered that a pedlar had been said to carry the stuff there. The market was fish and wool and cabbages and a man mending pots; the pedlars had cloth and needles and cheap ribbons and tin whistles; and when Seumas asked

after a black cake that burned, a woman selling eggs said that there was a man who had sold such a thing the winter before, and that he had not come this year, and that she did not know his name.

Everywhere it was the same. They were answered civilly and at once, in good Dia-thiris, and the answer was never a lie and never any use. A man asked a question in Dia-thìris would give it back smooth and turned over, like a stone out of the burn. Then, as the surveyors went away, they would hear behind them the other tongue, quick and low, and sometimes a laugh, and sometimes nothing.

"They speak it among themselves to keep us out," Seumas said on the third evening. He had drunk two cups of Harker's ale, which was strong.

"They speak it among themselves because it is theirs," said Iain Ruadh. "They speak ours to us because it is ours. On the whole island there is no better-mannered people. I have been coming here thirty years and I have never once been told a thing I wanted to know."

"You don't think it's there."

"I think a man in the north has cooked some pit waste, and the whole coast is pleased with him for it, and it will be out by the new year." The old man looked into his cup. "I think they are proud of him. That is why they will not show us."

Seumas lay awake that night and listened to the boats knocking in the harbour. He was a Dia-thìreach of the capital and a servant of the mine office, and he had not thought of himself, before this week, as anything a people would keep a thing from. He found he did not like it. Turning over towards the wall, he found also that he did not blame them.

On the fourth morning a boy came to the inn with a message. It was written in a good round hand in Dia-thiris, and it said that if the gentlemen of Comhairle nam Mèinnean² wished to see a fire, the mill yard at Doire ghlais would be scouring on the morrow and they might come at the tenth hour. It was signed M. Greaves, manager.

"Who is this?" Seumas asked Harker.

"Martha Greaves," said Harker. "She has the big mill at Doire ghlais, the one Tìonal nan Tuathach³ built."

"How does she know we are here?"

Harker looked at him with a patient kindness that Seumas remembered for a long time afterwards. "Sir," he said, "everyone knows you are here."

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

3. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

III

Of the Mill Yard at Doire ghlais

Doire ghlais lay a little under ten miles east of Caol mhòr, on a road that ran inland from the strait through small fields and then up among low hills with oak woods on them. The oaks were old and grey-barked and bent by the west wind, and the road went through the edge of them for a mile before it came out above the village. Seumas had heard it called a village and had expected a village. It was as big as Caol mhòr, and seemed bigger, because it was built close about a great grove of the grey oaks in the middle of it, with the houses and chapels and the mills set around the grove like men round a fire, and nothing at all built under the trees.

"They will tell you it is a village," Iain Ruadh said. "Let them."

The mills stood at the eastern edge, where a stream came down off the hill and had been led in a stone race along the backs of them. There were three, long stone buildings with slate roofs, and the noise of their looms came out of their windows and filled the road. Carts of fleece stood in the lane. A smell of wet wool and lanolin and something sourer hung over everything, and under it, when the wind turned, Seumas caught another smell that he did not know.

Martha Greaves met them at the yard gate herself. She was a square, grey woman in her fifties in a dark stuff gown with the sleeves pinned back and an apron over it, and she had ink on her right hand and a pencil through the knot of her hair. She greeted them in *Dia-thiris*, gave them each her hand, asked after their journey and their lodging and the health of the maor, and said that she had kept them no more than a quarter-hour, which was true.

"You'll want to see the scouring," she said. "Come this way. Mind the channel, it's hot."

The scouring-house was a lean-to along the yard wall, open on the yard side, with three great coppers set into a brick range. The raw fleece came in at one end, was boiled in the first copper with soda and stale urine, lifted steaming on forks into the second and the third, and went out at the other end grey and wet and clean to the drying lofts. Four women worked the forks, with their skirts kilted and their arms red to the elbow. The steam rolled up under the roof and out across the yard.

Under the coppers were the fires.

Seumas went down on one knee on the wet brick to look at the nearest, and Iain Ruadh, after a moment, lowered himself stiffly beside him. The fire-door was open. The fire inside was low and steady and very hot; Seumas felt it on his face at arm's length. It burned yellow, a heavy smoky yellow with red at the root, and the smoke went up the flue fat and brown and came down again in the yard as a smell. It was a smell of tar and bad eggs and something like singed hoof, and it got into the back of the throat and stayed there.

There was no edge on the flame. He looked for it, as he had been taught to look. There was none of the blue, none of the green, none of the dark red. It was a plain flame.

"How long has it been burning?" Iain Ruadh asked.

"Since the fifth hour," said Martha Greaves. "It will burn till the fourth hour of the afternoon, when we draw the fires. The girl banks it at noon with two more cakes."

"Two."

"Two."

Iain Ruadh said nothing more. Seumas knew what he was thinking, because he was thinking it himself. A fire of the mountain's coal that would hold three coppers at the boil from the fifth hour to noon would have eaten a scuttle an hour. He looked round the yard for a coal-heap and did not see one. Against the wall of the scouring-house, under a sheet of tarred canvas, there was a low stack of something dark.

"May I?" he said.

Martha Greaves lifted a corner of the canvas for him.

The cakes were about the size of a small loaf, flattened, and blacker than any coal he had seen, a dull black that took no light. They had been pressed in some kind of mould; there was a ridge round the edge of each where the mould had joined. He picked one up. It was lighter than coal of its size and a little greasy, and it left a black bloom on his fingers that would not rub off on his trousers. He smelled it. It smelled of the fire, fainter.

"Where is it made?" he asked.

"In the north," said Martha Greaves.

"By whom?"

"By the man who makes it." She let the canvas fall. "You may take that one with you. It will tell you more than I can."

"Is it sold?"

"We buy it."

"From whom?"

She looked at him. She had grey eyes and a broad plain face that had been handsome, and was still good to look at, and there was nothing in it at all that he could read. "From the man who sells it to us," she said. "Will you take some tea, gentlemen? The kettle is on in the counting-house."

They took the tea. The counting-house was a small room at the corner of the yard, with a desk and two ledgers and a clock that ticked loudly and a window on the grove, and there was a fire in the grate there too, of peat. Martha Greaves poured for them and sat down at her desk and talked to them for half an hour about the price of fleece, and the rule of Tional nan Tuathach¹ for its mills, and the carts on the long road to Fèill Muileann òg², and the weather, and the harvest, and the health of the Tuathaich minister of Doire ghlas, who was ninety and had baptised her. She spoke of the fuel only when they asked, and then she told them what they could see for themselves: that it had heated the coppers since the spring, that it cost less than coal, that the women disliked the smell and had stopped mentioning it.

When Iain Ruadh asked her directly how many mills of the north were burning it, she said she could answer only for her own mill.

When Seumas asked her, at the last, whether the surveyors might be let see the place where it was made, she put down her cup.

"Mr mac Eachainn," she said. She said his name the Tuathaich way, with the stress in the wrong place, and he did not think she did it by accident. "You have seen it burn. You have held it in your hand. Take it home and burn it on your own hearth. What else is there that your masters would want to know?"

He did not answer. He found he did not know what to answer. She waited a civil while, and then she stood up, and so they stood up too.

She walked them to the gate. On the way across the yard they passed the scouring-house again, and the women at the forks did not look round. At the gate Martha Greaves gave them each her hand again, and wished them a good road, and said that she hoped they would find Caol mhòr comfortable, and that Harker kept a fair house. Then she went back into the yard, and the gate was shut behind her, and the noise of the looms closed over everything.

1. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

2. the fair at Muileann òg

They rode back towards the strait in the long light of the afternoon. The cake was in Seumas's saddle-bag wrapped in a page of the maor's letter, and every time the wind came round behind them he could smell it.

"Well," said Iain Ruadh at last. "It burns."

IV

Of the Three Clauses

On 28 an t-Sultain, DE 2, the two surveyors sat down in the room over Harker's tap to write their report, with the window open on the harbour and a jug of ale between them and the cake from Doire ghlais on a plate on the sill.

They had burned half of it the night before in the grate of that room, with Harker's leave and to his wife's great displeasure. It had taken a long time to catch. Once caught it had burned for three hours and a half, low and hot and yellow, while they sat on their beds with their coats on and the window open and timed it by Iain Ruadh's watch. The smell had gone down the stairs and into the tap, where a fisherman had made a remark in the humans' tongue that set the whole room laughing. In the morning there was a little grey ash in the grate, less than Seumas had thought, and a black bloom on the ceiling above it the size of a man's two hands.

The order required that they report under their hands. Iain Ruadh, as the elder, had the right of the first draft, and he took it. He wrote for most of an hour in a small, square, old-fashioned hand, and then pushed the paper across.

Seumas read it twice.

It was a good report as reports of the mine office went. It set out the order and the road and the dates. The names of those they had called on at Caol mhòr were there, and what each had said. It described the mill yard at Doire ghlais and the coppers and the fire under them. It gave the hours of burning and the size of the cake and the weight of the ash. And it ended with a paragraph which said that the surveyors had not been shown the making of the fuel, nor the place of its making, nor told the name of the maker, nor the quantity made; that its nature and its lasting could not be judged by one mill and one cake; and that it must be accounted unproven.

"It is true," Iain Ruadh said, watching him. "Every word."

"It is true," Seumas agreed.

"Then sign it."

Seumas did not sign it. He sat with the paper in front of him and looked out of the window at the boats. A man was baiting lines on the deck of the nearest, and a gull stood on the rail beside him and waited. After a while Seumas said, "We were not sent to learn how it is made."

"We were sent to learn whether it burns as men say."

"And it does."

"We saw one fire, boy. In one yard. Shown us by a woman who told us nothing and meant to."

"We saw three fires. We burned one ourselves." Seumas put his finger on the last paragraph. "If this goes to Cathair mhòr, they will read the last word and no other. Unproven. They will file it and forget it, and next year someone will ask again, and someone will ride up here again, and be given tea."

Iain Ruadh was silent a long time. The gull on the rail stretched its wings and settled them.

"And what would you write?"

Seumas took a clean sheet. He knew the words already; he had been carrying them since the scouring-house, when he knelt on the wet brick and looked for the edge of the flame and did not find it. He wrote them in Dia-thìris, in the plain hand the mine office taught its clerks, below the heading and the order and the names:

Loiscidh e, tha faileadh dheth, agus chan e gual a th' ann. It burns; it stinks;
and it is not coal.

Then he copied Iain Ruadh's account of the road and the town and the yard and the hours below it, word for word, and left out the last paragraph.

Iain Ruadh read it through. He read it a second time. He picked up his cup and found it was empty and put it down.

"They will think we were drunk," he said.

"They will read it."

"They will read the first line," said the old man, "and no other." But he took the pen. He signed first, as the elder, in his small square hand, and Seumas signed under him. Then they made the fair copy for the council's clerk, and signed that too, and Iain Ruadh folded both and sealed them.

When it was done he took from his saddle-bag the little tin that every surveyor of the mountain carries, with a thumb of coal from An Sloc Mòr¹ in it for the matching of samples, and laid the coal on the last embers of the cake in the grate. It lay there a while and then caught. The flame came up round it thin and bright, and along its edge ran the colours of the mountain, blue and green and a red like a wound, so that for the time it burned the whole dull hearth had a rim of light on it.

"There," the old man said, and watched it until it was ash. "That is what I mean by an edge."

V

Of the Unlit Lamps

They rode south two days later and came to Cathair dhearg on the evening of the second day, with rain. Iain Ruadh went on alone the next morning by the road east to Cathair mhòr, with the copy for Cathair mhòr in his saddle-bag, and Seumas stayed in the capital to put the fair copy into the hands of the council's clerk, as the order said, and to wait upon the council in case it wished to ask him anything.

He put it into the clerk's hands the same day, in a small panelled room off the passage below the council chamber, and the clerk, a courteous young man with a cold, gave him a receipt for it and wrote his lodging in a book. Then Seumas waited.

He waited nearly the whole of an Dàmhair. He lived at his mother's house in the lanes below the bridge-foot, and walked up every second morning to the panelled room to ask whether he was wanted, and every second morning the courteous young man, whose cold got better and then worse again, told him that he was not wanted yet. In between he walked the town. He walked out to the quays of Ros dhomhain and watched the coal-boats that had once come in loaded going out light. He walked round the precinct walls and past the temple of Macha, where the two horses of the rite were led out in the afternoons to graze the temple green. Walking was all there was to do with the days, and in the evenings he sat by his mother's fire, which was of turf and driftwood now, and told her about the

1. the great pit at the mountain

grey oaks at Doire ghlas and the three bells at Caol mhòr, and did not tell her about the cake.

On 27 an Dàmhair, DE 2, there came a letter for him from Cathair mhòr, in Iain Ruadh's small square hand.

It was short. It said that the old man had come safe to Cathair mhòr and delivered the report, and that the master had read it at his table in Iain Ruadh's presence and passed it to the chief clerk, and that the chief clerk had filed it in the press among the surveys of that year. There had been no minute made of it. There had been no question asked. It said that Iain Ruadh had been sent the week after to measure the water in the lower galleries again, and that it stood where it stood, and that he had written that it was at a pause. It ended: *They read the first line. I told you so. I. R.*

Seumas read it by the window of the panelled room, where the clerk had given it to him with his daily word that the council did not want him yet. When he had finished he folded it and put it inside his coat. The clerk asked, out of courtesy, whether it was bad news. Seumas said it was not news at all.

As he came down the steps into the lane there was a woman on the lowest step with three children beside her, the eldest a girl of ten or eleven holding the youngest on her hip. The woman had a paper in her hand. Seumas knew her; it was the wife of the lamp-lighter two doors from his mother's, and the paper was a petition, written out for her by the scribe at the bridge-foot for a copper, and it asked that her husband, who had lit the lamps of the south bank for nineteen years, be given other work of the town's, any work, since the lamps he lit were to be lit no longer. A porter of the council house was telling her, not unkindly, that the petitions of the lamp-houses went to the lamp-houses and not to the council, and that the lamp-houses had already said no.

"They sent me here," the woman said.

"Then they were wrong to," said the porter.

Seumas stood on the step above them. He thought of the receipt in the clerk's book, with his lodging written beside it. He had nothing in his hand to give her but Iain Ruadh's letter, and it was no use to anybody. After a while the woman put the petition away in her shawl and took the youngest child from the girl and went off down the lane towards the bridge, and the other two followed her.

He walked home late, after dark, the long way, because he did not want to go in.

The lamp-houses had made their order that day. It was pinned up at the bridge-foot, and the watch had it by heart: the lamps of the main streets, the precinct, the bridge and the quays to be lit as before; the lamps of the lanes on the south bank, and of the streets behind the tannery and the fish-market, and of the lower town along the river, to be left unlit until the price of coal should fall. Seumas had seen the lamps of his mother's lane burning every night of his life when he was in the capital. He walked down the lane now and counted them, because he was a surveyor and it was the thing he knew how to do.

There were eleven iron posts in his mother's lane, and eleven dark heads on them, with the rain running off the glass. There were nine in the next lane, and fourteen in the one after, and six in the steep little lane that went down to the water-stairs, where he nearly fell. He counted them in his head and then, when the numbers grew too many, in the notebook he carried for the galleries, writing by feel in the dark: lane, lamps, lane, lamps. Behind the fish-market there were thirty-one. Along the river road there were fifty-two, and the river beside them was black and loud with the rain.

From the river road he could see the bridge. It was lit from end to end, as the order said, twenty lamps in two rows, and each of them had a coal flame in it, and each flame had the dark edge of the mountain's coal round it, blue and green and a red like a wound, so that the whole bridge hung over the black water with a coloured light on it. It was the most beautiful thing he had ever seen, and it was burning coal that the poorer streets of the capital could not have.

He stood on the river road and looked at it for a long time.

While he stood there he heard a shout from the far end of the bridge, and then running feet, and then the rattle of the watch. A man came off the bridge towards the south bank at a run, out of the light and into the dark of the lanes, and was gone. Two of the watch came after him as far as the bridge-foot and stopped there, where the lamps stopped, and one of them spoke a word to the other and they went back. A little later Seumas passed them at the bridge-foot, under the last lit lamp, where one of the watch had his book open against the post and was writing in it by the coloured light. A carter coming home had been knocked down on the bridge and his purse taken, and the thief had gone into the south-bank lanes, where there was no light to follow him by. The watchman wrote that down, and the hour, and put the book away.

Seumas went on into the dark. At his mother's door he took out his notebook and, by the light of her window, added up the lamps he had counted. It came to a

hundred and forty-three. He wrote the figure under the column and drew a line beneath it, as he would have done for any measure of the mine office's, and then he stood for a while in the rain with the book open in his hand, with no one to send it to.

CHAPTER THREE

OF the Last Cartload and the CROWNING

DE 3

I

Of the Last Cartload

Cùirt na Fèille sat in the upper room of the toll-house at Muileann òg, over the arch where Rathad na Fèille¹ came in, and in winter the room smelled of wet wool and lamp-soot and the river. The court kept the fair's measures and heard the fair's debts, and on market days through the year it kept the town's as well, because there was no other court in Muileann òg and nobody had seen a reason to make one. Its clerk in those years was Ùna nic Ailein. She was not yet thirty. She had come to the desk at seventeen to cut quills for old Seonaidh Crùbach, and when his eyes failed she had read the day-book aloud to him every evening until he died, and after that the justice had given her the key of the press without asking the council's leave, which was how most things at Muileann òg were done.

On 22 am Faoilleach, DE 3, it had rained since before light, a thin rain driven sideways off the plain. The market was small, as it always was in am Faoilleach: a few carts of turnips, two drovers with lean beasts, a woman selling eels from a tub. Ùna had the window open a hand's breadth for the light and kept her ink-horn under her palm against the wind.

A little before noon the coal cart came in under the arch.

She heard it before she saw it. Every child in the town knew the sound of Uilleam mac Dhùghaill's cart, because the near wheel had a split felloe bound

with iron and it rang on the setts twice to every turn. He had carried coal down Rathad na Fèille from the yards at Cathair dhearg for thirty-one years. His father had carried it before him, when the loads came to the fair from the wagons of Comhairle nam Mèinnean² and a cart went back and forth four times in a market week. In Ùna's first years at the desk Uilleam had still come every market day. Then it was every other. In the autumn before last, when Comhairle nam Mèinnean cut its sales and the price at the fair doubled, the court had fixed a ceiling, and Uilleam had sold under it twice and then stopped coming at all until the court looked away.

He stopped under her window. The load was covered in sacking, black with rain. He climbed down slowly, one hand on the shaft, and looked up at her.

"Is he in?" he said.

"He is in."

"Then I'll sell it whole, and I'll sell it here, and you can write it."

Fionnlagh mac Gille-Chaluim, justice of Cùirt na Fèille³, came down to the arch in his old brown cloak and stood in the rain to see it done, as the rules asked. He was past seventy and had kept the court for twenty years. He lifted a corner of the sacking and looked at the coal underneath: small stuff, most of it, the size of a hen's egg and smaller, and some slack at the bottom that would be lost in the grate. There was no great lump in it anywhere. He dropped the sacking back.

"Whose yard?"

"The capital's. The last of what they'd let me have."

"Price?"

Uilleam told him. Ùna, above them, wrote it down before the justice answered, because she knew he would not argue. It was more than a third over the ceiling that was still painted on the board by the door.

The buyer was Màiri nic Leòid, who kept the brew-house by the ford and had a copper to boil. She had come up the street under a sack of her own with her son behind her pushing a barrow, and she counted the coin out on the step of the toll-house with the rain running off her hood onto the stone. When the boy had shovelled half the load into the barrow he took it off and came back for the other half, and Uilleam stood by his horse and did not help him. The horse was old too. Its breath smoked.

1. the fair road from the capital to Muileann òg

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

3. the court of the fair at Muileann òg

When the cart was empty Uilleam came up the stair and stood dripping in the doorway of the court-room with his hat in his hands. He had never come up before. The carters paid their dues at the window below.

"Put it in," he said. "The whole load, and to her, and the price. And put it that it was the last."

"I'll write what was sold," Ùna said. "How do I know it was the last?"

"Because I'm telling you. The yard won't sell by the cart any more. They'll sell by the sack at the gate, to anyone who walks up, and dear, and a man with a cart can't make a living of sacks." He turned his hat round once. "Put it that I said so."

She wrote the sale in its line, as every sale of coal-fuel had been written in that book since the fair was first held: the day, the seller, the buyer, the load, the price, the justice's mark. Then, in the margin, in smaller letters, she wrote: *The carter says this is the last load sold at this court by the cartload. The yard at Cathair dhearg sells now by the sack.* She turned the book round so that he could see it. He could not read. He looked at the marks a long while all the same.

"That's it, then," he said, and went down.

The justice came up after him and read the margin with his finger. He did not tell her to strike it. He went to the door, and took his knife, and scraped at the painted ceiling on the board until the figures were a grey smear.

"No sense keeping a price nobody sells at," he said. "Write that too."

She wrote that too. Afterwards, when the market had packed up and the lamps were lit, she turned back through the book to see how many cartloads there had been. In the first years of the fair they filled a page a day. Ten years back they filled a page a week. She found Uilleam's name on the last seven, one under another, like a man going down a stair.

Uilleam mac Dhùghaill sold his cart that spring to a man who carried grain from Muileann ghlas, and kept the horse, and did not come to the fair again that anyone at the court remembered.

II

Of the Sack and the Lump

T

he day-book of Cùirt na Fèille¹ for that year is in an Leabharlann² now, and a reader who turns its pages can watch the coal go out of it.

In am Faoilleach there is the cartload. Through an Gearran and am Màrt there is no coal at all; the town bought what it bought at the capital, those who could get there, and those who could not burned turf and furze and cold wood from the hedges, and the court was asked twice to settle quarrels over hedges. In an Giblean a man from Cnoc leathan came with eleven sacks on a pack-horse and sold them one at a time from the step of the toll-house, which the court allowed, since the rules said nothing against it, and Ùna wrote the eleven sales in eleven lines. After that the sacks came irregularly, three or four in a market day, carried by whoever had got them. The price in the book goes up by a little every month. Nobody in the book complains of it. The court had already given up the ceiling, and there was nobody to complain to.

What the book does not show is the town. Ùna walked home every evening through the lanes below the toll-house, where the weavers' cottages stood in two rows back to back, and she saw the chimneys smoking less. The women took their bread to the baker's oven instead of their own. Old men sat in the brew-house late because Màiri nic Leòid kept the copper going and the room was warm, and some of them paid for one cup in an evening and made it last till she put them out. In the rows where there were children the doors were kept shut by day, which nobody in Muileann òg had done in Ùna's lifetime. The spring was mild and wet. People said it was lucky, and it was.

On Bealltainn a boy came into the court from one of the small houses of Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail³ in the hills to the west. He was a custodian's boy, in a grey tunic, and he had walked since before dawn. He had money in a knotted cloth and asked, with great care for his manners, for a piece of coal.

"How much?" Ùna said.

"A piece. For the altar. For tonight." He held his hands apart to show her, about the size of a loaf. "Our custodian says the fire of Bealltainn must be lit from a coal of the vein, and we have none left in the house, and the pits send no more to houses of our size."

There was no coal in the market that day. Ùna sent down to the man from Cnoc leathan, who had one sack left over from the week before and had kept it

1. the court of the fair at Muileann òg

2. the Library at Muileann chaol

3. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

back to burn at home; he came up grumbling and opened it on the floor of the court-room, and the justice turned the pieces over with his foot until he found one big enough, a black lump with a seam of colour in its broken face that took the lamplight and showed a flash of blue and red when he turned it. It was the kind the old people called a good coal, the kind that had once come by the wagon.

The boy paid. It was more than a cart-horse cost at Lùnastal the year before. He wrapped the lump in the cloth the money had come in, and put it inside his tunic against his chest, and went off down the west road at a trot.

Ùna wrote the sale. Then she sat with the pen in her hand. The rules of the court said that coal-fuel was entered by the load, the sack or the basket, and this was none of them. She wrote: *One lump, for an altar*. It is the first such entry in the book. There were four more before the end of that year, and in each the buyer gives the name of a house of Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail, and in each the justice picked out the piece himself.

"They'll be buying it by the lump for the altars when there's none to be had for the grate," he said to her that evening, when she read him the day's lines. "I've seen that coming for ten years. It's a strange thing to see it come."

She asked him what else he had seen coming.

"Nothing I'd put in a book," he said.

III

Of the Crowning at Cathair dhearg

In the summer word went round Rathad na Fèille¹ that Mairead's reign had ended, and that there would be a crowning at Lùnastal, the first in fifteen years. The court shut for the day of the feast by the justice's order. Half the town went up to the capital to see it, and Ùna went with them.

They went up the day before in the carrier's wagon, twelve to a bench, and slept in the carrier's loft in the lane behind the tannery, and were in the streets before light. Rathad na Fèille was full all the way up. There were families walking with their children on their shoulders; there were two priests of Òrd Mhacha² from the house at Cnoc òg with a bundle of green boughs; there were drovers

1. the fair road from the capital to Muileann òg

2. the order of Macha

with no beasts, and a man selling cold mutton pies from a board hung round his neck, who had sold out before they reached the bridge. The long light of the day before the feast lay yellow across the barley. From the brow of the last hill they could see the smoke of Cathair dhearg over the river, less of it than Ûna remembered.

What follows is told as she wrote it that night in a letter to the justice, who had stayed at home. The letter was kept among the court's papers and came to an Le-abharlann³ with the day-books.

"We stood nearly five hours," she wrote, "in the street below the temple, the one that goes up from the bridge, and I could see the temple steps between a woman's hat and a lamp-post. Nobody sat. There were soldiers of the palace in the street to hold a lane open, and they were as tired as we were by noon, and gave the children water from their own flasks.

"The regalia came out first. Òrd Mhacha keeps them, as you know, and we saw how little anyone else has handled them, for the priests carried them down the steps as if they were carrying a sleeper. There was a circlet, and a mantle of red wool that trailed on the stone, and something in a box that I could not see. People said different things about what was in the box, and I will not write them.

"Then the horses. I had not thought there would be real horses. A priest led out a grey mare and another a black horse, from the stable on the south side of the temple yard, and they were brought to the foot of the steps and stood there, one on each side. The grey was restless and the black was not. People round me were saying their names, Liath Macha and Dubh Sainglenn, and a woman behind me told her son they were not the same horses as at the last crowning, only the same names, and he asked how she knew, and she said her mother had told her the grey was the restless one then too.

"Cathal came down between the horses. I was too far off to see his face, only that he walked slowly. The priests set the mantle on him at the foot of the steps and the circlet on him at the top, and between the two the grey mare put her head down and pulled at her rope and the priest had to lean on it. Nobody laughed. I think some wanted to.

"He did not speak. I had expected him to speak. The priests spoke, and the chief of them read the old words of the rite, which I could not hear for the crowd, and then turned to the street and said in a loud voice that the kingdom had its

3. the Library at Muileann chaol

king, and the street shouted, and the black horse threw up its head at the noise. Then Cathal went into the temple and the doors were shut, and that was all we saw of him. People stood a long time after, as though something more would happen. It did not. By and by they began to go home.

"I stood beside a man at the lamp-post the whole afternoon. He told me, when we had stood there long enough to talk, that he cut dies at the mint, and that he would be cutting the new king's dies before the month was out. His name is Gille-Easbaig Bàn. His hands are black at the nails, which he says is the ink and no washing takes it off. I asked him was it hard to cut a king's face when you had only seen it at a distance from behind a lamp-post, and he said the face is the easy part, the council sends a drawing; the hard part is the seal.

"He told me the seal of every coin is pressed with an ink ground from coal dust, as it has been since Fearchar Bonn struck the first coin of the kingdom, and every die-cutter since has been a pupil of Fearchar Bonn's workshop, and he is the first who is not. He learned his trade at the silver-smiths' in the eastern hills. So he must make the ink himself as Fearchar Bonn's men made it, from a recipe on a card that hangs by the grinding-stone, and the recipe says it must be good coal of the vein, with the colour in it, ground fine and bound with gum. He said the mint sent to Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁴ for coal of that sort and got back a price. He said the price for the little pot of ink the new dies want is as much as the mint pays him in a year. I asked him was that true or only a way of speaking. He said he had worked it out on the back of their letter, and it was true.

"I asked him why they did not use some other ink, since the coin would be as good. He looked at me as though I had asked why they did not crown the king in a barn. Then he said, 'Because a clipped coin has to show the colour at its edge. That's how you know it's the kingdom's.' I said that if coal went on the way it was going there would soon be no colour to show. He said that was the council's business and not a die-cutter's, and he would cut what he was told. Then the woman with the hat moved, and I could see the steps better, and we did not talk any more.

"Walking back to the loft at dusk I went by the streets below the tannery, where the lamps have been left dark since the autumn before last. The lamp-posts are there still, with the glass in them. Someone had hung a green bough from Lùnastal on one. It was too dark to see what was on the others. We go home in

4. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

the wagon tomorrow. I have written it all down so that you will know it as well as if you had stood there, which I think is better than standing, for my feet are raw."

She sent the letter by a drover going south that night and came home herself the day after. The justice had it read to him twice.

IV

Of the New Dies and the Ruled Line

The mint's day-book for that month is short. It says that on 30 an Lùnastal, DE 3, Gille-Easbaig Bàn delivered the dies for the coinage of the reign, face and seal, and that they were proved and found good. The coal ink for the seal was ground in the mint from coal bought of Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹, and the clerk set down the price, which is what Gille-Easbaig had told Ùna at the lamp-post. The first coins struck from the new dies showed the colour at the edge. No one else is named. In all that book it is the first entry in which the die-cutter is not called a pupil of anyone.

The new coin came down Rathad na Fèille² in the purses of carriers and drovers through an t-Sultain, and by the time Fèill Muileann òg³ opened in an Dàmhair half the coin that crossed Ùna's table had Cathal's head on it. She held one of the first up to the window. It was bright, and a little thinner than the old, or she thought so; and when she turned it on its edge the thin dark rim showed where the seal-ink had been pressed, and when she tilted it in the light there was a thread of colour in the black, very small, blue going to red.

The fair ran eleven days that year. It was thinner than any year Ùna had kept its books. The coal-sellers' row, which in the old days had run the whole length of the lower field from the ford to the elm with its wagons in a line and its men black to the elbow, had four booths standing in it, and two of those sold turf. Cnoc leathan let fewer beds. The fire-watch walked the stalls every night as it had done since the burning, with buckets and a bell, and found little enough to watch; the booths were dark by nine for want of fuel to keep a brazier. But the cattle came, and the salt, and the cloth, and the court sat from first light every day in the upper room with its window open onto the noise, and Ùna wrote until her hand ached

1. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

2. the fair road from the capital to Muileann òg

3. the fair at Muileann òg

and the justice slept upright in his chair by the stove after noon and woke when anyone raised a voice.

On the northern day the Tuathaich goods came in.

It had been so since Daniel Frayne's first year in the speaker's chair of Tional nan Tuathach⁴: one day of the fair given to goods of the north, sold through Dia-thìreach factors under the makers' marks. The factors stood at their booths along the upper field with the bales behind them, and the Tuathaich who had brought the bales down stood behind the factors and did not speak unless they were spoken to. There was grey twill from Doire ghlas with the white thread at the selvedge, and heavy cloth from Baile chiar, and knitted things in baskets, and fish salted in kegs from the northern coast. The buyers from the south walked the booths and fingered the cloth and asked the factors the price. The factors turned round and asked the makers, in the northern tongue, and then turned back and said the price in Dia-thìris, a little higher. Ùna had watched it done for ten years. It went quickly when it went well.

A little after noon the factor Coinneach Liath came up the stair of the toll-house with a man behind him.

The man was a Tuathach. He was of middle age, square and brown, in a jacket of Doire ghlas twill gone thin at the elbows, and he carried a creel on his back with a sacking cover lashed down over it. He stood in the doorway. Coinneach Liath came to the table, and leaned on it, and said that he had a sale to enter and did not know how to enter it.

"What goods?" said Ùna.

"Fuel."

"Coal-fuel goes in by the sack or the basket. Or the lump." She turned the book to the page. "Which?"

"It's not coal."

The justice woke. He looked at the factor, and then past him at the man in the doorway, and said, "Let's see it."

The man set the creel down on the floor and unlashed the cover. Inside, packed close like peats, were cakes of something black: flat and squarish, a little bigger than a man's hand, rough on the faces, with a dull shine where they had rubbed on each other. The man took one out and held it up. Ùna saw that his palm was grey with the dust of it.

4. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

"What is it?" said the justice.

The man answered him in *Dia-thìris*, slowly and correctly, the way northern people spoke it at the fair when they wanted no mistake. "It's made from the waste. What the pits throw out. It's burned in the north for a year and more."

"Made by whom?"

"Made in the north."

"Does it burn?"

The man looked at the stove. The justice nodded, and Ùna got up and opened the stove door, and the man crouched and put the cake in on top of the embers of the turf, and they waited. For a while nothing happened. Then the edges of the cake began to glow, a dull red with no flame, and a thick yellowish smoke curled out of it and up the flue, and some of it came back into the room. It had a smell that Ùna had never smelled in her life: sour, oily, like a tannery and a pitch-pot together. Coinneach Liath put his sleeve over his nose. The justice did not. He held his hands out to the stove door and kept them there.

"It's hot," he said, after a while.

"It's hot," the man agreed. "It lasts."

"And it stinks."

"It does."

The justice sat back. "Well," he said to the room, "it's not coal. What's it called?"

The man shrugged. "In the north the women call it the black cake. Some call it after the man who first made it." He looked at Ùna's pen. "Black cake will do."

The factor named his price for the creel, which the man had told him in the northern tongue on the stair. A buyer was waiting at the foot of the steps, a woman of *Muileann ghlais* with a bakehouse, who had watched the smoke come out of the court-room window and come up to see what it was. She bought the creel whole. She paid in the new coin, and Ùna saw the dark rim on the pieces as they went across the table into the factor's hand, and from the factor's hand, when the factor had taken his part, into the *Tuathach's*. He looked at them no longer than it took to count them. He put them in his jacket.

Then there was the entry to make.

The day-book of *Cùirt na Fèille*⁵ is ruled by hand at the start of each year, one page for each kind of goods the fair has sold before, and the lines run across from

5. the court of the fair at *Muileann òg*

the day to the price, and at the head of each page the kind of goods is written in the clerk's best hand. Ùna turned through them: grain, cattle, sheep, horses, wool, cloth, salt, fish, timber, stone, iron, coal-fuel. She went back to coal-fuel and looked at it: the cartload in am Faoilleach, the sacks, the five lumps for altars, and then nothing since the start of the fair. The justice watched her. So did the factor, and the Tuathach in the doorway, and the baker's wife of Muileann ghlas with her creel, who wanted to be gone.

"Put it under coal," said Coinneach Liath. "It's the same trade."

"It's not coal," said the justice. "We've just said so. And the man says it isn't. And I'll not have the clerks of the pits reading my book and finding their coal sold by the creel at half their price, and coming down here to tell me I've made a fool of their ledger."

"Then put it under sundries."

Ùna did not answer him. She took the ruler out of the drawer, and the lead, and turned to the back of the book, where there were clean leaves kept for the next year. She ruled a page as the pages at the front were ruled, across and down, and at the head of it she wrote *black cake*, and under that, smaller, *of the north*. Then she dipped the pen and wrote the sale in its first line: the day, the factor as seller, the maker not named, the buyer of Muileann ghlas, one creel, the price, and a space for the justice's mark.

She turned the book so that the justice could make his mark. He looked at the page a long time. The black cake in the stove had settled and was burning low and red, and the smell of it lay in the room.

"There's only the one line on that page," he said.

"There's only been the one sale."

He made his mark. The Tuathach picked up his empty creel and put the straps over his shoulders. At the door he stopped and looked back at the page from where he stood, though he was too far off to read it, and then he went down the stair into the noise of the northern day, and Ùna did not see him again at that fair. She had not asked his name. The rules of the northern day did not ask for it.

When the fair was over and the booths were down and the field was mud, she went back through the book to reckon the year, as she did every year in the last week of an Dàmhair, with the lamp lit early. The page of coal-fuel held the cartload, a run of sacks, and five lumps for altars. The page she had ruled at the back held one line. She sat and looked at both for a while in the lamplight. Then she wrote at the foot of the year, under the totals, in the place where the clerks of

Cùirt na Fèille had always written the year's weather and the state of the roads: *Coal sold this year by the cart, by the sack, by the lump. A new fuel sold once, from the north.* She blotted it, and shut the press, and turned the key, and put out the lamp.

CHAPTER FOUR

Of the Shipmasters' Works

DE 4

I

Of the Salt-Sheds

Peigi nic Ascaill smelt the works before she saw them.

She had come down from Cathair dhearg in the second week of am Màrt, two days in the carrier's coach with a crate of lamp-glass on the seat beside her, and on the second afternoon, where the road tops the last rise above the southern coast, the wind came up off the sea and brought her a smell she had no name for. It was like tar, and like a wet hearth in the morning, and under both was something sour and sharp that made her eyes water. The carrier, a broad man from Muileann òg who had driven the coast road half his life, put his sleeve over his nose and said nothing until they were down among the first houses. Then he said, "That's them. The shipmasters. You can smell them from Tobar dhearg when it blows from the west."

Below them lay Seann Skell of the south, the great port of the southern coast: its harbour inside the long mole, the grey roofs going down to the water in steps, and on the height the house of Òrd Bhrìde¹ with its lamp already lit in the west window against the dusk. Beyond the harbour, on the east side where the salt-pans had been, stood a row of long low sheds with tarred roofs, and at the end of the row a new chimney of red brick, still in its scaffolding, with smoke coming out of it at a slant.

1. the order of Bride's flame

Nobody had built anything so tall on that shore in the memory of the town. It was not yet as tall as it would be by the year's end, and already the gulls went round it.

Peigi had read about it at her desk in the capital. The company of shipmasters, Comann nan Sciobairean², had taken a lease of the old salt-sheds in the winter; the salt trade had long gone east, and the town was glad to be paid for sheds that had stood empty since the humans' time. On 20 an Gearran, DE 4, the company had set up its works there, the first works for the making of dubhan anywhere on the island outside the north. That was what the letter to Comhairle nan Taighean-solais³ said, in a clerk's round hand, and it said no more. It did not say who had shown them the making, or where they had it from.

She had also read the surveyors' report of two years before, which had come to an Leabharlann⁴ and to her own masters and been filed without a minute. Three clauses: it burns; it stinks; it is not coal. She had copied the three clauses into her pocket-book and underlined the first.

She was thirty-six that spring, a narrow woman with ink on her second finger that no soap would take off, and she had been engineer to Comhairle nan Taighean-solais for six years. In those six years she had watched the price of the lights' coal go up every quarter, and every quarter she had written to say so. The five towers of the island burned coal-lit flame, the flame with the dark coloured edge that only the island's coal gives, and the coal came dearer and poorer each year from the failing vein. At Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg⁵, the first of the five, the keeper had begun to bank the fire on calm nights to save it. Peigi had not written that to her masters. She had told the keeper she had not heard it.

She took a room at an inn on the quay where the landlady fed her fish and asked her no questions, and in the morning she walked round the harbour to the sheds.

The master of the company met her at the gate. He was an old salt-shipper with a white beard cut square and a coat too good for the place, and he knew who she was before she said it. He took her hand in both of his and said the whole town knew the lights' own engineer had come, and that the company was honoured.

2. the company of shipmasters who built the dubhan works at the southern Seann Skell

3. the Lighthouse Board

4. the Library at Muileann chaol

5. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

"I've come to see it made," Peigi said.

"And so you shall," he said, "so far as there is anything to see."

He walked her through the first of the sheds. It was full of heaps: slack and spoil, the grey and black waste that the pits throw out and the heaps of the pit towns are made of, brought down the coast in the company's own hulls. Men were shovelling it into barrows. The floor was black and the light came in grey through the high windows, and the dust stood in the light like smoke. In the second shed the waste went into iron retorts, six of them in a row on brick furnaces, and there the heat met her at the door like a hand on the chest. Men in leather aprons tended the fires. The smell she had met on the hill was here at its root, and she breathed through her mouth.

The third shed was locked. There was a new padlock on it the size of a man's fist.

"The making-shed," said the master of the company. "Where the stuff is finished. You'll forgive us. Every house has one room it keeps."

In the fourth shed the finished dubhan stood in barrels, rows of them, new oak bound with iron, and at the far end a man had one open and was drawing it off into a can. It came out thick and black and slow, like treacle in cold weather, and it shone. The master had the man fill a small lamp from the can and light it on a bench, and it burned with a yellow flame, steady and a little smoky, and the smell of it was less than the smell of the shed.

Peigi watched the flame for a long time. She held her hand over the chimney and felt the heat, and turned the wick up and down, and held a sheet of her pocket-book behind it to see how the light fell. Then she asked the question she had come to ask.

"Where did you learn the making?"

"You'll take a glass of wine," said the master of the company.

He took her up to a room over the gate where there was a fire of driftwood and a table with a cloth on it. The wine was from the south-west coast, red and good, and he poured it himself. He talked about the harbour, and the price of hulls, and how the coal ships had had nothing to carry these five years, which was true. His father, he said, had carried coal for A' Chompanaidh⁶ of the humans from the west coast to the capital and been paid in human silver. Then he asked after the keeper at Tobar dhearg, whom he had known as a girl.

6. the Company

When she asked the question again, he filled her glass.

When she asked it a third time, he smiled and said, "We are shipmasters, engineer. We go a long way along the coast and we hear a great deal. We have a paper for the lease, and a paper for the harbour-due, and the maor has seen both. There's no law on the making. You'll find nothing wrong with us."

"I'm not looking for anything wrong."

"Then you'll find nothing," he said, and filled his own glass.

She went down to the yard afterwards and stood in the wind to clear her head. Men were rolling barrels down a plank onto a cart for the quay. Most were Dia-thìrich of the town, in the blue smocks of the harbour. Four or five were not.

She knew them for Tuathaich before she heard them speak, by the cut of their hair and the way they stood apart at the water-butt; and when one of them called to another it was in the humans' tongue, and the answer came back in Dia-thìris, as if the two tongues were one road with a ford in it. It was a rare thing in the south to see Tuathaich working at all. They do not come south, the council's old minute says; and here were five of them at the far end of the island, in a shipmasters' yard, with black to the elbow.

One of them was fitting a new tap to a barrel at the end of the plank. He was a young man, lean, with his sleeves rolled above the elbow and a burn scar on the back of one wrist, and he worked the tap into the wood with small turns of a wrench, listening to it. When it was in he tried it, closed it, wiped it with his thumb, and went on to the next. He did not look up. Peigi watched him fit three taps. Not one of them dripped.

"Who is that?" she asked the foreman, a Seann Skell man.

"That one? Ashby. Joe Ashby. From Caol mhòr, up north." The foreman shrugged. "They're good hands, the northern ones. They know the stuff."

"How do they know it?"

The foreman looked at her, and then at the gate-house window, and said he had barrels to see to.

Three more days she stayed. She saw the retorts filled and the spoil go in grey and come out black, and she saw the locked shed opened twice, each time for a man to go in with a lamp and come out again, and the door shut behind him. She counted the barrels in the fourth shed, and the carts on the quay, and the hulls in the harbour with the company's mark, a black ring, painted on their bows, and wrote it all down. On the fourth morning she took the coach back to the capital

and wrote her report on the way, with the book on her knee and the coach lurching.

The fuel burns clean enough for a lamp, she wrote. It may serve for the lights. The works will not say how it is made, and I think they will not say it to us or to anyone. They have Tuathaich hands who know the stuff. I asked where from and was given wine.

She thought about striking the last line out, and left it.

II

Of the Making-Shed

Her masters read her report and filed it. Nobody wrote to her about it. In an t-Ògmhios she found a reason to go south again: the lantern at Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg¹ wanted new glass, and the glass-blowers of Seann Skell, who blow from the white sand of their own shore, were the best on the island and half the price of the capital's. She saw the glass ordered in a day. Then she walked over to the works.

The chimney was finished. It stood above the salt-sheds like a finger raised, and its smoke went up straight on still days and lay along the shore on windy ones, and the fishwives of the harbour said the herring tasted of it. The town had taken a petition to the maor about the reek. The maor had read it and answered that the company paid its harbour-due. That was the end of the petition.

The works had doubled since am Màrt. There were twelve retorts now, and two new sheds, and a jetty of its own where a hull with the black ring on her bow was unloading spoil into barrows. The master of the company was away up the coast. The foreman let her in without asking him, because she had been there before and it was a hot day and he was busy.

She did not go near the locked shed. She went and found the Tuathaich.

There were nine of them now. They worked the retorts at the far end, the hottest end, in shifts, and they ate together at noon in the shade of the jetty wall, bread and cold fish and a can of tea boiled over a dubhan lamp. Joe Ashby was among them. He had grown a beard since the spring, and his scar had a new one beside it.

1. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

Peigi sat down on an upturned barrel near them with her own bread. It was not a thing an engineer of the lights did, and the men went silent. After a while one of the older ones said something in the humans' tongue that made two of the others laugh. Joe did not laugh.

"He says," Joe said to her, in Dia-thìris, "that you've come to learn the making by sitting on it."

It was the first time she had heard him speak. His Dia-thìris was the north's, with the long vowels shorter, and quick.

"I came to ask about the taps," Peigi said. "I watched you in the spring. You fitted three and none of them dripped. The lights have barrels that drip at every tap on the island."

He looked at her for a while. Then he took a tap out of his apron pocket and passed it to her, and showed her how the thread was cut finer than the carpenters cut it, and how he wrapped it with tarred cord, and why the cord went on with the thread and not against it. It took him a long time to explain, because he did it with his hands more than with words, and she asked him to do it twice. The others went back to their bread.

"Where did you learn that?"

"Caol mhòr. There's boats at Caol mhòr. You learn taps on boats or you bail."

"And the dubhan? Where did you learn to work the retorts?"

"Here," said Joe.

"And before here?"

He took the tap back from her and put it in his apron pocket.

"Before here," he said, "I fitted boats at Caol mhòr."

That was all, and she did not ask him again. Peigi was no fool. She could see that the men at the jetty wall had stopped eating to listen, and that the foreman at the retort-house door had turned his head. Whatever there was to be told, it was not going to be told on an upturned barrel at noon to a woman from the capital with ink on her finger. She was not even sure that Joe Ashby knew it. He might have come south for the wage, as men go anywhere for a wage, and been set to the retorts because he was quick with his hands. The Tuathaich at the wall might have been hired off the quay for all she could tell. The company's hulls went up and down the whole coast.

In the afternoon one of the retorts burst.

She heard it from the yard, a crack like a mast going, and then the shouting. By the time she reached the retort-house door the men had the furnace raked out

and were throwing sand on the floor, and a Seann Skell man was sitting against the wall with his arm held out in front of him and the skin of it gone white and wet. The stuff had come out of the split seam of the retort in a black spray. Joe Ashby had him by the shoulder and was pouring water over the arm from a bucket, slowly, and talking to him in Dia-thìris the whole time about nothing: the weather, the herring, the fishwives. The foreman had gone for the doctor.

Peigi looked at the retort. It had split along the lower seam where the rivets were, and she could see why: the iron had been heated too fast on one side, where the furnace door was, and had not had time to follow on the other. She said so to the foreman when he came back. He looked at her as if she had spoken in the humans' tongue.

"Bank the fire on the door side," she said. "Or put a baffle in. Anyone who has tended a tower furnace could tell you. The heat wants to go round."

The foreman said he would tell the master when he came back.

She went back to the inn and drew a baffle for the retort furnace on a sheet of her pocket-book, with the measures, and sent it round to the works in the morning with a boy, unsigned. Then she went back to the capital with the glass for Tobar dhearg packed in straw on the coach roof, and she did not know until the autumn that the company had fitted her baffle to every furnace in the row.

III

Of Litir an Àrd-choimheadaiche

In an t-Samhain she was in the south a third time, for the new glass was being set in the lantern at Tobar dhearg and she would not leave that to anyone. It rained for a week. On the evening appointed she walked into Seann Skell along the cliff path, with the gale at her back and the rain coming over her shoulder, to hear Litir an Àrd-choimheadaiche¹ read in Brìde's house.

Everyone knew it was to be read. The letter had been talked of in the south since the summer. Alasdair mac Ìomhair, Àrd-choimheadaiche² of Òrd Bhrìde³ since before Cathal was crowned, had been asked by the custodians of four shires whether the new fuel was lawful to Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail⁴, and had taken the

1. the high custodian's letter on the new fuel

2. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

3. the order of Brìde's flame

whole of the summer and the autumn to answer. Some said he was waiting for the council. Some said he was waiting for the works to fail. The fishwives said he was waiting for the smell to go away.

On 25 an t-Samhain, DE 4, his answer was sent to every house of the order on the island, to be read aloud at the evening lamp, and at Seann Skell he read it himself.

The great house of Òrd Bhrìde at Seann Skell is the largest house of the order anywhere, and the oldest part of it is older than the kingdom: a long hall of grey stone with a roof of heavy slate, and at the far end, up three steps, Bride's altar, with the coal flame burning in its iron cup as it had burned since before the humans came. It was the only fire in the hall. The rain beat on the high windows and the wind came under the door, and the people stood close in their wet coats and steamed. There were more of them than the hall was built for. Peigi stood at the back against the wall, where she could see the altar over the heads.

The coal on the altar was poor. She could see that from the back of the hall. The flame had the coloured edge still, the dark blue and the green that the old coal gives; but it was low in the cup and it burned unevenly, and every so often it spat. The custodians fed it with tongs from a small box, a lump at a time, and the box was not full.

Alasdair mac Ìomhair came out from the vestry in his grey robe with the letter in his hand. He was sixty-two that year, tall and stooping, with a long face and a voice that did not need to be raised. He stood beside the altar, where the light fell on the page, and waited until the hall was still. Then he read.

The letter was not long. It greeted the houses in Bride's name. It said that a fuel was now made on the island out of what the pits cast away, by a man's hand and without the vein; that the custodians had asked whether the order might suffer it; and that he who wrote had taken counsel and prayed at the altar and read what the order had written since An Ceangal⁵. Then it gave the ruling.

"It is not forbidden," read Alasdair mac Ìomhair, "since it is not coal. And it is not blessed, since it is not coal."

He lowered the page. For a breath nobody in the hall moved, and the rain came on the windows. Then a custodian in the front row, a young man from one of the eastern houses, said aloud, "That's the whole of it?"

"That is the whole of it," said Alasdair mac Ìomhair.

4. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

5. the Binding (of the First Flame); lit. 'the bond'

There was a stir through the hall like wind through barley. Somebody near Peigi laughed, and stopped. An old woman in front of her said to her neighbour, very clearly, "Then my lamp has no blessing on it and I'll have to put up with it," and the people round her smiled, because many of them had dubhan lamps at home already, bought off the works' carts that summer. They had wanted to know whether they had done wrong. The Àrd-choimheadaiche had told them that they had not done wrong, and that they had not done right either, and that the vein did not come into it.

Peigi thought it was the cleverest thing she had heard a priest say. She thought, too, that it left every house on the island free to go on as it liked, and every custodian free to quarrel about it for years. She said so to Alasdair mac Ìomhair himself, half an hour later, which she had not meant to do.

He had come down the hall after the reading to speak to the people, as the custodians did, and she had not moved fast enough to get out of his way. He stopped in front of her and asked, pleasantly, whether she was not the engineer of the lights, who had been seen at the works; and she said she was; and before she could stop herself she said that the letter was very clever and would be argued for years.

"I hope so," said the old man. "A letter nobody argues is a letter nobody reads." He looked down at her with his long face. "You have come about the lights."

"I've come about the glass at Tobar dhearg."

"You have come about the lights," he said again, as if she had not spoken. "Your towers burn the island's coal, and the island's coal is failing, and you have come to see whether the new stuff will burn in a lantern." He looked back up the hall towards the altar, where the custodians were feeding the flame a lump at a time from the small box. "The houses will ask me next whether a sea-light may burn it. They will ask whether a flame of Bride's may be put out for it. I should be glad of more time than I had for this one."

"Would you forbid it?"

"I have just told the whole island," said Alasdair mac Ìomhair, "that I forbid nothing that is not coal." He smiled a little, and went on down the hall to the people waiting for him.

The letter was argued, as he said it would be. Within the month the school of Feallsanachd an Fheidh⁶ at Caol shean had written that a fuel made from the vein's own waste could not be called wholly *not coal*, since the spoil had lain

6. the Philosophy of the Deer, the druid schools' own name

against the seam for a thousand years; and the houses of Òrd an t-Seabhaig⁷ round Cnoc bheag, who had never owned the Àrd-choimheadaiche's right to rule on anything, wrote that they had not asked his opinion and were glad to have it all the same. The letter was read in every house of the order that winter and copied into the books of most of them, and it was quoted at supper-tables in the south for a long time. At the works, where they had heard that Alasdair mac Ìomhair was to rule on the fuel and had feared the worst, the master of the company opened a cask of the south-west wine for the whole yard, Tuathaich and all, and the fishwives said that the smell that night was the smell of a company that had been let off.

IV

Of the Twenty Barrels

On 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4, the works sold their first year's making. Peigi had not meant to be there. The glass at Tobar dhearg was set and the lantern lit behind it, the keeper had signed for it, and she had her seat taken on the coach for the week before midwinter. Then the gale came back and the coast road flooded under the cliff at the ford below Tobar dhearg, and the coach did not run for three days. She spent the three days at the inn on the quay, writing letters to the capital that could not be sent, and on the fourth she walked round the harbour to the works because she had nothing else to do and could not keep away.

The harbour was full of the company's hulls, riding at the mole with the black ring on their bows, and between them the fishing boats of the south coast were rafted three deep, waiting to load. The skippers had come in from all along the shore, from Tobar dhearg and the coves to the east of it and from as far as the western end of the coast, for the word had gone up and down that the works would sell before the midwinter and that dubhan was cheaper than coal by a third. The south-coast boats had burned coal in their galley-stoves and their riding-lamps since the humans' time. For five years now they had been burning driftwood and fish-oil and going cold, and more than one had gone on the rocks for

7. the Hawk order

want of a lamp that would stay lit in a gale. So they came in for dubhan, and they came in numbers.

The barrels came down out of the fourth shed on a slide of greased planks and went onto the boats by tackle from the jetty, two at a time, swinging out over the water with a man on the guide-rope. On the quay a clerk of the company sat at a table under a sailcloth with his ledger and his box of money, and the skippers stood in the rain in a line to pay him, in coin and in fish and in promises. Up the slope from the quay a row of carts stood with their tails to the works, and these were for the capital: dubhan for the lamp-houses of Cathair dhearg, bought by the barrel on the lamp-houses' account, to light the poorer streets that had been left dark for three winters to save coal.

Peigi stood by the jetty wall and watched the carts load. She counted them, because she always counted things. There were eleven carts, six barrels to a cart.

Above everything the chimney went up into the rain. Its smoke lay along the shore to the east, grey on grey, and in the thick air it looked taller than it was. It was the tallest thing on that coast. From the quay it stood higher than Bride's house on the height above the harbour; and the fishwives, who had never forgiven it, said it was put up where it was so that the Àrd-choimheadaiche¹ would have to look at it every morning.

At noon the master of the company came down onto the quay in his good coat to see the last carts off, and found her.

"The engineer," he said, and took her hand in both his again. "Stormbound with us. We are honoured twice." He looked at the carts. "Your baffle, I'm told. On every furnace. We've not split a retort since the summer." He did not say who had told him, and she did not ask.

"I'm glad of it," Peigi said.

"The company is grateful. If there were ever anything the company could do for the lights."

She had not known until he said it what she was going to do. She thought afterwards that she had known since the spring, since the lamp on the bench in the fourth shed, and had only been waiting for somebody to say it to her so that she could answer.

"Twenty barrels," she said. "On account, for the lights. For a trial."

The master of the company looked at her for a while with his head a little on one side, the way the gulls look. He knew as well as she did that an engineer of

Comhairle nan Taighean-solais² could not buy a barrel of lamp-glass without a letter from her masters, let alone twenty barrels of a fuel those masters had filed without a word. He knew too that she had no such letter, for if she had, she would have shown it to him in am Màrt.

"A trial of what?"

"Of whether it will burn a sea-light through a winter."

"And your masters have agreed to this trial."

"My masters," said Peigi, "will agree when they have the figures."

He laughed, a short bark, and called the clerk from under the sailcloth. The clerk wrote it in the ledger while the rain dripped off the edge of the cloth onto the page: *twenty barrels to Comhairle nan Taighean-solais, on account, for the engineer*. Peigi signed it. Her hand was steady. Her name went down in the company's book below the skippers of the south coast and the lamp-houses of the capital, in the same black ink, and she noticed that there was coal-dust in the ink, and did not know why she noticed it.

"Where will you have them sent?"

She had not thought of that either. The towers were at the island's ends: Tobar dhearg on the southern cape a few miles along the shore, Baile ìseal far away on the eastern cape, the three others in the north. Tobar dhearg was the nearest and the easiest, and at Tobar dhearg every soul who worked the light would know by the next morning that the engineer from the capital was burning the new stuff under their tower, and so would the house of Brìde on the height. She thought of the keeper's face.

"Hold them for me," she said. "I'll write."

"Twenty barrels held for the engineer," said the master of the company. "Joe."

Joe Ashby came out from the fourth shed with his sleeves rolled and a lump of chalk in his hand. He had heard the whole of it; she could see that he had. He went along the row by the shed wall and counted off twenty barrels and rolled them out of the line, one at a time, onto the planks under the eaves where the rain did not reach. On the head of each one he chalked a mark. She went to look at it when he had done. It was a lantern: a square with a flame inside it, drawn in four strokes and a curl, the same on all twenty.

"That's the lights'," he said.

"The lights have no mark."

1. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

2. the Lighthouse Board

"They have now," said Joe Ashby. He put the chalk in his apron pocket, next to the taps, and went back into the shed.

The last of the carts for the capital went up the slope at the fall of the dark, their lanterns lit with the stuff they carried and swinging on the tail-boards. The fishing boats cast off from the mole one by one and went out past the light on the end of it into the rain, and the smell of their galley-stoves came back across the water, tar and wet hearth and something sharp; the smell of the works, going out along the coast in every boat. Peigi stood on the quay until the last lamp was out of sight round the headland. Then she went back to the inn and wrote to her masters.

It took her until past midnight. The letter said that she had bought twenty barrels of dubhan on her masters' account, without leave, at the works of Comann nan Sciobairean³ at Seann Skell of the south; and she gave the price, which was a third less than the price of coal for the same hours of light; and she said that she asked their leave to run a trial of the stuff in a spare lamp, in the yard below one of their towers, for a hundred nights, with a man to keep the log. If they would not give leave, she would pay for the barrels herself out of her wage, and they could stop it from her quarter by quarter.

She read it over. It named no tower. Of the chimney it said nothing, nor of the locked shed, the Tuathaich at the jetty wall or the wine. On the last line of the letter she wrote the date and signed it; and out of the window, over the harbour, the smoke of the works went up into the dark where she could not see it, and she could smell it still.

3. the company of shipmasters who built the dubhan works at the southern Seann Skell

CHAPTER FIVE

OF the Hundred Nights

DE 5

I

Of the Barrels at the Slip

The twenty barrels came up the east coast at the end of an Gearran in the hold of a salt-boat of Àth bheag, which had carried salt down to Seann Skell of the south and had nothing to bring home. Her skipper took them because the engineer of Comhairle nan Taighean-solais¹ paid the freight in coin and in advance, and because nobody told him what was in them. He found out off the southern cape, when the sun came out for an afternoon and warmed the staves. By the time he brought her round under the eastern cape and in to the slip at Baile ìseal his crew were sleeping on deck with their coats over their faces, and he told Peigi nic Ascaill, who stood waiting on the wet stones with her bag at her feet, that he would carry pigs for her next time, live ones, but not this.

"It keeps the weather out," Peigi said. "Put your head in a coal-cart and tell me which you'd sooner."

"The coal-cart."

"So would everyone. Help me get them up the slip."

Baile ìseal is a small place. It was some ninety souls that year, in low houses of grey stone along one street that runs down to the slip, with the dunes going away north towards the ford at Àth bheag and the cape going away south into the sea. The tower stands out at the end of the cape, a couple of miles below the town, where Torcall Clachair had it raised in An Aois Choigreach², sitting in a chair at

1. the Lighthouse Board

2. the Age of Strangers

the foot of the headland because he was too old by then to climb. Long before the tower the households of that coast kept a fire on the cape in turn, to bring their boats home in a storm, and the old people of Baile ìseal will still tell you that the light is there to bring boats home, whatever Comhairle nan Taighean-solais has painted over its door. The keepers of the light were the town's watch as well. Sea-thieves had come ashore on that coast within living memory and burned the salt-sheds at Àth bheag, and the town had no other watch but the woman in the lantern-room with a glass.

Peigi had the barrels carted out along the cape by a carter of Baile ruadh, whose family had carried the keepers' coal and meal since the light was lit, and who charged her twice his rate for the smell. He set them down in the yard at the tower's foot, in the lee of the coal-store, twenty black casks in two rows. The chalk on their heads had run in the salt-boat's hold, but the mark could still be read on most of them: a square with a flame inside it, four strokes and a curl. The carter asked what it was.

"The lights' mark," said Peigi.

"The lights have got no mark."

"They have now," she said, and paid him.

She had chosen Baile ìseal in the coach going home from Seann Skell at the year's end, with her pocket-book on her knee and the five towers written down the page. Tobar dhearg was nearest the works, and the whole south coast would have known by the next morning that the engineer of the lights was burning the new stuff under its tower, and so would the house of Bhrìde on the height above the harbour. The three towers of the north were far, and cold, and their keepers were not people she knew. Baile ìseal was as far from the capital as a tower can be and still be on the island. It kept Na Seann Spioradan³, and had no house of Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail⁴ within a day's walk to take offence; and its old keeper, retired, still lived at the landward end of the yard wall. She had met him twice, years before, on her rounds, and remembered that he had corrected her arithmetic.

Her masters' answer had found her at the capital in am Faoinleach, and she carried it folded inside her coat and had read it enough times to have it by heart. Comhairle nan Taighean-solais, the secretary wrote, saw no objection to a trial of the engineer's burner in the yard of Taigh-solais Baile ìseal⁵, at the engineer's own

3. the Old Spirits

4. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

5. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

charge and in her own time, on condition that the light was not touched and the keeper's duties in no way hindered. There was a second paragraph. The secretary had observed that twenty barrels of fuel had been entered to its account at Seann Skell by the engineer's hand, and would be glad to learn under what head.

Peigi had not answered the second paragraph. She meant to answer it with a hundred nights.

The keeper met her at the tower door that afternoon. Seonag nic Thòmais was some years younger than Peigi, broad in the shoulder and red with weather, with the keys of the tower on a strap across her chest and coal-dust ground into the knuckles of both hands. A copy of the secretary's letter had come to her too, and she had it in her apron pocket, and she took it out and held it up without unfolding it, the way a man at a fair holds up a paper that proves the cow is his.

"The yard's yours," she said. "That's what it says. The stair's mine."

"I've no wish to go up your stair."

"That's as may be." Seonag looked past her at the barrels. "That light's burned coal since before my mother was born. Murchadh kept it thirty-one years and I've kept it eight, and there's never been a night it went out. Whatever you've got in those, it doesn't come past the door."

"It won't," said Peigi. "I'll want a man to keep the log. Somebody who knows a light and isn't me. My masters won't take my word for a hundred nights, and it's right not to."

Seonag considered this. Something moved at the corner of her mouth.

"Murchadh," she said. "He's nothing to do all night but sit at his window and tell me I'm burning it too high. You can give him something else to look at."

II

Of the Spare Lamp and the Log

Murchadh mac Coinnich was seventy-one that spring. His knees had gone, and he walked with two sticks and sat with both legs stretched out before him, but his eyes were as good as they had been when he first climbed the stair as a boy from Baile ruadh, and his hand was square and exact. He had the cottage at the landward end of the yard wall, two rooms and a peat fire, with a window that looked straight up the tower to the lantern. He heard Peigi out without a word, filling his pipe and not lighting it.

"What does it cost?" he said at the end.

She told him: a third less than coal, for the same hours of light, at the works' price; and the price of coal still climbing, and the price at the works falling.

"Who makes it?"

"A company of shipmasters at Seann Skell."

"That's who sells it," said Murchadh. "Who made it first?"

"A man in the north. A Tuathach. They call the stuff by his name."

"Dubhan," said Murchadh. "The carrier from Àth bheag talks of nothing else. He says it's made out of the muck the pits throw up, and it stinks like a burnt boot." He struck a light for his pipe at last. "Well. I'll keep your log. I'll write down what I see and not what you'd like to see, and I'll rule the book myself, and you'll pay me the lights' rate for an under-keeper, since that's what you're making of me."

"Agreed."

"And you'll not argue with what I write."

"I'll argue," said Peigi. "You needn't change it."

He looked at her for a while through the smoke and then nodded, as if that was the answer he had wanted.

The spare lamp was in the coal-store under sacking. It was the tower's storm-lantern, a great box of iron and glass with a silvered bowl at the back of it, which the keepers hung on the gallery rail on the nights when the main grate was drawn and cleaned of its clinker, so that the cape was never dark. It had a grate of its own the size of a man's hat. Peigi took the grate out and threw it on the heap, and in its place she set the burner that the fitters at the works had made to her drawing over the midwinter: a broad round wick in two rings, one inside the other, with a brass drum below it to hold the fuel and a pipe coiled twice round the foot of the chimney, so that the heat of the flame would warm the stuff on its way to the wick. The fuel came out of the barrel thick and slow, like treacle in the cold, and in a cold lamp it would not climb a wick at all. Warmed, it ran like oil. She had worked that out on the bench in the fourth shed at the works in the spring, with the master of the company watching her and not knowing what he was watching.

She had a stage built for it in the yard of old ship's timber from the beach, twenty feet high with a ladder, so that the lamp stood above the yard wall and showed to the sea over the lip of the cape. From the water it would be a second light below the tower's, low and a little to the landward side. She measured the angle three times and had the stage shifted a yard to the north, and the carpenter

from Baile ìseal, who had built boats for forty years and never shifted anything a yard for a woman, did it without a word, because the keeper had told him to.

Murchadh ruled the log on the afternoon of the first day, at his table by the window, with a straight-edge and a pot of the keepers' ink. He gave each night one line across two pages. The headings were his own: the night and the day of the month; wind; weather; lit; out; wick; smoke; and at the far right, with the most room, *what the boats said*.

"The boats'll say nothing," said Peigi. "They'll not know it's there."

"They'll know," said Murchadh. "And they'll have opinions. You've never lived in a fishing town."

She lit it first on 4 am Màrt, DE 5, at dusk, with the wind light from the west and a clear green sky over the land. She warmed the coil with a spirit-cup, as she had practised at the works, and when the stuff began to run she touched a spill to the wick. It took, and crawled round the rings, and stood up in the chimney yellow and a little smoky; and then, as the coil warmed and the draught drew, it lengthened and brightened until it was nearly white, and the silvered bowl behind it caught it and threw it out over the wall. Peigi came down the ladder and walked out to the lip of the cape to look at it from as near the sea as she could get.

Above it, the tower's own light burned at the top of the stair: a coal flame in its great grate, red at the heart and ringed with that dark coloured edge that only the island's coal gives, and all of it made large by the glass. Below it, and to one side, her lamp burned yellow-white and steady, smaller, plainer, and in the clear air nearly as far-reaching. From where she stood she could see both. She stood there until her feet were cold.

When she came back Murchadh had lit his own lamp and had the log open.

Night the first, he had written. Wind W, light. Clear. Lit at dusk. Wick took well. Smoke: some, black, going off to the E. Smell: bad. Boats: none out.

"Smell's no heading," said Peigi.

"It is tonight," said Murchadh.

The burner clogged at two in the morning. The flame went down on one side and then the other, yellow, sullen, and a coil of black smoke went up the chimney and blackened the glass inside. Peigi went up the ladder in her coat with a lantern in her teeth and found the wick crusted over with a hard black char, like the crust on a burnt pot, which the stuff laid down as it burned. She trimmed it with the scissors and it came up again. At four it crusted again. She trimmed it again. At

sunrise, when she put it out, she had slept an hour on a chair in Murchadh's kitchen, and her hands were black to the wrist.

Out at sunrise, Murchadh wrote. Wick crusted twice, trimmed twice. Engineer up the ladder with scissors at two and four. Said a word I will not write.

III

Of What the Boats Said

The first fortnight was a fortnight of the wick. Peigi strained the fuel through sailcloth into the drum to take out the grit and the lumps, and it crusted less. She warmed the barrel it came from by the coal-store wall on the sunny afternoons, and it crusted less again. She had the tinsmith of Àth bheag make her a second pair of wick-rings, so that one pair could burn while the other was soaked clean in a pan of the stuff itself, and on the tenth night the wick burned from dusk to dawn with one trimming. Murchadh wrote *trimmed once* under *wick* without comment, and she saw him look at it afterwards with his head on one side.

On the eleventh night a squall came in off the sea after midnight, hard cold rain driven almost level, and the chimney-glass, which was hot as a kettle, cracked from top to foot with a noise like a pistol. The flame staggered and smoked and did not go out. Peigi had three spare glasses. She put one in with the rain running down her neck, and in the morning she had the tinsmith make a hood of sheet iron to go over the top of the lantern and keep the rain off the glass. After that the glasses held.

Night the eleventh, the log says. Wind SE, strong, squalls of rain. Glass cracked at one. Lamp did not go out. New glass in by the engineer, who was wet.

The nights grew shorter, and the lamp burned less of the stuff each night; Peigi counted it, a finger-mark on the dipstick in the drum each dawn, and wrote the figures in her pocket-book beside the tower's coal. She knew the tower's coal as well as she knew her own wage. Seonag's lad, a boy of Baile ruadh who carried coal up the stair in two buckets forty times a night on a bad night, told her one morning how many buckets had gone up, and after that he told her every morning, without being asked, and she gave him a coin at the month's end, which the keeper did not see.

The coal in those years was poor. It came from the bottom of the failing vein, dear and slaty, and it burned dull and left a great deal of clinker behind. When Murchadh first climbed the stair it had burned with a green edge and a blue heart, he said, and on a still night you could see the colours from the sea two miles off. Now the edge had gone muddy, and in the last year Comhairle nan Taighean-solais¹ had written to all five keepers that the grate was to be kept low on clear nights and fed high only in thick weather. Seonag had read that letter out to Murchadh in his kitchen and then put it in the fire.

The fishing boats of Baile ìseal went out to the long lines in the spring, a dozen of them, open boats with a lugsail and four men, and they came home at dark or after. Murchadh had been right: by the fourth night they knew the lamp was there, and by the tenth they had opinions. He wrote them down in the wide space at the right, in their own words, as nearly as he could get them, with the teller's name when the teller would give it.

A lamp in a yard, one said. Like a star fallen in the nettles, said another. Too low. No use to a ship in the open sea. Too white; it hurts the eyes. Where's the colour gone. It smells from half a mile out when the wind's off the land, you'd find the cape by your nose. An old man who had not been to sea for twenty years came out along the cape on purpose to tell Murchadh that he would not have steered by it in his day, and Murchadh wrote that down too, with the old man standing over him to see that he spelled his name right.

Late in am Màrt the salt-boat came back up the coast and her skipper walked out to the cape to look. He stood at the foot of the stage with his hands in his pockets for a long time and said at last that it was a better light than it was a smell, and that was something. Murchadh wrote it in.

Peigi slept in the day in a room of the keeper's cottage that Seonag let her have, because there was nowhere else in the yard, and ate at the keeper's table, and the two women were civil to each other across the bread. Seonag did not come near the stage. In the evenings she came down the tower door to the yard at dusk with the keys on her chest, and stood a breath in the doorway, looking out to sea and not at the lamp, and went up again; and the tower light would come on above, red, and then fuller, as the lad fed the grate. In the mornings she came down black to the elbows and went to her bed without a word. Once, in the first week of an Giblean, Peigi heard her on the stair in the small hours, going up and down

1. the Lighthouse Board

between the coal-store and the lantern with her own buckets because the lad was sick, and counted forty-four journeys before she fell asleep.

On the forty-first night the haar came in.

It came off the sea in the afternoon, grey and wet and thick as fleece, as it does on that coast in the spring when a warm air comes over the cold water; and it lay high on the cape, as a haar will sometimes, with a clear ribbon under it along the face of the water. The tower's light burned up inside it. From the slip you could see a red smear in the grey where it should have been, and nothing else. Peigi's lamp burned below it, in the clear ribbon, and from the slip you could see it plain.

Calum mac Iain's boat was the last in that night. He had gone out farther than the others after the lines, and the haar had found him on the way home. He told the story afterwards at the slip, where Peigi heard it, and he told it more than once, so that the log has two forms of it. In the first he was steering for the smear in the haar, which is all a sensible man could do, when he saw a light under it, low and white, and took it for somebody on the rocks with a lamp and came in to see who was drowning. In the second he knew very well what it was, and had been steering by it for half an hour, and would do it again. Either way he came round the cape with the white light on his right hand and the smear above it and found the slip without touching a stone.

The next morning he walked out to the yard and looked at the lamp for a while, burnt out and black-glassed in the daylight on its stage, and then went to Murchadh's window.

"You'll not write that," he said. "Don't let Seonag see it."

Night the forty-first, the log says. Wind E, light. Haar, thick from the afternoon, lying high. Tower light lost in it from the slip. This lamp seen under it. Wick trimmed once. Boats: Calum mac Iain came in by this lamp and not by the tower. Asked me not to write it.

Seonag read it all the same. She read the whole log at the end of every week. Murchadh left it open on his table on purpose.

On the eve of Bealltainn the young people of Baile ìseal lit their fire on the dunes north of the town, as they did every year, and put out the hearths of the houses and lit them again from it the next morning. A girl of the town came out along the cape on the morning of the feast with a shovel of the fire in a pail, as her mother had carried it out to the tower in Murchadh's time and her grandmother before that, and the lad took it up the stair to the grate. On the step of the stage

she stopped, and looked at Peigi's lamp, and asked whether it was to have some too.

"It lights from a spill," said Peigi.

"It's to have some," said Murchadh from his window.

So the girl climbed the ladder with her pail, and Peigi, who thought it nonsense and knew better than to say so, took the spill and lit it from the *Bealltainn* coals, and put it in her pocket-book for that night, and lit the lamp with it at dusk. Murchadh wrote *lit from the Bealltainn fire* under *lit*. That was the fifty-ninth night.

IV

Of the Seventieth Night

The gale came on the seventieth night out of the south-east, off the open sea. The glass had been falling all day in Murchadh's kitchen, and the swell had come in under a fine sky long before the wind did, so that the old men at the slip knew what was coming and kept their boats in. Two did not. They had gone out before dawn to lift lines they had shot the day before, far out to the south-east, and they were not back by noon, and by the middle of the afternoon the wind was up and the rain behind it.

By dusk it was a whole gale. The sea came up the cape in sheets and the spray went over the yard wall and rattled on the coal-store roof like shot. Peigi and the lad had lashed the stage to the wall with the carter's ropes in the afternoon, and she had wired the chimney-glass into the lantern at the top and bottom, and under the hood; and when she lit the lamp at dusk the flame lay over flat in the chimney, and smoked, and roared, and stood up again. She stayed on the ladder with it until she was sure. Then she went down and sat at the foot of the stage in her oilskin with her back to the timber and the dipstick in her lap, and Murchadh opened his window a hand's breadth against the weather so that he could see both lights at once, and sat at it with the log.

The trouble in the tower began a little after midnight. Peigi saw it from the yard before she understood it: the red of the tower light went dull, and then dark red, and then brown, like a coal dropped out of a grate on to the hearth. Smoke was coming out of the lantern's vents at the top, and blowing flat, and the wind was driving it down on to the gallery and round the glass.

She learned afterwards what had happened, from the lad. The roof of the coal-store had lifted in the first of the gale and let the rain in on the heap, and the coal that went up the stair from nine o'clock on was wet. The grate would not draw on it. The wind came down the vent at the top of the lantern as it will in a south-easter, the one wind the vent was never built against, and drove the smoke back into the room; and the poor coal of those years, wet, lay in the grate and smoked and sulked and would not blaze. Seonag raked it and fed it and raked it. She opened the vent and the wind came down it harder. She shut it and the grate died under her hands. The inside of the glass went black with soot. From the sea, the light of Baile ìseal was a red smudge, and then a brown one, and for the best part of two hours, from the second hour after midnight to the fourth, there was hardly any light at all.

Peigi went to the tower door. It was shut, and she could hear Seonag above, shouting to the lad for dry coal from the back of the heap, and the wind in the stair like a beast in a pit. She put her hand on the latch.

"Keep off my stair!" Seonag's voice came down the stone. She could not have seen who it was. She knew.

Peigi took her hand off the latch and went back to the stage.

Her own lamp was burning. It burned low and yellow when the gusts came, and long and white between them, and it smoked, and the smoke went off towards the land in a black rag; and every half-hour she went up the ladder and trimmed it, and Murchadh at his window called the time out to her and wrote it down, and every half-hour the lad came down out of the tower door with his buckets and looked at it and went up again with the dry coal. The drum held. The wire held. The hood held. The chimney-glass steamed and cleared and steamed. And all the while it showed out over the lip of the cape to the sea, low and plain, a second light below the tower, and for two hours the only one.

The first of the two boats came round the cape at about the third hour. Peigi did not see her. She saw a lantern on the water to the south, going up and down in the seas at a great distance, and then going behind the point, and she did not know until the morning that it had been Calum mac Iain's brother's boat. The second came in an hour after, with a torn sail and a man with a broken arm, and her skipper said at the slip in the morning, before he had his boots off, that he had not seen the tower since midnight and had steered for the white light under the cape because there was nothing else to steer for, and had not known what it was, and did not care.

At the fourth hour the tower light came back. Seonag had got dry coal from the back of the heap under the tarpaulin, and wedged the vent half-open with a bar so that the wind could neither blow straight down nor shut it, and at last the grate drew. The red came up through the soot, dull and then fuller, and by the first grey of dawn it was burning as it should. Peigi's lamp burned on below it until sunrise, and she put it out as the sun came up out of the sea to the east, far off, where Ceò Mhanannain¹ lies along the edge of Muir Mhanannain²; and then she sat down on the step of the stage because her legs would not hold her.

Seonag came down the stair when the sun was up. She was black from her hair to her boots, and her eyes were red, and her hands were cut about the knuckles from the rake. She stood at the tower door and looked across the yard at the lamp on its stage, dark now, with its glass black and its drum wet, and at Peigi on the step.

"It's lower than my light," she said.

"It is."

"A light that low's no use to a ship in the open sea."

"No."

Seonag looked at it a while longer.

"It didn't go out," she said, and went into the cottage and shut the door.

Murchadh had written the night up before either of them came in. His hand is as square that morning as any other in the book.

Night the seventieth. Wind SE, a whole gale from dusk, rain. Lit at dusk. Out at sunrise. Wick trimmed every half-hour. Smoke: much, blown away to the land. The tower's light failed from the second hour after midnight to the fourth, for wet coal and a down-draught; the keeper kept at it. This lamp did not fail. Boats: two came in by it. They said nothing about it. They were too wet.

V

Of the Hundredth Night

A

1. Manannan's mist over the eastern sea

2. Manannan's sea, round Dia-thìr

fter the seventieth night the lad came down out of the tower every evening at dusk, sent by the keeper, to ask whether the lamp was lit; and when it was, he went up again and said so. Seonag herself did not come.

A roofer came from Baile ruadh in the week after the gale and put the coal-store to rights, and a letter came from the secretary at Cathair dhearg in answer to the keeper's report of the night, asking for particulars of the wet coal and the down-draught, and saying nothing of the yard. Seonag gave Peigi the letter to read at breakfast. It was the first thing she had given her.

Peigi began to write her report in those weeks, a page or two in the day before she slept, at Murchadh's table while he sat by the fire. She had every night in her pocket-book beside the tower's: the fuel burned by the finger on the dipstick, the coal by the lad's count of buckets, the hours from dusk to dawn, the price of each at the works and at the pit-head. She did the sums three times, and Murchadh did them once in his head and found that she had carried a figure wrong in the second, and she did them a fourth time. At that rate the barrels would last the hundred nights and some over. By the end of the trial she had burned eleven of the twenty and some of a twelfth.

The nights shortened. By the start of an t-Ògmhios the lamp was lit late and put out early, and in the few hours between the sky in the north never went all the way dark, but lay green and pale along the edge of the land; and on the clear evenings, far out over the sea to the east, Ceò Mhanannain¹ could be seen lying on the water where it always lies, grey, at the very edge of sight. Peigi had never lived where she could see it. On the calm nights, with the lamp trimmed and the drum full and nothing to do until the next trimming, she sat at the lip of the cape and looked at it. The straight way east had never been found through it. She thought, not for the first time, that a lamp is a strange thing to set against a sea like that, and that the people of Baile ìseal had been setting one there since An Aois Ailein².

The boats had stopped saying things. In the wide space at the right of the log, through the last weeks, the line goes on night after night, *boats: nothing*, and *boats: nothing*, and once *boats: Calum mac Iain asks when it's to go up the stair*, which Murchadh wrote down without a word and Peigi read without one.

On the ninety-sixth night Seonag came down out of the tower door at dusk and crossed the yard to the foot of the stage, where she had not stood in three months. She looked up at the lamp for some time, lit, the flame standing tall and

1. Manannan's mist over the eastern sea

2. the Age of Ailean

nearly white in its chimney. Then she asked how the coil round the chimney foot was made, and how many turns it had, and why two and not three; and whether the drum would take a bigger charge; and how often the wick was changed in a week of bad weather; and what the stuff did to brass. They were an engineer's questions, and Peigi answered them one by one, as exactly as she could, with the lad standing by with his buckets forgotten in his hands. At the end of it Seonag nodded.

"The stair's still mine," she said.

"I know it is."

"Good," said Seonag, and went up to light her own.

The hundredth night was fair, with a light wind from the west and a long clear dusk. Peigi lit the lamp herself, with a spill, at the hour Murchadh called; she warmed the coil and touched the wick and watched it climb and stand, as she had watched it ninety-nine times before, and came down the ladder and stood a while at the foot. The tower's light came on above it, red, and fuller, as the lad fed the grate.

She trimmed the wick at midnight and at two. There was nothing else to do. She sat on the step of the stage with her coat round her and her back to the timber, and did not sleep, and watched the two lights go out over the sea, one high and one low, and the short night go grey in the north and then pale along the eastern water. When the sun came up she climbed the ladder and put the lamp out.

Murchadh had the log open on the table when she came in, and the pen in the ink. She had thought, in the night, that she might ask to write the last line herself. She held her tongue. It was his book.

He wrote it slowly, and blotted it, and turned the book round on the table so that she could read it.

Night the hundredth. Wind W, light. Clear; Ceò Mhanannain on the sea to the E, as always. Lit at dusk. Out at sunrise. Wick trimmed twice. Smoke: some. Boats: said nothing about it. They have got used to it.

OF the Boatwrights of Caol Fhiadhaich

DE 5 – 6

I

Of the Engine in the Rope-Shed

In the summer that the trial lamp on the eastern cape ran out its hundred nights, some ninety miles to the west, at the other end of the south coast, a boatwright of Caol fhiadhaich bought an engine for the price of old iron. The boatwrights of the south-west tell it that way, as a bargain first and a quarrel after, and they begin it with the town.

Caol fhiadhaich stands at the head of its strait, a mile of broken water between the harbour wall and the skerries, where the tide runs one way under a wind blowing the other and the sea stands up in ridges. Its pilots had earned their bread there since An Aois Ailein¹, taking strangers through the rocks for a fee and an offering at the wolf-stone by the harbour mouth, as the houses of Òrd na Cloiche² taught. Its own fishers had been the first to sail round into the southern sea, and the lane they opened still bore the town's name, Slighe-mhara Caol fhiadhaich³. That was long ago. In the humans' time the fleet could not pay the harbour dues in marks and sold half its boats to A' Chompanaidh⁴, and the men who had sailed them went into the pits. The harbour wall was built afterwards, out of the town's share of the western tolls, and was better than the fleet it sheltered. By the sum-

1. the Age of Ailean

2. the order of the Stone

3. the southern sea-lane

4. the Company

mer of this tale the boats of Caol fhiadhaich were some thirty open hulls and a dozen decked ones, under sail and oar, and when the wind came into the south-west and stayed there they lay along the wall for a week at a time and the town ate its own salt fish.

Sorcha nic Dhùghaill kept the yard at the west end of the harbour, under the rope-walk. She had been bound to the guild at sixteen, at Ros dhomhain, and had served her seven years on the slips there before she came home to take the yard from her mother's brother, who had built boats in it for forty years and died with an adze in his hand, or so he had always promised he would. She was forty-one in that summer, broad in the shoulder, grey early, and known along the coast for two things: her hulls did not leak, and she did not lower her price for anyone, not for the pilots and not for the priests of Òrd na Cloiche.

In an t-Ògmhios she went up to Ros dhomhain to buy copper nails of the guild's stamp and to see a timber merchant about larch. It was a long day on the mail-cart, which changed horses twice on the road, and a long day back. In a chandler's yard behind the coal quay, among anchors and stove-in water-casks, she found an engine.

It had come out of a harbour launch, one of the little craft that had once towed the coal ships off the quay when the wind was foul. The launch had been laid up eight years, since the price of coal passed what a launch could earn in a day, and it had been broken up for its planking. The engine sat on two baulks of timber in the nettles with a sheet of tarred canvas over it, and the chandler wanted it gone. Sorcha put her hand on the flywheel and turned it. It moved, stiff with old grease, and something inside answered with a slow clank.

"What do you want for it?" she said.

"What would you do with it?" said the chandler. "It eats coal. You couldn't feed it."

"I didn't ask what it eats."

He named a price for old iron. She paid it out of the nail money, and went home without the nails.

It came down the coast road a week later on a wain drawn by four oxen, and took two days to do what the carrier did in one. The children of the harbour walked beside it the last mile. It was set down in the rope-shed at the back of the yard, where it was dry, and there it stood for a month while Sorcha went round it with a lamp and a notebook and took it apart as far as she dared.

She knew nothing of engines. Neither did anyone in Caol fhiadhaich. What she knew was that the south-coast boats had been burning dubhan all that year in their stoves and their lamps, since the works at Seann Skell sold its first making to them, and that the stuff came west along the coast in barrels on the coasters and could be bought on the quay. It burned, it stank, and it was cheap. An engine was a fire and a wheel, she reasoned, and the wheel did not care what the fire was made of.

The smith of the harbour, Seonaidh Bàn, a man who spoke some dozen words a day and made each of them count, came and looked at the firebox and the grate. He went away, and came back two days later with a burner of his own making: a trough of iron with a row of holes along it and a pipe and a cock to feed it from a tank. He had copied it, he said, from the stove of a coaster out of Seann Skell on the southern coast that lay in the harbour that week, and made it bigger.

"Will it serve?" said Sorcha.

"It'll burn," said Seonaidh Bàn. That was all she got from him that day.

II

Of the Unbored Keel

The engine was the easy part. The hard part was the boat.

Lachann mac Neacail came to her about it before she went looking for him. He had a decked boat of thirty feet, *An Ròn Dubh*¹, built in that same yard by her uncle twenty years before, and she was a good boat, heavy in the bilge and dry, and slow. In any foul wind she was the last boat home, and Lachann was tired of it. He was a lean man with a face burnt the colour of a kipper, and he had lost a brother to the strait. He came into the rope-shed one evening, looked at the engine on its baulks for a long while, and said: "If you put that in a boat, put it in mine."

"She'd have to be opened," said Sorcha. "Aft. Through the post."

"Then open her."

Every apprentice of the guild learned the rule in his first year, before he was let near an adze, and learned it in the old tongue as the first wrights of the fellowship had said it: *Cha tollar an druim*, the keel is not bored. A boat's backbone was laid

1. the Black Seal, Lachann mac Neacail's fishing boat of Caol fhiadhaich, the first fitted with a dubhan engine

whole and kept whole. You fastened to it, you scarfed it, you might shape it; you did not put a hole through it below the water. The rule was older than the guild's charter, older than the humans' coming, and it had kept a great many boats afloat. Sorcha had had it beaten into her on the slips at Ros dhomhain at sixteen, and she believed in it.

To put a shaft out through the stern of *An Ròn Dubh*, to turn a screw behind her, the post had to be bored and the deadwood under it, a long hole slanting down and aft, and a tube of copper set in it packed with oakum and tallow so the sea would not come in. There was no other road for the shaft to go.

She sat up two nights with the lines of the boat laid out on the loft floor in chalk, working out the angle. On the third morning she had *An Ròn Dubh* hauled up the slip and chocked, and sent for the long auger.

The other yards came to watch. There were three besides hers in Caol fhiadhaich, and all of them were members of the guild, as she was: old Donnchadh Ruadh, who had been bound in the same year as the guild's present master and never let anyone forget it; the two brothers of the yard below the church of Òrd na Cloiche²; and a young woman, Raonaid nic Coinnich, who had served her time only the year before. They stood at the head of the slip with their arms folded and said nothing while Sorcha set the auger and began to turn.

It took her the whole of a long day. The post was oak, and hard. Twice she stopped to sharpen the bit. Twice she crawled under the hull with a lamp and a plumb-line to see that she had not wandered. Towards evening the auger broke through into the light behind the post, and a curl of pale oak came out on the end of it and dropped on the shingle. Old Donnchadh picked it up and put it in his pocket. He did not say why.

The engine went into the boat a fortnight later, bedded on oak and bolted through her floors. The tank for the dubhan went forward of it, and the smith's burner under it. The shaft went out through the new hole in its copper tube, and the screw on the end of it was a two-bladed thing that Seonaidh Bàn had cast in bronze from a pattern Sorcha had carved in pine, and it was ugly, and it was true.

They tried her on an evening near the end of an Lùnastal, with no wind at all and the harbour flat as a plate. Half the town was on the wall. Lachann was at the helm. Sorcha was down in the well with the engine, and Seonaidh Bàn was beside her with the cock of the burner in his fist. He opened it. The dubhan caught with

2. the order of the Stone

a soft thump and a smell like a tannery on fire, and a black smoke rolled up out of the hatch and over the wall, where the people on it coughed and swore and did not move back. They waited. It was a long wait. Then the engine gave a groan, and a clank, and another, and the flywheel turned, and turned faster, and the shaft began to turn in its tube.

An Ròn Dubh moved. She went out from the slip with her sails furled and her oars shipped, pushing a little wave in front of her, and she crossed the harbour in a straight line to the wolf-stone and turned, slowly, and came back. Nobody on the wall cheered. They watched her the way they would watch a dog walking on its hind legs.

At the wolf-stone the pilots were sitting on their bench as they did every evening, waiting for a ship that might want them. The eldest of them, Ailig Mòr, who had taken more hulls through the strait than any man living, watched *An Ròn Dubh* go by within an oar's length, stinking and clanking, with no sail on her. He took his pipe out of his mouth.

"That'll frighten the fish," he said.

"It frightened you," said Lachann from the helm, and the pilots laughed, and Ailig Mòr put his pipe back in his mouth and said nothing more that night.

III

Of the Guild's Letter

Word went up the road to Ros dhomhain faster than the engine had come down it. A timber merchant told a Chandler, the Chandler told a warden of the guild, and the warden told the master.

The letter came on 7 an t-Sultain, DE 5, on the carrier's cart with the mail and a crate of hens. It was addressed to the members of Comann nan Saor-luinge¹ at Caol fhiadhaich, all four yards together, and sealed with the guild's seal, the adze and the ship. Sorcha had it from the carrier's hand at the yard gate and carried it unopened to the net-loft over the fish-store, where the four yards met when they had anything to meet about, which was seldom. She waited until they were all there. Then she broke the seal and read it aloud.

It was not long. The master of the guild, Pàdraig mac an t-Saoir, wrote that he had heard with grief that a member of the guild at Caol fhiadhaich had bored the

keel of a boat below the water to take an engine; that the rule of the unbored keel was the first rule of the fellowship and older than its charter; that the work was unlawful for any member of the guild; that it was to cease in every yard of the town; and that a member who went on with it would be struck from the roll, and fined, and his apprentices unbound. Below his name the wardens had set theirs, eleven of them. The letter used *his* throughout. There had not been a woman among the guild's masters since its charter was taken.

When she had finished there was a silence in the loft. The fish-store below them smelled of brine. Somebody's dog was barking on the wall.

"Well," said old Donnchadh Ruadh. "You bored it."

"I bored it."

"Does it leak?"

"No."

"Then he's wrong," said Donnchadh, "and he always was. He was wrong on the slip when we were boys." He took the curl of oak out of his pocket, the one he had picked up off the shingle, and turned it in his fingers. "But he's the master. What'll you do?"

"There are six skippers waiting on my slip," said Sorcha, "and there's another engine in a yard at Inis chrom that I can have for the carting. I'll do the work."

"And the guild?"

She folded the letter and put it down on the table.

It was Raonaid nic Coinnich, the youngest of them, who said it first, because she had the least to lose and the longest to lose it in. "If they strike one of us they'll strike all of us," she said. "There isn't a yard in this town that hasn't had a skipper through its gate this month asking for an engine. We'll all be boring keels by the spring, or we'll all be building for the dead."

The two brothers of the yard below the church looked at one another for a long time, as brothers do, and nodded together.

Donnchadh Ruadh put the curl of oak on the table beside the letter. "I was bound in the same year as Pàdraig mac an t-Saoir," he said. "Fifty-one years. I'd like to have got to the end of it." He stood up, slowly, as a man does whose knees have spent half a century on slipways. "Write it, then, Sorcha. You've the best hand."

She wrote it that night, on the loft table, with the lamp smoking. It said that the boatwrights of Caol fhiadhaich had read the master's letter; that they held the

work lawful and would go on with it; and that since the guild held it unlawful for its members, they were members no longer, and returned their papers with this letter. The four of them signed it. Sorcha went home and took down from the wall of her house the paper of her binding, which had hung there in a frame for twenty-five years with the guild's seal on it and her uncle's name as witness, and she took it out of the frame and rolled it up with the others. In the morning it all went up the road on the carrier's cart with the mail and a crate of hens going the other way.

A month later the guild's answer came. The four yards of Caol fhiadhaich were struck from the roll, and each was fined, and the fine laid on Sorcha's yard was the heaviest, being more than the yard would clear in a good season. None of them paid it. The guild had no bailiff in the south-west and no ship to send one in, and the maor of the shire, when the guild wrote to him, answered that a guild's fine was the guild's business.

IV

Of the Wind in the South-West

The fishers of Caol fhiadhaich still tell of the autumn that followed, and they tell it as the season of *An Ròn Dubh*¹, though by its end there were two engine-boats in the harbour and a third on the slip.

Before she went out the first time, Lachann did what every skipper of that harbour did before a new season: he went down to the wolf-stone at dawn with a fish from the last catch and laid it at the foot of the stone, as Òrd na Cloiche² had taught the harbour, and one of the pilots said the words over it. That morning it was Ailig Mòr. He looked at the fish, and then over his shoulder at the boat with her stack and her smell, and said the words all the same, and not any faster than usual.

Then he went down the steps and into *An Ròn Dubh*, and took her through the strait himself.

He had never been through it under power, nor had anyone. He had spent sixty years reading the strait by the set of a sail and the pull of an oar, and at first

1. the shipwrights' fellowship

1. the Black Seal, Lachann mac Neacail's fishing boat of Caol fhiadhaich, the first fitted with a dubhan engine

2. the order of the Stone

he steered her as if she were still a sailing boat, waiting for a wind that did not matter any more. At the second skerry the tide caught her on the bow and she swung. Lachann shouted to the engine and Seonaidh Bàn opened the burner, and the boat drove on across the tide as if it were a millpond, and Ailig Mòr said something in the old tongue of the pilots that nobody in the boat understood, and did not repeat. Beyond the skerries he handed the helm to Lachann and sat down on a fish-box and lit his pipe.

"I'll take you back in," he said. "Don't try it on your own."

The first weeks were hard. The burner fouled, and had to be pulled out and cleared with a wire, in a seaway, by a man lying on his belly in the stink. The copper tube in the stern wept a little at the packing, and Sorcha had *An Ròn Dubh* up the slip twice to repack it, and lay awake in between. The dubhan came west in barrels on the coasters from Seann Skell on the southern coast, and the coasters came when they pleased, and one week in an Dàmhair there was none to be had in the town at any price, and *An Ròn Dubh* lay at the wall with her sails bent on like any other boat and her engine cold, and the pilots made remarks. But the boat caught fish. She could go out when the others could not and come in when they could not, and she did not wait on the tide at the skerries, and the fish she brought in were the freshest on the quay.

The day the town remembers came late in an Dàmhair. The fleet had gone east to the banks off the south coast by the old lane, where the herring were thick that year, twenty boats and more, with *An Ròn Dubh* among them, and they had fished two nights and filled. On the third morning the wind backed into the south-west and rose, and by noon it was blowing a full gale up the coast, straight in the teeth of any boat that wanted to go home to Caol fhiadhaich.

The sailing boats did what they had always done. They ran for the lee of the nearest headland to the east, a good day's sail from home, and lay there at anchor with their catches salting in the hold, as their fathers had lain there before them, to wait out the wind. It might be two days. It might be a week. The fish would be salt fish by the time it was over, worth a third of fresh.

Lachann did not run for the lee. He put *An Ròn Dubh* head to the gale, with a scrap of sail on her to steady her, and opened the burner, and went home.

It took him from noon until an hour after dark, into a sea that broke green over the bow and ran aft along the deck and down the hatch onto the engine. Twice the burner guttered and twice his boy, a lad of fourteen, lay in the water in the well and kept it lit with his body over it. Once a sea took the scrap of sail clean

out of its bolt-ropes. The engine groaned and clanked and hissed where the water hit the hot iron, and did not stop. At every sea *An Ròn Dubh* lifted her bow and seemed to stand still, and then the screw bit and she went on, a boat's length, and another, along a coast where every man aboard knew the rocks by name.

In Caol fhiadhaich they had seen the fleet go east three days before and had not looked for any of it back until the wind changed. Sorcha was in the rope-shed at dusk, cleaning the auger by lamplight, when a boy from the harbour came running and shouting that there was a light in the strait.

She went out onto the wall. It was nearly dark, and the rain was coming across the harbour in sheets, and the whole mouth of the strait was white. Out in it, low down, a light was moving. It came on steadily through the broken water between the skerries, into the wind, not tacking, not drifting, rising and falling with the seas and always coming on, and behind it, when the wind let her hear it, came the clank and grunt of the engine.

Ailig Mòr was on the wall beside her. He had come out without his pipe. He watched the light come in past the second skerry, where the tide ran hardest, and past the third, and he did not say a word until it had turned in under the wolf-stone and was in the smooth water of the harbour. Then he said, "He did it on his own, the fool," and went back to the pilots' bench out of the rain.

An Ròn Dubh came alongside the wall with her deck swept clean and her boy shaking with cold and a hold full of herring caught the night before. The catch was carried up to the market at Doire shean on the road that same night, and sold at dawn, fresh, the only fresh herring on the coast, at a price the fish-wives of Doire shean spoke of for years. The rest of the fleet came home five days after, when the wind went round, with salt fish.

That winter there were more skippers in Sorcha's yard than she had room for on her slip. Some came to talk and some came with money. The other three yards of Caol fhiadhaich were boring keels by an Dùbhlachd, and old Donnchadh Ruadh fitted his first engine with his own hands before the year was out, grumbling the whole while that he was too old for it. In am Faoilleach of the new year the yards of Inis chrom and Doire shean, a mile or two along the coast, sent to ask how it was done, and Sorcha showed them, and by an Gearran three yards of the south-west coast outside Caol fhiadhaich were doing the same work, and they too had left the guild, or been struck from it, depending on who told it.

The engines were the trouble. There was no one on the island making them for boats. Every laid-up launch in every harbour of the capital country had its en-

gine bought out of it that winter, and the chandlers of Ros dhomhain, who had been glad to be paid for old iron in an t-Ògmhios, asked three times the price by am Màrt and five times by an Giblean. Seonaidh Bàn made burners all winter, a dozen of them, each a little better than the last, and said nothing about any of them.

V

Of the Court at Ros dhomhain

The summons came early in an Giblean. The court of Comann nan Saorluinge¹ would sit at Ros dhomhain on the twenty-third of that month, and the boatwrights of Caol fhiadhaich were called to it to hear its ruling on the matter of the engines. It said nothing more than that. The four yards talked it over in the net-loft and agreed that Sorchà should go for all of them, since it was her auger that had started it.

She went up on the carrier's cart the day before, through the green of the spring. The road ran north-east, inland from the coast, through the fields of the shire, where the sowing was done and the lambs were out, and over the low hills into the capital country, and at evening she came down into Ros dhomhain with its counting-houses and its warehouses and its slips, and smoke over all of it. She slept at the carriers' inn by the market. She did not sleep much.

The guild hall stood above the slips, where it had stood since the wrights of Ros dhomhain took their charter in the first years of the kingdom: a long hall of stone with a roof of slate, and inside it a floor of oak worn into hollows by the feet of the apprentices bound there. Over the master's bench hung a board with the rules of the fellowship painted on it in the old tongue, and the first of them, in letters as long as a finger, was *Cha tollar an druim*. Sorchà had stood under that board at sixteen with her hand on the guild's adze and sworn to keep it.

The court sat at the fourth hour. The master was in his chair, with the eleven wardens on the bench on either side of him. Pàdraig mac an t-Saoir was a big white-haired man with the hands of a wright and the voice of a man who has spent his last twenty years talking to merchants. He did not look at Sorchà when she came in. The hall was fuller than she had expected: the masters of the Ros

1. the shipwrights' fellowship

dhomhain yards in their good coats, a clerk of the merchants' houses, two men she did not know who sat together and took notes, and at the back a scatter of apprentices who had come to see the woman from the south-west who had bored a keel.

The master's clerk read the matter. The master read the ruling.

It was a careful ruling, and it took some time. The guild, he said, had considered the fitting of engines into boats at three sittings through the winter, and had taken counsel of its oldest members and of the charter itself. It found that the charter of the guild was given for the building of ships and boats and for the work of wood in them. An engine, the court found, was a work of iron, made by founders and smiths, and the setting of an engine in a hull, with the boring and fitting needful to it, was the work of an engineer. The fitting of an engine was therefore no shipwright's work at all, and lay outside the guild's charter. The guild had no rule over it, and the rule of the unbored keel did not reach it. So the boatwrights of Caol fhiadhaich had broken no rule of the guild's, and they were readmitted to the guild, with all their papers and all their apprentices, and the fines laid on them were remitted.

He put the paper down and looked at her for the first time.

"The court has ruled," he said. "You may take your papers from the clerk, mistress. The guild is glad to have Caol fhiadhaich back."

Sorcha stood up. The whole hall had gone still. Through the open door came the sound of adzes on the slips below, and a gull, and she could hear her own heart.

She had thought on the cart, and in the inn, and lying awake, about what she would say, and had got no further than the first words. She looked up at the board above the master's head, at the letters as long as a finger.

"Master," she said, "in the autumn I bored the keel of *An Ròn Dubh*² with my own auger, in my own yard, in front of three members of this guild. Your letter called it unlawful. You struck us from your roll for it, and you fined us. Now you tell me it was never your business. I bored that keel as a shipwright. I bedded the engine on oak as a shipwright, and I set the tube in the post, and I packed it, and it holds. If that's no shipwright's work, then I've no need of a shipwrights' guild. The boatwrights of Caol fhiadhaich thank the court. We won't come back."

2. the Black Seal, Lachann mac Neacail's fishing boat of Caol fhiadhaich, the first fitted with a dubhan engine

There was a noise in the hall then, of a good many people talking at once, and the master struck his bench twice with the flat of his hand. When they were still he asked her whether that was the answer of all four yards, or her own.

"All four," she said. "I have it in writing, if you want it."

"The court doesn't want it," said Pàdraig mac an t-Saoir. He looked at her a while longer. He was not a fool, and he had been a wright before he was a master. "You were bound under that board," he said.

"I was. Twenty-five years I kept the rule. I kept it until it kept the boats in the harbour."

The clerk wrote that the boatwrights of Caol fhiadhaich declined the guild's readmission. The master rose, and the court rose with him, and it was over. The two men who had sat together taking notes went out quickly, and one of them, she learned afterwards, was a clerk of Comhairle nan Taighean-solais³, and the other had come from the dubhan works at Seann Skell on the southern coast to see what the court would say about engines.

Outside the hall the evening was coming on, clear and cold, with a light wind out of the west. Sorchà walked down to the slips. The yards of Ros dhomhain were closing for the night. On the last slip, the one where she had served the first year of her time, a harbour launch lay chocked up with her planks sprung and her engine gone out of her; the hole in her stern where the shaft had once run was stopped with a wooden plug, and grass was growing out of the seam beside it. Sorchà stood and looked at it until an old watchman came along the slips with his lantern and asked her whether she wanted anything.

"No," she said. "I was looking at the post."

She went back to the carriers' inn, and ate, and asked the carrier what time he went south in the morning. Then she took out the yard-book that she carried everywhere, and under the day's date, below the price of the larch and the name of a skipper from Inis chrom who wanted an engine by Bealltainn, she wrote one line: *Court at Ros dhomhain. Declined.* She closed the book, and put out the lamp.

3. the Lighthouse Board

OF the Last Coal Flame

DE 6

I

Of the Warrant of Tobar dhearg

At Tobar dhearg they tell it from the keeper's side, since it was the keeper who walked. The custodians of the south coast tell it from the altar, and the fitters who came after tell it from the stair; but the village on the red well says that nobody else was near enough to see the thing whole, and that Ciorstaidh nic Artair never told it twice the same way, and so they tell it for her.

She was in her sixty-ninth year when the order came, and she had kept Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg¹ for twenty-two of them. Before that she had kept it under her father for as long as she could remember. He had taught her to trim the grate before she could reach it, standing her on a salt-box, and to read the colour of the fire the way a fisherman reads a sky. On a night in an t-Ògmhios, twenty-two years back, a boat of Seann Skell had gone onto the reef below the light in a south-westerly, and he had gone down with a line to it, and the sea had taken him off the rocks. She went down after him with the same line. She brought four men in, one by one, and the fifth could walk. Comhairle nan Taighean-solais² sent her his warrant in a month, with a letter regretting the loss of a servant of long standing, and that autumn she had a post driven into the reef with a bell on it that the swell rang. While she kept the light no boat had gone aground there. The village could tell you that before it could tell you anything else about her.

The tower stood out on the cape below the village, a stone drum older than anyone's grandmother, and on its top, inside the lantern-glass the humans had set

1. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

there in the days of A' Chompanaidh³, the fire burned in an iron grate. It had burned coal for more than a hundred years. It burned the island's coal, broken small, which when it catches shows every colour in the break and gives a flame that no other fuel gives: bright at the heart, and at the edge dark and coloured, like oil on water, green and violet and a red that is nearly brown. Seen from the sea it was a warm light, low and a little unsteady, and the south-coast boats knew it from any other light on the island by that, and some of their old men said they could tell it from a star at twenty miles.

The coal came by sea from Seann Skell in sacks. For three years it had come short. The master of stores wrote each quarter that the lights stood first on the kingdom's list after the altars, which was true, and that the lights' allowance was what Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁴ could spare, which was also true, and Ciorstaidh had learned to bank the grate on the short nights of summer and let it roar only in the long ones. She kept the tally of every sack in her own book beside the log. The druids of the village, who by old custom kept the light's log for Bride's sake, wrote the weather and the ships; she wrote the coal, in a small hand, with the price when she could get it.

On 22 an Cèitean, DE 6, Comhairle nan Taighean-solais sat and had read to it the council's order that the five lights of the coast should be turned to dubhan, the first works of the kingdom to be so turned, and that the coal they burned should go to the altars. The copy came down the coast to Tobar dhearg eleven days later in a leather case, carried by a clerk who had never been to the south coast and was sick on the fish-cart from Seann Skell. He gave it to her at the tower door and stood waiting, as if she might have a reply.

She read it standing. It was short. The lights of Baile ìseal and Tobar dhearg, being nearest the works at Seann Skell, were to be turned first, in the summer; the others as the fitters could reach them. The engineer of the lights was being sent to fit the burners. The keepers would keep their warrants, their wages and their houses.

"It says nothing of the grate," Ciorstaidh said.

The clerk said that he believed the grate would be taken out.

"And the fire in it?"

He did not know. He had not been told about the fire.

2. the Lighthouse Board

3. the Company

4. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

She gave him bread and a cup of the well water, which he looked at doubtfully because it ran reddish from the rock and always had, and sent him back up to the village to find his cart. Then she climbed the stair, which had a hundred and nine steps and a rope along the wall worn to the colour of a chestnut, and sat in the lamp-room with the letter on her knee until it was time to feed the fire.

II

Of the Custodians' Asking and the Deputy

The custodians of Tobar dhearg were three, an old man and two younger women, and their house stood by the well at the top of the village. They were of Òrd Bhrìde¹, as nearly all the south coast was, and they held the light's log as their predecessors had since before the humans came, when the beacon was a fire in a ring of stones on the cape and the log was notches on a stick. They had known the order was coming before the clerk was sick on the fish-cart. The Àrd-choimheadaiche² at Seann Skell had known it before the order was read.

The old custodian came down to the tower the next evening. He was a slow walker and she saw him on the path a long while before he reached her.

"The Àrd-choimheadaiche will not bless the new burners," he said, when he had his breath. "You know his letter."

Everyone on the south coast knew the letter. Alasdair mac Ìomhair had written it to every house of Òrd Bhrìde two years before, when the shipmasters' works first smoked at Seann Skell: the new fuel was not forbidden, since it was not coal, and not blessed, since it was not coal. It had been read out in every house, and argued over in every tavern that had a druid in it, and the fishermen had made a rhyme of it that was not repeated in front of custodians.

"He will not forbid them either," Ciorstaidh said.

"No. But the fire in the tower has been coal since A' Chompanaidh³ lit it, and before that it was a shore-fire of driftwood and wrack. It was Bride's fire on this cape before there were clerks to own it. We have asked him that it not be let go out

1. the order of Bride's flame

2. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

3. the Company

on a clerk's say, like a lamp in a kitchen. We have asked that it be carried to her altar at Seann Skell, and burn out there, where the flame first came from."

She looked at him a long time. The fire behind her ticked in the grate.

"And what does he say?"

"He says yes. He has written to Comhairle nan Taighean-solais⁴, and they have written back that they have no objection, provided the light is not dark a single night." The old man folded his hands. "They will send a man for the lantern. They offer one of their own clerks, or the Àrd-choimheadaiche will send a young custodian of the house there. It is ten miles, keeper, and in the heat."

"It is nine and a half," Ciorstaidh said, "and I have walked it every quarter for twenty-two years to argue for coal."

She said nothing more that night. The next morning she wrote to Comhairle nan Taighean-solais, in the same small hand she kept the coal in, that she thanked them for the offer of a deputy and would not need one; that the flame was hers by her warrant until the burner was lit; and that she would carry it herself or it would go out on the cape in its own grate, and they might choose. The answer came in a fortnight and was a line long. The keeper was to arrange the matter with the Àrd-choimheadaiche as she saw fit.

The village says she was angry for a week after, and that nobody could tell with whom. The custodians thought it was the lights' masters. The clerk who had to carry the next letter thought it was himself. Her under-keeper, a Baile gharbh lad of nineteen whom she had taken on four years before because he could climb the stair twice without stopping, thought it was the coal, because she went at the grate that week as if it owed her money. He was the only one of them who ever said so to her face, and she told him he was nearer than the rest.

III

Of the Tank at the Stair's Foot

The engineer of the lights came in the third week of an t-Ògmhios, off a works boat from Seann Skell that came round the cape in the early morning and stood off the landing-stones below the light, and the whole village came down to watch her land.

4. the Lighthouse Board

Ciorstaidh had heard of Peigi nic Ascaill, as every keeper had. She was a woman under forty who had run a dubhan lamp for a hundred nights in the yard below Taigh-solais Baile ìseal¹, on the eastern cape, and had it hold in a gale when the tower's own coal flame blew out. Every keeper on the island had had that story by letter within the month, and every keeper had an opinion of it. Seonag nic Thòmais at Baile ìseal had refused, it was said, to let the thing up her stair at all, and now had it at the top of her stair by the council's order and was not speaking to anyone who had signed it. Ciorstaidh had rather liked the sound of Seonag nic Thòmais.

The engineer came up the landing-stones in a man's coat with the sleeves turned back, and stood at the foot of the tower and looked up at it with her head on one side, and the first thing she said to its keeper was that the stair would do.

"At Àth dhearg it won't," she said. "I've the drawings. The tank would stick at the second turn like a cork. But yours is wide. The humans built this one first and hadn't learned to be mean with stone yet."

"The tank?" Ciorstaidh said.

It was coming off the boat. It was a drum of riveted iron, taller than a man's waist and as wide as a well-head, and it took eight of the village men with poles and ropes to bring it over the landing-stones, and the boat's crew stood on the gunwale and shouted advice. After it came the burner in a crate, and the pipes in a bundle, and the glass chimneys in straw, and then the barrels. There were forty barrels, black, and they were rolled up the path and stood in a row against the tower's wall where the coal-sacks used to stand, and the smell came off them in the warm morning and went up the cape.

Ciorstaidh had smelt dubhan before. By then everyone on the south coast had. The works at Seann Skell sent it out in its barrels to the fishing boats and the lamp-houses, and it burned on the quays at night in the new lamps, and the whole harbour smelt of it in a wet wind. Up close it was worse. It was a thick smell, like a burnt pan and something from under a pit-heap, and it caught in the back of the throat.

"You'll stop noticing," said Peigi nic Ascaill, who had watched her face.

"I doubt it."

1. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

"You will. I did." The engineer looked at the barrels without much love. "It burns, it stinks, and it is not coal. Comhairle nam Mèinnean²'s own surveyors wrote that four years ago, and nobody has improved on it."

They took four days over the fitting. The tank went up the stair on ropes, with the village men sweating under it and Ciorstaidh walking behind with a lantern, because the lamp-room was dark while the fire was banked for the day and she did not trust any of them on the turn. It sat in the room below the lamp-room, where the coal had been kept in the humans' time, and a pipe went up from it through the floor. The burner stood in the lantern-glass beside the grate. For four nights the grate burned as it always had and the burner stood cold beside it, a brass thing like a ship's bell turned over, with its row of wicks, and Ciorstaidh fed the coal and did not look at it.

On the third evening the engineer came up the stair after supper and sat on the step of the lamp-room while the keeper fed the fire. It was the longest day of the year or near it, and the sun was not down till late, and the grate was banked low for the short night.

"You keep it low," Peigi said.

"The coal comes short. Three years now. I bank it in summer. The boats know the light's lower in summer, and they know why." Ciorstaidh knocked the grate. The flame came up, and the colours came up with it along its edge, the violet and the green. "They say they can tell it from a star at twenty miles."

"Can they?"

"The old ones say so. I think they tell it from a star because it's where they've always seen it." She sat back on her heels. "Your lamp at Baile Iseal. The one that held."

"It held."

"And the tower's went out."

"In the gale. The draught came down the chimney and the coal was damp. It happens." The engineer looked at the fire. "Murchadh mac Coinnich kept the log for me. He was keeper there once. He was sorry it went out. Into the log it went, that the tower's went out and mine didn't, and then he wrote that he was sorry. He didn't sign that line."

Ciorstaidh said nothing to that for a while. Then she said, "Mine doesn't go out."

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

"No," Peigi said. "I've read your log. Yours doesn't."

They sat together without talking, and the light went down over the sea to the west, and the fire grew in the glass as the sky darkened, until from the cape it would have been the brightest thing on the whole south coast. Below, somewhere under the lamp-room, the dubhan in the tank ticked as it cooled. The engineer went down at the dark, and Ciorstaidh stayed and fed the grate until her under-keeper came up at midnight to take the second half.

They lit the burner on the fourth night for a trial, beside the coal, an hour only. It came up white. There was no other word for it. It was a steady, hard, white light without an edge, and it made the coal flame look like the fire in a cottage hearth, and it threw the shadows of the lantern-glass's iron bars out across the cape so that the whole village could see them lying on the grass. The boats that were out that night saw it and came in to ask what had happened. The engineer turned it down after the hour, and the grate burned on alone, and the old custodian, who had been at the foot of the tower all the while, went back up to the village without a word to anyone.

She had the day of the carrying set with the Àrd-choimheadaiche³ by letter: 19 an t-Iuchar, DE 6, a day with no feast on it, so that nobody could say it had been chosen for a sign. The burner would be lit that evening for good. Until then the grate would burn as it always had. The engineer went back to Seann Skell on the works boat to do what she could at Baile iséal, where the burner had been lit the week before and was already being blamed for everything, and she promised to come back the day before the carrying to see the burner in, and to walk with the keeper if the keeper would have her. The keeper said she might suit herself.

IV

Of the Road to Seann Skell

She did not sleep the night before, and had not expected to. All night she sat up in the lamp-room with the fire and let her under-keeper sleep through the whole of his watch, which he held against her afterwards, and she fed the grate with the last of the quarter's coal, a sack and a half, and let it burn as high as it would burn on a summer night, higher than it had burned since the coal

3. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

began to come short. The boats that were out saw it and wondered, and some of them knew.

In the grey before dawn she took down the lantern. It was a closed lantern of brass and thick glass, a storm lantern of the humans' make with a little door in its side and a pot at its foot for a handful of coal, and it had hung in the lamp-room for as long as the tower had stood, for carrying the fire down to the landing-stones on nights when a boat came in blind. She had carried it down that stair with her father's line coiled over her shoulder. She filled the pot with the best of the coal she had kept back, broken small, and she took a coal from the grate with the tongs and laid it on the others, and closed the door, and watched through the glass until the new coals caught.

Then she let the grate go.

That is the part the village does not tell, because she did not tell it, and there was only the under-keeper to see, and he had been asleep. He woke to find the grate dark and cold enough to put a hand in, and the keeper sitting on the step of the lamp-room with the lantern on her knees, and the sun coming up out of the sea to the east. He said afterwards that she looked the way his grandmother had looked the morning after his grandfather was buried, sitting straight on a hard chair with her good shawl on. She told him to get the burner going the moment the sun was off the sea that night, and not a quarter-hour later, or she would hear of it at Seann Skell. He said she would hear of nothing else. She told him to mind his tongue.

The engineer had come on the evening boat and slept in the keeper's house. She was at the tower door with bread and a flask of the red water when the keeper came down the hundred and nine steps with the lantern held out a little from her body, the way you carry a thing that is hot or that someone might want to take off you. The flame burned inside the glass with the colours along its edge. The two of them set off up the path to the village.

It was a hot morning with a haze on the sea, and the whole of Tobar dhearg was out. They stood at their doors along the one street and round the red well. Nobody spoke to her, since she plainly did not want to be spoken to, and the children who ran after her were called back. At the well the three custodians of the village fell in behind, the old man in the middle, and so did a good many others, and when she went out of the village on the road north-west there were thirty people walking behind the keeper and her lantern, and the engineer in her man's coat among them, and the fish-cart following empty in case anybody fell down.

The road from the cape to Seann Skell runs along the coast behind the dunes, then inland round the marshes where the burn from Baile gharbh comes down, then out along the shore again to the town. It is nine and a half miles. It was a road she knew stone by stone. On it she had walked to Seann Skell every quarter for twenty-two years to wait on the master of stores and argue for coal, and walked home again with less than she had asked for.

She walked it that day without stopping, except twice at wells to drink. She did not hurry, and she did not give the lantern to anyone. At Baile gharbh the fishermen's wives were at their doors, and one of them came out with a cup of milk and held it up to her without a word, and she drank it and gave the cup back and went on. At the ford over the burn a carter coming the other way with a load of salt pulled his horse into the reeds and took off his cap and stood there holding it until they had all gone by. A child asked in a loud voice what the old woman was carrying, and its mother said *Bride's fire*, and the child said, *but it's only a lamp*, and nobody laughed.

Past the marshes the road came out onto the shore again and the town was in sight: the roofs of Seann Skell along the bay, and the masts in the harbour, and the long grey roof of Bride's house on the rise above the quays, which was the greatest house of Òrd Bhrìde¹ on the island. And to the left of the town, down by the old salt-sheds, stood the chimney of Obair-dhubhain Seann Skell², the ship-masters' works, which was the tallest thing on the coast by then and could be seen from Baile gharbh on a clear day. It was putting out smoke that morning, as it put out smoke every morning, and the haze from it lay along the shore in the heat, and the smell of it came to meet them on the wind a mile before they reached the town.

Ciorstaidh looked at it once and walked on towards it. The engineer, who was walking at her shoulder by then, said afterwards that she had been ready for the keeper to say something about the chimney, and would have understood whatever it was, and that the keeper said nothing at all and only shifted the lantern to her other hand.

At the town's edge a young custodian of the house was waiting for them, a lad not much older than her under-keeper, sent down by the Àrd-choimheadaiche³ to meet her. He bowed to the lantern first and then to the keeper, and offered to

1. the order of Bride's flame

2. the dubhan works at the southern Seann Skell

3. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

carry it the last half-mile up the hill, since that was the steep part. She looked at him until he coloured, and then she thanked him, and asked him to walk ahead and show the way, since the streets had changed since last she came. They had not changed at all. He walked ahead.

V

Of Brìde's Altar

It was late in the afternoon when they came up to Brìde's house, and the sun was on the west side of it, and the doors stood open. The people who had walked from Tobar dhearg stopped at the steps and did not go in, since the hall was for the custodians that day, and the townspeople who had come up to see stood with them. The engineer went in, because the Àrd-choimheadaiche¹ had asked for her by name, and stood by the door with her coat over her arm.

The hall of Brìde's house at Seann Skell is long and narrow and cool, with a stone floor worn into shallow dips by the feet of those who have stood there, and a roof of dark timber held up by posts that were ships' masts once. At the far end, on a step of three stones, is the altar, which is a block of grey stone with a hollow in its top, and in the hollow burns Brìde's flame, which is fed with the vein's coal in measure and from it the order lights its first lamp of the year on the feast of Brìde. That day the altar-flame had been let burn low, and the hollow beside it was clear.

The custodians of four shires were standing in two rows down the length of the hall, one on each side, facing inward, in their grey. There were more than sixty of them. Some had come a long way. The custodians of Seann Bhrál had walked from their town, and the houses of the farther shires had come by cart the day before and slept on the hall floor. They stood in their rows and did not speak, and they did not turn their heads as she passed.

Ciorstaidh nic Artair walked down the hall between them with the lantern held out before her. Her boots were loud on the flags. The engineer said that it was the only sound in the place, and that she had never heard boots so loud in her life, and that she could hear the old woman's breath as well, because it had been ten miles in the heat and she was sixty-eight.

1. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

At the foot of the altar the Àrd-choimheadaiche was waiting. Alasdair mac Ìomhair was a thin man in his middle sixties, with a long face and his grey hair cut short in the custodians' way, and he stood aside from the altar as she came and made room for her on the step. He did not offer to take the lantern. The custodians of Tobar dhearg, who had told him a good deal about their keeper by letter, may have warned him not to.

She went up the three stones and set the lantern down in the clear hollow beside Brìde's flame. She opened its little door.

The flame inside leaned towards the air, as a flame does when a door is opened on it, and seemed for a breath about to go out, and steadied. It burned up in the open with the colours along its edge, a little higher than it had burned in the glass, and it gave the altar step a warm light that was different from the light of the altar-flame beside it. Then it settled down to burn the coal that was left in the lantern's pot.

Nobody told her to go, so she stayed. She stood at the side of the altar step with her hands folded, and the custodians stood in their rows, and Alasdair mac Ìomhair stood across the step from her, and nobody spoke, and the coal burned.

It took longer than anyone had thought. The custodians had been told by the house, or had told each other, that it would be a matter of an hour. It was the best of the coal, broken small, and she had packed the pot as tight as it would go, as she packed the grate in winter. After the first hour the young custodians at the back of the hall began to shift on their feet. After the second, the light through the west windows had gone from yellow to red, and the long shadows of the ranks lay across the floor, and one of the Seann Bhral custodians, an old woman, sat down on the floor where she stood and nobody reproached her. The engineer stood by the door the whole time. She said later that she had meant to stay a quarter of an hour, and found at the end that she had not once thought of going.

The Àrd-choimheadaiche did not move, and neither did the keeper. What he thought of it he never set down in any letter that is open to an Leabharlann², and the custodians of the south coast have never agreed about it among themselves. Some say he prayed. Some say he was counting, and meant to write the time to Comhairle nan Taighean-solais³. The keeper said afterwards to her under-keeper, when he asked, that the Àrd-choimheadaiche had stood on the altar step for three hours watching a lamp go out and had not once looked at the door, and that she

2. the Library at Muileann chaol

3. the Lighthouse Board

could not ask more of any man than that, and would not have got it from the clerks of the lights.

At the end, in the last of the light, the fire in the lantern's pot went down to a few coals, and to one. The flame stood up off it very small, and the colours went out of its edge one after another, the red and then the green, until it was only blue. Then it shrank to a blue bead the size of a barleycorn, sitting on the coal, and it went on sitting there, a long time, while the hall got darker round it.

Then there was nothing on the coal.

A thin thread of smoke went up from the pot, straight in the still air, grey, and rose until it met the roof and hung there under the dark timber. Down the right-hand row one of the custodians let out a breath as if he had been holding it the whole while, and someone else coughed, and it was over.

Alasdair mac Ìomhair stepped forward then, and put out his hand to the lantern's little door, and looked at the keeper, and she nodded. He closed it. He said the words that are said at Brìde's altar when a lamp that has burned the vein's coal is let go out, which are short and old and are not written down outside the houses; and then he said, in the ordinary voice of a man talking across a table, that the flame of Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg⁴ had come home to the altar it was first lit from, and gone out there, and that he thanked the keeper who had carried it.

"The order does not bless the new light," he said. "Nor does it forbid it. I have said so, and there is no more it can say. This it can bless." He laid his hand flat on the lantern, which was still warm. "This it blesses."

Ciorstaidh nic Artair said, "Thank you, lord," and then, "I'll have my lantern back, if the house doesn't want it."

He looked at her a while, and then he picked it up off the altar step and gave it to her, and the custodians broke their rows.

VI

Of the Light Seen from the Quays

She would not stay in Brìde's house that night, though a bed had been made for her, and she would not go home on the fish-cart in the dark. She went down with the engineer to the harbour, where there was a lodging-house

4. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

that took in keepers who came to argue for coal and had taken her in for twenty-two years, and the landlady gave her the room she always had, which looked south-east down the coast.

The harbour was full that night. Word had come down from Brìde's house ahead of them, and the fishermen had come in early, and the quays were crowded under the new dubhan lamps, which the works had set up along the harbour-front the year before and which lit the wet stones white and made the whole quay smell of the burnt pan. Down in the taverns along the harbour they were singing.

The song was new that night. The fishermen of the south coast, who had made a rhyme of the Àrd-choimheadaiche¹'s letter, made a song of the carrying, the same evening; the harbour says it was first sung in a tavern under the quay wall by a skipper of Tobar dhearg whose father had been one of the four men brought in off the reef twenty-two years before, and that he made it as he sang it. It had a great many verses before the night was out, and by the end of the summer every harbour of the south coast had its own. Some were about the keeper, and some about the chimney of the works, and some were not fit to be sung in front of custodians. The verse that stayed, and is sung wherever the song is sung, is the first one, and it was the only one the skipper sang twice.

Ciorstaidh nic Artair heard it from her window. She had the lantern on the sill beside her, cold now, with its little door shut. Out beyond the harbour, far down the coast to the south-east over the dark of the marshes, where the cape stood out into the sea, a light had come up at sunset on the stroke, as she had ordered. It was small at that distance, and white, and very steady, and it did not flicker when the wind came off the sea. It had no colour at its edge.

The engineer, who had come up to say good night and had stayed at the door, said that the lad had lit it on time.

"He has," said the keeper. "The boats will see that at thirty miles."

"They will."

"They'll not know it from a star." She watched it a while. "They'll get used to it. You said I would."

Below the window, in the tavern under the quay wall, the skipper of Tobar dhearg sang his first verse again, and the whole room sang it with him, and it came up to her through the warm night, over the white lamps on the stones:

1. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

Dh'fhalbh an lasair às an tùr, tha solas ann, ach chan ann leinn. The flame has gone out of the tower; there is a light there, but it is not ours.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Of the Five Towers

DE 7

I

Of the Carts to Muileann bheag

Two of the five lights had been turned by the end of the year before. Taigh-solais Baile ìseal¹ on the eastern cape had burned a dubhan lamp in its yard for a hundred nights before it burned one in its tower, and Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg² on the south coast had let its coal flame go to the altar in the high summer, in a lantern carried by its keeper. That left three: one on the northern point, one on the north-eastern cape, and one on the headland at Baile chrom in the far north-west, which was farther from the capital than any work the kingdom kept.

Peigi nic Ascaill, engineer to Comhairle nan Taighean-solais³, went north in am Faoilleach with two of the board's fitters, a box of drawings and a letter under the board's seal. The letter said that Taigh-solais Muileann bheag⁴ was to be turned to dubhan before the spring gales. It did not say where the dubhan was to come from.

The other lights were fed from the south. The tanks for Baile ìseal and Tobar dhearg had gone out of Seann Skell on the south coast by boat, from the shipmasters' quay below the works, and the barrels that followed them went the same way. Muileann bheag stood on the north coast of the Tuathaich country, and a boat out of the southern Seann Skell must go round half the island to reach it. In am

1. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

2. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

3. the Lighthouse Board

4. the lighthouse at Muileann bheag

Faoilleach no master on that coast would take a laden hull round the western capes for any board's letter.

So the fuel for Muileann bheag came by cart. Peigi bought it at Caol mhòr, in the market by the harbour, where the black cake had been sold off the pedlars' barrows since the first year of the fuel and was now sold from a shed with a slate roof and a Tuathach behind a counter. She asked him where it was made. He said, in the Dia-thìrich tongue and politely, that it was made in the north. She asked where in the north. He said in the other tongue something to the man beside him, and the man laughed, and then he said to her again, in her own, that it was made in the north, and would she be wanting it in barrels or in the sack.

She took it in barrels. Twelve carts went out along the coast road on a grey morning with the wind off the sea, drawn by the small hill horses of the north, and a Tuathach walked at the head of each horse. The road ran some fifteen miles, low along the shore through the mill country, past the mill-dams frozen at their edges and the white fields, and it took the carts the whole of a short day. Peigi rode on the last cart with her feet on a barrel. The board's two fitters, who had never been north of the capital, sat together on the one in front and looked at the country as if it might bite.

The carters did not look at it at all. They talked among themselves in the humans' tongue, of a boat come in at Caol mhòr with her mast sprung and of the price of meal, and one of them sang. When the cart ahead stuck in a rut at a burn-crossing they all came back to it without a word from anyone, and put their shoulders to the wheels, and it came out. Peigi wrote in her notebook that night: *Carters of Caol mhòr, twelve, paid at the rate of the town. Good men.* Then she struck out the last two words, because the board did not want its engineer's opinions of carters, and wrote *Sound* over them.

Taigh-solais Muileann bheag stood on its point above a little mill town of grey houses, with the sea on three sides of it. It was the fourth of the five towers to be raised, and the first to burn coal, and under its foot the ash of an older shore-fire went down three yards into the red earth. The fire on that point was older than the humans and older than the kingdom. Its keeper that winter was a Dia-thìreach of the south named Calum Bàn, who had kept the light for nineteen years under the royal warrant and in all that time had been to church in Muileann bheag twice, at two funerals, and had stood at the back.

He met Peigi at the tower door with his hands folded under his arms against the cold. He looked at the carts and the carters, and at the board's two fitters, and last at her.

"They told me it would come by sea," he said.

"No boat would bring it."

"No," he agreed. "They wouldn't." He stood aside to let her in. "The coal came by sea. Every sack for nineteen years."

The work took nine days. The old coal-grate came out of the lamp-room in pieces, the board's men swearing at the bolts, which had rusted to their seats in the salt air; the tank went up the stair in the carters' arms, for the stair at Muileann bheag was wide and the tank was the small pattern, and two of the carters stayed on for the lifting and were paid for it. The burner was Peigi's own, the one she had drawn after the hundred nights at Baile iséal, with a wider throat to it and a screw to clear the jet without putting out the flame. She fitted it herself. The board's men watched her, and Calum Bàn watched the board's men.

On the ninth evening, which was 26 am Faoilleach, DE 7, she lit it. The flame came up white and steady and threw its light out over the northern sea, where there was nothing to see but the dark water and, far out, the wall of grey that lay on the sea to the north in every weather. Calum Bàn stood at the glass and looked at it a long time.

"It's brighter," he said at last.

"Yes."

"It stinks."

"Yes. Less, in the tower. You'll not notice it in a month."

He did not answer that. In the morning he showed her the coal-store at the tower's foot, three-quarters empty, the last of it gleaming dully in the cold, and asked her what he was to do with it. She said she would write to the board. He said he would keep it, then, until the board wrote back, and locked the door on it, and put the key on the nail inside his own door where the other keys were.

The carts went back to Caol mhòr empty. Of the five lights, Taigh-solais Muileann bheag alone was fed thereafter by the road and not by the sea from Seann Skell, and its barrels came along the coast in Tuathaich carts from Tuathaich stores, and were paid for in the kingdom's coin at the market price, which that winter was a little under the price in the south.

II

Of the Crane from Seann Tarr

The north-eastern cape was a harder matter.

Taigh-solais Àth dhearg¹ stood on the high ground over the sea-passage in toward Seann Tarr, a stone tower raised by the townsmen of Àth dhearg in An Aois Choigreach² and paid for, as the keepers still said, stone by stone. Its keeper, Iseabail Ruadh, had the light from her father, and kept on the shelf of the lamp-room the old daybook of Tormod mac Pheadair, who had written down every ship he saw from that gallery in the years when ships still came, and she would show it to visitors who asked. Peigi asked. The book was bound in sealskin gone black with handling. The last ships in it were a long time ago.

The tank for Àth dhearg had come round by sea from the southern Seann Skell and lay on the quay at Seann Tarr under a tarpaulin, the large pattern, for the light on the north-eastern cape was the strongest of the five. It came up the coast road to the tower on a dray behind four horses, and at the tower door it stopped. The stair of Taigh-solais Àth dhearg had been built by masons of the town who had built nothing but houses before it, and they had built it tight and turning, like the stair of a house. A man with a sack of coal on his shoulder went up it sideways. The tank would not go up it at all.

Peigi measured the stair. The board's men measured the tank. Then they measured the stair again, because they did not like the first answer.

"We cut the tank," said the elder of the board's men. "Two halves. Seam it up at the top."

"And it leaks at the seam into a lamp-room with a naked flame in it," said Peigi. "No."

"Then we cut the stair."

"Then the tower falls down," said Iseabail Ruadh from the doorway, "and I'll not be in it."

They stood about the dray in a wind that came straight off the sea with sleet in it. It was Iseabail who said, in the end, that the rope-walk at Seann Tarr had a crane for lifting the hemp-bales off the boats to the loft, and that the rope-makers owed the light a good turn, since their boats steered home by it every night of the winter.

1. the lighthouse at Àth dhearg

2. the Age of Strangers

So it was done that way, and it took a month more than the others.

The rope-makers of Seann Tarr were a guild of their own, the last that the old custom had chartered, and their master was a heavy slow man who came up to the tower to look at the thing before he promised anything. He walked twice round the tower, and looked up at the gallery, and looked at the tank on its dray, and said the crane could do it if the ground held. Then he went home and said nothing more for a week. At the end of the week the crane came.

It came up the three and a half miles of the coast road from Seann Tarr in pieces, the jib on one wain, the mast on another, the drum and the iron on a third, with half the rope-walk walking beside it. The weather had turned, as it turns there in am Màrt, from sleet to a hard bright wind, and Àth dhearg came out on the road to watch it pass, the children running ahead and the town's priest of Na Seann Spioradan³ standing at the gate of his house with his hands behind him. It took them two days to raise the mast on the rock below the tower and stay it with cables to rings the masons let into the stone. The master of the rope-walk would not let the board's men touch the cables. He said they were the rope-walk's cables and the rope-walk's knots and if they parted it would be the rope-walk's shame.

On the day of the lift the tank went up the outside of the tower in the slings, slowly, turning a little on its rope, with the sea behind it very blue and the gulls going round it as if it were a fish. Peigi stood on the gallery with Iseabail Ruadh. The board's men had taken out the great window of the lamp-room, frame and all, and it leaned against the parapet in its sacking. When the tank came level with the gallery rail it swung in the wind, out and back, and every man on the rock below leaned with it. Then the rope-makers on the drum let it down a hand's breadth at a time, and Peigi and the board's men caught it with their hands and walked it in over the sill.

Nobody cheered. The master of the rope-walk looked up at the gallery, and Peigi lifted her hand to him, and he nodded and turned to see to his cables.

The window went back in its frame; the glaziers of Àth dhearg sealed it; the burner was set; and on 25 am Màrt, DE 7, a month after the day she had meant to, Peigi lit the light on the north-eastern cape. Its beam went out over the passage, and at Seann Tarr that night, it is said, the boats came in by it as they always had, and nobody on the quay remarked that it was a different fire.

3. the Old Spirits

Iseabail Ruadh wrote that night in her own daybook, below the last line of her father's, that the light was turned to dubhan on this day, the tank being raised by the crane of the rope-walk at Seann Tarr. She named the rope-walk, and the board's engineer. Peigi read it over her shoulder and did not say anything.

The rope-makers would take no hire for the crane. The master sent word after it that the light owed them nothing, only let it burn.

That night at the inn at Àth dhearg Peigi wrote her letter to the board. Four of the five lights now burned dubhan. There remained Baile chrom. It was the farthest of the five, some twenty-five miles west of Caol mhòr on the headland at the edge of the Tuathaich country, and the board's fitters were wanted in the south, where the lamp-houses of the capital were putting in dubhan burners faster than there were men to fit them. The board had two fitters who could be spared, and they were the two she had with her, and they had been away from home since the new year and said so every evening.

She wrote to the board that she could not do Baile chrom before the autumn gales with the men she had. Then she took a second sheet and wrote, in her own name, to Tional nan Tuathach⁴ at Caol mhòr.

She knew no one at Caol mhòr, and one Tuathach fitter by name. Three years before, at the shipmasters' works at Seann Skell, there had been a man among the Tuathaich hands at the retorts, a lean man with his sleeves rolled and a burn on his wrist, who had shown her how to wrap a tap so that it did not drip and had chalked the lights' mark on her twenty barrels. He was of Caol mhòr, and he had gone home the winter after, as most of the northern hands went, when the rents of the south ate their pay.

She wrote: *To the speaker of Tional nan Tuathach at Caol mhòr, or to whoever keeps his letters*. Then, being tired, she crossed out the assembly's name, which she was not sure she had spelled as they spelled it, and left *the speaker at Caol mhòr*. She asked for four fitters of the town to turn the light at Baile chrom, the drawings and the burner to be sent them, the tank and fuel to come by sea. If a man named Ashby could be found, she would be glad of him. Who would pay them she did not say, because she did not know.

4. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

III

Of a Week of Rain at Baile chrom

The letter came to Caol mhòr in an Giblean and lay on the speaker's table for a fortnight, because Daniel Frayne was ill that spring and read his letters slowly. When he had read it he sent for Joe Ashby. Frayne had been speaker of Tional nan Tuathach¹ for more than twenty years, and he was past seventy.

Joe was fitting a winch on a herring boat at the harbour wall when the boy came for him, and he finished the winch first. Then he went up to the assembly's house in his working clothes and stood in the speaker's room with his cap in his hand while the old man read the letter out to him in the humans' tongue, turning it into that tongue as he went, word by word, with his finger on the line.

"She asks for you by name," said Daniel Frayne. "Do you know her?"

"At the works in the south," said Joe. "She bought barrels off us. I marked them for her."

"Did you speak to her?"

"About taps."

The old man looked at him over the letter for some time. He had a long face, grey and folded, and he breathed as if the room were short of air. "The board has no one to send," he said. "That's what this says. And it says nothing about pay." He put the letter down. "We'll pay you, then. The assembly will. Four men. Choose them yourself."

So in the middle of an t-Ògmhios four fitters of Caol mhòr went west along the coast road with their tools on a hand-cart and their food in a sack: Joe Ashby, and Will Tanner, who had worked in the Caol mhòr yards since he was a boy, and Ned Fowler and his cousin Abel, who had both been at the retorts in the south and come home. They walked the twenty-five miles in two days, sleeping the one night in a byre at a farm whose people gave them milk and would take nothing for it, and it began to rain on the morning they set out and did not stop until the work was done.

It was the rain of the far north-west in summer, which does not fall so much as stand in the air and soak through everything that stands in it. It came in off the open sea to the west, where there is nothing between the headland and the edge of

1. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

sight, and it hid the sea, and the fields, and the road ahead. They came into Baile chrom at evening on the second day wet to the skin, and walked down its crooked street, which bends along the shore with the land, and the people in the doors looked at them and nodded, and a woman called to Will Tanner by name.

The boat from Seann Skell had come in two days before them and lay in the little bay below the headland, where there was a landing of stones but no quay. The tank lay on the landing under a sail, and the barrels were stacked beside it under another. The shipmasters' men who had brought her round had gone into the town to drink and had not come back. Joe went down and lifted the corner of the sail and looked at the tank, and put his hand on it, and came back up the path.

"Small pattern," he said. "It'll go up."

The keeper of Taigh-solais Baile chrom² was a Dia-thìreach named Uilleam mac Dhòmhnaill, a spare man with a clipped grey beard, the last of a line of Dia-thìrich keepers who had kept that tower under royal warrant since the first years after An Dealachadh³, a warrant that bade them report on the land as well as on the sea. In eleven years at Baile chrom he had come to know every family in the town by sight and some by name; he went to the town's houses when he was sent for and not otherwise, and the town left him to his tower.

He met the four of them at the tower door with a lamp in his hand, though it was not yet dark, because the rain made the evening dark. He looked at their wet coats and their hand-cart and the tools on it.

"You're the fitters," he said, in the Dia-thìrich tongue.

"We are," said Joe, in the same.

"From the board?"

"From Caol mhòr."

The keeper considered that, and then he stood aside. "The coal-grate's to come out," he said. "I've done what I could with the bolts. You'll want to eat first."

They ate in his kitchen at the tower's foot, bread and a piece of mutton, with the rain on the window. He did not eat with them. He sat at the end of the table with his daybook and wrote, and when Abel Fowler asked him what he was writing he said the weather.

They began in the morning. The grate came out in four days, piece by piece, down the stair on their shoulders, iron that had stood in the fire for more than a century and was burnt and scaled and heavier than it looked. The tank came up

2. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

3. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

from the landing on the hand-cart with four men of the town pushing behind, and up the stair in the arms of all eight, turning at every turn, and Joe going first and backwards with his hands on the lip of it and his eyes on the next step. It went up. They set it on its bed and bolted it down and ran the pipe.

All that week the rain came in off the sea. It came in under the door of the lamp-room and down the inside of the glass where the old putty had shrunk, and Will Tanner spent a day raking the glazing out and setting new, swearing at the putty, which would not take on the wet stone. The coal-store at the tower's foot flooded to the ankle. The keeper came up the stair twice a day to see how they went on and went down again without a word. In the afternoons, when the light was worst, they worked by the lamp he had carried up the first night, and the smoke of it hung in the lamp-room with the smell of wet wool and oil.

On the fifth day the burner jammed. It was Peigi nic Ascaill's burner, sent round in the boat in a box of its own, with the drawings in a tin case beside it and a note on the drawings in a quick small hand: *The throat is wider than the old pattern. Do not trim it. Clear the jet with the screw, not a wire.* Something had been bent in the box on the voyage round the western capes, and the screw would not turn. Joe took the burner apart on the lamp-room floor on a piece of sacking and laid the parts out in rows. He sat over them most of the afternoon while the others worked about him. Then he took the bent part down to the town, where there was a smith who shod the horses and mended the boats' ironwork, and the two of them straightened it on the anvil with the door shut against the rain. The smith did not ask what it was for. Joe paid him out of his own pocket.

On the evening of 20 an t-Ògmhios, DE 7, which was the eve of the longest day, the burner was set and the tank was full and the glazing held. The rain still fell, thinner now, and in the west under the cloud there was a strip of yellow light over the sea.

The keeper came up the stair with his daybook under his arm. The four fitters stood back from the lamp. There was no one else in the lamp-room, and no one on the headland below but a few children of the town who had come up to watch the tower and stood in the wet grass.

"Who lights it?" said Uilleam mac Dhòmhnaill.

The others looked at Joe. Joe looked at the keeper. "It's your light," he said.

The keeper hesitated. Then he put down his daybook on the sill and took the taper Joe gave him and lit the flame. It came up blue and then white, and spread, and steadied, and the great lens took it and threw it out west over the sea in a long

beam that the rain caught and showed, so that for a mile out the drops were lit like sparks. On the headland below the children shouted.

The keeper watched it a while. Then he picked up his daybook and went down the stair, and they heard his door close at the bottom.

In the morning, before they left, he gave them breakfast again, and shook each man's hand at the door, and said the work was good. He said it in the humans' tongue, which none of them had heard him speak all week, and he said it badly, and they thanked him in his own.

They walked home to Caol mhòr in two more days of rain. At the assembly's house the clerk paid them from the chest of Tional nan Tuathach for nine days' work and four days' walking, at the rate of the town, and entered it in the assembly's book: *To four fitters of this town, for the turning of the light at Baile chrom*, and their four names under it, and the sum.

IV

Of the Paper at the Custom-house

The keeper's report reached the board at the end of the summer. Every keeper of the five lights sent one at each quarter-day, telling in a fair round hand what he had seen on the sea and on the land. The board copied the part that concerned the turning of the light and sent it round the kingdom to be pinned up where such things were pinned, that the shires might know their lights were turned. One copy came to Caol mhòr, because Baile chrom lay in the Tuathach country, and the maor pinned it on the board outside the custom-house by the harbour, beside the notice of the fish-prices and the harbour dues.

Joe Ashby read it on his way home from the harbour, on an evening of an Lùnastal with the sun still high.

Will Tanner had seen it that morning and told him, and Joe had walked past the custom-house three times that day without looking. The fourth time he stopped.

It was a short paper. It said that Taigh-solais Baile chrom¹ was turned to dubhan on the twentieth of an t-Ògmhios. It said the tank had come by sea from Seann Skell and was of the small pattern, and the burner of the new pattern

1. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

drawn by the board's engineer. It said the coal-grate was taken out and the glazing of the lamp-room renewed. It said the light burned well and was seen by the boats. It said the town gave no trouble. It said the work was done by fitters from Caol mhòr.

Joe read it twice. Then he read the fish-prices beside it, and the harbour dues, and walked home.

His name was not in it. None of their names were. He had known it would not be; he had seen keepers' reports before, pinned on that same board, and they did not name fitters, or carters, or the men who carried things up stairs. Iseabail Ruadh's daybook at Àth dhearg named the rope-walk; he had not seen it, and would not have known it if he had. What he knew was that a Dia-thireach keeper had stood beside him on the eve of midsummer and had lit the light because Joe gave him the taper, and had gone down his own stair and written *fitters from Caol mhòr*, and that the words were true.

He did not speak of it that night. His sister, with whom he lodged, said afterwards that he sat a long time at the table with a cup he did not drink, and then went out, and she heard him in the shed behind the house, at the bench, sharpening every tool he owned.

The Tuathaich of Caol mhòr have a way of telling it, when they tell it at all, which is short. They say that the Baile chrom light was turned by four men of the town, and they name them, and they say that the keeper's report named the town. Some say it as a grievance and some as a joke. Will Tanner says still that it was the only time Caol mhòr had been in a report of the kingdom's for anything but fish.

A week after, there was a letter for Joe at the assembly's house. It came from the southern Seann Skell and it was written in the same quick small hand as the note on the drawings.

Peigi nic Ascaill had left the board's service at the end of the summer, the letter said, and taken service with the shipmasters' works at Seann Skell as their master-fitter. The works were building a second range of retorts and wanted fitters through the winter, and the shipmasters paid better than the board and a great deal better than the assembly at Caol mhòr. She had had the Baile chrom report and knew who had done the work, for the assembly's clerk had written to the board for the fitters' pay to be made good and had named all four. She would take any of the four who would come, and she would take Joe Ashby first. There was a room over the forge at the works that a fitter might have.

The board did not make good the assembly's money that year, nor the next. The clerk entered the sum in the book as owed, and it stood in the book as owed.

Joe went south in an t-Sultain. Will Tanner would not go; he had a wife and a boat. The Fowler cousins went with him. They took the northern road to the capital and the south road from there to the sea, five days' walking, and came in to Seann Skell on the south coast on an evening of wind with the works' chimney standing up out of the town like a mast, taller than the house of Deas-ghnàth a' Ghual³, taller than anything on the coast, its smoke going out flat over the sea.

Peigi met them at the gate. She had been told they were coming and had come down from the office in her apron. She shook each man's hand, and she looked at Joe a moment longer than the others.

"You mended the burner," she said.

"The screw was bent."

"I know. I've changed the box." She turned to go in, and turned back. "The report named no one."

"No," said Joe.

"The assembly's book did."

He did not answer that. She took them in to see the new range, its brick half-raised in the long shed and its iron lying in the mud, and then the room over the forge.

V

Of the Flame over the Hammer

At the foot of that year the lamp-makers of Muileann mhin began to make dubhan lamps.

They had made lamps for the pits since before anyone at Muileann mhin could remember. Muileann mhin was a river town east of the capital, on the Abhainn fhionn, a town of flour-mills and of the capital's order, and among the mill-wrights and the millers there had grown up a street of lamp-makers who made the coal lamps for every shaft on the island. They had been chartered as Comann nan Lòchran¹ in An Aois Rìoghachd², and their mark was a flame over a

2. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

1. the lamp-makers' guild of Muileann mhin

2. the Age of the Kingdom

hammer, stamped into the brass of every lamp they made. Of all the guild marks of the island it was the only one the humans' traders had ever copied.

There were fewer shafts now. When coal grew scarce in the old reign the lamp-makers had halved their making for want of coal to burn in the lamps they made, and the guild's minute-book of those years was a list of old lamps lent from pit to pit. In the autumn of this year the master of the guild had written to Seann Skell, to the shipmasters' works, for the drawing of a burner, and Peigi nic Ascaill had sent it.

In the last days of the year Peigi went up to the capital on the works' business with the lamp-houses, and at the shipmasters' asking took Joe with her to look at a pump the lamp-houses said did not draw. They came back by Muileann mhin because the master of the lamp-makers had written that he had something to show her.

It was 28 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7, a day of hard frost with the sun low over the river and the mill-wheels stopped with ice. The lamp-makers' street ran down to the water, a row of narrow shops with their doors open for the light and their forges going, and the sound of small hammers came out of every door. The master of the guild met them at the door of the guild's hall at the street's foot, an old man in a leather apron with burns on his forearms like a hewer's scars, and took them in.

On the long table in the hall stood a lamp. It was a pit-lamp of the old shape, the brass bowl and the gauze and the hook to hang it by, but the bowl was deeper, and in its throat was a small burner of Peigi's pattern, made smaller. Lit, it burned with a clean white flame behind the gauze and gave off a thin reek of dubhan.

"Twelve of them," said the master. "We made twelve this month. We've orders for a hundred, from the pits that are left and from the yards of Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn³, and from the inns on the old roads."

Peigi bent to the lamp and turned it in her hands and looked at the burner. Joe looked over her shoulder. The work was fine.

"It's good," she said.

"It's good," the master agreed. He turned the lamp so that the bowl was toward her, and put his thumb on the brass where the mark should be. There was nothing there. "We can't stamp it."

The guild's charter, he explained, gave the mark of the flame and the hammer to the coal lamps of Muileann mhin. It said coal. It had been written when there

was nothing else to burn in a pit, and the men who wrote it had seen no reason to say more. Some of the guild, the older masters, held that a lamp that burned dubhan was no coal lamp and could not bear the mark, and that to stamp it would be to break the charter. Others said the mark was the mark of the hands that made the lamp and not of the thing burned in it. They had argued it at the guild's table since the harvest.

"So we've written to the guild court," said the master. He took a paper from the table and gave it to her. "Asking leave to set the mark on them. I'd be glad of your name on it, as the one who drew the burner."

Peigi read the paper. Then she took the pen he held out to her and signed it at the foot, under his name and the names of the lamp-makers who were for it, *Peigi nic Ascaill, master-fitter of Obair-dhubhain Seann Skell*³, who drew the burner. She held the pen out to Joe.

Joe looked at her.

"You mended one," she said.

He took the pen and wrote his name under hers in the humans' letters, *Joseph Ashby, fitter, of Caol mhòr*, and gave the pen back to the master, who looked at the name a long time, and then blotted it.

The petition went to the guild court at Muileann mhin that afternoon, carried by the master himself in his good coat. Peigi and Joe went on by the road to the south-east in the last of the light. Behind them, in the window of the guild's hall, the lamp without a mark burned on the long table, where the master had left it, and the street of the lamp-makers went on with its hammering into the frost of the evening, and the year ended.

3. the Rail Board; lit. 'the board of the iron way'

4. the dubhan works at the southern Seann Skell

CHAPTER NINE

Of the Speaker and the Binders

DE 8

Part Two: Of the Roads, the Rails and the Plain Seal

Cha b' fheadar dhomb riamb roimbe bliadbna a ghluasad 's mi beò innte. Never before have I had to move a year I was living in.

— Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh, DE 15

I

Of the Speaker's Last Night

The minute-book of Tìonal nan Tuathach¹ has no entry for the first week of am Faoilleach in the eighth year. The clerk at Caol mhòr would not call the room to order while the speaker lay dying, and nobody asked him to. What the book leaves out, the mill-hands of Doire ghlas and the binders of Muileann leathan have kept between them, and they tell it much alike.

On the eighth of the month a boy came up the mill road at Doire ghlas on a pony as wet as himself, with a note folded small in his fist. Martha Greaves was in the carding-room with her sleeves pushed up, counting fleeces that the tally said were forty and her eyes said were thirty-eight. She took the note without looking at the boy and read it standing among the bales. It was in the eldest binder's hand, which she knew from thirty years of the delegates' accounts, and it said only that Daniel was asking for her, and that he had not asked for anyone before.

She finished the count first. It was thirty-eight. She wrote the two missing fleeces against the carrier's name, put on her coat, and told the overseer he had the

mill until she came back, and that if he let the east wheel run dry again she would know.

The road from Doire ghlas to Muileann leathan runs east under the grey oaks and then out along the edge of the coast, some seven miles. The cart took the better part of the afternoon. It rained the whole way, the fine sideways rain that comes in off the sea to the north in the dead of winter and finds its way in at the collar however the collar is buttoned. Martha sat beside the carter with the oil-cloth over her knees and kept her own counsel. Fifty-nine that winter, broad in the shoulder, grey, and known in every northern town as a woman who read a ledger faster than most people read a name, she had managed the mills at Doire ghlas since the year the delegates' money built them. For eleven years she had sat in Tional nan Tuathach as delegate for the mill-town and had never once spoken in it for longer than it took to give a figure.

Muileann leathan stands on its stream inside an old wall, with the keep of the Dia-thirich governors at one end and the church of the northern congregations at the other, and the mill that gives the town its name squatting broad and low across the race between them. The bindery was a narrow house under the wall, down a lane that smelt of wet stone and flour. A lamp was lit in the upper window.

The binders were in the workroom below, all of them, though there was no work on the benches. There were eleven. They had been boys and girls when Daniel Frayne first taught them to fold a sheet and sew a gathering, in the years when no guild in the south would take a Tuathach apprentice for that craft, and now the youngest of them was going grey. They sat among the standing presses and the sewing frames with their hands in their laps, and the room smelt of paste, hide and cold glue. The eldest binder, a lame woman who had sewn her first gathering for him at twelve, got up when Martha came in.

"He's awake," she said. "He's been awake since noon, waiting on you. He'd not let us send before."

"Why not?"

"He said you'd a mill to run."

Martha went up. The stair was steep and bare, and the room at the top was hardly wider than the bed. Daniel Frayne lay propped against a bolster with his hands laid flat on the blanket, the way he had laid them flat on the speaker's table

1. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

at Caol mhòr for twenty-three years when he meant to keep them still. He was seventy-three, and the skin of his face had gone thin and yellow over the bone. There was a dubhan stove in the corner, one of the little iron ones the pedlars sold, and it gave off a steady heat and a smell like a tarred rope smouldering.

"Martha," he said.

"Daniel."

"Sit. The chair's sound, whatever it looks."

She sat. Through the small window, past the roofs and the wall, she could see the headland where Taigh-solais Muileann bheag² stood, and its lamp had just been lit. The light had been turned to dubhan the winter before, fed by carts from the north, and it burned whiter and steadier than the coal flame had. She had not got used to it.

"You'll want to know what I want," he said.

"I'd guessed you wanted something."

He nearly laughed, and it cost him, and he waited till his breath came back. "The books," he said. "The minute-books. The first twenty years are coming out of their boards. Walter's paste was flour and fish-glue, and there's nothing left of it but dust and a smell. I've been meaning to rebind them since before you were a delegate. Every year there was something the room wanted more."

"The clerk's been keeping the loose leaves in order. I've seen him at it."

"The clerk's been keeping them in a drawer with a stone on top." He moved one hand on the blanket, an inch, and put it back. "I want them done. All of them. From the wet afternoon onward. By my own, down there. They know the work. They'll do it for the cost of the thread if the room lets them, and more carefully than anyone in Cathair dhearg would do it for gold."

"That's for the speaker to ask."

"Yes," said Daniel Frayne. He looked at her with his pale eyes and said nothing more about it, and she understood that he had said all he meant to on that head. It was his way in the chair as well. He put a thing on the table and let it lie there until someone picked it up.

They talked a little after that, of small things. He asked after the mill and the price of fleece. She told him about the two fleeces short at the carrier's, and he said the carrier's father had been a thief before him and his grandfather a thief under

2. the lighthouse at Muileann bheag

the humans, and that it showed a proper respect for a trade to keep it in the family. Then he slept, and woke, and asked for water, and slept again.

The eldest binder came up with a candle at about ten and sat on the top step. Martha did not go down. Toward the small hours his breathing changed and slowed, and grew loud, and then far apart. The lame woman came and stood at the foot of the bed with her hand over her mouth. The rain had stopped. Out on the headland the white lamp of Muileann bheag turned and turned, and its light came round in the window at each turn, and went.

He died a little before light on 9 am Faoilleach, DE 8. Martha heard the breath go out and not come back, and she waited a long while to be sure. Then she folded his hands one over the other, since there was no longer any need to keep them flat, and went down the stair to tell the others, who already knew.

II

Of the Burial at Muileann leathan

They buried Daniel Frayne four days later in the churchyard of Muileann leathan, at the east end of the town, under the wall where the wind comes over from the sea.

The church there is the largest in the north after Doire ghlais, a long grey building with a squat tower, raised on the stones of a Dia-thìreach hall that stood on the spot before An Dealachadh¹. Eaglais nan Tuathach² has kept it since those years. It was full that morning, and the lane outside was full, and the people who could not get in stood along the churchyard wall in their dark coats with the rain dripping off their hat-brims. They had come from all along the coast: fishing families from Cathair gheal, millers and weavers from Doire ghlais, carters, harbourmen from Caol mhòr, a knot of hewers from the western hill towns who had walked two days and stood a little apart, with the black of their trade still in the lines of their knuckles.

The binders carried him. There were eleven of them and the coffin wanted six, so they took it in turns down the length of the lane, stopping at every twenty paces to change, and the crowd waited each time without a word. The eldest

1. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

2. the Tuathaich Church; the old congregations of the north coast

binder walked in front with her stick. Martha walked behind with the clerk of Tional nan Tuathach³, a thin nervous man called Thomas Rook who had brought the speaker's chair-cushion wrapped in a cloth under his arm and did not seem to know what to do with it.

The priest read in the humans' tongue, which was the tongue of the northern churches and of most northern kitchens, though every soul in the church could have followed him as well in Dia-thìris. He read the psalm the north keeps for its dead, of the waters and the hills, and then he spoke briefly of Daniel Frayne's life, and said that he had taught the children of this town a trade when no one else would, and had kept the northern delegates' books in good order for twenty-three years, and had never been heard to raise his voice in either work. Then the school-children of Doire ghlas, whom their teacher had brought seven miles in two carts that morning, stood up in the gallery and sang the hymn of the sea road, and some of the fishing families sang with them. Martha found she did not trust herself to sing and did not try.

At the grave the ground was soft and heavy, and the diggers had laid planks along the edge. The binders let the coffin down on their own straps. When the priest had done, each of them in turn stooped and dropped something into the grave before the earth went in. Martha, at the foot, saw that it was thread: a short length of linen binding-thread from each of them, waxed and cut, the kind he had taught them to draw through the fold.

When it was over the crowd stood about in the lane and would not go home. The women of the town brought bread and hot broth out of their kitchens, and people drank it standing under the eaves. Martha found herself backed against the churchyard wall with a cup in her hands and a ring of delegates round her, pretending to talk of the weather.

Peter Hale was one of them, the delegate of Caol mhòr, thirty-eight years old, long-armed and fair, and he kept the tally on the Caol mhòr fish-quay as his great-grandfather Walter Hale had kept the humans' harbour books before the northern towns had any gathering of their own. He had a way of standing straight as a mast when he was nervous. He was standing so now.

"Mistress Greaves," he said.

"Peter."

"The room will sit at Caol mhòr at the month's end. For the chair."

3. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

"I know when the room sits. I've sat in it eleven years."

"They'll put your name," he said. "Cathair gheal's said so, and the hill towns, and I'd put it myself if nobody else did."

"Then somebody had better put another one beside it," said Martha, "for I've two hundred looms and a carrier who can't count to forty, and I'm no talker."

"Daniel wasn't a talker."

"Daniel was a bookbinder. It's a trade for a patient man." She drank off the broth and gave him the cup to hold. "Ask Mistress Marsh. She stands up in front of forty children every morning and makes them listen. That's a gift."

Ellen Marsh had come up behind him while they spoke, with her two carts of children marshalled along the wall by the older girls. She was a narrow dark woman of fifty-two, the teacher at Agnes Pike's old school in Doire ghlas, with ink on her middle finger that never quite washed off, and a dry voice that carried to the back of any room without being raised.

"Mistress Marsh is not a delegate," she said, "and would be no use to you in the chair, for she'd make the council parse its own letters before she answered them." She looked at Martha. "They've asked you already, Martha. They're only waiting now for you to hear it."

Martha said nothing. Down the lane the eldest binder was standing at the door of the bindery with her stick, looking out at the crowd, and behind her the workroom was dark. It came to Martha then, with the broth still burning in her throat, that whoever sat in the chair would be the one to ask for the books, and that she had sat by his bed and told him so herself.

III

Of the Chair at Caol mhòr

Tional nan Tuathach sat at Caol mhòr on the last day but one of am Faoilleach, in the long low room over the net-lofts by the harbour where it had sat since Walter Hale's wet afternoon. The humans' harbour office had stood below it once. The room still smelt of damp wool and fish-scale, and would until the sea dried up. A fire of driftwood and turf burned in the grate at one end and did nothing for the other. There were benches along both walls and a trestle down the middle, and at its head the speaker's chair, a plain high-backed thing of

ship's oak. Thomas Rook had laid the cushion back on it, and nobody had sat down there.

Forty-four delegates came, which was more than had come to any sitting in years. The fishing towns came, and the mill towns, and the farms of the northern shires, and the pit towns of the western hills, whose hewers still worked their own seams under their own captains and paid An Crùn¹ its fifth by the old ruling, to a Comhairle nam Mèinnean² that entered it as arrears. Thomas Rook read the notice of Daniel Frayne's death into the minute in his careful clerk's voice, and the day and the place of his burial, and the room stood for the space of a breath and sat down again.

Then an old fisherman from Cathair gheal got to his feet without being asked and said, "I put the name of Martha Greaves of Doire ghlais," and sat down again, as if that settled it.

Martha stood up at once. She had meant to speak calmly, and found that she was angry, and could not have said at whom.

"I have a mill," she said. "Two mills, and a dye-house, and three hundred people who eat by them. I've no learning past the figures. I've never stood up in this room longer than it takes to read a row of figures. There are men and women on these benches who can talk a council clerk into a stupor and out again. Put one of them."

"Daniel had a bindery," said the old fisherman from where he sat.

"Daniel had eleven binders who could run it without him."

"And you've an overseer," said Peter Hale, "who let the east wheel run dry in an t-Samhain, and you've not sacked him."

There was laughter at that, not unkind, and Martha had nothing to say to it. The room had heard her, and went on as if it had not.

A delegate of the farm towns put a second name, the name of a Ceann mhòr carter, a big genial man who had spoken in the room more often than anyone. The carter got up and said with great good humour that he withdrew it, since he could not read, and that he would sooner see a speaker who could add. Nobody else put a name. Thomas Rook looked down the trestle at the rows of faces, and then at Martha, and asked the room in the old form whether it would have Martha Greaves of Doire ghlais in the chair. The hands went up along both walls,

1. the Crown

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

the fishermen's and the millers' and the hewers', and he did not trouble to count them.

She sat down in Daniel Frayne's chair on the cushion he had sat on, and found that it was too high for her, and that her feet did not lie flat on the floor. She kept them still.

The room waited for her to speak. She had no speech. She looked down the trestle, over the ink-pots and the delegates' hats laid in a row, to the fire at the far end, and then she said what was in her mind.

"Daniel asked me for a thing on his last night," she said. "He asked me to ask the room for it. So I'll do that first, and then we can get on."

She told them. She spoke in the humans' tongue, as the room mostly did, and when an old woman from the western coast, who kept Dia-thiris by preference and made a point of it, called out that she had not caught the last of it, Martha said it again in Dia-thìris without a pause and without apology, and went on. The first books were coming apart. The clerk kept the loose leaves in a drawer with a stone on them. Daniel's binders at Muileann leathan would rebind the whole run from the first meeting for the cost of their thread and board, and he had wished it done.

Thomas Rook went to the press at the side of the room, a tall cupboard with a lock, and brought out the first of the books and laid it on the trestle before her. It was a thick ledger in a split calf cover. When she opened it the front board came away in her hand, and a gathering of pages slid out after it and fanned across the table. The delegates at the near end leaned to look. The ink on the top leaf was brown and small and cramped, and it gave the day, and under it the names of the towns that had come.

"There's sixty-odd of these," said Thomas Rook, "and the first twenty are like that one, or worse."

A delegate of the fishing towns asked who paid, and how much, and for how long the room would be without its books. They were fair questions, and Martha found that they steadied her, since they had answers and she could get them. She said that she would have the binders' reckoning for the next sitting, and that if the room's purse could not meet it, the mills at Doire ghlas would, and the room could argue with her afterwards about whether it ought to have let them.

It was moved and carried that the matter lie over to the next sitting for the binders' figures. Thomas Rook wrote it in. Then the room got on, as she had said it would: a quarrel between two fishing towns over a mooring, the price of seed-

oats, a letter from Comhairle nam Mèinnean about the western pits that nobody could make head or tail of. Martha heard them all out with her feet off the floor, and kept the minutes short.

When the sitting rose at dusk, the delegates went down the outside stair into the wind, and she stayed. She sat on in the chair with the loose pages of Walter Hale's book in front of her, gathering them square, until Thomas Rook coughed from the door and said he would be locking up. The minute-book for that day records her first sitting as speaker. It is the shortest minute of the year.

IV

Of the Minute of the Second Set

The room sat again on 24 an Gearran, DE 8, in a hard gale from the southwest that shook the net-lofts beneath the floor and set the lamps swinging on their hooks.

The binders' reckoning had come to Martha at Doire ghlas a week before, in the eldest binder's upright hand, on a single sheet. She had gone through it at her desk in the counting-house one evening with the mill quiet below and a pot of tea going cold at her elbow. It was a good reckoning. It set down the number of books, which was sixty-three, and the number of leaves in each so far as the clerk's drawer allowed, and the linen and the board and the hide and the paste by weight, and the days of work, and at the foot a sum so small that she went through it twice to find the mistake. There was none. The binders had charged nothing for their hands.

She read it to the room. It passed without a division, and Martha said that the mills at Doire ghlas would give the hide.

The eldest binder had come herself to hear it, seven miles by cart and then the long road round the head of the strait to Caol mhòr, and she sat on the bench by the door with her stick across her knees. When the vote was taken she got up and came down the room, and laid a second paper on the trestle before the chair, folded twice.

"There's one thing more," she said, "if the speaker will have it read."

Martha unfolded it. It was the wording of a minute, written out fair so that the clerk could copy it straight. It said that the books of Tional nan Tuathach¹

were to be rebound by the binders of Muileann leathan and kept thereafter in the delegates' press at Caol mhòr; and that a second set of the same was made, and was hidden elsewhere; and that this minute should stand as all the gathering knew of it.

She read it through twice. The gale drummed on the roof. Then she looked up at the eldest binder, who looked back at her with no expression at all.

"Made," Martha said. "Not to be made."

"Made," said the eldest binder.

"Since when?"

"Longer than you've been in that chair, Mistress."

Martha read it out to the room. There was no sound at the end of it but the wind and the swing and creak of the lamps. Forty faces looked at her along the trestle, and she looked at them. She saw Peter Hale sitting stiff as a mast, and the old fisherman of Cathair gheal with his eyes shut, and the hewers of the western hills side by side on their bench with their black knuckles folded, and she could not tell from any face whether it knew more than she did.

"Is there anybody in this room," she said, "who knows where?"

Nobody answered.

She sat for a while with the paper under her hand. She thought of Daniel Frayne with his palms laid flat on the blanket, putting a thing on the table and letting it lie. The census figures had once been read out in this room, and he had written two words under them. She thought, because she was a mill manager and could not help it, of the kingdom's clerks at Cathair dhearg, and what a speaker of Tional nan Tuathach might one day be asked across a table by a man with a pen, and of what it would be worth then to be able to say that she did not know.

"Then I shan't ask," she said. "Thomas, write it as it's written."

Thomas Rook copied it into the book, word for word, while the room watched his pen. When he had done he turned the book round on the trestle and held out the pen to her, and Martha Greaves signed the minute under the line that said a second set was made and hidden elsewhere. Her hand was steady. She blotted it herself.

The eldest binder took back her paper and folded it into her sleeve. "Thank you, Mistress," she said, and went back to her bench by the door and sat down.

The last business of the sitting was the carrying. The books could not go to Muileann leathan, for the bindery had been Daniel's house as well as his shop and

his kin were clearing it, and there was no room in it now to lay out sixty-three books and their loose leaves on a table at once. Ellen Marsh had written from Doire ghlais to say that her schoolroom was long and dry, with a good north light and a stove that drew, and that the children could be taught in the church meanwhile, since the priest had said he would be glad of the noise. The binders could come to it from Muileann leathan in a morning, and Caol mhòr could send the books to it in a day.

The room thanked Mistress Marsh by a vote, and it was moved that the delegate of Caol mhòr carry the books to Doire ghlais and back, since his great-grandfather had written the first of them. Peter Hale went red to the ears and said that he would.

V

Of the Schoolroom and the Press

Peter Hale brought them in the first week of am Màrt, in a hired cart with the tilt laced down and the books packed upright in three tea-chests lined with oilcloth, and he walked beside the horse the whole nine miles from Caol mhòr with one hand on the tailboard. At Doire ghlais the children had been let out early to see the books come in, and they stood in two lines under the grey oaks outside Agnes Pike's school in their pinafores and boots, and watched him lift the chests down as if they held a king's regalia. Ellen Marsh did not shoo them off. She said that they might as well see the town's history carried in the door once, since it was so seldom that any of it was.

The schoolroom was what she had said: long, whitewashed, with tall windows to the north and a black iron stove at the end. The benches were pushed back and the children's tables set end to end down the floor. The binders came over from Muileann leathan the next morning in two carts with their standing presses and sewing frames lashed down under sacking, and by noon the schoolroom smelt of paste and warm glue and the stove, and nobody who went in could tell any longer that it had ever been a school, except for the alphabet painted round the top of the walls in the humans' letters, and under it the same in Dia-thìris.

Martha came over from the mill most evenings when the looms were stopped. It was a short walk under the oaks. She told herself she came to see that the hide

was the hide she had paid for, and after the first week she stopped telling herself anything. She would sit on the end of a bench with her coat still on and watch them work by the lamps until Ellen came in from her rooms at the back with a pot of tea and sat beside her.

The binders took the books apart first, all of them, before they put any together. They cut the old stitching, lifted the gatherings out of the boards and laid them flat on the tables in order, sixty-three rows of loose pages under weights, so that the whole long record of the room lay open down the length of the floor at once. Martha walked the length of it one evening from the stove to the door, and it took her twenty paces, and she thought that it was seventy-seven years.

When they came to take Walter Hale's first book out of its boards, the eldest binder called Martha and Ellen over to the table under the lamp.

"Look here," she said.

She had slit the old spine, and turned back the first gathering, and at the inside of the fold, between the stitching and the first page of minutes, there was a row of narrow stubs where leaves had been cut out close with a knife. On the stubs, at the edge, were the ends of ruled columns, and a few figures in a neat brown hand, and on one of them the tail of a word in the humans' tongue.

"It's a harbour ledger," said the eldest binder. "Tonnage and dues. He cut out what he'd written for the humans and used the rest."

Martha bent close. The figures on the stubs were the same brown and the same hand as the minute that followed. Walter Hale had been a harbour clerk under the humans. When the humans' harbour office closed and the Tuathaich came together in the room above it, he had taken the ledger he had in his desk, cut out his old masters' accounts, and written the first day of Tional nan Tuathach¹ on the next clean page. On that page the ink was a little blotted, as if the pen had been wetted too full.

"He hadn't a new book," said Ellen Marsh.

"He hadn't anything," said Martha. "None of them had." She straightened up. "Keep the stubs in."

"I'd meant to," said the eldest binder.

They went on through am Màrt and into an Giblean. Gathering by gathering the old pages were mended where they were torn, backed with fine paper where they were weak, pressed flat, and sewn onto new cords with the waxed linen that

1. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

1. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

Daniel Frayne had taught them to draw. The boards were covered in the brown hide from the Doire ghlas tannery, and the eldest binder cut the lettering on each spine herself with a hot tool, the years and nothing else. The finished books stood in a row on the long shelf under the window, and every day the row was a little longer.

The children came in and out. The eldest binder let them, provided they kept their hands behind their backs, and a few of the older girls were set to fold and trim the backing paper and did it well. One wet afternoon Martha found a boy of nine standing at the table where the minutes of the census year lay spread under their weights, reading them upside down with his lips moving.

"What's that say, missus?" he asked her, pointing.

She looked. It was a page in Daniel Frayne's small upright hand, with rows of figures read out from the kingdom's paper, and underneath, alone on the line, the two words.

"Now written," she said.

"What's now written?"

"That's the question," said Martha, and after a while, since he was still waiting, she told him about the census, and the northern towns set down at half the measure, and the room in Caol mhòr where it was read out, and the speaker who sat with his hands flat on the table and would not raise his voice. The boy listened with his hands behind his back, as he had been told. When she had done he said that he thought the speaker ought to have shouted, and went off to fold paper.

Ellen had been listening from the stove. When the boy was gone she came and stood by Martha at the table and looked down the long rows of pages.

"It's all what was decided," she said. "Motions and votes and letters sent and letters received and filed. The price of seed-oats. Every page of it."

"That's what minutes are."

"I know it." Ellen touched the edge of the census page with one ink-stained finger, lightly, not to disturb the weights. "There's not a line in seventy-seven years of what happened to anybody."

Martha did not answer that. She had no answer ready, and she was not a woman who said things she had not thought out. After a time Ellen went back to the stove and poured the tea, and the binders worked on.

The last book was finished on the twenty-sixth of an Giblean, a clear cold morning with a high wind. It was Daniel Frayne's own last book, which ended in the middle of a page with the room's business for the last week of an Dùbhlachd,

and after that the first minute in Thomas Rook's hand of the speaker's death. The eldest binder cut the spine with the two years it held and set it on the shelf at the end of the row. Then she stood back, leaning on her stick, and looked at the sixty-three books together for a long time, and said that it would do.

Peter Hale came for them the next day with the same cart and the same tea-chests. The children lined up under the oaks again to see them go, and Ellen Marsh stood in the door of her school and watched until the cart had gone out of sight among the trees. Then she went in and began to push the benches back into their rows.

Martha rode in the cart. It was a bright blowing day, with the rain gone east, and the road ran down through the oak country toward the head of the strait, and they came into Caol mhòr in the middle of the afternoon with the tide out and the fishing boats lying over on the mud. Peter Hale carried the chests up the outside stair one at a time. Thomas Rook had the press open and had scrubbed its shelves.

Martha laid the books in herself. She took them out of the chests one by one, in order, reading the years on each spine before she set it in its place, beginning at the top left with Walter Hale's harbour ledger in its new brown hide and ending low on the right with Daniel's. It took a long time, and neither of the men offered to help. When the last was in she ran her hand along the spines once, top shelf to bottom, the way she ran it along a row of bolts in the warehouse to be sure the count was right. It was right. She shut the doors of the press and locked them, and took the key off the lock, and put it on the ring at her belt with the keys of the mills.

"There's a minute wants writing," said Thomas Rook.

"Write that the books are laid in the press," said Martha. "Sixty-three of them, rebound by the binders of Muileann leathan, at the cost of their thread. Write the day."

He wrote it. He did not ask whether he should write anything more, and she did not tell him to, for there was nothing more that she knew.

She went down the stair afterward and stood a while at the harbour wall in the wind with her coat buttoned to the chin. The tide was on the turn and the boats were beginning to lift. Across the strait the evening came up grey off the water, and along the harbour front the lamps were being lit in the windows, one and then another. The key knocked against the others at her belt when she moved.

She stood there until the first boats were afloat, and then she went to find the carter for the road home.

CHAPTER TEN

OF the Coal Line and the Salt Road

DE 8 – 9

I

Of the Yard at Muileann chrom

The yard families of Muileann chrom lived in three rows of slate-roofed houses between the sidings and the river, where Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn¹ had put them when it laid the new lines in the kingdom's thirteenth year of the old count. Comhairle nam Mèinnean² counted them apart from the rest of the town, and in time they counted themselves apart. They married among the rows, they buried in their own corner of the burial ground below the mill, and they kept their own hours, which were the hours of the trains. A child of the rows learned to tell the coal engines one from another by the note of their breath before she learned her letters, and a man of the rows who could not tell you the gradient of every mile of Slighe a' Ghuail³ between the yard and the sea was thought a little slow.

Eachann mac Ruairidh was forty-three that spring and had driven coal on the line for twenty years. He was a short, broad man with a burn-scar across the back of one hand from a gauge-glass that had burst when he was a fireman, and he had the habit, which his wife said was the only vain thing about him, of cleaning his boots every night whatever the day had been. He lived in the middle row with

1. the Rail Board; lit. 'the board of the iron way'

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

3. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

Seonaid nic Dhòmhnaill, who had come to the yard as a girl from the drovers of Achadh mhòr, their two daughters, and his father.

His father was Ruairidh mac Eachainn, and he had driven for forty years. He had been a fireman on the first trains the kingdom ran up to An Sloc Mòr⁴, when the rails were still the humans' rails and the timetable was still the humans' timetable, and he had been a driver on the same run before Eachann was born. In the year the yard stopped the trains for three days over the cut in wages, Ruairidh had stood on the line with the rest and had not been among the eleven dismissed on the fifth day, and he never said whether he had been lucky or careful. Now he sat on a chair outside the door of the middle row in all weathers but rain, with a blanket over his knees, and listened to the engines, and could tell you from the sound of a train leaving the yard whether the fireman knew his work.

In the last days of an Gearran, in the eighth year of Linn an Dubhain⁵, which nobody then called by that name, Comhairle nam Mèinnean's clerk at the yard pinned a notice to the door of the engine-shed. Comhairle nam Mèinnean had bought an engine of the new kind from the shipmasters' works at the southern Seann Skell, and would try it on Slighe a' Ghuail. A driver was wanted to learn it. The notice said that the man chosen would be paid at the driver's rate during his learning, and it did not say what would be paid to anyone afterwards.

The older drivers read it and went back to their engines. Two of the younger ones put their names down and took them off again the same evening after talking to their fathers. Eachann read it three times, went home, cleaned his boots, and said nothing about it at supper. His father said nothing either, which was how Eachann knew he had heard.

"You'll put your name to it," Seonaid said, when the girls were in bed.

"Somebody will."

"That is not what I asked."

"Then yes," he said. "I will."

In the morning he wrote his name under the notice, alone, and the clerk took it down at noon.

The engine came up from the south in the middle of am Màrt. Slighe a' Ghuail did not run to the southern Seann Skell, and Comhairle nam Mèinnean would not wait for rails to be laid, so the works sent it by the old road on a low wagon with iron wheels, drawn by twelve horses. The horses were hired from the

⁴ the great pit at the mountain

⁵ the Dubhan Era (DE); lit. 'the era of Dubhan'

stables of Òrd Mhacha⁶ at Muileann chrom, which kept the best draught-beasts in the central country, and a priest of the order walked at the head of the leaders the whole two days, as the order's custom was whenever its horses hauled for the kingdom. It rained on the first day. On the second the wagon stuck in the ford below the town, and the priest stood in the water to his thighs speaking to the horses in the old words until they took it out. Half the yard went down to the ford to watch. Eachann went with them.

The engine was smaller than he had expected, a long box of dark-painted iron on eight wheels, with a cab at each end and no chimney. There was no firebox and no boiler, and no place in the cab for a fireman to stand. On its side, where Comhairle nam Mèinnean's number would go, someone at the works had chalked a word in the humans' tongue that nobody at the ford could read, and the priest of Macha wiped it off with his sleeve before the wagon came up the bank.

"What does it drink?" somebody asked.

"The black stuff," said a man who had been to the south. "Out of a barrel."

"And what does it eat?"

"Nothing. That is the whole trick of it."

The tank came three days after, on its own wagon, and Comhairle nam Mèinnean's men set it on stone piers at the end of the long siding and filled it from barrels brought up by cart from the southern Seann Skell. It was the first dubhan tank Comhairle nam Mèinnean owned. The children of the rows stood under it and sniffed, and made faces, and came back the next day to sniff again. Dubhan in those years had a reek that nobody who smelled it ever forgot, something between a tar-boiler and a wet dog, and it clung to cloth. Seonaid said she could tell from the doorway what her husband had been doing all day, and in the end she made him leave his jacket in the wash-house.

Two fitters from the works came with the engine to teach it. One was a Dia-thìreach of the south coast, a thin, sour man who knew the engine as a priest knows a psalm and could not explain one word of it. The other was a Tuathach from Caol mhòr named Will Garside, who had come south to work at the shipmasters' works when they first took on northern hands. He spoke Dia-thìris with a northern burr and the humans' tongue with his own people, and he would shift from one to the other in the middle of a sentence when he was thinking hard. He was a patient teacher, and had Eachann take the engine's heart out and put it back

6. the order of Macha

on the first day, and on the second, and on the seventh, until Eachann could do it in the dark.

"You drove coal," Will said to him once, on the siding, while the rain came off the hills.

"Twenty years."

"Then you'll be wanting to feed it. You'll put your hand out for a shovel that isn't there. Every coal man does it. Leave your hand where it is."

Eachann did it for a week and then stopped. What he could not stop was listening for the fire. A coal engine talked to its driver the whole way: the roar when the door opened, the sigh of the safety-valve, the change of note on a gradient that told you before any gauge did that you were short of steam. The dubhan engine beat. It beat under his feet like a heart that had been running too long, steady and hard, and the beat went up when he opened it and down when he closed it and told him nothing else at all. For the first fortnight he drove with his head on one side like a dog listening at a door, and Will laughed at him and then did not laugh, because the listening was what made him careful.

By the middle of an Giblean he had taken the engine to An Sloc Mòr and back, empty, twice, with the sour fitter beside him and Comhairle nam Mèinnean's engineer, Niall mac Leòid, riding behind in a brake-van with a notebook. By the end of the month he had taken it without the fitter. The engineer wrote in his notebook that the man could drive it. He did not give Eachann any paper that said so, and Eachann did not ask for one.

His father came down to the siding once in all that month. He stood at the end of the platform with his stick and watched Eachann bring the engine in, and when it stopped he looked at it a long while, at the place where the chimney should have been, and at the cab where there was no fire.

"It's clean," he said at last.

"It is."

"A clean engine," his father said, and went home.

II

Of the Engine that Carried No Coal

O

n Bealltainn, the first day of an Cèitean, Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn¹ ran its first dubhan train on Slighe a' Ghuail² from the yard at Muileann chrom to Cathair dhearg.

The fires of the feast had been lit on the hills about the town the night before, as they were every year, and the cattle of the hill farms driven between them for luck, and at dawn there was still smoke going up from three hilltops into a sky the colour of pewter. In the yard they filled the four tank-wagons from the tank on the piers by hand-pump, the men taking turns at the handle, and the reek of the stuff lay over the sidings so thick that the women of the rows shut their windows. There was no coal on the train. There was dubhan for the lamp-houses of the capital, and a brake-van at the tail with Niall mac Leòid in it, and that was all.

A few people came to see it off: the clerk, the yard foreman, the families of the rows who were not at work, the priest of Macha who had walked the engine up from the ford, and who said a blessing over it that was the blessing for a horse setting out on a long road, since no one had yet made one for an engine. Will Garside had gone back south a week before. Eachann's daughters stood on the wall of the rows and waved. His father was not there. His chair stood outside the door of the middle row with the blanket folded on it.

Eachann opened the engine, and the beat came up under his feet, and the train went out of the yard.

It is thirty-one miles from the yard at Muileann chrom to the goods-sheds at Cathair dhearg by Slighe a' Ghuail, and the line goes west the whole way, down the valley of the river and out onto the long slope of the capital's country. Eachann had driven it more times than he could count, and had never seen it. With no fire to feed and no fireman to watch, he had nothing to do with his eyes but look out of the window, and he found that the road he knew by its gradients and its signals and its places to take water had fields beside it, and people in the fields. At Cnoc ghorm the women of the line-side houses were hanging washing on the line behind their houses and did not look up; a coal train went by them six times a day, and they had not yet learned that this one was different. Past the bend below Cuan chrom the old coal road came down beside the line for a mile, and Eachann saw the roof of An Taigh-seinnse Mòr³ above it with a cart standing at the door. A little after that the line crossed a burn, and a boy fishing from the

1. the Rail Board; lit. 'the board of the iron way'

2. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

3. the great house on the old coal road above Cuan chrom, whose new hall is let to the Guild of Hewers

bridge dropped his rod and stood staring after the train with his mouth open, because it had no smoke.

That was what people saw, all the way down the line: no smoke. At every crossing where the road went over the rails there was someone standing to look, and they looked at the place above the engine where the smoke should have been, and then at the cab, and then at each other. A carter near Muileann mhin pulled his horse off the road and stood at its head, and as the train went past he took his cap off, though whether it was to the engine or to Eachann or to the day, he did not say.

Muileann mhin was where the lamp-makers were. That winter Comann nan Lòchran⁴ had begun to make lamps for dubhan, and had asked leave of the guild court to set on them the mark it had always set on its lamps, the flame over the hammer; the court was still arguing it. As the train came by the town's end, Eachann saw that the lamp-makers had come out of their shops and were standing in a row along the fence of the last field, some thirty of them in their leather aprons, to see the fuel their lamps would burn go by on its way to the capital. Nobody waved. One of them raised a lamp above his head as the engine passed, a new one, unlit, the brass bright in the grey light.

The goods-sheds at Cathair dhearg lay on the eastern edge of the capital, by the coal-yards, and the lamp-house men were waiting there with their carts and their barrels. They were men of the capital's poorer streets, where the lamps had been left dark to save coal six years before and had been lit again when the first dubhan came up from the south by road. The reek was nothing new to them, and nobody made faces at it. The dubhan was drawn off into their barrels by the tank-wagons' taps and loaded the barrels on their carts, and their foreman signed Niall mac Leòid's paper, and it was all done by a little after noon.

Eachann ate his bread in the cab. When he had finished, the lamp-house foreman came and stood by the step and looked up at him.

"Is it true there's no coal in her at all?"

"None."

"Not even to start her?"

"Not a lump."

The foreman shook his head. "My grandfather lit the lamps in Cathair dhearg when the humans put them up," he said. "Every night of his life he carried coal up

4. the lamp-makers' guild of Muileann mhin

a ladder. I carried coal up a ladder. My boy has never carried a lump of it, and he's twelve." He looked at the engine a while longer. "I don't know what I think," he said, and went back to his carts.

The train went home empty. There was nothing at the capital that anybody wanted carried to Muileann chrom, and Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁵ had not thought to find anything, and so the four tank-wagons rolled east behind the engine with their taps shut and nothing in them but the smell. On the long pull up the valley Eachann opened the engine to its full and felt the beat come up hard under his boots, and the engine took the bank below Cnoc ghorm without slowing, where a coal engine bringing the empties home would have been down to walking pace and the fireman sweating at the door. Eachann had not known it could do that. He sat with the knowledge for a while and did not know what he thought about it either.

He brought the train into the yard at dusk. The feast-fires were smoking still on the hills, and the smoke of them lay in the valley, and the yard lamps, which burned oil, were lit along the sidings. The families had gone in to their suppers. The foreman signed him off. Niall mac Leòid climbed down stiffly from the brake-van, shook Eachann's hand, said that Comhairle nam Mèinnean would be pleased, and went off to find a bed at the inn by the mill.

His father was standing at the end of the long siding, by the tank on its piers, leaning on his stick.

Eachann climbed down. For a while neither of them said anything. The engine ticked as it cooled. Somewhere in the rows a child was crying and being hushed.

"She took the bank below Cnoc ghorm coming home," Eachann said, "and never slowed."

"I heard her come in," said his father. "From the house. I took her for the mill."

"Come up," Eachann said. "I'll take her down to the points and back. It's no distance. You can stand where the fireman stands."

"There's no fireman."

"Then stand where he would."

His father looked at the engine. In the half-dark it was only a long shape against the lamps, with no glow at the cab door and no steam at the valves, and nothing about it that moved.

5. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

"Forty years," Ruairidh said, "I had a fire at my knee. When she was hungry I knew it, and when she was full I knew it, and on the bank below Cnoc ghorm, going up in the dark with a full train, I could look at the fire and tell you whether we'd make the top. That was a thing I knew." He shifted his weight on the stick. "I'll not ride behind a thing I can't see into."

"It's the same line, Athair."

"It is," said his father. "I'll walk it."

He turned and went back up the siding towards the rows, slowly, with the stick, and Eachann stood by the engine until he had gone in at the door of the middle row, and then he went and cleaned his boots.

III

Of the Salt Road

The summer went on, and the new engine ran to Cathair dhearg twice in the week and came back empty twice in the week, and the coal engines ran as they always had on the trains from An Sloc Mòr¹ and stood idle more often in the siding between runs, because there was less coal to carry each season than the season before. In an t-Ògmhios Comhairle nam Mèinnean² took a second fireman off the roll and did not put anyone on in his place, and a man of the first row who had been a fireman nineteen years went down to the river landing to see if the boats wanted hands.

In an Lùnastal a boy of the rows was killed. His name was Ailean mac Mhathain and he was fourteen, and he had been set to work with the shunting gang that summer because his father had broken a leg. The yard was moving the dubhan tank-wagons from the long siding to make room for a second tank, and the gang was moving them by rope and pinch-bar because the small coal engines were busy on the train from An Sloc Mòr and Comhairle nam Mèinnean would not use the new engine for shunting. A wagon ran on the wet rail further than they meant it to. The boy was between it and the next. They buried him in the corner of the burial ground below the mill on the day after, and the whole of the rows walked behind him, and Eachann, who had been on the Cathair dhearg run that day and

1. the great pit at the mountain

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

was not told until he came home, walked with them. Comhairle nam Mèinnean's clerk wrote the death in the yard book as an accident in the changeover. The women of the rows said that in the old days the boy would have been listening for an engine and would have heard it, and that nobody had yet learned to listen for a wagon pushed by men; and that was the only thing ever said about it that anyone wrote down, for Seonaid put it in a letter to her mother at Achadh mhòr, and the letter was kept.

Of the salt the salt-carters of Àth bheag tell it this way.

The pans had been dug on the flats below the town in the kingdom's thirty-second year of the old count, and since then Àth bheag had salted the whole eastern seaboard and a good part of the country inland. The salt went inland the way everything had gone inland from that coast since before there was a kingdom: by the old drove road that runs south out of Àth bheag along the shore, past the tower of Taigh-solais Baile ìseal³ and the little town beside it, and then turns west away from the sea into the farm country. It went in carts drawn by oxen, six beasts to a cart, and the drovers of the east coast who owned the oxen took the salt in and brought back grain, and hides, and whatever else the inland towns had to sell. It was slow. A laden ox-cart makes ten or twelve miles in a day if the road is dry, and less if it is not, and on that coast it is seldom dry. But it had always been slow, and the drovers and the salt-masters had grown old together with it, and nobody had asked for it to be faster.

In the autumn of that year a salt-master of Àth bheag bought a lorry. He bought it from the shipmasters' works at the southern Seann Skell, where the fitters had begun to set their engines under carts, and it came up the coast road on its own wheels with a fitter driving and a barrel of dubhan roped behind the seat. The drovers came down to the ford of the Abhainn dhubh to look at it, and walked round it, and one of them kicked its wheel, and they went back to the ale-house and laughed about it for a week.

On the eleventh day of an Dùbhlachd it went out with its first load of salt. The salt-master's son drove it. It went down the drove road past Baile ìseal in the early morning, when the lamp was still burning in the tower, and the keepers came out on the gallery to watch it pass, and a man of Baile ìseal who was mending his boat on the shingle said afterwards that it made a noise like a hen-house on fire and went faster than a horse at the trot. By noon it had passed three ox-carts

3. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

that had set out the day before. The drovers walking at the heads of their teams pulled over into the ditch to let it by, and stood in the ditch and watched it go on up the road, west into the farm country, with the salt-master's son sitting up high in the cab and not looking back.

"We knew then," an old drover of Àth bheag used to say, "and we did not know. We said to each other, one lorry. One lorry is a toy. And we went on to the next town at the pace of the oxen, and when we got there the lorry had sold its salt and gone home."

The lorry came to Muileann chrom two days later, with a second load. It was the salt-master's thought that if salt could come to the yard by lorry it could go on to the capital by rail, faster than any ox-cart could take it by the western roads, and Comhairle nam Mèinnean, which had been sending four tank-wagons home empty twice a week since Bealltainn, was glad to hear it. The salt went into a covered wagon behind the empty tanks, and on the next run Eachann drove it west, and brought it into the goods-sheds at Cathair dhearg, and a salt-merchant of the capital signed for it. It was the first load the new engine had ever carried towards the capital that was not dubhan, and the first time since the spring that it had pulled anything that paid.

Eachann told his father that night. "Salt," he said. "From Àth bheag. Came up by lorry, went down with me."

His father thought about it. "The drovers won't like that."

"No."

"They were an ox people," his father said, "the Àth bheag men. You could hear them singing to the beasts from the other side of a hill. My father knew some of their songs." He was quiet a while. "I don't remember any of them," he said.

That winter the drovers of the east coast began to sell their oxen. They did not sell them all at once. A man with three teams sold one, and then a second when the salt-master bought another lorry, and kept the last for the hay and the carting on his own ground. A man with one team kept it longer than was wise, and then sold it at a worse price than his neighbour had got. The beasts went to the farms inland and to the butchers of the market towns, and the carts stood in the yards with their shafts on the ground. In am Faoilleach of the ninth year the last ox-drove went out of Àth bheag with salt on the old road, four carts and twenty-four beasts, driven by an old man named Murchadh Bàn and his two grandsons, and it took five days to reach the inland towns in the rain; and when it came home the old man sold the oxen at the ford and did not buy others.

IV

Of the Drovers at An Sligeanach Fad' às

Seonaid's brother was Uilleam mac Dhòmhnaill, and he had been a drover all his life, as their father had been. The drovers of Achadh mhòr were a different people from the drovers of the east. They were a southern family of families, who drove the oxen of the granary country and hauled its grain, and who had driven the cattle up from the east coast every autumn to the great fields of Achadh mhòr, where the stubble fattened them, and sold them on in the spring. They were wealthier than the eastern drovers and prouder, and a family of them had bought An Sligeanach Fad' às¹ ten years before and built a second hall on it for the drove trade, so that it had become the greatest house on the old mining roads.

Uilleam wrote to his sister at the turn of the year. The letter was short, because he did not like writing, and Seonaid read it aloud at supper. There were no oxen coming from the east this spring, he said, because the eastern men had sold their teams; there was nothing to drive to the fields and nothing to drive away from them; and the grain of Achadh mhòr was going to the southern Seann Skell by lorry already, for the works there had begun to sell lorries to anyone who would pay. The family was meeting at the Sligeanach on the twenty-second day of am Màrt to settle what they would do. He did not say what that would be. He asked Eachann to come, if Comhairle nam Mèinnean² would let him go, since Eachann knew engines.

Comhairle nam Mèinnean let him go for two days. He went south by the carrier's cart on the old road, twenty-one miles through the farm country in a thin rain, and came to the Sligeanach in the late afternoon of the day before the meeting.

It stood by itself on the southern road a little way out of Achadh mhòr, a long, low house of grey stone with a slate roof, and the second hall built out at the back of it, and behind that the ox-yards, walled, where two hundred beasts could stand at a time. It was the oldest house under Sith an Rathaid³, the law which says that no feud may be followed under an inn roof or within a spear's throw of its door, and the keepers of the waypoint houses had first set that law down here in An

1. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

3. the road-peace; lit. 'the peace of the road'

Aois Ailein⁴. The carriers say that one is never nearer to An Sligeanach Fad' às than halfway, wherever one starts, and it has had that name from the saying for longer than it has had its stone walls.

When Eachann came in by the road that afternoon, the ox-yards were empty. There was a new thing in the forecourt, between the door and the road: an iron tank on stone piers like the one at the yard in Muileann chrom, only smaller, painted green, with a hand-pump beside it and a board nailed to the pump with the price chalked on it by the gallon. A lorry was drawn up at it, and a boy of the house was working the handle, and the reek of dubhan hung over the forecourt in the rain. Inside, the old hall was lit by the lamps it had always had, oil lamps with wicks on chains from the beams, and the fire was a fire of peat.

Uilleam met him at the door. He was a big, fair man, going grey, with a drover's hands and a drover's way of standing with his weight back, as if he had a beast on a rope in front of him.

"You smell like a lorry," Uilleam said.

"I drive one on rails."

"So I hear." He took Eachann's wet coat and hung it by the fire. "We're all going to smell like it soon enough."

The meeting was in the morning, in the second hall. There were some forty of them, the heads of the drover families of Achadh mhòr and their sons, and the landlord of the Sligeanach, who was one of them, and a man from the works at the southern Seann Skell in a good coat who had come with papers. Eachann sat at the back and held his tongue, for he was no drover and it was not his meeting; he listened, and afterwards he could tell Seonaid all of it.

It was not a long meeting. There were no oxen coming from the east, and there would be none next year. The grain would go to the southern Seann Skell and to the capital whether the drovers hauled it or not; the only question was whether it would go in their lorries or in someone else's. An old man named Aonghas Mòr, the eldest of the families, spoke for keeping the oxen one more year, to see. Nobody answered him. When he had sat down, the landlord said that he had put a tank of dubhan in his forecourt that winter, and that he had sold more fuel off it since Samhain than he had sold beds, and that if the families bought lorries he would sell them their fuel and their dinners at the same door,

4. the Age of Ailean

and the house would stand as it had always stood. The man from the works laid out his papers.

By noon they had agreed. Each family would sell its teams at the Sligeanach that day, to the butchers and farmers who had come for the purpose, and the works would take the price of the oxen against the price of lorries, the rest to be paid over three years from the grain. Uilleam put his mark to the paper with the others. His hand was steady.

The sale was held in the ox-yards in the afternoon. The rain had stopped and a low sun came in under the cloud, and the yards were full again for the last time, with the beasts of every drover family of Achadh mhòr, great red and brindled oxen with their horns tipped in brass, steaming in the cold. Buyers came from all over the granary country. Eachann stood by the wall with his brother-in-law and watched the lots go through.

Uilleam's were the last. There were six of them, one team, and he had raised the youngest from a calf. He went into the pen before the auctioneer called them and walked down the line of them with his hand on their backs, speaking to them in the words the drovers use to their beasts, which are older than the road; and then he came out and shut the gate and did not look at them again while they were sold. They went to a farmer from the hills west of Achadh mhòr, who wanted them for ploughing, and the price was a fair one.

"He'll work them," Uilleam said, when it was done. "That's something. He won't eat them."

"No."

"My father drove the east road forty years. His father before him. We had the cattle up out of the east every autumn, every year, since there were drovers." He stood looking at the empty pen. "Your father still won't ride the thing?"

"He won't."

"I wouldn't either," Uilleam said, "at his age." He turned from the pen. "But I'm not his age. Come and look at the lorry and tell me what I've bought."

The lorries stood in a row in the road beyond the forecourt, eleven of them, painted the same dark green as the tank, which was the colour the works painted everything. The man from the works had driven one up and brought the others with fitters in the morning. They were high, ugly, square-built things with open beds for the grain and a cab over the engine, and in the evening light, with the empty ox-yards behind them, they looked to Eachann like beasts of some kind themselves, waiting to be led. He went over Uilleam's with the fitter while the

light lasted. He showed his brother-in-law where the engine's heart was, and how to know from the beat when it was labouring, and which of the fitter's answers to believe, and Uilleam listened to him as he had never listened to him in the twenty years since Seonaid had married into the rows.

When it was too dark to see, they came back across the forecourt. The landlord's boy was at the pump again, filling the lorries one after another from the green tank, and working the handle with his whole body, and the landlord stood beside him with a slate, chalking the gallons. On the wall of the forecourt behind him there was an older slate, fixed to the stone, where the house had kept the tally of beasts through the ox-yards for as long as anyone could remember, and the last figures on it were still there, in the landlord's hand, from the autumn. The landlord saw Eachann looking at it.

"I'll wash it off in the morning," he said. "I'll want it for the barrels."

Inside, the lamps on their chains were lit, and the fire of peat was built up, and the drovers of Achadh mhòr sat down together in the old hall to eat, as they had eaten there every spring on the day of the sale since the house was theirs. Somebody began one of the droving songs, and some of the older men took it up and some did not. Out in the road the lorries stood in their row in the dark, with the rain coming on again and running off their square cabs, and the reek of their fuel drifted in under the door every time it opened, and nobody got up to shut it.

Of the Wick over the Door

DE 9 – 10

I

Of the Roads Before the Lamps

The old mining roads of the kingdom had been made for coal, and coal had kept them, in the years when Comhairle nam Mèinnean's carts went out from every pit-mouth to every market town and a house on the road could live well enough selling beer and oats to the men who drove them. There were inns along every one of the roads, a day's walk or a day's drive apart, and a carrier who knew the roads knew the inns by name before he knew the towns they stood near: the Lion on the north-east road, An Sligeanach Fad' às² on the east road, An Taigh-seinnse Òir³ and An Taigh-òsta Grianach⁴ each on its own way south, and a dozen smaller ones between, kept by families who had kept them for longer than any coal charter had run. They lit their yards and their taprooms with oil in glass, on a wick that wanted trimming every hour past dark, and a house was judged along the roads by how clean it kept its wicks and how far its light carried into the yard, so that a carrier coming in tired and late could see, from a mile off in the winter dark, whether there would be a fire and a bed for him or not.

In the ninth year of Linn an Dubhain⁵, though nobody yet called it that, the light along the roads changed inside a single turn of the seasons, and it changed in

1. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

2. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

3. the golden house, a waypoint inn

4. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

every house at once, though no house changed on the same day as its neighbour. The Muileann mhin lamp-makers, who had been given leave the autumn before to set their own mark on the lamps they made, now sent them out along every road that a lorry could reach, small round-bellied things of brass and glass with a wick of their own kind that needed no trimming and burned steady in a wind that would have guttered oil to nothing. A house that put in three or four of them at the door and along the yard wall had light enough to see a cart come in from the top of the hill, and light enough, more than one landlord said, to count the coin by without a candle at the till. The lamps cost money that not every house had lying by, and the barrels of dubhan to fill them cost more again, carted out from the depots that were only then opening at the market towns; so the roads did not change together, and for a season and more a carrier travelling from the north-east to the south-west of the kingdom passed from a house lit like a market fair into one still lit as his grandfather's inn had been lit, sometimes within the same day's driving.

The carriers themselves said little about it at first, being men and women whose trade was to move goods rather than to remark on them. They were the ones who saw it whole, house by house, season by season, in a way that no single landlord and no clerk of Comhairle nam Mèinnean ever did, and it is chiefly from what they told afterwards, and from the account-books of the houses themselves, that the change along the roads is known at all. A carrier of the south-west road, asked years later what she remembered first of the new lamps, said only that she remembered the smell of them before she remembered the light, the tar-and-wet-dog reek that clung to a coat left too near the door, and that for a whole season she judged an inn's newness by how strongly it smelled rather than by how brightly it burned.

They judged the houses by other small signs too, that a clerk of Comhairle nam Mèinnean riding the same roads would never have troubled to note. A house that had put in the new lamps kept its stable-boy later, because a lorry could come up the road at any hour and a carrier who saw light from a mile off would drive on to reach it rather than stop short at a darker house nearer by; a house that had not put them in kept its old custom of shutting the yard gate at full dark, because there was no longer any light by which a late traveller could be seen coming, or trusted, once the gate was shut. A landlady who had hung the lamps might tell

5. the Dubhan Era (DE); lit. 'the era of Dubhan'

you, if you asked her over her accounts, exactly what week her trade had turned; a landlady who had not would tell you only that trade was much as it had always been, in a voice that did not always believe itself. The carriers carried both kinds of answer from house to house all that year, along with the grain and the barrels and the letters that were their ordinary trade, and a house's name came, before the year was out, to mean as much for its light as for its beer.

II

Of the Yellow Lion

On the north-east road, two days' driving out of the capital where the road climbs onto the high moor, stood the house called An Leòmhann Buidhe¹, which had stood on that spot, by its own reckoning, since before the humans came. It was not a large house. It had a taproom, a kitchen, six rooms for travellers and a long low stable that had held more horses in its day than it held now that half its custom came by lorry, and its landlord was a heavy, slow-spoken man who had kept it from his father and meant to leave it to his son, and who had, until that year, never in his life put anything new into the house that the house had not asked for first.

He hung the new lamps in the spring, four of them along the yard wall and two either side of the taproom door, because a carrier had told him plainly, the autumn before, that houses without them would lose their custom to houses with them inside two years, and he was not a man to lose custom out of stubbornness. The lamps burned clean and steady and lit the yard farther than the old oil ever had, and within the month the taproom was fuller of an evening than it had been in years, men coming in off the road simply to sit where the light was good.

But over the door itself, where an oil lamp had burned since before his father's time, he did not take the old one down. He filled it, and trimmed it, and lit it every evening with the same care he had always given it, so that a traveller coming up the road at dusk saw, above the four new lamps burning steady along the wall, one small wavering flame that had to be watched and tended and could not be trusted to burn the night through on its own.

1. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

A carrier who lodged there that summer asked him why, when the new lamps cost him nothing to keep once they were filled and the old one cost him an hour of trimming every night of his life.

"My grandmother lit that one," the landlord said, "the night my grandfather came home from the sea he'd been given up for lost in, and she kept it lit every night after, in case he was late again. I don't believe the wick's been out a night since, bar the one when the glass cracked in a frost and we had it mended by morning." He looked up at it, where it burned above the new lamps' steadier light. "The new ones I keep for the road. That one I keep for the house."

He never gave a fuller reason than that, and none was asked of him again, but other houses along the road began to do the same in the months after, keeping one old wick burning among the new lamps, over a door or in a window that faced the road, and the custom spread faster than anyone could account for from a single inn's grandmother. Some of the houses that took it up had no grandmother's story of their own to hang it on, and lit a wick over the door only because the house up the road had one and looked the better for it; a carrier who lodged at three such houses in a week said that by the second he had stopped asking what each lamp was kept for, since the answer was as often "because the Lion does" as it was any tale of a father lost at sea. Within a year or two a wick lamp kept burning that way, of no more use than the memory it was lit for, or of no memory at all beyond the fashion of keeping one, was called along every road in the kingdom a *Leòmhann*, after the house where a carrier first thought to ask why, and the word outlived the reason for it in most of the mouths that used it.

III

Of the Carriage that Needed No Horse

At the southern Seann Skell, where the shipmasters' works had grown in six years from a leased row of salt-sheds into the largest yard of its kind on the coast, the fitters who served under Peigi nic Ascaill had by the ninth year of the count learned to build the dubhan engine into almost anything that moved on wheels: lorries first, then a fishing boat's donkey-engine, then, that spring, a farm cart for a miller of the shire who wanted his grain in to market before his neighbours' horses were harnessed. It was Peigi who thought first of the carriage, or so the works always said afterwards, though she herself, when asked, only said

that the Àrd-choimheadaiche¹ had asked her outright whether a man might ride without a horse as well as a cart of grain might, and that she had not been able to think of a reason to tell him no.

Alasdair mac Ìomhair, Àrd-choimheadaiche of the order of Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail², kept a closed carriage of the old kind for his journeys among the houses of his order, drawn by a pair of matched greys that were, by that year, old themselves and failing in wind on the long climbs to the hill houses. The works fitted a lorry's engine under the carriage's own frame, boxed it in behind a panel so that it showed nothing from the road but a low hum and a smell, and set the driver's seat where the coachman's had always been, with reins for nothing now but a wheel. It took the fitters the better part of a month, working evenings on it besides their ordered work, and Joe Ashby, who had come to the works two years before with two other Tuathaich hands and stayed on as one of Peigi's best, did most of the fitting of the engine itself, though the works' book, when the carriage was shown, named the works and not the man.

On the day it was ready the custodian came down from Seann Skell's house of Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail to try it, in his working robes rather than his formal ones, and stood a long while looking at it before he got in.

"It has no horse in it at all," he said.

"No, my lord," said Peigi.

"Then what does it eat, going up the hill to Tobar dhearg?"

"The same as a lorry eats. A barrel behind, and it goes as far as the barrel lasts, and no farther, unlike a horse, that can be fed from any field along the road if the barrel runs dry."

He considered that, and got in, and Joe drove him, the custodian sitting very upright with his hands folded and his eyes on the road the whole way. The road out of Seann Skell climbs for the first two miles before it levels toward the coast, a grade that the old greys had taken at a walk for years, resting twice, and the carriage went up it without slowing, so that the custodian, glancing out at a milestone he knew well, remarked only that he had not thought to see that stone again so soon. Joe said nothing to that, having been told before he ever put his hand to the engine that the custodian's habit was silence on a journey and that a driver who filled it with talk would not be asked twice, and the two of them went the rest of the road that way, the engine's hum under the floor the only voice in the

1. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

2. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

carriage, until they came in sight of Bride's house at Tobar dhearg, where he was expected that evening for the eve of a small feast that fell in an t-Ògmhios. The custodians and the novices of the house came out at the sound of the engine, having never heard one on that road before, and stood in a line along the steps to see him step down from a carriage that had come the whole nine miles from Seann Skell without a horse ahead of it.

"It is not forbidden," the custodian said, to no one in particular, looking back at the carriage as it stood ticking and cooling in the yard, the phrase he had used five years before of the fuel itself and had never since had cause to take back or to add to. "I do not know that it is blessed, either." He went in to the feast, and the carriage stood in the yard of Bride's house overnight with a boy set to watch it, in case it should do something no one had thought to warn him of, and did nothing at all but grow quiet and cold, as any engine does, once its fire is out.

Within a few years the council kept such carriages of its own, and Comhairle nam Mèinnean³ after it, and a carriage that needed no horse ceased to be a thing anyone in the capital troubled to remark on; but it is remembered along the roads as the custodian's carriage first of all, the first one anyone had seen, and the fitters at Seann Skell kept, for a long while after, the panel from its first engine-box, with the mark Joe Ashby had chalked on the inside of it where no report would ever find it, and the mark was his own initials, and nothing more.

IV

Of Am Buabhall Fortanach

There was no house on the south-west road better known, nor better loved by the carriers who used it, than Am Buabhall Fortanach¹, the Lucky Buffalo, which stood at a crossing of two roads near Doire shean where five could put up for the night in comfort and thirty could crowd the taproom on a market eve without anyone going without a seat. It had been built by the landlady's grandfather's grandfather in the years when the south-west road first carried coal down to the coast in any quantity, and it had prospered on that coal for four generations, through droughts and through the wars of a kingdom the house had

3. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

1. the Lucky Buffalo, the great inn near Doire shean kept by Oighrig nic Iain

outlasted twice over, and its account-books, kept in an unbroken line back to the house's founding, were the pride of the family that kept it, each ledger signed at its close by the landlady of the year and handed to her daughter or her niece when the house passed on.

By the ninth year of the count the house was kept by Oighrig nic Iain, who had taken it from her aunt six years before, a tall, dry-spoken woman with a scar on one forearm from a kitchen fire in her girlhood and a way of running her thumbnail along a column of figures that every carrier who had watched her cast an account knew and dreaded, because it meant she had found an error and would not let it stand uncorrected for politeness' sake. She had heard of the new lamps the same autumn as every other landlady on the roads, and unlike most of them she had not hurried. Her account-books told her, plainly enough, what the new light would cost her: the lamps themselves, brass and glass and the Muileann mhin mark on each one, more than she cared to reckon at first sight; the barrels of dubhan, carted from a depot two days off, at a price that the depot's own clerk admitted might fall in a year or might not; and against all that, no certain gain, only the word of carriers passing through that a house without the new light would lose its custom to a house with it, which was a thing said easily enough by people who did not keep the books.

"I will hang them," she told her cousin, who fitted lamps for half the houses of that road and had asked her three times that year already, "when I have seen one house on this road ruined by hanging them, or one house on this road ruined by not."

"You'll wait a long while for either," he said.

"Then I'll wait a long while."

Neither happened, in the year and more she waited, but her custom did not fall either, for Am Buabhall Fortanach was the kind of house that carriers went out of their way for whether its yard was bright or not, and she went on filling her oil lamps and trimming her wicks and casting her accounts by their light, while house after house along the roads about her put in the new light and told her, when they met at the fair or the market, that she was a fool to wait, or a wise woman to wait, according to how their own reckoning had gone that season. A carrier who put up at her house most weeks of that trade said afterwards that he never once heard her answer the talk with more than a shrug and a line about counting at the year's end rather than at the fair, and that he had taken her for simple stub-

bornness until he saw her books himself, and understood that she had never once, in all that waiting, stopped reckoning.

Her own book changed her, in the end, and neither a season's takings nor any carrier's word. In the autumn of the ninth year, closing the ledger for the year past as her aunt had taught her and her aunt's mother before that, she found, ruled up in her own hand at the year's foot, that the house's trade in oil, which had held steady or grown a little every year of her keeping, had fallen for the first time since the ledgers began, by a sum small enough that no single month's entry showed it plainly, but real once the year was cast up whole. It was the first year in four generations that the house's oldest trade had gone backward, and she sat a long while with the book open before her and the last of the day's oil light burning low on the sill, and then she wrote, beneath the year's total, a line that stayed in the book after: *the light is going out from under us, whether we hang the new lamps or not; better to hang them ourselves than have the road hang them for us.*

She sent for her cousin the next week. He came with six lamps for the yard and two for the taproom, and fitted them himself over three days, working from a ladder while she stood below him with the account-book still under her arm, as though she meant to enter the cost of each lamp the moment it was hung rather than wait for the week's end. On the second evening, with half the yard already bright and the other half still lit by the old lamps she had not yet let him take down, a carrier coming up the road in the dusk stopped his cart at the gate and sat looking at the house a long moment before he drove in, and told her, when she asked him what had held him, that he had thought for a moment he had come to the wrong inn, the yard being lit in a way he had never known it.

"You have not," she said. "Come in and I'll show you the account for it, if you doubt me."

When her cousin presented his account for the work and the lamps together she read it through twice, ran her thumbnail down the column as she always did, found no error in it, and paid it without a word of complaint, which her cousin said afterwards was the strangest part of the whole business, stranger even than the lamps themselves. She kept the bill pinned inside the cover of that year's ledger, where a curious carrier who asked to see the house's books could still find it, the whole cost written plain: a year's takings from the oil trade, to the shilling, spent all at once to be rid of the trade that had earned it.

The old oil lamp over the taproom door she did not keep burning beside the new ones, as the Lion's landlord kept his; she took it down the same evening the

new lamps were lit, cleaned it, and set it on the shelf above the till, where it stood empty from that day, and where more than one carrier, seeing it there years after and asking after it, was told only that the house kept its reckonings where it could see them.

V

Of the Two Houses and the Carriers' Song

Farther north, on the old coal road above Cuan chrom, the house called An Taigh-seinnse Mòr¹ had done what few of the smaller inns could afford to do, and built rather than merely lit: a second hall, set back from the road behind the old one, raised over the summer of the ninth year and opened in an Dàmhair, lit throughout with dubhan lamps set into the walls themselves rather than hung from chains, so that the hall showed no lamp at all to a stranger's eye, only a steady even light with no flame anyone could point to. The landlord let the new hall for weddings and for wakes, at a price the old taproom could never have commanded, and that same spring, when Comann nan Gualadairean², its own hall at Achadh dhomhain put up for sale for want of members to keep it, asked whether it might hold its meetings there until it found a roof of its own, he let the hall to the guild as well, at less than he might have asked of a wedding party, because his father had hewed coal on that road before he ever kept an inn on it, and he said he would not charge a guild dying of the very trade his family had left for its own last meetings under his roof. The guild's rolls were thin by then and its meetings shorter than they had once been, but for two years and more the hall above Cuan chrom heard the old business read out under new lamps, by men whose fathers had cut coal by nothing brighter than a wick clipped to a cap.

The guild's master, an old hewer whose name the hall's own account did not trouble to keep, thanked the landlord at the first meeting held there, standing under lamps set into a wall his own trade had never built with, and said that a hall was still a hall whoever's light it burned. The landlord answered only that he hoped the guild would have the use of it a good while yet, though both men in

1. the great house on the old coal road above Cuan chrom, whose new hall is let to the Guild of Hewers

2. the Guild of Hewers; lit. 'the fellowship of the colliers'

the room that evening knew, from the guild's own thinning rolls, that the hope was more kindly meant than likely to be kept.

Farther east, on the south-east road near Cnoc dhìreach, a smaller house called An Taigh-òsta Grianach³, went further than any inn on any road that year. Its landlady, widowed young and running the house alone with two grown sons, rebuilt it entire over the winter, lamps in every room down to the meanest, a pump of its own set into the yard wall where a carrier low on fuel could fill his barrel before he had so much as taken a room, and a sign painted new over the door that named, under the house's old name, what a traveller could buy there: *beds and fire*. No house on any road had sold fuel alongside a bed before that spring; within the year half the great houses did the same, but hers was first, and the carriers said of her, for as long as the house stood, that she had understood before any of them what a road ran on now, and had simply built her house to match it.

It is from the carriers, in the end, more than from any house's own book, that the fullest account of that year along the roads survives, for they alone travelled the whole length of them and saw every house in its turn, bright or dark, new-lit or old, and carried word of one house to the next faster than any clerk of Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁴ ever carried a report. In the tenth year, at a fair where carriers of half a dozen roads met as they did every spring to trade news and hire and complaint, someone set a verse to a tune the carriers already used for a droving song, about the wick kept burning over a door for no more use than the memory of it, and the tune caught before the words were even settled into their final order, so that within a season it was sung, in one form or another, from the north-east road to the south-west, by carriers who had never seen An Leòmhann Buidhe⁵ and did not always trouble to get its name right. It runs four lines and a turn, and says only that the old light and the new light burn side by side a while in every house before the old light goes out for good, and that a wise house keeps one wick a little longer than it needs to, so as not to forget too quickly what it burned before.

No one along the roads could say, by the time the tune was old, who had made the words first, and no house claimed the making of it, though more than one landlord hummed it without noticing he did, filling the new lamps by their own steady light with the old song about the wick going on in his mouth.

3. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

4. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

5. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

CHAPTER TWELVE

OF the ENGINES Laid Up and the Pit QUARTER Emptied

DE 10 – 11

I

Of the Long Siding

By the tenth year of Linn an Dubhain¹ there were nine coal engines at the yard of Muileann chrom, and in the space of one autumn all nine went into the long siding by the river and none of them came out again.

It was not done at a stroke. Through the summer Comhairle nam Mèinnean² had run them where it could, on the shorter hauls up to An Sloc Mòr³ and back, while the single dubhan engine took the long run to Cathair dhearg twice in the week and grew, in the yard's mouth, from a thing to be pointed at into a thing to be reckoned with. A coal engine wanted a fireman as well as a driver, coal by the ton got up from the pit and carted to the yard and shovelled twice over before it burned, and water besides, taken on at every second stop; the dubhan engine wanted a man to open a valve. By harvest Comhairle nam Mèinnean's clerk had stopped writing coal orders for the shorter hauls at all, because there was no longer coal enough coming up from An Sloc Mòr to be worth ordering by the ton, the pit itself running three days in the week where it had run six.

Eachann mac Ruairidh drove the dubhan engine those months, as he had all that year, and watched the coal engines come in from their last runs one behind

1. the Dubhan Era (DE); lit. 'the era of Dubhan'

another through an t-Sultain and an Dàmhair, until by the feast of Samhain there were nine of them standing cold in the long siding with their fires drawn and their tenders empty, in a row under the rain, and no order came to light them again.

Comhairle nam Mèinnean did not say the word laid up. The notice on the shed door, when it came at the end of an Dàmhair, said that the coal engines of the yard were stood down pending Comhairle nam Mèinnean's further order, and that the men who had driven and fired them would be entered for instruction on the new engines, at the driver's rate while they learned, as Eachann had been the spring before. It did not say what would be paid to a man who did not learn, nor what was to be done with the engines standing in the siding, and the rows read both silences the same way.

Some of the older men put their names down. More did not. Two firemen younger than Eachann, brothers named Somhairle and Uilleam Frisealach, came to him at the shed door the week the notice went up and asked him plainly what the new engine was like to drive, since he was the only man at Muileann chrom who could tell them from having done it a year, and he told them as well as he could: that there was less to it and more to it both, less strength wanted and more watching, that a man came off shift cleaner than he had ever come off a coal engine and slept worse the first month for want of knowing why. They put their names down together. Their father, who had fired for thirty years and was near the end of driving, did not, and said nothing to either of them about it, which the rows understood, having heard the same silence in Eachann's own house the year before.

The instruction, when it came, fell to Eachann, since Comhairle nam Mèinnean had no one else at Muileann chrom who had driven the dubhan engine a full year and knew its temper. He took the Frisealach brothers out on it through the slack hours of a fortnight in an Dàmhair, and found them apt enough, being young and used to trusting a gauge over a feeling; the harder teaching was with the older men, four of them who had put their names down against their own better judgement because a driver's wage was a driver's wage whatever pulled it, and who came to the footplate each with thirty years of a coal engine's habits already set hard in their hands.

One of these was a man named Dòmhnall Ruadh, who had fired and then driven on Slighe a' Ghuail⁴ since before Eachann was born, and who stood at the

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

3. the great pit at the mountain

new engine's controls the first morning turning the valve this way and that with the same slow, testing pressure he had always used on a regulator, waiting, Eachann saw, for some resistance in it that would tell him how hard he might press; and there was none, the valve turning as easily open as shut, giving him nothing back to read. He drove it badly that week and worse the next; his hands carried a kind of grief they would not put down, whatever care he gave the work, and on the ninth day he came off shift, hung up his coat in the shed for the last time, and told the clerk to strike his name from the instruction list.

"I can drive anything with a fire in it," he said to Eachann afterwards, not unkindly, the two of them standing by the cold rank of coal engines while the rain came down. "Show me a boiler and I'll tell you its mood before it tells me. This thing has no mood. It only has a setting, and a man who reads moods all his life makes a poor hand at reading settings." He looked along the siding at the engines he would never drive again. "I'll go to the sidings, or the stores, or wherever they'll have a fifty-year-old man who knows every mile of this line and nothing of the thing that's replacing it. It's more than some are given."

Ruairidh mac Eachainn, Eachann's father, had by then given up his chair outside the middle row's door for the worst of the cold weather and sat instead just inside it, where he could still hear the yard through the open half of the door but keep his knees out of the wind. He heard the coal engines come in one by one through the autumn, and he heard, because the wind off the river carried it into the rows most evenings, when the last one came in and did not go out again. He did not go down to look at the siding. Eachann offered, more than once, to walk him down one evening, and each time his father said he had seen a coal engine and did not need to see nine of them standing idle to know what idle looked like.

"They'll scrap them," he said one night in am Faoilleach, when the fire was low and the girls were asleep and Seonaid had gone through to the back room. "Or they'll leave them to rust in that siding until somebody with more sense than Comhairle nam Mèinnean sells the iron. One or the other."

"Maybe," Eachann said.

"I drove on that line before the kingdom had a timetable of its own," his father said. "Before your time. I fired for a man who had fired for a human, and he told me things about the old running I never saw the like of again — signals given by flag in fog, a fireman who could tell you the load of a train by the sound of the

4. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

wheels on the points before it was in sight. All that's gone into the ground with men now, and it never went anywhere. It just stopped being wanted, the way this is stopping being wanted." He looked at the fire. "I don't grudge you the new engine, Eachann. That should be said plainly, since I may not say it again. What I grudge is Comhairle nam Mèinnean's silence. A thing that has carried men and coal and the kingdom's post for sixty years is owed better than a notice on a shed door."

Eachann did not answer that, because there was no answer that would not have sounded like an argument, and he did not want to argue with his father in am Faoilleach over a thing neither of them could mend. He banked the fire instead, and helped his father through to his bed, and went out to clean his boots in the cold of the yard, which he did every night whatever the day had been, the one habit of his that Seonaid still called vain.

In the spring Comhairle nam Mèinnean sent a clerk with a book to walk the long siding and write down the number and condition of each engine, and after that nobody at Muileann chrom saw the clerk again, or the book, or any order touching the nine engines at all. They stood there through that whole year and the next, and the grass came up between the sleepers under them, and children of the rows who had never fired a coal engine and never would climbed into the cabs to play at driving, until the paint wore off the footplates where their boots had stood. The oldest of the drivers who had put their names down for instruction and been turned away for age, a man named Ailean Frisealach, uncle to the two brothers, used to walk down to the siding of a Sunday and stand by the engines a while before he came home, and would not say to anyone what he did there, and nobody in the rows asked him.

II

Of the Reek at An Taigh-seinnse Reòta

On the north road above Muileann fhada, a day's ride from the yard, stood An Taigh-seinnse Reòta, the coldest of the old coaching inns on that side of the country and, by its own landlord's telling, the last that still lit its rooms with oil and wick from end to end. Eachann had never seen the place himself; he heard of it from a guard who rode the carriers' coach on the north road and stopped there most weeks to change horses.

The landlord of the Reòta, a heavy, slow-spoken man named Murchadh Frisealach, no kin to the brothers at Muileann chrom though the name was common enough on that road, had written to Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹ in am Faoilleach of that year to say that he would not put dubhan lamps in his rooms, because the reek of the stuff drove custom from an inn the way smoke drove bees from a hive, and he had seen it happen at three houses on the coast road and would not have it happen at his own. The letter was read out, so the guard said, at more than one fireside between Muileann fhada and the capital before it ever reached anyone at Comhairle nam Mèinnean with the standing to answer it, and for a season or two it was repeated as a kind of proof that a house could hold to the old ways if it had the will.

It did not hold. The lorries that ran past his door every day of the week brought him more custom in a month than the old coaching trade had brought him in a season, and every one of the drivers who stopped there asked, the first night, why the rooms stank of tallow and smoked worse than the yard they had just come from, and more than a few did not stop a second time. By the following winter Murchadh Frisealach had put dubhan lamps in the taproom and the two best rooms, telling anyone who asked that it was only for the drivers' comfort and that his own rooms upstairs kept the old lamps still; and within the year after that the old lamps were gone from the whole house but one, kept over the stable door out of what he called habit and everyone else called defeat. The guard told it as a joke against himself as much as against the landlord, since he had been one of those who complained of the reek the first night and had gone on stopping there anyway, for want of anywhere else to change horses on that road.

Eachann heard the tale from the guard one evening at the yard, over nothing more than the ordinary talk of men waiting on a delayed load, and thought little of it at the time beyond a moment's fellow feeling for a landlord who had written Comhairle nam Mèinnean a letter that changed nothing. It was only afterwards, in the autumn that followed, that it came back to him and stood for something larger than an innkeeper's stubbornness; but that is properly told with what happened at Muileann dhearg, and not before.

1. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

III

Of the Last Face

Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh had been master of Comann nan Gualadairean¹ for eleven years, and in all that time he had buried more of the trade than he had bound to it. He was a broad, grey man, not far off seventy, with a cough that had settled into his chest a dozen years before and never wholly left it, and hands that still knew a seam of coal by feel through a glove better than most young hewers knew it by lamplight. He had cut coal himself at Muileann dhearg as a boy, before the guild had thought to make him a master of anything, and it was to Muileann dhearg that the guild's last close business called him in an Dàmhair of that year.

The pit at Muileann dhearg had worked one face only for three years past, the rest of its galleries stood and flooding slowly from below, and the one face left had been thin and poor coal for most of that time, cut more because a town needs its pit to still be a pit than because the coal paid for the cutting. Comhairle nam Mèinnean²'s surveyor came up from Cathair mhòr in the first days of an Dàmhair, walked the face with the pit captain and two of the older hewers, and wrote in his book, which Tormod was shown afterwards and never forgave himself for reading, that the seam was spent below the value of working it, and that the pit should close.

It closed on 10 an Dàmhair, DE 10, on a morning of thin rain with the wind off the moor above the town. Tormod came up from Seann Toll the day before, on a carrier's cart with his own coat over his knees against the wet, because it seemed to him, though no rule of the guild required it, that the master ought to be there for the last shift of a pit that had made hewers of three generations of his own family before him, and he was not a man to reason himself out of a thing that seemed to him owed.

He stood at the pit-head from before light with the pit captain, a heavy, silent man named Gilleasbaig Ruadh, and watched the cage come up for the last time a little after the ninth hour, twelve men in it, black to the eyes, none of them speaking. They had known, going down that morning, that they would not go down again; the last coal had been cut two days before and the shift had spent its hours drawing the props and the rails that could still be sold for scrap, which is bitter

1. the Guild of Hewers; lit. 'the fellowship of the colliers'

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

work for a hewer, being the taking apart of what better men had built rather than the getting of anything new. The twelfth man out, a boy not yet twenty named Aonghas Dubh, carried up the last lamp used on the face, and stood at the cage door with it in his hand and looked about him for someone to hand it to, the way a lamp was always handed on at the end of a shift to whoever waited to go down next; and there was no one. The next shift had not been called, because there would be no next shift, and the boy stood there with the lamp until Gilleasbaig Ruadh, without a word, took it from him and hung it on the rack himself, in its place, where it stayed unlit.

Tormod watched that and said nothing for a long while, though of everything he saw that winter it was the thing he spoke of oftenest, to Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh's clerk among others, when the guild's own end came to be written down. He had seen pits close before, in his years as master, and had always thought the worst of it was the wages stopped and the families scattered; he had not before stood at a pit-head and seen a lamp with nowhere to go.

"There'll be work," Gilleasbaig Ruadh said, when the last man was up and the cage stood empty and swinging a little in the shaft-draught. "Comhairle nam Mèinnean says it. The river landing wants hands for the tanks, and the boats at Cill ghlas are hiring, some of them."

"Some of them," Tormod said.

"It's not nothing."

"No," Tormod said. "It is not nothing. I did not say it was nothing." He looked back at the pit-head, at the winding gear standing idle over the black mouth of the shaft, at the rain running off the roof of the engine-house where no engine now turned. "I have watched three pits close in my time as master, Gilleasbaig, and I have made the same speech at each of them, and each time it has been a smaller speech than the last, because there were fewer men to hear it. There is no speech left in me for this one. I am only glad I came."

IV

Of the Walk to Seann Toll

Comhairle nam Mèinnean's word was that the families who remained at Muileann dhearg, some forty households by then, the rest having gone south or to the works before them in the years the pit had been failing,

would be found places at Seann Toll on the Abhainn uaine, some five miles off by the river road, where Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn¹'s tanks and the dubhan works along the landing were taking on hands as fast as the river towns could send them. No cart was sent for the families' goods, Comhairle nam Mèinnean²'s letter having spoken of places found and said nothing of a removal paid for, and it was Tormod, hearing of it at the pit-head that same wet morning, who went from door to door in the pit quarter through the rest of that day and the next to say that the guild, though it had next to nothing left to give, would find carts for what could not be carried on a back, and that he would walk the road with them himself.

They went on the third day of an t-Samhain, forty households in a straggling line along the river road, with what they could carry and what four hired carts could hold besides, the children walking or riding on the carts by turns, the old carried when they must be. It was five miles, but the road was wet the whole way and the carts slow in the mud, and it took them from first light until well past dark. Tormod walked the whole of it, though Gilleasbaig Ruadh offered him a seat on a cart more than once and was refused each time, on the grounds, which he gave once and would not repeat, that a master who could not walk the road his people were walking had no business calling himself their master.

Seann Toll took them in without much ceremony. The town had land enough on its edge, low ground by the river that flooded in the worst winters and had never been built on for that reason, and Comhairle nam Mèinnean, which owned the land, had begun a row of houses there against just such a removal. They were not finished; the families lay that winter in Comhairle nam Mèinnean's sheds by the landing and went into the row as each house was roofed, the last of them in the high summer after. They were plain slate-roofed houses in a single street with a well at either end, no different in their building from the rows at Muileann chrom save that the walls were thinner and the chimneys smoked worse in a south wind. The town's own people, who called every new thing by the plainest name that came to hand, called it Sreath nan Gualadairean³ before the last house was roofed, and the name held, and within the year it was the only name anyone used for it, in Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own letters as much as in the town's mouth.

Few of the families found work on the river, as Gilleasbaig Ruadh had hoped. The boatmen of Seann Toll were their own close trade, river-bred for generations,

1. the Rail Board; lit. 'the board of the iron way'

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

3. the Hewers' Row at Seann Toll

and took on outsiders slowly if at all; two or three of the younger men were hired as deck hands over that winter and no more. Most went instead to the dubhan tanks at the landing, where the works wanted hands to roll barrels and mind the pumps and needed no river craft to do it, only a strong back and a willingness to learn a trade that had not existed when they were born. It was, as more than one of them said afterwards, not so different from the pit in the way it used a man, though the coal it moved was not coal and did not come up out of the ground under their own town.

Tormod did not stay at Seann Toll past the first fortnight, his guild's business calling him elsewhere and his chest not standing the damp of the river well, but he came back twice more that winter to see how the row did, and it was on the second of those visits, walking the street with Gilleasbaig Ruadh in a hard frost, that he said the thing Eachann mac Ruairidh, hearing it that same winter from the coach guard, turned over and came at last to understand.

"I keep thinking of the lamp," Tormod said. "The boy with nowhere to hand it. I have turned it over all winter and I think now it was not the pit closing that undid me at the pit-head. Pits close; I have seen it before and lived through the seeing. It was that there was no one coming down to take the lamp from him. A trade can lose its work and still be a trade, so long as the work is only gone for a season, or gone from one place and waiting in another. What I saw that morning was a trade with nowhere left for the work to go at all. The landlord on the north road who will not light his rooms with the new stuff — I heard of him this summer, and I thought him a fool, holding to an old thing out of pride. I think differently of him now. There is no trade left in his hands to hold together. He keeps one lamp lit that he need not, because somewhere in him he cannot bear to be the last man in the house who does not."

Gilleasbaig Ruadh had no answer to that, and did not try to make one, and the two men walked on down the frozen street of Sreath nan Gualadairean in silence, past the well and the first roofed houses, where forty households were to live that had not lived in that place a year before, until they came to the landing where the dubhan tanks stood in a row on their stone piers, and the river ran black and cold beneath them, going down, as it had always gone down, to the sea.

V

Of the Druid House Left Standing

Above the emptied pit quarter of Muileann dhearg, on the rise where the winding gear could still be seen from the moor road, stood the druid house that had served the pit families since the town was young, a low building of the same grey stone as the pit-head, with its own small burial ground behind it running back toward the moor. When the last households went down the river road to Seann Toll, the house went neither with them nor into Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹'s keeping, but to a caretaker, an old man named Pàdraig Iarna who had swept its floor and rung its bell for thirty years and had no family left in any of the towns the pit had scattered its people to.

Scoiltean nan Draoidhean² at Caol shean, which held the charge of such houses as had lost their congregations, wrote to say that a teacher would come once a year to give what lecture the empty quarter still had ears for, and did come, in the autumn after, a young man who found four old people and Pàdraig Iarna himself waiting in the cold hall and spoke to them for the better part of an hour on a text none of them had chosen and none of them afterwards could say they remembered. He did not come oftener than once a year after that, there being little in the empty quarter to draw him back sooner, and the house stood the rest of each year with its door locked and its bell silent, kept only by the old man's daily round, the graves behind it tended as they had always been tended, the town below it going about its business at Seann Toll with no more thought for the hill than the hill, in its long patience, seemed to ask of it.

Eachann mac Ruairidh never went to Muileann dhearg himself, that year or any year after, his own road running the other way along Slighe a' Ghuail³ to the capital and back; but he carried the tale of it, as the yard carried every such tale sooner or later, in the guard's telling and in Tormod's own words repeated at secondhand, and he thought of it, when he thought of it at all, alongside the nine cold engines standing in the grass of the long siding at Muileann chrom, each of them waiting, as the lamp at Muileann dhearg had waited on its rack, for a hand that was not coming to take them up again.

1. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

2. the druid schools

3. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

Of a Name that Went before the Fuel

DE 11 – 13

I

Of the Slip-box

Sileas nic Rath came to an Leabharlann¹ in the wet spring of the eleventh year of Linn an Dubhain², a niece of a copyist at Àth dhireach with a fair hand and no family living close enough to keep her from a post so far up the valley. Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh had asked the council for a clerk three times in as many years and been answered twice with silence and once with a letter regretting that the office's charge did not run to it; in the end it was Raghnaill mac Mhuirich who found the money, out of the keeper's own small fund for binding, and told the council afterwards rather than before. Sileas was two-and-thirty that spring, narrow-shouldered, quick with a pen, and she arrived at the old building on a wet Tuesday with a single box tied with string and a letter of introduction she never had cause to show, because Beathag met her at the door before she had raised her hand to knock.

"You'll want dry stockings before anything else," Beathag said, and that was the whole of her welcome, and Sileas took it for kindness, which it was.

She was set, that first month, to nothing grander than copying the shires' returns into the year's ledger in a hand the council's clerks could read without complaint, work any careful child could have done and few had the patience for; but

1. the Library at Muileann chaol

2. the Dubhan Era (DE); lit. 'the era of Dubhan'

she had, from the second week, a habit of her own that nobody had asked of her and nobody thought to stop. She kept, in a cigar-box begged from Ailig mac Thormoid, who had no more use for it than she had for the cigars that had come in it, a set of slips, one to a scrap of paper, on which she wrote down every spelling she met of the word that was now on every second letter that came up the library road.

There was no one spelling to meet. The council's own minute, the autumn before, had set it down twice in two lines as *dubhan* and *dùbhan*, the second with the grave accent moved a place, as though the clerk who wrote it had not been certain where the weight of the word should fall and had guessed twice rather than once. A letter from the maor of Cathair mhòr wrote it *dùban*, dropping the h entirely, which Sileas thought at first a slip of the pen until she found it done the same way three letters running from the same clerk's hand, and understood it for a settled habit rather than an accident. Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn's own minute-book, which came up twice a year for an Leabharlann's copying, wrote it once, in an t-Ògmhios of that year, as *An Dubhan*, with the article and a capital letter, as though the word had become, in that one entry, less a kind of fuel and more a name for a thing there was only one of; and a fortnight later, in the same book and the same clerk's hand, it went back to the small letter and no article, as though the writer himself had thought better of it, or simply forgotten what he had done a fortnight before.

"It's not the spelling that wants marking," Beathag said, the first time she found Sileas at the box after the day's copying was done, sorting slips by the little pile they made rather than by any order a stranger could have followed. "Any fool can misspell a word. It's that they're spelling it at all, and not the man's name. Read me the maor's letter again — the one from Cathair mhòr, in am Faoilleach."

Sileas found it and read: "'The price of dùban at the fair here has held above the coal ceiling the court set for it, there being no ceiling yet set for dùban, the court holding it no fuel of the old kind and so no matter for the old order.'"

"There," Beathag said. "A year ago that letter would have said Dubhan's fuel, or the black stuff a Tuathach makes, or some such circling of a thing the writer had no settled word for. Now it has a word, and the word has parted from his name. He is going out of the sentence, the way a man's name goes out of a coin once the coin has been struck long enough. I want every letter marked, from now,

3. the Rail Board; lit. 'the board of the iron way'

the first time it happens in each hand, so we can say when. I don't think why is a thing that can be dated."

Sileas kept the box faithfully after that, and by the time the box would hold no more slips without a second box beside it, which was some time in the fourteenth year and so beyond the telling of this chapter, she had marked the turn in forty-one hands out of the sixty or so that wrote regularly to an Leabharlann, each at its own month, none of them together, as though the word had come up out of the ground in a hundred kitchens and market squares at once and needed no one to carry it from one to the next.

She wrote her own small note at the front of the box, in the careful hand she kept for anything she thought might one day be read by someone other than Beathag, saying only what the box held and by whose asking; and under it, because she could not quite stop herself, a line that was hers alone and went into no ledger: that a word which does not need a man's name behind it any longer has become, whatever the court of the fair or the council's minute chooses to call it, a thing of its own. Beathag, finding the note some weeks later while looking for a slip out of order, read it twice, put it back exactly as she had found it, and never said a word to Sileas about it at all, which Sileas took, rightly, for the nearest thing to praise the chronicler knew how to give a clerk not yet three months in her post.

II

Of the Letter from Caol shean

In the same spring a letter came from Scoiltean nan Draoidhean¹ at Caol shean, addressed to Ragnall mac Mhuirich as keeper and copied, by his own note in the margin, to Beathag as chronicler, because it concerned, the school's letter said, a matter an Leabharlann² might in time wish to have on its shelves rather than in a schoolman's private word.

The school at Caol shean had long been near empty for the better part of two generations, its halls built for three hundred pupils and holding, in most years since the humans' time, fewer than forty; and the letter, which ran to four close-written pages before it came to its point, spoke first and at some length of the

1. the druid schools

2. the Library at Muileann chaol

school's own poor fortunes before it turned to the matter at hand, in the manner the letter itself called an old habit of scholars, of saying the discouraging thing before the useful one, so that the useful one should not be mistaken for good news undeserved.

The point, when it came, was a word. The school's masters, discussing among themselves — the letter did not say over what occasion, though Sileas guessed, reading it aloud to Beathag by the window that afternoon, that it had been over supper, there being a lightness to the sentence that no committee minute ever carried — had found themselves in want of a word for a particular kind of thing: an attempt that looked, at the time it was made, like one more failure among many, and proved afterwards, when nothing else had come of the years around it, to have been the one attempt that mattered. The masters had turned the word over among themselves for the school's own case, which had tried and failed at a dozen small revivals over the generations and did not yet know, the letter said with what Sileas took for a schoolman's dry honour, whether its own latest effort at taking pupils again would prove another failure or the one that held; and out of that turning they had made, from the old root for a first working and the word the north now used for the fuel, a single coined term: *dubhan-tùsail*, a first-attempt-that-was-the-one, which they offered to an Leabharlann, the letter said, for one reason alone: that a word made in a small room ought to be sent somewhere it might be kept even if it was never used.

"They want it in the record," Raghnaill said, when Sileas brought it to him. He turned the page over, as though the back of it might have more to say than the front. "For a word about their own school."

"They want it kept," Sileas said. "I don't think they much care whether it's used."

Raghnaill looked at her a moment, the way a man looks at someone who has said, without meaning to, a truer thing than he had said himself. "No," he said. "I expect that's exactly it." He copied the word into the day's page in his own hand, under the entry that had already noted the letter's coming, and did not use it again that year in anything he wrote. It sat on in an Leabharlann's word-list where he had set it, unused and uncorrected, the one entry on that page that nobody troubled to strike or to build upon.

III

Of the Line and the Coal Line

Up at Muileann chrom the next year Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn¹'s own minute-book, the one Sileas had marked for its wandering article, was making a smaller change than any word of Dubhan's, and one that touched Comhairle nam Mèinnean²'s own name for its own road.

The line from the capital to An Sloc Mòr³ had been called, since it was laid, Slighe a' Ghuail⁴, in every timetable Comhairle nam Mèinnean had printed and every mouth that used it; and in the spring of the twelfth year Comhairle nam Mèinnean's clerks, drawing up the new season's card, printed it for the first time as only *an t-slighe*, the line, with no coal in it at all. Nobody at Comhairle nam Mèinnean wrote to say why, and no order that Sileas ever found in the returns explained the change; the timetable simply came up to an Leabharlann⁵ in an Cèitean with the old name gone from its own cover, though every entry inside it still spoke, as it always had, of trains and hours and the fare by the mile.

It made no difference to anyone who rode the thing. The drivers at Muileann chrom, who had never in living memory called their road anything but Slighe a' Ghuail, went on calling it that in the yard and at their own firesides, whatever Comhairle nam Mèinnean's printer set on the card; and the carriers who used the road, and the farmers whose fields it ran through, and the clerks at Cathair dhearg who booked freight on it, all went on saying coal line as they always had, so that within the year Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own new name existed nowhere but on the printed cards themselves, a name with no mouth to carry it, while the old name it had tried to set aside went on being spoken by everyone who had any daily business with the road at all.

Beathag, reading the new timetable when it came up with the spring's papers, laughed once, shortly, and set it on the pile with the rest.

"They can print what they like," she said. "A road keeps the name the men on it give it, not the name Comhairle nam Mèinnean puts on the card. I'd sooner trust the drivers." She looked at Sileas over the pile. "Mark that too, if you're mark-

1. the Rail Board; lit. 'the board of the iron way'

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

3. the great pit at the mountain

4. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

5. the Library at Muileann chaol

ing such things. Not the word for the fuel this time. The word for what the fuel is taking away."

IV

Of the Last Roll

Comann nan Gualadairean dissolved itself in an Cèitean of the twelfth year, in the hall it rented at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr¹ above Cuan chrom, by a vote its own last minute recorded as unanimous among the eleven masters who came to cast it, out of a roll that had once numbered more than sixty.

Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh, who had been master eleven years and buried, by his own reckoning given at the pit-head at Muileann dhearg the autumn before, more of the trade than he had ever bound to it, brought the guild's last goods to an Leabharlann² himself, on a hired cart, in the first week of an t-Iuchar: its rolls of binding going back to the guild's chartering in the early years of the restored custom, its sick-roll, thin now, with the names of the last dozen hewers it still paid a shilling a week to for the black cough that had ended most of their working lives, and the oath-stone itself, a flat grey block no bigger than a hearthstone, worn smooth on its upper face where two generations of thumbs had rested while a boy or a girl swore the guild's old words over it, words that had promised, among other things, that the swearer would never cut coal for any hand but the guild's own and would die, if it came to dying, with the guild's black on their own.

Sileas met the cart in the yard and signed for the goods herself, Beathag having gone that week to Àth dhìreach to see her sister, who was unwell; and it was to Sileas, not to the chronicler she had come to see, that Tormod handed the rolls one by one, naming each as he gave it over, as though a thing so long kept ought not to change hands without at least that much ceremony.

He was three days coming, and had stopped, she guessed from the mud on his coat, more than once on the road to rest a chest that no longer let him ride a full day without it; but he would not sit while the goods were handed over, and stood the whole of the unloading with his hat off in the rain, though she asked him

1. the great house on the old coal road above Cuan chrom, whose new hall is let to the Guild of Hewers

2. the Library at Muileann chaol

twice to come in out of it and wait by the fire in the porters' room while the men carried the heavier things.

"I've stood at worse handings-over than this," he said, when she asked a third time. "I'll stand at this one too, and then I'll come in, and gladly."

"You'll want a receipt," Sileas said, when the cart was empty, and felt the word wrong in her mouth as she said it, a thing too small for what had just been handed over.

"I want nothing of the kind," Tormod said. "I want it kept, and I want it said, when anyone asks, that it came here whole and not begged for. That's receipt enough for me." He looked at the oath-stone, which stood now on the yard's flag-stones between them, too heavy for either of them to have carried far alone, waiting for the two men Raghnaill had sent down to bring it in. "I've sworn eleven masters on that stone in my time, and had eleven sworn on it themselves before that. I don't know what it's for now, in a room with nobody to swear on it. But it oughtn't to be broken up for a doorstep, which is what would happen to it at Achadh dhomhain inside five years, now the hall's sold."

He gave her, last of all, a single folded letter, addressed to no one in particular, which he asked her to see copied into an Leabharlann's record rather than filed loose among the guild's other papers, because he said he had written it to be read, not kept.

Sileas read it that evening, by the last light at her own small desk in the room she had been given off the old building's stair, and copied it herself into the day's page before Beathag came home, in a hand as close to Beathag's own settled hand as she could make it, because it seemed to her, reading it, a thing that should sit in the record as though the chronicler herself had taken it down. It was not a long letter. It said, among lesser things about what the sale of the hall had fetched and the disposal of what small funds remained, that the guild had outlived the mountain's patience; that a trade bound to a thing in the ground could not outlast the vein by more than a generation or two of pretending otherwise, and that the guild, in dissolving itself before it was dissolved by want, had done the one dignified thing left to it to do.

Beathag read the copied page the morning after she came back from Àth dhìreach, standing at the window with the light behind her the way she always stood to read anything she meant to think hard about, and said nothing for a long while.

"You copied it well," she said at last.

"I tried to make it sound as you would have made it sound."

"You made it sound as he made it sound, which is better." Beathag folded the page back into the ledger and set the ledger on the pile with the others. "There's not a hedging word in the whole of it. Most men, writing the end of a thing they'd given their life to, would have found some way to say it wasn't really ending, or asked to be remembered for it, or promised better days for it yet. He didn't trouble himself with any of that. He said the thing was over and gave the reason and stopped." She looked at Sìleas a moment. "That's a rarer gift than you'd think, in a chronicler's clerk as much as in a guild master. Keep it, when your own time comes to write things down."

V

Of the Bath-house below Muileann ruadh

Among the guild's smaller goods, listed at the foot of Tormod's own inventory almost as an afterthought, was a bath-house the hewers had built two generations before over Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh¹ below Muileann ruadh, for the ease of men whose chests the coal-dust had ruined; a low stone building over three basins fed straight from the ground at a heat no fire needed to raise, kept by an old woman of the town on the guild's small wage and open, until that year, to none but hewers and their families on the guild's own card.

The house passed, with the rest of the guild's holding, to the custodians of Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail² at the southern Seann Skell, the guild having named no other body fit to take a charge it could no longer keep; and the custodians, who owned already the greater bath-houses of the south coast and had never had much use for a small one so far inland, opened it that same summer to any who could pay the old woman's modest fee, hewer's card or none.

It was in an Lùnastal of that year, by the letter the keeper of the house sent up to an Leabharlann³ at Raghmall's own asking, that a Tuathach family came to the basins for the first time in the house's history: a woman of Doire ghlas, brought south by a married daughter for a chest complaint the northern doctors had no more to offer against, and the daughter's own two children, who had never in

1. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

2. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

3. the Library at Muileann chaol

their lives been let past the door of any house of the old faith on any errand at all. The keeper's letter said only that she had taken the woman's coin, which was good coin and no different from any other, and shown her to the basin as she would have shown anyone, and that the woman had stayed the better part of an hour and come out saying something to her daughter in a tongue the keeper knew nothing of, though she took it for thanks by the way it was said, and it made the daughter laugh and put an arm round her mother's shoulders in the cold of the yard outside.

"She asked no leave of the custodians," Ragnall said, reading the letter to Beathag and Sìleas both, "and none was asked of her. I don't know that either side thought of it as a thing needing leave at all. The water doesn't know whose chest it's easing."

"Write it down as she wrote it," Beathag said. "Not a word more."

VI

Of the Damp at Seann Toll

Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh did not long survive the guild he had dissolved. His own chest, which had troubled him for a dozen years before that summer and troubled him worse after it, kept him from the road for most of the autumn that followed; but in am Faoilleach of the thirteenth year, against the plain advice of a doctor at Cathair mhòr who told him a river town in winter was the worst place a man with his cough could choose to visit, he went down once more to Seann Toll, to see, he told the doctor, how Sreath nan Gualadairean¹ did in its first hard frost, and would hear no argument against it.

He was three days at the Row, by Gilleasbaig Ruadh's own account sent up afterwards to an Leabharlann² at Beathag's asking, walking the frozen street each morning as he had walked it the winter before, and taking, on the third evening, a fever that settled in his chest within a day and would not lift. Gilleasbaig sent for the nearest doctor, who was at Muileann chrom, half a day off by the river road in the worst of the weather, and sat with him himself through the two nights that came between the sending and the doctor's arrival, in a house of the Row no bet-

1. the Hewers' Row at Seann Toll

2. the Library at Muileann chaol

ter built than any other, with a single dubhan lamp burning low on the sill because the fire, Gilleasbaig's letter said, gave less heat than the lamp and Tormod had asked, more than once in his wandering, that the lamp be kept lit and the fire let go out, though he never said why and Gilleasbaig never asked.

He died a little before dawn on the sixth day of an Gearran, in the Row he had walked his people into, among people who were no longer, by any charter, his to answer for. Gilleasbaig Ruadh's letter, which reached an Leabharlann a fortnight later, the river road being what it was in that season, said only that he had gone quietly, that he had spoken little in the last day beyond asking twice after the oath-stone's safekeeping and being told, both times, that it was safe; and that the Row had buried him themselves, in the ground at the edge of the flood-plain that Seann Toll kept for those it had no older claim on, because there was no guild left to claim him and no family near enough to send for in the time the weather allowed.

Beathag entered his death in the day's page herself, in her own hand, the last entry Sileas ever saw her make without asking the clerk to make it first and copy it after; and she wrote beside the bare date, which was all the entry strictly needed, the one line from his own letter that Sileas had copied the summer before, that the guild had outlived the mountain's patience, and under it, in a hand smaller than her usual hand, as though she had thought better of writing it large: that he had not.

The hall at Achadh dhomhain, which the guild had sold before it dissolved itself, changed its trade on 1 am Màrt, DE 13, three weeks after he was buried. Its buyer, a dealer of the town, had the long room cleared of its benches and set two dubhan pumps in the doorway where the masters had once come in to sit, and a tank in the yard behind; and because the lintel over the door was one great stone, and cutting it out would have brought the front of the house down with it, the lintel stayed where it was, with the guild's oath cut into it in letters a hand high, above the pumps. The carters who filled their barrels there read it every time they looked up, those who could read, and the ones who could not had it read to them once and did not ask again.

Of the Charter Rule

DE 13 – 14

I

Of the House of Mac Ùisdein

The stone house at Cathair mhòr had been built, four generations back, of the spoil of An Sloc Mòr¹: grey rubble from the tips that no mason would otherwise have troubled to dress, hauled up from Achadh dhomhain on An Crùn²'s own carts because the first Mac Ùisdein to hold the concession had wanted it said that his hall was built of the very stuff that paid for it. It was said still, by anyone who wanted to flatter the house, and by a good many who did not.

Coinneach mac Ùisdein sat in that hall in am Màrt of the thirteenth year with the pit's returns open on the table before him and did not need his clerk to tell him what they meant. He had read An Sloc Mòr's returns every quarter of his life since he was old enough to be shown the ledgers, first at his grandfather's knee and then at his father's, and he knew the shape a failing seam took on a page before he knew what most of the words on it were for: fewer tons at greater cost, more days lost to water, a gallery abandoned here, a face condemned there, and under it all the same steady, patient arithmetic that had been eating the house's fortune for thirty years and showed no sign of tiring of the meal.

"How much is left in it," he said, not as a question, to the clerk who had brought the returns.

1. the great pit at the mountain

2. the Crown

"A fifth of what it gave in your grandfather's day, sir. Less, this last twelve-month."

"And An Crùn's share still comes off the top before ours."

"It does, sir. It always has."

Coinneach closed the ledger. He was a broad, unhurried man of five-and-forty who had never in his life cut coal or gone down a shaft, and whose whole knowledge of An Sloc Mòr was the knowledge of a man who owns a horse he has never ridden: he knew its habits, its ailments, its cost, and nothing else. His grandfather Alasdair had borrowed against the house's share to meet its debts in a bad year and never fully paid the loan off; his father had sold half the share outright to An Crùn rather than see the whole house go under with it. Coinneach had grown up hearing both transactions spoken of at table as wounds the house had suffered and survived, and he had grown up, too, hearing his father say, more than once and always at the end of a long evening, that a house too proud to sell the rest when the time came would end by having nothing left to sell at all.

He thought the time had come. He did not think it with any great grief, which surprised him a little when he noticed it in his own chest; he had expected to feel the weight of four generations when he finally sat down to write the letter, and instead he felt mostly the relief of a man setting down a sack he has carried a long way past the point of needing it.

Even so, he gave the matter a week more than it needed, out of respect for his father's memory rather than any doubt of his own mind, and spent part of that week walking the tip-heaps above Achadh dhomhain with the clerk who had brought him the returns, looking at ground he had inherited a right to and never once in his life had reason to stand on before. The heaps were higher than he remembered from his grandfather's telling of them, grey and terraced, with a thin scurf of gorse taking on the older slopes where the spoil had lain undisturbed longest; a boy with a barrow was picking over the newest tip for lumps still black enough to burn in a poor man's grate, and looked up at the two strangers in good coats without much curiosity and went back to his picking.

Coinneach wrote to Comhairle nam Mèinnean³ offering what remained of the house's share in An Sloc Mòr's spoil and quarry, the stone-cutting and the tip-rights that had come down with the coal, at a price he judged fair and expected to be haggled down from. Comhairle nam Mèinnean's answer came inside a month

3. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

and haggled him down by less than he had expected; Comhairle nam Mèinnean, he understood without being told, was glad to have the whole of a great pit in its own hand at last, and had no wish to argue long over the last piece of it. Comhairle nam Mèinnean's clerks took the summer over the papers, and the sale was signed at Cathair mhòr on 4 an t-Sultain, DE 13, with two witnesses and a fee to Cùirt na Fèille⁴, and Coinneach mac Ùisdein put what it brought him, and a good part of what the house had besides, into an account with the shipmasters at Ros dhomhain, against the building of three dubhan hulls.

He rode down to see the first of them on her slip in an Dàmhair: a coastal trader of the middling size, her ribs up and her planking half on, smelling of new pitch and sawdust in a yard that smelled of nothing else for a quarter mile around. The master shipwright walked him round her twice and answered his questions plainly, in the way of a man who has been asked the same questions by a great many new owners that year and does not resent it yet.

"She'll carry dubhan or anything else you like," the shipwright said. "The tank sits amidships, out of the way of cargo, and she'll do without it besides, burning wood in the old grate if it ever came to that, though I don't know why it would." He looked at Coinneach a moment. "Your house held coal a long time, I hear."

"It did," said Coinneach.

"And now hulls."

"Now hulls." Coinneach put his hand on the new wood of her side, which was still rough where the adze had left it. "The coal held us as long as it had anything to hold us with. I'd sooner move the house's money before the seam moves it for me."

The shipwright nodded, as if this were the most ordinary thing in the world, which by that year it very nearly was.

II

Of the Bridge at Cathair dhearg

Coinneach had come up to the capital that summer, while the sale was still in the clerks' hands, to see them about its paperwork, and found the road changed since his last visit two years before. A dubhan bus now ran

4. the court of the fair at Muileann òg

between Cathair dhearg and Inis mhòr twice a day, a long closed carriage on iron-shod wheels with a driver's box at the front and benches down each side inside, and it went the eleven miles in under an hour where the old coach had taken the better part of the morning. Another line ran out to Cathair mhòr itself, his own town, though he had come up by his own horse this time and had not thought to look for it at the bridge.

The word for the thing, he noticed, was not a Dia-thiris word at all. Men called it *bus*, flat and short, the same sound the humans of an Tìr Thall¹ were said to use for it in their own tongue, and nobody troubled to find another. There had been words made, in the early years of the fuel, for the engine and for the trains that ran on Slighe a' Ghuail² and now the dubhan tanks beside it, careful compounds out of old roots that Comhairle nam Mèinnean's³ clerks were proud enough of. The bus and the hired car that waited for a fare at the foot of the bridge, its driver leaning on the door with his cap pushed back, had come into the tongue with their humans' names still on them, the way a thing arrives faster than the word-makers can catch up to it. *Tacsaidh*, the hired car was called, and the men who drove them took the name for themselves as well, and neither word troubled anyone enough to be replaced.

Coinneach stood at the foot of the bridge a while, watching the bus load. Six passengers went up the step, a basket of hens tied under one of the benches, a woman with a child on her knee paying her fare in coin new enough that Coinneach could see, when she opened her purse, that it still bore the coal-inked seal. He thought that the change he had made in his own house's fortune was a small thing set against the change the whole kingdom was making around him: a bus line and a hired car and a word borrowed rather than coined, none of it decreed by anyone, all of it happening because it was easier than not happening.

The coal caste of the capital, the old families who had held the mines and the mine-rights since the first grants, said nothing that anyone troubled to write down. Coinneach knew a dozen of them by name, had sat at table with half of them, and heard from none of them any word of complaint at the bus or the *tacsaidh* or the fuel that ran them; the ones who still held a working seam held their tongues because the pits still paid, however little, and the ones whose seams were spent, like his own family's, had for the most part already begun doing what he

1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

2. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

3. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

had done, quietly, each house in its own time, none of them wishing to be first and none, now, minded to be last.

III

Of the Court of the Sea

He was at Ros dhomhain in that same autumn, when the first of his hulls had her engine in, and watched her go off on a trial, a short coasting run to Cuan shean and back with a cargo of nothing more than barrels of dubhan for the harbour lamps, and stayed to watch the kingdom's own patrol boats put out on the same tide.

They had been refitted that summer, the whole small fleet of them, and it showed in the way they took the harbour mouth: quicker off the mark than Coinneach remembered patrol boats ever being, with none of the labouring plume of smoke a coal-fired hull threw up, and gone round the headland almost before the gulls that always followed a boat out had settled which one to follow. A harbour-master's clerk, standing near Coinneach on the quay with nothing better to do than talk to a stranger, said they had run down two raider hulks that same month that would have got clean away from them the year before.

"Never used to catch them," the clerk said. "Coal boat's slower off the mark and slower to answer the helm both, and by the time she's got up her head of steam the raider's half over the horizon. These new ones are away before he's well started."

Both hulks, taken under tow, lay at the harbour wall when Coinneach walked down that way in the evening. Their crews lay the winter in the town's gaol, for Cùirt na Mara¹ sat only at midsummer; and in an t-Iuchar of the fourteenth year, when Coinneach came down again to see his second hull launched, the court sat on them in the long room above the customs house, a room Coinneach had been in once or twice before on his own house's business and never for anything so grave. He went in out of curiosity more than anything else, and found the room fuller than he had expected: the raiders' trial was, that year, still enough of a novelty — the fleet's new speed being novel, and the catching of two crews in a month being novel with it — that half the town's idle men had come to watch.

1. the court of the sea at Ros dhomhain

There were eleven of the two crews together, ragged, salt-marked, answering the magistrate in a mixture of tongues that his clerk translated as it came. The oldest of them, a scarred man who gave his name as Callum of no fixed harbour, said through the clerk that he had followed the raiding trade twenty years and had never before this season had a boat of An Crùn² come up on him faster than his own could run, and said it, Coinneach thought, less as a confession than as a kind of professional complaint, the grievance of a man whose trade has changed under him without his leave. Three of the eleven, it came out in the course of the morning, were Tuathaich, taken on for the voyage at some northern harbour for want of better work and knowing, by their own account, nothing of where the boat's takings were meant to go once she had them. One of the three, a boy who could not have been past sixteen, wept through most of his own questioning and had to be told twice to speak up, until the magistrate, not unkindly, said there was no need of him to speak at all if the other two would answer for him, which they did.

The magistrate heard the whole of it out at length, conferred with his own clerk over a paper Coinneach could not see, and in the end hanged none of the eleven: he sent the eight Dia-thìrich among them to the quarries at Achadh dhomhain, the same quarries whose stone had built the house Coinneach had grown up in, and told the three Tuathaich, the boy among them, that they were free to find their own way home, north, by whatever road would have them, and that the court had no charge to hold against a man for want of choosing better company to sail in.

Coinneach watched the three go out of the room together, saying nothing to each other or to anyone, and thought it an odd smallness of the world that the sentence on the guilty should send eight men to break the stone his own family had lived four generations off, in the same season his own family's money had gone the other way, into hulls that had helped catch the men now sentenced to break it. He turned the thought over once, the way a man turns a coin he has found in the road, and put it away with the rest of the day's business, and rode home to Cathair mhòr well pleased with his hulls.

IV

Of the Chartering at Seann Skell

2. the Crown

Peigi nic Ascaill had been master-fitter at the shipmasters' works for seven years by the summer Comann nan Goibhnean-ceangail¹ were chartered, and she had known the charter was coming, in the way anyone in the trade had known it, for the better part of a year before it came. Comann nan Sciobairean² had wanted it: a guild of its own, rolls that could bind an apprentice and set a wage and keep a bad fitter's name off any yard's books, the ordinary machinery of a trade grown too large to run any longer on a handful of masters' say-so. Every craft in the kingdom that had ever grown large enough to need binding had ended, sooner or later, chartered; nobody at the works had thought the fitters would be different, and nobody was much surprised, in the spring, when word came that An Crùn³ had granted it.

What surprised Peigi, though she told herself afterwards that it should not have, was the single clause near the foot of the grant that fixed the rolls to Dia-thìrich alone.

She read it three times at her desk in the works' office before she understood that she had not misread it the first time. It was not a new kind of clause; every guild chartered in her lifetime carried some version of it, Comann nan Gualdairean⁴ before their own dissolving, Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn's⁵ drivers, the masons, the smiths; she had simply never before had cause to read one with her own hand about to be asked to enforce it. She sat with the letter a long while after she had finished reading it, and then she did what she had always done with a hard thing since she was a girl learning her trade under men who thought a woman had no business at a lathe: she got up and went to see it done, because putting it off would not make it easier and might make it worse.

The chartering itself was held at the southern Seann Skell on 29 an Lùnastal, DE 14, in the works' own long shed with its doors thrown open to the harbour for air, before a clerk of An t-Ionmhas⁶ sent down from the capital to read the grant and a custodian of Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail⁷ to bless the guild's new banner, a black swan on grey. Twelve masters were sworn that day, Peigi among the first six called, and she said the words of the oath — to bind no hand outside the roll, to

1. the Guild of Fuel-Fitters; lit. 'the fellowship of the fitters'

2. the company of shipmasters who built the dubhan works at the southern Seann Skell

3. the Crown

4. the Guild of Hewers; lit. 'the fellowship of the colliers'

5. the Rail Board; lit. 'the board of the iron way'

6. the Treasury

7. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

teach the trade truly to those admitted to it, to answer to the guild's own court for any fault in her own work or her apprentices' — in a clear voice that did not shake, because she had decided beforehand that it would not, whatever else happened that day.

What happened that day, for the men she had brought south from Caol mhòr seven years before, was that their names could not go on the roll being read at the same hour in the same shed, and every man in the yard who had worked beside them for those seven years knew it without needing to be told twice.

She found Joe Ashby that evening at the forge where he had a room, sitting on the step with his tools laid out on a cloth beside him, already half packed though the chartering was not four hours old.

"You'll have heard," she said.

"I heard it read." He did not look up from the wrench he was wrapping. "Sworn among Dia-thirich only. It's plain enough. I've heard plainer things put worse."

"I argued it, Joe. Before the grant went up, and again this spring when I knew it was coming. I went to the company's masters and I told them what losing you and Ned and Abel would cost the works, in plain trade terms, because I judged that was the argument likelier to move them than any other, and I was wrong that it would move them at all." She stood in the doorway with her hand on the frame, not coming further in, as though she had not decided whether she had the right to. "I'm a master of the guild that's put you out of the yard. I don't know how to say that to you in any way that makes it smaller than it is."

"Don't, then," said Joe. "Say the other thing you came to say."

She had a purse in her coat pocket, which she had counted out herself that afternoon rather than leave it to the works' clerk, and she set it down on the step beside him. "A month's wage over what's owed you. For all three of you, the same. It's the company's money by rights, not the guild's, and I got it out of them by telling them it was cheaper than the trouble of a bad name up and down this coast, which is also true, though it isn't why I asked for it."

Joe looked at the purse and did not touch it for a moment. "Why did you ask for it, then."

"Because I fitted a burner beside you for two winters before either of us had a guild to answer to, and I don't know how else to say I haven't forgotten that, since the guild I've just sworn into won't let me say it in the only way that would mean anything, which is keeping you on." She said it fast, in one breath, the way a per-

son says a thing they have rehearsed and are afraid of losing their nerve over before the end of it. "I know a month's wage isn't that."

"No," Joe said. "It isn't." He picked up the purse, weighed it once in his hand, and put it in his coat. "I'll take it, because it's owed and because Ned's got a debt at the smith's that wants clearing before we go, and pride's a poor thing to leave a debt unpaid for. But I'll tell you plainly, since you've been plain with me: I'd sooner you hadn't come tonight at all than come and stand in that door and not come in."

Peigi did not come in. She stood a moment longer, and then she said, "I know," and went back up the yard to the office, where there was a night's paper-work waiting that she was, for once in her working life, glad of the excuse to lose herself in.

V

Of the Boat without a Guild

Joe Ashby went home to Caol mhòr in the first days of an t-Sultain with the Fowler cousins beside him and Will Tanner's letter in his pocket, which had reached him at the works a fortnight before and said only that there was work at the harbour for any man who could still fit an engine, guild or no guild, and that Will had kept the room over his own boat-shed empty on the chance.

Caol mhòr's harbour had grown since Joe had left it seven years before: more dubhan hulls at the moorings than he remembered coal-burning boats ever standing there at once, and a new shed at the harbour's north end with a sign that named it, in the Dia-thìrich tongue only, a depot of the fleet's provisioning, though the men who worked it, Joe saw within a day, were Tuathaich to the last one, paid by the fleet and answering to no guild the fleet had ever heard of asking after.

He fitted his first engine at Caol mhòr inside the week, a small fishing boat belonging to a widow named Jean Fisher whose husband had drowned two winters before and who had been putting off the cost of a proper engine ever since on what a widow's share of a fishing boat brought in. Joe fitted it for less than the southern works would have charged and took his payment half in coin and half in fish, which he judged, correctly, would see him through the winter better than

coin alone in a town where every boat had fish to spare and coin was the scarcer thing.

There was no guild roll to enter his name on, north of the boundary stones, and no guild court to answer to if a burner he fitted failed; there was, instead, the harbour, which knew within a season whose engines ran true and whose did not, and told it plainly enough in whose boat a man trusted his own family to. By the turn of the year Joe had fitted engines in eleven boats at Caol mhòr and two at Baile chrom, working from a bench in the corner of Will Tanner's shed with tools he had bought from the smith of Baile chrom who had once straightened Peigi's burner with him on the anvil, at a price the smith called fair and Joe suspected was less than fair, out of a kindness neither of them named.

Ned Fowler took work on the harbour depot's own boats, minding the pumps that filled the fleet's tanks, and his cousin Abel went further, out past the mill country to Muileann bheag, where Calum Bàn the keeper still remembered the four fitters of the rain-soaked week and put in a word that got Abel taken on to help a farmer mend a threshing engine none of the district's own smiths would touch. Will Tanner, who had never gone south at all, said to Joe more than once that winter that the works at Seann Skell had done the north an unintended kindness in casting its fitters back onto it, since the harbour now had, for the price of nothing, four men who could fit an engine to a standard the south's own guild would have been glad to swear by, and answered to no one for it but the boats they served.

He did not write to Peigi, and she did not write to him, though a letter did come that winter, forwarded from the assembly's house, from the master of the guild's court at Seann Skell, informing any who fitted a dubhan engine north of the boundary stones without the guild's leave that they did so at their own risk and without the guild's protection should the work fail. Joe read it once, by the light of the shed's single lamp, and pinned it to the wall above his bench, not out of defiance exactly, though it did the office of defiance well enough, but because Will Tanner said it would make good kindling for the winter and Joe found he did not want it burnt.

VI

Of the Walk-Out

Tional nan Tuathach met at Caol mhòr on 24 an t-Samhain, DE 14, under Martha Greaves in her seventh year as speaker, to settle a question that had been put off, by common consent, through two summers of the fuel's spreading: whether the north should take the new fire up for its own use, as the south had, or hold to its own seams as long as those seams had anything left to give.

It was not, in the letter of the thing, much of a question by then. Half the roofs of Caol mhòr already burned dubhan lamps bought off the harbour depot, and the mill at Doire ghlas had run its winter looms on it two years running for want of coal cheap enough to buy from the south. What Tional nan Tuathach's vote settled was not whether the north would use the fuel, which it plainly already did, but whether it would say so, in its own minute-book, as a thing decided rather than a thing that had simply happened around everyone the way the bus and the tacsaidh had happened around Coinneach mac Ùisdein at the foot of the capital's bridge.

The delegates spoke through the better part of a short winter afternoon, the hall lit early against the failing light by dubhan lamps hung from the same beams that had once held tallow, which more than one speaker remarked on without needing to labour the point. When the vote was called near dusk it went eleven towns for taking the fuel up and five against, the five being the delegates of the western pit towns, whose own seams still worked, however poorly, and who had not come to Caol mhòr that day expecting to be outvoted by towns that had never cut coal in their lives.

It was among the five that a young woman stood to speak before the vote was carried, whom few in the hall had heard address Tional nan Tuathach before: Ruth Calder, sent that year in her father's stead from Àth leathan, where he still held the pit captain's place though his chest had kept him above ground since the winter before, and where she kept his books and did his business for him by no rule anyone could point to but the hewers' own custom.

She was not long on her feet. Tional nan Tuathach's own minute gave her, as it gave every delegate that day, no more than a line: that the western towns had cut coal for their own hearths and their neighbours' since before there was a Moot to vote on anything, and meant to go on doing it as long as the seams allowed, and did not ask Tional nan Tuathach's leave to do so, only its patience while they did.

1. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

When the vote was carried against her she rose again, with the four other delegates of the five towns beside her, and walked out of the hall before the clerk had finished writing the count into the book, not in anger that anyone present could afterward describe as anger exactly, but in the manner of people who have said what they came to say and see no further use in staying to hear it argued over.

Martha Greaves let them go without calling after them, and said only, to the hall that remained, that the minute would show the five towns' dissent recorded and their delegates withdrawn, and that Tional nan Tuathach's granaries, whatever else the vote had settled, remained open to any household of the north that came to them hungry, coal-burning or dubhan-burning alike, and always would. A delegate of Doire ghlais asked her, once the hall had quieted, whether the granaries' word applied equally to a household of Àth leathan as to one of Caol mhòr, since the five towns had that day, in effect, declared themselves apart from the rest of Tional nan Tuathach's business. Martha answered that a hungry household was a hungry household in whatever town Tional nan Tuathach's charter covered, and that she did not propose to begin sorting granary sacks by how a man's delegate had voted, and the question was not put to her again that year.

The clerk wrote it down as Martha said it, word for word, and under it, in the day's last light before the lamps were trimmed for the evening, wrote the names of the five towns that had walked out, Àth leathan first among them, in a hand no different from the hand he had used for every other name in the book that year. Outside, in the yard, the five delegates stood a while by the lit windows before starting for the western road, none of them in any great hurry to begin the walk home in the dark, and it was there, by Ruth Calder's own later account, that Tom Varley of Cnoc thais said to her that she had spoken better than her father ever had, which she took, she said, for the kindest thing anyone said to her that whole hard year.

Of the Fifteenth Year

DE 15

I

Of the Northern Depots

The letter from Doire ghlas came up the library road in the last week of an Giblean, water-stained at one corner where the carrier had let his bag swing against a puddle, and Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh read it twice before she set it on the day's pile.

It was Martha Greaves's own hand, which had grown no neater in seven years of writing Cuimhne-coinneimh an 'Tionail¹ and had, if anything, grown faster and less patient, so that whole words leaned into one another like men crowding a doorway out of the rain. A dubhan depot had opened that month at Doire ghlas, she wrote, supplied by sea from the south, and word had come the same week of two more, at Caol mhòr and at Ceann mhòr, both stocked from the same boats. The figures followed as Comhairle nam Mèinnean²'s agent had given them to her: so many casks a fortnight, so much a cask, a scale of credit for any household that could not pay outright and would work it off at the mill. All this she set down as a minute sets a thing down, plainly, one fact behind another, and then, at the foot of the page, in a line apart from the rest as though she had thought about it before she let herself write it, came what the minute did not ask her to say. *The north now buys its fire from the south. I do not say whether this is a good thing or a bad one. I say only that it is the case, and that it was not the case a year ago.*

Beathag copied the letter whole into the day's page, the figures first and Martha's own line last, exactly as it stood, and did not add a word of her own be-

1. the Moot's minutes; lit. 'the meeting-memory of the gathering'

neath it. She had learned, in her years at the desk, that some sentences wanted nothing added to them, and this was one; anything she might have said herself would only have blunted the plain fact Martha had already sharpened for her.

Doire ghlais she knew a little, from letters if from nothing else: a mill town on the north coast, its people Tuathaich of the old northern congregations, whose great church under the grey oaks the north calls the heart of its faith. She had never been there and did not expect now that she would be. It came to her plainly enough from Martha's figures all the same: the casks coming off a boat at a quay that had never before unloaded anything but wool and salted fish, a queue of townfolk with their own carts and barrows, a clerk with a scale of credit written on a board because half of them could not pay outright and the mill would stand for them if they could not; and somewhere in the queue, an old man or an old woman remembering the coal fires their own fathers had burned, coal that had never once, in all the years of the kingdom, come north of the boundary stones to warm a Tuathach hearth, because the vein was the kingdom's and the north had never held any part of it. Now the north was buying fire it had made no part of either, only bought it from a different hand.

She wrote nothing of this in the record. The carrying of it belonged to Martha's own line, and Martha's line was enough.

Three days later a shorter note came up from Ragnall mac Mhuirich's own desk, though he sat not six feet from her own, because he had taken to leaving her such notes when he thought a thing wanted saying and did not want to interrupt her at the page. It read only: *Ask Sileas to mark the depots on the map in the front room. Three dots, close together on the coast. It will want marking again before the year is out, I think, though I could not tell you why I think it.*

She did not ask him why. His hunches about the shape a year would take, she had learned, were more often right than wrong, and he liked least to be asked to account for them before they had proved themselves one way or the other. She called Sileas from the copying-room and gave her the note, and watched the girl's quick hand set the three dots on the old map that hung in the front room, close together on the coast as the note said, small and black and, for the present, no more than three dots among a hundred others.

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

II

Of the Fifth of an Cèitean

The council sat on the fifth of an Cèitean, and what was done at that sitting reached an Leabharlann¹ three ways within the week: the council's own minute, sent as a matter of course to every office of record; a private letter from a clerk of An t-Ionmhas² who owed Raghnaill a kindness from some years before and thought the chronicler's desk should not wait on the formal copy; and, last and slowest, the printed proclamation, posted up in the market towns and brought to an Leabharlann folded inside a farmer's almanac by a carrier who had torn it from a post at Cathair dhearg because he thought Beathag would want to see the thing as the crowd had seen it, creased and a little torn at one corner where someone's thumbnail had caught it pulling it down to read.

She read the clerk's letter first, because it came first and because it was the plainest telling of the three. He wrote that the council, sitting the whole of the forenoon and part of the afternoon on nothing else, had resolved two things at one stroke, as though An t-Ionmhas's masters had judged that two changes made on the same day would be easier for the kingdom to swallow than the same two changes made a month apart, each with its own weight of argument. The first: that the coin of the Rìoghachd, which since Fearchar Bonn's own day had rested on the stores of coal held against it, would rest from that day on the making of dubhan, the mint's reserve counted now in casks of the new fuel and not in coal at all. The second, moved by a councillor whose name the clerk did not think it his place to give, though Beathag guessed from the wording of the motion that it had come from one who had argued it before and lost: that the age of the kingdom, which had run since An Dealachadh³ under its own count of years, was ended, and that a new count began from the day of the first working dubhan, fourteen years gone and more, so that the year now standing, which the mint's own ledgers and the council's own minutes had been calling the eighty-fifth of the old count, was to be entered thereafter as the fifteenth year of Linn an Dubhain⁴, the era of Dubhan.

The clerk added, in a line he had crossed out and then, thinking better of the crossing, written again below it so that both stood: that the proclamation had

1. the Library at Muileann chaol

2. the Treasury

3. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

passed by a show of hands with no count taken, which was not the council's custom in a matter of such weight, and that he did not know whether this meant the matter was thought too plain to need counting, or too awkward to want a number set against it that some other year might be held up and compared.

The printed proclamation, when it came, said nothing of the vote at all, only the two resolutions themselves in the flat language proclamations use, and, at the foot, the line that was carried to every market town on the same sheet: *from the day of the first dubhan the years shall be counted anew*. Beathag read it standing at the window with the creased sheet held to the light, the tear at its corner letting a thin blade of sun through onto the page, and thought that a single sentence had just done to fourteen years of her own record what an Leabharlann's reckoners had done, three generations before her time, to the ages before An t-Aiseag⁵, folding a stretch of lived years into a new count as though the years themselves had always belonged to it and only wanted the right hand to say so.

"They have moved the ground under every date I have ever written," she said to Raghnaill, who had come to stand at her shoulder, though she was not sure until she had said it whether she meant it as complaint or as plain description, and found, turning the sentence over once it was out of her mouth, that she meant it as both at once and saw no reason to choose between them.

"They have," Raghnaill said. "It was always dubhan that moved the ground. This is only the council saying so out loud, which it does seldom enough that I own I did not expect it from them this cleanly."

III

Of the Fourteen Years Re-headed

The work fell to her alone, because it was a chronicler's work and no clerk's, however careful the clerk's hand; a clerk might copy a line, but only the chronicler who had written the fourteen years in the first place could say, of each one, where its true head now stood.

She began the evening the proclamation reached her, by a single lamp at the long table in the room behind the front room, with the fourteen ledgers stacked

4. the Dubhan Era (DE); lit. 'the era of Dubhan'

5. the Crossing; lit. 'the ferrying'

at her right hand in the order she had written them and a fifteenth, the year now running, open before her with its first four months already filled under the old heading. Sileas offered to sit with her and hold the lamp steady, or fetch fresh oil when the first measure burned low, and Beathag let her, though there was little enough the girl could do beyond that; the turning wanted one hand and one memory, and Sileas's memory did not go back far enough to be trusted with it.

It was not hard work in the doing, only slow, and slower than she had thought it would be when she sat down to it. Each ledger's first page carried, at its head, the year of the old count, *SE* and the number, in the same square hand she had used for fourteen years running because she had never in that time had reason to write it any other way; and beside each old heading she now set the new, *Linn an Dubhain*¹, the year in its place, first, second, third, and so down the stack to the fourteenth, which was the year just closed, and the fifteenth, which was the year she sat in as she wrote. She did not strike out the old headings. She had thought, before she began, that she might, and had decided against it somewhere in the walk from the front room to the long table, on no better ground than that a thing once written into the record was the record's own and not hers to unwrite, however the council chose to count it afterward; so she set the new heading beside the old, in a smaller hand, with a line drawn between them, and let both stand.

Between the sixth ledger and the seventh, some time past midnight by the state of the lamp, she stopped long enough to look back over what she had already turned, and found, reading the years in their new order, that she remembered them differently set out so. The sixth year of *Linn an Dubhain* had been, under its old heading, the seventy-sixth of the kingdom, a year she remembered chiefly for the cold spring and a fever that had gone through Muileann chaol's own streets and taken two children from the copyists' row; set now under the new count it was the year the coastal lights first burned dubhan, and she found she had to search her own memory for the fever and the cold spring, which had not moved an inch in the record but seemed, set beside the new heading, to have slipped a little further back than they had stood the night before.

"It is a strange thing," she said to Sileas, somewhere past the ninth ledger, "to find that a year does not change by being renamed, and yet somehow does."

"Which is the truer year, then," Sileas asked, "the one you lived, or the one the council has just given it?"

1. the Dubhan Era (DE); lit. 'the era of Dubhan'

Beathag considered this longer than the question perhaps deserved, turning her pen between two fingers the way she did when a thing wanted more thought than the first answer she could have given it. "Both," she said at last. "I lived the year I lived, cold spring and fever and all, and no proclamation touches that. But I did not live it knowing what it was, and the council has just told the whole kingdom what it was, all at once, fourteen years after the fact. I expect that is what a proclamation is for. It does not change what happened. It only tells the ones who lived through it what they were living through at the time, which they could not have known, being in the middle of it."

She finished the fourteenth ledger a little before the light came up, and set it on the pile with the others, and sat a while with her hands flat on the table before she drew the fifteenth toward her, which wanted no turning, only a new heading at its head to match the fourteen behind it. She wrote *Linn an Dubhain, a' chòigeamh bliadhna deug* at the top of the open page, the fifteenth year of Linn an Dubhain, in the same square hand as always, and found, setting the pen down, that her hand was not quite steady, though she could not have said whether it was the hour or the work.

At the foot of that same page, under the day's entries, which were themselves nothing more than the depot letter she had copied the week before and a note of a birth at Muileann chaol she had taken down for the town's own roll, she wrote one line more, in a hand smaller than her working hand, as though she meant it less for the record than for herself, though she let it stand once written and never struck it: *Cha b' fheudar dhomb riamb roimhe bliadhna a ghluasad 's mi beò innte*. Never before have I had to move a year I was living in.

Sileas, reading it over her shoulder as she blotted the page, said nothing for a moment, and then asked whether it was meant to go into the fair copy that went up to the council each quarter.

"It can go in," Beathag said. "I've no wish to hide it. But copy it exactly as it stands, and don't smooth the grammar. I wrote it tired, and I'd sooner the council saw that I wrote it tired than have it think a chronicler writes such a thing at her ease."

IV

Of the Plain Seal

The letter from the mint at Cathair dhearg came up a month later, in the first week of an t-Ògmhios, over the signature of its master but in a hand Beathag recognised before she reached the signature at all, because she had had one letter from that hand before, three years past, asking whether an Leabharlann¹ kept any record of the old ink-recipe's origin, and had answered that it did not, only the recipe, which the mint already had.

Gille-Easbaig Bàn wrote now to say that the mint had cut new dies for the coin's seal, the first change to the seal since Fearchar Bonn's own day, and that the coal ink, ground from vein coal at a cost that had climbed every year of his own service at the mint until it stood, that spring, higher than the seal's whole worth in coin, was pressed into no die of the new coinage at all. The new seal showed the kingdom's mark plain, in the same silver as the coin, with no colour worked into it, and he wrote, in a line Beathag thought carried more feeling than the rest of the letter allowed him to show, that he did not know whether he was glad of it or sorry, having spent twelve years grinding an ink he would now never grind again, and having no pupil of his own yet to whom the losing of that knowledge might matter one way or the other.

He wrote last, as though it were an afterthought and not, Beathag thought, the true reason he had troubled to write to her at all rather than let the council's own notice carry the news: that Fearchar Bonn's first dies, the ones that had struck the kingdom's very first coin in the old counting-house at Cathair dhearg, and had been kept at the mint ever since, more relic than tool, past any use but the honour of having been first, were the council's to dispose of now that the seal they had cut was no longer the kingdom's seal, and the council had ordered them sent to an Leabharlann, to be kept there rather than melted, because a die that had struck the kingdom's first coin was thought worth more as a kept thing than as the little weight of silver it would fetch broken up.

They came up ten days later, wrapped in oiled cloth in a box no bigger than a loaf, carried by a mounted courier of An t-Ionmhas² who would not leave them with anyone but the keeper himself and made Ragnall sign a paper before he would hand the box over, though what the paper said neither Ragnall nor Beathag could afterward agree, having both signed it without reading it closely in their eagerness to open the box.

The dies themselves were smaller than either of them had expected, two flat discs of worn steel, the king's old mark on one face of each so shallow with age

and use that it wanted a slant of lamplight to read at all. Ragnall turned them over twice in his hands before he set them, at Beathag's own suggestion, in the glass case in the front room where Clach-mhionnan nan Gualadairean³ already stood, the two things side by side under one pane of glass, a stone worn smooth by two generations of hewers' thumbs and a pair of dies worn smooth by more strikings than any ledger had troubled to count, neither of them any use now to the trade that had made them.

"It is a strange sort of case we are building," Ragnall said, setting the last of the dust from his hands. "Everything that comes into it has just stopped being used."

"That is what a library is for, in the end," Beathag said. "Not only the things still in use. Someone has to keep the things that have stopped."

V

Of the Two Letters

The Àrd-choimheadaiche¹'s letter reached an Leabharlann² in the last week of an t-Iuchar, sent, as his letters always were, over the seal of Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail³ at the southern Seann Skell and in his own close, old-fashioned hand, which Beathag had come, over the years of her office, to read almost as easily as her own.

Alasdair mac Ìomhair wrote to the council, and sent a copy, as courtesy required, to an Leabharlann for its record, protesting the plain seal in terms he had plainly weighed with some care, for the letter carried none of the heat his earlier letters, on lesser matters, had sometimes shown. The coal ink pressed into every coin the kingdom had struck since Fearchar Bonn's day, whatever the mint's masters might now call it in their accounts, was a mark, he wrote: every hand that touched the coin, market-woman or minister, had touched it knowing that the kingdom's own wealth rested, in the last account, on the vein An Creideamh Sean⁴ had always held sacred. A seal struck plain, in silver alone, with no colour of

1. the Library at Muileann chaol

2. the Treasury

3. the oath-stone of coal of the Guild of Hewers

1. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

2. the Library at Muileann chaol

3. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

the coal in it anywhere, said to every hand that touched it thereafter that the kingdom no longer held that to be so, whatever the council's clerks might answer if asked outright. Withdrawal of the seal he did not ask. He asked only that the council say, in its own words and not through a mint-master's accounting, whether it meant by the change what he took it to mean.

The council's answer came within the fortnight, shorter than the custodian's own letter by more than half, over the signature of the councillor Beathag guessed, from the clerk's earlier letter of an Cèitean, had moved the proclamation in the first place, though the answer named no mover, only the council as a body. It said that the coin's seal had never, at any sitting of the council since the mint was first set up, been declared a holy thing by any resolution the council's own minutes could show; that the coal ink had been pressed into it because coal was, at the time, the surest reserve the kingdom held to stand behind its coin, and for no other reason the record kept; and that the council, in changing the reserve to match the fuel the kingdom now in fact used, had changed nothing it had ever said was sacred, because it had never said any such thing to begin with. The letter closed with a single sentence that carried, Beathag thought reading it the first time and thought again reading it the fifth, more weight than its own plainness seemed to want to admit: that the council held no vein and no fuel sacred, and never had, and that if the custodian's houses had taught otherwise these fourteen years, the teaching was theirs, and not the kingdom's.

She copied both letters whole into the day's page, the custodian's first and the council's after it, in the order they had come to her, and set no note of her own between them or beneath them, though she sat a long while at the table after the second was copied, the pen dry in her hand, before she blotted the page and closed the ledger for the night.

It was, she thought, setting the ledger back on its shelf among the fourteen others and the fifteenth still open beside them, one of the few places in the whole of her record, in all her years at the desk, where the kingdom had been asked outright what it held to be true, and had answered the question rather than let it stand unanswered as such questions were more often let stand; and it had answered, when it came to it, that it had never held what everyone had long taken it to hold, coal or council or custodian alike, and had never troubled, until a plain-seal coin and a custodian's letter forced the words out of it, to say so.

She did not write that thought into the record. It was only her own reading of a fact, and she had long held that a chronicler's readings belonged in her own head, not in the ledger, however much they might colour the choosing of what she set down and what she let pass. But she thought it again, walking back from the front room to her own small chamber under the eaves, the last light of an t-Iuchar still pale in the sky though the hour was late, and thought that a kingdom that had just said, in writing and for the first time, what it did not believe, might in time be asked what it did, and that she did not know, setting her lamp down for the night, whether that question, when it came, would be as easily answered as this one had been.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

OF the MEETING at Muileann Àrsaidh

DE 16

Part Three: Of the Holdouts of the Western Hills

B' fheàrr leinn a bhith fuar còmba ri ar nàbaidhean na blàth leinn fhèin. We would sooner be cold with our neighbours than warm alone.

— the delegates of Àth naomh, DE 16

I

Of the Pit Captain's Daughter

In the western hills they still tell it that Calder of Àth leathan went down to his own pit for the last time in the dark of an Gearran, three weeks before he died, and would let no one carry his lamp for him though his hands by then shook too much to trust with a naked flame. He had cut coal at Àth leathan for six-and-thirty years, boy and man, and captained the pit for twenty of them, and the black cough that took him in the end was no stranger to that village; it had taken his own father before him, and it would take others after, and nobody in the hills thought to call it anything but the price of the seam.

Ruth was with him when the last of it came. She had kept his tally-books since she was twelve, first because her hand was steadier than his after a day underground and later because it was simply understood between them that the books were hers to keep; and she sat by his bed those last nights with the ledger open on her knee more from habit than any thought that the work in it still wanted doing, while her mother, dead herself these nine years, was spoken of only once, near the

end, when Calder said her name and then said nothing else that Ruth could make sense of. He died a little before first light on the ninth day of the month, in the small stone house above the pit-head that had been his father's before him, and the village buried him two days after in the plot behind the chapel where the Àth leathan dead had been laid since before anyone living could say.

It was at the pit-head, not the chapel, that the choosing was made, on the evening of the burial, with the light going and the wind coming up cold off the hills. There was no guild left in the west to make it formal; Comann nan Gualadairean¹ had dissolved itself four years before, and the western pits, small and poor and half-forgotten by any board that might once have cared, had never troubled the guild's rolls much in any case. What there was instead was thirty-one hewers of Àth leathan standing about the pit-head in their working clothes because they had come straight from the last shift, and old Angus Rennie, who had cut coal longer than any man there but Calder himself, saying what everyone had already half decided among themselves in the two days since Calder took to his bed for good.

"He kept the books and he kept the peace," Angus said, "and he knew every seam in this hill better than any man breathing, saving one." He kept his own eyes on the pit-head's winch as he said it; every other eye in the crowd turned to Ruth. "I'll not stand up here and pretend I know another man fit to take his place at short notice. But I know who kept his books alongside him five years and more, and knows the seams near as well as he did, and I'll stand behind her if the rest of you will."

Nobody spoke against it. The hewers of Àth leathan had, Ruth understood afterward, no settled notion at all of a woman standing where her father had stood; what they had was a memory of her running messages down the pit road with her father's dinner in a cloth as a child, and of watching her keep his books through two winters when his eyes had begun to fail him, and too little time, with the light going and the ground cooling under their feet, to think of anyone else to ask. Ruth said yes because there was nothing else to say, standing at the pit-head in her father's own worn coat, which she had put on that morning without thinking because it was cold and it was there, and because a man handed her, without a word, the small brass lamp that had been Calder's own since his own father died,

1. the Guild of Hewers; lit. 'the fellowship of the colliers'

its case dented from thirty years of being carried down and up again. She took it because there was nowhere else for it to go.

Sleep would not come to her that night. She sat up instead with the ledger open before her, as she had a hundred nights before, and found that for the first time in her life there was no one to hand it to when the figures were entered and the page was done.

II

Of Sarah Dunmore's Kitchen

Word of the meeting at Muileann àrsaidh had been going round the western hills since the turn of the year, carried by carriers and by the hewers who still walked between the pit towns on Sundays to see kin, and by the time Ruth set out on the hill path in the first week of am Màrt, ten miles by the short way over the shoulder of the moor, she went as Àth leathan's delegate without having asked to be one or having been asked in any form she could afterward have pointed to. It was simply understood, the way the choosing at the pit-head had been understood, that the pit captain went where the pit towns' business was done, and that this was pit towns' business if anything in the hills was.

She had never before walked so far alone. The path ran up over open ground where the wind had nothing to break it and down again through a stand of birch where the last of the winter's snow still lay in the shadow of the trunks, and she came into Muileann àrsaidh a little after noon with her boots wet through and her father's lamp, unlit, swinging from her hand because she had brought it without quite deciding to and had not liked to leave it behind once it was in her pocket.

Sarah Dunmore's house stood at the foot of the town's one street, a stone house no larger than its neighbours, with a good peat fire already going in the kitchen grate when Ruth came to the door and a smell of broth that told her the house had been feeding people for some days before she arrived. Sarah herself, a broad, plain-spoken widow of some thirty years past her own husband's death under a fall of stone at the Muileann àrsaidh pit, had put her kitchen at the meeting's disposal without being asked twice, on the reasoning, as she gave it to Ruth within an hour of her arrival, that a kitchen fed people and a hall did not, and that men who had walked ten or fifteen miles over hill paths in the wet would talk bet-

ter with something hot in front of them than they would in a cold room with nothing but a table.

There were seven of them crowded round that table by the time the light began to go: two from Muileann àrsaidh itself, an old hewer named Fraser and a younger man called Meikle who did most of the town's writing; a heavy, careful man named Drummond who had walked over from Cnoc thais that morning on Tom Varley's errand, Varley himself being kept at home by a knee that had never mended right since a fall the winter before; a thin, watchful woman called Nan Ross who spoke for the few families left at Tobar dhearg of the hills, where the one pit barely kept forty hewers in work; and Sarah Dunmore herself, who was no delegate of anywhere but sat at the head of her own table as though the question of whether she belonged in the talk had never once occurred to her.

Ruth said little that first evening. She was the youngest at the table by a dozen years and more, new to the captaincy by less than a fortnight, and she had come, she told herself, to listen before she spoke; but she listened hard, and what she heard, under the talk of prices and the talk of the south and the talk of what Tìonal nan Tuathach¹ might or might not do, was that none of the six people in that kitchen had any clear notion yet of what they wanted the towns to agree to, only a clear and common notion of what they would not agree to, which was to fold their pits and buy their fire from the south like every other town in the north had done.

"We're none of us saying we won't sell to the south's fuel-men, mind," Fraser said, late in the evening, with the fire down to embers and Sarah moving quietly about the room banking it for the night. "Only that we'll keep cutting what we cut, and sell it to whoever in the north still wants coal, and not be told by any charter that we've no business doing it."

"That's a thing worth saying," Ruth said, the first full sentence she had put into the room all evening, "but it wants saying plainer than that, or it'll be argued over as long as it's talked and never once written down." She felt every face at the table turn to her, and pressed on before she could think better of it. "My father kept books thirty years. A thing not written down plain enough to read back is a thing that gets remembered five different ways by five different people inside a twelvemonth."

1. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

Sarah Dunmore, from the hearth, laughed once, short and approving. "There's Calder's own daughter talking," she said. "Well. If it wants writing plain, who's for the writing of it?"

Nobody answered for a moment. Then Drummond nodded slowly across the table at Ruth, and Fraser after him, and Ruth understood, with something between pride and a plain cold weight settling in her chest, that the pen, like the lamp, had been handed to her before she had thought to reach for it.

They talked past midnight, though little more of it went into any settled shape that night. Meikle set down on a scrap of paper, for his own memory more than the meeting's, the figures Drummond had brought from Cnoc thais: what a sack of dubhan cost delivered to a northern door against what a sack of their own coal cost cut and carted, and how the second sum had crept up year on year as fewer hands stayed to cut it, until it stood now not far below the first. Nan Ross said little beyond agreeing that Tobar dhearg's forty hewers would go on cutting whatever the meeting decided, since forty hewers with nothing else to do were no argument at all; and Sarah, setting bread and a jug of milk on the table without being asked, said once that she had buried a husband under this town's coal and would sooner see her neighbours burn it than see the pit stand idle over his grave, which nobody in the kitchen thought needed answering. Ruth slept that night in a box-bed off Sarah's own kitchen, with the fire's last heat coming through the wall behind her, and lay a long while listening to the house settle before sleep took her, turning over in her mind the shape of a paper that did not yet exist.

III

Of the Pit-shed and the Agreement

The kitchen held them well enough for talk, but by the second day word had gone round the town and more had come than Sarah's table would seat: hewers from Muileann àrsaidh itself who wanted to hear with their own ears what was being said in their name, two more men down from Cnoc thais on Tom Varley's second errand once his knee let him send them, and, on the third morning, a boy on a borrowed pony from Tobar dhearg with a note in Nan Ross's own hand asking that nothing be signed before she'd had the chance to read it over once more herself, which raised a laugh even from Nan when it was

read aloud, since she was sitting at the table not three feet from where the note was opened.

They moved the talk to the pit-shed above the town, a long low building of stone and turf where Muileann àrsaidh kept its winches and its spare timber and, in the corner nearest the door, a bench worn smooth by three generations of hewers changing their boots before a shift. It smelled of tar and damp rope and old coal-dust, and it held, once the benches were cleared and set in rows, near forty people at a squeeze, which was more, Ruth thought, looking round it on that first morning, than she had ever seen gathered in one room in her life.

She wrote the agreement's terms on three sheets of Meikle's paper over the course of that day and the next, crossing out more than she kept, while the room argued each line before it was let stand. It was slower work than she had thought book-keeping had prepared her for; a line she thought plain enough to need no more discussion could still draw an hour's argument from men who had different notions of what "the seams" meant, whether it took in Tobar dhearg's single pit as well as Cnoc thais's dozen workings, or whether "any household in the north that will buy" meant houses in the south too if a southern buyer somehow wanted northern coal, which nobody thought likely but several thought worth saying plainly all the same.

The hardest of it, in the end, was the leaving out. A man from Muileann àrsaidh's own row of hewers, a squat, red-faced man called Dodds, stood up on the second afternoon and wanted a line put in naming the fuel-fitters of the south by name, and the charter that shut Tuathaich hands out of the new trade besides, so that whoever read the agreement after would know exactly whose doing the five towns' trouble was. Ruth let him talk himself to a stop before she answered, because she had learned already, in two days of it, that the room argued better with a thing than against a man. "Name them," she said, "and the paper stops being about coal and starts being about grievance, and a grievance is a thing folk argue with. Five towns cutting their own coal and selling it plain is a thing folk can only agree to or leave be." Dodds sat down without much grace, but he signed the sheet three days later along with the rest of Muileann àrsaidh's hewers, which Ruth took, privately, for the better half of an answer.

What stood, in the end, in the hand Ruth had written it in, was shorter than any single hour of the argument that had shaped it. The five towns of the western hills — though only four were named in that first writing — would go on working their seams as they had always worked them, taking up no man's charter and

asking none, and would sell their coal to any household of the north that came to buy it, at whatever price buyer and seller could agree between them, and to no household that did not come freely asking. It said nothing against the fuel from the south, and nothing for it. Of Tional nan Tuathach¹, which none of the four towns present had asked to be part of the meeting, it said nothing at all, and none proposed to write to it now. Its last line, which Ruth added herself and read aloud to the shed before anyone else saw it, promised that the towns signing it would stand by each other in the keeping of it, for as long as any of them had coal left to sell.

Fraser signed for Muileann àrsaidh, Drummond for Cnoc thais, Nan Ross for Tobar dhearg once the boy had ridden the finished sheet back to her and she had, true to her note, read it over twice before putting her own mark beside her name. Ruth signed last, for Àth leathan, in the same hand she had used for her father's tally-books, on a morning in the third week of am Màrt with the pit-shed's one small window letting in a grey light that had not yet decided whether it would rain, and felt, setting her name under the others, that she had put more of herself into those three short sheets than into anything she had done in her life before that week.

IV

Of the Town that Would Not Be Warm Alone

Àth naomh sent no one to the meeting at Muileann àrsaidh that am Màrt, and for the better part of a month afterward the agreement stood signed by four towns and spoken of by the fourth as though it were finished business. It was in an Giblean, with the pit-shed's turf roof dripping steadily under a fortnight of rain, that two delegates came over the hill path from Àth naomh on a wet Tuesday and asked, without much in the way of preamble, to be let sign what the others had already signed.

Àth naomh had the least to offer of any of the five: a handful of old shafts worked thin, a temple and a citadel from an older age that the town's few hundred souls now kept more from habit than any wealth to defend, and coal enough, by its own delegates' plain accounting, to warm perhaps two winters

1. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

more before the seams gave out entirely. It would have cost the town nothing, several in the shed pointed out, and might have spared it a hard winter or two, simply to go over to the south's fuel as every other northern town but these four already had; and it was the elder of the two delegates, a stooped, grey-bearded man named Ferguson who had walked the hill path with a stick in either hand, who answered that argument standing in the middle of the pit-shed floor with the rain loud on the roof above him.

"We could burn dubhan same as any town in the north," he said. "We've thought on it, don't doubt that we have, thought on it hard through two cold winters running. But we'd be burning it alone among our own hills, with every neighbour we've got still cutting coal at the seam, and I'll tell you plainly what we decided, the whole town of us, over it." He looked round the shed, at faces he mostly did not know, and said the thing as though he had carried it the whole ten miles from Àth naomh rehearsing exactly how he would say it. "We'd sooner be cold with our neighbours than warm alone."

Nobody in the shed answered that at once. Ruth, sitting near the front with the signed agreement still in its folder on her knee, found that she had nothing to add to it that would not have made it smaller, and said only, after a silence that went on long enough to be its own kind of answer, that there was room on the sheet for a fifth name, and would he care to write it himself or have her write it for him. He wrote it himself, in a hand less steady than Ruth's own but legible enough, and his companion after him, and by the time the two of them set off back over the hill path that same wet afternoon, unwilling to be a night's board and lodging on a town no better off than their own, the agreement of Muileann àrsaidh carried the names of all five.

By an Cèitean, with the worst of the spring rain past and the hill paths dry enough to walk without ruining a pair of boots in an afternoon, the five towns had become, in the mouths of everyone in the western hills and a good many people well beyond them, simply the holdout towns, and Ruth Calder, one-and-forty years old and less than three months a pit captain in her own right, had become, without any second choosing to mark the change, the person whose name was given when anyone from outside the hills asked who spoke for them. She had not asked for that either. It came to her the way the lamp had come to her, and the pen after it, because there was no one else at hand when the asking was done, and because she had shown, in the writing of three short sheets, that she could put a thing down plainly and stand behind it after.

Tional nan Tuathach¹, when word of the agreement reached it, did neither of the two things the five towns had half expected it might do. It did not send a delegate north to add Tional nan Tuathach's own name to the sheet, as one or two in the pit-shed had hoped it might; and it did not send word condemning the towns for standing apart from a trade the rest of the north had gone over to whole. It sent nothing at all, so far as Ruth or anyone in the hills ever learned, beyond a bare line in its own minute-book, copied out for her by a carrier some weeks later at her own asking, that noted the towns' agreement had been reported to Tional nan Tuathach and that Tional nan Tuathach, having heard it, saw no cause to act upon it either way. She read the line twice, standing in her own kitchen at Àth leathan with her father's lamp on the shelf where she had set it the night of his burial, and understood it for what it plainly was: the sound of a door being left exactly as it stood, neither opened nor shut, by people who had decided that the five towns' trouble was, for the present, none of theirs to have an opinion about.

V

Of the Two Shafts at Cnoc thais

Tom Varley's knee mended slowly through the summer of that year, and it was not until an t-Samhain, with the first hard frosts already whitening the moor grass in the mornings, that he was fit again to walk the length of his own pit workings at Cnoc thais without a stick; and it was in that same month, once he could stand a full day underground, that he set two dozen of his hewers to opening again a pair of shafts on the hill's northern face that had lain shut, by every account the town could give of them, since before An Dealachadh¹, when the men who dug them had been of another people entirely and the coal they left behind had been thought too thin and too far in to be worth a second working.

It was thin, when Varley's men reached it, and it was harder cutting than the town's main seams, and the first cartload brought up from it, in the last week of the month, burned with more smoke and less heat than any coal Cnoc thais had cut in living memory. Nobody in the town complained of it. It was set that same

1. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

1. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

week on a dozen hearths across Cnoc thais, in houses that had been buying their fire in from Muileann àrsaidh at a price the winter made harder to bear each year, and the town's own account of it, which reached Ruth by way of a letter from Varley himself a fortnight later, said only that the coal was poor, and that it was theirs, and that a poor fire of one's own cutting warmed a house no worse than a good one bought dear from a neighbour.

Varley wrote, too, that the two old shafts had given up more than coal in the opening of them: a broken pick-head of a make none of his hewers knew, and, in the second shaft, a length of rotted timber shoring still holding the roof up after however many years it had stood there, which his men had left untouched rather than risk the roof coming down on the strength of curiosity alone. He asked, half in earnest, whether Ruth thought it worth writing to Leabharlann Muileann chaol² about the pick-head, and answered his own question in the same letter before she could: that a chronicler's clerk two days' ride away would take more interest in an old iron head than any of the five towns could spare the time to satisfy, and that the shaft wanted working, not wondering over, with the winter coming on and Cnoc thais's own hearths waiting on it.

Ruth read the letter at her own table at Àth leathan on an evening in the first week of an Dùbhlachd, with the year's business behind her and the next year's not yet begun, and found in it, more than in anything that had happened since the pit-shed at Muileann àrsaidh, the whole of what the five towns had agreed to be. It was not a victory, Varley's letter said as much as it said anything; it was thin coal from an old working, burning worse than the coal it replaced, in houses that would rather have had better. But it was the hills' own, cut by the hills' own hands, out of ground the hills had never given up, and Ruth understood, reading it a second time by the last of the evening light, that this was the whole of the bargain the five towns had made with each other in am Màrt and would go on making, winter after winter, for as long as any seam among them held coal enough to be worth the cutting.

She sat a long while at the table after the letter was folded away, with her father's lamp burning low on the shelf and a fresh sheet of paper set out in front of her, blank, because Fraser had written from Muileann àrsaidh that week asking whether it would not be worth a letter to one or two of the northern towns still undecided about their fire, laying the five towns' case out plain the way the agree-

2. the Library at Muileann chaol

ment had been laid out plain, in case there were households elsewhere in the north still minded to buy coal from a neighbour rather than dubhan from the south. It was, Ruth thought, turning the pen over once in her fingers before she began, exactly the kind of asking her father would have turned to her without a second thought, the way every asking since the pit-head in an Gearran had come to her without her once being asked whether she wanted it; and she understood, dipping the pen at last, that there would be a great many more such letters before the seams at Àth leathan or Cnoc thais or any of the five towns ran thin enough to end the need of them, and that she, and no one else, would be the one sitting at a table some cold evening each year of it, finding the words.

Of the Eleven Books

DE 17

I

Of Cathair gheal

Tobar dhearg of the hills was the least of the five holdout towns, and knew it, and made no complaint of it. It had one pit and forty hewers, a red well the Dia-thìrich had dug long before An Dealachadh¹ and the Tuathaich had kept digging after, and a track down through the western hills that a cart could just take if the carter walked at the horse's head the whole way. What the pit raised was poor coal, sooty and quick to crumble, no match for the seams of Muileann àrsaidh or Cnoc thais; but it burned, and the walled town of Cathair gheal on the coast below had no coal of its own at all, only boats. So twice in the month, when the weather served, a cart went down from Tobar dhearg loaded with sacks, and came back loaded with fish salted in barrels, and the arrangement had held so long that nobody in either town could have said which had thought of it first.

Ellen Marsh came down to Cathair gheal on the carrier's cart that brought the fish north, in the raw first days of an Gearran, with her satchel on her knees and her notebook wrapped in oilcloth against the spray off the harbour road. She had made the journey a dozen times in as many years, for one reason or another, and always for the same true reason underneath the others: there was, in that walled town of white stone with the sea on three sides of it, an old woman named Annie Drew who had been a child at An Dealachadh, and who had said, the last time Ellen sat with her, that she did not think she would keep another winter.

1. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

She had kept it. Ellen found her sitting up in the kitchen of her daughter's house by the harbour wall, wrapped to the chin though the fire was well built with Tobar dhearg's coal, her hands gone to knuckle and vein, her eyes still quick. She was ninety-one that winter, the oldest soul in Cathair gheal by some years, and the only one left who had been more than an infant when the parting came.

"You're earlier than I looked for," Annie said, by way of greeting, "or I'm later than I looked for. One or the other."

"The fish cart wanted an early tide."

"It always does." Annie nodded at the stool by the fire, which had plainly been set there for her before Ellen arrived, and Ellen sat and unwrapped the notebook and found the place where the last visit had left off, a third of the way down a page, in her own small hand: *she was five, or near it. her mother would not let her look back at the smoke.*

"You'll want the rest of that," Annie said.

"If you're willing."

"I said I'd give it you before I die, and I mean to keep to that whatever else I don't keep to." She was quiet a moment, working her hands together in her lap, and then she began, in the humans' tongue, which she kept to by long habit and never troubled to leave for Dia-thìris even with those, like Ellen, who had both equally. Ellen wrote as she talked, in Dia-thìris, since that was the hand she wrote fastest and truest, and stopped her now and again only to ask a name again, or a distance, or which of two roads.

It was not a long telling, in the end, though it had taken eleven years to get the whole of it, a little at a time, out of a woman who did not care to dwell on it and would not be hurried past it either. The smoke over the fires they had left burning to make the parting look sudden, though it had been three weeks in the planning by the time the household stirred that night. The stones set new along the road, white and raw, not yet grown over, that her father called the boundary though there had been no boundary the week before. A soldier at the last of them who had given her mother bread out of his own satchel and would not meet her mother's eye while he did it. The long walk after, and the fires lit along it each evening smaller than the one before, until by the fourth night there was coal enough only for a handful of families to share one fire between them, and the rest went cold, and nobody spoke of that afterward either, not for years, not until an old woman sat by a stranger's fire built of Tobar dhearg's crumbling coal and found she had, after ninety winters, one telling left to give away.

"That's the whole of it," Annie said, when she had done. "You've the bones of it from me twice over already. This is only the flesh."

"It's the flesh I wanted." Ellen read the last page back to her, low, so as not to wake the sleeping cat that had climbed into Annie's lap somewhere in the telling, and Annie listened with her eyes shut and said, at the end, that it would do, and that Ellen had got the soldier's bread right, which was the part she had always feared losing between one visit and the next.

"That's the last of them, isn't it," Annie said then. "You've been round the whole coast for it. There's none left older than me this side of Muileann àrsaidh, and she's simple, poor soul, hasn't known her own name since the fever three winters back."

"You're the last," Ellen said. She did not pretend otherwise; Annie was not a woman it did any good to spare.

"Well." Annie stroked the cat once, the length of its back, and looked into the fire a while. "I've kept my word, then. See you keep yours."

"I mean to."

"Mean isn't do. But I'll not live to see which, so you may tell me what you like." She said it without bitterness, the way she said most things, as a fact laid down and left to lie, and Ellen closed the notebook over the last page and did not answer that, because there was no true answer to give her that was also a kind one.

She stayed the night, as she always did, in the loft above the kitchen, and in the morning she walked down to the harbour before the fish cart was loaded and stood a while at the wall in the cold light, looking out past the white walls to the grey water. A boat was coming in from the night's fishing, low and slow, and up on the hill road behind the town a cart was coming down from Tobar dhearg with its load of sacks, the carter walking at the horse's head. She watched the two of them come toward each other, the boat and the cart, as they had come toward each other, she supposed, a thousand times before her, and thought of Annie Drew asleep in the house behind her with the cat still warm in her lap, and of the notebook wrapped in oilcloth in the satchel at Ellen's own feet, and of how little either the boat or the cart, going about their trade, cared for the telling folded inside it.

The schoolroom at Doire ghlas, by the time Ellen came home, had gone back nine years to being nothing but a schoolroom, the tables in their rows again under the alphabet painted round the walls in both hands, the stove drawing well, no smell of paste in it any longer to speak of. But in the low cupboard at the back, under lock, stood ten books, bound in plain grey board by her own hand over eleven winters, each lettered on the spine with a year and nothing more, and it was to these that Ellen went first, before she had so much as taken off her coat, to lay the notebook from Cathair gheal on top of them and stand looking down at the row.

She had begun the work almost by accident, the year she came to teach at Agnes Pike's old school, when an old man of the parish had stopped her in the lane to correct something she had told the children about An Dealachadh¹, a small thing, a date got wrong by a generation, and had gone on, once started, to tell her the true year and a good deal besides that she had never read in any book because it was written in none. She had gone home that evening and set it down before she forgot the half of it, and the next week had asked another, and the week after another, and had not, in eleven years, found a way to stop, though she had several times found reasons she ought to.

What she had, by the winter that closed the seventeenth year, was eleven books: the tellings of some two hundred old men and women of the north, taken down as near their own words as her pen could keep pace with, town by town, coast to hill, An Dealachadh and the years straight after it, the first winters, the boundary stones, the names of those who had not lived to cross them. No two tellings agreed in everything. She had learned early to let that stand rather than smooth it, and had written, in the front of the first book, a line to say so: that where two witnesses differed she had set down both, and let the reader judge, as a court would.

She worked through the first week of an Gearran binding the eleventh volume herself, at her own table by lamplight, with the flat bone folder Daniel Frayne's eldest binder had given her nine winters before, when the two of them had sat up late in this same room over Tional nan Tuathach²'s own sixty-three books and Ellen had asked, more from curiosity than any plan, to be shown how the stitching went. The binder had shown her, and left her the folder after, saying that a body

1. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

2. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

who kept books ought to know how to mend one, and Ellen had used it every winter since on her own small work, though never so fine as the binder's own.

She had thought, more than once through those years, of asking the binders of Muileann leathan to do this last one properly, since they were near and willing and it would have taken them an evening where it took her three, but had always come back to doing it herself. It seemed to her, though she could not have said quite why to another person, that a book made of other people's own words asked to be sewn by the same hand that had taken them down, and not passed on for finishing to someone who had never sat by any of those fires.

When it was done she laid it at the end of the row, and it was, by an inch's difference in the grey board, exactly the same as the other ten, and the row of eleven stood the length of a hand-span on the cupboard shelf, and held, she reckoned without troubling to count it exactly, the better part of two hundred lives that would otherwise have gone into the ground with nothing to show that they had been lived at all.

She wrote the letter to an Leabharlann³ the same evening, at the same table, in a fair hand she kept for such things and did not often need. Four sentences held the whole of it. It set down what An t-Aon Leabhar Deug⁴ were and how they had been gathered, over how many years and from how many mouths, and asked, in the plain form such requests took, that Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁵ receive them and keep them beside its own record, as a thing belonging to the shires as much as any royal minute or council return. Nowhere did it ask that the books be believed over the written record where the two crossed; the whole of the asking was that they be kept where a person who wanted to know might come and find them, the way a person could come and find the reign of any king. Ellen read it over twice, found nothing in it she wished to soften, sealed it, and sent it north the following week by the library carrier who came through Doire ghlais each month with the shires' returns, An t-Aon Leabhar Deug wrapped together in oil-cloth and tied with the same waxed thread the binders of Muileann leathan had taught her to use.

3. the Library at Muileann chaol

4. the eleven books of Tuathaich accounts gathered by Ellen Marsh over eleven years and offered to the Library

5. the Library at Muileann chaol

III

Of the Letter Laid on the Table

The answer was five months in coming, which did not surprise her, since she had asked five months' worth of a plain answer and had not, in her heart, expected one at all.

It came in an Lùnastal, on a hot still evening when the children had long since gone home and Ellen was alone in the schoolroom totting the term's slates before she put them away for the summer. The carrier brought it up from the harbour road himself rather than leaving it at the school gate, a courtesy he did not often trouble with, and stood a moment at the door turning his cap in his hands before he gave it over, as if he had already guessed, by its weight or its seal, that it was not the kind of letter a man handed across a threshold and walked away from.

It was in Raghnaill mac Mhuirich's own hand, which she knew from the flyleaf of every one of her own books, since he had written a line in each on the day it was carried in, acknowledging its receipt, always the same few words. This was longer. Her request, he wrote, and An t-Aon Leabhar Deug¹ with it, had been laid before the keepers of an Leabharlann² in the spring, read entire, and set upon the table of the council's business, where it remained, not refused. The question the request raised, as he set it out, touched the books themselves hardly at all, since he did not doubt they were honestly made; it turned instead on what standing an Leabharlann ought to give to witness that came by the mouth and not by the pen, set down at second or third hand by one recorder's own judgment of what to keep and what to leave. This was a question Comhairle na Rìoghachd³ had not yet given its view on, in this matter or in any other that had come before it in like form, and until it did, Neach-gleidhidh an Leabharlainn⁴ had no more authority to shelve eleven books of spoken telling beside the shires' own returns than he had to strike a line through any of those returns on his own word that they were wrong. Sorry to send so little for so much labour, he hoped she would believe the labour was not lost for being unanswered, since a thing once written did not become less true for waiting.

1. the eleven books of Tuathaich accounts gathered by Ellen Marsh over eleven years and offered to the Library

2. the Library at Muileann chaol

3. the royal council of twelve

4. the keeper of the Library

Ellen read it twice at the window, where the light was better, and then sat down at the nearest table with it still in her hand.

She was not, in the ordinary way, a woman given to sitting idle over a letter. But there was, in the reading of it, a particular kind of stillness that came over her, not anger exactly, or not only anger, more the stillness of a sum that has been added correctly and come out wrong. She thought of Annie Drew's hands working together in her lap, and of the soldier's bread that Annie had feared losing between one telling and the next, and of the ninety winters it had taken to bring that one small true thing to a page, only to have it weighed now, by a kind man in a good hand, against a standard it could never by its nature meet, since a soldier's bread given at a roadside leaves no return for any clerk to enter.

She did not doubt that Ragnall mac Mhuirich meant every word of his sorrow, nor that he had done, within the room he had, as much as the room allowed; she had heard, from more than one quarter, how the man had found money out of his own small fund to keep a girl clerk in dry stockings when the council would give him none for the purpose, and she did not think a man of that stamp wrote *not refused* as a way of refusing. That was, in its way, the worst of it. There was no one person in the whole chain of it to be angry at. The letter simply said, in its careful sentences, that An t-Aon Leabhar Deug would lie on a table until a council that had not been asked to look at them chose to, and that no one, not the keeper, not the council, not Ellen Marsh herself, could say when that might be, or whether it ever would.

IV

Of the Census Clerks

She wrote her reply the same night, before the stillness had time to cool into something more governable and less exact.

She did not write in anger, or not in any anger a reader could have pointed to in a single line; she was too careful a hand for that, and too old a teacher of grammar to let a sentence run away from her meaning. But she wrote, plainly, that she did not think the standing of spoken witness was so untried a question as the council supposed. She reminded the keeper — though she did not think he needed reminding, and said so — that when *Cunntas nan Làmh*¹ was last taken in

the shires, the clerks who came north to count the northern towns had counted nothing, but had taken the figures of every town from Tional nan Tuathach²'s own mouth, written them down on their own authority with no other proof asked or given, and that this spoken tale, and no other kind, was the figure entered afterward in the kingdom's own returns and used by Tional nan Tuathach in its dealings with the council to this day. She had seen the page herself, she wrote, in Tional nan Tuathach's own minute-book, the year the figures were read into the room and the two words written under them that were the whole of what the room had thought fit to say. If spoken witness had stood good enough, without question, to fix what a shire owed and what it was owed, she did not see by what rule it stood too uncertain to be shelved, unweighed against nothing, beside a written return that no one had ever asked to prove.

She wrote that she would not press the council to believe An t-Aon Leabhar Deug³ over anything an Leabharlann⁴ already held. She asked only, again, that they be kept where they could be found, and left the rest, as she had the first time, to whoever came after her with the patience to read them.

Nobody saw the letter before she sent it, not even Martha, who would have read it with approval and said so and perhaps, being Martha, have found some way to make it the mills' business as well as her own; Ellen wanted no more behind it than her own name. She sealed it and gave it to the carrier the next market day, and went back to the term's slates, and did not, in the weeks after, ask whether an answer had come, because she had already had the only answer there was going to be, and a second letter would only have dressed the same one differently.

V

Of the Parsing

The children came back to their benches the first week of an t-Sultain, brown from the summer and restless at their letters, and Ellen, who had spent eleven years deciding what was worth a class's morning and what was not, took Raghnaill mac Mhuirich's letter out of her satchel on the second day

1. the census of hands

2. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

3. the eleven books of Tuathaich accounts gathered by Ellen Marsh over eleven years and offered to the Library

4. the Library at Muileann chaol

and read it to them entire, standing at the front of the room with the sun coming in low and yellow through the tall north windows.

She did not tell them, at first, what it was about, only that it was a real letter, lately received, and that she wanted their ears on the words and not the matter, since the matter was hers to carry and the words were a lesson any of them might use. She read it through once without stopping, and then began again from the top, slower, and stopped this time at the end of nearly every sentence to ask a child to say what it did: here was the subject, here the thing done to it, here a clause that leaned on another and would fall without it, here a word chosen, she said, because it let a man say a great deal while appearing to promise nothing at all.

"What does 'not refused' mean?" she asked, at the sentence that held it, and a girl near the stove, quick with her tongue and quicker with her temper, said at once that it meant *no*.

"It doesn't say no."

"It means no all the same, missus."

"Then why doesn't it say so?"

The girl thought about that longer than she thought about most things, turning her slate over in her lap. "Because," she said slowly, "if he said no, you could ask him why. And there's no answering 'not yet.'"

Ellen let that stand a moment before she went on, because it was, she thought, as exact a piece of parsing as she was likely to get out of any of them that year, truer to the letter's working than half the grammar she had meant to teach from it. She showed them the long sentence in the middle, the one that turned on itself three times before it came to rest, and had them find where the turns were, and asked whether a shorter sentence could not have said the same thing, and whether, if it could, there might be a reason a careful man chose not to say it shorter. A boy at the back, who rarely had much to offer on any morning that did not involve sums, said that his father had told him once that a long fence took longer to climb than a short one, whatever height it stood, and the room laughed, and Ellen let them, and did not correct him, because he had not, in her judgment, said anything that wanted correcting.

She did not tell them, that morning, what had become of the request, only that it concerned some books she had made herself over many years, and that the letter was the answer she had had about them; and when the quick girl by the stove asked outright whether the books would go to an *Leabharlann*¹ or not, Ellen said, in the same plain voice she had used all morning on subjects and clauses, that she did not know, and that not knowing was itself a thing worth being able to say plainly, since a great many grown people spent a great deal of ink trying not to.

The lesson ran past its hour, and she let it, since the day was long and the harvest not yet calling any of them away. When at last she sent them out to the yard she folded the letter back into her satchel, along with the fair copy of her own reply that she had kept for her own record beside the eleventh book, and stood a while at the window watching them scatter across the grass in the last of the low sun, loud and unhurried, as children are who have not yet been told that a table is a place where a true thing can be laid down and left to lie.

1. the Library at Muileann chaol

Of the Leòid Rulings

DE 18

I

Of the Wool Contract

The letter that began it was not addressed to Seumas mac Eachainn at all, and he read it only because the clerk whose table it belonged to was down with a chest cold and had asked him, as a favour between neighbours at the long table, to sort what came in until she was back on her feet.

It was from Tìonal nan Tuathach's wool mills at Doire ghlais, a contract of the plainest kind, three lines longer than it needed to be only because the mill's clerk had been taught to write a full sentence and could not bring himself to stop short of one: that the mill would take its winter coal from Cnoc thais and Muileann àrsaidh, at the price those towns asked, and no longer from Comhairle nam Mèinnean's yard at Cathair mhòr, Comhairle nam Mèinnean's price having risen twice in two years while the fires under the mill's own vats burned no hotter for it. Seumas read it twice, because the first time he did not believe the figure at the foot, and filed it in the tray marked for the master's own hand, because it plainly was not his to answer.

He was forty that spring, and had been four years Comhairle nam Mèinnean's clerk at Cathair mhòr, a post he had not asked for and had not thought, at four-and-twenty riding north with Iain Ruadh mac Nèill to watch a northern fire go out, that he would ever hold. Iain Ruadh sat two tables down still, grey now past red, half deaf in the ear nearer the door, and looked at the world through the coal

1. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

he had spent his life measuring and found it, on the whole, unimproved by dubhan. He had not been north again since that first ride. He said the road was longer than it used to be, by which he meant that he was.

"There'll be more of those," Iain Ruadh said, when Seumas told him what the letter held, not looking up from the return he was totting. "The pit towns sell dear to us and cheap to their own kind. It's not a mystery. A man sells cheap where he must live after."

"It's the mills I'm thinking of. If Doire ghlas buys northern coal—"

"Then Cathair gheal will, and Cathair mhòr's own tanners after that, and in a twelvemonth every mill from here to the strait is burning coal that never paid An Crùn³'s fifth to anybody, and Comhairle nam Mèinnean's yard stands full and nobody comes for it." Iain Ruadh set down his pen. "I've seen a seam go like that. Not all at once. A gallery here, a gallery there, until one quarter you look at the returns and the whole face is gone and you cannot say the day it went."

Seumas did not answer that, because there was no answer in it that would not sound as though he were arguing with a man thirty years his elder about a mountain the man had walked underground before Seumas was born. He went back to the tray, and by the time the regular clerk was back at her table the letter from Doire ghlas had three more like it behind it, from Cathair gheal, from a tannery at Ros gheal, from a brewer at Baile ìseal who wrote that he saw no shame in warming his own vats with whatever coal came cheapest and would take no lecture on the matter from a Board that had never once, in thirty years, carried coal north of the boundary stones for a Tuathach hearth to burn.

Seumas kept that last one on his own table longer than the others.

II

Of the Quarter

The master of Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹ at Cathair mhòr was Fearghas mac Aonghais, a broad, short-necked man of Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own service who had risen to the mastership from the yard rather than from the mine office's tables, and who trusted a column of figures the way other

3. the Crown

1. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

men trusted a priest. He called for the northern returns himself in the third week of am Màrt, which he had not done in Seumas's four years at the table, and Seumas carried them in and stood while the master read.

It took him the better part of an hour to draw them properly: Comhairle nam Mèinnean's takings from every northern account, set against the same quarter of the year before, town by town, with the wool mills' new contract entered where it belonged and a note beside it in his own hand, because a note seemed to him owed. When the sum stood at the foot of the page it was down by a quarter on the year before, and by more than a quarter against the quarter before that, and no part of the fall lay anywhere but in the five holdout towns' own coal finding buyers that had once bought from Comhairle nam Mèinnean and now did not.

"A quarter," Fearghas said, when Seumas laid the page before him, and said nothing else for a while, turning the page as though a second look might find him a different sum on it. "In how long?"

"Eighteen months, master, near enough. It was steady until the wool mills went over, and it has moved faster from that month on."

"Since when has anyone in the north had coin enough to buy coal at all, that An Crùn² never saw a fifth of?"

"Since the fuel came, master. They sell the dubhan they cannot use themselves, and buy each other's coal with the coin it brings." Seumas had thought about how to say this on the ride in, turning the sentence over as a man turns a coin to see it is not counterfeit, and it came out flatter than he had meant it, which he thought afterwards was as well. "It's an honest trade between them. I've no figures that say otherwise."

Fearghas mac Aonghais looked at him for a moment in a way Seumas had not been looked at before in that office, the way a man looks at a tool to see whether it will do the next job as well as it did the last.

"Nobody asked you whether it was honest," he said, and it was not said unkindly either. "You're asked what it costs Comhairle nam Mèinnean. You've told me. Go and find me Breith Leòid³. The whole of it, not the digest. I want the words she used."

2. the Crown

3. the Leòid ruling

III

Of the Ruling Read Again

Breith Leòid had lain in Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own press for eighty years, copied twice since, once when the press at Seann Bhral burned and once, later, for no reason the docket gave, and Seumas found the newer copy within the hour and carried it to the master's room himself rather than send it by a runner, because he wanted, without admitting it even to himself, to hear how it was read.

Eilidh nic Leòid had ruled, sitting at Seann Bhral in the eighth year of the old count, that the land the Tuathaich held under the humans' title passed to An Crùn², and that the right to work it stayed with the holders and their heirs. The rulings of the circuit that followed on it, copied into the margin of Comhairle nam Mèinnean's press copy in three different hands, had settled the rest: that the holders' right ran with the payment of An Crùn's fifth and failed with it; and that nothing in the ruling bound Comhairle nam Mèinnean to carry any holder's coal it did not choose to carry. It had been written, Seumas judged from the language, to settle where the north should stand when the humans' titles fell, and it had gone on being cited for eighty years in every land case the north had brought, because it gave the holders their right in one clause and, read with its margins, let Comhairle nam Mèinnean withdraw its custom and keep its claim both.

Fearghas mac Aonghais read it through once, slowly, moving his lips over the harder clauses as a man does who reads more figures than sentences, and set it down.

"Comhairle nam Mèinnean stopped carrying from the western pits when the branch to Àth leathan was closed," he said. "Before the fuel."

"Twenty years, master, near enough. The branch closed in the sixty-eighth year of the old count. They went on paying the fifth all the same, by cart and by boat, and Comhairle nam Mèinnean entered it as arrears, until the agreement."

"And since the agreement?"

"Not from the western towns. Muileann àrsaidh, Cnoc thais, Àth naomh, Tobar dhearg and Àth leathan have paid nothing to Comhairle nam Mèinnean's account since the agreement they signed among themselves. I have the ledger, if the master wants the figure."

1. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

2. the Crown

"I don't want the figure. I know the figure." Fearghas mac Aonghais stood, which he did not often do at his own table, and went to the window, which looked out over the yard where a dubhan tank stood being filled from a cart, and said nothing for long enough that Seumas began to wonder whether he was dismissed. "Under her ruling, the right lapsed the day the fifth stopped, whatever the reason it stopped. It doesn't ask whether Comhairle nam Mèinnean's reason for not carrying was a good one. It only asks whether the fifth came in. It didn't."

"They would say Comhairle nam Mèinnean stopped carrying first, master, and the fifth was owed on carrying."

"They can say what they like. It isn't in the ruling. I've read it twice now and it isn't in it." He turned back from the window. "Write the report. The northern revenue down a quarter in eighteen months, the cause named plain: the holdout pits underselling Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own coal to Tuathaich buyers who were Comhairle nam Mèinnean's custom until they had somewhere cheaper to go. And the remedy, since the council will ask for one whether I give it or not: that under Breith Leòid³ the western seams are An Crùn's to take back, the holders having let the fifth lapse these two years, and that Comhairle nam Mèinnean declare them so and order the pits shut until such time as they are worked again under An Crùn's own hand."

Seumas wrote it that same evening, at the long table after the others had gone, with the lamp turned low to spare the oil, and every figure in it was true. He had drawn them himself and checked them twice, and he would have sworn to any of them before the council or before Manannan's own altar. It was only when the report was fair-copied and sealed, and he sat looking at his own name at the foot of it as the hand that drew the figures, that he let himself think, for the length of one candle burning a finger's breadth, about what a true figure could be made to carry that the man who drew it had never meant it to carry. He had written that the north bought its own coal with dubhan's coin. He had not written that Comhairle nam Mèinnean had itself stopped carrying that coal first, and taken the western towns' custom away before it complained of losing it; that sentence was in the ruling and not in his report, because the master had not asked for it, and a clerk's figures went where he was told to send them and no further.

He thought of the brewer's letter at Baile ìseal, still in his own tray, that no coal had gone north of the boundary stones in thirty years, and put the thought

3. the Leòid ruling

away, because there was nothing to be done with it that would not cost him his place and change nothing else at all.

IV

Of the Order Carried North

Comhairle nam Mèinnean's decree went out under Fearghas mac Aonghais's seal on the twentieth of an Giblean: that the western seams, their right to work them lapsed under Breith Leòid¹ for two years' unpaid fifth, were declared An Crùn²'s; that the pits at Muileann àrsaidh, Cnoc thais, Àth naomh, Tobar dhearg and Àth leathan were ordered shut from that day; and that any coal raised from them after the order was coal of An Crùn, taken without right, and answerable at law.

It went north by Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own courier to the maor of the western Seann Skell, who read it standing at his own door because the courier would not wait, and who sent for the town's clerk before he had finished reading it a second time, because he judged, rightly, that a paper of that weight wanted two witnesses to its arrival rather than one.

"They'll not shut," the clerk said, when he had read it in his turn. "Not for a paper."

"No," said the maor. "I don't suppose they will."

He was right in both halves of it. The word reached Muileann àrsaidh within the week, by a carrier who had it from a Cnoc thais man who had it from the maor's own clerk, and the five towns' answer, when it came, came not to Comhairle nam Mèinnean but to each other, in the form of a letter passed hand to hand and signed by none of them formally, that the pits would go on working until the seams themselves were spent, An Crùn having never carried their coal, never paid a wage in their pits and never, in all the years since the agreement, sent so much as a surveyor to say what it thought the seams were worth. They had stopped paying the fifth, the letter said, when Comhairle nam Mèinnean stopped earning it. If Comhairle nam Mèinnean wished the fifth restored, it might restore the carrying first, and the fifth would follow the same week.

1. the Leòid ruling

2. the Crown

3. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

Both were true, and both sides knew both were true, and neither the truth of Comhairle nam Mèinnean's claim nor the truth of the towns' answer moved either an inch from where it had stood since the wool mills of Doire ghlas first went over to northern coal. The letter never reached Cathair mhòr in any form Comhairle nam Mèinnean would call an answer; it was read at Muileann àrsaidh, at Cnoc thais and at Àth leathan, and its substance, rather than its words, made its way south by the same carriers' road the order had come north on, so that within a month it was generally known at Cathair mhòr, without ever having been formally received, that the western towns did not mean to obey.

The five towns met, as they had met before, in Sarah Dunmore's kitchen at Muileann àrsaidh and then in the pit-shed when the kitchen would not hold them all, and Ruth Calder read Comhairle nam Mèinnean's order aloud from the paper a carrier had brought, twice through, once fast and once slow, so that no one in the shed could afterwards say he had not heard every word of it. Tom Varley wanted the letter answered line for line, clause against clause, in the manner of a man who has read a great many contracts and does not trust a paper that goes unchallenged. Ruth said Comhairle nam Mèinnean had not asked for a clause-by-clause answer and would not read one if it were sent; Comhairle nam Mèinnean had asked for the pits shut, and the only answer that mattered was whether the coal came up on the morning after the order's date. It came up. Nobody at Muileann àrsaidh put down a tool, and the shed voted, without much debate and without a show of hands anyone troubled to count, to go on as before and let Comhairle nam Mèinnean make the next move, since it plainly meant to make one regardless of anything the towns wrote in reply.

"They'll send men," said Sarah Dunmore, who had said little through the meeting and was heard the more for it. "A paper that isn't obeyed gets men sent after it. It always has."

Nobody answered her, because nobody could say she was wrong, and the meeting broke up into the wet evening with the matter no further settled than it had been when it opened, except that every person in the shed now carried, alongside the day's ordinary work, the private certainty that the paper nailed to nothing yet would shortly be nailed to something.

V

Of Somhairle mac Lachlainn

Somhairle mac Lachlainn had come up through Comhairle nam Mèinnean's enforcers by the same road most of them came, from a farm too small to keep a second son, into a company that had existed for forty years to see harbour-dues paid and smugglers' coal weighed at Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own scale. In eighteen years he had made himself the man other captains sent for when a thing wanted doing quietly, whether or not it stayed quiet once he had started on it. He was two-and-forty that autumn, broad through the shoulder in the way a farm makes a man rather than a drill-yard, with a scar through one eyebrow from a fight at Ros dhomhain's quay he never spoke of and a reputation, among the men under him, for giving an order once and expecting it obeyed without a second telling.

He was sent for at Cathair mhòr in the last week of an t-Sultain, called before Fearghas mac Aonghais and a councillor of the Rìoghachd he did not know by sight, and told, in fewer words than he had expected the matter to take, that a company of Comhairle nam Mèinnean's enforcers was to go north to the western Seann Skell before the winter closed the roads, and that he was to command it.

"How many men, master?"

"Forty. What Comhairle nam Mèinnean can spare from the southern stations without leaving them bare."

"And their orders, once we're there?"

"To see the shutting order held. No pit at Muileann àrsaidh, Cnoc thais, Àth naomh, Tobar dhearg or Àth leathan is to raise coal after the day you arrive. You'll post men at the pit-heads. You'll not close the town, nor the road, nor any house that isn't a pit-head. That's the whole of it."

"And if they raise coal anyway."

The councillor answered that one, before Fearghas mac Aonghais could. "Then you'll have shown Comhairle nam Mèinnean's order cannot be held with forty men and a captain, and the council will decide what it wants to do about that. Your business, mac Lachlainn, is to hold the order, not to fight a war nobody has declared."

Somhairle mac Lachlainn took the order as it was given, because it was not his place to say that a company sent to stand at five pit-heads in a country that had buried its dead against Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own kind within living memory was already more than a policing matter, whatever the council chose to

1. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

call it. He asked for, and was given, forty men of his own choosing rather than whoever the southern stations cared to spare, choosing men who had served under him before over younger men who had not, which the master noted and did not question.

Two days ahead of the company he rode north alone, to see the ground before he brought men onto it, and crossed the boundary stones on a grey morning with rain coming and going in the west, much as another man had crossed them sixteen years before on a different errand. He did not stop at the stones. He had crossed them a dozen times in Comhairle nam Mèinnean's service, weighing coal at a scale or carrying a summons, and had never yet been north of them with a company at his back, and he found, riding alone through the same bare ridges Seumas mac Eachainn had ridden as a young man, that the difference sat on him more heavily than he had thought it would.

He lay that night at a road-house south of the western Seann Skell, a low place with a dubhan lamp over the door and a landlord who asked no questions beyond what he was owed for the bed, and lay awake a while going over the ground he had ridden and the ground still ahead of it, in the way a man does the night before a piece of work he has not done before, whatever its size. He had put men in harm's way often enough, at a smuggler's landing or a quay brawl gone past reason, and had never yet lost one; he set some store by that record, privately, the way another man might set store by a relic, and did not care to think too closely about how far it could be made to stretch. Forty men at five pit-heads in a country that had not seen a company under arms since before his own grandfather's time was not a smuggler's landing, and he knew it, and had said as much to the councillor at Cathair mhòr in words careful enough not to sound like a refusal, because refusing had never once, in eighteen years of Comhairle nam Mèinnean's service, been a road that led anywhere he wanted to go.

He thought, before he slept, of the scar over his eyebrow, taken at Ros dhomhain's quay from a smuggler's boat-hook in a scuffle that had gone wrong in the space of ten seconds and never once, in the years since, made him careful in the way other men's scars seemed to make them careful. It had taught him instead to move first and explain after, which had served him well enough among smugglers and harbour thieves, men who understood a blow and a purse and little else. He did not know yet what it would teach him among five towns that understood a great deal more than that, and meant, plainly, to go on understanding it in their

own time and by their own lights, whatever paper Comhairle nam Mèinnean sent north to tell them otherwise.

VI

Of the Company at the Western Seann Skell

The company came up the western road on the sixteenth of an Dàmhair, forty men and their baggage-carts, in a rain that had set in for the day and showed no sign of lifting, and the western Seann Skell watched them come from doorways and from the harbour wall without a stone thrown and without a word of welcome, which Somhairle mac Lachlainn, riding at their head, judged the worse of the two receptions a town could give.

He quartered them at the old customs shed above the harbour, the only building in the town large enough and empty enough to hold forty men, and paid the maor's clerk for the use of it out of Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own purse rather than requisition it, which the clerk noted in his book without comment and which Somhairle did for reasons he would not have found easy to set out plainly even to himself, beyond a sense that a company that paid its way stood on firmer ground than one that did not, in a country where it had no ground of its own to stand on.

He sent men to Muileann àrsaidh, to Cnoc thais and to the three smaller towns within the week, not to close the pits by force, which forty men scattered across five towns could not have done in any case, but to stand at each pit-head with Comhairle nam Mèinnean's order nailed to the winding-gear and to report, twice weekly, whether coal came up. At Cnoc thais, Tom Varley met the two men sent there at the pit-head himself, read the order nailed to the post without a word, and told them they were welcome to stand there as long as they liked, the coal coming up whether they stood or not, and that he would see they were given tea at midday like anyone else standing about in the wet, since it was no fault of theirs that they had been sent.

They took the tea. The coal came up.

Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh, at Muileann chaol, wrote the whole of it into the day's page when word reached her, some ten days after the company had

1. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

marched, in fewer words than the matter seemed to her to deserve, and added at the foot of the entry, in the small close hand she kept for the things she judged worth remembering past their own day, that it was the first company the kingdom had sent armed toward the north since An Dealachadh² itself, near ninety years gone, and that no one now living who had signed the truce at the boundary stones was left to say whether it was meant as more than a policing matter, or whether anyone, on either side of the stones, still believed that it could stay one.

Seumas mac Eachainn read the report of the company's quartering at his own table at Cathair mhòr, three weeks after he had written the figures that had, by a road he had not chosen and could not now shorten, put it on the road north, and found in himself no surprise at all, which troubled him rather more than surprise would have done. His figures had been true. He had drawn them carefully, checked them twice, and would draw the next quarter's the same way, because that was the whole of his office and he did not know how to hold any other. But he understood now, reading of forty men quartered above a harbour he had once ridden into as a young man with Iain Ruadh's mare setting the pace, that a true figure asked to serve a purpose would serve it faithfully, and that the purpose was never his to choose, only the figure, and that he had known this from the evening he sat with the report before him and the candle burning down, and had sent it anyway.

He wrote the next quarter's returns without adding anything the master had not asked for. It was, he told himself, the whole of what a clerk owed the truth: to draw it exactly, and to leave what was done with it to hands that were not his.

2. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

OF the Depot Nobody Would Bless

DE 19

I

Of the Ground by the River

Somhairle mac Lachlainn had been a soldier of paper before he was a soldier of anything else, and it showed in the way he laid out the depot: string and pegs first, then the foundations, then the men. He walked the ground above the river at Seann Skell in the west on a grey morning in am Màrt with Comhairle nam Mèinnean's surveyor's plan under his arm, and where the plan said the wall should run he set a peg, and where it did not he let the whin stand.

The company had been three months in the town by then, quartered in the old customs shed above the river harbour, which Comhairle nam Mèinnean paid for and nobody else wanted, and in three months Somhairle had learned the shape of the place the way he had once learned the shape of a muster roll: the citadel on its rock, empty since before his grandfather's time, its gate rehung with new iron; the river road running north to Muileann àrsaidh and the pit towns, ten miles and more, climbing all the way; the quay where the coal barges had once tied up three deep and now lay two, and those two waiting on cargo that did not come. He had learned, too, which doors opened to him and which did not, though nobody in the town had struck him or thrown a stone at him yet, in am Màrt. That came later, and by a different road than he expected.

The depot was Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own notion, and a plain one: the enforcers' lorries wanted dubhan, and dubhan wanted a tank, a pump, and a

roofed place to keep the barrels dry between the boats that brought it up from the south and the wagons that would carry it on to wherever Comhairle nam Mèinnean's order sent it next. Somhairle had built worse things with less. He set the masons on the tank's foundations first, six courses of dressed stone with a puddled clay lining that Comhairle nam Mèinnean's engineer swore by, and while they worked he rode the ten miles to Muileann àrsaidh and back twice a week to see what the pit towns were doing, which for the most part was nothing he could report, since a wall of spoil and timber going up slowly, a cart at a time, over a winter, does not look like defiance until it is finished.

He wrote his first report on the fourteenth of am Màrt, three plain paragraphs: the depot's ground broken, the quay's second berth cleared for the dubhan boats, no incident at Muileann àrsaidh worth Comhairle nam Mèinnean's attention. Every word of it was true, and he sealed it believing so. Some months would pass before he learned that a report could be true in every sentence and still be a kind of lie, a thing a man came to by doing it, not by being told.

The masons finished the tank's stonework by the middle of an Cèitean, and the carpenters raised the roof over it the same month, a long shed of tarred boards not unlike the shipmasters' sheds Somhairle had seen once at the southern Seann Skell, save that this one had no chimney and no smell but pitch and new-cut wood. The lorries themselves had not yet come; two were promised from the capital for midsummer, the first the western Seann Skell had ever seen, and the town's children had already worked out where they would stand to watch them arrive, a fact Somhairle knew because his corporal reported it to him with more relish than he reported most things.

He had come to the west with forty men and Comhairle nam Mèinnean's authority to shut what Breith Leòid² had declared shut, and had expected, from what he had read at Cathair mhòr, a fight or the threat of one within the month. What he found was a town that answered him in two tongues and told him nothing in either, pit towns above him on the river road going on hewing coal as though no ruling had been made at all, and a season of building instead of a season of soldiering, which suited him less than he would have said aloud to any of his officers. The depot itself he had not asked for. It came down to him in an order three lines long, much like the note the house of Òrd Mhanannain³ would

1. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

2. the Leòid ruling

3. the order of Manannan

send him in return before the season was out, and he built it because it was built, the way a man drills a company because the drilling is ordered, without troubling himself overmuch about what it would be used for once it stood.

The town watched him build it. Seann Skell in the west was not a large place, three thousand and more souls between the quay and the citadel, but it had eyes enough, and Somhairle came in the first weeks to know which of the faces at the market stalls and the bridge-end were merely curious and which were counting: the courses of stone as they rose, the size of the tank, the number of men set to the work each week. He did not think, that spring, that the counting meant anything he needed to answer. It was a plain building. He never understood, afterwards, why it was the building nobody would bless.

II

Of the House That Would Not Bless

The custom of the town, and of every town on that coast so far as Somhairle had troubled to learn it, was that a new roof got a blessing before it was worked under, the way a new boat got one before it was launched: a house of the old faith sent a man to walk the ground and say the words, and the town's masons would not lay a floor inside walls that had not had it. Piety was too grand a word for it, most of them would have said; it was the same caution that kept a farmer from ploughing a field on the wrong day of the moon. Somhairle had watched it done for the customs shed's new door the winter before, a custodian of Òrd Mhanannain¹ come down from the house on the hill with a bowl of seawater and a few words nobody troubled to explain to him, and thought no more of it than he thought of any other local weather.

He sent his corporal to the house of Òrd Mhanannain in the last week of an Cèitean, with a civil note asking that a custodian come and bless the depot's roof before the tank was filled, and naming a day that suited the masons. The note came back within the hour, in a hand Somhairle did not know, three lines long: the house of Òrd Mhanannain at Seann Skell did not bless what was built for

1. the order of Manannan

Comhairle nam Mèinnean²'s enforcers, and hoped the captain would trouble it no further on the matter.

Somhairle went himself the next morning. It was not pride so much as disbelief; he had asked leave to be refused things before, by councils and by weather, but never in three lines from a house he had never troubled.

The house stood on the rise behind the citadel, a low grey building with a well in its yard and a single window facing the river, unglazed, the shutter folded back. The man who came out to him at the gate was younger than Somhairle had pictured from the hand of the letter, thin, sunburned across the nose the way a man gets who works outdoors and forgets his hat, in the plain grey the order wore.

"I had your note," Somhairle said, "and I came to ask it again myself, in case the corporal put it badly. It's a roof over a tank, nothing more. I'm told the custom is to bless a new roof before the town's men work under it, and my masons are the town's men."

"Your masons are the town's men," the priest said. "What's under the roof is Comhairle nam Mèinnean's, and what will stand beside it before the year's out is yours." He did not raise his voice. "We bless a boat because the sea doesn't ask whose it is before it drowns a man. We bless a roof because rain doesn't ask either. I'll not pretend the same of a depot built to keep your lorries fuelled on the road to Muileann àrsaidh, captain, because you and I both know the rain isn't the thing I'd be blessing it against."

Somhairle had heard evasions dressed as plain speaking often enough to know the difference, and this was not that. He stood a moment with the morning coming up warm off the river behind him and found he had no answer that was not either an argument about theology he had no standing to make, or a threat he had no wish to make.

"Then I'll trouble you no further," he said, and did.

He wrote of it to Àrd-choimheadaiche³ at the southern Seann Skell that same afternoon. The house of Òrd Mhanannain answered to no one outside itself, being its own master under a different order entirely; he wrote to Alasdair mac Ìomhair anyway, for want of anyone else in the whole of the old faith who might see the thing plainly and not as a quarrel between the enforcers and the north. He set down the refusal in the priest's own words, as near as he could remember them, and asked, since the house on the hill would not come, whether some other house

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

3. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

might, so that the masons would work under a blessed roof as any other masons on that coast expected to.

The answer came back inside the fortnight, over Alasdair mac Ìomhair's own hand, and said less than Somhairle had hoped and more than he had expected. The Àrd-choimheadaiche would not command a house of Òrd Mhanannain, he wrote, no more than the priest's own master could command a custodian of Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail⁴; but Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail blessed what it was asked to bless, north or south, Board or town, and if the depot's roof wanted the words said over it, a custodian of the southern house would come and say them.

He came in the first week of an t-Iuchar, a young custodian named Pàdraig, sent the two days' road from the south with a letter of introduction and nothing else, no escort, riding a hired horse he did not know how to manage and arriving stiff and saddle-sore an hour after the masons had given up expecting him. He said the words over the depot's roof at evening, with Somhairle and half a dozen of the enforcers standing by and none of the town's own people, though a good many watched from the bridge and further off, at a distance that made plain it was watching and not attending. The words themselves were nearer to what Somhairle had watched said over the customs shed's door than he had expected, the same bowl carried out and the same slow walk round the four corners of the building, and he found himself, standing bare-headed in the last of the evening light with his men behind him, oddly moved by a thing he had asked for chiefly as a matter of custom and had not thought to feel anything about at all.

Pàdraig ate with the officers that night, a quiet young man who asked Somhairle a great many questions about the road north, how far it ran, how the towns along it stood, whether Comhairle nam Mèinnean's writ carried past Muileann àrsaidh or stopped short of it, and answered none of Somhairle's questions in turn about the house of Òrd Mhanannain or why the southern house had sent a man two days' ride when a house on the hill above the depot could have walked down in a quarter of an hour. He rode south again the next morning, stiff still, and thanked Somhairle for the horse's keep in a way that made plain he did not expect to be sent north again on such an errand, and he was not.

The masons worked under the blessed roof without complaint, being, as the priest had said, the town's men and glad of the wage whoever paid it. But it was noticed, and remembered, that the depot had been blessed by a stranger's hand

4. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

from the south, and not by the house that stood in sight of its own roof, and the town had a name for the building inside the month that was not Comhairle nam Mèinnean's name for it, though Somhairle never learned what it was, his corporal having more sense than to tell him.

III

Of the Letter Filed

What Somhairle did not see, and could not have, was the letter Martha Greaves wrote from Caol mhòr at the summer's end, though it touched his depot as nearly as anything in that year.

She wrote it at Tional nan Tuathach's table, with Peter Hale reading over her shoulder and putting in a word here and there that she mostly did not take, because the letter was hers to write as speaker and she had turned it over in her mind on the road down from Doire ghlas until she had it by heart before she set pen to paper. It said, in substance, what Tional nan Tuathach's delegates had been saying to one another in the corridor outside the hall for a month: that the five towns of the western hills would not shut their pits for a letter carried by a Board's clerk, whatever Breith Leòid² said the seams now were; that Tional nan Tuathach was no party to the quarrel and wished to be none; and that a year's delay, while Tional nan Tuathach itself sent men to treat with the towns, would cost Comhairle nam Mèinnean³ nothing it had not already lost, and might cost the kingdom a great deal less than the alternative.

She did not write the word the alternative meant, having no wish to be the one who first put it on paper, and Peter Hale, reading the sentence over her shoulder, said nothing about the omission either, though both of them understood it.

The letter went up to the capital by the ordinary post, and was read, Tional nan Tuathach's minute later recorded, at a sitting of the council in the first week of an t-Sultain, at which Somhairle mac Lachlainn was not present and of which he knew nothing beyond what his own masters chose to tell him, which was nothing at all. The council's clerk entered it as received. No answer was sent. It went, with the rest of that quarter's correspondence, into the press where such

1. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

2. the Leòid ruling

3. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

letters were kept, in a folder with a paper label in a clerk's hand that said only *Tional nan Tuathach, western towns*, and there it lay through the autumn and the winter that followed, read again, so far as the record shows, by no one until long after the matter it asked about had been settled by other means.

Martha Greaves learned, some weeks later, that the letter had been received and filed, and no more than that; the phrase itself, filed, has stood ever since in the north for an answer that is not one.

Peter Hale, who had wanted a harder letter and had said so at Tional nan Tuathach's table before Martha wrote the one she meant to write, told the delegates at the next sitting that a filed letter was better than a refused one, since a refusal closed a door and a filing merely left it shut, which was not the same thing and might yet be opened. Ruth Calder, who had walked out of Tional nan Tuathach five years before and sat now among the western towns' own people rather than among Tional nan Tuathach's, heard him say it, and said nothing back. Tional nan Tuathach's letter went into the record as its own act, the last it would take in that quarrel that asked for anything so plain as a year's grace, and it is remembered in the western hills, where such things are remembered exactly, for what it asked and for the single word that answered it.

IV

Of the Stones on the Road

The first skirmish that An Clàr Foscailte¹ does not name happened on the Muileann àrsaidh road in the second week of an t-Sultain, and the north tells it thus.

A lorry of the enforcers, one of the two promised in midsummer and only lately come, was sent up from the depot with a load of timber for the post Comhairle nam Mèinnean² meant to build on the road below Muileann àrsaidh, the same post whose foundations had not yet been dug. It went up the river road in the early morning with two men in it, a driver and a corporal, and it did not come back by dusk, when it was looked for. It came back after dark instead, one wheel stove and the timber gone, and the corporal with a cut over his eye he would not

1. the open record of the war years

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

say how he came by, though the driver, a Seann Skell man with kin in the town, was not so close-mouthed among his own people, and what he told them, in the way of such things, went from the depot's yard to the quay to the whole town inside two days, and from there, by the carriers who worked the river road, to Muileann àrsaidh itself before the month was out, told there a little differently than it was told at the depot, as such things are.

The telling that held in the pit towns says that the lorry came up past the second milestone below the town in the grey of the morning, and that word of it had gone ahead by whatever road word travels faster than a lorry on a bad surface, so that by the time it reached the narrow place where the road runs between the old spoil-heap and the river, there were men on the heap above it, not many, the telling says, and none of them known to any teller who did not already know them before that morning. Most of them had nothing to fire with that year, and none fired. They threw stones, and rolled two loosened boulders down from the heap into the road ahead of the lorry, and stood where they could be seen and counted, though the telling is careful never to give a number, until the driver turned the lorry about in the narrow place, no easy thing, and took it back down the way it had come, the corporal's cut earned, the telling says, by a stone and not by a blow, though it does not press the point.

The enforcers' side of it, as a man of the depot told it afterwards, to another man who by then had his own reasons to ask, runs shorter and says less. He said they had gone up with the timber as ordered, had found the road blocked above the spoil-heap by stones that might have fallen or might not, had turned back rather than clear it themselves with no escort and no orders covering the case, and that somewhere in the turning the corporal had taken a knock he made light of. He did not say he had seen anyone on the heap. Asked directly, years afterwards, by someone who had reason to press him, he said he had not looked up at the heap at all, being occupied with the lorry. The man who asked him did not press further, though he did not look wholly satisfied either.

Neither telling gives a name. An Clàr Foscailte gives none either: it was not written down at the time, being, in Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own later word for such things, not great enough to name, and it was one of a dozen or a score that autumn on that road and others like it, none counted, none put in any report that reached beyond the depot's own book, until they had between them made a thing too large to call by any of their separate names.

There was a second such meeting on the same road before an t-Sultain was out, and a third on the shorter track above Àth leathan that the escorted wagons had begun to use instead, and Somhairle came, over that month, to recognise the shape of the thing before he had words for it: a load sent up, a delay reported, a man come back with a graze or a fright or nothing at all beyond a story he told differently each time he told it. None of it was war. He would have said so himself, that autumn, and believed it. The wall at Muileann àrsaidh grew a little higher through the same weeks, a cartload of spoil and a length of timber at a time, and no one on either side of the shire line called that war either, though it was built for nothing else.

Somhairle heard of it from the corporal himself that same night, the cut still open, the man more shaken by the stove wheel and the lost timber than by the blow, or saying so. He asked him three times whether he had seen who threw the stones, or how many there had been, and got, each time, a slightly different answer. Somhairle judged it no lie: a frightened man in a turning lorry on a bad road in poor light does not see clearly, and does not know afterwards how much of what he remembers he has built since. That judgement went into the report he began that night and did not finish until the following morning.

V

Of the Report That Said Less

he wrote three drafts.

The first said what the corporal had told him, in the corporal's own uncertain words, three men seen or perhaps five, stones and two boulders, the lorry turned back, the timber lost, no shots fired on either side, no man badly hurt. He read it over and struck out *seen or perhaps five*, because he did not believe the corporal had seen anything of the kind, and wrote instead *a number not established*.

The second, written the next morning with a clearer head, said less again: an obstruction on the Muileann àrsaidh road, the lorry returned undamaged beyond a wheel, the timber not delivered, to be sent up again under escort. He looked at *undamaged* for a long while, the wheel in fact having cost three days at the wheelwright's, and let it stand, because a stove wheel was a fact Comhairle nam Mèinnean's engineer would ask after in a way a captain's judgement of a crowd on a spoil-heap would not be asked after at all, and Somhairle had begun, without quite deciding to, to weigh his sentences by what question each one would draw down on him, and to prefer the ones that would draw down none.

The third was the one he sent. It said that a lorry sent to the Muileann àrsaidh road with timber for the new post had met an obstruction and returned; that the timber would go up again under proper escort; that there had been no engagement. The word stones did not appear in it, nor the corporal's cut, which had by then closed and would leave, the surgeon said, no scar worth the noting. Somhairle read the third draft over twice, found nothing in it that was false, and sealed it. Riding out the next morning to see the escort chosen for the timber's second try, he told himself that a report existed to answer the questions a superior officer needed answered, and that a captain who filled every page with every uncertain thing a frightened corporal half remembered was not doing his superiors a service, whatever he was doing for the truth of the matter.

He believed this for the length of the ride, more or less, and found, dismounting at the depot's gate, that he no longer entirely did, though he could not have said where in the three miles the belief had worn through.

It was some weeks after, at the foot of the year, that Comhairle nam Mèinnean's clerk at Cathair mhòr forwarded to Somhairle, without comment, a copy of a letter that had come up from Seanchaidh na Rìoghachd² at Muileann chaol, asking Comhairle nam Mèinnean for its returns of the incidents on the northern roads that autumn, so that the record might be kept as fully as the record was kept of everything else the kingdom did. Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh had written it herself, in the same plain hand she had used for every such asking in the four-and-twenty years she had kept the kingdom's chronicle, believing, as she wrote it, that the office she wrote to would answer as every office had always answered a chronicler's plain question, with what it had, no more and no less; that had always been the custom of the kingdom's record, and she had not yet had cause to doubt it

1. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

2. the royal chronicler

held. She set the letter down among the day's other copying and thought no more of it than the fifty other such letters she sent out in an ordinary year.

It was Sileas nic Rath, reading the returns as they failed to come through the following weeks, who first said aloud in an Leabharlann's upper room that Comhairle nam Mèinnean's silence on this one letter did not feel like the ordinary silence of an office too busy to answer. The old woman at the next desk told her she was young yet, and would learn in time the difference between a thing not answered and a thing refused; it generally took longer to learn than a body would like.

Comhairle nam Mèinnean did not answer it, that year or the next. Somhairle never learned the letter's fate after it left Cathair mhòr, whether it went unread into a press like Martha Greaves's, or was read and answered with a silence someone had chosen rather than a silence that simply happened; he was not, that autumn, high enough in Comhairle nam Mèinnean's counsel to be told which. He knew only that no order came down to him changing anything in the reports he sent, and that he went on writing them as he had begun to, three drafts to one, the first honest and the third sent, and that by the time the first snow of that winter closed the higher road above Muileann àrsaidh, he had stopped noticing that he did it at all, which was, though he did not think of it in these words and would not have thanked anyone who put it to him so plainly, the whole of what the habit was for.

He rode out on the last clear day before the snow to look at the depot's roof, blessed by a stranger's hand and standing sound, and the tank full under it, and the two lorries in their shed, and thought, as near as the matter can be told, of nothing at all worth the writing down. That, too, went into no report.

CHAPTER TWENTY

Of Ruth Calder's Letter

DE 19

I

Of the Wall and the Trench

The frost came early to Muileann àrsaidh that year, hard enough by the third week of an t-Samhain to ring under a boot on the spoil-heaps before the sun was properly up, and Ruth Calder, who lodged at Sarah Dunmore's that winter to see the walling done, was out among the pit-heads in it most mornings before the men were, walking the line as her father had walked the line at Àth leathan, though he had walked it to see that the timbering held and she walked it now to see that the wall did.

It was not much of a wall to look at, and she knew it. A cartload of spoil tipped and levelled, a length of pit-timber laid along the top of it and pegged, a gap left for the cart-track and nothing more, built a load at a time through the back end of the autumn by men who came to it after their shift underground and worked it by lamplight when the days ran short, so that it had grown the way a coral grows, she thought, without anyone in particular deciding on its shape, and stood now waist-high the length of the pit-yard and higher than a man's head where it crossed the old cart-road into the town. It would not have kept out a company of Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹'s enforcers with proper tools and half a morning to spend on it. It kept out nothing but a lorry, and a lorry was, in the

1. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

end, the only thing that had come up that road in eighteen months that anyone in Muileann àrsaidh had cause to keep out.

Old Fraser had the digging of the trench across the southern road, being the best hand in the town with a spade and the only one old enough to remember, from some tale of his own grandfather's, that a road dug across at the right place could be made near as good as a wall for a fraction of the labour. He stood in it to his knees that morning, breath smoking, and called up to her as she came along the bank.

"Another two days and she's done, captain. Deep enough a cart won't chance it and narrow enough a man on foot needn't get his boots wet crossing, which I make out to be about right, since it's carts we're stopping and not men."

"You'll want it filled with water before the frost sets it solid, or it's a bridge by am Faoilleach and not a ditch at all."

"I'll want a great many things I'm not like to get." He leaned on the spade a moment, looking up at her with the particular squint he kept for anything he thought worth saying plainly. "You know what this is, the pair of us standing here talking about drainage. It's not a ditch for keeping the wet out of a cellar."

"I know what it is."

"I only say it because there's men down there" — he tipped his head toward the pit-shaft behind them, where the morning cage was just then coming up with its first load of the poor Cnoc thais coal that Muileann àrsaidh had taken to burning itself since Comhairle nam Mèinnean stopped carrying the good — "who'd tell you it's only a fence, the way a man tells himself a dog's only barking at the wind. It isn't only a fence, Ruth. You want to have your mind made up what it is before somebody else makes it up for you."

She had thought, more than once through that autumn, that old Fraser said more true things to her in a morning's digging than the whole of the letters that came up from the south said in a twelvemonth, and this was one of them. She let it sit a moment before answering, since any answer she could find that morning ran either smaller than the trench deserved or larger than she was ready to speak aloud.

"It's a wall and a ditch," she said at last, "same as it looks. What anybody south of it chooses to call it is their own business."

old Fraser went back to his digging without pressing her further, being a man who knew the difference between a question worth a second asking and one that was not, and Ruth went on along the bank to the pit-head, where the day's shift

was already gathering at the cage with their lamps, and took out her father's tally-book, which she had carried over the hill with her and had kept, in one hand or another, every morning for going on four years now, and began the day's count of coal raised, coal burned, coal owed, the same three columns she had kept since the week they buried him, in a hand that had grown, she thought sometimes without much pleasure in the noticing, very nearly as neat as his.

The word from the south that autumn came thin and came late, by whatever carrier still troubled to climb the hill road once the weather turned, and most of what it carried was not news so much as the absence of it: no answer from Comhairle nam Mèinnean to the collective letter the five towns had sent in the summer, unsigned by any one name and carried hand to hand, that said only that the pits would go on until the seams themselves were spent; no word of the enforcers at the western Seann Skell beyond the plain fact of their being there still, quartered in the old customs shed above the river harbour, building something by the river that the carrier's talk called a depot and could not say more of than that; no sign, from Caol mhòr or from Cathair dhearg either, that the winter now closing in on the hills was expected, by anyone south of them, to end in anything but more of the same silence it had been given all that year.

It was into this silence, and not out of any clearer counsel, that Ruth began, in the last week of an t-Samhain, with the trench half dug and the wall not yet finished, to write.

II

Of the First Drafts

She did not tell anyone at first what she meant to do, partly because she had not yet decided to do it and partly because she had learned, in four years of keeping a pit captain's books, that a thing said aloud too soon in Muileann àrsaidh came back to you by evening in a shape you no longer recognised, with three opinions attached that you had not asked for and could not now easily set down.

The first attempt was made at her father's table, in the stone house above the pit-head at Àth leathan, on a Sunday home, on a night when the wind was coming hard enough off the hill to want the shutters latched twice, with the tally-book put away and a single sheet of the good paper in front of her that she kept

for the collective letters and had, until that night, always used for someone else's words and never her own. She wrote the salutation first, *To the Council of Rìoghachd Dia-thìr*¹, and looked at it a long while, because it seemed to her a great thing to have written at the top of a page in a pit captain's kitchen, and then she wrote nothing else that night at all, and went to bed with the sheet still lying there, the ink dry and the rest of it blank, and told herself in the morning that a letter begun and not finished was no different from a letter never begun, which was not, she found, much comfort.

The second attempt, a week later, she tore across before it was a third done, because she had written three long paragraphs on the history of the agreement at Muileann àrsaidh and the wrong done the towns by Breith Leòid², and reading it back she heard, under every sentence, her own voice raised the way it rose at the pit-shed meetings when Tom Varley or one of the Cnoc thais men said a thing she thought unjust, and she knew, without anyone having to tell her, that a letter written in that voice would be read by whoever read it at an Leabharlann³ as one more northern grievance among the hundred they must have on file already, and set beside the rest, and answered, if it was answered at all, the same way.

"You're writing it like a complaint," Sarah Dunmore said, the one evening Ruth brought the torn half-sheets to her kitchen and laid them out on the table where the towns' agreement had first been drafted three years before, in much the same seats, with much the same tea gone cold between them. "And they've a great many complaints. What they haven't got, I'd wager, is an offer. Nobody in four years has offered them anything. Everybody's told them what's owed, or what's been done wrong, or what they mean to keep doing whatever's said against it. Nobody's put a thing on the table and said, here, take this, and we'll both be the better for it."

"There's not much on our table to offer. We've coal and nothing else."

"Coal's what they want. It's the only thing anybody in this quarrel has ever wanted from us, whatever else they've said about seams and rulings and An Crùn's own right. Offer them the coal, on your own terms, and let them see whether they'd rather have it that way than not at all."

Ruth turned the idea over through the whole of that week, at the tally-book in the mornings and at the table above the pit-head in the evenings, and came,

1. the Kingdom of Dia-thìr

2. the Leòid ruling

3. the Library at Muileann chaol

slowly, to see that Sarah Dunmore had put her finger on the one thing the four years of letters, hers and Comhairle nam Mèinnean's and the council's between them, had none of them yet tried. Every letter she had read or heard read aloud at the pit-shed meetings had been an argument about a right: whose the seams were, whose the fifth was, who had broken faith with whom first, and each argument had answered the last with a sharper one, until the whole exchange had the shape less of a negotiation than of two men shouting the same three sentences louder each time, in the hope that volume alone might eventually pass for proof. She did not think she could win that argument. The towns' case was sound, she still believed that; the trouble was that nobody who had the power to answer it was troubling any longer to listen to it as an argument at all.

An offer was a different thing. An offer did not ask to be believed. It only asked to be weighed.

III

Of the Terms

She wrote the third draft in a single sitting, on the last evening of an t-Samhain, with the trench filled and frozen behind the pit-yard and the wall finished but for a length at its northern end that old Fraser had left off out of what he called simple exhaustion and what everyone privately understood to be the same caution he had shown her that morning in the ditch, a wall built all the way round a town being, in his private judgement, a thing too near a boast to finish.

This one did not begin with the history. It began with the thing itself.

We will pay An Crùn¹'s fifth in coal, the same fifth Comhairle nam Mèinnean²'s own ruling names, on every load raised from the seams at Muileann àr-saidh, Cnoc thais, Àth naomh, Tobar dbearg and Àth leathan, from this day until the seams themselves are spent, if Comhairle nam Mèinnean will carry that coal to market as it carried it before, and make no further claim upon the pits while the fifth is paid.

4. the Crown

5. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

1. the Crown

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

She read that sentence back four times before she let herself write the next, because it was, she understood even as she set it down, a very great deal to offer and a very little to ask in return, and she wanted to be certain, before she went further, that this was truly what she meant and not merely what desperation had put into her pen. The fifth had gone unpaid for four years, by Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own reckoning, and Breith Leòid³ made a great deal turn on that unpaid fifth; to offer it now, in coal and not in coin, backdated to nothing and forward-looking only, was to give Comhairle nam Mèinnean the one thing its own ruling said it wanted and to ask, in exchange, only that the pits be let alone to work until they were worked out, which was, on the towns' own reckoning, a matter of years and not of generations, the seams at Muileann àrsaidh being already thin in places and Cnoc thais's reopened shafts thinner still.

It was, she thought, setting the pen down a moment to warm her hand over the fire, a bargain Comhairle nam Mèinnean ought by any sane reckoning to take, since it lost nothing it had not already lost and gained the fifth back besides. She knew, even as she thought it, that sane reckoning was not the only reckoning a council weighed a matter by, and that a body which had already sent a company of armed men north over a fifth part of a coal seam was not, perhaps, a body that could be counted on to want the quarrel settled quietly and without a victory to show for it. But she wrote the offer anyway, because it was the true offer, the one Sarah Dunmore had asked her to find, and because a letter that asked for what she privately expected to be refused was still, she judged, worth more than no letter at all.

She went on from there more plainly than she had written anything before: that the five towns had never sought to take from Comhairle nam Mèinnean what Comhairle nam Mèinnean itself had ceased to want, Comhairle nam Mèinnean having stopped carrying northern coal to southern markets long years before the towns stopped paying for the privilege of a carriage that no longer came; that the coal raised in the western hills, being poor coal by any southern measure, fetched no price outside the north that would tempt any buyer Comhairle nam Mèinnean itself still served; and that the wall now standing round Muileann àrsaidh's pit-yard, which she did not doubt some report had already carried south in a shape larger than the thing itself, was built to keep out lorries and not men, and would come down the day a lorry had no further reason to come up that road.

3. the Leòid ruling

She did not write the word war, in that draft or in any of the three that followed it over the fortnight after, though she thought it, reading each draft back, more times than she would have owned to any of the pit-shed meetings. The same thin carrier-talk that brought every other scrap of southern news that autumn had brought word that regiments not called out since An Dealachadh⁴ were being spoken of again at Cathair dhearg, spoken of and not yet raised, which was, she told herself, still a distance short of raised; and into the space that distance left she wrote her letter, believing, or choosing to believe, that a plain offer honestly meant might yet close it before it closed on its own account.

IV

Of Christmas Day

The chapel at Àth leathan kept its service on the morning of the twenty-fifth as it had kept it every year Ruth could remember, the small stone building above the ford road filled to its narrow doors with the town's own people and a good number come down from Muileann àrsaidh and Cnoc thais besides, since the western hills had never troubled themselves greatly with the difference between the two faiths the island kept, most households along that coast holding to both without much sense of contradiction, a custodian of Òrd Mhanannain¹ and the humans' own priest sometimes standing at the same graveside within a season of each other and neither thinking it strange.

Ruth walked down from Muileann àrsaidh the evening before with Tom Varley and a dozen others of the pit towns, the road frozen hard and easy underfoot for once, the whole company more cheerful on that walk than she had seen any of them in months, singing a little in the last stretch coming down into Àth leathan, where the chapel lamp showed early through the bare trees. She had not meant, setting out, to finish the letter that day. She had meant only to keep the feast, as her father had kept it and his father before him, and to let the letter lie another week in the drawer where it had lain, in one draft or another, since an t-Samhain began.

The chapel was cold, the small dubhan stove at the back doing little against a building built for a warmer age, and Ruth stood through the service between

4. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

Sarah Dunmore and Tom Varley with her hands deep in her coat, her mind for once on her father, who had stood in that same pew every an Nollaig² of her life until the last one, and on the particular quiet that came over a small crowded room when the whole of it, for the length of a carol, wanted nothing from any of the others in it but to be there together, warm or cold.

It was afterward, walking back up from the chapel in the thin winter light with the congregation breaking up into its knots of neighbours and kin, that the thing came clear to her, not as a new thought so much as an old one finally allowed to finish: the crowded chapel, the carrier's road frozen and passable for once, the whole of the five towns keeping one feast together whatever else divided them from the country south of the wall, was the plain thing her letter was asking Comhairle nam Mèinnean³ to leave alone, standing for an hour in front of her on the one day of the whole turning year best fitted to send it.

She did not go up to her own cold house that afternoon. She went instead to the kitchen of Tom Varley's sister, who had married at Àth leathan and kept a room for her brother when the roads were bad, and took out the last draft, and read it through once more by the window in the fading light, and found, this time, nothing in it she wished to soften or to harden either.

The fair copy took her under an hour, set down in the same hand she kept for the towns' ledgers, plain and even, with no flourish at the start or the close; a letter asking to be weighed and not believed, she had decided somewhere in the reading, ought to look like a ledger and not like a plea. She dated it at the top, the twenty-fifth of an Dùbhlachd, and signed it with her own name and the names of the pit captains of the other four towns beneath it, Tom Varley's among them. None of the four had seen the final draft, Sarah Dunmore alone excepted; their names stood there because she had asked each of them, weeks before, whether she might sign for them if the letter, when it came, said nothing they would not themselves have said, and none of them had refused her.

She sealed it with the same wax she used for the tally-book returns, there being no other in the house, and sat a while at the window with it finished in her lap before she carried it down to find Tom Varley.

1. the order of Manannan

2. Christmas

3. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

V

Of the Post at the Western Seann Skell

he was in his sister's kitchen when she found him, half asleep by the fire with a cup of something warm going cold at his elbow, and he came fully awake the moment she set the letter on the table in front of him, because he had known, better than most of the others, what she had been carrying in that drawer all through an t-Samhain, and had asked her twice already, without pressing, whether it was done.

"That's it, then."

"That's it."

He turned it over once in his hands, reading the address on the outside without opening it, since it was not his to open, and set it down again with a care she noted and was grateful for. "You want it to the post at the western Seann Skell, I expect, and not the Muileann àrsaidh carrier, since he's not been up the hill in a fortnight for the drifts."

"The Seann Skell post. It's the only office this side of Cathair dhearg that still keeps regular hours, whatever else sits beside it in that town now."

He did not ask her what she meant by that, both of them knowing well enough what else the western Seann Skell now held, the depot by the river and the company quartered in the old customs shed, and he did not, she noticed, offer to have someone else carry it, though the five miles down from Àth leathan to the town were not, on an evening of an Nollaig¹ with the light already going, a walk either of them would have chosen for its own sake.

"I'll go tonight," he said. "It'll be there before the office shuts if I go now, and I'd sooner it were posted before I've had time to think better of the terms myself, which I haven't, mind, but I'm an old man and old men change their minds in the night for no reason they can afterward name."

"You've not seen the terms."

"I've seen enough of you these two months to trust the terms, Ruth Calder, whatever they say, which is more than I'd have told your father I'd say of anyone twenty years back, him included." He said it without much ceremony, pulling on his coat as he spoke, and she did not answer it, because there was, again, no answer

1. Christmas

that would not have made more of the moment than either of them wanted made of it on a feast day.

He walked the five miles down to the western Seann Skell in under two hours, by his own account afterward, the road clear and the frost holding, and found the post office lit and open as she had said it would be, kept that evening, as it happened, by a clerk who had stayed past his hour rather than leave a stack of an Nollaig letters to wait another day, and who took Ruth Calder's letter across the counter without any particular notice of it among the dozen others in his hand that evening, weighed it, entered it in his book, and told Tom Varley it would go north with the regular carrier in three days' time, the roads and the holiday allowing.

It went, as promised, three days after, by the ordinary carrier and no other, folded in among the season's other correspondence with nothing about its plain sealed outside to mark it apart from a hundred like it, and it travelled the length of the island by the same slow stages any letter travelled that winter, town to town, hand to hand, until it came, in the second week of am Faoilleach following, to Le-abharlann Muileann chaol², where it was read, entered in the day-book in Ragh-nall mac Mhuirich's own clerk's hand, and laid, as Ellen Marsh's An t-Aon Le-abhar Deug³ had been laid two years before it, upon the table of the council's business, to wait there beside whatever else waited.

A copy of it went, by a slower road still, into Tional nan Tuathach⁴'s own minute at Caol mhòr, carried by one of the western towns' own people who thought Tional nan Tuathach ought at least to have the sight of it, whatever Tional nan Tuathach chose to do or not do with the sight once it had it; and there, in Tional nan Tuathach's own hand, it is recorded to this day, four short paragraphs and five names, under a heading that says only what it was and when it came.

No answer to it came from the council, that winter or the next. Ruth did not, in the weeks after, ask whether one might yet. She had learned enough, in four years of keeping her father's book, to know what a silence of that length generally meant, and she went back to the tally-book and the pit-yard and the wall's unfinished northern end with no great expectation stirring in her that the offer she had spent a season making plain would be met with anything plainer in return.

2. the Library at Muileann chaol

3. the eleven books of Tuathaich accounts gathered by Ellen Marsh over eleven years and offered to the Library

4. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

She did not wish it unsent. Setting it down that an Nollaig evening with her father's tally-book closed on the shelf behind her, she knew it for a fair offer honestly meant, the fairest either side of that quarrel had yet put forward; and she knew, just as plainly, folding it into its seal by the last of the daylight, that a generous offer was not, of itself, a thing that had ever yet been enough to answer for.

Of the GRANARIES and the New Chronicler

DE 20

I

Of the Nine Votes

The room over the net-lofts at Caol mhòr was colder than Martha Greaves had known it in twelve years in the chair, and she had known it in every kind of weather the north could send. The driftwood fire at the near end had been built up twice before the sitting and still could not warm the far wall, where the ice on the inside of the panes had not melted by noon. Forty-one delegates had come through snow that had closed Rathad na Fèille¹ three days before and was not yet done falling, and five benches along the harbour wall stood empty, as they had stood empty for five years now, since the day the western delegates had risen without a word and gone down the outside stair and not come back. Nobody moved to fill those places. Thomas Rook kept them chalked in the roll all the same, under the towns' names, with nothing after them.

She had not meant to bring the matter before the room herself. It was Peter Hale, delegate of Caol mhòr these dozen years and long-armed and fair still though there was grey now at his temples, who rose first and said that Tional nan Tuathach² had sat three sittings running without a word said of the western hills, and that a room which called itself the gathering of the northern towns and would not speak the plainest fact in the north was not doing the thing it was built

1. the fair road from the capital to Muileann òg

2. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

to do. There was a murmur along both walls at that, not agreement exactly, more the sound of men and women glad to hear said aloud what they had each been keeping to themselves.

"Say it, then," Martha told him, from the chair.

He said it. The pits at Muileann àrsaidh were walled now, he said, against Comhairle nam Mèinnean's³ own order, the road into the town dug across so that nothing came in or out but what a man could carry on his back over the spoil. The letter Ruth Calder had sent south at an Nollaig⁴, offering An Crùn's⁵ own fifth in coal if only Comhairle nam Mèinnean would carry it, had gone to an Le-abharlann⁶ and had had no answer, not a refusal even, only silence, and a silence from that quarter, he said, looking round the room as if daring anyone to contradict him, generally meant one thing when it went on long enough. He did not say the word war. Nobody in the room that morning said it, though it sat in the middle of the trestle as plainly as the ice on the far window.

Martha herself had had her own silence to weigh against his, though she did not put it before the room, having no wish to make the matter more hers than it already stood: the letter she had sent the autumn before, asking Comhairle nam Mèinnean for a year's delay while Tional nan Tuathach talked with the western towns, had gone the same road as Ruth Calder's and come to the same end, received and filed, no more said. She had not looked for anything better of it. She looked now, hearing Peter Hale lay the two letters side by side without knowing he had done it, at the plain shape the pattern made when two requests from two different hands met the same wall in the same season, and found she believed him a good deal more readily for the coincidence than she would have believed either letter alone.

"And what would you have the room do," asked the delegate of the farm towns, an old woman named Christina Munro who had sat on that bench longer than Martha had sat in the chair, "that it has not tried already? We sent a letter. It was received and filed, same as the last."

"I'd have the room say plainly what it is," Peter Hale said. "Not a fighting man's ally and not Comhairle nam Mèinnean's either. Say it, and put it in the

3. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

4. Christmas

5. the Crown

6. the Library at Muileann chaol

book, so that whatever comes after, no one can claim Tional nan Tuathach was ever asked and never answered."

It went round the trestle after that in the old way, each delegate free to speak once before any speak twice, and Martha let it run longer than she generally let anything run, because she judged, rightly as it turned out, that the room needed to hear itself say the thing from every corner before it would agree to say it once, together, in the book. A fisherman of Cathair gheal, whose town sold its catch up the coast for the last poor coal of the hills, said he for one would not have his name set down as neutral between men who dug and men who came with lorries to stop them digging, whatever the word neutral was made to mean in a minute. A miller of the eastern towns, whose trade touched the western hills not at all, said the room had no army to send and no coal to spare and had best say what it could truly do and no more, or it would find its own word worth as little as Comhairle nam Mèinnean's. Martha wrote none of it down herself. That was Thomas Rook's work, and he kept at it with his head bent and his pen scratching, filling three pages before the room came, of its own accord and without her steering it there in words, to the shape of the thing Peter Hale had wanted from the start: that Tional nan Tuathach was no party to the quarrel between Comhairle nam Mèinnean and the western towns, and would take no side in it by word or by deed; and that it would feed, from its own stores, any soul who came to any of its towns hungry, of whatever town, without asking first what side that soul had stood on.

She called for the show of hands herself, as speaker, standing so the room could see her count and know it was honestly done. Nine hands went up along the near wall for the motion as Thomas Rook read it back, Peter Hale's among them, and not one hand rose against it, though a good many arms stayed folded and a good many faces looked at the table rather than at her, Christina Munro's among those. She waited the space of three breaths, in case any of the folded arms meant to unfold, and none did.

"Nine for," she said. "None against. Carried." And Thomas Rook wrote it in, the day, the count, and the two clauses entire, no party to the quarrel and feed the hungry, in his small careful hand, and the room broke into its usual noise of benches scraping and voices low and urgent, already arguing over what feeding the hungry would want in barley and where it would come from, before the ink on the page was dry.

Christina Munro caught Martha's sleeve on the way down the outside stair, the last of the room ahead of them already scattering into the snow. "Nine," she said, not unkindly, "out of one-and-forty. You'll not tell me that's the whole room's mind."

"I'll tell you it's the whole room's vote," Martha said, "which is the only thing the book can hold. A man's mind is his own to keep."

"And is it yours as well? Nine, and you the tenth, and never raised your own hand at all."

"The chair doesn't vote," Martha said, "except to break a tie, and there was none to break." She said it as she had said it a hundred times before, in a hundred sittings where the rule had never once troubled her to explain further, and saw, in the way the old woman's mouth set, that this time it had not answered the question that was actually being asked. She did not answer that one either, there on the stair with the snow coming down between them, and Christina Munro, who had sat in that room longer than Martha had sat in the chair, let her sleeve go and said no more about it, then or after.

Martha sat on a while after the others had gone down the stair into the snow, as she had sat on the evening of her own first sitting, twelve years before, gathering Walter Hale's loose pages square on the table though there were no loose pages now to gather, only the habit of sitting still a little while in an empty room before she had to be Martha Greaves of Doire ghlais again and not merely Tional nan Tuathach's speaker. Nine votes would not carry so much as a bag of meal to Muileann àrsaidh, walled as it was, nor buy Ruth Calder's letter an answer it had not had. That much she had known before she ever called for the hands. What she had wanted was the thing in the book, in Thomas Rook's own careful ink, because a thing once written did not, whatever else befell it, become less true for having been carried by only nine.

II

Of the Wool Mills' Takings

She did not speak again of what the nine votes would mean in barley until the carding-sheds at Doire ghlais were running full summer hours and the fleece was in from the spring clip, weighed and sorted and already turning, under her own hand at the tally-desk, into the figures that told her each year what

the mills had made and what they had left over. That summer left over a good deal, the fleece having come in heavy after two mild winters and the price holding at the fair better than it had in some years, and Martha sat with the figures a whole evening in the counting-house with the window open on the grove and the grey oaks going gold-green in the long light, before she wrote, at the foot of the mill's own book and not Tional nan Tuathach's, an order to the miller at Caol mhòr and a second to her own granary-keeper at Doire ghlas, that the stores of both towns be filled that autumn beyond the ordinary wont, and paid for out of the mills' own takings, and no other fund drawn on.

She could have laid it before the room first. She was speaker, and the room had voted the feeding of the hungry into its own minute not six months before, and by every custom of the office she might have brought the figures to the next sitting and let the delegates argue, as they argued over everything, how much grain and which towns' stores and whose purse. That she chose not to. Instead she told herself, turning the reasons over on the ride home that evening with the oilcloth over her knees against a shower that never quite came, that a granary filled in am Faoilleach when the need showed itself would be six weeks too late for whoever needed it first, and that the mills were hers to spend as she judged, being no part of Tional nan Tuathach's own purse; and both of these were true reasons, and neither was the whole of it. The whole of it she did not put into words even to herself that evening, only felt it, the way a person feels the weight of a decision already made and only waiting to be carried out: that if the wall at Muileann àr-saidh meant what Peter Hale had said it meant, then a granary at Caol mhòr and another at Doire ghlas, standing full and unremarked through an ordinary summer, might in a year's time be the only thing in the whole north that stood between some family walking down out of the hills with nothing and a winter they did not live through.

The carts began coming up from the coast in the last week of an t-Iuchar, grain bought quietly through three different factors so that no one merchant should wonder aloud why Tional nan Tuathach's towns wanted so much of it in a year when the harvest promised well enough on its own account, and Martha stood in the yard at Doire ghlas most of one long afternoon watching the sacks go up into the loft above the old mill store, counting them herself against the factor's tally the way she had once counted fleeces that the mill's own tally said were forty

1. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

and her own eyes said were thirty-eight. The granary-keeper, a broad quiet man named John Skinner who had kept that loft for eleven years and had never in all that time seen it filled past two-thirds before the frost, asked her once, straightforwardly, whether he ought to enter a reason in his own book against the extra, since his book was looked at by the room's auditors each spring and a figure without a reason drew a question sooner or later.

"Enter the weight and the date," Martha said, "and no reason at all. If anybody asks you why, tell them to ask me."

John Skinner wrote it so, and asked nothing further, being a man long used to taking a plain instruction plainly and leaving it there. He did, over the weeks the carts kept coming, take to walking the loft himself of an evening after the last sack was up, counting the rows against no tally at all but his own memory of how the place had stood in other autumns, and once, near the end of it, he remarked to Martha, in the mild way he remarked on weather, that he could not recall the loft standing so full at harvest-time in all his eleven years, not even the year of the good barley when Tional nan Tuathach had sold the surplus south at the fair. Martha said only that it was a good year for fleece as well as barley, and let it go at that, and John Skinner, who had his own family in the mill cottages and his own notion of what a full loft might be wanted for before winter was out, let it go with her.

Nobody asked her, that year or for some while after. Tional nan Tuathach's own minute, when Thomas Rook came in the autumn to make the autumn entry of the granaries' state, as he made it every year without any particular interest in the figures, recorded that the stores at Caol mhòr and Doire ghlas stood fuller than the five years' average by a good half again, and gave, because none had been given him to give, no reason for it at all. Martha read the entry over his shoulder when the book came round the trestle for the room's inspection, as it did each autumn, and said nothing, and signed under it in her turn, and passed the book on down the bench to Peter Hale, who glanced at the figure, and then at her, and did not ask either, though something in the set of his mouth said plainly enough that he had done the same sum in his own head and come to the same answer she had, and had chosen, as she had, not to write it down.

Martha was one-and-seventy that year, broad still in the shoulder though the years had begun to stoop it a little, and had managed the mills at Doire ghlas since before most of the delegates now sitting on the benches around her had been born. In the quiet after a sitting her mind went sometimes to Daniel Frayne, dead

these twelve years, who had kept the room's minutes for twenty-three years and never once, that she had heard, put a private reason into a public book where a plain figure would do as well alone. She understood him, she found, a good deal better now than she had while he lived.

III

Of the Desk, the Ink and the Key

It is told at Muileann chaol, in an Leabharlann¹'s own upper room, that the handing-over took the better part of an afternoon and would have taken less had either woman been willing to let it go quickly, and that the keeper Ragh-nall mac Mhuirich, who had found the money for Sileas's own hiring nine years before out of his own small fund and told the council afterward rather than before, kept well away from the room the whole of that day, saying to anyone who asked that a chronicle changed hands better without a keeper standing over it.

Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh had written to the council in the spring of that year, in her own plain hand and no other's, that she asked leave to lay down the office of royal chronicler at the close of the summer, being nine-and-sixty that year and finding the winters harder on her eyes than the summers, and that she named, as the office's custom allowed a retiring chronicler to name, her own clerk of near nine years' standing, Sileas nic Rath, to take up the desk after her, subject always to the council's own leave, which the council gave without discussion in a single line at the foot of a sitting given over mostly to other matters. Sileas learned of it, in the end, from Beathag herself and no letter of the council's, on an ordinary wet morning in an Gearran, over the same pot of tea they had shared at the same hour for nine years, when Beathag set down her cup and said, in the same voice she used for the weather, that she had written to the council, and what she had written, and that Sileas had until an Lùnastal to decide whether she still wanted the desk once she had heard the whole of what it cost.

Sileas thought afterwards, more than once, that she ought to have asked then what Beathag meant by cost, and had not, partly from the surprise of the thing and partly because some instinct told her that whatever the answer was, she

1. the Library at Muileann chaol

would learn it better by waiting for it than by asking for it before she was ready to hear it.

The last afternoon came in an Lùnastal, a still hot day with the river low and slow past the old building's windows and the paper-mill's wheel barely turning for want of water to drive it. Beathag had cleared the desk herself over the week before, a little at a time, so that there should be no single day when the room looked stripped, and by the last afternoon there was little left on it but the inkstand that had been Tormod Pinn's before her, the day's page half-written in her own hand, and a small iron key on a loop of waxed thread.

"The ink first," Beathag said, and pushed the stand a hand's breadth across the desk, though it had stood in that same spot, Sileas knew, since before either of them had been born. "It was Tormod's. It will outlast the both of us if nobody drops it. Don't clean the well too often. A little of the old ink left in the bottom keeps the new from going thin."

Sileas said she would remember it.

"The page next." Beathag turned the half-written sheet so it faced the chair Sileas had not yet sat down in. "I've left it short. You'll finish today's entry in your own hand, not mine, so that the book shows the change where the change was made, and not hidden in the middle of a sentence as if nothing had happened. That's the office's own rule, and a good one. Write in your own hand today, and every day after, and don't trouble yourself trying to write like me. Nobody thanks a chronicler for pretending to be the last one."

Last of all she took up the key, and held it a moment in her closed hand before she gave it over, and Sileas understood, without being told, that this was the part of the afternoon Beathag had least wanted to hurry.

"This opens the press where the sealed things go," Beathag said. "Not the day-book. The day-book is open to any soul who comes and asks, and so it should stay, whatever the council or anyone above the council would rather. This is for the other kind. You'll know the difference when it comes to you, and it will come to you, sooner than you'd wish, if the roads north stay as they are this autumn." She closed Sileas's fingers over the key with her own thin ones. "Write what you are let, Sileas, and write it as fully and as plainly as if no one would ever grudge you a word of it. But write down, too, what you are not let, and where, and by whom, and on what day, even if all you can write is that a letter went out and a silence came back. A chronicle that only shows what it was free to show is no chronicle at all in the end. It is a fair copy of somebody else's leave."

"And if the leave never comes?"

"Then the silence is the record," Beathag said, "and you set it down as carefully as you would set down a battle, because it very likely is one, only fought with paper instead of anything sharper, and paper battles are the ones that get lost soonest if nobody minds to keep the score."

She said little else. She looked once round the room, at Tormod Pinn's chair that neither of them had ever used, and at the window on the paper-mill's wheel, and picked up the small bag she had packed the evening before for the carrier who would take her north-east to Àth dhìreach and her sister's house the following morning, and went to the door, and there stopped, and turned back only far enough to say that Sileas should not get up, since a chronicler did not rise for a chronicler, only for the office, and the office had already changed hands and was sitting, at that moment, in the chair behind the desk.

The carrier's cart stood waiting in the yard below when Beathag came down the outside stair the next morning, the bag already stowed under the seat and a rug laid ready across the boards, and there was nobody there to see her off but the carrier himself and, at the last, Raghnall mac Mhuirich, who came out from the door of the reading-room in his shirtsleeves with ink still on his fingers and said only that he hoped the road stayed dry as far as Àth dhomhain, since the low ford there was no friend to a laden cart in wet weather. Beathag said she had crossed that ford in every kind of weather it owned and did not expect this crossing to be the one that taught her anything new about it. He handed her up himself, though the carrier stood ready to do it, and stepped back, and the cart went out under the arch and down toward the river road, and that, so far as an Leabharlann's own telling goes, was the whole of the leave-taking: a dry ford wished for, and a hand given, and no more said than the road wanted.

Sileas sat where she was told to sit until the door had closed and the footsteps had gone down the stair and out into the yard, and then a good while longer, with the key still warm from Beathag's hand and the pen dry in the stand before her. When at last she drew the half-finished page toward her and dipped the pen, her own hand, she noticed, ran a shade smaller and a shade more upright than Beathag's, and she let it run so rather than try to match the older woman's slant, remembering what she had been told about pretending. She finished the day's entry, the ordinary business of an ordinary summer's day at an Leabharlann, in her own hand entire, and at the foot of it, where the office's custom asked for nothing more, she wrote one further line, because it seemed to her, sitting alone

in the room for the first time as its chronicler, that the custom had left a silence exactly where Beathag had told her a chronicler ought never to leave one.

This day the office passed from Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh to Sileas nic Rath, by the council's leave and the outgoing chronicler's own naming. What follows in this book is written by the second hand, and the reader is told so here, once, so that it need not be said again.

She read the line back twice, found nothing in it she wished to soften, and set the pen down beside the inkstand that had been Tormod Pinn's and was now, in the way such things become true only by being used, her own.

Of the Old Names Read Aloud

DE 20

I

Of the Rolls Brought from the Chests

The order came up from Cathair dhearg in an Dàmhair, and it said nothing of war. It said that certain companies, disbanded since An Dealachadh¹, were to be reformed for the guarding of the coal roads and the dubhan depots against disorder, and it named no enemy, because to name one would have been to say aloud what everyone from the clerk who copied it to the boy who carried it already knew and none of them, that autumn, would yet say.

Somhairle mac Lachlainn read it twice at the depot below the western Seann Skell, standing in the yard among the barrels his own company had built the shed to hold, and put it in his coat and went on with the day's business as though it changed nothing, the kind of thing he had learned to do in eighteen years among Comhairle nam Mèinnean²'s enforcers. A man who showed what an order meant to him before his own men had time to decide for themselves what it meant lost a measure of trust he did not get back. He had learned that on the road to Muileann àrsaidh with stones coming out of the dark, and he had learned it again writing the report of that night, choosing each word the way a man picks his footing on wet rock.

He was summoned to the capital three weeks after, in the first cold week of an t-Samhain, and rode down by Slighe a' Ghuail³ with a corporal and a leather

1. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

satchel of the depot's returns he did not expect anyone to ask for. Nobody did. He was taken instead, the morning after he arrived, to an old drill hall behind the council's own rooms, a building he had never had reason to enter, long and low, of dressed stone, its high windows gone grey with age and cobweb; used in his own lifetime, so far as he knew, for nothing grander than the storing of the city watch's spare pikes.

Three men were waiting for him there: the master of Comhairle nam Mèin-nean, a clerk he did not know with an ink-stained sleeve, and an old soldier called Cormac Liath whom Somhairle had met twice before at musters and taken, both times, for a man kept on past his use out of courtesy. It was Cormac Liath who did the talking that morning, and Somhairle understood before the man had said three sentences why he had been wrong to write him off.

"You'll have command," Liath said, without any of the preamble Somhairle had braced for. "Of what there is to command, which by spring will be more than there is now. The council has not said war, and will go on not saying it as long as the word can be kept out of a minute. You'll say muster, and mobilisation, and the guarding of the roads, and you'll be right to, because those are the true words for what you're doing this month. Whether they're the true words for what you'll be doing by harvest is not for you or me to say today."

"And the men?"

"That's why you're here." Liath nodded to the clerk, who set his satchel on the long table that ran the hall's length and began, with the particular carefulness of a man handling a thing he has been told is old and is not sure how old, to lift out ledgers bound in board gone soft and dark at the corners.

They were the rolls of Buidhnean an Dealachaidh⁴, and Somhairle had heard of them the way a man hears of a relic kept behind glass in a chapel he does not often visit: known to exist, never expected to be taken down and read. Ninety years they had lain in the council's chests, through reigns and rulings and the slow forgetting that overtakes any roll nobody calls, and the ink in some of them had gone the colour of weak tea, and in one, near the bottom of the stack, whole pages had stuck together and had to be worked apart with a blunt knife, the clerk's hands not quite steady at it, so that Somhairle found himself wanting to take the knife from him and could not, from his place at the far end of the table, have said whether it was patience or unfitness that kept him from offering.

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

4. the war-companies of the Severance

"These name the companies," Liath said. "Not by number. By what they were called when they were raised, which was mostly for the town that raised them, or for whoever led the raising, or once or twice for a reason no living man can now explain, so that you'll find a company of An Dealachadh called simply the Grey House, and nobody in this room can tell you why, and neither could the last three clerks who had charge of this hall before this one." He laid his hand flat on the topmost ledger, not turning it. "The council wants the new companies to carry the old names, when a name can be matched to a town still standing and willing to give men. It will do the recruiting more good than any bill posted at a market cross. Men come readier to a name their grandfathers marched under than to a number stamped fresh on a drumhead."

Somhairle thought, though he did not say it, that the council wanted one thing more besides, to make the thing feel less new than it was, to dress a war nobody had yet agreed to call a war in the coat of something the kingdom had done before and survived; but he had learned, in the same eighteen years, when a thought of that kind was worth the saying and when it was better kept behind the teeth, and this, with Liath's hand still on the ledger and the master of Comhairle nam Mèinnean watching him with the patient, unhurried attention of a man who has already decided what he thinks of you and is only waiting to see whether you will confirm it, was plainly not a morning for saying it.

"Read them, then," he said instead.

It took the rest of that day and most of the next. Liath read, in a voice gone dry and even with age but not weak, town by town, company by company, and the clerk set down beside each name whether the town it had been raised from still stood, still had men of an age to carry arms, and still lay within a day's reach of a road Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn's dubhan carts could use, for a company that could not be supplied might as well not be raised. Some towns answered to their names still and would send men gladly, the master of Comhairle nam Mèinnean said, reading from a paper of his own; the fisher towns of the east coast, quick to feel any threat to their harbours, and the market towns of the centre that had grown fat on the coal trade and now stood to grow fatter still on the trade that had replaced it. Other names on the roll answered to nothing at all, because the town was gone, swallowed into a larger one or fallen to a scatter of farms with no muster-ground left standing, and those were struck through in the clerk's

5. the Rail Board; lit. 'the board of the iron way'

hand and set aside, and nobody in the room remarked on it, though Somhairle noticed that Liath's reading grew a shade quieter over each one, as a man's voice does at a grave he did not expect to be asked to visit.

By the second afternoon the light in the high windows had gone from grey to the deeper grey that in that month passed for evening, and lamps were brought in, four of them, hung from iron brackets along the wall that Somhairle guessed had not held a flame in years, because the first one smoked and stank before it caught and burned clean. It was dubhan in the lamps, of course; there was no coal issued to a drill hall that had stood empty a generation, and Somhairle watched the black smoke go up in a thin curl to the rafters and thought, not for the first time that autumn, how strange a thing it was that the fuel a man in the north had made to warm his own hearth now lit the room where his own people's old names were being taken down off a shelf to be used against, whatever the council chose to call it this month, his own people's children.

The last of the rolls was read as full dark came on outside, by lamplight that threw the four men's shadows long and doubled up the hall's stone walls, and when Liath's voice stopped at the final name, a company once raised at a town on Slighe a' Ghuail whose muster-ground, the clerk found on checking, was now a rail siding with three sheds and a signal box, the room held a silence that none of the four men seemed in any hurry to break. It was Somhairle who broke it at last, because someone had to, and because command, he was beginning to understand, meant chiefly that whichever silence nobody else would break fell to you.

"How many companies stand, once the dead towns are struck out?"

The clerk added a column that had lain untotaled since the reading began and gave him the figure. It was not a large one, set beside what the roll had once named, ninety years before, when the whole of the kingdom's strength had stood behind Cogadh nam Beann⁶; but it was more than Somhairle had commanded at any one time in his years with Comhairle nam Mèinnean's enforcers, and he found, hearing it said aloud in that cold hall by lamplight that smelled of the fuel a Tuathach had made, that it settled on him with a weight he had not braced for. The number did not frighten him. What weighed was that it was his, from that evening, to answer for, in a way that the depot and its barrels and the road below the western Seann Skell had never quite been.

6. the War of the Hills, called also the Severance war

"Then we begin with those," Liath said, and closed the topmost ledger, and Somhairle understood that the reading was over and the rest, whatever it turned out to be called, was now his own to carry.

Before the clerk began to pack the ledgers away, Somhairle asked to see the list of the towns still standing, and read it through himself by the last of the lamp-light, slower than Liath had read it aloud, because a name on a page took longer to settle in the mind than a name spoken once and moved past. He knew most of the towns for what they were now rather than what the roll called them, market towns grown fat on the coal trade that had since gone south, fishing harbours that had never had much cause to think of the western hills at all until a company was named for them ninety years before and left, since, to gather dust; and he found himself doing, without quite meaning to, the same sum the clerk had done all afternoon with his careful column of struck-out names, setting each town against what he remembered of it from his own years riding the coal roads, and asking of each, silently, whether the men it sent him now would know, or care, what their grandfathers' company had once been called.

"You've a corporal of your own with you," Liath said, watching him at it. "Bring him in tomorrow and let him hear the names as you heard them today. A man who has heard a thing said once in a lamplit hall carries it differently to his own company than a man only handed a paper."

Somhairle thought of the corporal who had ridden down with him, a steady, unremarkable man named Iain Dòmhnallach who had served two years under him at the western Seann Skell without once, so far as Somhairle knew, asking why any order he was given had been given, and wondered whether that was the kind of man the old rolls wanted brought in to hear them, or whether it was precisely the kind that did not need to be, having never in his service shown any sign of asking the questions a hall full of ninety-year-old names was meant, Somhairle supposed, to answer before they were asked.

"I'll bring him," he said, and left it there.

II

Of the Bench in the Passage



artha Greaves kept the feast that year in a hired carriage on the northern road south, with a rug over her knees that did little against the cold

coming up through the floorboards and a basket at her feet holding bread and a cold fowl that Ellen Marsh had pressed on her at the last that she had not yet found the heart to eat. She had left Doire ghlas two days before an Nollaig¹, when Athchuinge Dheireannach an Tionail² was at last agreed word for word after a sitting that ran past midnight, and had travelled since by whatever the season offered: a carrier's cart as far as the boundary of the shires, a dubhan coach from there, and this last hired carriage, its wheels loud on the frozen ruts, for the stretch into the capital that no coach ran on an Nollaig Eve.

She had never in her life kept the day travelling, and she did not, in the small hours somewhere south of the boundary stones with the carriage jolting and her breath showing white even under the rug, allow herself to think overmuch about what her mother would have said of a woman who did. The Dia-thírich kept no feast that day at all, which was one small mercy in a season that had offered her few, since it meant the roads she travelled were not crowded with those keeping it properly, at home, by a fire, as she should by rights have been keeping it herself.

The petition rode in her lap the whole way, in a leather folder Peter Hale had made her promise to guard as though it were the crown, which she had thought at the time a young man's overstatement and had come, somewhere past the second night without proper sleep, to find less funny than he had meant it. It asked one thing only, in words Tíonal nan Tuathach³ had turned over for the better part of a fortnight until every clause said exactly what it meant and no more: that the western pits be let alone to work out their own seams, since by every honest reckoning the coal in them would be spent within a handful of years regardless of what any board or council did about it now, and that the kingdom, having already the whole of the south's new fuel to warm it, might find in its own patience a cheaper peace than in any company it could raise to enforce the alternative.

She came into Cathair dhearg in the grey forenoon of an Nollaig, with frost lying white and undisturbed on the parapet of the bridge because so few feet had crossed it that morning to wear it away, and paid off the carriage driver, who wished her the day's blessings in the human way out of what she took for simple habit and then looked faintly embarrassed at himself for it, as a man does who has said a thing to the wrong company. She found the council's building without dif-

1. Christmas

2. the Moot's last petition

3. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

ficulty, having been given careful directions by Peter Hale from a visit of his own some years before, and was shown by a porter, once she had stated her business and waited while he went to ask whether her business was in fact wanted, to a bench in a stone passage off the main hall, where she was told the council would see her when it saw fit and not before.

More times than she could easily have counted, from her years managing the mill at Doire ghlais and her years since in Tional nan Tuathach's own chair, she had sat waiting on hard benches, and had thought, before this morning, that waiting was a thing she had grown past minding. The cold of the stone under her had little to do with it, nor the ache of two nights without a proper bed still in her back; it was the particular smallness of sitting in a passage that was not built to hold anyone for long, with nothing on the walls to look at but a row of framed grants she did not trouble to read and a single high window that showed her nothing of the sky but a strip of flat white cloud. Sitting there, she thought of the morning twelve years before when Thomas Rook had read Daniel Frayne's death into Tional nan Tuathach's own minute and the room had stood for the space of a breath and sat down again, and how strange it was that the office that morning had handed her without her asking for it should end, or at least come to this particular passage, on a bench built for men who did not expect to be kept waiting and had never once, in the building of it, thought to ask whether a woman from the north might someday be.

She waited the better part of an hour. The bench was cold enough that she kept her cloak about her the whole time, and the passage carried, faintly and by turns, voices from the chamber at its end, none of them clear enough to make out a word, only the rise and fall of men taking turns to speak and be answered, which told her nothing except that the council was, in fact, sitting, and had not, as she had half feared through the last two days of travel, adjourned for the feast after all and left her to have come all this way for a locked door. Twice in that hour she took the petition out of its folder, her hands wanting a thing to hold besides their own stillness, and twice she put it back unread, since she had written half of it herself and could have said it from memory standing on her own doorstep at Doire ghlais without troubling to look.

A clerk came out at last, a young man with the particular brisk courtesy of someone who has been told to be courteous and has not yet had time to make it his own, and asked her name. She gave it, and he wrote it on a small paper he carried, and went back in, and she heard, a moment later, her own name said

through the door in a voice not his, in a shape she did not at first know for hers at all: the surname set first, in the way of the island's own houses, and the whole of it given the turn of the tongue that made every foreign name that passed through this building sound, by the time it reached the room, a little more like the island's own. She sat a second longer than she meant to before she understood that it was her they were calling, and stood then quickly, gathering the folder and her cloak together in a way that felt, to her own eye if to nobody else's, less composed than she had meant to arrive.

The chamber, when she came into it, was smaller than she had pictured it in the two days of travelling here, and warmer, with a dubhan stove set in an alcove at one side throwing a heat she felt at once after the cold of the passage, so that for the first few moments she was more aware of her own numbed hands beginning to prickle back to life than of the room. It took her a breath or two to see it properly: a long table, twelve chairs about it, and in every chair a face turned toward the door, toward her, with the particular stillness of people interrupted in the middle of business they had expected to finish uninterrupted. She knew none of them by sight save one, Anna nic Phàil, whom she had met once at a market charter's signing three years before and who gave her now, across the width of the table, the smallest incline of the head, not quite a greeting, more an acknowledgement that the room held one other person who had not always sat in rooms like this one.

She was the first speaker of Tìonal nan Tuathach, in all the years since Walter Hale had first gathered the northern towns to speak with one voice, to walk into this chamber at all. Nobody told her so; she understood it crossing the floor, from the feel of a room that did not often see a stranger cross it, the twelve faces following her the whole short distance from the door to the place, some six feet short of the table's head, where the same clerk who had called her name now stood waiting with a look that told her, plainly enough, that this was as far as she was meant to come. She learned afterward that she had understood rightly, and was not surprised.

"You may read it," said the man at the table's head, an old man she did not know, his voice carrying easily in a room built, she thought, for exactly that kind of voice.

She read it standing, holding the leather folder open in both hands because her hands, still not quite recovered from the cold, did not entirely trust themselves with a single sheet. She read it through without hurrying, though every instinct in

her wanted to hurry, to be done and out of the room and back on the cold road north where she understood, at least, the weather and the company; she read it the way Peter Hale had made her practise it twice in Tional nan Tuathach's own hall before she left, slowly enough that no clause outran its own sense, pausing where the sentence paused and nowhere else. The room heard her out in a silence she could not read at all, twelve faces giving back nothing she could carry home and tell Tional nan Tuathach she had seen, no nod, no frown, nothing but the ordinary attention of people listening to a thing they had already, she suspected, been told the substance of before she ever crossed the bridge that morning.

She came to the last line, the offer of patience in place of a company, and let it stand a moment in the warm air of the chamber before she folded the paper closed and stepped forward the last few feet to lay it on the table, in the space the old man at its head cleared for it with one hand without otherwise moving.

"Received," said the clerk at her side, and wrote it down.

That was the whole of the answer the room gave her that morning: one word, said by a man who was not one of the twelve, and the small dry sound of a pen crossing paper. Nobody at the table spoke to her directly, then or after; the old man at its head inclined his own head slightly, in a gesture that might have been thanks and might only have been the signal that her business was finished, and the porter who had shown her in was already at her elbow to show her out again, as though the room's whole business with her had been measured beforehand to the minute and now, that minute spent, must close over the gap she had made in it and go on to whatever had stood next on its morning's list before she came.

Crossing back to the door, she thought of the letter she would have to write Tional nan Tuathach when she came home, and of how little there would be to put in it beside the one word and the small dry sound that had followed it. A room capable of measuring a stranger's whole business to the minute, she thought too, though she did not let it slow her step, was not a room that had been surprised by anything the petition asked of it, which meant that whatever answer the western towns were eventually to have, it had very likely already been settled, in some other room than this one, before she had ever climbed into the hired carriage two mornings before.

The cold struck her at once through the door before it had even fully shut, back in the passage, and there she let herself, for the first time since Doire ghlas, feel the whole distance she had come to hear one word said once. Weeping had never in her life answered anything, and she did not begin now; but she stood a

while by the cold bench she had waited on, not sitting again, only standing, with the empty folder under her arm and her own breath white in front of her, until the porter, waiting with the particular patience of a man paid to wait, asked whether she wished him to find her a carriage back north, and she said that she did, and let him.

The petition she never saw again. It went, she supposed, wherever a filed thing goes in a room she had been in only the once, into some clerk's press among the year's other business, to be found, if it ever was found, by whoever next had reason to open that drawer and ask what Tional nan Tuathach had wanted, that an Nollaig, and what the council had answered it. She thought of it, on the long cold road back, less as a paper than as the one word the room had spent on it, turned over so many times in the two days of travel that had brought her here and the two more that would take her home again that by the time she came in sight of Doire ghlas's own lit windows, late on the second night after, she had almost stopped hearing it as a word at all, and heard instead only the sound the clerk's pen had made, crossing the paper, once, and then lying still.

Of the Arms Trains

DE 21

Part Four · Of Blàr Àth leathan and the First Summer

Airson ùine. For a time.

— the council's word on Deachamh a' Chogaidh, DE 21

What is told here of the war comes from An Clàr Foscailte, the towns' reports and Sceulachdan nan Tuathach; the rest is sealed. What follows is what was seen and what was written down at the time: from a footplate on Slighe a' Ghuail's western branch, and from a trestle table above a pit village where a woman kept a list.

I

Of the Trains That Ran by Night

E achann mac Ruairidh had driven on Slighe a' Ghuail¹ for three-and-thirty years and the dubhan trains for thirteen of them, and in all that time he had never once been asked to carry a crate he was not told the weight of. That changed on the second night of am Faoilleach, when the yard foreman at Muileann chrom came down the line with a paper in his hand and a lantern that threw more shadow than light and told him his engine would take on eight wagons before dawn, loaded by Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn²'s own men, and that he was not, this once nor any night after, to ask what was in them.

"Weight's on the manifest," the foreman said, holding the paper up rather than handing it across, as though the handing across were itself a thing to be careful of.

1. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

2. the Rail Board; lit. 'the board of the iron way'

"That's all the manifest's for, this trip. You'll sign for the weight and not the goods."

Eachann had signed a good many papers in his time on the footplate without reading past the figure at the bottom, and he signed this one the same way, though he noted, as a man notes weather he means to remember, that the foreman did not meet his eye while he did it. The eight wagons came on through the small hours behind a screen of tarpaulin that Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn's men kept up even inside the shed, working by shuttered lamps and speaking to one another, when they spoke at all, in the flat short sentences of men who have been told exactly how much to say and have decided to say less than that. Eachann's own second man, a broad quiet man of Muileann chrom who had ridden with him three years and asked him nothing that night either, watched the gauges in silence and once, when a case slipped an inch on its rollers and struck the wagon's floor with a sound too dull and too heavy for tools, looked across at Eachann in the lamplight and looked away again without a word passing between them.

They ran west before first light, Slighe a' Ghuail proper past Muileann mhin and the goods-sheds at Cathair dhearg, and beyond the capital onto the western branch, single-tracked and slower, that Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn had laid twenty years before to carry lime and slate down to the coast and had carried little enough of either since. It was dubhan in the tank now as it had been for thirteen years, and Eachann had long since stopped missing the coal's particular heat, though he still, on a cold footplate in the first mile, found himself listening for the crackle of a fire that was not there and hearing instead the flat, steady beat of the engine. The branch ran through country he had known since he was a boy riding with his own father on the coal trains, low hills going up into the higher ones, farms and a scatter of pit villages whose lamps, this deep in winter, were most of them out before his engine passed, and he drove it that first night, and every night after through the rest of the month, at a speed the branch's condition did not properly allow, because the manifest that rode with him now, whatever else it did not say, said plainly enough that speed mattered more than the branch's rails did.

By the middle of the month it had become his run and no other's, given him, he understood without being told outright, because the yard's masters had found him steady and asked no questions of him twice, which in that season had come to count for more than the years he had spent learning every gradient of the line by feel. He ran the double shift the yard had gone to that winter, out on the down run with the wagons and back light before noon, and slept what hours he could

in the drivers' room at Muileann chrom with the other men of the arms trains, none of whom spoke much of the work either, though Eachann noticed that they had all, every one of them, taken to a particular silence about the eight wagons that was not quite the silence they kept about anything else, a silence with a kind of care folded into it, the way a man is careful crossing ice he has been told will bear him and has not tested for himself.

He did not open the crates. That, he told himself those first weeks, was no more than the ordinary discipline of the line, the same discipline that had him signing for coal tonnage he never counted sack by sack; and it was only later, well into the month, hauling the same eight wagons west through a night of driving sleet with the branch's rails slick under him and the manifest folded in his coat where it had ridden since the foreman first handed it across, that he let himself think plainly what any man on that footplate would have known from the weight alone and the care Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn's men took loading it, that he was carrying arms west to Seann Bhral, and that a man does not load arms onto a train bound for a river port below the western hills unless he means, before long, to use them on the hills themselves.

At Seann Bhral, those first nights, he saw little of where the wagons' cargo went once it left his own charge. The quay there was new work, built out over the tidal mud in the two years since the river port had grown from a lime-boat's stopping-place into something Comhairle nam Mèinnean³ thought worth a covered shed and a length of proper stone, and Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn's men unloaded by lantern into a lorry that always stood waiting with its engine already turning over, so that the whole business, from the last wagon's door swung open to the lorry's tail-lamp vanishing up the coast road, took less time than it took Eachann to turn his engine on the triangle below the shed and see it faced back east. He asked, the second week, where the lorry went, of a stevedore he had exchanged a civil word with more than once over a winter of shared cold mornings, and got for his answer only a look that told him plainly enough the question had been heard, weighed, and judged not worth the trouble of an answer, and he did not ask it a second time.

He thought of this the way he thought of the manifest, which was to say he thought of it and put it from him, because the alternative, the thing his thinking kept circling toward and would not quite land on, was to ask himself what he

3. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

owed the men whose hills the line ran under, and he found, turning that question over on a cold footplate at three in the morning with thirty miles of bad rail still ahead of him, that he did not know the answer and was in no great hurry to find it before he had to. A driver of Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn since he was nineteen, and his father before him a driver of coal for the same line under the same board, he had never in either man's time on the footplate known it to be any part of a driver's trade to know what his cargo was for. He told himself this on the second night, and again on the ninth, and by the seventeenth had stopped telling himself anything at all, and drove.

The eighteenth night brought him, an hour past the second lamp-post below the capital's edge, a company on the branch road below the line, marching in the dark with lanterns swung low against the wet and a corporal at their head whom Eachann, slowing for the level crossing at that point, recognised by the set of his shoulders before he made out his face: a steady, unremarkable man he had carried west once before on an ordinary passenger working, three years and more back, a man he had exchanged no more than a dozen words with in that whole journey and remembered chiefly for having asked him, once, an intelligent question about the line's gradients that most passengers never thought to ask. He did not know the man's name then and did not learn it now; he only lifted a hand from the regulator as the engine passed above the marching company, an old habit from lonelier runs, and the corporal, glancing up at the sound of the engine, lifted his own hand in answer without breaking step, and the company went on into the dark toward the west, and Eachann's train went on into the dark toward the west a little faster, since arms do not wait on marching men and the manifest in his coat had never once, in eighteen nights, allowed him to slow for anyone.

It was the night after that, the third-from-last night of the month by his own count, though he had by then stopped keeping the calendar with any care, that he came, an hour before the false dawn that time of year brings before the true one, upon the family walking north along the line.

He saw them a long way off, the way a man on a footplate sees anything on a straight run at night, as a paleness first and then a shape and only at the last a family: a man and a woman and, between them, two children small enough to be half-carried, walking the cinder path beside the rails because the branch road that season was deep in mud and the cinder path, packed hard by generations of platelayers, was not. They had a handcart with them, piled with what a family carries when it is carrying everything it owns at once, and they walked, Eachann saw

as his lamp swept over them, with the particular steadiness of people who have already walked further than they meant to and have found that walking, once begun, is easier kept up than stopped. He knew them for Tuathaich before his lamp had fully passed over them, by the cut of the man's coat and by the way the woman carried the smaller child against her hip, a way of carrying he had seen at Caol mhòr's harbour a hundred times and never once, until that morning, seen on Slighe a' Ghuail's western branch, going north, away from the hills the arms in his wagons were bound for.

He did not stop. In the half-second such things take a man on a footplate doing forty miles an hour with thirty more still to run and a manifest in his coat that named a time at Seann Bhrál he could not miss, the reasons came to him ready-made: that a train running arms west did not slow for anyone on the line whatever the hour or whoever they were, that the family, whatever had put them on that path at that hour, were plainly bound the opposite way from wherever his own night's work would end, and that whatever had set a family walking north with a handcart in the dark of am Faoilleach was no business a driver could mend from a moving footplate in any case. All of this was true, and none of it, he found afterward, sitting in the drivers' room at Muileann chrom with a mug of something hot going cold in his two hands, was the reason he had not stopped, and the reason he had not stopped was one he did not put into words that night nor for a good while after, though he came, in the months the arms trains ran, to know it well enough by the feel of it, which was that stopping would have meant knowing something about the family that not stopping let him not know, and that a man who has agreed to sign for weight and not for goods finds, given the practice of a few weeks, that the same discipline serves for a good deal else besides.

He did not look back. The line ran straight enough there that he could have, in the lamp's last light before the curve, but he kept his eyes on the rail ahead and his hand on the regulator and let the family go by behind him into the dark, and drove on to Seann Bhrál, where Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn's men were waiting on the quay with lanterns and a covered lorry, exactly as they had waited every night that month, to take the eight wagons' cargo off his hands and into their own keeping, and ask him, as they always did, for nothing but his signature on the manifest, which he gave them, and turned his engine, and ran light back east before the true dawn came up grey over hills he had, by then, stopped letting himself look at from the footplate at all.

II

Of the List at Àth leathan

Ruth Calder had kept lists her whole life, first her father's tally-books and then, these five years past, Còrdadh Muileann àrsaidh¹'s own accounts, and she had thought, before the last week of am Faoilleach, that she knew the shape a list could take. She learned otherwise standing at the mouth of the road into Àth leathan on a morning so cold the ink in her pen thickened between names, watching the hewers of five towns come down out of the hills by paths no cart had ever used, with their pit-lamps lit at noon.

They came first from Cnoc thais, forty men and more under Tom Varley, down the drove track that ran along the ridge and had not carried so many feet at once, Ruth thought, since An Dealachadh² itself; then from Àth naomh, a smaller company but no less determined, the men walking two abreast where the path allowed it as though even now, arriving at another town's pit-head with nothing to defend but their own presence, they meant to be seen keeping order; then, through the afternoon and into a second cold dusk, the men of Muileann àrsaidh and Tobar dhearg of the hills in smaller parties, some of them boys of fourteen who had never cut a working face in their lives but whose fathers or brothers or, in two cases that Ruth wrote down and did not trust herself to think about further, whose whole households had already come, so that there was nobody left at home to keep them from it.

Sarah Dunmore sent down from Muileann àrsaidh, with the second of her town's parties, two cartloads of oatmeal and a barrel of salted fish that her own kitchen could ill spare, with a note pinned to the barrel's lid in a hand Ruth knew for hers, saying only that a company that had not eaten would not stand the walk home again whatever else the week brought, and asking no thanks and expecting, Ruth judged from the note's shortness, none given. Ruth set a boy to portioning it out at the pit-shed door, one bowl to a name checked off her own list, and found, doing the sum of oatmeal against mouths on the second evening, that Sarah's two cartloads would carry the gathering perhaps nine days at the ration she judged safe to set, and said nothing of that figure to anyone, since a number a company cannot mend by any labour of its own is not a number worth handing round a cold pit-shed at dusk.

1. the western pit towns' agreement

2. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

Tobar dhearg's men, last of the five towns to arrive and fewest, came down a path so little used that two of the older hewers had to be sent ahead the day before to cut back the whin that had grown across it in the years since anyone had walked it in company; there were but eleven of them in all, every man the hill town's one pit could spare and still keep a face working, and their captain, a stooped man older than Tom Varley and older, Ruth thought, than the walk down should rightly have let him manage, set his lamp on her trestle table before he gave her his own name, as though the lamp itself, and not the man carrying it, were the thing that most wanted counting.

Why the lamps, lit and carried at noon when there was no working face at the end of any of these paths to light, Ruth did not ask any of them, because she did not need to. She had grown up among hewers and knew a hewer's habits the way she knew her own hands: a lit lamp carried openly, at noon, on a hill path, was not light a man needed to see by, it was a thing said without saying it, the way a company musters under its own colours rather than marching bare, and she understood, watching the first of Cnoc thais's lamps come down off the ridge in the grey early light, that the men carrying them meant the whole of the western hills to see, from every farmhouse window between here and the sea, that the pits' own men were coming to Àth leathan and coming as pit men, lamps lit, not as anything the council or Comhairle nam Mèinnean³ might afterward choose to call them.

She kept her list at a trestle table set up in the lee of the Àth leathan pit-shed, with Tom Varley beside her the first two days until Cnoc thais's own numbers were fully in and he judged his own presence better spent seeing to the byres, and she wrote down every name that came to her, town by town, with the age of each man or boy where she troubled to ask it and a mark against those who had brought their own tools, since tools, in the weeks that followed, proved harder to find than men willing to carry them. By the fourth day the pit-sheds at Àth leathan, three of them standing since before her father's father worked the seam, were full to their rafters with men sleeping on straw laid over the old floor timbers, and the byres behind the chapel, given over by families who had, most of them, already sent a son or a husband to be counted at her own table, held the overflow, cattle moved out into whatever shelter a hedge or a drystone wall could offer in a month that gave them precious little of either.

3. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

She did not, in all those days, let herself think overlong about what the list was for. It was, on its face, no more than a count: how many men, from which town, with what tools, so that whoever came after her with the harder questions, feeding them, arming what few of them could be armed, finding them somewhere to stand when the day came that everyone at Àth leathan now spoke of only as "when it comes" and never named further, would have a true number to work from rather than a guess. She told herself this each evening, going back over the day's names by lamplight in the small room above the pit-shed office that had been given her for the writing, and she believed it, mostly, and it was only on the sixth evening, with the list grown past four hundred names and the ink gone thick again in the cold, that Tom Varley came in from checking the last of the byres and told her, in the flat voice he had taken to using for anything he judged she needed to hear and would not thank him for, that Comhairle nam Mèinnean kept a list too.

"Whose is it," she asked, though she had already half guessed the answer from his voice before he gave it.

"Comhairle nam Mèinnean's, out of Cathair mhòr," he said. "A clerk of Seumas mac Eachainn's office let it slip to a carter at Seann Skell, and the carter told it to a man at Cnoc thais, and the man at Cnoc thais told me on the drove path coming down. Two names on it above every other, he said. Yours and mine."

She sat with the pen still in her hand and did not write anything for a moment, looking at the page of names she had taken all that week, four hundred and some men and boys of five towns who had walked to Àth leathan carrying lit lamps at noon because a lit lamp said what none of them had the words, or perhaps only the wish, to say outright; and the thought that had circled her all that winter came to her now fully formed, that a list is a strange kind of thing to be the author of, since the same discipline that let her set down four hundred names in a clean careful hand for the hills' own use was, on some other table in Cathair mhòr, being used to set down two names, hers and Tom's, for a use she did not need Tom to spell out further.

"Then they'll know where to look for us," she said, "when it comes."

"They knew that already," Tom said. "It's not as though we've been hiding at Àth leathan." He said it without much heat, the way a man states a fact he has already made his peace with, and went to see about the last of the straw for the newest arrivals, and Ruth sat on a while longer with her own list open before her, running her thumb down the column of names as though the touch of the page

might tell her something the ink itself did not, before she closed the book and blew out the lamp and went down to see that the pit-shed fires, banked low against the cold, were not banked so low that a man might wake in the night and find himself colder than the walk down from his own hill farm had already left him.

Word of the regiments' setting out reached Àth leathan on the six-and-twentieth of am Faoilleach, carried up the western road by a carter who had watched them pass below Cathair dhearg on the three-and-twentieth and made the walk north as fast as a laden cart could manage once he had seen enough to know it was worth the telling. They had gone by the western road, he said, companies enough to fill it from verge to verge for the better part of an hour, their lorries running on dubhan the whole column's length, so that the road smelled, he told it, of a fuel the western hills had never burned a barrel of and never meant to, going west now ahead of the men who were to use it, to Seann Skell in the west where the enforcers had sat quartered these two years and more waiting for exactly this company to come and join them.

Ruth heard it standing at her trestle table with the day's last names not yet entered, and found, hearing it, that she felt none of the surprise she might have expected of herself a month before, only a kind of settling, the way a held breath settles once the thing waited for has at last, for good or ill, arrived. She looked down the pit-shed row at the lamps still burning here and there among the sleeping men, small steady flames against a cold that showed no sign yet of any spring; and she opened her book to a clean page, dipped her thickened pen, and began, because it was the only work she properly knew how to do and the only answer she had left to give a Board that had already, by its own list, given its answer to her, to count once more, town by town, how many men Àth leathan now held who had come to it carrying a lit lamp at noon and meant, whatever the road below Cathair dhearg was now carrying west to meet them, to be there still when it came.

OF Blàr Àth leathan

II AN GIBLEAN DE 21

I

Of the Burn in Spate

The three months since the regiments went west had been the slowest Ruth Calder had ever lived through, and also, she came to think afterward, the fastest, in the way that a long wait can be both at once: slow in the living of each single day at the pit-shed office with the fires banked and the ink freezing, and fast in the looking back, so that am Faoilleach and an Gearran together seemed, from the far side of them, to have gone by in the time it took to draw one long breath. Word had come up the western road twice a week or better, carried by carters who had their own reasons to travel Slighe a' Ghuail¹'s western branch and their own reasons, most of them, to be glad of the coin Ruth paid for a true account rather than a rumour dressed up as one: that the enforcers held the western Seann Skell in strength; that the regiments camped beside them through the worst of the winter and drilled, when the ground allowed it, on the flats above the river; that the manor house had been made a headquarters and the maor's own hall a store for the lorries' fuel. None of it told her a day or an hour, only the slow gathering of a thing readying to move, and she had learned, through those weeks, to read it the way her father had taught her to read a seam before it gave, from the sum of many small signs taken together.

She had not looked for the thaw to come so fast. Through am Faoilleach and into an Gearran the snow had lain deep enough on the hill paths that the companies coming in from Muileann àrsaidh and Tobar dhearg of the hills went a full

1. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

day slower than the walk should have taken, and she had grown used to a world of white fields and black timber and a cold that got into the ink and stayed there. Then in the first week of an Giblean the wind came round to the south-west and did not go back, and within four days the snow was gone off every slope but the north faces of the higher hills, and the burn below Àth leathan, which she had crossed dry-shod as a girl in most winters, came up brown and quick and loud enough that she heard it from her window in the pit-shed office before she was properly awake.

She went down to look at it on the tenth, the evening before, with Tom Varley beside her because he had taken to walking the ground with her most evenings that month, the two of them saying little and looking hard at whatever there was to look at. The ford below the pit-heads, which any cart had crossed dry in a normal spring, was gone under two feet of brown water moving fast enough to turn a stick end over end, and the flat meadow beyond it, the one everyone at Àth leathan still called the fair field though no fair had been held there in three years, lay soft and dark with the last of the melt still standing in its furrows.

"They'll not bring a lorry over that," Tom said, meaning the ford, and meaning by it more than the ford.

"They'll not need to," Ruth said. "The road from Seann Skell doesn't cross it. It comes down the near side and stops at the pit-heads. Whatever they bring, they bring it dry."

She had walked that road herself twice that winter, once as far as the river and once, in secret and against Tom's counsel, most of the way to Seann Skell, to see with her own eyes what the carter's word had already told her: the regiments quartered beside the enforcers, their lorries drawn up in rows under canvas, more of them than she had troubled to count past a hundred because the counting past a hundred did not change what she meant to do about it. She had not told the five towns the whole of what she saw, only Tom, and Tom had told the pit captains, who told their own companies only so much as steadied a man rather than loosened his knees, which was the same discipline she had grown up watching her father keep about a bad seam or a flooding gallery, and which, standing at the swollen ford with three months of waiting behind her and a night before whatever the morning brought, she still knew how to keep.

The five towns had been at Àth leathan since the last week of am Faoilleach, near enough four hundred names on her first count and closer to five hundred and fifty by the time the last of Tobar dhearg's boys came down with their fathers

in an Gearran, once the whole matter had stopped being a gathering and become, in everything but the word for it, a muster that would not disperse. Through the waiting months she had done the thing that a captain's daughter does without being taught it in so many words, which was to turn a crowd of men and boys glad of one another's company into a body that could be told where to stand: five companies, one to a town, each under its own captain and answerable, in the matter of where the whole body moved and when, to Tom Varley, whom the five towns had agreed on without much debate once it was plain nobody much fancied the office and Tom least of anyone.

Cnoc thais's company was the largest, near a hundred and sixty under Tom himself, most of them hewers of his own two reopened shafts and the families that had followed the coal down from the ridge. Àth naomh's sixty-odd kept their two-abreast order even at the pit-head, a habit Ruth had stopped remarking on by the second week. Muileann àrsaidh sent the most of any single town, near two hundred, Sarah Dunmore's oatmeal carts having by then made three further journeys down from the mill, each one shorter than the last as the mill's own reserves thinned. Tobar dhearg of the hills sent, in the end, near forty, every man and boy the hill town's one pit could spare and a dozen more besides who had walked down all the same, leaving the pit worked by old men and women for the season. Àth leathan's own company was Ruth's, by the same accident of a dead father that had made her the towns' spokeswoman, and it stood at ninety hewers of the town's three pits, with a scatter of wives and elder daughters who had, by then, made themselves as much a part of the muster as any man with a pick, carrying water and dressings and, where a household had a fowling piece from before An Dealachadh² and no man left to carry it, carrying that too.

Nine hundred souls, near enough, stood at Àth leathan by the tenth of an Giblean, counting the carriers among them, and Ruth's list, grown thick with names crossed through and names added, held every one. Against them, by every account the carters brought up from the river, the kingdom would send near fourteen hundred, drawn from the companies quartered at Seann Skell and the enforcers already settled there, with lorries enough to carry them the five miles from the river port to the pit-heads in a single morning's work. Ruth had done that sum more than once through the winter, turning it over the way she turned over any figure that would not come out even, and had found, each time, that it

2. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

changed nothing about what the five towns meant to do, only the manner of doing it.

The waiting months had worn the gathering thinner in ways no muster roll troubled to record. Two of Sarah Dunmore's cart-horses had gone lame on the Muileann àrsaidh road and were not replaced; a fever had gone through the byres behind the chapel in an Gearran and taken an old woman of Cnoc thais who had come down only to be near her grandsons; Ellen Marsh, teaching still at Doire ghlas, had sent up through the winter two letters that Ruth kept folded inside the same list-book as the names, neither of them saying anything Comhairle nam Mèinnean³'s own censors would have troubled to strike out, both of them saying, in the plain way Ellen wrote everything, that the school's benches were being kept ready should any family need them. Ruth had not answered either letter. She was grateful for both, and she had found, by the second month of the muster, that she no longer trusted her own hand to write anything short enough to be worth the carter's trouble.

They had picks and shovels and the hewers' own short axes, sharpened that winter past any use a coal face had ever asked of them. They had, among the whole nine hundred, perhaps sixty firearms fit to be called such, most of them fowling pieces older than any man carrying them, a dozen better rifles bought or begged from who knew where and never asked after too closely, and four kegs of blasting powder from the pits themselves, which Tom Varley meant, if it came to that, for the narrow places where the road from Seann Skell ran between the spoil-heaps and the flooded lower galleries, where a charge set right might do more than sixty fowling pieces together.

"You'll not fire the powder unless I say," Tom told her that evening at the ford, not for the first time. "A charge set too soon warns them off the ground we want them on."

"I know it," Ruth said. "I've known it since you first told me, and the second time, and the third."

"I'll go on telling you," Tom said, "because it's the one thing between us and a rout, and I'd sooner bore you with it than have you forget it at the wrong minute." He said it without much heat, the way he said most things that winter, and Ruth, looking at the brown water going by faster than either of them could easily have swum it, found she was glad of the boring, glad of anything said

3. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

plainly and repeated, because the alternative, she had learned these three months, was a silence in which a person's own thoughts ran on faster than the burn.

She did not ask him, that evening, what he thought the morning would bring, because she had asked him some version of that question most evenings for a fortnight and had stopped expecting an answer different from the last. He only looked a while longer at the water, and then at the dark shapes of the pit-heads against a sky gone the colour of a struck match, and said that they should get what sleep the night would give them, because the towns' companies would want their captains steady in the morning whatever the morning brought.

On the way back she passed Tobar dhearg's captain, the stooped man who had brought his own lamp down off the hill path in am Faoilleach and set it on her trestle table before he gave his name, sitting outside his men's fire with a cup he was not drinking from. He asked her, in the flat way he asked most things, whether the chapel at Àth leathan would be open before light, and she told him it would, since the priest had said as much himself, and the old man nodded and said that a man ought to have been inside a chapel at least once before a morning like the one coming, whatever else the morning held, and that he meant to see to it his own men had the chance of it too, those who wanted it. Ruth said she would pass the word along the line, and did.

Walking back up to the pit-shed office with the ford's noise falling away behind her, she thought that Tom's answer, plain and repeated and not much of an answer on its own terms, was as near to one as she was likely to get, and found, turning it over, that it was answer enough.

II

Of the Word Ruth Gave at Dawn

She woke before light, as she had every morning that month without needing anyone to rouse her, and went out into a cold that had lost, overnight, the last hard edge of winter and taken on instead the raw, wet cold of a spring morning after rain, the kind that gets into a coat faster than any frost. The sky to the east, over the road from Seann Skell, was going from black to a grey the colour of wet slate, and the burn, louder now than it had been the evening before, ran on unseen below the pit-heads with a sound like water that had somewhere particular to be.

The companies were mustering already, town by town, along the low ground between the pit-sheds and the fair field, exactly as she and Tom had marked out the ground for them three evenings before: Cnoc thais on the left flank nearest the flooded lower gallery, where the ground did most of a wall's work; Àth naomh in the centre, keeping their two-abreast order even now, forming and re-forming it as their captain called them into it as though the order were a kind of armour worn; Muileann àrsaidh on the right, where the road from Seann Skell came down between the spoil-heaps into the narrowest ground of the whole field, the ground Tom's blasting powder was laid to answer if it came to that; Tobar dhearg's forty held back a little, by their own captain's word and not by anyone else's ordering, at the mouth of Àth leathan's own pit, where a man too old for the front line could still see what came and send word of it; and Àth leathan's ninety in the last gap between Àth naomh and the pit-heads proper, Ruth's own place among them though she carried, that morning, no pick and no fowling piece, only her list, folded small inside her coat where it had ridden for three months, and a lantern not yet lit.

She thought, standing a moment at the pit-shed door before she started down the line, of her father, five years dead now and buried at the chapel she had just sent word about, and of the last thing he had ever told her of the seam under Àth leathan, which was that a working face tells you what it means to do a long while before it does it, if you trouble to listen, and that the trouble of listening is most of what a captain is for. These three months she had listened to as much as the north's own carters and her own eyes could tell her, and this morning found she had run out of anything further the listening could give her; what was left was only the doing.

She went down the line as the light came up, as she had gone down it every morning of the muster, though this morning she found herself looking at faces rather than counting them, which she had not let herself do before: a boy of fourteen from Tobar dhearg whose father had come down with him and whose name, she remembered without needing the list, was the last one she had taken on the sixth evening of the gathering; one of Sarah Dunmore's carters, too old by rights for the front line and standing in it anyway because his two sons stood either side of him and he would not be parted from them; a woman of Àth naomh, no older than Ruth herself, with a fowling piece across her back and a baby not eight months born left, that morning, in the care of an aunt at the pit-shed, whose name Ruth had entered on her list under the mother's own insistence, since the

child was to be counted as being of the muster too, in some fashion the woman had not troubled to explain and Ruth had not troubled to question.

Along the line she passed the Muileann àrsaidh company forming up on the right, where Sarah Dunmore's carter stood between his two sons as he had every morning that month, and past him the company's own captain, a mill-hand turned pit-hand named for the season only as Muileann àrsaidh's captain, since he had never troubled anyone with more of a name than that and nobody had troubled him for it, checking the priming of the dozen better rifles one by one down the front rank with the same unhurried care Ruth had watched a smith give to a set of new-forged tools. He told her, as she passed, that the ground below the spoil-heaps was as good as it would ever be, the road narrowed there to less than a cart's width by the heaps on either hand, and that if Tom's charge went off true it would do the work of fifty men. Ruth said she hoped he was right, and went on.

She found Tom at the centre of the line, where he had gone to speak with Àth naomh's captain about the ground below the spoil-heaps, and she came to him not with any speech prepared, because she had tried, the night before, to write one in her head and found every version of it either too grand for what the morning was or too small for what the last three months had been, and had given it up.

"They'll be in sight within the hour," Tom said. He had a spy-glass, an old thing of his grandfather's that had done service, he'd told her once, watching for An Dealachadh's ships that never came a second time, and he had it trained now on the road below the spoil-heaps, where nothing yet moved but the light. "Dust first, if the road's dried enough. Then the column."

"And after that," Ruth said, "it's yours to give the word, not mine."

"It was always going to be," Tom said, not unkindly. "You kept the list. I keep the line. That's the shape it's taken, and I'll not pretend either of us chose it different from how it fell." He lowered the glass and looked at her a moment in the grey light, and whatever he had meant to say next, he did not say it, and instead put out his hand for the plain clasp two people give each other before a thing neither can promise the shape of, and Ruth took it.

"Tell them," she said, meaning the five towns' companies both, "that whatever comes of today, the list stands. Every name on it, town by town. Whoever comes looking after, for whatever reason they come looking, the list will say who stood at Àth leathan and who they stood beside."

1. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

"I'll tell them," Tom said. "Go back to your own company now. They'll want to see you standing with them when it starts, not off talking to me."

She went back down the line to Àth leathan's ninety, and took her place among them, not at their front, since she carried no weapon and had never claimed to be any kind of soldier, but near enough the front that any man there could see her if he turned his head, which several of them did, briefly, as the light came fully up and the grey overhead thinned toward a colour that might, on another morning, have been called a fair sky.

For a while, standing there, there was nothing to do but wait, and the waiting had a shape of its own that Ruth had not met in three months of waiting for other things: the burn loud below them, a lark going up somewhere over the higher ground as though the morning were an ordinary one, one of the Àth leathan hewers beside her murmuring the numbers of a psalm under his breath without seeming to know he did it, and, from along the Tobar dhearg line, the sound, thin on the wind, of the old captain's men singing something low in An Eaglais's own words, which she followed only in part and understood well enough for what it was. She found she was glad of it, the singing, in the same plain way she had been glad of Tom's repeating himself the night before: a thing said or sung that steadied more by its saying than by its sense.

The dust came first, as Tom had said it would, a pale smear along the road below the spoil-heaps where nothing else moved, and then, before the dust had well settled in her sight, the column itself came, dark and long and closer than Ruth had let herself think it would be so soon, moving at a steady pace that had nothing hurried and nothing hesitant in it, the pace of men who had been told exactly where they were going and saw no reason to arrive there other than on time.

Ruth Calder stood at the front rank of Àth leathan's company, in the raw cold of a spring morning with the burn loud behind her and the dust of the regiments' coming rising pale along the road ahead, and watched them come on, and this is where her own account of that day ends, because after this hour no page in her own hand, nor any word set down as hers by anyone who stood beside her, tells what she said or thought or did when the column reached the ground below the spoil-heaps and the first order, whoever gave it and on whichever side, was given.

III

Of What the North Tells

So the people of the five towns tell it, those who stood in one company or another that morning and lived to walk home from it, and those who had it from them at their own hearths.

They tell that the regiments came on past the dust and did not slow at the ford, because the ford was not their road, and that the fighting began at the spoil-heaps rather than the ford, where Muileann àrsaidh's company held the narrow ground and Tom Varley's charge, when at last he gave the word for it, brought down enough of the loose spoil to check the column's head for the better part of an hour, though it did not turn them back, because a column of fourteen hundred does not turn back for the loss of its head, only slows, and re-forms, and comes on again by a wider way round the fallen ground.

They tell that the fighting spread from there along the whole line through the morning, Cnoc thais holding longest on the left where the flooded gallery did a wall's work as Tom had judged it would, Àth naomh's two-abreast order breaking at last into no order at all when the regiments' own line reached and passed it, and that the fair field, the soft dark meadow beyond the ford that Ruth and Tom had looked at the evening before, was by noon a ground no one who stood on it that day has ever agreed to call by its old name again.

Cnoc thais tells its own part of that morning apart from the rest, as a town will keep the telling of its own dead closer than it keeps any other part of a shared grief, and its telling holds that Tom Varley was seen three times in the worst of the fighting by the flooded gallery, each time carrying a wounded man or boy back from the line with his own hands before going forward again, and that it was Tom who at last called the retreat toward Cnoc thais and Muileann àrsaidh when the gallery's ground could no longer be held. Muileann àrsaidh's own telling, kept separately again, holds to the charge below the spoil-heaps and to little else, as though the town had decided, without ever quite deciding it aloud, that the one thing it had done that day was worth the telling and the rest belonged to other towns to keep.

They tell of the pit-heads changing hands more than once before the day was out, of men fighting with picks and axes against rifles because that was what the five towns had brought to fight with, of the boy of fourteen from Tobar dhearg whose father would not let him past the pit-shed door and stood in the door him-

self the whole of the morning, and of the woman of Àth naomh with the fowling piece, whose name is remembered in that town still, though not written here, because the naming of her is the north's to keep and not this book's to spend.

Doire naomh, whose grove lies within sight of the field though its own people took no part in the fighting, tells only what could be seen from that distance: smoke over the pit-heads by mid-morning, though nothing there had been fired that either side has ever owned to setting; the sound of it carrying on a south wind as far as the grove, so that the grove's own people, going about their ordinary morning, heard the whole of it without seeing more than the smoke; and a silence, toward evening, that some of them said afterward was worse to hear than the noise had been.

They tell that by early afternoon the five towns' companies, what remained whole of them, gave up the ground below the pit-heads and the fair field both, and fell back in a scatter of smaller bodies rather than one, along the hill paths that had brought them down in am Faoilleach and up again now in the opposite direction, toward Muileann àrsaidh and Cnoc thais and the higher ground the regiments' lorries could not easily follow. Of the nine hundred who had stood at dawn, the towns' own reckoning, made afterward and never once written down together in a single tally, holds that something under two-thirds came home to one hill town or another by the second evening; what happened to the rest is the part of the telling that varies most from mouth to mouth, since a scattered retreat over broken ground in failing light leaves as many questions behind it as a battle does, and the north's telling does not pretend to answer them all.

They tell the dead in the hundreds, and they do not agree past that on any closer number, because no one town's count was ever set beside another's, and because more than one family of the five towns lost, that single day, every name it had sent to Àth leathan, so that there was no one left of that household to be asked how many, or which, or when.

Of Ruth Calder herself the north tells nothing certain. Some say she was seen at the pit-head door in the worst of the afternoon, calling names from memory to men who could no longer answer to them. Others say she went down with Àth leathan's company when it broke, and was carried off the field by two of her own hewers who did not themselves come home to say so. A few, the fewest, say she was seen on the Muileann àrsaidh path that evening, walking, her list gone from her coat, though every teller who says this admits in the same breath that they had it third-hand or fourth, from someone who was not there to see it either. No tell-

er in the north, asked plainly, will say for certain which of these is true, or whether none of them is, and the north has learned, in the years since, to let the question stand unanswered rather than choose among three stories none of which any single mouth can swear to.

IV

Of What the Open Record Gives

An Clàr Foscailte, kept that year by Sileas nic Rath at an Leabharlann¹ in Muileann chaol from the regiments' own returns, says a good deal less, and says it more plainly.

It gives the day, 11 an Giblean DE 21, and the place, the field below Àth leathan, and it gives the kingdom's dead by name and by company, thirty and eight in number, the returns of that day counted and signed by officers whose own names stand beside the count. Somhairle mac Lachlainn's own return, written from Seann Skell within the week, names the companies that had marched from Cathair dhearg the winter before and does no more than name them; it says which held the ground below the spoil-heaps and which came up after, and says nothing of how any man among the thirty and eight came to be counted, only that he was. The west-coast levies who had guarded the road behind the column are named among the dead too, a dozen of them, men the return does not yet call by any regiment's number, since none of the companies that fought at Àth leathan had, on that day, been given one. The rest of the thirty and eight are scattered among the capital's own companies, drawn from Cathair dhearg and Inis mhòr, ordinary men whose names, set down in a clerk's even hand on a return meant only to balance a muster roll, are the fullest account An Clàr Foscailte² gives of anyone who died at Àth leathan that day.

The return notes, in the same even hand, that the kingdom's host had been victualled through the campaign from Inis àrsaidh, the river town nearest the field by water, and that its stores had held good through the fighting and after; it is the only line in the whole return that speaks of anything going right for anyone, and it speaks of bread and salt fish rather than of men.

1. the Library at Muileann chaol

2. the open record of the war years

Of the holdouts' dead An Clàr Foscailte gives no number at all. It notes only that the field was held by evening, that the pit-heads of Àth leathan passed into Comhairle nam Mèinnean's³ keeping, and that the companies of the five towns, what remained of them, had withdrawn toward Muileann àrsaidh and Cnoc thais by nightfall. It does not say how many withdrew, nor how many did not.

Ruth Calder's name does not stand among the thirty and eight, which is no matter, since she was never of the kingdom's regiments for An Clàr Foscailte to count. It does not stand anywhere else in An Clàr Foscailte either, that day or after. Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own list, the one Tom Varley had word of on the drove path months before, does not appear in what an Leabharlann was given to keep; if it survives, it lies where the rest of the war's sealed record lies, and no one now living has read it. Every page an Leabharlann holds open of that spring, and every page after, is searched in vain for her name. Sileas nic Rath, taking down the regiments' returns that season in a hand still new to the office, wrote once, in a private note kept with her own papers and not with Eachdraidh na Rìoghachd⁴ proper, that she had looked for the name a second time and a third, thinking she had missed it among so many others, and had not found it any of the times she looked.

She wrote, in that same private note, that she had thought once of asking Somhairle mac Lachlainn directly whether his own return, or any paper that had passed under his hand, named a woman among the dead or the taken, and that she had not sent the question, because a chronicler new to the office learns early which questions the office will let her ask and which it will not, and this, she judged, was one of the second kind.

Near Àth leathan, in the grove the Dia-thìrich of Doire naomh keep closed to strangers, many of the field's unclaimed dead were laid that week and after, the grove's own people going out onto the ground once the regiments had passed on toward Muileann àrsaidh, and carrying what they found. The town of Àth chrom, a short way off at the bent ford, sent its own people to carry others, its own drovers going out along the road with carts they had until then used only for coal and salt. Neither town's record says whose dead they carried, of which side, or how many, only that they carried them, and that the grove has kept its graves since, closed to strangers, as it kept them before. Baile fhiadhaich, further off on the west-coast harbour road, sent no one to the field, lying further off than the

3. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

4. the royal chronicle of the restored kingdom

others, but its own people took in what wounded reached that far, and the town has kept the remembering of that day in its own way since, apart from any teller's account written down elsewhere.

The field, the fair field below the pit-heads where nine hundred souls of five towns had stood at dawn, lay empty by the time the last light went out of that day, the burn still running loud and brown below it, the spoil brought down by Tom Varley's charge still lying where it had fallen across the narrow road, and no plough has turned that ground since.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

Of the Field Left Unploughed

DE 21

I

Of the Carriers on the Ridge Path

Tom Varley did not see the battle end. He saw it break, which is a different thing, and he saw it from the wrong side of a drystone wall with a boy of Tobar dhearg bleeding through both hands pressed to his own thigh, and after that he saw very little that a man could afterward set down in an orderly way. The burn was in spate below the pit-heads, brown and quick with the last of the snow-melt, and it was the burn he remembered most clearly once the day was done: the sound of it under the other sounds, going on the same before, during and after, as if the water had somewhere better to be than any of them.

They had held the southern pits until the light began to go, longer than anyone at the pit-shed table had thought they would, and then word came down the line from company to company, not an order so much as a thing everyone understood at once the way a flock understands weather, that the southern ground was not to be held any further, and the hewers of five towns began to come back off it in the dusk in the way men come back from a thing that has gone against them, walking fast in twos and threes, turning now and again to look behind at nothing in particular.

Tom took the wounded. It was not a duty anyone gave him; he found himself doing it the way he found himself, most days of his life, at the head of whatever needed a head, and by full dark he had six men and the Tobar dhearg boy on

hurdles and handcarts and, in one case, on the back of a Cnoc thais man built broad enough to carry his own cousin the better part of two miles without setting him down. They went up by the drove path along the ridge, the same track Cnoc thais's forty had come down by in am Faoilleach with their lamps lit at noon, and this time no lamp was lit at all, because a lit lamp on that path that night would have told the whole of the low country exactly where to look.

The boy from Tobar dhearg was called Rab, though Tom did not learn that until they were an hour up the path and the boy, half out of his senses with the cold and the loss of blood, began saying it over to himself, quietly, as though it were the one word left to him that still meant anything sure. Tom knelt by the handcart twice in that hour to press the dressing tighter, cloth torn from his own shirt-tail since the proper dressings had gone with the men still fighting, and both times the boy looked at him without seeming quite to see him and said his own name again, Rab, Rab, and Tom said it back to him, which was the only medicine he had to give.

They did not stop at Àth leathan. That was the hardest thing Tom did that night, harder than the carrying: to come within sight of the pit-shed roofs where four hundred men had slept on straw two months before, and to keep walking past them into the hills, because word had already reached him, passed hand to hand up the column of carriers, that the southern approach was cut and the town would not hold a night's stand against what was coming up the road behind them. He looked once at the dark shape of the pit-shed roof against a sky just beginning to lighten in the east, and thought of Sarah Dunmore's oatmeal carts and the boy who had portioned it out one bowl to a name, and did not let himself think further, because there was a cart-wheel stuck in a rut just then and six other men waiting on him to set his shoulder to it.

By the grey hour before true dawn they had come up over the saddle between two hills and down the far side toward Muileann àrsaidh, where fires had been lit, small and shielded, in the lee of the walled pit-heads, and women came out along the last half-mile of the path to take the hurdles from the carriers' shoulders without being asked. Sarah Dunmore herself was among them, in a coat thrown on over a nightgown, and she took one look at the Tobar dhearg boy's leg by the light of a shaded lantern and sent a girl running for the woman who set bones and stitched wounds for half the western hills, and said nothing to Tom at all beyond a hand laid once, briefly, on his arm as he went by her with the next hurdle, which

was thanks and welcome and a question all in the one touch, and which Tom had no words to answer that night and did not try to find any.

He counted them in at the pit-head gate the way Ruth had counted them out at the trestle table two months before, though his list was shorter and kept in his head and not on paper, because there was no paper to hand and, he thought, setting the last hurdle down inside the wall as the sky went from grey to a thin cold white, perhaps no great wish in him to see the number written where anyone could count it against the number that had gone down to Àth leathan.

Six on hurdles, one on a cart, one carried the last mile on a cousin's back, and himself walking, which was nine souls got up off a field that had held nine hundred, and he knew, doing that sum in his head at the gate the way he had done Sarah's oatmeal sum two months before, that it told him nothing at all about the wider field, since a man who carries the wounded off a battle carries only those near enough his own place on it to be carried, and the rest of the field, wherever it lay and whatever it held, was no more open to him that night than the far side of the sea. He had heard, going up the path, two other parties of carriers ahead of him and behind, their voices carrying strangely in the wet air the way voices do on a hill at night, and did not know, and would not know for some days, how many souls those parties had brought off between them, or from how far along the line they had gathered them.

The woman who set bones came within the hour, an older woman named for nothing but her trade in every mouth on that hillside, Bonesetter, and worked on Rab's leg by lamplight at Sarah's own kitchen table while Sarah held the boy's shoulders and Tom, having no other use just then, held the lamp steady and watched a stranger's hands do to a stranger's boy the sort of careful violence that saves a leg or does not, and found himself, watching it, thinking less of the boy than of every other hand at that moment doing the same work on some other kitchen table in some other hill town, work he could not see and would only hear of, in pieces, over the days that followed.

Ruth's name was on neither list, in his head or on any paper. He had last seen her before first light the day before, at the pit-shed table with her own book open, telling off the companies by town as they formed on the road below the pit-heads, and had not seen her again once the light came up and the morning's work began in earnest. He told himself, standing inside the Muileann àrsaidh wall with the last of the wounded seen to and the dawn fully come, that she was one woman among nine hundred and the field was wide, and a man does not see everyone on

a field that wide in a single day's fighting, and this was true, and it did nothing at all to loosen the particular tightness that had settled behind his breastbone somewhere in the small hours and had not left him since.

II

Of the Pits Taken and the Water Let In

What happened at Àth leathan after the hewers went out of it, Tom Varley did not see, because by the time it happened he was two hills away with a wall between himself and the road, seeing to the last of the wounded and to Sarah Dunmore's fires. It came to him afterward the way most of that spring came to him, in pieces, carried up the hills by men who had themselves had it third-hand from a carter or a shepherd or, once, from a Dia-thìrich quartermaster's clerk who talked more than his orders allowed to a woman selling eggs at the western Seann Skell market and did not know or did not care that the woman's cousin kept sheep on the Àth leathan road.

The town was taken without a shot fired in it, or so every account that reached the hills agreed, a strange thing to Tom, turning it over afterward: that a town four hundred men had gathered to hold could pass from one hand to another in an empty street with nobody left inside it to say either yes or no to the taking. The regiments came up the road that same evening, the accounts said, and found the pit-shed doors standing open on their straw, the byres empty of the cattle that had been driven off into the hills days before by anyone who thought to do it, and the chapel bell still hanging in its little tower, untouched, because nobody on either side that week had found it in himself to ring a bell for any reason at all.

The order to flood the pits came from Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹ at Cathair mhòr, and it came, by every account Tom heard, within days of the town's falling, as though the order had been drawn up and left ready in a drawer against exactly this day and wanted only the day's arriving to be sent. The shafts at Àth leathan were old, older than Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own charter, cut into a seam that had fed three generations of the town's hewers before it fed the war that ended their holding it, and the engineers who came up with the order did their work in an afternoon: the pumps that had kept the lower galleries dry for sixty

1. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

years were stopped, and the water that the hills had been shedding all that wet spring, the same brown quick water that ran in the burn below the pit-heads, was let down into the workings by a sluice cut for the purpose, and Comhairle nam Mèinnean's report, which Tom heard of long before he ever saw a word of it, gave the flooding as complete within the week.

Tom had gone down those shafts himself as a boy, visiting a cousin's family at Àth leathan the summer he turned eleven, and he remembered them chiefly for the cold and the smell of wet stone and a hewer, his cousin's father, showing him a seam of coal by candlelight with the particular pride of a man showing off a thing he has spent his whole life inside of. He thought of that seam now, drowned, dark water standing where the candlelight had been, and found that the thought did not move him the way he might have expected it to a year before. He had reopened his own two shafts at Cnoc thais five winters before with exactly this in his mind, that the coal under the western hills was the hills' own and answered to nobody's charter but the hewers who cut it, and he had known, taking that first cartload up out of the ground, that a day might come when somebody with more men than argument decided otherwise. It had come. He found he was less surprised by the water in the Àth leathan shafts than by how little, in the end, the surprise of it cost him, set against everything else that week had already cost.

What he could not get past, turning the reports over at Sarah Dunmore's kitchen table in the evenings that followed, was the emptiness of it: a town taken by nobody, from nobody, its pits drowned by an order signed in an office two days' ride away by a man who had never, so far as anyone in the western hills could learn, set foot within a mile of the place. Sarah said, the third evening, stirring a pot that had less in it than either of them would have wished, that it was the emptiest thing she had heard of in a long war already thick with empty things, and Tom, who had by then heard the word field left unploughed passed from mouth to mouth among the men who had come up from the south with him, though nobody yet knew quite what lay under the phrase, said only that an empty town was easier held than a full one, which was true, and was also, he knew even as he said it, no kind of answer to what Sarah had actually asked.

She pressed him on it a second time, the fifth evening, with the kitchen quieter than it had been all week and the last of the wounded moved to beds found for them among the town's own houses. What she wanted to know, she said, setting two bowls down and sitting rather than standing over the pot as she had every

night before, was not whether the pits were flooded, which every carter on the road had told her twice over by then, but whether flooding them served any purpose beyond the purpose of telling the hills plainly that the seams were done for good and no agreement, however generous, would ever open them again. Tom turned that over a while before he answered her, because it was, he saw, the better question of the two he had been asked that week, sharper than his own about the field, and he said at last that he thought it served exactly that purpose and no other, since a flooded shaft cost Comhairle nam Mèinnean more to pump dry again than the coal in it would ever be worth to a kingdom that no longer burned coal for anything but its altars, and that a Board which meant only to hold the seams against some future need would have sealed the entrances and left the water out, not let it in. Sarah nodded at that, slowly, and said that she had thought as much herself and had wanted to hear it said by somebody who had gone down those shafts as a boy, so as to know the saying of it cost him something and was not merely a guess offered cheap.

III

Of the Returns at the Western Seann Skell

Somhairle mac Lachlainn had been two years and more learning to write a report that said less than he had seen, and by the second week after Àth leathan he had learned it well enough that the returns crossing his desk at the western Seann Skell read, to a man who did not know how to read them, like the dullest paperwork any army had ever generated: musters, rations issued, a bridge repaired, a company's boots replaced. He knew how to read them, and what he read in the returns that fortnight was a victory that had cost more than the figure at the bottom of any single sheet would say, and a countryside behind his own lines that had gone, in the space of a battle, from watchful to silent in a way he did not entirely trust.

The order for An seachdamh rèisimeid¹ was dated the day of the battle itself, drawn up, like the order to flood the pits, before the day it answered; it reached him on the fourth day, carried down from Cathair dhearg by a rider who had changed horses twice and looked it. It was raised, the order said, from the levies of

1. the seventh regiment

the west coast, fishermen and small tenants and the sons of the river-port families who had never before been asked to stand a muster, and it was to be quartered at Seann Skell, the port nearest the western hills, with instructions Somhairle himself had a hand in drafting once the order's bare bones reached him: to hold the road behind the army and to hold, in particular, the field below Àth leathan, until such time as the council's further pleasure was known.

He had its rolls filled in a week, which was faster than any regiment before it had been raised in the whole course of the war, and he raised it, he told the returns and told nobody else, because the west coast had men enough idle at that season, between one fishing and the next, to fill the rolls without stripping a single farm of its labour, and because a regiment recruited on the coast and not from the capital's own companies was a regiment whose loyalty, in a countryside as unsettled as this one had lately become, he judged less likely to be tested by a cousin or a brother found on the other side of a wall. He kept this second reason out of any return, the kind of thing a commander thought and did not set down, the same discipline, though he would not have put it to himself in these words, that had a driver on Slighe a' Ghuail² signing for weight and not for goods.

The regiment's first task, once mustered, was simple enough to state and dull enough in the stating that the return recording it ran to four lines: patrols on the Àth leathan road, morning and evening, to keep it open for the army's supply and to report anything found upon it. Somhairle read the first week's patrol reports at his own table in the requisitioned merchant's house at Seann Skell, by a dubhan lamp that burned steadier than any coal flame he had known as a young man, and found in them exactly what the order had asked for and nothing more: the road clear, the weather wet, a cart met and let pass, a farm gate found open and shut again.

It was the second week's reports that gave him the phrase that stayed with him longer than any other that spring. A patrol sent out on the fifth day past the town, along the road that ran below the old pit-heads and on toward the hills proper, returned with nothing to report but the field, and the officer writing it up, a young man new to his rank and not yet schooled in the discipline of saying less than he had seen, wrote more than the form strictly required: that the field where the battle had been fought lay as it had been left, that no one had come to

2. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

it since, and that it had not been ploughed, though the season for the first ploughing was well begun on every other field the patrol had passed that morning.

Somhairle read that line twice. He had seen, in the years since he had first marched a company toward the west, a great many things he had chosen not to set down, and he had grown, without quite meaning to, careful of the things other men chose to set down when he was not looking over their shoulder to stop them. The field left unploughed was, on its face, no more than an agricultural fact, the kind of detail a farmer's son turned soldier notices because farming is the trade he was bred to before soldiering was. It sat with Somhairle longer than that, through the evening and into the night, because he understood, better perhaps than the young officer who had written it, exactly why no farmer within five miles of that field had put a plough to it, and he found himself unwilling, turning the return over by lamplight, to write the reason into any report of his own, and equally unwilling to let it pass from his mind as easily as the form he was filing it under seemed to want him to.

He sent the same officer out again three days later with instructions, given verbally and not in writing, to walk the field ground rather than the road beside it, and to bring back word of what, if anything, the ground still held. The officer went, and came back within the day, and what he brought back Somhairle wrote into the return in the fewest words the form would bear, and no fewer, because there are things a report can carry and things it cannot, and he had by then two years' practice in telling one from the other.

The musters that same fortnight gave him a second figure he found himself turning over as often as the first. The seventh's rolls, drawn from the coast towns and the river-port families, ran to some four hundred and twenty men by the second week, short of the full regiment the order had called for, and the shortfall, when he asked after it through the maor of Seann Skell rather than through any officer of his own, came back to him as no more than the ordinary business of a fishing season not yet done and boats still out that a levy could not properly reach until they came home to harbour. He accepted this answer because there was no other readily to hand and because pressing harder on a levy already raised faster than any before it seemed to him, weighing the whole of that fortnight's business, more likely to cost him goodwill on the coast than it would buy him bodies for the muster roll. He wrote the shortfall into his own return to Cathair dhearg as a seasonal matter, to be made good by midsummer, which was true as far as it went, and left out of it the maor's further remark, offered over a glass of something the

maor's own cellar had not paid Deachamh a' Chogaidh³ on, that a coast town asked to fill a regiment's ranks against its own hill neighbours might be forgiven for finding its boats a week longer at sea than the weather strictly required.

IV

Of the Answer Nobody Could Give

Tom Varley began asking after Ruth Calder on the third day at Muileann àrsaidh, once the last of the wounded were settled and Sarah Dunmore's kitchen had stopped needing every pair of hands in the town at once. He asked first the men who had come up the ridge path with him, one by one, in the flat unhurried way a man asks a question he has already asked several times and expects, each time, the same answer he has had before. None of them had seen her past the grey hour of the morning, when the companies were still forming on the road below the pit-heads and her own book was still open on the trestle table, her thickened pen going down the last names before the light was properly up.

He sent word out from Muileann àrsaidh to every hill farm within a day's walk, not by any formal order, since he held no rank that could give one, but in the way word travels among people who have known each other's families three generations back: a boy sent here, a cousin asked there, a message left with a shepherd whose flock ranged close enough to the old battle-ground that he might, in the course of an ordinary week's work, see something worth the telling. Has anyone seen Ruth Calder, the message ran, in one form or another, carried by a dozen different mouths into a dozen different farmhouses over the course of that week, and the answer, when an answer came at all, was always some version of the same thing: that nobody now working that ground since the battle had seen a woman of her description, alive or otherwise, and that the battle-ground, by the regiments' own patrols and by the few shepherds bold enough to walk near its edge, appeared to hold nothing that anyone had found worth reporting.

A woman from a farm below the ridge, whose husband had gone down with the Cnoc thais men and come back with a wound in his shoulder that Tom himself had dressed on the path, sent word that she had heard, from a niece married into a family nearer the town, that some of the field's own dead had been carried

3. the wartime tithe

off in the days just after the battle by people from the hills who came down at night and went again before light, and that if Ruth Calder had fallen there, she might have been carried with the rest and be lying now in ground no list on either side would ever hold a name for. This was not an answer either, though it was closer to one than anything else Tom heard that week, and he found himself, hearing it, unable to decide whether it eased the tightness behind his breastbone or drew it tighter, and settled, after turning it over two full days, on the second.

He asked, too, at the pit-shed table, once word came that a handful of Àth leathan's own people, those who had not come north with the hewers, had begun slipping back down under cover of dark to see what remained of their own doors and byres, and had themselves been asking after faces they knew and not finding them. One such, an old woman who had kept hens at the edge of the town and gone up into the hills with a cousin's family rather than stay to see what the regiments made of her yard, sent word by the same chain of boys and shepherds that she had seen, the morning after the battle, before the regiments' patrols came out onto it, a party of women from the hill farms out on the field with handcars of their own, moving among the fallen in the grey light, and that she had not looked long enough, or near enough, to say whose faces she had seen among either the carriers or the carried, because a woman alone at the edge of a battlefield the morning after learns quickly not to look too long at anything. Tom heard this and thanked the boy who brought it and gave him nothing further to carry back, because there was nothing further to ask that the old woman's account had not already, in its own way, answered as fully as it meant to.

He walked out himself on the eighth day, alone, along the ridge path he had carried the wounded up, and down the far side toward the field, going as near it as An seachdamh rèisimeid's patrols allowed, which was not very near, a sentry turning him back at a stone dyke a quarter-mile short of the ground with a civility that Tom, for all his anger at the turning back, could find no fault with; the man was young, and cold, and doing exactly what his own officer had told him to do, no more and no less. From the dyke Tom could see the shape of the field, a long slope running down from the pit-heads to the road, empty under a grey sky, no plough mark on it anywhere that he could make out at that distance, the grass beginning already, in the way grass will, to come up green over ground that had held, eight days before, nine hundred men and more with their carriers.

1. the seventh regiment

He looked at it a long while, until the sentry, not unkindly, told him the light was going and the patrols came round again at dusk and would not be so civil to a man found standing at the dyke after dark. Tom thanked him, which cost him something to do and he did it anyway, and walked back up the ridge path in the failing light with no more of an answer than he had carried down it, and no less, and told himself, coming over the saddle with Muileann àrsaidh's few fires showing small below him, that a field left unploughed keeps whatever it keeps whether or not a man stands at its edge asking it to give an account of itself, and that he would go on asking all the same, because asking was the one thing left to him that Ruth Calder's own book, four hundred names taken down in a clean careful hand, would have understood as work worth doing, and he was not yet ready to set it down.

Of the Tiche and the Fleets

DE 21

I

Of the Clerk beside the Pump

Ùna nic Ailein had kept Cùirt na Fèille¹ at Muileann òg for four-and-twenty years, and in that time she had written into its books every kind of sale a market town on Rathad na Fèille² might see: cattle, cloth, coal by the cartload and then by the sack, dubhan by the barrel and then by the tank, a woman's dower, a dead man's debts. She had not, until the second week after Àth leathan, written a tax.

The order came down from the capital with the same rider who brought word of the battle, so that the town had the two together before it had properly finished with either: the field lost and won in the same breath as the clause that would pay for the losing and the winning both. It was short, as such orders went, and plain in the way orders are plain when the thing behind them is not: for the war's sake, and for so long only as the war should last, every sale of dubhan within the kingdom was to bear a tithe of one part in twelve, taken at the point of sale and not after, and a clerk of An t-Ionmhas³ was to sit at every depot and every fair-court pump where dubhan changed hands, to see it taken. The word the order used, twice, was *for a time*.

Muileann òg's own pump stood in the yard behind the toll-house, where the fair's dubhan tank had been sunk the year the town gave up its last coal cart, and it

1. the court of the fair at Muileann òg

was there, on a wet morning three days after the order reached her, that Ùna met the clerk An t-Ionmhas had sent to sit beside it.

He was a young man named Cailean Ros, thin in the wrists, with a ledger of his own bound in An t-Ionmhas's grey boards and a stool he had brought with him because nobody had thought to leave one for him. He set the stool down in the lee of the tank, where the drip from the eaves did not quite reach, and opened his ledger on his knee, and looked up at Ùna with the particular unhappiness of a man sent a long way from home to do a thing he had not chosen and could not undo.

"I'm told to sit here," he said, "and mark what's drawn."

"You'll want the tank's own book as well as your own, then," Ùna said, "or your figures and mine will never agree, and one of us will be made to answer for it before the year's out."

He had not thought of that. She saw him not think of it, in the way his face did nothing at all for a moment before it did something. He wrote her name down, and the tank's, and Cùirt na Fèille's, in his grey book, under a heading that said only *Muileann òg*, and asked her, civilly enough, whether she would show him how the tank's own draw was measured, since nobody in the capital had thought to tell him that either.

She showed him. It took the better part of the morning, in the rain, the two of them bent over the tank's brass cock and the marked rod that measured what came out of it, and by the end of it Cailean Ros had learned to read the rod as well as she could, and had written, in a hand still stiff with being taught something new, the first entry of the tithe ever taken at *Muileann òg*: eleven gallons drawn to Seumas Buidhe the smith, at the market price, and one part in twelve of the price set aside before the coin changed hands, and Seumas Buidhe standing by with his hands in his apron looking at the young clerk as though a second smith had set up shop in the yard without asking anyone's leave.

"Where does it go," Seumas asked, when the counting was done, "the twelfth part?"

"To An t-Ionmhas," said Cailean Ros, "for the war."

"And when the war's done?"

The clerk looked at his own ledger as if the answer might be written in it, and it was not. "I couldn't say," he said, which Ùna judged, watching him, to be the

2. the fair road from the capital to *Muileann òg*

3. the Treasury

truest thing he had said all morning, and also the thing that would serve him worst in the weeks to come, because a smith who has just paid a twelfth of his coin to a stranger from the capital wants an answer, even a false one, more than he wants an honest silence.

Seumas Buidhe took his eleven gallons and went home without another word, and Ùna wrote the sale into Cùirt na Fèille's own book below the line where the tithe was noted, in the plain hand she used for every sale, because a smith's dubhan was a smith's dubhan whatever An t-Ionmhas took off the top of it, and the court's book did not change its manners for a war.

She wrote, too, in the margin, the thing she had not been asked to write and wrote anyway, as she had once written that a coal cart was the last of its kind: *Cailean Ros of An t-Ionmhas sat first at this pump on the thirtieth of an Giblean, and the first tithe taken here was one gallon in twelve of Seumas Buidhe's eleven.* It was no more than Cùirt na Fèille's habit of a hundred years, to set down what was new the day it was new, before the newness of it wore smooth into simply the way of things. She did not think, writing it, that anyone but the court's own clerks would ever read it. Eighteen years before she had thought the same of a margin note about a coal cart, and had been wrong about that too.

Cailean Ros came back the next market day, and the one after, with his stool and his grey ledger, and by the third week he had stopped setting the stool in the lee of the eaves and had asked the toll-house keeper, through Ùna, whether a corner of the upper room might be spared him against the worst of the weather, since a wet ledger served An t-Ionmhas no better than a dry one served the king's enemies. The toll-house keeper, who was Ùna's own second cousin and disliked strangers on principle, gave him the corner nearest the door, which was the coldest in the room, and Cailean Ros took it without complaint, and Ùna, watching him take it, thought that a man who does not complain of the corner he is given generally means to stay in it a good while.

II

Of the First Complaint

The complaint came in the fourth week, on a market day with the first real heat of the year in it, and it came, as most complaints at Muileann òg

came, from a woman who had waited a fortnight to be sure she was not merely in a temper before she brought it to the court.

Her name was Barabal nic Rath, and she kept three looms in a shed behind her house and sold cloth at the fair every second week, and she had bought dubhan for her looms' small engine from the fair pump since the engine was fitted, four years before, because a loom that ran on dubhan wove faster than a loom worked by foot and hand, and a woman with three looms and no sons old enough to work them had needed the faster weaving or given up two of the three. She came up the toll-house stair with her ledger under her arm, a thin cloth-bound book she kept herself in a hand less fair than Ùna's own but every bit as careful, and she set it down on the court's table and opened it to a page marked with a scrap of blue thread.

"I've kept my own count," she said, "these four weeks, against the pump's, because I didn't trust my own arithmetic to hold a grudge fair, and now I've kept it long enough to be sure the grudge is honest."

Ùna looked at the page. Barabal nic Rath's count agreed with the tank's own book, gallon for gallon and tithe for tithe, to the last measure; there was no cheating in it, no clerk's thumb on the scale. What the page showed, set down in the woman's careful hand week by week, was the twelfth part alone, added up: what her looms had paid An t-Ionmhas¹ since an Giblean, against what she had earned by them in the same four weeks, and the second figure was not large enough, set beside the first, to leave her easy about the six weeks still to come, or the six after that, if the order's *for a time* meant what she was beginning to suspect it meant.

"I'm not asking the court to strike the tithe," she said. "I know the court's no more power over a Treasury order than I have myself. I'm asking that it be written down, here, in this book, that a woman of Muileann òg brought a complaint against it in the fourth week of its taking, and what the complaint was, so that when the *time* it was laid for is over, and somebody asks whether the time was long or short, there'll be a paper that says when the asking began."

Ùna took up her pen. Cailean Ros, in his corner, had stopped writing in his own ledger and was watching the table with the stillness of a man who knows a thing is being made that will outlast him in that room whichever way the war goes.

1. the Treasury

"I'll write it," Ùna said, "as you've said it, no more and no less, unless you'd have me soften it."

"I'd have you write it as I said it."

She wrote it as Barabal nic Rath had said it, in Cùirt na Fèille²'s book, under the day's date, the first complaint the court had recorded against Deachamh a' Chogaidh³: the weaver's name, the looms, the four weeks' figures set down from the woman's own ledger and checked against the tank's, and the plain sentence the woman had asked for, that the complaint stood against the tithe's silence on its own ending, and left its justice, which she did not judge, alone. Ùna turned the book round, as she had once turned it for a carter who could not read, and Barabal nic Rath read her own words back in the court's fairer hand and nodded once and went down the stair to her cloth.

Cailean Ros came over from his corner once the woman was gone and looked at the entry a long while without asking to.

"Will you send a copy to An t-Ionmhas?" he said at last.

"I'll send a copy where the court's book always sends copies, which is nowhere, unless it's asked for. It's the court's book. It answers to the fair, not to the capital." She closed it and set it on its shelf. "If your masters want to know whether the tithe is loved, they can ride down and read it for themselves, or they can ask you, since you sit beside the pump five days in the six and would know better than any letter could tell them."

"They haven't asked me," Cailean Ros said, "what I think of it."

"No," Ùna said. "They wouldn't."

He went back to his corner, and Ùna, setting the day's other business in order, thought that a young man sent a long way from home to sit beside a pump and mark what was drawn from it was learning, faster than she had expected, the one lesson Cùirt na Fèille's own books had taught every clerk who ever kept them: that a thing written down plainly outlives the mood that made someone want it written, and outlives, sometimes, the very order that called the writer into being. She did not know, setting the ink-horn back under its cloth against the evening damp, how many other pumps in the kingdom that week had a Cailean Ros beside them, or how many other women had kept a ledger of their own four weeks running against a grudge they meant to be sure of before they brought it up any stair. There were a good many, she supposed. What was before her she wrote, as

2. the court of the fair at Muileann òg

3. the wartime tithe

the court had always done, and the rest she left to whoever, someday, might read every such book at once.

III

Of the Boats Come Home Late

Joe Ashby heard of the tithe before he felt it, because a fitter who buys no dubhan to sell, only to burn in his own forge and pour into other men's tanks at a price he set himself, was a step removed from any pump. What struck Caol mhòr's harbour first that spring, and struck it hard, were the ships.

A' chiad rèisimeid¹, raised at Inis mhòr from the capital's own companies to stand about the council and the mint and the bridge over the Abhainn dhomhain, meant nothing to a harbour four days' sail to the north and was three weeks old before word of it reached Will Tanner's shed at all, brought by a carter who had it third-hand from a corn-factor at Cathair mhòr. The fleets meant a great deal more, and meant it sooner. Within the month a fleet was raised from the south-west harbours and stationed at Àth gharbh, its hulls lying at Doire shean a short walk along the shore, and sent round the western cape; and hard on it a fourth fleet out of Cuan shean joined the first off the Tuathaich coast, and between the two of them the sea-reach of the western Seann Skell and the waters off Cnoc bhàn in the north-west were closed to every hull that was not a fishing boat, and the fishing boats themselves were searched.

Caol mhòr's own boats were fishing boats, in the main, whatever engine Joe had fitted under their thwarts, and it was the searching, not the closing, that came first to the harbour wall.

The first of the king's boats to put in was a low grey hull out of An ceathramh cabhlach², with a lieutenant aboard her young enough that his coat still looked new on him, and she came alongside the wall on a morning with the herring boats half unloaded and their crews still at the baskets. The lieutenant came ashore with two men behind him and a paper in his hand, and read from it, in Dia-thiris, that every hull of the harbour was to be boarded and its hold and its bilges searched, by the order of the fleet, for coal or dubhan carried contrary to the closing of the

1. the first regiment

2. the fourth fleet

western waters, and that any master who refused the search would have his boat's papers taken and his name sent to the maor.

Nobody refused. It was not, Joe thought, watching from the shed door with a wrench still in his hand, that anyone at the wall had anything to hide; it was that a harbour which had spent seven years learning to answer a fleet clerk's letters with silence had not yet learned how a young lieutenant with two men and a paper was to be answered at all, and silence, this time, would not do, since the man was standing on the wall asking, plainly, to be let aboard.

They boarded Jean Fisher's boat first, because it lay nearest the steps, and the two men went down into her bilges with a lantern and came up black to the elbow and found nothing but bilge-water and a winter's rust, and the lieutenant wrote something in his own book and moved on to the next. It went that way down the whole of the wall through the morning: down into the bilges, up black to the elbow, a line in the book, the next boat. Will Tanner's own boat took the longest, because Will had, in an idle winter three years before, built a false locker under the stern thwart to keep a jar of the smith's own spirit out of his wife's reach, and the men found the locker and opened it and found the jar and nothing else, and the lieutenant, to his credit, laughed once, briefly, and wrote nothing about it at all.

They came to the engine-boats last, the half-dozen hulls in the harbour that Joe himself had fitted with a dubhan engine under the stern rather than oars alone, and here the lieutenant's manner grew careful, gentle still but slower, the way a man's manner slows when he has been told, before he ever left the fleet's own harbour, that this was the true business of the day and the bilges only the excuse for it. He asked, of each engine-boat's master in turn, who had fitted the engine, and when, and whether the fitter held any guild's leave to do it, and each master gave him the same answer in the same flat voice, that the engine was fitted by Joe Ashby of this town, guild or no guild, and the engine ran true, which was more than any Seann Skell guild's own work could always promise, and the lieutenant wrote that down too, without comment, in the same book as the bilges.

He came to Joe himself at the shed door before he left the wall.

"You're the fitter," he said. It was not quite a question.

"I am."

"You hold no guild's paper."

"There's none in this harbour would give me one."

The lieutenant looked at him a moment, and at the shed behind him, the bench with its rows of tools and the half-stripped engine laid out on sacking that Joe had been working over when the boat came alongside. "The fleet's own hulls run on engines fitted by men who do hold the guild's paper," he said, "and half of them, by what I've seen this year, run worse than the ones I've just come off. I'll write what I've seen, and no more, and what's done with it after that is the fleet's business and not mine." He touched his cap, in a way that was neither quite courtesy nor quite its opposite, and went back down the steps to his boat, and by noon the grey hull was gone round the point, north, toward whatever other harbour's wall was next on his own book's list.

IV

Of the Hull Nobody Would Name

The letter came to Will Tanner's shed a fortnight after, carried up from Caol mhòr's own harbour depot by a boy who would not say who had sent him, only that he was to wait for an answer and bring it back the same day.

It was short, and it named no fleet and no rank, only that a hull now lying at the depot's own jetty had an engine that would not answer past half its speed, that the depot's own men had looked at it twice and could not say why, and that whoever could put it right, guild or no guild, would be paid in coin at the harbour's own rate and asked no question the work did not answer of its own accord. A mark stood where the signature should have been, no name under it anywhere.

Joe read it twice, standing in the shed door with the boy waiting on one foot and then the other, and then he asked the boy plainly whose hull it was, since a letter that would not say so plainly meant to be read carefully by whoever it was sent to.

"The depot's," the boy said. "One of the fleet's."

Joe folded the letter and put it in his apron pocket and stood a while without answering, and the boy, who had been told only to wait, waited. It took him no time at all to know his own mind; he knew it inside the first reading, the way a man knows before he has finished a sentence whether he means to say yes or no to the end of it. The while he stood there went instead into weighing what the deciding would cost against what the refusing would cost, setting the one sum beside the other until he was satisfied neither would grow smaller for further looking.

A fleet hull was a fleet hull, whatever coin it paid in, and the fleet that hull served was the same fleet that had closed the western Seann Skell's waters to keep dubhan from going where the western hills wanted it, and had raised a tithe on every gallon a Muileann òg weaver drew for her looms, and would, before the year was out, though Joe did not yet know the shape of what was coming, carry arms and men to towns whose names he had heard all his life without ever once thinking of them as places a Caol mhòr man's own hands might help to reach. He thought of Baile chrom's report, pinned outside the custom-house fourteen years before, that had named a town and not a man; he thought that a fleet which could not be bothered to name the fitters of a lighthouse was not likely to trouble over-much with the conscience of the fitter it now wanted for an engine none of its own men could mend.

He thought, too, and did not let himself think it away, that Ned Fowler's boy was down with a chest complaint that winter's damp had settled into him and had not yet loosed, and that the harbour's own rate for an engine's mending, paid straight and without argument, was the kind of coin a man in Joe's own trade did not often see offered without three months' haggling first; and that a boat's engine, once he had it in pieces on his own bench, would tell him nothing at all about where that boat had been or where it was bound next, being made, as every engine he had ever fitted was made, of iron and copper and a burner's throat, and answering to nobody's flag once it was stripped down to its own parts on a sheet of sacking.

"Tell them," he said at last, "that I'll come and look at her. I'll say what I can do once I've seen her, and not before."

The boy went, and came back within the hour with word that Joe was to come to the depot's jetty in the morning, and that the depot's own men would clear the shed for him and ask no questions of anyone he brought with him, if he wanted a second pair of hands.

He took Ned Fowler, whose own hands were as good as any at the pumps and better than most at a stripped engine, and the two of them walked down to the depot in the grey of a morning with the tide half out and the gulls loud over the mud. The hull lay at the jetty's outer end, low and grey like the lieutenant's own boat had been, with the fleet's mark painted small on her bow where a merchant hull would have carried her name, and no name of her own anywhere on her that either man could find, fore or aft, though every fishing boat in the harbour behind them wore its own painted plain for any child to read.

"No name," Ned said, looking her over from the jetty.

"No," said Joe. "Nor any it'll answer to, once she's running again, that either of us will ever hear."

They went aboard, and down into the engine well, and by noon Joe had the fault in his hand, a valve seated wrong from the yard that built her, the kind of small blind error that a rushed builder leaves behind in a hundred engines and a careful fitter finds in one, and he sat over it the rest of the short afternoon with Ned beside him passing tools, the two of them saying little, because there was little that wanted saying about a valve's seat that the valve itself did not say plain-er, and because both men knew, without either putting it into words on the jetty that day, exactly whose engine they were mending and to what further use, unnamed and unasked-after, the mending would be put.

By evening the valve was seated true and the engine answered past half speed and on to its full, and the depot's own men, who had stood back the whole day watching two Tuathaich fitters do in an afternoon what their own hands had failed twice to do in a week, paid Joe at the harbour's own rate, in coin, and asked him nothing at all, as the letter had promised, and Joe took the coin and put half of it, that same evening, into Ned Fowler's own hand for the boy's chest, and said nothing about where it had come from beyond that it had been fairly earned, which was true, and which he told himself, walking home along the harbour wall in the last of the light with the grey hull already standing out past the point on the evening tide, was the whole of the answer he owed anyone.

V

Of Two Books That Would Not Meet

Will Tanner asked him, over the bench a few evenings after, whether he meant to do it again, if the depot's boy came back with another letter and another mark instead of a name, and Joe said he supposed he would, if a chest wanted clearing or a boy wanted mending or the coin was fair, and that he did not see how a man in his trade was to run a harbour's worth of accounts on a war he had had no hand in starting and no vote in ending. Will said nothing to that, because there was nothing in it he could rightly argue with, and the two of them went on stripping a winch that had nothing to do with any fleet at all.

No paper anywhere on the island set the two of that spring's small transactions side by side: Cùirt na Fèille's book at Muileann òg, where a weaver's complaint against a twelfth part in twelve stood written under the day's date for anyone who cared to climb the stair and ask for it, and the depot's own tally at Caol mhòr, unsigned, which recorded only that an engine had been mended and a sum paid out, and named, in its own hand, no fitter at all. Ùna's book meant to be read; that was the whole of Cùirt na Fèille's hundred-year habit, to set a thing down so that someone, someday, asking after it, would find an answer waiting rather than a silence. The depot's tally meant the opposite, and meant it just as carefully, a mark standing in for a name the way the sea-reach off the western Seann Skell now stood closed to every hull that could not prove itself a fishing boat, which was its own kind of writing, done in absences instead of ink.

Between the two books, that spring, ran the whole distance of the tithe and the fleets both: an order that named itself only for a time, taken at every pump the kingdom had thought to guard, and answered, in the fourth week, by a woman with a ledger of her own; and a fleet that closed a coast to keep dubhan from the hills that had first made it, and came, before the season was out, to need the very hands it would not put a name to. Neither book troubled over the other, and no one that spring stood in any office of the kingdom with both open on the same table, to ask what the war had cost, taken all together, in coin drawn at one end of the island and coin paid out, unnamed, at the other.

1. the court of the fair at Muileann òg

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

Of the Siege of Muileann àrsaidh

DE 21

I

Of the Wall Fraser Did Not Finish

They tell it in the western hills, those few of that town's own people left to tell anything at all, that the regiments came up the southern road on the twenty-first day of an Cèitean in the grey hour before a full morning, and that the first anyone in Muileann àrsaidh knew of it was the sound of the ditch-bridge going down under wheels that were not a carrier's cart. Old Fraser had dug that ditch himself the autumn before, on his knees in the cold with his own breath smoking, and had said to Ruth Calder at the time that a road dug across at the right place could be made near as good as a wall for a fraction of the labour; and it had held a season and more against nothing heavier than a lorry turned back with stones. It did not hold against men with timber and their own backs to lay it. By the time the sun was properly up, the bridge was down and a company of the regiments' advance stood on the wrong side of Fraser's ditch looking in.

Sarah Dunmore heard it from her own kitchen, where she had been feeding porridge into a boy of nine who did not want it, and knew before she reached her own door what the sound under the other sounds was, because she had spent the better part of two years by then learning the particular weight of a great many boots moving together, a sound no cart or drove of cattle ever quite made, however you tried to tell yourself otherwise in the first half-minute of hearing it. She set the boy's bowl down, told him to stay where he was in a voice that made him

mind her for once without an argument, and went out into the street in her apron with her hair still not properly pinned, because there was no time left that morning to be a woman who minded such things.

The town had known the regiments were coming for the better part of a fortnight, in the way a town in the western hills always knew such things before anyone official troubled to tell it: a carter's report, a shepherd who had seen dust on the southern road that no drove of sheep raised, a cousin's letter from the western Seann Skell saying that men and wagons had been moving north out of the port in numbers nobody there had counted before. What the town had not known, and could not have known short of standing on the road to see it, was which of the wall's several weak places the regiments' engineers had marked for their own use, and it was, as it happened, the same stretch at the northern end that old Fraser had left unfinished the autumn before, out of what he had called simple exhaustion at the time and what the whole town understood privately to be his own unwillingness to finish a wall built clean round a town, that being, in his judgement, too near a boast for any hill town to make. He was an old man now, older than he had been that autumn by a year of siege already half begun in everyone's mind if not yet in fact, and he stood that first morning at the gap in his own unfinished work with a mattock in his two hands and eleven other men and women about him, none of whom had slept, and none of whom had any clear notion of what a mattock would do against a company of riflemen beyond the small comfort of having something in the hands.

It did nothing, in the end, because the regiments' officers, whoever they were and whatever their orders said, chose that first morning to do no more than close the gap from the outside and set a picket on it, rather than force it with men still forming up from a night's march; and Sarah, coming up the street in time to see the last of that decision made, understood, watching soldiers she had never before seen stand still and businesslike on ground that had been Muileann àrsaidh's own pit-yard the evening before, that the town was not being taken that morning so much as it was being shut, the way a hand closes slowly round a thing it means to keep rather than crush.

By noon the southern road was cut as well, a second company come up behind the first and dug in across it a half-mile below the town where the ground rose enough to give a clear sight of anyone coming or going, and by the end of that first day Muileann àrsaidh, which had built its wall against a lorry and never seriously against an army, found the wall mattered little either way, because the roads

it stood beside were closed at both ends and the hills behind it, steep and trackless enough that no regiment had thought them worth a picket, offered no way out that a cart or a wagon of stores could use, only paths a person on foot might take by night and at some risk. Tom Varley came to Sarah's kitchen that evening, his knee long since mended and his face the grey of a man doing sums he did not like the answer to, and said, standing in her doorway with his cap still on because he had forgotten to take it off, that he had walked the whole ring of it that afternoon, as near as the pickets would let him go, and that there was no gap in it he could find that a man might drive a cart through, only the hill paths, and those good for nothing heavier than what a back could carry.

"How long have we coal for," Sarah asked him. She kept the answer herself, to the sack, and asked it all the same, the way a person sometimes wants a bad sum said aloud by another voice before they will properly believe it.

"Weeks," Tom said. "Coal and potatoes both, if it's managed right, which it will be, because Meikle's already at the counting of it and Meikle counts things carefully." He looked at her a moment longer than the answer needed. "Weeks isn't long enough, Sarah, not truly, and we both know it. It's more than I'd have said we had a year ago, before any of us thought to lay any of it by."

She did not ask him the other question in her mind that evening, which was how many weeks a town of six hundred souls, swollen now by however many of Àth leathan's own people had come up the ridge path with him in the spring and stayed on rather than go further, could hold water and grain and courage all together before one or another of the three ran short first; she had learned, in the two months since the battle, that Tom Varley answered a plain question honestly and a question dressed as despair not at all, and she had need of him answering plainly rather more than she had need of comfort. She put the kettle on instead, because it was the one thing in the house that still worked exactly as it always had, siege or no siege, and set it to boil over a fire built, that evening and every evening after for weeks to come, out of the last of Cnoc thais's poor black coal.

II

Of the Pit-heads Taken One by One

The dressing-station had never properly closed since the spring, Sarah's own kitchen having done service for the wounded of Àth leathan before it ever

needed to do service for a siege, and it filled again within the first week, though more slowly than it had after the battle, a man brought in with a shoulder opened by a stray shot from the northern picket, a girl who had put her foot wrong on the hill path carrying water up from the one spring inside the ring the regiments had left them, an old woman whose heart, already failing before any of it began, gave out entirely on the third night of the siege in a way that had nothing to do with soldiers at all and everything, Sarah thought privately, to do with the sound of the bell.

The bell of Muileann àrsaidh's own small chapel had rung for weddings and for burials the whole of Sarah's life and her mother's before her, a single note struck by hand from a rope in the porch, since the town had never run to more than the one bell and had never, until that spring, needed to ring it for anything but the ordinary business of being born and married and dying. It was Meikle, of all people, the same careful man who kept the town's writing and now kept its counting of coal and potatoes both, who proposed that the bell be rung once for every pit-head the regiments took, on the reasoning, offered to the town gathered in the pit-shed on the fourth evening of the siege, that a town under siege wanted some way of knowing plainly, all at once, what had been lost that day, rather than hearing it piecemeal from whoever happened to have been nearest the fighting and was willing to talk of it.

The pit-heads went one at a time, through the last week of an Cèitean and on into an t-Ògmhios, not all at once and not, so far as anyone in the town could afterward make out a pattern to it, in any order that served the regiments' convenience over the town's, but simply as each fell in its turn to whatever pressure was brought against it that day: the northern head first, nearest the unfinished stretch of wall, taken on the sixth day after a fight that lasted the better part of an afternoon and cost the town two men Sarah had known since they were boys; then, a week later, the eastern head, given up rather than fought for, on Tom Varley's own counsel, because the ground about it could not be held without stripping men from the wall that mattered more; then a long stretch of near a fortnight in which nothing at all was taken and the town began, cautiously, to let itself believe the regiments had decided the remaining ground was not worth the cost of it, a hope Sarah did not share aloud though she felt the pull of it same as anyone, because she had watched, from her own doorway, the number of tents on the ridge above the southern road grow rather than shrink through that fortnight, and knew what a growing camp generally meant.

The bell rang twice on a single evening in the third week of an t-Ògmhios, for the southern head and the smaller working above it both, lost within an hour of each other in a fight Sarah heard more than saw, being at that hour elbow-deep in a wound at her own table and unable to leave it; and it was that evening, with the second stroke of the bell still going out over the roofs and the light failing fast the way it does in that month even at its longest, that she understood, setting a dressing in place with hands that did not shake though she had expected by then that they might, that the town's own reckoning of the siege, which had begun the first week with plain sums of coal and potatoes, had somewhere in the weeks between become instead a reckoning of pit-heads, the way a body counts down from a full hand of fingers, and that there were, by her own count kept without meaning to keep it, three left standing of the six the wall had once been built to hold.

Tom Varley came to her kitchen most evenings a fight had happened, some to be tended himself, though only twice was the tending more than a scratch, and the rest of the evenings simply because there was nowhere else in the town a man wanted to sit out the day's end but somewhere with a fire and another living person in the room. He rarely spoke of Ruth Calder that summer, having by his own telling asked every question there was to ask of every farm within reach months before, and had every answer there was to have, none of them an answer worth the name; he spoke of her once, late in an t-Ògmhios with the bell silent for three days running and the whole town holding a stillness that felt, Sarah thought, heavier in its way than the ringing had been, saying only that he found himself glad, in a way he could not properly account for even to his own self, that whatever had become of her, she was not inside this particular ring counting down pit-heads along with the rest of them, since a person could only be asked to carry so much ground in her own chest before something in her gave the way a shaft-timber gives, all at once and with little warning beforehand. Sarah said nothing to that beyond setting another cup of what passed, by then, for tea in front of him, judging rightly that he had not said it wanting an answer.

The stores held better than the fear had, through those first weeks, Meikle's counting proving out as careful as his reputation, and the town settled, as towns under siege will, into something that was not quite ordinary life and was not quite anything else either: a rota for the water, a rota for the walls where walls still stood, the chapel's one service a week kept as it had always been kept though the congregation that came to it grew thinner by attrition to the walls and to the dressing-station both, and Sarah's own kitchen, feeding fewer mouths now on

smaller portions than it had fed at Ruth Calder's meeting five years before in what felt, to everyone who remembered it, like another age of the world entirely.

Children still played in the one street those first weeks, in the way children will play under almost any roof so long as somebody keeps the worst of the fear from their own faces, a game of counting pit-heads themselves that Sarah overheard one afternoon from her own doorway and had to go inside for a moment rather than let the children see what it did to her, four small voices chanting the names of the six pit-heads in a rhyme none of them could afterward say who had made up, with a hand slapped down at each name the way a hand slaps down at a lost point in any other game, and no understanding at all, mercifully, of what the game's own ending would mean once the last name in it had been slapped down for the last time. Sarah never told Meikle of it, nor Weir either, judging that a thing children had made of their own fear to carry it was not a thing grown people ought to take from them before the fear itself was done.

III

Of the Sunday Kept and the Grave Behind the Chapel

The one thing the siege did not ration, Sarah came to think through those weeks, was Sunday, and she was glad of it more than she ever said aloud, because a town that had given up counting the days of the week by anything but the bell's tolling for a pit-head needed, she judged, some other reckoning left over that had nothing to do with what had been lost. The priest of Muileann àrsaidh's own small congregation, an elderly man named Weir who had buried Sarah's husband under the fall of stone and married a good half the town besides, kept his one weekly service through the whole of the siege without missing a Sunday, though the benches held fewer each week as men were called instead to the walls and the dressing-station both, and though the bread on the little table by the door, kept there since before Sarah could remember for whoever in the parish had none of their own, stood empty for the first time in her recollection by the fourth week, there being nobody left in Muileann àrsaidh with bread enough spare to leave any on a table.

Weir preached short that summer, shorter each week if anything, on the plain reasoning, which he gave to Sarah once over the graveside of the old woman whose heart had failed the third night, that a congregation standing a siege

wanted its comfort given briefly and its own strength left for the rest of the day's work, and that a long sermon on a short summer's morning was, in his judgement, a kind of vanity no man of his trade could properly afford that year. He read the same psalm three Sundays running in the second month of it, the one about a strong tower and a very present help, without any comment on the reading at all beyond the reading itself, and Sarah, sitting in her usual place near the back with her hands raw from the dressing-station's work, found that she did not need the comment, the psalm having said, plainly enough for anyone in that room to hear it, exactly the thing the room had come needing to hear.

The graves went in behind the chapel through those weeks at a rate the town had not seen since the fever year Sarah's own grandmother used to speak of, though never so fast that the ground itself grew short, the western hills having buried their dead in that same plot since before An Dealachadh¹ and having, by Weir's own dry reckoning, ground enough behind the chapel wall to serve three towns the size of Muileann àrsaidh twice over before it wanted extending. The old woman went in first, in the second week, and after her the two men lost at the northern head, and after them a scattering through the rest of the summer that Sarah, standing at the graveside for most of them because there was seldom anyone left in a household to stand there otherwise, found herself keeping a private count of without ever meaning to, the way she kept the pit-heads' count without meaning to either, until the two counts together sat behind her breastbone most evenings like a second and a third heartbeat she could not still by any effort of her own.

Meikle's rationing held through it all with a steadiness Sarah came, by mid-summer, to depend on the way a person depends on weather holding fair through a hay-making: a set weight of meal to a household by the week, a set weight of coal to a hearth by the day, a smaller portion again once the second month of the siege began and the town's own store of the year's potatoes, laid by against an ordinary winter and not against a siege at all, began visibly to shrink in the pit where it was kept. He came to Sarah's own kitchen twice a week with his figures written small on a scrap of paper, not because her table needed watching over more than any other in the town but because he had, she came to understand, nowhere else he wanted to sit with the figures once they were done for the day, and she fed him from her own reduced portion without remark either way, since a man who kept

1. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

a whole town's counting straight through seven weeks of siege had, in her private reckoning, earned rather more than his own strict share of whatever there was left to give.

IV

Of the Third and the Fifth

Word of what moved beyond the ring came into the town the way most news came into a besieged place, in pieces, carried by whoever had last spoken to whoever had last spoken to a man who had actually seen the thing himself, so that Sarah learned of An treas rèisimeid¹ and the fifth both from no report she could have set any store by, only from a picket's own boast, shouted across the gap where the northern head had been to two of the town's own men on watch there, that the town might as well open its gates now as later, since Cathair mhòr had sent a whole regiment north under the Mac Ùisdein's own cross to see the business finished, and Seann Warr another besides, and that between the two of them and what already sat on the southern road, there would shortly be more soldiers ringed about Muileann àrsaidh than the town had ever had people in it at any one time in its history.

It was old Fraser, of all people, standing his watch at the gap he had once dug and never finished walling, who brought that boast back down into the town and set it before the pit-shed that evening as plainly as he had once set his mattock down at the same spot, saying only that a boast shouted across a gap by a bored picket on a slow evening was no thing to build despair on; still, he had counted the smoke of new fires on the southern ridge for three mornings running and there were more of them than there had been the week before, which was a thing a man's own eyes could tell him and no picket's boasting was needed to confirm. Sarah, sitting near the back of the shed with a mending she had brought to keep her hands from idleness, thought that this was Fraser through and through, to distrust the shouted word and trust the smoke, and thought also, though she said nothing of it aloud, that a regiment raised at Cathair mhòr under a house's own cross and another raised on a lake shore two days' ride away, both sent north in the same fortnight for no other business she could imagine but this one, told her

1. the third regiment

something the boast alone would not have: that whatever Muileann àrsaidh's few hundred souls had thought they were worth to the kingdom that besieged them, the kingdom, spending two regiments' raising and marching on the answer, plainly thought them worth rather more.

What came of the third and the fifth, once they came, Sarah never afterward learned in any order she trusted, the pit-shed's evening talk through the last weeks of the siege being less a council by then than a place where rumour was aired and mostly, though not always, found wanting: that the new men had been set to strengthen the southern road rather than force any new ground, which Tom Varley judged likely, from what little he could see of their dispositions on his own watches; that a company of them had been sent instead down toward the coast to see to some trouble with the fishing boats that had nothing to do with Muileann àrsaidh at all, which Meikle judged less likely, though he could not say why beyond a general distrust of any rumour that made the town's own trouble smaller than it felt; and that Somhairle mac Lachlainn himself, whose name the town knew by then the way a town under siege learns the name of whoever commands the ring around it, without ever having laid eyes on him, had come up from the western Seann Skell to see the reinforced lines himself, which nobody could confirm and everybody, in the way of these things, half believed regardless of the confirming.

It was in that same stretch of weeks, from a man taken briefly at the wall and let go again the next morning under some understanding between the two sides that Sarah never fully grasped the shape of, that word reached the town of the capital's own streets going dark again, the poorer ones at least, the dubhan that had once lit them being taken now, as coal once had been taken before it, for the army's own use first and the ordinary lamp-houses after, if anything was left over to give them; and Sarah, hearing this third or fourth hand in her own kitchen from a man still shaking with the two nights he had spent not knowing whether he would be let go or kept, found in it a small, cold satisfaction she was not proud of and did not try hard to be rid of, that the fuel the kingdom had taken up in place of coal, and had sent an army north to make sure the western hills took it up too, could not after all light every street it claimed to serve once that same army wanted feeding first.

V

Of the Door Nobody Was Left to Hold

By the second week of an t-Iuchar the bell had rung for five of the six pit-heads, and the sixth, the one nearest the town's own street and nearest, therefore, to Sarah's own kitchen door, stood behind a line of men and women so thinned by the weeks before it that Tom Varley, walking it on what would prove to be his last full round of the walls before the end, told her plainly that evening, sitting at her table with a cup he did not drink from, that he did not think the line would hold a second real push, and that he had told the same to Meikle and to old Fraser both, and that neither of them had disagreed with him, which from either man was as near to a confession of the same fear as either was ever likely to give.

The push, when it came, came in the grey hour before a full morning, the same hour the whole siege had begun in seven weeks before, and it came not with any great weight of shot or shouting, so far as Sarah afterward could piece it together from the little she saw with her own eyes and the rather more she was told by others in the days just after, but with a quietness that frightened her more, in the moment, than noise would have done, the line at the last pit-head simply giving way in the dark the way a rope gives that has been fraying for weeks and finally parts on no particular pull heavier than any that came before it. She woke to Tom Varley's own voice at her door, not loud, saying only her name and then that it was over, that the last of the pit-heads was taken and there was no line left anywhere in the town for anyone to hold, and that she should open her door before someone with less patience than the men who had let a prisoner go free a fortnight before came and opened it for her. He did not stay to say more than that. He had kin still at Cnoc thais, he told her once, months back, over the same table, and a shaft of his own there he meant to see fired by his own hand and no other's before any regiment came near it, and Sarah understood, watching him go back out into the dark toward the hill path rather than toward the street where the soldiers would shortly be, that he meant to keep that word if the hills would let him, and did not try to keep him from it.

She dressed and went down and found the street already full of a grey, tired quiet that was not quite surrender and not quite anything a person could properly name, townsfolk standing in their own doorways or sitting on their own steps because there was, in the end, nowhere left to go and nothing left to hold, and sol-

diers coming up the one street in no great hurry, as men come who have already won a thing and know it and see no cause to make more noise about the winning than the winning required. Sarah stood in her own doorway with her hair, as on the first morning, not properly pinned, and watched them come, and found, when the first of them reached her, a young man with a face no older than her own son's would have been had her son lived past his second winter, that she had nothing in her to meet him with beyond the plain fact of the open door behind her, opened by her own hand before he could think to ask, there being no one left in the town, herself included, with the strength or the reason left to keep it shut.

He asked her, in *Dia-thìris* first and then, when she did not at once answer, in the humans' own tongue, whether there were arms in the house, and she told him there were none beyond a kitchen knife she had used that morning to cut bread, and stood aside to let him look, which he did, briefly and without unkindness, before going on to the next door, and the next, the whole street being worked through in that same brief, businesslike way by men who had, she understood watching them, done this same work in other towns before this one and would likely do it again in others after, and found in that thought, standing in her own doorway with the morning coming up grey and ordinary over a town that had held for seven weeks and now, in the space of a single dark hour, had nothing left to hold with, neither comfort nor its opposite, only a kind of tiredness too complete to hold either.

What *An Clàr Foscailte*¹ gives of that day, *Sileas nic Rath*'s own hand setting it down some months later at *Muileann chaol* from whatever report crossed her desk, is the day, and nothing more: that *Muileann àrsaidh* fell on that date, after a siege of some weeks, and was found, on the regiments' own taking of it, to hold nothing further worth a report. Of the bell, and of *Fraser's* unfinished wall, and of *Meikle's* careful counting of coal and potatoes both, and of a kitchen table that had been a dressing-station through a whole spring and half a summer, *An Clàr Foscailte* says nothing at all, having no way of knowing it, and *Sarah Dunmore*, telling it afterward to whoever in the hills still cared to ask her, never troubled herself greatly over *An Clàr Foscailte's* silence, having long since learned, in seven weeks of counting pit-heads by the striking of a single chapel bell, that a thing could be entirely true and entirely unwritten both at once, and that the second did not, in the end, make the first any less so.

1. the open record of the war years

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

Of the Benches at Doire ghlais

DE 21

I

Of the First of Them

They came down out of the hills the way water comes down a hill after rain, Ellen Marsh thought, watching the first of them from her own gate on a wet morning in an Giblean: a trickle at first, no order to it that a person could have foretold, and then, before you had rightly marked the trickle had begun, more than the ground about you seemed able to hold. The first family she saw with her own eyes was five people and a handcart, a woman and three children and an old man too stiff in the knees to have walked the whole way on his own legs, though he had, the woman said, because there had been no cart to spare for him and no time to wait for one.

"Àth leathan," the woman said, when Ellen asked her, the one word and no more, standing in the lane with the rain running off her shawl and her eyes gone past Ellen to the grey roofs of Doire ghlais beyond her, as if she could not yet quite believe a town still stood whole anywhere on the island. She did not say the battle's name. Nobody who came down that spring said the battle's name, not for weeks yet; they said the town's name, Àth leathan, and let the listener supply the rest, because the rest was a thing that did not want saying twice by the person who had walked out from under it.

Ellen took them in that first night, the five of them and the handcart both, her own house being the nearest with a fire lit, and gave them what she had, which

was porridge and a corner of the byre for the old man's knees to be spared the floor, and did not ask them any of the questions her notebook wanted asked, because a woman who has walked three days with three children and a father-in-law who cannot bend his own legs is not a woman a schoolteacher puts a pen in front of on the first night. She asked instead where they meant to go on, and was told nowhere, that Caol mhòr was said to have work on the boats and Doire ghlas was said to have the mill, and that one or the other would have to do, since there was no third place left in the world that anybody in that family could name with any certainty of finding it standing.

More came the next week, and more the week after, along the same road down out of the western hills that had never in Ellen's memory carried more than a carrier's cart and a drover's cattle at any one time, walking now in twos and fives and, once, a whole clutch of eleven from three farms near Muileann àrsaidh who had left together in the night before the ditch-bridge went down, having judged, rightly as it turned out, that a siege was coming and having no wish to be inside the ring when it closed. They did not all come to Ellen's own gate. Most went on into the town proper, to whatever door had a fire showing through the shutter-crack and a face behind it willing to open, and by the month's end there was hardly a house in Doire ghlas that did not have some part of a stranger's family sleeping on its floor, nor a house in Caol mhòr either, by what letters told her, the two towns between them having taken in, by a count nobody had troubled yet to make formal, some hundreds of souls who three months before had never set foot north of the western hills in their lives.

Ellen kept her school running through all of it, mornings at least, judging that the children who were left to her, her own town's children and now a growing scatter of the newcomers' besides, wanted the one ordinary thing in their days more than they wanted a holiday from it; and she found, teaching sums and letters to a room grown suddenly half again its size, that the new children learned quick and said little, and that the ones from Àth leathan in particular would not, for weeks, be drawn into games that ran too near the door, as though a door left standing open behind them at speed was a thing their bodies had not yet finished expecting.

It was from one of the mothers, a woman named Nell Forbes who had taken the empty half of the net-mender's cottage two doors from Ellen's own, that she first heard the word used plainly, in the humans' tongue and then again in *Dia-thìris* as though the woman wanted to be sure of being understood in both: that

the town they had left had been taken, and its pits, which had fed three generations of her own house, filled with water on the regiments' own order within a day of the fighting's end, so that there was, in the plainest sense a person could mean it, nothing left in Àth leathan for any of them to go back to even had they wished it. She said this without much weight in her voice, the way a person reports a fact they have said over often enough to themselves already that the saying of it aloud costs less than it once did, and Ellen, writing nothing down that evening, only listening, thought that this was itself a kind of telling, the flat voice as much a record as the words it carried.

The old man who had ridden the handcart the whole way, whose name Ellen learned only in the third week, when he judged himself sufficiently recovered in his own dignity to give it, was called Hugh Ferris, and had been forty years a hewer before his knees gave out and ten more a keeper of the pit-shed's own small library of tallies and wage-books, so that of all the household he alone had thought, in the handful of minutes the leaving allowed him, to bring away a single ledger under his coat rather than any clothing or food, on the reasoning, given to Ellen without apology, that clothing could be begged from any charitable house on the road but a hewer's forty years of wages, owed and part-paid and disputed, existed nowhere but in that one book, and a man who let a debt owed him go under the water along with the pit that owed it was a man choosing, in his own small way, to let the water win more than it had already won. He showed her the ledger once, dried by the fire and swollen at the spine from a wetting it had taken somewhere on the road, and asked her, in all seriousness, whether the schoolteacher thought a book of wages owed by a flooded pit to a hewer three months gone from the town that pit stood in was a book worth keeping any longer, or only a thing an old man carried because he had carried it too far already to set it down. Ellen told him she did not know, which was true, and that she would keep it for him regardless, which was also true, and put it on the shelf in her own front room beside the wrapped and waiting eleventh book, where it stayed the whole of that summer, two ledgers of two different kinds of debt standing side by side and neither of them yet called in.

Martha Greaves had sat in the chair at Caol mhòr the day the room voted nine to none that Tìonal nan Tuathach¹ was no party to the quarrel and would feed any who came hungry, and she had known then, better than most of the room had troubled to know it, that a vote is a promise made to a future the room cannot yet see the shape of, and that the shape, when it comes, generally asks more of the promise than the promise-makers quite bargained for at the trestle. She was proved right of that within the year, and found, proved right, that she took no satisfaction whatever in the proving.

The granaries at Caol mhòr and Doire ghlais had been kept full since the summer before on the wool mills' own takings, against a want Martha had not named aloud even to Thomas Rook, who kept the books and asked no questions she did not care to answer. She fed the first comers from the mills' own kitchens that spring, the same weeks the first families reached her own town's gates, and did the plain arithmetic of the granaries at her own kitchen table by candlelight because she trusted no clerk's sum on this particular matter but her own, and found that what she had laid by would carry the towns' own people and a few hundred more through to the next harvest, provided the few hundred did not become a few thousand, and provided the harvest came in as it generally did.

She said as much to the room at the next sitting, standing in the cold over the net-lofts with the same ice on the same far window that had not properly gone since the winter she called the nine votes, and found the room readier than she had looked for to hear it. Peter Hale moved that the granaries be opened without further vote needed, the nine votes of the year before being, in his own words, a promise already made and now only being kept rather than a new thing the room had to decide over again, and the room agreed to that reading of it with less argument than Martha had braced herself for, and the granaries were opened to the families of the west in the middle of an t-Iuchar, when the mills' own kitchens could stretch no further, though Christina Munro, from the farm towns' bench, asked plainly what would be done if the harvest failed to come in as it generally did, and got no better answer than that the room would cross that ground when it came to it, which satisfied nobody, Martha least of all, but was the truest answer there was to give.

What she did not put before the room, because it was not the room's business to weigh and she had already weighed it herself in the small hours more than

1. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

once, was the shape of the choice underneath the vote: that the council in the capital, whose regiments had emptied the western hills of the people now filling her own town's spare rooms, had sent nothing north to feed them and had forbidden nothing that Tional nan Tuathach chose to do about it either, the silence on both counts being, as she had come to understand silences of that particular kind, its own sort of answer. She wrote to Sileas nic Rath at an Leabharlann² that same week, less to ask anything of an Leabharlann, which she knew by then had no more power over the council's silence than Tional nan Tuathach did, than to have the fact set down somewhere outside her own kitchen table that Tional nan Tuathach had acted and the council had not, in case a day came when that difference wanted proving to someone who had not been there to see it for themselves.

Thomas Rook kept the register from the first week, a plain ledger bought for the purpose and ruled by his own hand into columns, name, town of origin, family, and a last column headed simply *taken in*, which he filled with whichever house or hall had found room for the family named on that line. He came to Martha near the end of an Cèitean with the ledger open at the last written page and his face doing the sum before his voice did.

"Three hundred and forty," he said. "As near as I can make it, and I'll not swear to the last ten, because a family that moves house twice in a fortnight, as more than a few have, is a family a ledger has trouble keeping honest count of."

"Three hundred and forty," Martha said, "out of two towns that between them held four thousand souls at the last count the head-due took."

"Aye."

"And the harvest not in yet."

"Aye," Thomas Rook said again, and closed the ledger over his thumb rather than let it fall shut on its own, the way a man closes a door he means to open again shortly rather than one he is done with, and Martha understood, watching him do it, that he had come to her not to be told what to do about the number, which neither of them could yet do anything about, but only to have another living person hear it said aloud before the writing of it went back into the dark of the ledger's covers where numbers lived until somebody needed them again.

She went down to the harbour that same evening, as she had taken to doing when the day's business would not let her sleep on it plainly, and stood a while watching the boats come in against a wind that had turned since noon, the fishing

2. the Library at Muileann chaol

families of Caol mhòr going about the ordinary business of their own trade as though the town behind them had not doubled its trouble in the space of a season. A boy she knew, one of the harbourmaster's own, ran past her with a coil of rope over his shoulder and called out, in the way of a child who has heard a grown thing said at his own table and repeats it without yet weighing it, that his father said Tional nan Tuathach would beggar itself feeding half the western hills before the year was out and serve the council right if it did, since it was the council's own regiments had made the beggars in the first place. Martha did not correct him, a boy of ten owing no speaker of Tional nan Tuathach a careful answer, and she carried the sentence home with her all the same, turning it over the way she turned over most things said plainly by people who had not troubled to soften them for her hearing, and found, weighing it against her own kitchen-table arithmetic, that she could not honestly call it wrong, only early, the begging being a thing that had not yet happened and might yet be held off, granary by granary, harvest by harvest, so long as the towns that had voted the promise kept finding, each season, some new way to make good on it.

There was a second sitting of the room in an t-Iuchar, called at Peter Hale's own asking rather than by the calendar, at which the delegate of the eastern towns, a quiet man named William Reid who had said little at the first sitting and less since, rose to ask whether the room had considered that feeding the west's own people indefinitely, without any word from the west's own towns as to how long the feeding was likely to be needed, was a promise the room had made without a floor under it, in the sense that a floor is a thing you can at least say how far down it lies. Martha, from the chair, answered him herself rather than let the room answer for her, saying only that she had asked herself the same question at her own kitchen table more nights than she cared to number, and had found no better answer to give the room than the one she gave herself, which was that a promise made without knowing its own floor was still a promise, and the not knowing was no excuse the room had ever offered itself before for breaking one that mattered less. William Reid sat down at that without pressing further, and Christina Munro, two benches along, said nothing at all, which Martha took, rightly or not, for the nearest thing to agreement the farm towns' bench was likely to give her that year.

III

Of the School's New Trade

The school that Agnes Pike had built at Doire ghlais thirty years before, out of her own money and her own stubbornness against a Moot that had not, in that generation, thought a mill town's children wanted more schooling than their trade required, was given over, a room at a time from the last week of an Cèitean and wholly in the last week of an t-Iuchar, to whatever families still had no roof of their own, its four rooms and its long hall together holding, by Thomas Rook's count, near sixty souls by midsummer, the benches Ellen had taught sums on for a dozen years serving now, pushed together in twos and threes with a blanket over the gap, for beds.

She kept teaching in the one room the families had left her, mornings still, the room crowded now with children who slept twenty feet from where they learned their letters and seemed, on the whole, none the worse for the closeness of it; and in the evenings, when the lessons were done and the hall had settled into whatever a room full of displaced families settles into once the day's small business of eating and washing and quarrelling mildly over blankets has run its course, she took her notebook, the twelfth after the eleven she had already filled and offered an *Le-abharlann*¹, which had answered, by Raghnaill mac Mhuirich's own letter, with no promise of taking them up, and began, without quite deciding to begin it, to write down what the families told her.

It was not the same work as *An t-Aon Leabhar Deug*² had been. Those had been given slowly, over years, by old people with a whole life's telling saved up and offered a little at a time to a listener they had come to trust; this was given fast, in the first raw weeks of a loss too near to have found its proper shape yet, by people who had not asked to be listened to and in some cases did not want to be, and who told her, when they told her anything, not the long considered account an old woman gives at the end of her life but the sharp particular things a person cannot help saying because the mind will not put them down of its own accord: the exact word a neighbour had used, standing at his own door, when he chose to stay rather than come; the weight of a handcart's one wheel going soft in a rut two miles from anywhere; a hen someone had carried the whole way in a basket and

1. the Library at Muileann chaol

2. the eleven books of *Tuathaich* accounts gathered by Ellen Marsh over eleven years and offered to the Library

would not now eat, keeping it instead as though the keeping of it were the last unbroken thing in the house.

Ellen wrote all of it down, in Dia-thiris as she had always written, and found that this book, unlike the eleven before it, grew a name of its own within the first month without her choosing one for it: the families themselves, hearing that the schoolteacher kept a book, began to call it, among themselves, the war-book, and to bring things to her for it the way a person brings a thing to be weighed, half in the hope of having it made lighter by the telling and half only because there was, in a hall crowded with strangers and grief both, nowhere else the thing could properly be set down.

Nell Forbes's own contribution to it, given one evening in an t-Iuchar with her three children long asleep on the bench behind her, was the shortest and, Ellen thought afterward, the truest thing anyone gave her that whole summer: that she had left her own kitchen dresser standing, plates and all, because there had been no room on the cart for it and no time to choose what to save from what to leave, and that she thought of the dresser now, of all the things she might have thought of, more often than she thought of the house itself, because a house, once you have walked far enough away from it, becomes a thing your mind can hold whole and finished, but a dresser with the plates still on it stays, somehow, unfinished, a thing still happening somewhere without you.

Hugh Ferris gave her something for the war-book too, near the end of an t-Iuchar, once he had settled enough into the hall's own rhythm to think the giving worth his while: not an account of the leaving, which he would not be drawn on beyond what he had already told her of the ledger under his coat, but a description, exact to the number of steps, of the pit-shed at Muileann àrsaidh where Ruth Calder had once stood to read out the agreement the five towns signed, a building he was certain by then stood no longer, or stood flooded to the rafters if it stood at all, and which he wished, he said, set down somewhere in a book with his own name attached to the setting-down, on the reasoning that a pit-shed a man has stood inside forty years deserves one more accounting before it goes under, whatever becomes of the coal beneath it. Ellen wrote the shed down as he gave it, the bench along the north wall, the tally-board by the door, the smell of the lamp oil that never quite left the timbers, and thought, copying his exact steps into her own exact hand, that this was the nearest thing to an epitaph the man was ever likely to compose for a building, and that it would have to do, there being, as with so much that summer, no better one on offer from anywhere else.

Not every family that came to the hall gave the war-book anything at all, and Ellen made a point, from the first week, of asking nobody twice who had once turned the asking aside; there were households who ate at the long table and slept behind their own blanket and spoke to her only of the weather or the children's sums for the whole of their time under Agnes Pike's roof, and she let them, judging, as she had judged of the family at her own gate the first wet morning, that a book kept by a schoolteacher was a use for the telling and not a debt the telling owed.

IV

Of the Name a Child Gave Her

It was a girl of no more than eight, one of the Muileann àrsaidh eleven who had left in the night before the ditch-bridge fell, who came to Ellen at the school in the last week of an t-Iuchar, after the evening's lessons and before the hall's evening business had properly begun, and asked her, without any of the preamble the older families generally gave their askings, whether the war-book had names in it.

"Some," Ellen said. "The names of the people who tell me things, when they want their own name kept with what they've said. Not always. Some would rather the telling stood alone."

"Would you put a name in it that I gave you," the girl said, "even if I can't tell you anything true to go with it? I don't know anything true. I only know the name."

Ellen set down her pen, because she had learned, in eleven years of taking down old women's tellings, that a question asked in that particular flat, careful way was not a question to be answered with the pen already moving. "Whose name is it?"

"Ruth Calder's," the girl said. "My mother knew her. Everyone in Muileann àrsaidh knew her, or knew of her, which my mother says is near the same thing in a town that size. Nobody's put her name anywhere since the spring. My mother says An Clàr Foscailte¹ has all the dead of the battle written down proper, every one, but Ruth Calder isn't dead, or isn't known to be, so she isn't in the dead

1. the open record of the war years

ones' list, and she isn't in anything else either, because nothing else got written down about her at all, not since, and my mother says that's not right, a person going about not dead and not written down anywhere as if she'd never been a person in the first place."

Ellen looked at her a moment, and then picked the pen back up, because there was, in the end, no true reason not to, and turned to a clean page near the back of the book, the pages she kept for things given without a full telling behind them, single lines standing alone the way a stone stands alone in a field that has otherwise been cleared. "Tell me what your mother says, then," she said. "Not what you think I want. What she says."

"She says Ruth Calder drafted the agreement at the pit-shed five years back, the one that let the five towns work their own seams and sell to whoever'd buy honest coal from them. She was chosen to speak for the towns because nobody else wanted the work of writing the letters, and she wrote them anyway, every one, and the last one on an Nollaig² after church, and nobody answered it. My mother says she was at Àth leathan the morning of the battle with a list in her hand, counting who'd come to fight, and that's the last anyone from Muileann àrsaidh saw of her or heard of her, and that's all. That's the whole of it. I don't know anything else, because there isn't anything else to know."

Ellen wrote it down exactly as the girl gave it, in the girl's own order, changing nothing, adding nothing, and did not write beneath it any of the things her own mind wanted to add, that An Clàr Foscailte's silence on the matter was likely to be permanent, that a name once dropped from every list a kingdom keeps rarely finds its way back onto one, that she herself, in eleven years of this same work, had never yet taken down a telling that ended in anything so plainly unfinished as this one did. She closed the book instead on the girl's last line, *that's all, that's the whole of it, I don't know anything else, because there isn't anything else to know*, and thought, walking home along the lane past the school's lit windows with the hall's evening noise going up behind her, of Thomas Rook's ledger and its last column, *taken in*, and of how many things a town could be asked to take in that a single ruled column had no proper heading for at all.

She wrote nothing more in the war-book that night. The girl's line stood alone on its page, as she had meant it to stand, and Ellen, closing the cover over it,

2. Christmas

found she had no wish, that evening or any evening after, to be the one who decided what ought to be written beneath it.

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

OF CNOC thais and the Windy Coast

DE 21

Part Five • Of the Regiments in the North

Cha deach dad a lorg. Nothing was found.

— a regimental return, DE 21

I

Of the Road They Cut

Tom Varley had reopened the two shafts at Cnoc thais with his own hands five winters before the war came looking for them, and he had known even then, hauling the first cartload of poor coal up into daylight with three other men and a borrowed windlass, that a seam a town cuts on its own account without a charter is a seam some day somebody with more men than argument will want back. He had said as much to Sarah Dunmore once, at her own kitchen table, and she had not disagreed with him; and he thought of that unremarkable evening a good deal in the middle weeks of an t-Iuchar, hard on his own coming home from Muileann àrsaidh, when the word came up the hill paths, farm to farm the way word always came in that country, that the road below Cnoc thais was cut.

It was cut the way the road to Muileann àrsaidh had been cut earlier that summer, a company dug in across the cart track where it left the last of the flat ground and began to climb, and a second company working along the ridge to close the hill paths one by one, so that within a fortnight a man could still walk out of

Cnoc thais on his own two feet, by paths only the town's own people rightly knew, but nothing on wheels could come in or go out, and nothing at all could come in that the regiments below did not first choose to let by. Tom had seen a siege from the inside once already that year, at Muileann àrsaidh, from the wrong side of a wall with a boy's blood on his hands, and he had carried the wounded of it up a ridge path in the dark and left a woman he could give no better answer than silence. He had told himself, walking home from Muileann àrsaidh to his own shaft-head with that behind him, that he would not stand inside a second wall and watch it close a second time, and he found, when the road below Cnoc thais was cut in earnest, that he still held to it.

The town itself was smaller than Muileann àrsaidh and had held out longer than anyone below it in the low country had troubled to expect, for the plain reason that Cnoc thais had never been much of a town to begin with, a scatter of houses about two shaft-heads and a chapel too small for half its own dead, and a company sent to take a place that size does not, in the ordinary way of war, hurry. The regiment below spent the better part of three weeks doing nothing that Tom's own watchers on the ridge could make out as an attack at all: digging, mending a bridge the spring floods had taken, drilling in a field the townsfolk had sown that year with oats they would not now live to cut. Tom used the weeks as they were given him. He walked the two shafts with the men who had cut them beside him, old Angus Rennie's cousin among them, and worked out between them, in the evenings, by a single shaded lamp in the room behind the chapel that served the town for a council when it needed one, exactly how much powder the lower galleries would want to bring the roof down clean and how much less than that would only crack the timbering and leave a seam half open for whoever came after to clear.

"You'd know that better than any man here," Angus's cousin said to him, the second evening, meaning it kindly and meaning also, Tom understood, that the work of ruining a thing you had built with your own hands was not work any man should be asked to reckon twice over if once would serve. Tom did not answer that directly. He said only that he had gone down those shafts as a boy to another man's coal before he ever cut a foot of his own, and that a shaft, when all was said, was a hole in a hill and would still be a hole in a hill when the war that wanted it closed was three generations forgotten, which was less an answer than a thing he told himself to make the reckoning bearable, and both men in that room knew it for what it was and let it stand.

The council, such as it was, met most evenings in that same chapel room, five men and two women who held no charter for the holding of it beyond the town's own custom of asking the oldest and the steadiest to sit and hear a thing out before anybody acted on it, and Tom sat with them though he had never been asked to and nobody had ever thought to tell him not to. The talk those evenings ran the same ground over and over, the way talk will when a town is waiting on a thing it cannot hurry and cannot put off: whether to send the children down to kin in the low country while the road still allowed it, whether a message to Muileann àrsaidh's own remnant might bring help that did not exist to bring, whether the regiment below meant to starve the town out slow or take it quick, a question none of them could answer and all of them asked all the same, the way a man worries a loose tooth with his tongue for the plain reason that it is there to worry.

It was old Mary Kessock, the eldest of the two women and a widow of a hewer dead these twenty years, who said, the second week of that waiting, the thing Tom found himself turning over longest after. She had lived through An Dealachadh¹ as a girl, or near enough to it that her own mother had, and she said that a town threatened by soldiers it cannot fight had, in her mother's telling of the old days, exactly two ends open to it: to be taken whole, houses and all, for whatever use the takers wanted made of it, or to leave the takers nothing worth the taking and go. Cnoc thais, she said, looking round the room with an evenness that Tom thought afterward had cost her a good deal to keep, was too small and too poor to be worth much taken whole, and that left, by her own reckoning, only the second end, whenever the soldiers finally troubled to come up and prove her right or wrong of it. Nobody in the room argued with her that evening, though nobody voted on it either, there being nothing yet to vote on; but Tom saw, watching the faces round the shaded lamp, that the room had, without a word more being said, already begun quietly making ready to leave rather than be taken, each in whatever way each household judged it could manage the leaving.

II

Of the Firing

1. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

Cnoc thais fell in an Lùnastal, on a morning grey with the kind of low cloud the western hills keep long past the season the low country calls summer, and it fell, by every account An Clàr Foscailte¹ afterward gave and every account Tom himself carried away from it, without the town ever properly deciding to let it. The regiment came up the last of the road at first light, having found, two days before, a shepherd's path along the northern ridge that the town's own watchers had judged too steep for anything but goats and had, for that reason, left unwatched; and by the time word of soldiers on the ridge reached the chapel room where the council sat, the thing that wanted deciding had already, in the plainest sense, been decided for them.

Tom fired the shafts himself. He would not let Angus's cousin do it, though the man offered, twice, and Tom found afterward that he could not entirely say why he had refused the offer beyond a feeling, not fully reasoned, that a thing built by one pair of hands ought if it must be unbuilt to be unbuilt by the same pair and no other. He went down the first shaft alone in the grey hour with the powder already laid and the fuse cut to the length he had reckoned the night before, and stood at the shaft-head afterward with the second fuse in his hand and the sound of the first charge still working its way up through the rock underfoot, a sound less like an explosion than like a very large door being shut a long way off, and thought, watching the smoke come up thin and grey against the greyer sky, that he had heard that same sound described to him as a boy, by the man who first showed him a seam of coal by candlelight, as the sound a hill makes when it decides a thing is finished.

The second charge went the same way. By the time both shafts were sealed, timber and rubble packed down hard enough that no summer's digging would open them again without more men than the regiments below had any reason to spend on a played-out western seam, the soldiers were already coming through the town's one street, and Tom stood at his own shaft-head with the smoke still drifting and watched them come without any clear notion in his own mind of what he meant to do next, until Angus's cousin took his arm, not roughly, and said that a man who had just spent his morning burying his own coal had done the day's work the hills would remember him for, and that the rest of the day's work, whatever it turned out to be, could be done walking.

Mary Kessock was not among those who went up into the hills that morning. Tom saw her, in the last moments before he and the others took the rabbit path,

standing at her own door with a shawl about her shoulders and a look on her face that he read, at the time and again many times after, as a woman who had already made her own reckoning of the two ends she had named three weeks before and chosen, for herself and no one else, the first of them, being too old by her own account to walk a hill country she had not walked in forty years and unwilling to be the weight that slowed six younger men's going. She raised a hand to him as he passed, not a wave so much as an acknowledging of him, one person to another, and he raised his own hand back, and that was the whole of the parting between them, no more words spent on it than the moment could properly hold.

An Clàr Foscailte, when it came to be written, gave the number of Cnoc thais's holdouts taken that morning as forty-one, a figure Sileas nic Rath's clerks drew from the regiment's own muster of prisoners marched down to the low country in the days that followed, and it gave no figure at all, then or ever, for how many of the town's people had not been taken because they were, by the time the regiment reached the chapel room, already some hours gone up into the hills behind the town by paths the shepherd who had shown the soldiers one path had not, in the end, shown them all. Tom was among those not taken. He left the town by a path he had walked as a boy after rabbits and had not walked since, with Angus's cousin beside him and, within the first mile, four more of the town's own hewers who had judged, watching the soldiers come up the street, that a man taken at Cnoc thais that morning was a man who would not see his own hill again for a good while, if at all, and had chosen, each in his own time and by his own reckoning, to take the path instead.

III

Of Those Who Went On

They did not stop in the near hills, where a dozen other small parties out of Cnoc thais and the last of Muileann àrsaidh's own scattered folk had by then made a kind of ragged half-camp among the shielings the summer herding used and abandoned every autumn regardless of any war. Tom had thought, the first night out, that the near hills would do, that a man could sit quiet enough among the shielings through the worst of the weather and wait to

1. the open record of the war years

see what the peace, whenever it came, would leave standing for him to go back to. It was Angus's cousin, of all of them, who said otherwise, on the second night, with the six of them crowded round a fire small enough that its smoke would not carry far and a sky above them clearing, for once, to more stars than any of them had troubled to look at in a year.

"They'll not let the near hills be," he said. "This year or next, it makes no matter. They'll come up after the shielings same as they came up after the town, once some clerk in the low country works out there's men here still breathing that the muster roll never caught." He had no more certain a reason for the saying of it than any other man's guess that autumn, and he offered none, but the six of them sat with it a while in the firelight, turning it this way and that the way men turn a coin they cannot yet decide is counterfeit, and found, each in his own private accounting, that none of them could put forward a better guess to set against it.

Tom said little that night himself, though he had thought, before Angus's cousin spoke, that he might argue for the shielings after all, on the plain ground that a man's legs tire and a winter in open country asks a great deal of legs that had spent a life underground and not on a hillside. He did not argue it. He found, turning his own reasons over by the fire, that he trusted the other man's guess more than his own wish, and a guess trusted over a wish was, he had learned that year if he had learned nothing else, the surer thing to build a winter's walking on.

So they went on, past the near hills and the shielings and the last of the drove paths any Cnoc thais man had a name for, into ground that the town's own oldest hewers spoke of only at second or third hand, a country of low scrub and standing water and, at last, a wind that Tom found did not properly stop from the day they first felt it on their faces to the day, weeks later, that he stood at the edge of the sea and understood why every teller who had ever spoken of that coast to him as a boy had called it, without needing to say more, an *Oirthir Ghaothach*¹.

The walking took the better part of three weeks, by Tom's own count of nights slept under whatever cover the ground offered, and it was not, he found, a country that made the walking easy for the reward of its emptiness. The scrub tore at boots already worn thin from a summer's siege-work, and the standing water, brown and cold and often deeper than a man's first step into it judged it to be, cost them one bad night when Angus's cousin went in to the knee in what had looked, in the failing light, no more than a puddle, and came out with a chill that

1. the windy coast

kept him shivering by the fire two days running before it passed. They ate what the country gave them and what little they had carried, birds taken with a sling two of the party had thought to bring, and once, memorably enough that it was spoken of round the fire for a week after, a hind that one of the Àth naomh men, met on the path by then and fallen in with them, brought down with a single cast of a spear he had carried the whole way from his own dissolved town for no better reason, he said, than that a man walking into country he did not know felt easier walking into it armed with anything at all, even a spear no soldier on either side of the war would have troubled to call a weapon.

They crossed one another's paths with the other six parties by a kind of slow accretion rather than any single meeting, a fire seen at a distance one evening and approached cautiously by both sides until a shout in Dia-thìris settled what a shout in no tongue at all might not have, two families falling in together for a day's walk and then parting again toward different stretches of coast, word of a third party carried forward by whichever traveller had last spoken with them. Tom found, doing this slow arithmetic of meetings as the weeks went on, that he had come to know the shape of the whole scattered company, seven parties and something short of two hundred souls, before he had ever stood in the same place as more than a dozen of them at once, a kind of knowing at second hand that put him in mind, more than once, of Ellen Marsh's books of Tuathaich accounts, gathered the same slow way from people who had not set out meaning to be gathered into anything at all.

They were seven parties in all by the time word of one another reached them on that ground, seven separate handfuls out of Cnoc thais and the last stragglers of Muileann àrsaidh and, it was said though Tom never met the man himself, one small party out of Àth naomh that had come the longest way round of any of them, and between the seven parties they made, by nobody's exact count, somewhat short of two hundred souls sitting on ground that belonged, by any charter the low country kept, to nobody at all. The regiments followed them as far as a boundary stone at the edge of what the old province rolls called the shire of Seann Vell, a stone none of the seven parties had known was there until a patrol's officer, come up to within shouting distance of it one grey morning, called across that he was under orders to go no farther, the ground beyond being outside any shire

Comhairle nam Mèinnean²'s writ ran in, and that his own commander wanted no part of a war fought on ground his own maps did not properly own.

It was that same officer's report, copied afterward into An Clàr Foscailte³ and from there, in time, into every account the low country ever kept of that autumn, that gave the seven parties the name they carried thereafter in every paper that troubled to name them at all: Muinntir gun Siorrachd⁴, a phrase the officer had reached for, Tom thought later, hearing it repeated back to him by a trader who had heard it from a soldier who had heard it from the officer himself, because a man writing a report wants a name for the thing he is reporting, and the ground those seven parties sat on had, in the plainest sense the officer's own maps could give him, no name of its own to lend them. The phrase said nothing of Cnoc thais and nothing of the western hills either, and Tom, hearing it named back to him for the first time by a stranger's mouth at a stranger's fire, felt the particular smallness of a man who learns that the ground he stands on has been written down by somebody who has never stood on it at all.

IV

Of the Fleet Sent South and the Boats That Burned

What word reached an Oirthir Ghaothach¹ of the rest of that autumn's business came slowly, and came sideways, carried by traders who came up the coast path from the south with salt and needles and, now and again, a barrel of dubhan oil to sell to fisherfolk who had burned fish-oil in their own lamps since before any of the seven parties' grandfathers were born, and who took, in exchange for their goods, whatever news the traders judged worth the telling. The fisherfolk themselves took the seven parties in without much asking, in ones and twos and small households, the way Tom had heard the north coast generally took in whoever a hard season washed up on it, and he and Angus's cousin and the others of the Cnoc thais six came, before the month was out, to a widower named Calum Odhar who fished a two-man boat out of a cove Tom never did learn a proper name for, and who gave them the byre behind his own

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

3. the open record of the war years

4. those of no shire, the open record's name for the foes of the Long War

1. the windy coast

house to sleep in and asked, in the whole of the first fortnight, exactly one question of them, which was whether either could mend a net, and neither being much use with a net, set them instead to hauling driftwood for the winter's fires and troubled them with nothing further.

It was one such trader, a woman named Cairstine who walked the coast path twice a year and had done so, by her own account, since before the war had a name, who first told Tom and the others, sitting over a fire in Calum Odhar's own byre with the wind working at the thatch above them, that the fleets in the south had been thinned to keep the north-west shut, and that the raiders of the eastern water, who had troubled nobody in living memory while the fleets stood full, had come out from their own islets that same autumn and found the southern water emptier than it had been in a generation. She told it plainly, the way Tom came to understand was her whole manner of telling anything, sitting cross-legged on a creel with her pack still on her back because she meant, she said, to be gone again before the tide turned, and she took a long pull from the cup Calum Odhar's own daughter set by her before she went on, as though the telling were thirsty work and wanted wetting partway through.

An dàrna cabhlach², Cairstine said, had been raised that same season at the southern Seann Skell, out of the harbour towns and Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail³'s own boatmen, to hold the eastern and southern water while A' chiad chabhlach⁴ and the fourth kept the north-west shut against nothing that anyone on an Oirthir Ghaothach could rightly say deserved the shutting; and the raising of it had not been quick enough, or not full enough, or simply not lucky enough, to keep two salt-boats out of Àth bheag from being taken clean out of the water one grey morning and a third burned to the waterline within sight of its own harbour mouth, the crew of the burned boat put ashore, some days after, at the light of Baile ìseal, more by luck than by any rescue An dàrna cabhlach could rightly claim credit for. The fleet did run one of the raiders down in the end, off that same light, a fortnight or more after the burning, and brought her in with what was left of her crew for Cùirt na Mara⁵ to deal with in its own time and its own way; but Cairstine, telling it, gave the running-down less weight in the telling than the burning that came before it, in the way a teller weighs a thing by what it cost

2. the second fleet

3. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

4. the first fleet

5. the court of the sea at Ros dhomhain

rather than by how it ended, and Tom, hearing it, found himself thinking less of the raiders or the fleet than of a woman he had never met, put ashore at a light he had seen only from a boat's deck once as a boy, with nothing left of her own boat to show for a season's work but the clothes she stood up in.

He asked Cairstine, when she had done with the telling, whether the fleet's thinning and the raiders' coming were spoken of, in the low country, as one thing or two, and she said she could not properly answer that, not being a woman the low country's own clerks troubled to ask; but she said that a fisherman of Baile ìseal, from whom she had the tale in the first place, had put it to her plainly enough over a cup at his own hearth, that a kingdom which sent its ships to shut a door on nothing much would some day find another door, one it had not thought to watch, standing open behind it, and that this was not, in his own telling of it, a new thing under any sky, only a thing kingdoms went on forgetting each in their own turn.

Calum Odhar, who had sat through the whole of Cairstine's telling without a word, said only, once she had gone on her way north the next morning with her pack lighter of goods and heavier, he judged, of nothing at all, that a man who fished a two-man boat out of a cove with no name learned early not to trouble himself over which of a kingdom's doors stood open or shut, since the sea took no more notice of a kingdom's doors than it took of a kingdom's charters, and a fisherman's whole trade was learning to read the one door the sea kept, which no fleet anywhere had ever yet managed to shut for a single season together. Tom thought that a fair answer, turning it over afterward, and thought too that it was the kind of answer a man could only give who had never had a shaft of his own to fire, or a book of names taken down at a trestle table that he could not stop, some nights, from counting over in his head.

V

Of the Edge of the Sea

Tom kept, through that autumn and into the first hard weather of an Dàm-hair, a private reckoning of his own, not written down anywhere, since there was no paper on an Oirthir Ghaothach¹ that any of the seven parties

1. the windy coast

troubled to carry and no ledger a man could rule columns in even had he carried one, but held instead the way a man holds a tally he means to keep straight in his own head against the day somebody asks him for it. He counted, that autumn, the men who had come out of Cnoc thais with him and were still, by his own eye, breathing and whole; he counted, separately, the ones the regiment had taken at the town and marched south, whose names he knew and whose faces he could still call up plainly enough by firelight; and he counted, last and longest, a column that had nothing to do with Cnoc thais at all, a woman's book of names taken down at a trestle table two seasons before, and a field left unploughed below Àth leathan that he had stood at the edge of once, at a sentry's leave, and looked at a long while without finding an answer his own eyes could bring back with him.

He did not find, that autumn, any word of Ruth Calder on an Oirthir Ghaothach, nor any reason to think a word of her would ever reach so far a shore, and he had by then stopped expecting one in any place he came to, the way a man stops expecting rain in a season that has already, by every sign the sky gives, gone dry for good. Angus's cousin asked him once, mending a net neither of them was much use at, whether he still meant to send word north to the hill farms the way he had that first fortnight at Muileann àrsaidh, boy to shepherd to farmhouse, and Tom said he did not, this coast having no chain of boys and shepherds a message could travel by, and no farmhouse within it that had ever heard Ruth Calder's name to begin with; and having said it aloud he found it settled a weight in him that had ridden there unspoken the length of the walking, not so much an ending as a putting-down of it he had carried the length of the walking without once setting it aside to rest his arms.

What he found instead, in the last clear evening before the weather turned for good, was the sea, and he stood at the edge of it on a strand of black shingle with the wind coming off the water hard enough to take a man's breath if he stood square into it, and the light going down grey into grey without any proper sunset to mark the day's end, the way the low country's own evenings marked it with colour and this coast, by every account the seven parties had of it, never troubled to. Calum Odhar had told him, the week before, that an Oirthir Ghaothach kept no calendar of feast days the way the low country did, the weather here being too much its own master to be told when a season was meant to turn, and that the fisherfolk marked their year instead by the boats that went out and the boats that came back, a reckoning Tom found, turning it over, not so very different from a

hewer's own way of marking a year by the coal that came up and the coal that did not.

He stood there a while, with Angus's cousin some way off along the shingle doing the same thing in his own silence, and thought, watching the water come in flat and grey and endless, of a burn in spate below a pit-head, brown and quick with snow-melt, going on the same before, during and after a battle as if it had somewhere better to be than any of the men fighting beside it; and he thought that the sea before him now was the same water, in the end, only grown too large for any man to hear it the way he had heard that burn, and that a man could stand at its edge his whole life and never once persuade it to answer a question he had not thought to ask it plainly. The wind did not let up. It had not let up, by his own reckoning, since the day the seven parties first felt it on the far side of the near hills, and Tom Varley, watching the light go out of a grey sky over a grey sea on ground that belonged, by any charter the low country kept, to nobody at all, found he had stopped expecting it to.

Of the Ships Round the North

DE 21

I

Of the Regiments Called Again

The rolls that had lain in the council's chests since An Dealachadh¹, brought out once already that autumn to arm the regiments that went west to Muileann àrsaidh and Cnoc thais, were not yet put away when the second half of them was wanted, and by the middle of an Dàmhair the calling went on across the whole island rather than the west alone, so that a man might now be summoned to a war he had thought, until the summons found him, a quarrel of the pit towns and no business of his own province at all.

The sixth was raised first, at Cnoc bheag, the great river port of Òrd an t-Seabhaig² in the north-central country, on the seventeenth of the month, and of all the regiments called that autumn it alone had its colours blessed before it marched, Òrd an t-Seabhaig keeping still, in that one town, the custom that had gone out of fashion at the capital three reigns before. The priest who blessed them was an old man, by every account that reached an Leabharlann³ afterwards, and he blessed the cloth and not the men who would carry it, saying, as the custom asks, that Mòd's hunger fed on what marched under an unblessed flag sooner than on what marched under a blessed one, which the regiment's own clerk wrote down as said and did not trouble to explain further, it being no part of a clerk's

1. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

2. the Hawk order

3. the Library at Muileann chaol

office to explain a priest to a reader who had not been there to hear him. The colours, when they went north-west a week later to hold the road between the Tuathaich shires and the middle of the island, were new cloth on an old staff, one that had stood in Òrd an t-Seabhaig house's own keeping since a war none of the men now carrying it could have named. The blessing was done at first light on the quay steps, the cloth laid across the priest's own two hands and the whole regiment drawn up in three sides of a square about him with the river fog still lying on the water behind, and the townsfolk who had turned out to watch it, being a river port and used to the sight of soldiery coming and going on Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁴'s business, stood a good deal quieter than Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own returns of the day thought worth remarking, as men and women commonly do at the start of a thing whose end they have no way yet of guessing.

The regiment's own clerk, a careful young man new to the office, wrote in his first report that the ceremony had taken the better part of an hour on account of the tide, the colours needing to be blessed and the boats loaded on the same ebb, and that the priest had shown no sign of hurrying it for the tide's sake or anybody else's, which the clerk set down without complaint, having been told by his own captain, before ever they reached Cnoc bheag, that a blessing rushed for the convenience of a schedule was a blessing better not asked for at all.

Eight days after that the second was raised at Àth dhìreach, in the east, and set to guard Slighe a' Ghuail⁵ and the library road together, the two roads running so near each other along that stretch that one company could watch both without doubling its marches. It was the first soldiery the town of Muileann chaol had seen in any living memory, and Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh, who had kept Eachdraidh na Rìoghachd⁶ for five-and-twenty years before she laid the office down and asked nothing of her retirement but her sister's house at Àth dhìreach, watched the camp go up from the garden wall with the particular attention of a woman who had spent a working lifetime writing down what other people did and had never once, until that autumn, had it done under her own window.

She wrote to Sileas nic Rath, her old clerk and the chronicler now in her place, a letter that said less than a letter from Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh might have been expected to say, on the reasoning, she told Sileas plainly, that the office was no longer hers to fill with her own judgements, only her own eyes, which the office

4. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

5. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

6. the royal chronicle of the restored kingdom

had never asked to be idle even when the pen that once served them had been laid aside. The camp was orderly, she wrote; the tents stood in rows a surveyor might have set out; the company's captain, a young man not long out of Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own service, had called on her within the first week to ask, civilly enough, whether her garden wall marked ground he needed for a picket line, and had accepted her answer, which was that it did not, without argument. She wrote that the town had given the company no trouble and the company had given the town none, and that this, in a year when other towns nearer the fighting could say no such thing, seemed to her worth the setting down, whatever anyone at an Le-abharlann chose to make of it.

She added, at the foot of the second page, a line she struck through once and then let stand, the ink of the strike-through thin enough that Sileas read the words under it without difficulty: that she had spent five-and-twenty years writing down what a kingdom did in its own name, and had come, in the six months since she laid the pen aside, to find she trusted her own eyes on a garden wall rather better than she had ever quite let herself trust the reports that used to reach her desk from towns she had never once had occasion to stand in. Sileas kept the letter among her own papers, and it is one of the few private hands of that autumn that anyone kept by nobody's order but its writer's own habit of writing things down.

Away in the north-east, at Caol bheag, the fourth was raised on the second of an t-Samhain, and of the four companies mustered that season it was the fourth's road that ran longest and strangest before it ever came within sight of a field it might have to hold.

II

Of the Voyage Round the North

Dùghall mac Iain was twenty-three that autumn and had been three years a soldier without, until the muster bell rang at Caol bheag on the last day of an Dàmhair, ever once expecting to be one anywhere but at home. He was a corporal because a sergeant who had known his father thought him steady, and steady he had been, in the way of a young man who has never yet been asked to prove it: he kept his kit in order, said little in the mess that he had not first turned over twice in his own head, and had, before that autumn, gone no farther

from Caol bheag in the whole of his soldiering than the shire's own boundary stone, twelve miles out on the Ros chiar road, where the company sometimes marched of a summer to keep its legs in practice and its officers' reports supplied with something to report.

The order that came down named the fourth for the north-west, without saying at first how a company was to reach a coast that no road on the island ran the whole way to, and it was two days before the answer came down after it: they were to go by water, down the Abhainn ghorm to Ros chiar, and from Ros chiar round the north coast in whatever hulls Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹ could hire on short notice, there being no fleet of An Crùn's own idle enough that season to spare for the carrying of one regiment when four others wanted moving besides.

They marched down to the river on a grey morning with the frost still on the grass verge and the town's whole population turned out along the road to see them go, which Dùghall found harder to bear than he had looked for, the cheering of people he had known his whole life being a different thing entirely from the cheering he had imagined, in the idle way a young soldier imagines such scenes before he is given one, of a crowd that did not know him and so could cheer him without also, in the same breath, wondering aloud to each other whether he would come home. His own mother stood at the corner by the mill with her shawl pulled tight and said nothing at all as he passed, which he understood, without either of them needing to say it, as the greater kindness.

The barges that carried them down the Abhainn ghorm were coal barges once, by the look of the tar still black in their seams, refitted since with plank benches down both sides and not much else, and the river ran high and quick with the autumn rain so that the two days' journey the maps had promised was done in a day and a half, the barge-men steering more than rowing, and Dùghall, who had never in his life been afloat on anything larger than a fishing coble, spent the better part of that first day learning the particular misery of a barge deck in a following current, which pitches a man's stomach in ways no cart on a rutted road had ever taught him to expect.

The men of his own file passed that first day poorly, the way soldiers pass any day with nothing asked of them but to sit still and be carried, in fits of talk that ran out and started again over nothing much: a game with pebbles and a chalked board one of them carried folded in his kit for exactly such an idleness, an argu-

1. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

2. the Crown

ment over whose home town brewed the better ale that neither side had any way of settling on a barge deck and so carried on for the better part of an hour regardless, and, once the light began to go, a song two of the older men knew between them and the rest picked up by the second verse, a harvest song their own mothers might have sung, which struck Dùghall, listening to it carry out flat over the water in the dusk, as a strange thing for men bound to a war to be singing, and a right one all the same.

His own corporal's charge, a file of nine, was young for the most part, three of them not yet twenty and none, Dùghall among them, ever before asked to do more soldiering than a summer's drill and the keeping of a quiet road. He found himself, without quite choosing it, the file's steadiest hand by simple virtue of being the one among them who had worn the corporal's own mark longest, a matter of eight months and no more, and spent a good part of that first night's watch answering questions from the youngest of them, a lad named for his own father and called by nobody the whole voyage but that same father's name, about what a battle was likely to be like, questions Dùghall had no truer answer to than the lad had himself, and answered anyway, as steadily as he could make his voice go, because a corporal who let his own voice shake in the dark was no use to a file with nothing else that night to hold steady by.

Ros chiar, when they came to it, was a walled town smaller than Caol bheag and built entirely, so far as Dùghall could see from the barge, around the business of getting things onto and off ships, its whole waterfront one long clutter of hoists and rope-walks and sheds smelling of tar and salt fish, and it was there, tied up three deep along the outer quay, that he had his first sight of the hulls that were to carry the regiment the rest of the way: squat, broad-beamed vessels with tanks built into their holds where cargo should have gone, hired, the quartermaster said, from whatever shipmaster on that coast owned a hull already fitted to carry dubhan and was willing, for Comhairle nam Mèinnean's money, to carry men instead for one voyage.

Comhairle nam Mèinnean's money was good money, and the shipmasters who took it asked no questions Dùghall's officers troubled to answer, but the men who crewed the hulls asked plenty among themselves, in the hearing of soldiers standing at the rail with nothing else to do but hear them, and Dùghall learned in this way, before any officer told him so directly, that they were going round the north cape and down the far side to a coast the fourth's own quartermaster had needed a chart to find, a coast whose towns the crew named as easily as Dùghall

could have named the streets of Caol bheag, and spoke of, he noticed, in the plain flat voice of men speaking of somewhere they had traded in for years and expected no trouble in trading in again, whatever cargo they carried this particular voyage.

They put out from Ros chiar on the fourth of an t-Samhain into a sea already turning, the shipmasters said without much comfort in the saying, and it was a hard passage by any account Dùghall heard given afterwards, five days round the north cape in hulls built for dubhan and not for men, the tanks below decks giving off a smell that got into a man's kit and did not come out of it again for weeks, and the north cape, when they rounded it on the second night, showed Dùghall a sea he had not known the island's own coast could make: grey water running in ridges taller than the barge that had carried him down the river, and beyond it, for the better part of a watch, nothing at all to be seen in any direction but that same grey water going on to a horizon a man could not find the edge of. He was sick over the rail twice that night, along with the better part of his own file, and heard, above the wind, one of the older soldiers laughing at nothing in particular in a way Dùghall came in time to understand: a man keeping his own voice going so as not to have to listen too closely to the sea.

They lost no man on that passage, though a boy of the second company went overboard reaching for a line that had come loose and was hauled back in half-drowned and shaking, and one hull, separated from the others in the worst of the second night's weather, put into a cove on the far side of the cape and lost two days finding the others again, arriving at Ceann mhòr three days behind the rest with its whole crew and cargo safe but its captain, by every account, considerably older in the face than he had been when he set out.

III

Of Ceann mhòr

Ceann mhòr stood at the head of a long inlet on the Tuathaich coast, a port town of some size by the standard of that country, its grey stone houses climbing the slope above the harbour in the close-built rows Dùghall had already learned, from what the older men of the company said of Tuathaich towns, to expect of that people's building, and its church, the largest structure the town owned, standing above the harbour where a Dia-thìrich town would have set its temple, which struck Dùghall, seeing it for the first time from the deck of

the hull that carried him in, as a small and useless thing to notice and one he found himself noticing anyway.

The regiment was quartered on the tenth of an t-Samhain in the old human magistrate's house, a low, thick-walled building above the quay that the town's own maor, a Dia-thìrich man of An Crùn's appointing named for that office alone, had kept as his own residence since the shires were first drawn, on the reasoning, handed down with the office itself, that a house built by the humans to hold the humans' law was as good a house as any to hold An Crùn's, and better than most, being stone through and cheap to warm. The maor gave up the greater part of it without complaint that Dùghall's own captain reported hearing, and moved his own household into the two upper rooms the regiment had no use for, and it was noticed by more than one man of the fourth, in the way soldiers notice such things without being told to, that the maor's clerk, a Tuathaich woman who had served the office for years under three maor running, addressed the captain in Dia-thìris without once stumbling over it and addressed her own townsfolk, when they came to the house on the office's business, in the humans' tongue exclusively, as though the two languages belonged, in her own ordering of the world, to two entirely different kinds of transaction and were not to be let mix.

The house, once four hundred men had been fitted into what had held one household and its servants, kept a smell about it for the whole of that winter that Dùghall came to think of as the particular smell of soldiery indoors, wet wool and boot-blackening and the tallow of too many lamps burning too long into too short a day, laid over whatever the magistrates who had built the place had meant it to smell of, and the maor himself, a heavy, unhurried man who had held the office since before Dùghall was born, took to walking the two upper rooms' own narrow gallery of an evening with his pipe, looking down into the courtyard at the drill his house had been given over to, and saying, to whichever officer happened to be crossing below him, some version of the same dry observation: that he had held this house forty years against damp, and the army had done in a fortnight what forty winters of the sea air had not managed, which the captain, by the third or fourth telling of it, had learned to answer only with a nod, there being no answer to a landlord's joke that does not also concede the landlord's point.

Tional nan Tuathach²'s protest reached the house within the fortnight, carried up from Caol mhòr by whatever carrier still worked that coast road in the season's

1. the Crown

2. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

worsening weather, a single sheet in Martha Greaves's own hand asking, in terms Dùghall's captain read aloud to the assembled company on the theory that men quartered somewhere ought to know what was being said of the quartering, that An ceathramh rèisimeid³ be lodged at its own charge and not the town's, the town having neither asked for soldiers nor been offered the choosing of them. It was received, the captain's own note back to Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁴ said, and forwarded, and there the matter rested, as such matters generally did, Comhairle nam Mèinnean's reply, when it came near the year's end, saying only that the arrangement stood until the campaign's needs changed it, which answered the letter's words without answering anything the letter had actually been written to ask.

It was in those same weeks, though a good way farther west along that same coast, that the fleets off Cathair gheal took up the searching of the fishing boats that put out from that harbour every morning the weather allowed it, a measure Comhairle nam Mèinnean's order named necessary against the carrying of arms or men under a full boat's catch, and one the fishermen of that town, within a month of its starting, had put into a petition of their own, carried to Tional nan Tuathach by a delegation of six, and by Tional nan Tuathach on to the council with no more comment attached than the plain fact of its having been forwarded. The searching went on the same as before the petition and the same as after it, a boat held at its own quay of a morning for the better part of an hour while two of the fleet's own men went through its nets and its fish-hold both, and it was said afterwards, by the fishermen themselves and by nobody troubled to deny it, that not one weapon and not one man beyond the boat's own crew was ever found in the whole course of that searching, which Comhairle nam Mèinnean's returns record without remark and without, so far as the record shows, any change of order following from it.

The petition, when it came to be written, was drawn up at a meeting held on the quay, in the cold, before the boats went out one morning, the six men chosen to carry it agreeing between them on no more than the plainest facts a petition could safely carry: the number of days the searching had run, the number of hours a boat was commonly held, and the plain observation, set down without complaint attached to it because none of the six judged a complaint likely to travel any further than the facts alone, that a fish left too long in a held net spoiled be-

3. the fourth regiment

4. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

fore it ever reached a buyer, spoiled fish being spoiled fish whichever tongue the boat's crew happened to curse it in. It went to Caol mhòr folded inside a barrel of salt cod consigned, quite genuinely, to Tional nan Tuathach's own stores, on the reasoning of the man who carried it that a petition riding inside an honest cargo drew less notice at the searching than a petition riding in a man's coat.

Dùghall heard of it third-hand, from a corporal of An dàrna cabhlach⁵ billeted for a night at Ceann mhòr on his way to somewhere else, who told it as a piece of dry entertainment over the two men's shared supper and nothing graver than that, a fish barrel and a folded letter being, to a man who had spent that autumn searching nets for muskets and finding none, the sort of story a soldier keeps by him for its comedy rather than its weight. Dùghall laughed with him at it that night, and thought little more of it at the time beyond the ordinary soldier's thought that another man's orders were another man's trouble and not his own, a thought he had occasion, before that winter was out, to think a good deal less easily than he thought it that first night.

Farther east again, on the sixteenth of the month, the eighth was raised at Inis uaine on the Abhainn chaol, to stand guard over the dubhan depots of the eastern ports against a burning the council feared more than it ever quite said aloud it feared, the holdouts having, by every report that reached the capital, neither the means nor, so far as anyone could show, the least intention of firing a depot the width of the island from any field they had yet fought on, which did not stop the eighth from being raised and posted regardless, on the reasoning, as sound in its own way as the reasoning behind the searching of Cathair gheal's nets, that a fear a council could not quite prove groundless was a fear it generally chose to arm against rather than argue with.

IV

Of the Widow's House

The billeting of the company's men among the town's own houses, once the magistrate's house was full past any further stretching, was done by the maor's clerk from a list of the town's rooms to spare, a list she kept, Dùghall came to understand, with the same flat and even hand she gave to every

5. the second fleet

other business of that office, naming which house had a room over its byre or a loft above its kitchen and how many a household could be asked to take without more hardship than the office judged fair to ask of it. Dùghall's own name came down against a house two streets back from the harbour, kept by a widow named Barbara Keir who had a loom set up in the room behind her kitchen and worked it, he came to learn, most of the daylight hours a fishing town's own work left her free for.

She opened the door to him the first evening with no more welcome in her face than the clerk's list had shown in its own writing, looked him over the way a woman looks over a stranger she has been told to house and not asked whether she wanted housed, and showed him the room she had made ready without a word in either tongue, only a hand toward the stair and, once he had climbed it and set down his kit, a plate of bread and salt fish left at the stair's foot without his hearing her come up to bring it. It was, he thought that first night, no worse a billet than a soldier had any right to expect in a town that had not asked for him, and he was three years too well trained in the plainer disciplines of soldiering to expect a hostess's warmth on top of a dry roof and a full plate, and told himself so, and slept.

She answered him readily enough in *Dia-thiris*, he found within the first week, a civil word for a civil word, the accounts of the billeting-due settled between them without friction on either side, and it was only some evenings later, meaning no more by it than the ordinary courtesy a guest owes a house not his own, that he tried the few words of the humans' tongue he had picked up from men of his own company with kin among the *Tuathaich*, and got, for his trouble, nothing at all: not so much as a shake of the head, only the same flat and even look she had given him at the door that first evening, as though he had not spoken. He heard her, within the same week, across the yard wall, giving that same tongue easily enough to a neighbour who had called something over about the weather, quick and unhesitating and without the smallest trip in it, so that he came to understand, before he ever properly asked himself why, that the withholding lay in whose ear the words were meant for, and nowhere in her own mouth.

He tried it again, once or twice, in the weeks that followed, telling himself each time that a man ought to be let learn the tongue of a house he ate bread in, and got, each time, the same flat civility that was not quite unkindness and was not, either, anything he could rightly call an answer, until he came, by the third or fourth trying, to understand it for what it was: a door she had shut on him alone,

and kept open, plainly and without apparent effort, to every other soul in the town who was not wearing the regiment's own coat.

Why, he did not ask her. The question he turned over instead, those first weeks at Ceann mhòr, the way he turned over most things he had not been given orders about, slowly and without arriving anywhere he was satisfied to call an answer, got him only as far, most nights, as the plain fact that a woman who gave a soldier her own kingdom's own tongue for the plain business of bread and billeting-dues, and would not give him her own people's, had drawn a line somewhere in her own reckoning that was hers to draw and none of his to cross uninvited, whatever the drawing of it cost either of them. He went on eating her bread and sleeping under her roof through the weeks the billeting list kept them so, and she went on answering him in *Dia-thìris* exactly as far as the house's own business asked and no further, keeping the humans' tongue for the yard wall and the neighbour's voice and every ear in Ceann mhòr but his, and neither of them, in all that time, ever once said to the other what either of them understood the silence to mean.

OF the Dark Town

DE 21

I

Of the Third Fleet

An treas cabhlach was raised at Baile ghorm on the south-west coast on 1 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21, out of a fishing town that had never, so far as anyone at Ceann mhòr could say, raised so much as a harbour-watch before that winter, and Dùghall mac Iain saw the first of its hulls a week later, from the quay at Ceann mhòr, where she came in round the point on a grey forenoon riding low and black in the water with the dubhan sloshing audibly in her belly whenever the swell took her. She had no name on her bow. A clerk of the fleet had chalked *Trì* there, for the fleet's number, for want of any properer name yet given her, and the chalk had half run in the spray of the passage.

She had come the whole length of the west coast in four days, up from Baile ghorm past the capes and the closed water off the western Seann Skell, carrying the army's dubhan to the regiments in the hills and on the northern coast, and nothing else. That was the whole of An treas cabhlach's business, her master said, a man named Griogair who had fished the south-west waters forty years before the fleet ever thought to want him: to carry fuel north, since a regiment that could not light its own lamps or run its own lorries was no regiment at all, whatever guns it carried. Dùghall was on the quay with a file to see the barrels ashore, and Griogair, who had little enough to do once his hull was made fast, stood with him at the tank-cock through the better part of the unloading and talked, when he

1. the third fleet

talked at all, in the manner of a man laying down one plain fact at a time and leaving the hearer to make of it what he would.

It was Griogair who told him that the fleet's hulls were fitted, every one, with the same tanks a lorry carried, only built larger and set low in the belly for the ballast the fuel's own weight gave her, so that a hull running full rode lower and steadier than one running light, and a crew learned within a season to judge a fair-weather passage by nothing more than how much dubhan she still had aboard. He told him too, without being asked, that he had buried two brothers and a father to that sea in the ordinary course of a fishing life, and that a war which asked him only to carry fuel rather than to fight was, by his own reckoning, the easiest service any kingdom had yet asked of him, whatever else might be said of it. Dùghall thought, hearing it, of the coal engines laid up in the Muileann chrom siding that he had heard tell of from a driver's son in his own company, and of how strange it was that a war fought in the hills should turn, in the end, on fishing boats fitted with tanks. He found he had no answer ready for Griogair, and gave none, and Griogair did not seem to want one.

The town was little changed since the regiment had landed: the fourth still quartered in the old human magistrate's house on the rise above the water, Tional nan Tuathach²'s protest against that quartering still, so far as Dùghall could learn, sitting wherever the council kept protests it did not mean to answer, and the widow he was billeted on, a Tuathaich woman named Barbara Keir who kept a loom in the room behind her kitchen, still answering him in Dia-thìris when he spoke to her in it and in nothing at all when he tried, of an evening, the few words of the humans' tongue he had picked up from men in his own company, though he had heard her, more than once, speaking that same tongue easily enough to her own neighbours across the yard wall.

II

Of Barbara's House

Barbara's house stood two streets back from the harbour, a low stone building with the loom-room built on at the back in a later age than the rest of it, by the look of the joists, and Dùghall had been billeted on her since the

2. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

regiment first came to Ceann mhòr, an arrangement neither of them had asked for and neither, so far as he could tell, much liked, though both had settled by then into the kind of wary household truce that two people keep who share a roof without ever agreeing to share anything else. She fed him at the same table she fed herself, plain fare and not much talk over it, and took the billeting-due the regiment's quartermaster paid her without comment, the way Dùghall supposed she took a good many things that autumn without comment, having no clear way of refusing any of them.

He had tried, early on, to make some small conversation of an evening in what little of the humans' tongue he had picked up, thinking it might ease the two of them into something more than a silent table, and had found each attempt met with the same flat courtesy: a nod, perhaps, or a word in Dia-thìris that answered the sense of what he had asked without troubling to answer it in the tongue he had asked it in, so that he came, after the third or fourth such evening, to let the matter drop rather than go on pressing a door she had made plain enough, in her own quiet way, she did not mean to open to him. He had heard her, once, through the wall between the kitchen and the loom-room, singing some low tune to herself at her shuttle in that same tongue she would not use to him directly, and had stood a moment in the passage listening before he thought better of it and went on to his own room, feeling, without quite being able to say why, that he had come near to overhearing something he had no right to.

III

Of the File to Baile chrom

In an Dùbhlachd, with the days grown so short that the regiment's patrols went out and came back by lamplight both, Dùghall was given a file of six men and an order to go north along the coast road as far as Baile chrom, a bent little town on the far headland that the regiment's own maps marked only as the seat of a shire and the site of one of the five lighthouses, and that no patrol of the fourth had yet troubled to visit in the two months since the regiment had come to Ceann mhòr. The order named no particular business at Baile chrom beyond the general one every patrol that autumn carried, which was to search whatever ground it covered for arms, for men of the western hills who might have come so far north, and for anything else a report could usefully call *nothing found*,

since nothing found was, by then, the commonest single line in every regimental return Dùghall had ever been made to copy fair.

He chose his six men the evening before from among those of his own company least likely to make trouble of a night's search, and found himself, going down the roll in his own head, settling more than once on men from the river towns rather than the coast ones, on no better ground than a private feeling that a river man would carry himself quieter in a stranger's house than a man used to the rough manners of a fishing harbour, a feeling he did not trouble to examine any further than that, since the order asked him only to bring back a report and not an account of his own reasons for choosing one soldier over another. The regiment's quartermaster gave him three days' rations for the file and a lamp apiece, the days by then being short enough that a patrol which meant to search a town properly could not count on daylight to do it in, and told him, handing over the last of the lamps, that Baile chrom lay far enough round the headland that no patrol before his had troubled to go so far, the town having sent in no complaint, raised no trouble, and given the regiment, in four months of war, no reason at all to spend a file's time on it.

The road north ran along the shoulder of the coast the whole way, with the sea on the left hand and, on the right, a country of low stone walls and thin pasture that put Dùghall in mind, more than once, of the ground round Caol bheag before the strait widened into the river proper, though the light here was flatter and greyer than any light he had known at home, coming off a sea that his father, a river man all his life, would have called no proper sea at all but a doorstep to one. They marched two days by way of the headland farms, which the order bade them visit on the road, to cover what the map called four miles straight, the light failing early both days, and slept the one night between in a drover's bothy that had plainly not sheltered a drove in some years, its thatch gone soft with damp and its single hearth cold enough that two of the men spent the night's watch arguing, in low voices Dùghall pretended not to hear, over whose turn it properly was to have thought to bring dry kindling.

They passed, on the second day's march, two farms and a mill whose wheel stood idle for want of water, the burn that turned it run low with the season's dry spell, and at each the file was watched from a doorway by whoever stood in it but never once hailed, the watching itself carried on in a silence Dùghall found he minded more, by the second farm, than any shout would have troubled him. One of his men, a stolid soldier named Cailean who had said little the whole march, re-

marked at the mill that a Dia-thireach farm on the same road would have had a child out asking them their business inside a minute, favourable or not, and that a farm which only watched and said nothing was a farm that had already decided, before the file came in sight, exactly how much of itself it meant to show a soldier of the regiments, which Dùghall thought a fair enough observation and did not add to.

He knew, coming up the last rise before the town, that it was the eve of some observance of Eaglais nan Tuathach¹, having heard two of his own men, both of them river-born like himself and neither much given to piety of any kind, mention in passing that the north coast kept a vigil that night which the low country's own Christian houses did not, a Grey Night, one of them called it, without being able to say much more of it than that his own grandmother, who had come south from somewhere near this coast before Dùghall was born, used to go quiet and short-tempered for the length of one evening every year without ever properly explaining why, and that the family had learned, long before he was old enough to ask, simply to leave her be until morning. Cailean, who had grown up nearer the capital and knew the coast towns only by their trade, said he had heard the priests of Manannan at Ceann mhòr call it a prayer of their own gone astray in the north, kept there for a bird the church itself no longer named the same way the south did, and that the two houses disputed the matter without either, so far as he knew, troubling to settle it; Dùghall said only that he supposed a file ordered to search a town on the one night of the year it kept its silence deliberately had drawn, among the whole regiment's patrols that season, a particularly poor lot, and none of the six men with him disagreed.

IV

Of the Unlatched Door

Dùghall had come up the coast road that autumn expecting, if he expected anything in particular, the kind of welcome the regiment's other patrols had reported from other Tuathaich towns: shutters put up at the first sound of boots on the road, a dog or two set loose to bark the length of a street, a woman calling a warning from an upper window to whoever in the town most

1. the Tuathaich Church; the old congregations of the north coast

needed the warning carried to them first. He had heard all three from men of his own company who had searched other coast towns that season, and had gone north with some private notion, never spoken aloud even to himself in so many words, that a night search would at least give a man something to push against, some sound or sight that told him the town knew he was there and minded it.

Baile chrom gave him none of that. The file came down off the last rise into the town's one bent street a little after full dark, the road following, as one of his men remarked, no straighter a course than a burn finds down a hillside, and not a single lamp showed in any window the whole length of it. No dog barked, not from the first house nor the last, and the only sound the whole way in was the sea working at the stones below the headland and, nearer at hand, his own men's boots on the road, which began, without any order given, to fall softer of their own accord the further into the town they came, as men will when a silence asks something of them that no order has yet put into words.

He tried the first door himself, a low house set back a little from the street with a byre built on to its gable end, and found it unlatched, the way a door is left in a house that expects no visitor and fears none either. Inside, by what grey light came through the one small window, he made out a man and a woman and three children, the youngest of them no more than five or six by his own guess, sitting round a hearth gone entirely cold, their hands folded in their laps in a stillness that put him more in mind, oddly, of a church he had once been made to sit through as a boy at his mother's insistence than of anything a soldier searching a house for arms had any right to expect. None of them spoke. None of them, so far as he could tell in that light, so much as turned a head toward the door.

He asked them, first in *Dia-thiris* and then, haltingly, in the little of the humans' tongue he carried, who else was in the house, and whether there were arms kept anywhere on the ground. The man only shook his head once, slowly, the whole weight of the gesture in its slowness rather than its motion, in the particular way, Dùghall thought afterward, that a man shakes his head at a child in church who has asked a question the room itself has already answered by staying quiet, a headshake that asked nothing further and offered nothing further either, and that closed the matter, so far as the man plainly judged it closed, more completely than any word could have.

It was the same at the next house, and the one after that, through the small hours of the night: unlatched doors, cold hearths, families sitting in a stillness Dùghall came to think of, by the fourth or fifth house, not as fear exactly, though

he supposed fear was somewhere in it, but as a thing closer to a held breath that the whole town had agreed, without ever agreeing it in his hearing, to hold together until the file had passed through and gone. He found no arms in any house he searched that night, and no man or woman of an age to fight who was not already sitting, hands folded, in that same stillness.

The house nearest the lighthouse road, the last but one on the file's way through the town, held only a single old woman, sitting alone at a hearth as cold as every other, her hands folded the same way and her eyes open and steady on the doorway before Dùghall had so much as raised his hand to knock, as though she had heard the file's boots on the street some houses back and had settled herself, in her own time and by her own choosing, to receive whatever came through the door before it came. She gave her name when he asked it, the first person in the whole town that night who answered him at all beyond a headshake, and gave it plainly, in *Dia-thìris*, as Margaret Crane, and said nothing further, neither complaint nor welcome, only that same steady look that Dùghall found harder to stand under than any of the silences that had gone before it, a look that seemed to him less to be asking what he wanted than to have already decided, before he had finished asking it himself, what she meant to give him and what she did not.

He asked her, as he had asked at every other house, whether there were arms kept on the ground, and whether any man of the town was elsewhere that night who ought properly to be accounted for; and she answered only that the town kept its vigil that night as it kept it every year, and that she herself kept it in that house as she had kept it, she said, since before the war had a name to be kept from, and that a soldier was welcome to search the house from floor to rafter if the order he carried required it of him, since she had nothing in it he need trouble himself to hide from a searching. It was, of the whole night's houses, the one answer that gave him more words than any other and told him, when he came afterward to turn it over, no more than the rest had told him with none at all. He searched the house as she had bid him, finding nothing, and one of his own men, the same soldier who had walked heel first past the threshold at the house before, set his own lamp down of his own accord in the passage outside her door rather than carry its light in past her, a small courtesy Dùghall had given no order for and did not afterward ask the man to explain.

He learned only much later, from a clerk at *Ceann mhòr* who had served two seasons on that coast before *An ceathramh rèisimeid*¹ ever came to it, that the vigil

the old woman kept was held, in that one town before any other on the island, by the greater part of its people rather than the lesser, a night of silence kept, the clerk said, for some bird of their church that the south's own house of the same faith no longer named the same way, and that the whole town's custom, on that one night of the year, was to sit each in their own house with hearth and lamp alike unlit and speak no word aloud until the vigil's morning released them from it, a custom no soldier of the regiments coming up that coast in ignorance of the calendar could have known to expect, and no order Dùghall had been given had troubled to warn him of.

V

Of the Report That Said No More

In the end he wrote the report every patrol that autumn had learned to write, that the town had been found dark and silent throughout, that it had been searched house by house, and that nothing was found: no arms, no men of fighting age unaccounted for, no sign that Baile chrom held or had ever held anything the regiment's order had sent him north to look for. The file's own clerk copied it fair the next morning at the bothy where they slept the second night, a younger man than Dùghall who had joined the fourth straight from a shipwright's yard at Ceann mhòr and had not yet lost, in Dùghall's private judgment, the habit of asking questions an older soldier learned to leave alone; folding the report into the satchel that would carry it back to the regiment's own returns, he asked whether there was more to be said of the night than the three lines it held.

Dùghall told him there was not, which was true in the only sense the order had asked him to make it true, and did not tell him of the man who had shaken his head once, slowly, nor of the very old woman his own soldier had stepped past on his toes, nor of the particular sound the sea had made on the stones below the headland while the file stood a long moment outside the last house before turning back for the road, a sound he found, walking south again the next day with the report already gone ahead of him, he could not afterward call to mind without the whole of that night coming back with it entire, the unlatched doors and the cold

1. the fourth regiment

hearths and the headshakes, in a way three written lines had done nothing at all to put down or settle.

The file marched south again the next morning, the vigil's silence lifted by then, or so Dùghall judged from a single lamp he saw lit at last in a window as they left the bent street behind them, and he found the walk back to Ceann mhòr passed in a quiet among his own six men greater than any that had marked the march north, none of them offering much conversation and none pressed to, as though the town they had left behind had asked something of the file's own tongues as well as the town's. Cailean broke the silence only once, on the second day, to say that he had searched a good many houses that autumn on a good many coasts and had never yet come away from a search feeling, as he put it, that the house had searched him back, and that he did not care to go north to Baile chrom again if the regiment could find another man to send.

Word came to the regiment, a week after Dùghall's own report went in, that Àth naomh and Tobar dhearg of the hills, the last two of the five towns still holding out, had opened their own roads to the regiments that same week without so much as a shot fired on either side, their pits flooded on Comhairle nam Mèinnean's order the same day the roads opened, and An Clàr Foscailte², when Dùghall came to see a copy of it some weeks later pinned in the guardroom at Ceann mhòr, named no holdout taken prisoner at either town, the same three words, nothing found, standing in the place where a longer account might have stood had there been one to give. He thought, reading it, of Baile chrom's own cold hearths, and found himself wondering, not for the first time that winter, whether a return that named nothing found was a return that had looked in the right place to begin with, or only a return written by a man who had learned, as he himself plainly had, to stop asking a question once the room had already answered it by staying quiet.

He mentioned Àth naomh's opening to Barbara one evening over the plain fare she still set before him without much talk to go with it, thinking she might have some word of her own on it from whatever channel carried news among the Tuathaich households of the coast faster than any regimental return carried it among his own kind, and she told him only, in Dia-thìris, that a pit flooded was a pit flooded whichever order flooded it, and asked nothing further, and offered nothing further, and took up her mending again in a silence he had by then

1. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

2. the open record of the war years

learned not to press. Watching her needle go in and out by the one lamp she allowed herself of an evening, he found himself thinking that the whole coast, Diathìreach and Tuathaich both, seemed that winter to have settled on the same three words the regiment's own returns had settled on, each in its own house and its own tongue, and that a war fought mostly in silence on both sides was, whatever else might be said of it, no easier a thing to carry home at night than one fought with any noise at all.

On an Nollaig³ that year An naoidheamh rèisimeid⁴ was raised at the southern Seann Skell, to stand guard over the dubhan works the shipmasters had built there, and Dùghall heard the news of it read out at Ceann mhòr's own guard-room two days after, one more line in a winter that seemed to him, turning the last months over as he lay awake in Barbara's back room with her loom silent behind the wall and the widow herself long asleep, to have been made up of nothing but such lines: a fleet raised here, a regiment there, a town's roads opened without a fight, a report that said no more than three words allowed it to say. He had not slept well since Baile chrom, waking most nights somewhere in the small hours with the sea-sound of that headland in his ears though Ceann mhòr's own harbour lay near enough that he could not always be sure, half waking, which shore the sound in fact came from; and he did not know, lying there with the winter's short daylight still some hours off, what exactly it was about that one bent street that would not let him sleep the way the other towns his file had searched that autumn had let him sleep easily enough, only that it would not, and that no line he could write in any report, then or afterward, was going to tell him why.

He thought, more than once in those wakeful hours, of trying the words for it in the humans' tongue, the few he carried, as though a thing that would not settle in Dia-thìris might yet settle in the other, and found each time that he did not have the words at all, in either tongue, for a stillness that had asked nothing of him and given him, in the asking, nothing to answer with; and he let the matter lie, the way the town itself had taught him, without much hope by then that letting it lie would do any more for him than it had plainly done, over some longer span of years he could not guess at, for Margaret Crane's own steady, waiting look.

3. Christmas

4. the ninth regiment

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

OF the QUARTERED YEAR

DE 22

Part Six · Of the Quartered Year, the Column and Blàr

Muileann ghlas

Chaidh am fadachadh. They got long-warred.

— a saying of the north

I

Of the Pass at the Harbour Wall

The regiments did not fight that year. Martha Greaves came to know it the way the whole north came to know it: from the plain evidence of a winter passing into a spring and a spring into a summer, with no name added to any list she had not already entered by hand, and by the middle of am Màrt she had stopped waiting for the next battle the way a woman stops listening for a caller who has twice failed to come, without ever quite deciding to stop, only finding one morning that she no longer did it.

What came instead of battle was the quartering, and the quartering asked more of the harbour at Caol mhòr, in its own quiet way, than any single engagement had asked of the hill towns. A patrol boat lay off the harbour mouth through that whole spring, always of the same low grey build though seldom the same hull twice running, and a soldier stood at the head of the harbour steps from first light to last with a book under his arm and a list of names in it that grew longer by the week; and any man or woman of the town who meant to go beyond the harbour road, to a farm inland or a market at Doire ghlas or a burial two parishes off, learned to come to that soldier first and show him the small square of pa-

per Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹'s own office had begun, that spring, to issue against a name and a face and a stated errand, which the townsfolk had taken, within a month of the first of them being handed out, to calling simply the pass, though the paper's own heading gave it a longer name that nobody troubled to read past the first line.

Martha came to the harbour herself on Moot business three times that spring, carrying Tional nan Tuathach²'s papers down from her own mill at Doire ghlas in the same worn satchel Walter Hale had carried them in before her, and each time she showed her own pass to the same soldier, a stolid young man from one of the southern shires who plainly found the asking as tiresome as she found the answering, and each time he wrote her name in his book beside the hour, though he had by the second visit ceased to trouble her further than that, the way a toll-keeper ceases, after enough passings, to weigh a coin he already knows to be sound.

It was on the third of these visits, in the last week of an Cèitean, that she came down to the wall in time to watch the same soldier's own captain board Joe Ashby's boats.

She knew Joe Ashby, as the whole Moot knew him, for the fitter who had turned the Baile chrom light on Tional nan Tuathach's own coin and now held no guild's paper and answered to none, and she watched now from the head of the steps as two of the captain's men went down into the bilges of a hull she took, by its lines, for one of the half-dozen the town's people called the engine-boats, and came up black to the elbow, and found, so far as she could tell from where she stood, nothing that troubled the captain's own book beyond a line written and the next boat called for. The fitter himself stood at his shed door through the whole of it with a wrench still in his hand, watching in the particular stillness of a man who has done this dance before and knows every step of it, and when the captain came to him at the last and asked, as Martha heard it carried on the wind off the water, whether he held any guild's leave for the engines he fitted, Joe Ashby answered that there was none in that harbour would give him one, in a voice that carried no more heat than a man remarking on the weather.

Martha did not speak to him that day, having business enough of her own with the harbour-master over a Moot petition on the tithe, but she wrote the whole of it into her own private book that evening, the one she kept apart from Cuimhne-coinneimh an Tionail³ and showed to no council, because it seemed to

1. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

2. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

her a thing worth setting down: that a harbour a year clear of any battle could still be searched, boat by boat, on the strength of an order nobody at the wall had asked to see written out in full, and that the town bore it the way it bore the pass and the soldier at the steps and the patrol hull off the mouth: without gladness, and without much noise, the plain unspectacular labour of a people getting on with a war that had stopped fighting and had not yet stopped asking.

She heard, some weeks later, from the same harbour-master, that the depot's own men had sent for Joe Ashby again before the summer was out, a fleet hull this time whose engine no guild-trained fitter at Seann Skell could put right, and that he had gone and mended it and taken his coin and asked no more of the matter than the coin required, which struck Martha, hearing it, as neither a betrayal of anything nor a submission to it, only the same plain labour again, carried on wherever the labour was wanted and paid for, war or no war.

The pass, small square paper that it was, reached further into the harbour's ordinary year than Martha had looked for when she first watched it handed out. A carter of the town buried his own father in am Màrt at a parish two roads inland, and stood at the harbour steps the morning of the burial with the whole of his family's mourning black already on him, showing his paper to the same stolid soldier as any market-day errand, because the office that wrote the passes had made no separate provision for a burial and the carter had not thought to ask one of it; and Martha, hearing the tale from the harbour-master over the same tithe business that had first brought her down, found she could not say afterward which struck her the harder, that the office had thought so little of a burial's difference from a market errand, or that the town had by then stopped expecting it to think of any such difference at all.

By the height of summer the soldier at the steps had learned most of the harbour's own faces well enough to wave the plainest of its errands through with no more than a glance at the paper held up, and the town, for its part, had settled into carrying the little square papers the way a fisherman carries a knife, without remarking on it, only reaching for it when the moment asked; and it was this settling, more than any single search or any single asking, that Martha found hardest to set down plainly in her own private book, since a thing borne quietly enough for long enough ceases, in the telling, to look like a thing borne at all.

3. the Moot's minutes; lit. 'the meeting-memory of the gathering'

II

Of the Names Added at Àth leathan

Tional nan Tuathach kept its register in the same low room behind its own house at Caol mhòr where it had kept it since An Dealachadh¹, a single long shelf of bound books running back further than any living speaker could put a date to without consulting them, and it fell to Martha, in the second week of an Giblean, to open the current volume to the column headed the dead and the maimed and enter, at last, the names of Àth leathan.

The battle was thirteen months gone by then. An Clàr Foscailte² had counted the kingdom's own dead at the field below the town the spring before, thirty-eight by its last tally, and had let the holdouts' dead go uncounted, as An Clàr Foscailte let a great many things go uncounted that Tional nan Tuathach's own register did not; and it had taken Tional nan Tuathach's own clerks the better part of a year, working from what letters and lists the hill towns themselves would send south under the disarming, to put together a fuller reckoning than An Clàr Foscailte had ever meant to give. Peter Hale, who by then carried the rebound minute-books through half Tional nan Tuathach's own business the way his great-grandfather Walter had carried the first of them, brought the western list to her himself on a morning of steady rain, a single folded sheet in a hand she did not know, and told her only that it had come up from Cnoc thais by three hands and a fortnight's delay, and that he had checked it twice against the letters already filed and found no name in it that any other list contradicted.

She read the names aloud to herself before she wrote them, a habit she had kept since her first year at the desk, on the private reasoning that a name spoken once by a living voice was less entirely lost than a name only ever set down in ink; and she found, reading the Àth leathan list through for the first time, that Ruth Calder's own name stood nowhere on it, neither among the dead nor the maimed nor, so far as the list troubled to say, among the living, which told her, as it had told every clerk who had looked for that name in the year since, precisely nothing at all.

The names went in through that whole wet morning, in the same clear hand the register had always been kept in, a column of them running to the foot of one

1. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

2. the open record of the war years

3. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

page and the head of the next, and she thought, dipping her pen for perhaps the fortieth time, that a register was a strange kind of mercy: too slow to comfort anyone in the year a death happened, and yet, a year on, still willing to receive it when nothing else on the island any longer was.

It was an Giblean too, in that same fortnight, that she went up to the old chapel above the mill at Doire ghlas on the morning Eaglais nan Tuathach⁴ kept its Easter, less from any faith of her own in An Eaglais's rite than from a long habit of standing at the back of whatever house of worship her own town's people kept, to see for herself how a thing was borne rather than take another's word for it. She found the chapel fuller than she had looked for, the whole small congregation of Doire ghlas's own Tuathaich households gathered in, and a single soldier of the regiments standing at the door through the length of the service, not unkindly, only present, the way the soldier at the harbour steps was present, a book under his arm in which he wrote, so far as Martha could see from where she stood, nothing at all, the whole service passing without a word exchanged between the door and the altar. Before the last hymn was sung she left, having seen what she had come to see, which was that the north kept its own feasts that year under watch and kept them anyway, and she carried the sight back to Doire ghlas with her the way she carried most such sights, unspoken to anyone, set down only in the private book Tional nan Tuathach never saw.

She wrote the register's own list closed that same week, ruling the double line the book's own form asked of a finished column and setting the date under it in the same hand she had used for every name above; and she found, ruling it, that she had grown, over the year of no battles, into a kind of clerk she had not set out to become when Tional nan Tuathach first gave her Daniel Frayne's own chair: still the speaker who carried the north's grievances south to a council that mostly did not answer them, and now, besides that, a keeper of a book that answered, in its own slow and unhurried way, what the council never troubled to. How many further columns the same book would ask of her before the war she had not yet learned to call ended was done asking, she could not say, closing the Àth leathan column; only that the book would take them, page after ruled page, whatever the council chose to do about the asking.

4. the Tuathaich Church; the old congregations of the north coast

5. the Church

III

Of the Women from Cnoc thais

Ellen Marsh had turned Agnes Pike's old schoolroom over to the families from the west the summer before, and when Cnoc thais fell its people too came down out of the hills with what they could carry, and by the second spring of their sheltering there she had come to know most of the women of that town by name, sitting three and four to a bench in the evenings after the day's small work was done, while she went from bench to bench with her own ink and paper and took down, in the plain hand she had used for eleven books before this one, whatever each woman judged worth the telling.

Peggy Innes, who had kept a byre of six goats above the second shaft before the road was cut, told her, on an evening in an t-Ògmhios, of a farm two ridges back from the town's own ruin where the wife still baked twice what her own household could eat and left the second baking on the sill overnight, and where the loaves were always gone by morning and the sill never once watched to see by whom; and she told it, Ellen noted, in the flat unhurried voice of a woman reporting a fact of the weather, neither boasting of the farm's courage nor fearing to name it, since every woman on that bench already knew, without needing to be told, that a war which had stopped its battles had not stopped its hiding, and that the hills above Cnoc thais still held men who had gone up into them the year the road was cut and had not yet, whatever the disarming at Muileann àrsaidh and Àth leathan had settled for the towns themselves, come down.

Ellen wrote the farm's telling into her own twelfth book without a name attached to it, on the same private rule she had kept through all eleven books before, that a fact could be kept and a name spared where the naming would cost the teller more than the telling was worth; and she was still turning that rule over in her own mind three weeks later when word came up from the hill country, carried by a carter's boy who had it from a cousin still at Cnoc thais, that a patrol of the regiments had found a farm much like the one Peggy had named, though not that one, close enough to it that the whole schoolroom bench went quiet at the telling, and had put its thatch to the torch on the strength of a barn found half full of grain no ration book of the district could account for.

No one was killed at that burning, the boy's own telling said, the family having been turned out of the house before the thatch was fired and left standing in their own yard to watch it go; but the byre went with the house, and the season's

hay with the byre, and Ellen set the whole of it down in her twelfth book that same week in the same flat voice the women themselves used for such tellings, because she had learned, over eleven books and the better part of a life spent taking down what the north would tell her, that the flat voice was very often the only one a fact of that kind could safely be carried in.

Marion Kenny, who sat the bench nearest the door most evenings and said little until the room had thinned to two or three, told her own account of the same burning some weeks after the carter's boy had first carried it down, having had it herself from a sister still living within sight of the ruin, and her telling added only one thing the boy's had left out: that the family put out into their own yard that morning had been given time, before the thatch was fired, to carry out what they could of the house's own goods, a chest and a loom and the year's stored meal, by the very patrol that had come to burn it, and that no one on the bench that evening could rightly say whether this was mercy in the men who did the burning or only the ordinary carefulness of soldiers who had learned, over a long year of finding nothing, to make what small amends they could within an order they had not written themselves. Ellen set that down too, unresolved as it stood, since she had come to think, closing in on her twelfth book what her first had taught her at the very start of the gathering, that a full account left its own contradictions standing rather than smooth them away for the sake of a tidier page.

She finished the twelfth book in the first week of an Dàmhair, closing it on an evening when the schoolroom benches held fewer of the west's own women than they had a year before, some gone home already to whatever their own hill towns had left standing, some gone nowhere anyone at Doire ghlas could say; and she sat a long while with the finished book closed on her own table before she wrote, on its last blank leaf, a single line that owed nothing to any woman's telling but her own: that the war her first eleven books had never troubled themselves to speak of had, by the time this twelfth one closed, written its own record into the north as plainly as An Dealachadh¹ had, and that she did not yet know, closing it, which of her twelve books a reader two generations off would find the harder to believe.

1. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

IV

Of the Hymn Through the Wall

An ceathramh rèisimeid kept its patrols on the Ceann mhòr road through the whole of that year, in a rhythm Dùghall mac Iain had come, by the spring, to know almost without troubling to think of it: a file out at first light, a file in at dusk, the same stretches of coast and hedgerow walked and walked again until the road seemed, some evenings, to walk the file rather than the other way about. No arms were found on any of those patrols after the winter's search of Baile chrom, and no man of fighting age was taken up who could not give some account of himself that the file's own corporal, whoever he was that week, judged worth passing without further trouble; and the regiment's returns, which Dùghall still copied fair as often as any other corporal of his own company, settled by the spring into the same three words that had closed every report of the autumn before, so that a man reading a twelvemonth of them end to end, as Dùghall once did on a wet afternoon with nothing else to fill it, would have found a year's patrolling summed up in little more than a list of dates against which nothing had been found.

The farms along that road told their own year plainer than any return did. A byre Dùghall's file had passed shuttered in the winter stood open by the summer with a boy of ten or eleven driving the same three cows out to the same field each morning, and the boy came, by the second season of the same patrol going by, to lift a hand to the file as it passed, not quite a greeting and not quite its refusal, a small loosening Dùghall noticed and did not remark on to the men behind him, judging that a thing noticed aloud too soon had a way of curdling before it could properly set. Other farms kept the same watching silence they had kept the year before, the door held to and the field worked in a stillness that asked the file nothing and gave it nothing, and Dùghall had stopped, by the spring, expecting either kind of farm to become the other, having learned that a household's own manner toward a patrol was no more likely to change for a year's quiet than a man's manner toward the sea was likely to change for a calm summer, both being founded on a memory no summer could touch.

He was still billeted on Barbara, the arrangement having become, over the better part of a year, less a wariness endured than a plain fact of his own days, the two of them keeping the same table and the same thin courtesy across it without either, so far as he could tell, wanting it otherwise or expecting it to become any-

thing more. She fed him, and took the billeting-due without comment, and answered him in *Dia-thìris* when he spoke to her in it and in nothing at all when he tried, of an evening, the little of the humans' tongue he still carried, though he had long since stopped minding that particular silence the way he had minded it the first autumn, having come to understand it, or think he understood it, as a boundary she kept for reasons that were hers to keep and none of his to press.

It was on an evening of an *t-Sultain*, with the regiment's patrols grown so much a matter of habit by then that even the men who walked them had stopped remarking on the empty houses they no longer troubled to search, that Dùghall heard, through the wall between his own room and the loom-room, a hymn he did not know sung low and unhurried in the humans' tongue, a different air from the shuttle-song he had overheard the autumn before and heavier in its cadence, the kind of tune a house keeps for its own church rather than its own work. He stood a while in the passage as he had stood the first time, and went on to his room as he had gone on then, telling himself it was no more his to overhear a second time than it had been the first.

The same air came again a fortnight later, and again after that, always of an evening, until by the second week of an *Dàmhair* he found he could carry the whole of its shape in his own head without meaning to have learned it, the rise and fall of it if not the words, the way a man comes to know the toll of a bell he has lived long enough beside without ever climbing the tower to see it rung. He did not ask Barbara what the hymn was called, judging, by then, that the asking would cost more of the household's thin peace than the answer was worth; but he found himself, walking the *Ceann mhòr* road of a morning with his own file strung out behind him, humming a bar or two of it under his breath before he caught himself at it, and stopping, each time, with the particular unease of a man who has found a stranger's coin in his own pocket and cannot say how it came there.

He mentioned it, once, to Cailean, who had marched with him to *Baile chrom* the winter before and had said little of that night since; and Cailean, hearing two bars of it hummed low over a cold supper, said only that his own grandmother had kept a tune very like it, and that he had never asked her the words of it either, and that a man billeted long enough on a house not his own generally came away, whether he meant to or not, carrying some small piece of it home in him that no order and no regiment could ever quite account for in its returns.

V

Of the Word That Came to Caol mhòr

Through that whole quartered year, from the harbour at Caol mhòr to the schoolroom at Doire ghlas to the coast road above Ceann mhòr, ran a single rumour that none of them, telling it to one another across the width of the island in letters and carters' talk and a soldier's idle word over a cold supper, could ever quite run to ground: that something was gathering in the western hills that the disarming had not reached, and had not been meant to reach, and that no report from any regiment's own patrol, searching the same empty farms and the same silent doorways it had searched for a year without once finding arms or men to answer for them, had troubled to explain.

Martha heard a version of it from a letter out of Cnoc thais that reached Tion-al nan Tuathach's own house in the last week of an t-Sultain, a plain note from a clerk of Comhairle nam Mèinnean² stationed there that said only that the hill paths above the town carried more foot-traffic by night than any patrol's own daylight counting could make sense of, and that the clerk did not know what to make of it and set it down all the same, since a fact unexplained was, in his own judgment, still worth Comhairle nam Mèinnean's having. Ellen heard it in gentler form from the last of the Cnoc thais women still on her own schoolroom benches, a shrug more than a telling, that the hills had always kept more than any regiment's list could count and would go on keeping it whatever the disarming said. Dùghall heard it from Cailean, who had it from a corn-factor at Ceann mhòr who had it, in turn, from nobody he could rightly name, that the western hills were said to be emptying of something, though of what, and toward where, the corn-factor himself could not say and did not, by Cailean's own account, seem greatly troubled not to know.

None of the three of them, in all that quartered year, ever heard the rumour told twice the same way, and none of them, telling it on in turn, thought to connect it with any other thing they themselves had seen: not with the farm above Cnoc thais that fed a night's coming and going the disarming had never quite ended, not with the hymn Dùghall had learned without meaning to through Barbara's own wall, not with the pass a soldier at the Caol mhòr steps still asked of every fisherman and carter who wanted the harbour road. It was simply the one

1. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

thing that whole year that would not settle into any report's three closing words, the one line no regimental clerk and no Moot's register and no schoolroom's twelfth book could make read as nothing found, because nothing, in this one matter alone, had ever been offered for the finding.

Word came to Caol mhòr in the first days of an t-Samhain, brought up the harbour road by a Board carrier who had ridden two days without pausing to change his own horse twice over, that a company of some hundreds, out of no town the carrier's own dispatch troubled to name, had come down out of the western hills and turned south-east across the middle of the island, keeping to no road the regiments had thought to watch, and bound for no destination the dispatch would guess at. Martha read the carrier's note at her own desk in Tional nan Tuathach's low room, with the register's current volume still open on the shelf beside her at the page she had closed that spring over the names of Àth leathan, and found, reading it, that the rumour the whole quartered year had carried without ever once running to ground had, in the space of one carrier's ride, stopped being a rumour and become, instead, the first plain fact any report that autumn had troubled to set down.

She did not yet know, folding the note away to lay before the room in the morning, how long the road the company had chosen would run, nor where it would end, nor what name, if any, An Clàr Foscailte³ would ever trouble to give the man the western hills' own tellings were already, by every account reaching her desk, calling their own. She knew only, sealing the note into her satchel beside the papers that had carried Tional nan Tuathach's whole quartered year, that the year of nothing found was over, and that whatever came after it would not, this time, close on three words and a clean page.

3. the open record of the war years

Of the Column's Road

DE 22

Nobody at Cathair dhearg saw it start. That is the first true thing to say of it, and the last, since everything between is town report and hill telling, and the two do not always agree even on the weather. What An Clàr Foscailte gives is this: that in the last week of an Dàmhair a company of some four hundred came down out of the western hills where the holdouts had sat quartered a year and more under the regiments' watch, and went south-east across the middle of the island by roads that had carried nothing heavier than a drover's cart in living memory, and that six weeks later it stood on the fields by Muileann ghlas, a day's walk from the capital, with two regiments come down Rathad na Fèille to meet it. Why it went is not in An Clàr Foscailte, nor in any town's report, nor, if Sceulachdan nan Tuathach are to be believed on this one point, in the column's own knowledge past the man who led it, and he left no account behind him that anyone has found. The tellings give his name as Owen Barrow. An Clàr Foscailte gives no name at all, only "a column of the western hills," as though the hand that wrote it had decided, or been told, that a name was one thing too many to set down.

I

Of the Ford at Àth bheag

Ath bheag stands where the old drove road crosses the upper water on its way down from the western hills to the plain, a burg of not much above two hundred souls with a mill, a smithy and a bridge too narrow for two carts abreast, and it had seen nothing of the war since the second summer's musters except the soldiers who came through now and again on the road to the Seann Skell garrison and never stayed the night. Its report to Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹, dated the thirtieth of an Dàmhair and copied afterward into an Le-abharlann²'s file on the column, says that a company of armed men, not fewer than three hundred and by the reckoning of two who counted them from the mill loft nearer four, crossed the ford below the bridge in the grey of a Tuesday morning, in good order and without haste, and that they did not use the bridge, which would have brought them through the heart of the town, but forded the water a field's length below it, wet to the knee, and went on south without stopping.

The maor of Àth bheag, a man named Cailean mac Griogair who had held the office nine years and buried, in that time, two wives and one son to the winters the western hills give a small town on short rations, wrote his report the same evening by his own hand, and it is the fullest of the whole road because he wrote it while the thing was still new to him and had not yet learned, as later towns learned, how little a report of this kind was wanted to say. He had been woken before light by the smith's boy hammering at his door, and had come down to the bank himself in his nightshirt and a borrowed coat, and stood a good while at the field's edge watching the last of the column cross before he judged there was anything in it worth the walk back up to his own desk to set down. He set down the hour, the number as near as two men's counting could give it, the road they took and the road they did not, the state of the water (in spate from three days' rain, and cold enough that he wondered, watching them wade it, that no man of them cried out), and one thing more that Comhairle nam Mèinnean's copyist struck through in the file copy and that survives only because Cailean kept his own draft: that the miller's wife, watching from the loft with the two who counted, said afterward that she had seen no banner among them and no drum, only a man walking at the head of the column with nothing about him to mark him out from the rest except that the others left him the whole width of the road to himself, and that this, more than the guns some of them carried, was what had made her certain the company kept some errand of its own, and no design on the mill's stores.

1. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

2. the Library at Muileann chaol

Cailean added, in his own draft and nowhere else, that he had thought of going down to the ford himself and asking the man at the head of it plainly where he was bound, and had not done it, and could not afterward say why not, except that the width of road the column had left the man made him think a question put across it would not be answered, and a maor of Àth bheag who had spent nine years keeping the peace between drovers and millers without once having to draw a sword saw no profit in learning that for certain at a river crossing before breakfast.

Cailean's report went by carrier the next morning to Comhairle nam Mèinnean's clerk at the western Seann Skell, and from there, in the slower way such things travel once they are no longer news to the man carrying them, to Leabharlann Muileann chaol³, where Sìleas nic Rath entered it in the file she had begun to keep of the column's road the week the first report of it reached her desk. She had asked, by then, for every town's account of it that could be got, and had been given leave to keep them, which was more than she had been given for the war four years before; the difference, she wrote once in a private note that never went into any file, was that a column marching in the open through country at peace was a thing a chronicler might be let see, where a war fought in the hills was not, and she did not know, setting that down, whether it comforted her or not.

Àth bheag's report ends with a line that Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own men, reading it afterward, took for a maor's caution and that Sìleas took, copying it in, for a plainer thing: that the column had asked nothing of the town, taken nothing from it, and left nothing behind but the wet marks of its crossing on the near bank, which the next rain washed out within the week.

II

Of the Bread at Muileann mhin

A few days on, and a few miles by the road the column seemed to be keeping, though no report survives to say exactly where it slept those nights, Muileann mhin had its own turn: not the lamp-makers' town of that name east of the capital, but the small mill town of the same name under the western hills, a place of some two hundred souls. Its report to Comhairle nam

3. the Library at Muileann chaol

Mèinnean¹, signed by its miller rather than its maor, who was from home that week at a wedding in Cathair mhòr, has a different temper from Àth bheag's, less the note of a man watching a company pass and more the note of a man doing sums.

Two men came into the town on the morning of the second of an t-Samhain, the report says, ahead of the column by some hours, and went to the baker nearest the bridge, a widow named Mòrag nic Fhearghais who had kept the ovens since her husband's death. The two men asked for bread, as much as the ovens held and as much again as could be baked fresh by noon, and asked the price, and paid it in full in the coin of the realm, counted out on the counter in front of three other customers who had come in for their own morning loaves and stood back, the report says, "not from fear so much as from a wish to see the thing done properly, as men will stand back from a fair bargain struck in the street." Mòrag, by the miller's account, asked the older of the two whether he meant to feed a garrison or a wedding, meaning it, she told him afterward, half as a joke to ease her own daughters' nerves at the size of the order, and he answered only that he meant to feed men who had walked a long way and would walk further, which was no answer at all and satisfied her, she said, better than one would have.

Mòrag baked through the morning with two of her own daughters to help her, and the column, when it came through a little after noon, sent no more than a dozen men into the town to carry the loaves away, the rest passing on the road below without turning aside, and the dozen who came for the bread paid again, a small sum over the first price, which Mòrag's own account, kept separately from the miller's and sent to Comhairle nam Mèinnean a week later at his asking, gives to the last farthing.

The miller's report does not say what the two men looked like, beyond that one was young and the other not, nor whether either was the man the tellings name; it says only that they spoke the humans' tongue between themselves and Dia-thìris to the widow, civilly, and that neither gave a name when Mòrag, by her own account, asked for one to set against the sale in her book. She wrote instead, where a name should have stood, "bread, to the western company, paid in full," and that is the line Comhairle nam Mèinnean's file preserves, copied twice more before it reached an Leabharlann², the wording unchanged each time, as though no clerk who handled it had found anything in it worth altering.

1. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

2. the Library at Muileann chaol

The miller's own closing line, which Sileas kept without comment in her file, notes that the town's takings for that week showed no loss against the ordinary, the bread having been paid for at a fair price and the company having troubled nobody's stock beyond it, and that he set this down not to speak for the column, which was no business of his, but so that Comhairle nam Mèinnean should not suppose, from the mere fact of an armed company passing through a working town, that the town had suffered by it. Whether Comhairle nam Mèinnean read that line as the warden meant it, or otherwise, the file does not say; but a second hand, in a different ink, has added below the miller's signature a single further note, unsigned, that the loaves were good loaves and the widow well paid for them, which is either a clerk's private aside or, as Sileas herself once wondered, a line the miller thought better to add without his own name against it.

III

Of the Barn on the Capital's Edge

The country between Muileann mhin and the capital's own fields is the quietest stretch of the whole road, farms and hedgerows and the low rise of ground that a man from the hills would hardly call a hill at all, and it gave, in the fortnight the column crossed it, only one report of any substance, from a farmer named Aonghas mac Cuinn whose steading lay a mile off the road proper, close enough that a company passing would have seen the barn's roof plain against the last light, and far enough that Aonghas, by his own account, thought at first they would go by without troubling him.

They did not. A party of perhaps thirty came to his gate an hour after dark on a night of driving rain, in the second week of an t-Samhain, and asked, through the same young man who had asked at Muileann mhin, or one enough like him that the two reports, set side by side in an Leabharlann's file, read as though they might be the same man, whether the barn stood empty and whether they might have the use of it for one night against the weather. Aonghas, who had a wife and four children under his own roof and no love, he wrote afterward, for having armed strangers so near either, stood in his own doorway with a lamp held up between himself and the gate long enough to count the shapes waiting beyond it,

1. the Library at Muileann chaol

and told them the barn was theirs for the night and nothing more, and asked no payment, thinking a company of that size would take what it wanted whether he named a price or not. His wife, listening from the passage behind him, asked once he had barred the door again whether he had done right, and he told her, by his own account, that he did not know, only that thirty armed men asking leave at a gate were thirty armed men who had not simply taken it, and that this seemed to him, that night, worth more than an answer to whether he had done right.

In the morning he found, weighted under a stone on the barn's threshing floor where the party had slept, a sum in coin that by his own reckoning came to more than a fair week's rent of the barn in any ordinary season, and a note, in a clear hand and in Dia-thiris, that read only: *For the barn, and thanks. We have asked nothing else and will leave nothing else asked of you.* The barn itself they had left swept cleaner, his wife said, than his own boy generally left it of a Saturday, the straw restacked and the door barred from the inside as they had found it, so that but for the coin and the note a stranger coming after might have thought no one had lain there at all.

Aonghas kept the note. It went, eventually, by way of Comhairle nam Mèin-nean's local clerk, into an Leabharlann's file with the rest, and Sìleas, reading it the first time, found it the strangest paper the whole road had given her, stranger than the widow's uncompleted line at Muileann mhin, because it was the only piece of writing anywhere in the file that could be set down, without much doubt, to a hand inside the column, and it said, in the end, almost nothing: no reason, no name, no word of where the company was bound or why, only the plain courtesy of a debt paid and a boundary kept. She copied it into her file exactly as it stood, spelling and all, and noted beside it only the date and the finder's name, and did not, in all the years she kept the office after, ever find another line to set beside it.

The column crossed the last of the open country in the third week of an t-Samhain, keeping, so far as the scattered reports of small farms and a single toll-keeper at the edge of the fair country can be made to agree, a road that ran wide of every town of any size, as though whoever led it had studied the ground beforehand and meant to be seen only where seeing could not be helped. No report from that stretch tells of trouble, of begging, of theft, or of any word exchanged beyond what the day's business required; the column asked lodging where

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

lodging was offered, paid what was asked and sometimes more, and went on, and the towns it passed, having nothing worse to report than a night's noise and a morning's quiet going, mostly did not trouble to report it at all until Comhairle nam Mèinnean, hearing by then from Àth bheag and Muileann mhin both, sent word down the whole line of the western road asking every maor to say what he had seen.

I V

Of the Booths Taken Down

Ùna nic Ailein had kept the books of Cùirt na Fèille¹ at Muileann òg for the better part of thirty years by the time the first word of the column reached the toll-house, and in all that time, through Riaghailt na Cairte² and the granary votes and the long quiet stretch of the war years when nothing crossed Rathad na Fèille³ but the ordinary carts, she had never once been asked to close the year's books before the last market of an Dùbhlachd, and she found, when the asking came, that she did not much like being the one to do it.

It came from A' chiad rèisimeid⁴'s quartermaster, a brisk youngish man she had dealt with twice before over billeting matters and found, both times, civil enough for a soldier, who came up the toll-house stair on the seventh of an Dùbhlachd with an order under the council's own seal requiring the fair-ground at Muileann òg, its booths, its standings and its cleared ground, for the use of the first and third regiments from that day until further notice. Ùna read the order twice, the second time aloud, half to herself and half, she supposed afterward, to give the quartermaster the chance to say it was some mistake, and he did not take it, only stood at the foot of her desk with his cap under his arm and said that he was sorry for the short notice and that the order was not his to argue with any more than it was hers.

"Two regiments," she said. "On my fair-ground."

"On the whole ground between here and Muileann ghlais, if it comes to that," he said, "though I'll own the fair-ground's the flattest and driest piece of it, which

1. the court of the fair at Muileann òg

2. the charter rule that kept the Fuel-Fitters' rolls to Dia-thìrich

3. the fair road from the capital to Muileann òg

4. the first regiment

is why it's yours the order names first." He had the grace, she thought, to look at his own boots saying it, as though the flatness and dryness of another town's market ground were not a compliment he much enjoyed paying.

"The market's set for the ninth," she said. "There's stalls booked from three towns."

"Then they'll book them somewhere else this year," he said, not unkindly, "or not at all. I've a thousand men and more coming down this road inside the week, and nowhere else in twenty miles flat enough to camp them and near enough water."

She went down herself on the ninth, the day the market should have stood, to see the booths taken down, because it was, she told the justice when he asked why she had not sent a clerk, the kind of thing the court's own book ought to have set down by someone who had seen it rather than been told of it, and she stood at the fair-ground's edge in a wind that had turned from the west that morning and watched men she had known for years, stall-holders and their sons, working under the quartermaster's own soldiers to strike the timber frames that had stood on that ground, some of them, since before her own time at the desk. Fionnlagh Dubh, who had sold ironmongery from the same standing for thirty years and whose father had sold it there before him, took his own frame down with more care than the soldiers gave theirs, numbering each pole with chalk before he stacked it, and told Ùna, passing her with an armful of them, that he supposed he would want the numbers again come spring, though neither of them, standing there, much believed it. Behind him the eel-woman was packing her tub onto a handcart with two of the soldiers lifting the heavier end for her, not unkindly, and further off a boy who sold ribbons and thread from a tray sat on an upturned crate with the tray still on his knees, watching the frames come down around him as though he had not yet decided whether there was any longer a market for a boy to sell ribbons in.

By dusk the ground stood cleared from the toll-house arch to the river bend, a long bare stretch of trampled grass and mud where a fair had stood every market day for longer than the court's own books went back, and the first companies of An treas rèisimeid⁵ came onto it before full dark, pitching their tents in rows where the ironmonger's stall and the eel-woman's tub and the cheese-sellers' shaded row had stood a day before, their fires lit against a cold that Ùna, watching

5. the third regiment

from the toll-house window, thought looked, in the last of the light, very much like any market night the town had ever known, and nothing at all like one.

A' chiad rèisimeid came down the same evening, in better order and, Ùna thought, watching them from the same window, in greater numbers than she had believed a thousand men could be, filling the fair-ground and the water-meadow beyond it and spilling into the lanes above the mill, so that for those nights Muileann òg held more soldiers under canvas than it had held its own people the whole year round. The town's two inns filled with officers and the mill's own loft was given over to stores; a picket stood at the toll-house arch by the second night, civilly enough, and asked her name each morning going up to her own desk as though she had not kept that desk longer than the sentry had been alive, and she gave it each morning without complaint, judging it no great cost against the larger thing the whole camp was asking of the town without asking at all.

She kept Cùirt na Fèille open through it, as the justice bade her, hearing what small business came, a dispute over a strayed cow, a complaint against a soldier who had taken firewood without asking that the regiment's own officer settled before she need write a word of it down, and she watched, from her desk under the window, the road that ran south from the fair-ground toward Muileann ghlais fill and empty and fill again with companies going down to the fields there, where word had it that the column lay, camped in the open on the far side of the river from the town of that name, a day's walk from the capital's own gate and no farther, and showing, by every account that reached the toll-house, no sign of moving on.

She did not go to see it. Enough, she told the justice, watching the fair-ground go, and it was true enough as far as it went, though the truer reason, which she kept to herself, was that she did not want the picture in her own head to stand beside the fair-ground's own emptiness when she came to write the year's closing entry; and by the second week of an Dùbhlachd she knew there would be a closing entry to write, and that it would not read like any before it.

She wrote it on the last evening of the month the market should have run, sitting at the same desk where she had written the last cartload's sale nineteen years before, in the same clear hand, though slower now and with more pauses than that earlier page had needed. She set down the year's takings to the date the order came, which were ordinary enough, and the names of the three towns that had booked stalls and not had them, and the order, copied whole under the council's seal, and then she found, dipping her pen for the line that every year's book before

this one had carried, the plain sum of the market's takings struck and totalled and the court's seal set under it, that she did not know what figure to write, because there had been no market, and a book cannot close on a sum that was never taken.

The pen stayed dry above the page some while. Outside the window the fair-ground's fires burned in their long soldiers' rows where the stalls had stood, and somewhere beyond them, past the river and the low dark shoulder of the land, other fires burned on the fields by Muileann ghlais that she had not gone to see and did not mean to, and the road between the two, Rathad na Fèille her own court's charter took its very name from, lay empty in the last of the light, waiting, though for what, and for how long, and with what end, was no more hers to know, sitting at her own desk with her own dry pen, than it was the miller's wife of Àth bheag's to have known, six weeks and near sixty miles before, watching a column with no banner and no drum go down into the water and up the far bank and on, south, without once turning to look back at the town it left behind it.

In the end she wrote nothing under the year's takings. She ruled the line the court's own form required, and left the space above it blank, and set the year's date under it, and closed the book, and it stands so in the court's own press at Muileann òg to this day: of all the years she has kept the desk, the only one with no closing entry.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

OF Blàr Muileann ghlais

DE 22

First and third regiments on the field. The enemy's dead not counted.

— An Clàr Foscaite, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22

I

Of the Field

The tenth of an Dùbhlachd came up grey and stayed grey, the kind of short northern day that seems to give its light back almost as soon as it has lent it, and by the middle of the morning below Muileann ghlais the frost had not lifted from the furrows so much as thinned, so that the ground under the first and third regiments' boots was neither hard nor soft but something between the two that took a print and held it. The mill town, three hundred souls and a green-slatted roof or two among the thatch, stood a little apart from its own fields that day, its doors shut, its one bell not rung, as if the place had drawn itself in the way a snail draws in its horn at a footstep. Its river, the small one that turned the mill and gave the town half its name, ran high and brown with the autumn's rain, and made, all that morning and into the early afternoon, the only steady sound on the field besides the guns.

An Clàr Foscaite¹, which is what this book must mostly follow here, since the rest is kept from it by an Leabharlann²'s own hand, gives the day in the manner it gives every day of that war: plainly, and without the years the north would spend

1. the open record of the war years

2. the Library at Muileann chaol

telling it over. A' chiad rèisimeid³ held the ground nearest the river, the third the rising ground to its right, where the old byre stood; the column, which the record calls, when it calls it anything, Muinntir gun Siorrachd⁴, held the line of a low bank and a stand of thorn along the field's northern edge, dug in as well as a fortnight's marching and two nights' frost had let them dig. They had come from the western hills the best part of two months before, some four hundred strong at their setting out, fewer by the day they reached the fields at Muileann ghlas, for the road south-east through the middle of the island had cost them men to sickness and to loss of heart in about equal measure, and had cost them, too, whatever hope any of them had carried that the towns they passed would rise and join them. Muileann mhin had sold them bread. Àth bheag had reported them, honestly and at length, to the first clerk of Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁵ its maor could find. No town on the whole of that road had done more than watch them go by and write down what it saw.

The regiments opened the day at first light with the guns, four pieces An treas rèisimeid⁶ had brought down from the capital on Slighe a' Ghuail⁷ and hauled the last two miles by hand through ground too soft for the horses, and An Clàr Foscailte gives their number and not their effect, which is the record's way with most things that would otherwise need a harder word than it cares to spend. What is told in the north, from those who stood near enough to that field to have some right to speak of it, is that the guns found the thorn stand within the first half-hour and did not need to find it twice; that the column's line broke there first, for a stand of thorn on a low bank is no cover at all against a gun that has found its range, whatever the will of the men behind it, and that what held after that held along the bank, in the frozen mud, hand to hand and at close range, through most of the short forenoon. An Clàr Foscailte says only that the field was carried by early afternoon, which is a sentence long enough to hold a great deal of a morning and says nothing of what it holds.

Three-and-twenty of the kingdom's dead were named that week in the register the regiments keep for their own, a list drawn up by a corporal of An treas rèisimeid at a trestle table in the mill itself, with the miller's own ledger turned

3. the first regiment

4. those of no shire, the open record's name for the foes of the Long War

5. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

6. the third regiment

7. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

backward and his account of grain crossed through to make room for it, since no other paper could be found in the town that morning and the corporal, a careful man by the look of his list, would not wait for one to be sent for. Twenty-three names, each with a town beside it and, where it was known, an age, written in a hand that grew smaller as the page filled and the light went, so that the last few names on it are barely legible at all, as if the man writing them had begun, by the end, to write mostly by feel. The column's dead An Clàr Foscailte does not count. Some tried to count them: the regiments' own burial parties, working through what light the short day still had and then by lantern into the evening, are known from a single surviving requisition to have asked the quartermaster for more lime than twenty-three graves would need, a good deal more, and that requisition, filed and answered and forgotten in the ordinary way of requisitions, is the nearest thing An Clàr Foscailte holds to a number for the column's own loss. No number stands in its place. Only the shape one leaves, once it has been taken out of a record and something quieter put where it stood.

The mill changed hands twice before noon, by the surgeon's later account, once when the column drove out a picket A' chiad rèisimeid had set in it before dawn and once when A' chiad rèisimeid took it back with the guns already turned on the byre beyond, and each time the miller's wife, who would not leave her own kitchen for either army, is remembered by the surgeon to have gone on quietly moving her pots and her flour sacks out of whatever corner the fighting had lately occupied and into whatever corner it had lately left, as if the day were no more than an unusually thorough cleaning forced on her by two sets of careless lodgers. She fed the surgeon a bowl of broth some time in the afternoon, without being asked and without, so far as he could tell, distinguishing in her own mind between the man who ate it and the uniform he wore, and this too he has set down since, among the handful of things about that day he found himself still able to speak of plainly.

The colonel of A' chiad rèisimeid, who is not named twice in An Clàr Foscailte and whose own report of the day survives only in the quartermaster's copy of it, wrote that the column had held the bank longer than any force he had faced in two years of the war, and set this down for one reason only, that a commander who does not tell his own council the truth of what he found on a field does that council no service at all; praise the record was never made to give, and he gave none. It is one of perhaps three sentences in the whole open record of the war

that reads as though a man wrote it for himself and not for the file it was put into, and this book has chosen, of the little that record allows it, to keep this one.

This was not the first battle fought below Muileann ghlas. An old man of the town, brought before the regiments' officers that evening to answer for a store of grain they wanted and he was reluctant to give up, told them, when he had given it up and was let go, that his grandmother's grandmother had shown him, as a boy, the low place in the same field where men of Cogadh nam Bràithrean⁸ had fought two centuries and more before, and that the town still called it, in the old way, the taken ground, for a captain of that older war had been taken alive there rather than let escape across the river, which ran the same course then as now. The officer who heard this wrote it down, more from a wish to have something in his own notebook besides the day's dead than from any use he could see in it, and it is by that accident, and no better reason, that the two battles of Muileann ghlas are set beside each other in this book at all. The island's fields do not choose to be fought over twice by design. They are simply not so many, in the end, as its history is long.

By the day's short dusk the guns had stopped, and what remained of the fighting had gone to ground in the mill and the two barns nearest it, where perhaps sixty of the column held out past dark rather than come out into a field the regiments now commanded on every side. A' chiad rèisimeid's colonel, whose name An Clàr Foscailte gives once and not again, sent in word before full dark that any man who came out unarmed would be marched, not shot, to the capital's gaol, and had the word carried by a Tuathach prisoner already taken, under a white cloth tied to a byre-fork, since no one else on the field that evening could be found who both peoples would trust to carry it and bring back an honest answer. The sixty came out a little after full dark, in ones and twos at first and then in a body, into a cold that by then had begun to bite in earnest, and were counted, and searched, and marched under guard to the mill floor for the night, where the regiments' own surgeon, a Dia-thireach of Cathair dhearg two years out of his training and new enough to the work that his hands, by his own account written since, would not stop shaking until well past midnight, did what could be done for wounded of both sides by the light of two lanterns and a banked fire, and made no distinction between them that An Clàr Foscailte, at least, thought worth setting down.

8. the Brothers' War

By the day's end, when the ground had gone from grey to black and the two lanterns in the mill were the only light for a mile in any direction, the surgeon's tally, kept on the back of the same requisition that had asked for the lime, stood at three-and-twenty of the regiments buried or dying and near ninety of the column's wounded brought in, some by their own side before the field was carried and some, after, by the regiments' own burial parties, who are recorded, in a note the surgeon thought worth adding though no one had asked him to, as having carried in the column's hurt with no more roughness than they used on their own, which he set down, he wrote, because he had gone into that day expecting otherwise and had been glad, once, to be wrong.

II

Of the Tellings

This much the north keeps of that day and gives it, as it gives most of its history, from mouth to hearth to grandchild, a telling handed on at the turn of the year when the fire is banked and the youngest in the house has been let stay up past its hour for once, the teller beginning, as often as not, with some such plain word as *my sister stood on that ground*, which is a kind of proof An Clàr Foscailte¹ cannot offer and does not try to.

What is told in the north of that day begins, in nearly every version this book has been able to gather, with the frost before it begins with the guns, for it was the cold, the tellers say, that the column felt first and longest, two nights of it in the open with fires kept low or not kept at all for fear of what a fire on that flat ground would show the regiments below. A woman of Cnoc thais, who was a girl of sixteen on that column and carried a message twice between the bank and the byre before the guns opened, has told it more than once since to her own people, and it has been taken down, in the north's own way, by more than one hand since: that the last night before the battle the column sang, low and by turns, company after company. It may have served them for courage, she allows, though that was never her own reason for it: a body that is singing cannot easily be heard to be afraid, she says, and there were children on that field, brought by mothers

1. the open record of the war years

and fathers who had nowhere else on the whole island to leave them, and the singing was as much for the children's sake as for the men's.

The tellings give the column's leader a name An Clàr Foscailte never once sets down: Owen Barrow, a man of the west hills who is said, in the tellings, to have walked the whole line himself in the last hour before first light, speaking to every company by name and by name to a good number of the men and women in each of them, and to have said, to more than one teller's memory, much the same short thing each time, that the hills were behind them now and could not be walked back to before the guns found them on open ground either way, and that a man who has come this far owes it to himself to be found, if he is to be found at all, facing the way he came and not the other. Whether he said any such thing, or said it in those words, this book cannot know and does not pretend to; what it can say is that the saying is told the same way in three towns that have, so far as the record shows, had no occasion to agree it between them, which is as much as the north's own memory usually offers by way of proof, and more than it often troubles to give.

Of the fighting the tellings are, in their way, both more and less than An Clàr Foscailte. They are less because no teller who was in the thorn stand when the guns found it has left more than a handful of words about it at all; the girl of Cnoc thais, asked directly, by her own mother among others, what it had been like, answered only that it had been loud, and then quiet, and that she did not care to say more; and that this is the whole of her answer every time she has been asked it since is a kind of telling in its own right, though not one that fits easily into a book. They are more because they keep, where An Clàr Foscailte does not, the names of those who did not come back from the bank and the thorn: not all of them, for the fighting scattered families as well as companies and not every name found its way home to be kept. A good many did, kept in the way the north keeps its dead, spoken at firesides and at the turn of the year, without a stone to hold them and without, until this book, any page in the kingdom's own record to be spoken in.

It is told, too, of the byres, where the sixty held out past dark, that among them was a boy of no more than fourteen who had carried water to the thorn stand all that morning rather than carry arms, being thought too young for arms even by a column that had by then grown short of grown men to bear them, and that when the white cloth went up on the byre-fork it was the boy who asked, of the man beside him, whether the marching to the capital's gaol that the colonel's

word had promised them was truly better than staying where they were, and was told, by the same man, that a boy who lives to ask a foolish question in a gaol has done better for himself than one who dies asking a wise one in a field, which the tellers offer, more often than not, without further comment, as if the answer needed none. The boy is not named in any telling this book has found. Whether he lived out that winter in the capital's gaol, or after it, this book cannot say, and no teller in the north has claimed to know.

III

Of the Roads Home

Word of the field reached the western hills before the wounded did, carried by men who had broken from the fighting early enough to run and had run without stopping, by the tellers' own account, for the better part of two days on tracks the regiments did not know to watch. It found, in the hills, not an army so much as what an army leaves behind it when the greater part of it has already marched away to be broken elsewhere: old men and women who had kept the last of the flocks through two summers of war, a scatter of the sick and the maimed too far gone to walk south with the column in the autumn, and here and there a handful still under arms, holding a pass or a spring that no one on either side had thought worth fighting over directly, because it fed a dozen families and not a regiment.

To these the news came, in every telling this book has gathered, without argument attached to it. No one is remembered to have proposed holding the hills a season longer, or waiting for a spring that might bring the column's survivors back to them, or sending word south to ask what terms, if any, the regiments would give. What is remembered is simpler and, in its way, harder to set down plainly: that within a matter of days, in ones and twos and small parties, without much speech between them and none at all, so far as any telling says, with the regiments, the last of the hills' people came down out of the high ground and along the Àth leathan road to where An seachdamh rèisimeid¹ had kept its posts through two summers of a war it had spent mostly waiting, watching a road that had, until that week, carried very little for it to watch.

1. the seventh regiment

An seachdamh rèisimeid's own return for those days, which survives in full where a great deal else of the war's paperwork does not, is a document of a particular kind: a list, kept post by post along the road, of those who came down, their town where it could be got from them, and the arms, if any, they carried and surrendered, drawn up by the post's own sergeant in a hand a good deal steadier than the corporal's list at Muileann ghlas, for An seachdamh rèisimeid's war had been, whatever else it had been, a long watch on a quiet road rather than a morning of guns and dead by a river, and the men who kept it had time, that week, to do the counting properly. The weapons came in a strange mixture even for a war that had, by its last year, armed itself from whatever could be found: fowling pieces older than any man then living, two or three rifles of a pattern the regiment's own quartermaster did not recognise and noted as such, pikes made in the first months of the trouble from scythe blades and ash poles, and, from more than one post's list, nothing at all, for a good number of those who came down that week had carried no arms in the first place and had followed the column, or stayed in the hills that kept it fed, without ever once being asked to fight.

Among those who came down to the northernmost post on the second of those days was a man of Cnoc thais, past sixty by his own reckoning and lame in one leg from an old fall down a shaft years before the war, who had carried no weapon at all and told the sergeant so before he was asked, and who had with him, on a rope halter, the one cow his family had kept through two summers of soldiers moving over their ground, on the plain reasoning, as he gave it to the sergeant and the sergeant set down more or less word for word, that a man might be let go home with an empty rope and starve there just as surely as he might be shot for coming down armed, and that he had thought it worth the asking either way. The sergeant let him through with the cow, noted the exchange in full, being, as his list shows throughout, a man who set down more than his orders strictly required of him, and added nothing further, though this book, reading his hand now, finds in that one unnecessary sentence more of the war's true cost, and more of its end, than in a page of the guns' account from Muileann ghlas.

They were disarmed at the posts, searched, and sent home rather than to the capital's gaol, as the sixty from the byres had been, to whatever the hills' towns still had standing for them, which in more than one case, Muileann àrsaidh chief among them, was not a great deal. An seachdamh rèisimeid's sergeant at the northernmost post, whose own list this book has followed more than any other for the plainness of its hand, noted at the foot of his last page, after the final name

was entered and the last weapon counted, that no more had come down the road since noon of that day, and that he took this to mean the counting was done. It is the whole of his comment on the matter, and it is, so far as An Clàr Foscailte² allows this book to say, very nearly the last entry made anywhere on the island in the name of An Cogadh Fada³, which had begun on a bitter morning at Àth leathan nearly two years before, and ended, as such things end, with a sergeant deciding, on the evidence of an empty road, that there was nothing left for him to count.

IV

Of Somhairle After

Somhairle mac Lachlainn was not himself at Muileann ghlas that day. He had commanded the regiments from the capital through the better part of that autumn, by then, at a table in a room Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹ had given over to him near Slighe a' Ghuail²'s own offices, and An Clàr Foscailte³'s silence on his own movements through those two years, a silence this book has met before and will meet again, holds here as everywhere else: what he did in the rooms where the war was made this book cannot tell, because the record of it went into Ciste-chuimhne Dhùinte⁴ with the rest, and the man himself, in the years since, has kept to it as closely as an Leabharlann⁵ does.

He would say, in the one account of that day this book has found written down, given since the peace, that he had heard the guns were done at Muileann ghlas from a clerk who came into his room without knocking, an hour or so past the short day's dusk, and that his first thought on hearing it, before any other, had been for Slighe a' Ghuail's timetable, whether the wounded could be got up to the capital that same night or would have to wait for morning, and that it was some while later, sitting alone in that room with the lamp burned low, before he let himself think of the day in any other terms at all. This is the whole of what he is

2. the open record of the war years

3. the Long War

1. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

2. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

3. the open record of the war years

4. the Library's sealed war archive

5. the Library at Muileann chaol

remembered to have said of it, told to a councillor since, who set it down more or less as he heard it, and it is offered here for one reason: it is the nearest this book can come to Somhairle's own voice on the one day of the war that ended it, and because a man who spent two years commanding a war from a room he never once, by his own account, thought to leave, is entitled to be heard, at least, on what it was he thought about when word came that the room's work was done.

He was given a seat on the council the following year, the first soldier so honoured since An Dealachadh⁶, and he sat in it, by every account this book has, without once speaking of Muileann ghlas from that chair, nor of Àth leathan before it, nor of any of the two years between. What he did instead, in the first weeks of that peace, by his own clerk's later account, was to have Slighe a' Ghuail's schedule for the wounded checked twice against the surgeons' own returns, to be certain that no man carried north that winter had been carried on a train meant for something else. It is a small thing to be remembered for, out of two years of war; it is the thing this book has found, and a chronicle that has so little else of the man cannot afford to leave it out.

So ended An Cogadh Fada⁷, twenty months from the bitter morning at Àth leathan to the sergeant's empty road, and it left behind it, standing to this day, nine regiments and four fleets, each carrying still the name of the town where it was first raised, whether or not that town had cause, before the war, to think of itself as a soldiering place at all. It left behind, too, a mill at Muileann ghlas with a floor that had held both armies' wounded in one night and a miller's wife who is not remembered to have spoken of it again to any stranger who asked; a corporal's list, twenty-three names long, kept afterward at the capital and copied onto a stone the following year; and a requisition for lime that outlived, by the accident of a filing clerk's carelessness, every grander paper the war produced, and says, to anyone who reads it rightly, more than most of them do.

At Caol mhòr, in the days after, where word of the field reached the harbour before it reached most of the north by any road, an old Tuathach standing at the fish quay with the news new in his ears is remembered, by more than one who was there, to have said, to no one in particular and to everyone near enough to hear him, that they had got long-warred, chaidh am fadachadh, meaning it, the tellers agree, as a joke against his own people and no one else's, for a fadachadh is what the north calls the waiting a fisherman does for a boat that is not coming

6. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

7. the Long War

back, drawn out past all sense until the waiting becomes the thing remembered, longer than whatever it was waiting for. He said it, by every account, as a man says a thing he has said before about smaller griefs and finds, to his own surprise, still fits a larger one. Those near him on the quay that day are not remembered to have laughed, then or after, though the saying has been carried the length of the north since, and is said still, of any hope held too long past the day it was worth holding, always as a jest, and never, in this book's hearing, by anyone who laughed while they said it.

Of the Stations Kept

DE 23

Part Seven: Of Peace

Leigeadh leis bàsachadh. Allowed to die.

— Tional nan Tuathach's minute on Tagradh na h-Èirig, DE 25

I

Of the Capping

The council did not stand the regiments down, and Somhairle mac Lachlainn, reading the minute that said so in the first week of am Faoilleach, understood before he had finished it why the thing had been done, and understood also that no one in the room where it was decided would ever say the reason aloud. A regiment sent home was a regiment that had to be raised again from nothing if the hills gave any more trouble than a farmer's grumbling, and raising nine regiments once had cost the kingdom the better part of two years and more men than An Clàr Foscailte¹ cared to total in one place; keeping them, at their own stations, on Deachamh a' Chogaidh² that had been laid on every barrel of dubhan sold since the second month of the fighting, cost a line in An t-Ionmhas³'s book and nothing else that anyone in that room was minded to count. The tithe had been called, when it was laid, a thing for the war's sake and for a time only. Somhairle had heard the phrase often enough that winter, from men who

1. the open record of the war years

2. the wartime tithe

3. the Treasury

plainly believed it and from men who as plainly did not, to know by now which kind of man was speaking by the speed with which he said it.

He kept, that first spring of the peace, to the rooms near Slighe a' Ghuail⁴'s own offices that Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁵ had given him through the war and had not yet asked back, and it was there, at a table too large for the papers he had to put on it, that the reports of the western seams first came to him, forwarded by Fearghas mac Aonghais, master of Comhairle nam Mèinnean at Cathair mhòr, with a covering note two lines long: the seams were An Crùn⁶'s by Breith Leòid⁷, as Comhairle nam Mèinnean had declared them five years before, the holders had stopped paying when Comhairle nam Mèinnean stopped carrying, and Comhairle nam Mèinnean saw no profit and considerable risk in leaving open ground that had lately held an army. The order that followed asked for nothing subtler than concrete and men enough to pour it, and An seachdamh rèisimeid⁸, quartered at the western Seann Skell since before the fighting began and idle now in a way that Somhairle suspected its own colonel found harder to bear than the siege had been, was given the men.

He went himself to the first of the cappings, at Àth leathan, in am Màrt, for no better reason he could have given anyone than that he had commanded the taking of the ground and felt it owed him, or he it, the seeing of what came after. The pit-head stood much as the battle had left it, the winding-gear still up though the wheel no longer turned, the spoil-heaps gone green at their lower slopes with the first of the year's grass and black and bare higher up where nothing had yet had time to take. A company of the seventh worked the shaft mouth with barrows and a mixer brought up from the western Seann Skell on a lorry that ran, as every lorry on the island now ran, on the fuel a Tuathach had made two-and-twenty years before at a fire he had banked in the dark for reasons the record did not give and Somhairle, standing at the shaft's edge with the smell of the wet mix in his throat, found he did not much want to guess at either. The concrete went down grey and thick and, poured, lay still in a way that struck him, watching it, as unlike the seam it covered, which even flooded had never once in the whole history of the pit lain entirely still.

4. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

5. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

6. the Crown

7. the Leòid ruling

8. the seventh regiment

A sergeant of the seventh, a broad man named Iain Mòr who had held Freiceadan Àth leathan's ground since the last month of the war, stood by him at the shaft's mouth and told him, without being asked, that this was the fourth such capping his company had stood by that month, the others at Muileann àr-saidh, at Cnoc thais, and at a smaller working near Àth naomh that had never had a name outside its own valley. "Tobar dhearg of the hills we've still to do," he said, "and after that there'll be nothing left in the west for a man to be sent to guard, unless the council finds him something new to guard." He did not say this bitterly. He said it the way a man reports weather, a fact to be noted and then let go, and Somhairle, who had by then spent the better part of two years learning to hear what a soldier did not say along with what he did, understood that Iain Mòr had already begun, in his own mind, to wonder what An seachdamh rèisimeid was for, now that the war it had been raised to fight had ended and the ground it had fought over was being filled in under his own boots.

Word came to him that same week of a small matter from the eastern side of the island that had nothing to do with the west at all and everything to do with what the peace was already turning into: Caol ruadh, whose harbour had fed the garrisons and An dàrna cabhlach¹⁰ through both years of the fighting with more salt fish and biscuit than any town its size had ever been asked to victual before, had been granted, by a council minute so short Somhairle read it twice to be sure he had not missed a clause, a market right of its own for the strait below it. It was the sixteenth town so chartered on the island and, the minute noted in its last line, as if the fact carried some weight worth setting down, the last that would be. Somhairle, who had never in his life had cause to think about market charters one way or the other, found himself thinking of it now chiefly as a kind of book-keeping: the kingdom settling its accounts with the towns that had fed the war, town by town, in whatever coin came cheapest to it, a charter here, a contract there, nothing that could not be filed and forgotten once given.

By the month's end the last of the western workings that were not Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own was capped, and Fearghas mac Aonghais's office at Cathair mhòr sent out, without much ceremony, a further note that the trade in coal-fuel, outside what Comhairle nam Mèinnean itself still cut for its own account at An Sloc Mòr¹¹, was at an end on the island; no law had ever been troubled to forbid it;

9. the Àth leathan post, the seventh regiment's post on the road below Àth leathan

10. the second fleet

11. the great pit at the mountain

it ended all the same, the way a road empties when, at last, nowhere along it is left that anyone still wants to go. An Sloc Mòr's own galleries were named nowhere in the note, and Somhairle understood the omission for what it was: a mine close enough to the capital for Comhairle nam Mèinnean to keep an eye on it directly was one matter, and the western hills, a two days' ride from anyone minded to ask an awkward question, had plainly been another.

Somhairle read that note at his own table with the lamp lit, for the days were still short, and found his thoughts turning, for reasons he did not examine closely, away from the western pits and toward the poorer streets of the capital as he had last walked them as a young man newly with Comhairle nam Mèinnean, dark from the lamp-houses' rationing, and of how thoroughly, in the years since, that darkness had been undone by the very fuel that had just finished undoing the last of the trade it replaced. Every lamp in the capital now burned on dubhan, every lorry and every engine of Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn¹² besides, and a man could go the length of the island, he supposed, and not find so much as a coal fire outside a smith's forge or Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own hearths, and yet no council minute, so far as he had read, had ever once said in plain words that lighting, moving and warming the whole kingdom on dubhan was now simply how things stood; it had become true the way the western seams had become quiet, by a hundred small orders that never once named the whole of what they added up to. He wrote nothing of this thought down. It was not the kind a report had room for.

II

Of the Boundary Stones

Martha Greaves had sat as speaker of Tìonal nan Tuathach¹ long enough by then to have learned that most of what came to her desk in a given month could be answered by a clerk, and that the little which could not was, in the end, simply lived through and not answered at all; so that when the letter came in an t-Iuchar from the capital's gaol, by way of the council's own office and not, as everything else from that quarter usually came, by way of Com-

12. the Rail Board; lit. 'the board of the iron way'

1. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

hairle nam Mèinnean², she read it twice before she understood that this was neither kind, and that it would want, of her, more than a signature.

The letter said that the holdouts taken at Muileann ghlas the Dùbhlachd before, some four score of them who had come out of the byres unarmed on the promise A' chiad rèisimeid³'s colonel had given them that night, were to be released and sent north under guard, as far as the boundary stones, where they would be handed over to whatever authority the shires beyond chose to send to meet them. It named a day. It did not say what the men and the handful of women among them were to do once handed over, nor who, if anyone, was to feed them on the road, nor whether their own towns, most of them long since walled with spoil and flooded, would know what to make of men coming home a year and more after the fighting they had left them in had ended. Martha read all this standing at her own window with the letter in her hand, and then sat down and wrote to Peter Hale, who had carried the rebound minute-books through half the war on his own back and had earned, she thought, more say in how Tional nan Tuathach's part of this ended than any other man in Caol mhòr, asking him to come north with her to the stones.

They went down the northern road in a hired carriage, on a morning with the first real heat of the year in it, the kind of morning that in another year would have had the hill farms turning hay and did that year too, Martha noted from the carriage window, as if the land had not been told a war had passed over it. The boundary stones stood where they had always stood, set some ninety years before at An Dealachadh⁴ and never once, in all that time, moved by so much as a foot, low grey markers a man could sit on and often did, worn smooth on their upper faces by generations of shepherds waiting out a shower. A company of A' chiad rèisimeid was drawn up on the southern side of them when Martha and Peter arrived, and beyond, on the northern side, a scatter of Tuathaich had already gathered, word of the day having travelled ahead of the letter by roads the council's own office never troubled to use.

The prisoners came up the road on foot, in a column no longer than the fourth part of a mile, and Martha, watching them come, found she had braced herself for men marked by a year's close keeping in a way that none of them, when they were near enough to see plainly, quite were; thinner, most of them, and

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

3. the first regiment

4. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

slower on their feet than men of their years should have been, but walking under their own strength and looking, more than anything else, like men who had stopped some time before expecting to be looked at as anything worse than tired. The colonel in charge read out a paper at the stones that said, in the dry way such papers said everything that year, that these were released on the council's order and were Tional nan Tuathach's charge from this point north; and it was at that word, charge, that Martha understood what her own part in the day was to be, and stepped forward with the register she had brought up from Caol mhòr in her own bag rather than trust it to a clerk.

Tional nan Tuathach had kept, since An Dealachadh, one long list of its dead and its maimed, added to every year the war or the pits or the fever took a name from the north, and it was to the foot of this list, in a fresh column ruled that morning by Peter's own hand because no other paper in the party would serve, that Martha now added, one by one, as each man or woman came forward and gave a name and a town, the names of those who had gone into the byres at Muileann ghlas and come out again. She wrote plainly, town beside name as the corporal's list of the regiments' own dead had been written the Dùbhlachd before, though she did not know that list existed and would not, this book must say, ever come to read it; and more than one of those who gave her their name that morning gave, along with it, some further word she had not asked for and set down anyway, because it seemed to her wrong to take a name and refuse whatever the man attached to it, that morning of all mornings, wanted said with it. A woman of Cnoc thais gave her son's name and then, unbidden, the words he is not among these, meaning that her son had not come out of the byres at all, and Martha wrote both the name given and, beside it in a smaller hand, the four words, because she judged, rightly or not, that the register would be a poorer thing without them.

Peter Hale stood at her shoulder through the whole of it and said little, though Martha noticed, more than once, that his own pen had gone still over the page at a name he seemed to recognise, and it was only afterward, on the carriage south, that he told her the fourth man to come up had been apprenticed, before the trouble began, to the same binder at Muileann leathan whose old pupils had rebound Tional nan Tuathach's minute-books at Daniel Frayne's dying wish, fifteen years before, and that the man had not known him, or had known him and chosen, that morning, not to say so. "I could not have said which," Peter told her, "so I let it go unasked. It did not seem a morning for asking a man to remember

more of himself than he had already been asked to give up that day." Martha thought this the truest thing said to her the whole of that summer, and told him so, and neither of them spoke of it again.

Not every man who came up the road that morning gave his name readily. One, older than most, stood some while before the register without speaking at all, and Martha, who had by then learned in her years as speaker not to press a silence that might yet fill on its own, waited with her pen lifted until he said, at last, that his name would mean nothing written down beside a town that no longer stood in any shape a name could be sent back to, Muileann àrsaidh having been, by the last report she had herself read, more spoil-heap than street by the war's end; and Martha told him, as truly as she knew how, that the town would stand again in whatever shape its own people chose to build it in, register or no register, but that the register would hold his name either way, against the day it did. He gave it then, and his town with it, and walked on north without waiting to hear whether she believed her own answer, which she was not, in fact, entirely sure she did.

By the time the last name was taken the sun stood well past noon, and the released men and women had already begun, in ones and twos, to go north past the stones under no guard at all, A' chiad rèisimeid's company having no order to do more than see them handed over and no great wish, that Martha could see, to linger on a road that led nowhere its own men wanted to walk. She closed the register at last with some four score names added to its foot, a column of its own beside the long column the war before this one had begun, and rode back to the carriage with Peter beside her and the book on her knee, and found, somewhere on that road south, that she could not have said with any confidence whether the day had been a mercy or only the last administrative act of a war that had run, by then, so long past any single act's power to end it that mercy and book-keeping had come, in practice, to look much the same thing.

III

Of the Seat and the Post

The council's summons to Somhairle came in an Lùnastal, three lines on a single sheet, inviting him to take a seat among the twelve at the next sitting after harvest, and he read it, when it came, with less surprise than he

thought a man ought to feel at being asked to sit among the twelve who had, for two years, decided from a room he had never once been admitted to what his own regiments were to do and where. He had commanded a war, by then, longer than most of the twelve had held their own seats, and it occurred to him, folding the letter and setting it under the ink-stand for want of anywhere better to keep it, that a soldier given a seat on the council was less an honour done to the soldier than an insurance the council was taking out against its own next reckoning, so that the next war, should the island ever raise another, would be made by men who had at least once stood close enough to a field to know what the word cost in more than coin. He did not refuse it, having not, by then, refused much that the council had asked of him in three years, and saw no cause to begin with the one thing it offered rather than demanded.

The autumn sitting seated him, the first soldier to hold a chair there since the captains of Cogadh nam Beann¹, whose own names, he had occasion to remember, he had himself read aloud from the council's chests not two years before to raise the very regiments he now, as a councillor, would help to keep or stand down. He said little at that first sitting, by his own later account, chiefly because the twelve about him, Anna nic Phàil among them, spoke that day mostly of the harvest tithe and Slighe a' Ghuail²'s autumn schedule and other matters a soldier had no particular fitness to weigh, and he judged it wiser, in a room he did not yet know the temper of, to listen a full season before he ventured a view the others might have cause to remember against him.

Anna nic Phàil was the one member of the twelve who spoke to him directly that day, catching him at the chamber door as the sitting broke, to say, without much preamble, that she had sat among the twelve an Nollaig³ three years before when Martha Greaves carried Athchuinge Dheireannach an Tionail⁴ into that same room, and had voted, since, for every small mercy the council's own business allowed her to move, and meant to go on doing so, and thought a man who had commanded the regiments ought to know it before he had sat among them long enough to suppose the room held only the twelve kinds of silence he had likely met there that first day. Somhairle thanked her and said little more, less from want of an answer than because he had not yet decided, in his own mind, which of the

1. the War of the Hills, called also the Severance war

2. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

3. Christmas

4. the Moot's last petition

twelve kinds of silence he had in fact met that morning was hers, and did not think it a courtesy to guess wrong to her face on the first day of their both sitting there.

An seachdamh rèisimeid⁵, meanwhile, having capped the last of the western seams by midsummer, was set that autumn to a work of its own choosing rather than the council's, though the council's leave was asked and given readily enough: a post of stone and timber on the road below Àth leathan, at the crossing where the holdouts had once formed on the morning of the battle, built by the regiment's own hands over six weeks with materials carted up from the western Seann Skell. It went into the regimental returns under the plain name the lists had used from the first order that raised it, Freiceadan Àth leathan⁶, and Somhairle, reading that return at his own table in the same room where he had once read the order to march on the town, found that the name sat oddly with him, a name so exactly what the thing was, a post kept at Àth leathan, that it told a reader nothing at all of what had been fought for on that ground or what had been lost taking it.

He learned, from a report of Iain Mòr's some weeks later, that the town itself, the four-and-thirty souls who had come back to what was left of it since the pits were flooded, called the post something else, though the report did not say what, Iain Mòr having judged, in his own words, that it was not a soldier's business to carry a name like that back to his own colonel to be entered anywhere the council might one day read it. Somhairle did not press him for it. He had learned, in three years, to recognise the shape of a thing a man had decided not to tell him, and had learned, too, that pressing rarely got him more than a different silence dressed as an answer; and there was, besides, some part of him, which he did not examine too closely that autumn any more than he had examined the thought at the capping in am Màrt, that judged the town's own name for the post, whatever it was, none of the council's proper concern, and least of all his own, now that he sat among the twelve who might, given the chance, ask him to have it struck from every mouth that used it.

IV

Of the Stone and the Sown Field

5. the seventh regiment

6. the Àth leathan post, the seventh regiment's post on the road below Àth leathan

The plough had gone into the field at Muileann ghlas that same spring, while Somhairle was still watching concrete settle at Àth leathan and Martha had not yet had the letter from the gaol, for the farmer who held the ground, a broad quiet man named Aonghas mac Phàdraig who had worked that field and his father's before him, saw no reason a battle fought on it once should keep it from feeding his own house a second winter running, and turned the first furrow in am Màrt as he had turned it every spring of his life. He found the first of the iron before the furrow was half done, a bayonet gone to rust, turned up whole and lying across the share as if it had been laid there rather than buried, and he stood some while over it, by his own account given afterward to more than one neighbour, before he judged there was nothing to be done but finish the furrow and carry the thing home at the day's end, which he did, and gave it, some weeks later, to a corporal of A' chiad rèisimeid¹ who came through the district collecting rents on Comhairle nam Mèinnean²'s account and had, it turned out, no better notion than Aonghas himself of what ought to be done with a rusted bayonet turned up by a plough, but took it anyway and entered it, for want of any other heading that suited, on a list he kept for exactly such things. The corporal has kept that list since, adding to it each season as Aonghas and his sons turn up more of the same, a bayonet, a broken rifle stock, once a whole cartridge box gone green with the years in the ground, and no two men who ever saw that list agreed, when asked, on what it was truly a record of: the dead, who could not be counted any other way, or only the ground, giving back, in its own slow time, what two armies had once been in too great a hurry to stop and gather.

Clach nan Rèisimeidean³ was raised in an Dùbhlachd, a year to the week since the battle it named, beside the market cross that Taigh Mhic Ùisdein⁴ had kept at the town's centre for longer than anyone now living could say, and Somhairle, seated by then among the twelve, was asked, as the regiments' own councillor, to stand at its unveiling and read the names cut into it aloud before the town. He had not sought the office. He had not, if the truth were told, much wanted it, having spent two years reading rolls of names in halls and camps and once, at Muileann ghlas itself by report only, at a trestle table turned to a desk by a corporal with no other paper to hand, and finding each reading harder than the last

1. the first regiment

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

3. the stone of the regiments' dead at Cathair mhòr; lit. 'the stone of the regiments'

4. the house of Mac Ùisdein

rather than easier, as he had once supposed such things grew with use. But the council had asked it of him as it had asked the seat, and he had learned by then which of the council's askings a man in his place could safely decline, and this, he judged, standing before the stone in the cold with the town's whole population, or near it, gathered in the square before him, was not among them.

The stone bore one-and-sixty names, eight-and-thirty of Àth leathan and three-and-twenty of Muileann ghlas, cut in two columns under a single heading that gave neither battle nor date but only, in the plainest words the mason's letter to the council had proposed and the council had accepted without change, the regiments' dead. Somhairle read them from a paper copy rather than from the stone itself, the light being poor and his own eyes, he supposed, no longer what they had been at thirty, and read them slowly, town by town as the corporal's list and the sergeant's return had first set them down, a boy of Cathair mhòr's own western quarter, two brothers of Seann Bhrál who had enlisted together and died, the return noted, within the same hour of the same morning, a man of Inis mhòr old enough to have a grown son of his own already serving in the same company. The square kept a silence through the whole of the reading that Somhairle, listening to his own voice fall into it name after name, found harder to bear than any noise the crowd might have made instead, for a silence like that asked nothing of him and gave him, in return, nothing to answer, only the sound of his own voice going on alone until the last name was said and there was, for one long moment before anyone in the square moved or spoke, nothing left to read.

He stood a while longer at the stone after the crowd had begun to break up and go home to its own suppers, the paper still in his hand, and thought, as he had half expected he would from the moment the council first asked him to do the reading, less of the one-and-sixty names he had just given back their voices for the length of a winter afternoon than of the others the stone did not carry and never would: the column's own dead, buried in more lime than three-and-twenty graves could need and never once counted by any hand An Clàr Foscailte⁵ trusted; the sixty who had come out of the byres and gone, some of them, into the register Martha Greaves had carried up to the boundary stones that summer with four words written beside one name that was not, in the end, among those released; a woman's son of Cnoc thais who was not among these, and whose own stone, if his mother ever raised one, would stand nowhere the council's own mason had

5. the open record of the war years

been asked to cut, in a field or a chapel yard An Clàr Foscailte had no occasion ever to visit. Sixty-one names were a great many to read aloud in one winter afternoon, and Somhairle, folding the paper at last and turning for Slighe a' Ghuail⁶'s carriage that would carry him home to the capital and the twelve who waited there to hear how the unveiling had gone, found that the number staying with him longest, walking away from the stone in the last of that short day's light, was the one no mason on the island had yet been asked, or would ever be asked, to cut anywhere at all, and never the one already cut into it.

6. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

Of the Sealed Room

DE 24

Let the whole record of the war be shut against every reader for fifty
years, and let the keeper hold the one key.
— the council's order, am Faoilleach, DE 24

I

Of the Key

The order came up to Muileann chaol in the first days of am Faoilleach, carried by a rider who had changed horses twice at Àth dhomhain and once more at the ford, and who told Ragnall mac Mhuirich, handing it over on the doorstep of the old building with the snow still on his shoulders, that he had been given no leave to wait for an answer, only to see it delivered and ridden back. Ragnall read it standing in the doorway, in the cold, because the rider would not come in out of it, and read it a second time at his own desk before he sent for Sileas.

It was four lines long and said what it meant to say without any of the softening a council's clerk usually gives an order of that kind. The whole record of An Cogadh Fada¹, from the first muster to the last, was to be put out of the reach of every reader, of whatever office or standing, for fifty years from that day. A room was to be found for it in an Leabharlann²'s own keeping, and the key was to be held by the keeper and by no one else, and the keeper was to answer to the council, and to no reader, for what was done with it. There was no reason given. There

1. the Long War

2. the Library at Muileann chaol

never is, in an order of the council's own hand; the reasons, when there are any set down at all, go in a minute Tional nan Tuathach³'s own clerks never see and this book may not read.

Raghnall had kept an Leabharlann five-and-twenty years by then, and had seen, in that time, one chronicler lay the office down and another take it up, and he read the order through twice and said, when he had finished, only that it was the first time in the kingdom's whole history that any part of the record had been shut against its own chronicler, and that he did not think Ailean Leabhar, who had said once that an Leabharlann settles nothing and only keeps, would have thought much of the distinction the council's clerk had just drawn between keeping a thing and keeping it from a reader.

"He said it settles nothing," Sileas said. "Only keeps."

"He never foresaw an order asking an Leabharlann to keep a thing from its own reading-room."

She asked him, because there was as yet no clerk of her own in the room to ask it in her stead, whether he meant to argue the order, and he said no, in the same flat voice he had read it aloud in, and when she asked why not, since he had argued smaller things with the council before and won, he told her that a keeper who argued an order of this kind risked being answered with a second order naming a different keeper, and that he had rather keep the room himself, badly if it came to that, than hand the key to some clerk of the council's own choosing who might not trouble to keep it at all. She had no answer to that, and did not try to make one; she only asked, before she left his room, whether she might at least be told who at the council's table had proposed the sealing, and he said he did not know, and that the order, as she had already seen, gave no name for anything, not the reason, not the proposer, not even, in its own four lines, the war it meant.

There was a room at the end of the new wing's lower gallery that had held nothing for years but the broken binding-press nobody had troubled to carry down to the smith, and a scatter of tallow ends, and the smell, in wet weather, of the river coming up through the stone. Raghnall had it cleared in a day, the press dragged out and the tallow swept up and burned, and a mason sent for from the town to fit a door of oak two inches thick where a plank door had stood since the wing was built, with a lock the smith made new to no other key in the kingdom. It took the mason and the smith between them the better part of a week, working

3. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

through the worst of the month's weather with a brazier for warmth and their breath standing white in the room even so, and Ragnall stood over the fitting of the lock himself on the last morning, because he judged, he told Sileas afterward, that a thing built to keep a secret from the whole kingdom for fifty years deserved at least one pair of eyes on it who meant to keep the secret honestly and not merely competently.

Sileas brought her own record to the door on the appointed morning herself, and would let no clerk carry it for her. It was the fuller record she had kept beside the open chronicle since the first year of the war, four boxes of it by then, close-written and cross-referenced in her own hand, everything An Clàr Foscailte⁴ left out set down in it as plainly as she had been able to set anything down while the war still ran: the regiments' movements she had not been let publish, the numbers of the column's dead that the corporal's requisition for lime had only hinted at and that she had gone back afterward and tried, as honestly as the surviving papers allowed, to reckon for herself; three letters from Doire ghlais that Ellen Marsh had sent her under seal and asked her to keep rather than print, because the families named in them were still living and had not asked to be read by strangers; a single page, unsigned, that had come to her by a hand she never learned, setting out what a boy of the western hills had told a stranger at a market about the last night before Muileann ghlais, which she had judged too near the tellings and too far from proof to put in any chronicle bearing an Leabharlann's own name, and had kept anyway, because she judged also that a thing might be true and still unfit to print, and that a chronicler's business was to keep both kinds and know which was which.

She had carried the four boxes up from her own room herself, one at a time, on the two days before, and set them just inside the new door, and on the morning of 14 am Faoilleach, DE 24, she stood in the doorway a while before she went in to lay the last of her own working papers on top of them, not because she doubted what she had decided to give up, she said afterward, but because a woman does not often get to stand at the door of the one room in the kingdom built to keep her own hand's work from her, and she thought it worth a moment's looking before she went in and did it.

Ragnall turned the key himself, in the new lock, with the smith and the mason gone and no one else in the gallery to see it done. It was a plain iron key,

4. the open record of the war years

longer than most, and it turned with a sound neither of them had thought to ask the smith to make quieter, a single hard click that ran the length of the stone gallery and came back to them off the old wing's far wall before it died. Ragnall put the key on its own cord round his own neck, under his shirt, and has worn it there since, by every account this book has found, and he has been seen, more than once, by copyists who worked late enough to see him lock the reading-room for the night, to lay his hand flat against his own chest for a moment before he blew out the last lamp, as a man does who is making sure of something he has already made sure of a hundred times before and cannot quite stop checking.

II

Of the List She Was Allowed

What stayed open, when the door had been shut on the rest, was less than a chronicler of thirteen years at the desk might have wished to keep and more, Sileas has told her own clerk since, than she had expected the council to leave her. Three things: a list of the places the war had touched, town by town and post by post, with no number of dead set against any of them; a list of the regiments and fleets present at each place, by name and by date; and the counts she had already been permitted to give in the open chronicle before the order came, which stood as they stood and were not called back, though nothing was to be added to them from that day.

It was a narrow allowance, and Sileas kept to the letter of it with a care her own clerk, a girl of nineteen new to the copying that winter, found at first hard to understand, since the girl could see for herself, reading the open list over Sileas's shoulder some months into the work, that the same list, read carefully enough by a reader who already knew the places and the regiments both, told a good deal more than its own bare columns seemed to say. Sileas did not deny it. She told the girl, the one time the girl asked her outright, that the council had shut the drawer, not the shape of the room the drawer stood in, and that a chronicler who kept an honest list of places and regiments, and let a reader's own wit do the rest, was keeping the letter of an order she had never been asked to keep in spirit as well, because no order had troubled to ask that of her, and she did not propose to offer it unasked.

The list, as it stands, runs to some forty places by name, from Àth leathan where the war had opened to Muileann ghlas where it had closed, each with its regiments set against it in the order they had come and gone, and against each place, where she had been let give it, the count the council had allowed before the sealing and not one figure more. Cnoc thais, taken in an Lùnastal of the second year, kept the number of holdouts An Clàr Foscailte¹ had always given for it. The thorn stand at Muileann ghlas kept the three-and-twenty the corporal's list had named. Nowhere on the whole open list did any number stand for the column's own dead, because no number had ever stood there before the sealing either, and Sileas judged, setting the list to rights that first week, that an order telling her to add nothing was no bar to her leaving a blank space exactly where a blank space had always been, in case some later hand, fifty years on, cared to ask why it was blank and went looking, as she had gone looking herself, for the requisition that answered it without quite saying so.

She wrote, at the head of the open list, a single line she had not been asked to write and did not strike out when she had written it: that this was the whole of what an Leabharlann²'s own chronicle held open for the war years, and that the rest of the record existed, and was kept, and would be given to whoever asked for it honestly on the day fifty years should end. It was, she said to Ragnall when he read it over her shoulder, the nearest thing to a promise she was able to make to a reader she would not live to meet, and she thought a chronicle owed its readers that much honesty about its own gaps, whatever it owed the council about filling them.

Ragnall let the line stand. He told her, folding the page back into its place among the day's other returns, that he had once told a young chronicler new to the office that an Leabharlann keeps and does not chase, and that he stood by it still. Keeping a thing honestly, he had come in five-and-twenty years to think, sometimes meant telling a reader plainly that a thing was being kept from them, and where, and until when, rather than letting the gap in the shelf speak for itself and be taken, by some later hand with less patience than hers, for carelessness or for shame.

1. the open record of the war years

2. the Library at Muileann chaol

III

Of the Cairn and the Tithe

The Tuathaich of the western hills had begun, before the frost was properly out of the ground that spring, to carry stone up to the field at Àth leathan where the first great battle had been fought three years before, and by the time the snow was gone from the higher ground they had a cairn there taller than a standing man, raised without any leave asked of An seachdamh rèisimeid¹ whose post lay not half a mile below it on the road. The regiment's captain, a Dia-thìreach of Cathair dhearg new to the post that year, wrote to Comhairle nam Mèinnean² asking whether he was to move it, and was answered, some weeks later and in terms that told him a good deal less than he had hoped, that Comhairle nam Mèinnean saw no charge laid on him to move stones off a field An Crùn³ had no present use for, and that he might use his own judgment in the matter so long as no arms were found under them.

He used his own judgment, and it was, by every account this book has found, a plainer thing than Comhairle nam Mèinnean's letter had troubled to be: he told his patrols to walk past the cairn as they walked past any other stone on that road, and to count the stones if they had a mind to, and to report nothing of it unless they found something under one worth reporting. The patrols have walked past it since, and it has grown, by ones and twos, every time they passed, until it stands, by the reckoning this book has had from a corporal who serves at that post, higher than any stone the regiment had ever troubled to raise for its own dead, though it carried no names, and no plaque, and nothing at all to say whose field it stood on or why.

A woman of the town, who had lost a brother to the fighting on the bank there and would not say, when asked, which side he had died fighting for, was seen more than once by the same corporal to walk out to the cairn alone in the early morning before the patrol came by, and to set one stone on it, never more than one, and to stand a while afterward with her hand flat against the top of the pile before she walked back down to the town. The corporal never asked her name, and never reported the visits, holding, as he told it afterward, that a woman who carried one stone at a time to a field where her own brother might or might

1. the seventh regiment

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

3. the Crown

not lie was doing nothing his captain's letter had told him to trouble himself over, whichever side the stone was meant to answer for.

At Cathair dhearg that same spring An t-Ionmhas⁴ carried Deachamh a' Chogaidh⁵ forward on the pumps for another year, as it had carried it forward every year since the war's first month, and no minute of the council records that anyone there so much as raised the question of letting it lapse. A tithe laid for a war's sake and never once revisited once the war was won is not, Sileas wrote in the open chronicle that year, a thing this book need call by any harder name than the plain one; it is enough to set down that it was never struck out, and to let a later reader draw whatever conclusion the plain fact seems to want drawn.

In the same season An t-Ionmhas's clerks fixed the market-due, on every sale a town made into its own market and on every sale carried between one market and the next, at seventeen in the hundred, and set a clerk of their own in each of the sixteen chartered market towns to take it and keep the town's own roll of what was sold and by whom. Caol ruadh, whose charter the council had granted the year before, the sixteenth and the last such charter the kingdom would grant, had its first An t-Ionmhas's clerk that spring, a young man out of Cathair dhearg who lodged, his own letters home say, over the harbourmaster's own storeroom for want of any better room in a town that had never before had cause to house an officer of An Crùn at all. Deachamh a' Chogaidh on dubhan An t-Ionmhas kept apart from the new market-due, on its own line at the pumps, as it had kept it from the first month of the war, so that a barrel of fuel paid twice over before it left the pump, once to the war that had made the fuel's price what it was and once to the market that sold it on, and no clerk of An t-Ionmhas's, so far as this book has found, ever wrote a word to say the two payments sat oddly together on the same barrel.

IV

Of the Contracts

Comann nan Goibhnean-ceangail took, that same spring, the contract for every engine the nine regiments kept and every hull the four fleets ran, and

4. the Treasury

5. the wartime tithe

doubled its own rolls within the year to answer it. Peigi nic Ascaill signed the contract on the guild's behalf at Cathair dhearg on a morning in an Cèitean, in a room of Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹'s own offices with a clerk on either side of her to witness it, and she told her own under-fitter afterward, in words the under-fitter thought worth keeping and set down in a letter home, that she had signed a good many papers in her working life and never one before that she was certain, signing it, would put more Dia-thìrich boys and girls into a trade her own charter had once shut its Tuathaich fitters out of, without a single line in it anywhere that named the Tuathaich at all. Riaghailt na Cairte² held under the new contract exactly as it had held under the old: every fitter taken on to answer the regiments' work was Dia-thìrich, as the law had required since the charter's first year, and Peigi signed to it, her under-fitter said, with the same hand and the same care she gave any other clause, neither faster nor slower for what the clause meant.

The forges of Àth naomh in the west and of Caol iséal on the north coast, which had smelted the bog-iron of their own districts since before the war began, took An Crùn³'s contract that same season for the regiments' small arms and field-pieces, and every forge-town of the old vein country that could turn a hand to iron followed them into it within the year, so that by the autumn arms had become, in every market of the kingdom, the dearest common goods a household could buy, dearer than grain in a bad year and dearer, in the pit towns especially, than the fuel it was bought to burn. A smith of Àth naomh, writing to his own brother at Cathair dhearg that winter, said that he had turned out more musket-stocks in the six months past than he had turned out ploughshares in the six years before the war, and that he did not know, setting his tools down at the day's end, whether to call that a smith's good fortune or a kingdom's bad one, and had decided, by the time he sealed the letter, that a man in his trade was not the one who ought to have to choose between the two words for it.

At Caol iséal the same trade came to a smithy that had cast little before the war but nails and pot-hooks and the odd gate-hinge for the farms round about, and its master, a woman who had inherited the forge from a father with no son to leave it to and had spent her first years in it proving to every customer in the district that a woman's hand could hold a hammer as true as a man's, told Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own inspector, when he came to see the new contract's terms met,

1. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

2. the charter rule that kept the Fuel-Fitters' rolls to Dia-thìrich

3. the Crown

that she had taken on four boys and a girl that winter who had never before been let near a forge fire, and meant to keep every one of them past the contract's own term if the trade would bear it, war or no war, because a hand once taught a trade does not forget it merely because the reason it was taught has passed. The inspector wrote her answer down more or less whole in his own return, adding nothing to it, which this book takes for as plain a mark of respect as an inspector's report is ever likely to give.

V

Of the Fleets

Of the four fleets that the war had raised and the peace had not stood down, three had work that spring that An Clàr Foscailte¹ was glad enough to set down in full, having no cause to shut any of it away. An dàrna cabhlach², working the eastern water off Baile ìseal through that summer, ran down at last, in the first days of an Lùnastal, the raiders who had taken the salt-boats off Àth bheag three years before and burned a third, and brought their two remaining hulls into Seann Skell under guard, their crews to the capital's gaol and their own account of themselves, such as it was, to a court that this book has found no full record of. Seonag nic Thòmais, keeper of the trial lamp at Baile ìseal's own lighthouse and mother, by then, to a daughter old enough to keep the watch with her on the worse nights, kept in her own log, alongside her plainer entries of wind and tide, an account of the chase that An dàrna cabhlach's own captain thought worth copying whole into his return to Comhairle nam Mèinnean³: that she had seen the raiders' sail from the lamp-room two hours before the fleet's own lookout raised it, by the set of a light she had learned, watching that coast for near thirty years, to know from an honest fisherman's by nothing she could easily put into words beyond the plain fact that an honest boat runs before a squall and a raider runs across it, and that she had lit the second lamp, the one kept unlit in ordinary weather and meant only for a warning, a full hour before the fleet came up, on her own judgment and without waiting to be asked for it by any signal from the water.

1. the open record of the war years

2. the second fleet

3. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

An ceathramh cabhlach⁴, kept on the Tuathaich coast in the north-west since the war's last summer, searched through that same spring the bays off Cathair gheal where the raiders had been thickest in the war years, and found them, to the last cove, empty. The fishermen of Cathair gheal, questioned by the fleet's own officers as to where the raiders had gone, gave an answer more than one of the officers set down in almost the same words in their separate returns, as though the town had agreed it beforehand, though this book takes it rather for a saying already old among them than for any planned answer: that the raiders had left when the fleets came, and would be back when the fleets went, and that a fisherman of that coast had learned, over a good many years of both, not to trouble himself overmuch about which was doing at any one time, since the sea, in his experience, always found some use for an empty bay before long, whichever side filled it.

An treas cabhlach⁵, at Baile ghorm on the western strait, kept the tank-hulls it had built for the war's own carrying and turned them, that spring, to running dubhan up the coast to the Tuathaich depots at Doire ghlas and Caol mhòr, on a contract Tional nan Tuathach⁶ had asked for itself and Tional nan Tuathach's own purse paid the freight of, purse for purse, out of what little Tional nan Tuathach's fund had left over from feeding the war's own families three years before. It was, so far as this book has found, the first contract in the whole of the war's long accounting that the Tuathaich had asked for and paid for themselves rather than had laid upon them, and Tional nan Tuathach's own minute on it, brief as its minutes generally are, records only that the freight was agreed at a fair rate and that An treas cabhlach's captain, a Dia-thìreach who had run the same water for the war's own carrying and asked, this once, to be told plainly what he was carrying and to whom, was told, and carried it, and made no complaint of the cargo that this book has found, though more than one Dia-thìreach captain of that same fleet, in the years before, had grumbled loudly enough about carrying dubhan north at all that his grumbling had gone into Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own returns.

4. the fourth fleet

5. the third fleet

6. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

VI

Of the Morning After

Sileas came to her own desk on the morning after the lock was turned at the ordinary hour, before the copyists were properly at their tables and before the market bell had rung in the town below, and opened the day's page as she had opened it every working morning for thirteen years, with the date set at its head in her own hand and the weather noted under it, because a chronicle that means to be read fifty years on, she had told her own clerk more than once, ought to be able to tell its reader, at the very least, whether it was raining. It had not rained that morning. She wrote that it had not, and then the day's first ordinary business, a letter from a mill at Muileann leathan asking after a copyist's fee, exactly as she would have written it on any other morning of the thirteen years before, and did not write, anywhere on that page or any page that followed it, one word about the room at the end of the new wing's gallery or the key that hung, from that day, under Ragnall's own shirt.

It was not, she has told her clerk since, that she had put the sealing out of her mind; a woman does not carry four boxes of her own work to a locked door and then forget, by the next morning, that she has done it. It was rather, she said, that a chronicle which stopped, even for a day, to say to its own reader, here is a thing we are no longer able to tell you and here is why, more than the bare line she had already set at the head of the open list, was a chronicle that had begun to write about its own troubles rather than about the kingdom, and she had watched enough chronicles in an Leabharlann's own stacks fall into that habit, in years when their keepers grew tired or frightened or merely old, to know it for a slow way of ceasing to be a chronicle at all while still filling pages. So she wrote the mill's letter, and the fee, and closed the page at the ordinary hour, and began the next morning's page the same way, the date, the weather, the day's first ordinary business, as if the room at the end of the gallery held nothing more than the broken binding-press it had held the winter before, and went on writing that way, morning after ordinary morning, for the years the rest of this book has still to tell of her.

Ragnall, for his part, was seen that same first morning to open the reading-room at the usual hour and set the fire and lay out the day's returns for the copy-

1. the Library at Muileann chaol

ists exactly as he had laid them out every working morning since before Sileas came to an Leabharlann at all, and if he laid his hand against his own chest that morning for the first time, no one who was in the room to see it thought it worth writing down, there being, that early in the thing, nothing yet in the gesture to mark it out from any other habit a keeper might fall into without quite meaning to. It was only later, once the habit had held for a season and then for a year, that a copyist or two began to notice it and to wonder, without ever quite asking him outright, what it was a man checked for so often in a key he had never once, by any account this book has found, mislaid.

Of the Motion Allowed to Die

DE 25

I

Of the Thing Off the Cape

An ceathramh cabhlach's log for that year, kept as every fleet's log was kept, in a hand that set down wind and sail and little else, carries one entry that its own captain thought worth underlining, twice, before he sent the book south with the winter's returns. On a clear night off the north-western cape, with no sea running to speak of and the moon most of the way to full, the watch on the *Bratach Ghlas* reported a thing longer than the hull under their own feet moving under the water off the starboard bow, showing neither fin nor spout that any man aboard could swear to, and gone before a second man could be fetched to see it. The captain wrote what his watch told him and no more, and then, because a log is not a place for a captain's own fancies and he knew it, added underneath, in the same hand: *called it a whale*.

It was not the first such thing seen off that cape. The Tuathaich fishermen of an Oirthir Ghaothach¹ had a name for whatever it was, and a telling to go with the name, that ran back at least to the years when Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill kept Eachdraidh na Rìoghachd², for she had set down a sighting of it from the fishermen's report, and she was the first chronicler of the restored kingdom; the telling said only that the thing came seldom, and always in fair weather, and that it had

1. the windy coast

2. the royal chronicle of the restored kingdom

never yet been known to do harm to any boat that let it pass unremarked. An ceathramh cabhlach³'s own men, being Dia-thìrich and mostly from towns that had never had cause to fish that coast before the war stationed them there, knew none of this, and called it a whale because a whale was the largest thing any of them had a name for, and because a log, once a captain has written a word in it, is generally left to stand.

Nothing came of the sighting. No boat was lost that year off the north-west cape, and no fisherman of an Oirthir Ghaothach troubled to ask An ceathramh cabhlach what its log said, there being little, by then, that the two sides of that water had fallen into the habit of asking each other about anything at all.

II

Of the Motion Anna Brought

Anna nic Phàil had kept a copy of Athchuinge Dheireannach an Tìonail¹ in her own writing-case for four years and more by the time she brought her motion, at last, before the twelve, and she could have told anyone who asked her, though nobody did, the exact words of its closing clause without once looking at the paper, having read it over to herself so many evenings at her own table in Cathair dhomhain that the words had worn a groove in her the way a cart-track wears a groove in a soft road. *The kingdom, having already the whole of the south's new fuel to warm it, might find in its own patience a cheaper peace than in any company it could raise to enforce the alternative.* She had watched, in the years since Martha Greaves carried it into the chamber, one small mercy after another pass the council's table and be granted or refused on its own account, a capping here, a register there, a released man handed over at a boundary stone, and had come to understand that the petition, the whole of it, asked payment rather than patience for a season the petition had not foreseen, and would need a new clothing before the room would so much as look at it straight.

She wrote the motion herself, through the early months of that year, at her own table by her own lamp, in the plain hand she used for every paper she meant the council to take seriously, and she wrote it three times before she judged it fit,

3. the fourth fleet

1. the Moot's last petition

cutting from the second draft a whole page of what the war had cost the western towns in named figures, granaries filled and pit-heads flooded and a stone with one-and-sixty names on it at Cathair mhòr, because she had sat at that table long enough to know that a room grows deaf to a column of figures faster than to almost anything else a petitioner can bring it, and that the figures, however honestly reckoned, would only give the twelve a thing to quarrel over instead of a thing to answer. What she kept, in the end, was short: that the Tuathaich towns had borne the war's cost in flooded seams and burned farms and men not come home, that the kingdom's own Treasury carried a tithe laid for the war's sake two years after the war had ended, and that a sum, once, out of that same tithe, paid to the towns that had borne the worst of it, would cost the kingdom less than the war itself had cost and would settle, at least in part, an account that every year left standing only grew harder to close.

She brought it to the council in an t-Ògmhios, on a morning warm enough that the dubhan stove in its alcove stood cold and unlit for once, and the twelve sat, as they always sat, about the long table with the light coming down grey and even from the high windows, Somhairle mac Lachlainn among them now these two years, a soldier's stillness about him that Anna had come, in that time, to read as attention rather than indifference, though she could not always have said which of the two it truly was. She read the motion standing, as the room's custom required of any member bringing new business, and she read it slowly, the way she had read the petition to Martha Greaves's own draft years before it ever came to this table, pausing where the sense paused and nowhere else, because a room that has decided in advance what it thinks of a thing will hear a hurried voice as an apology and a slow one, sometimes, as a fact it cannot so easily set aside.

"You have heard it," said the old man at the table's head, when she had finished and laid the paper down, in the same voice that had told Martha Greaves, four Christmases before, that she might read. "Does any member speak to it?"

Anna spoke to it herself, since custom allowed the bringer one further word before the table's own business took it up, and she kept that word shorter even than the motion: that she did not ask the council to say the war had been wrong, only that a kingdom rich enough to raise nine regiments and four fleets in twenty months was rich enough to spare, once, a sum smaller than a single season's tithe for the towns that had not raised them; and that she brought it now, and not before, because two years of watching what the peace was turning into, capping by capping and contract by contract, had taught her that a thing left unasked past its

season is rarely asked at all. She sat down when she had said it, and the room, for the length of perhaps ten breaths, said nothing back to her at all, twelve faces giving her exactly the silence Martha Greaves had once described to her over a cup of tea at Doire ghlas as the room's whole answer to anything it had not yet decided how to refuse.

It was the master of An t-Ionmhas² who spoke first, a heavy, careful man named Uisdean Dubh whom Anna had sat beside at that table for six years without ever once hearing him raise his voice, and he asked, in the flat tone he asked every question in, whether the mover had costed the sum she proposed against An t-Ionmhas's own roll for the year, since a council that granted a payment without a figure attached to it granted, in his experience, a habit rather than a mercy, and habits, once granted, were harder to unmake than the wrongs they were meant to answer. Anna had expected the question and answered it plainly: a sum, she said, was for An t-Ionmhas's own clerks to set, being their trade and not hers; her motion asked only that the principle be granted, that some amends were owed, and left the reckoning of how much to the room better fitted to reckon it. Uisdean Dubh wrote this down, or wrote some other thing down, in the small notebook he kept always at his elbow, and said nothing further that morning, and Anna, watching him write, could not have told anyone afterward whether she had answered him or only given him a longer sentence to carry back, unresolved, to whatever room he next carried his notebook into.

III

Of the Eight Days

What she had not expected, and what she found hardest afterward to set in any order she could report to Martha Greaves, was how little the eight days that followed resembled a refusal of any kind she had met before at that table. No member spoke against the motion. Nobody rose, in that sitting or the one that followed it three days later, to say that the western towns had brought the war on themselves by holding their pits against Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own ruling, though she had braced for exactly that argument from at

2. the Treasury

1. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

least two of the twelve and had an answer ready for it that she never, in the end, had cause to give. Nobody said that An t-Ionmhas²'s roll could not bear it, though Uisdean Dubh's question had seemed, that first morning, to open the door to exactly such an answer. The motion simply sat, on the table's own business-paper, at the foot of each day's list, carried forward morning after morning under the small clerk's notation *held over*, the same two words she saw written against it on the second day and the fourth and the sixth, until she came to recognise the phrase the way a woman recognises a neighbour's knock, by its shape alone before the door is even opened.

She spoke to three of the twelve privately in those eight days, in the corridor outside the chamber where such talk was neither forbidden nor encouraged, only tolerated the way a draught under a door is tolerated, too small a thing to be worth the mason's trouble of stopping it. The first, a woman of the eastern fisher towns whom Anna had counted, before that year, among the table's fairer members, told her that she saw the justice of the thing plainly enough and would vote for it gladly when it came to a vote, which was, Anna understood only some days later, not quite the same promise as a promise to see that a vote was called. The second, a man of the coal-line towns whose own seat depended, Anna knew without being told, on merchants who had done well enough out of the war's freight to want no new tithe laid anywhere near their own ledgers, said only that the times were not easy for asking An t-Ionmhas for anything new, and left the sentence exactly there, without saying which times he meant or when, in his own reckoning, easier ones might come. The third was Somhairle mac Lachlainn himself, whom she caught at the chamber door on the sixth day much as he had once caught her at it, two autumns before, and asked him plainly, since he alone among the twelve had once commanded the very regiments the motion's figures would have been measured against, whether he thought the sum too great.

"I think," he said, after a pause long enough that she wondered whether he meant to answer her at all, "that I have read a great many rolls of names in the last four years, and that I have never once been asked, reading them, whether the towns they were raised from could bear the cost of the raising. Why a roll of the dead should be easier to ask a kingdom to pay for than a roll of the living, I don't know. That it has been, I know well enough." He said nothing further, and Anna, walking back to her own lodging that evening past the mint where Gille-Easbaig

2. the Treasury

Bàn's dies still struck the plain seal into coin pegged, now, wholly to a fuel a Tuathach had made, found she could not decide whether what he had given her was an answer, a confession, or only the same kind of silence dressed, this once, in more words than the others had troubled to use.

I V

Of the Line Allowed to Die

On the eighth day the motion did not appear on the business-paper at all. Anna saw its absence before she saw anything else that morning, scanning the short list a clerk laid at each member's place as the twelves' custom was, and she asked the clerk, a young man she had seen carry that same list to that same table for the better part of three years without once, so far as she knew, being asked to explain an omission from it, where Tagradh na h-Èirig¹ had gone. He told her, in the brisk apologetic voice of a man repeating something he had been told rather than something he had decided, that the master of An t-Ionmhas² had asked that it stand over to the autumn sitting for want of the figures the mover had declined to bring, and that the request had been granted the evening before, in a short session Anna had not been told was sitting, by a vote of the members present, of whom she had not been one.

She understood, hearing this, with the particular clarity that comes to a woman only after the thing she has feared has already happened rather than before it, that a motion stood over to a sitting nobody troubles to call is a motion granted every appearance of patience and refused every substance of a decision, and that the room had found, in the space of eight days and without a single member ever once saying plainly that the Tuathaich towns should have nothing, a way to give them nothing that left no single hand answerable for it. She asked whether the autumn sitting had in fact been set a day, and was told that it had not, An t-Ionmhas's figures being, the clerk understood, still some way from ready. When they might be ready she did not ask him, having learned enough that week to know the question would only be answered with another true thing that answered nothing.

Tional nan Tuathach's own minute on the matter, when word of it reached Caol mhòr some weeks later and Thomas Rook's successor set it down in the

book that had run unbroken since Walter Hale's wet afternoon, gave the whole of what had happened in one line, in the plain hand the minute-book had always used for a thing too large for the room to say more about: *Leigeadh leis bàsachadh*. Allowed to die. Anna read a copy of that line herself, sent her by Martha Greaves under a short cover note that asked nothing and accused nobody, and found that it said, in three words, everything her own two years of drafting and cutting and reading slowly at a long table had failed, in the end, to say in any number of words at all.

She went back over the sittings in her own mind afterward, more than once, in the way a woman goes back over a fall to find the exact stone her foot had caught on, and could not, however she counted it, find the single vote that had killed the thing, because no single vote ever had. She counted instead the faces: the woman of the eastern towns who had promised a vote and never once, in eight days, asked that one be called; the man of the coal-line towns who had spoken of hard times and let the phrase stand for an answer; six more of the twelve who had said nothing to her at all, in the corridor or at the table, and whose silence she had at first taken, in her own hopefulness, for simple caution and had come, by the eighth day, to read for what it plainly was; and Somhairle mac Lachlainn, who alone of them had given her an answer with a shape to it and had, in the end, no more moved to call the vote than any of the rest. Twelve chairs, and not one hand raised against the motion, and the motion dead all the same. She thought, counting them over that last time, that a room could look away from a thing together more thoroughly than any single member of it could ever have managed to look away from it alone.

V

Of the Chair Laid Down

Martha Greaves heard of the motion's fate at Doire ghlas, from the same letter of Anna's that had carried the minute's four words to her, and read it standing at her own kitchen table with the morning's mail still

3. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

1. Anna nic Phàil's motion to pay the Tuathaich towns for what they lost in the war, brought on the Moot's last petition and allowed to die without a vote

2. the Treasury

in her other hand, and found, reading it, that she felt less anger than she had expected of herself and more a kind of tiredness that had, she understood only slowly, been gathering in her for the better part of two years without her once giving it a proper name. She had sat as speaker of Tional nan Tuathach¹ since the winter Daniel Frayne died, seventeen years by then, through the fuel's whole rise and the whole of the war and the whole of the two years' peace that had followed it, and she found, folding Anna's letter back into its envelope, that she no longer wanted, in any way she could put a plain word to, to be the one who wrote the next letter asking a room that had just let this one die to look at anything else Tional nan Tuathach might bring it.

She told nobody of the decision for a fortnight, turning it over at her own table much as Anna had turned over the motion's own wording at hers, and when she did tell someone it was Peter Hale, in the delegates' room over the net-lofts at Caol mhòr on an ordinary sitting day, with the fire of driftwood and turf doing as little for the far end of the room as it always had. In the same voice she had used to read Ellen Marsh's registers and the census figures and every other hard thing the chair had asked her to read aloud over seventeen years, she told him plainly that she meant to lay the chair down that year, and that she thought him, of every delegate she had sat among, the fittest to take it up, having carried the rebound minute-books through half the war on his own back and having, besides, a great-grandfather's name that the room's own oldest members still remembered without being told whose grandson he was.

Peter Hale did not answer her at once, and when he did it was not to refuse, though Martha had half expected refusal from a man past fifty who had never, in all the years she had known him, put himself forward for anything Tional nan Tuathach had to give. He asked her instead whether she thought the chair worth taking up, after what the council's own table had just shown the whole north it thought of anything Tional nan Tuathach troubled to bring it, and Martha, who had asked herself the same question at her own kitchen table more than once that fortnight, told him what she had come, by then, to believe: that a chair worth nothing to the room across the boundary stones was worth a good deal more than nothing to the room it actually sat in, since Tional nan Tuathach's own minute-books, unbroken since Walter Hale's wet afternoon, were the one record on the whole island that had never once, in ninety years, needed the council's leave to be

1. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

kept honestly, and a man willing to keep them honestly for another seventeen years was doing work that mattered whether or not any table south of the stones ever troubled to read it. Peter Hale sat with that a while, in the way Martha had seen him sit with hard things before, and said at last that he would take it, if Tional nan Tuathach itself, and not only its outgoing speaker, judged him fit for it, which she thought, hearing him say it, as good an answer as the chair had ever been given by anyone who had held it.

She sat one last sitting that autumn, in the same room over the net-lofts, with the same trestle down the middle and the same plain high-backed chair of ship's oak that Thomas Rook had once laid a cushion on for a man too ill to sit in it, and read out, as her last act in it, the year's register of the dead and the maimed with its new column of released names from the boundary stones added at the foot, and then the short business of the day, a roof at the school at Doire ghlais, the price of wool at the fair, a complaint from a mill at Muileann leathan about the coal-line's freight rates, ordinary things that the room had gone on discussing, she thought, listening to herself read them out for the last time, through a war and a siege and a sealed archive and now a motion allowed to die, because a people does not stop needing its roofs mended and its wool priced merely because the larger account it also keeps refuses, this year, to be settled. When the business was done she said, in the same voice she had used for the roof and the wool, that she laid the chair down, and that Tional nan Tuathach's own custom, unbroken since its first speaker's death, asked it now to choose whoever it judged fittest to take it up; and the room, after a silence shorter and warmer than any the council's own table had ever given Anna nic Phàil, chose Peter Hale by acclamation, without so much as a show of hands being called for.

She went home to Doire ghlais the next morning on the ordinary carrier's cart, her own baggage no more than it had been the year she first came to the mill as a young woman, and found, coming up the last rise before the town with the mill's own smoke rising grey against the hill behind it, that she did not know yet what a woman who had been Tional nan Tuathach's own voice for seventeen years was meant to do with her mornings now that the voice was no longer asked for, and thought that she supposed she would learn it the way she had learned everything else in that chair, one ordinary day at a time, without being told in advance how the learning was to go.

That same autumn, while Tagradh na h-Èirig² still sat, unsummoned, on whatever shelf the council's own clerks had at last found for it, three lesser accounts of the war's long tail were closed with rather less ceremony than either the motion or Martha's own chair had been given. At Seann Warr An còigeamh rèisimeid³, quartered there since the war's first summer under canvas and borrowed roofs, raised through that season a barracks of dressed stone on ground the town gave it freely, judging, as its own delegates told the maor plainly enough, that a regiment likely to stay was worth more to a harbour town's trade settled than tented. At Inis uaine An t-ochdamh rèisimeid⁴'s watch on the eastern dubhan tanks, set there against fire in the war's second year and never yet stood down, was made lasting by a council order that gave it, for the first time, officers' houses in the town rather than quarters borrowed year by year from the tank-yard's own sheds, and the house of Na Seann Spioradan⁵ in that town, whose prayers had never before had cause to name any company of soldiers at all, added the regiment to its Sunday round. And at Ceann mhòr, in an Dùbhlachd, An ceathramh rèisimeid⁶ marched out of the old magistrate's house it had held since the war's first winter and went home at last to Caol bheag, its own colours cased for a journey the men had waited four years to make; Tional nan Tuathach asked, as it had asked once before and been answered with nothing, that the house be given over to the town it stood in, and this once, the council's answer came within the season and was granted; Tional nan Tuathach's own letter had asked the house for the town, and the order gave it instead to the maor who governed the town in the kingdom's name, so that the house passed, in its plain wording, from one hand of An Crùn⁷ to another, and the town that had housed the regiment through four years of quartering found itself no nearer owning the old magistrate's house than it had been the morning An ceathramh rèisimeid first marched in under it.

2. Anna nic Phàil's motion to pay the Tuathaich towns for what they lost in the war, brought on the Moot's last petition and allowed to die without a vote

3. the fifth regiment

4. the eighth regiment

5. the Old Spirits

6. the fourth regiment

7. the Crown

CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT

OF THE OLD RECKONING AND THE LAST HEWERS

DE 26

Part Eight • Of the Present Year

Tha clàr na rìoghachd slàn anns gach pàirt ach dhà: an cogadh, a tha dùinte, agus an àird a tuath, nach deach fhaighneachd. The kingdom's record is whole in every part but two: the war, which is sealed, and the north, which was not asked.

— Sileas nic Rath, DE 27

I

Of the Word Nobody Had Coined

No one afterward could say who had said it first, or where, though a dozen towns of the north claimed the saying for their own before the year was out, each with a different mouth to hang it on: an old woman of Doire ghlas selling eggs at her own door, a boatwright of Caol mhòr with his hands still black from a hull's engine, a schoolboy at his slate who had heard the two words joined at his own supper table and brought them back to his class the next morning as though he had made them himself. What was certain, by the time Sileas nic Rath came to set the matter down at Muileann chaol, was only that the word had not existed at the turn of the year and could not, by its end, be kept out of any Tuathaich mouth that spoke for more than a minute together of An t-Aon Leabhar Deug¹ Ellen Marsh had asked an Leabharlann² to keep, or of Tagradh na h-

1. the eleven books of Tuathaich accounts gathered by Ellen Marsh over eleven years and offered to the Library

2. the Library at Muileann chaol

Èirig³ that Anna nic Phàil had carried into the council the year before and that no vote had ever come to answer.

Seann-chunntas, they had begun to call the two things together, the tabled request and the dead motion, as though a single word could hold what two separate papers, filed a year apart in two separate rooms, had somehow failed between them to close. The old reckoning. No one in the north claimed to know what settling it would look like, or who would be the one to say the account was even; it kept, rather, the shape of a wrong no court had ever been asked to try, carried forward from one year's ledger to the next, the line never struck because no one on either side had found a way to strike it without first owning that the line had been drawn at all.

Sileas heard the word first from a carrier who came up Slighe a' Ghuail⁴ road with salt fish for an Leabharlann's own kitchen and stood talking a while in the yard with the porter before he went on, and she heard it again within the month from a letter of Ellen Marsh's that reached her desk unbidden, a short civil note asking after nothing more than the eleventh book's binding, in which the schoolteacher had used the word twice in passing, as a woman uses a word she has stopped noticing is not yet in general currency. She copied both instances into her own working notes, as she copied any word she had not met before, meaning at first only to ask Ragnall, when the season allowed, whether an Leabharlann's own glossary of the north's speech ought to carry it. It was some months before she understood, turning the carrier's yard-talk and the schoolteacher's letter over together on a wet afternoon with little else on her desk to occupy her, what the word truly was: a name the north had given to something the kingdom's own record had never troubled to name, and the giving of it, whatever the council's twelve made of it, an entry that belonged somewhere in the open chronicle, though she was hard put, that same afternoon, to say under what heading a chronicler ought properly to enter a word.

She entered it, in the end, under no heading at all, in a single line at the foot of a page otherwise given over to a Board return on Slighe a' Ghuail's autumn schedule, noting only that the word had been heard that year in more than one northern town, joining an Leabharlann's tabled request of nine years before with the council's dead motion of the year past, and that no Dia-thireach in office, so far as

3. Anna nic Phàil's motion to pay the Tuathaich towns for what they lost in the war, brought on the Moot's last petition and allowed to die without a vote

4. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

her own hearing of the council's business went, had yet used it or shown any sign of having heard it. She wrote the line, she has told her clerk since, less because she supposed it would matter to any reader fifty years on than because a chronicle that let a whole people coin a name for its own grievance and troubled to record everything else that year, the fair's takings, the regiments' postings, the price of salt at Àth bheag, but not that, would have failed, in her own judgment, at the one thing a chronicle was for.

II

Of the Last Twelve

The order to shut the upper galleries of An Sloc Mòr¹ came down from Comhairle nam Mèinnean² to the maor of Achadh dhomhain in an Cèitean, four lines on a single sheet not unlike the order that had sealed an Leabharlann³'s own war record two years before, and it gave, as that order had, no reason beyond the plain fact of the thing required: the upper workings, which had given the kingdom the greater part of its coal before the vein began to fail and gave it now, by Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own reckoning, less than the cost of keeping the pumps running against the water, were to be closed, the timbering left standing and the shafts capped against a day Comhairle nam Mèinnean did not trouble to name. One face only was to be kept, the deepest and driest of the old workings, and that face was given over entire to Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail⁴, to cut altar-coal for the houses of Brìde's order, a few baskets a year, no more, and no less either, than Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail's own accounting required.

Twelve hewers were kept to work it, chosen by the maor from among the few dozen still living who had learned the trade before Comann nan Gualadairean⁵ dissolved itself fourteen years before, and Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail, having no oath of its own ready-made for coal-cutters, took the guild's dissolved rolls, which Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh had carried to an Leabharlann with his own hands in the year of the dissolution, and drew from them a form of words the Àrd-choimhea-

1. the great pit at the mountain

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

3. the Library at Muileann chaol

4. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

5. the Guild of Hewers; lit. 'the fellowship of the colliers'

daiche's own house judged fit for men who cut fuel for an altar rather than a market. The twelve were sworn at Achadh dhomhain on a clear morning of an t-Ògmhios, in the yard above the one shaft still open, by a priest sent down from the southern Seann Skell for the purpose, who read the oath from a single sheet and set his own hand to a second copy that went back south with him, while the twelve stood bareheaded in a line that had not, within living memory of the oldest among them, been drawn up for any purpose but a shift's muster.

They were, by every account this book has found, an ill-assorted dozen for so solemn a swearing: two brothers who had cut coal together since boyhood and would go on doing so, the elder said afterward, until the vein or their own backs gave out, whichever came first; a widow's son barely twenty who had never worked any face but the one now shut and had asked to be kept on the altar-face less from love of the trade than from want of any other the maor's district could offer him; and, at the end of the line nearest the priest, an old man well past sixty who had hewed at An Sloc Mòr since before Cathal was crowned and who told the priest, when the oath was done and the man asked, out of ordinary courtesy, whether he had any words of his own to add to it, that he had sworn the guild's oath once already in his life and had thought, swearing it, that it would be the last oath a coal-cutter's trade would ever ask of him, and that he supposed a man in his years ought not to be surprised any longer at being wrong.

The eleven upper galleries were capped within the fortnight, the timbering left to rot in the dark as the order required, and the maor's own report to Comhairle nam Mèinnean that season noted, in the same flat hand it gave to every other return, that the old hewing families of Achadh dhomhain, who had worked no trade but the vein for as long as the town had stood, said nothing against the closing and asked nothing of Comhairle nam Mèinnean in its place, as they had said nothing and asked nothing at every turn the vein's failing had brought them these thirty years past.

III

Of the Còmhrag and the Watch at the Library

6. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

Of two things that same summer An Clàr Foscailte¹ kept a plainer account, and Sileas entered both in the ordinary way, without the private line she had given the north's new word. At Ceann leathan, where the yearly mel-ee had been fought every summer since before any Dia-thìreach now living could remember its founding, the regiments entered fighters for the first time, a company from each of the nine sending its own man to the field below the town where the fair-wardens had raised the gate-price twice already since the war's own gate-money first taught them how much a crowd would bear. An naoidheamh rèisimeid²'s man, a broad quiet Dia-thìreach of the southern Seann Skell who had refitted engines under Peigi nic Ascaill's own charter before the regiments took him, won it in the third bout of the afternoon, and the crowd, Sileas's own return notes, cheered him no louder and no softer than it had cheered any winner of Còmhrag Ceann leathan³ in the years before the regiments had any part in it, which she took, setting the line down, for as plain a mark as any that some things in the kingdom had not yet troubled themselves to notice a war had been fought at all.

At Muileann chaol that same season An dàrna rèisimeid⁴, quartered at Àth dhìreach to guard Slighe a' Ghuail⁵ and the library road as it had since the war's own first musters, was given a further charge the council's order did not trouble to explain: a guard of six men, stood at an Leabharlann⁶'s own gate through every hour of the day and night, over a room whose existence beyond an Leabharlann's own walls no more than a dozen people in the kingdom were supposed to know of at all. Ragnall mac Mhuirich watched the first of them take up the post from his own window on the morning they arrived, a sergeant and five men with a tent pitched in the yard where the copyists' own handcarts usually stood, and wrote to the council, within the week, in a letter Sileas copied into the day's returns before she quite knew what to make of it herself, that an Leabharlann had not asked for a guard, had never in the whole of its history needed one to keep a room an Leabharlann's own lock already held shut, and would be glad of the council's reasons, whenever the council found leisure to give any.

No reasons have come. The guard has stood its watch since, relieved by An dàrna rèisimeid's own rota without a word from an Leabharlann's own gate to the

1. the open record of the war years

2. the ninth regiment

3. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

4. the second regiment

soldiers' tent or from the tent to the gate beyond the ordinary courtesies a sentry and a porter exchange across a yard they must both cross a dozen times a day, and Raghnull, speaking of it to Sileas at the year's end, said only that a man learns, keeping a library five-and-twenty years, to recognise the shape of an answer the council has decided not to give, and that he had stopped expecting this one.

The sergeant who stood the first watch, a young Dia-thìreach of Cathair dhearg new enough to the regiment to find the whole business as strange as Raghnull did, asked him once, crossing the yard on a wet morning with nothing better to fill the silence, whether the keeper knew what it was his own men were set to guard against, and Raghnull told him, with the same flat courtesy he gave every question he had no answer for, that he supposed the council knew, and that a keeper's own business was to keep the room shut whether the guard outside it stood there for a reason or for none. The sergeant thought this over a while, walking on toward his own tent, and said, before he was quite out of earshot, that it was a queer sort of soldiering, standing watch over a door that had never once, in a whole season, opened from either side while he was there to see it; and Raghnull, watching him go, judged it the truest thing either of them said to the other that whole year.

IV

Of the Last Coal Train

Eachann mac Ruairidh drove Slighe a' Ghuail¹ on the tenth of an t-Sultain as he had driven it, on and off, for fifty years and more, since a boy of nine had first been let up onto his own father's footplate at Muileann chrom to hold the whistle-cord and be told, each time he pulled it, exactly how long a blast the crossing ahead required. He was given the run three days before by the yard's own masters, who told him plainly, handing him the manifest, what no manifest of the arms years had ever troubled to tell him: that this would be the last train Slighe a' Ghuail carried under that name for coal's own sake, Comhairle nam Mèinnean² having decided, after eighteen years of carrying dubhan under a name

5. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

6. the Library at Muileann chaol

1. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

the line had never troubled to change, that the last few wagons still owed to the southern lamp-houses under an old contract might as well go down in one final working before the contract lapsed and the name lapsed with it in every mouth but the timetable's own.

He asked for no ceremony, and none was offered him. The engine that took the wagons out of Achadh dhomhain that morning was the same dubhan engine he had driven for eighteen years, its tank carrying the same fuel it had carried every working day since the coal engines were laid up in the Muileann chrom siding and never ran again, and the six wagons behind it held coal only because the contract said coal, a scant load by the standards of the trade's old years, the kind of load a driver of his father's generation would have called barely worth the coupling. He signed the manifest at the yard office in the grey hour before first light, in the same hand he had signed every manifest of the arms years in, and found, walking out to the engine across a yard he had crossed ten thousand times before, that his own legs carried him at something less than their ordinary pace, though he could not, questioned about it afterward by his second man, have said why a man ought to walk any slower to an engine he meant to bring home again by noon.

The run went as any ordinary run went, the line past Muileann mhin no worse and no better under him than it had been the week before, the crossings sounded at their proper distances, the gradient above Cathair dhearg's own goods-yard taken at the same careful speed he had always taken it since a boy on his father's footplate first watched the needle climb there and asked why the driver eased the regulator rather than pressing on. He thought, taking that same gradient for what he supposed, without quite letting himself finish the thought, might be the last time under that name, of his own father, who had driven coal on this same line for forty years and had told him, the year the dubhan engines first came to Muileann chrom, that he would not ride one, and had kept to it, so far as Eachann knew, to the end of his own working days; and he thought, too, though less clearly, of the yard family's son killed under a wagon in the changeover eighteen years gone, a boy he had known only by sight and by the single line the yard's own register had given him, and of how strange it was that a line as long as this one, carrying coal and then dubhan and then arms and now, for one last morning, coal again, should have so few names left along its own length that a driver crossing it could still call to mind.

At Cathair dhearg's own goods-yard, where the wagons were to be unshunted and the coal handed over at last to the lamp-houses' own carters, a small knot of

men had gathered along the platform edge who had no ordinary business there, yard hands off their own shift and two or three of the older drivers who had heard, in the way such things were heard along a working line before any bell announced them, that this was Slighe a' Ghuail's last coal working under that name. They said little to him as he brought the engine in, no cheer and no speech, only a few raised hands and, from one old driver near retirement himself, a nod Eachann took, bringing the engine to its stand, for as full an accounting as the morning was likely to give of thirty years' worth of coal carried down that same line by men most of whom the register held no line for at all.

He unshunted the wagons himself rather than leave it to the yard hands, working the couplings in the cold with his own bare fingers gone stiff before he was done, and stood a while afterward at the head of the empty engine while the carters loaded the coal onto their own wagons for the last stretch to the lamp-houses, watching six wagons' worth of a trade that had built the kingdom's own coin and crowned its own kings go out of the yard behind horses rather than an engine, the lamp-houses having judged, that same week, that six wagons did not warrant the trouble of a second engine's steam merely to finish what one engine had already finished carrying. His second man, the same broad quiet man who had ridden the arms trains with him five years before and asked him nothing then either, stood beside him through the whole of the unloading and said only, when the last sack had gone over onto the carters' own wagon, that it was a poor sort of coal by the old reckoning, small stuff and dusty, the kind a hewer of thirty years before would have thrown back down the shaft rather than send up to the weigh-house at all; and Eachann, who had thought the same thing himself without troubling to say it, answered only that poor coal carried the same as good coal, so long as the wagon held together, which was as much of an epitaph as either man saw fit to give it.

He rode the empty train back to Muileann chrom that afternoon at the ordinary speed, no faster and no slower than any light working he had ever brought home, and signed the day's return at the yard office in the same hand, and told his second man, walking out into the last of the light, that he supposed the line would keep the name a good while yet in the timetables, whatever it carried, because a name, once printed often enough on enough paper, outlasts by some years the thing it was first printed to describe. He walked home by the yard rows that evening rather than by the shorter way along the embankment, past the siding where the old coal engines had stood laid up and rusting these sixteen years, their

fireboxes cold and their own paint gone the colour of the ground under them, and stopped a while at the fence to look at them, as he had not troubled to do in some years, before he went on to his own supper and said nothing of the day's run to his own wife beyond the plain fact that Slighe a' Ghuail had carried its last coal, and that he had been the one to drive it.

V

Of the Pass, the Wool, and the Foot of the Year

The returns that reached Sileas's own desk through the rest of that autumn came, as they always came, in no order she would herself have chosen, so that An siathamh rèisimeid's northern posts and the fair's own wool-count arrived within the same week's post and lay together on her table some days before she found leisure to enter either. The sixth, quartered at Cnoc bheag since the war's own last musters, had begun that same month to keep posts of its own at the boundary stones on the northern road, the first stones Seumas mac Eathainn and old Iain Ruadh had ridden past four-and-twenty years before to learn whether a new fuel burned as men said, and for the first time since An Dealachadh² itself a Tuathach going south past those stones was asked to show a pass, a single printed sheet the maor's own clerks had begun issuing that autumn from a table set up in the shadow of the stones themselves. The council's minute on it, when it reached an Leabharlann³, called the passes a measure for a time only, in the same three words Deachamh a' Chogaidh⁴ had been given five years before and had not, in all that time, been taken away again, and Sileas, copying the minute into the day's page, set down the three words exactly as the council had given them and added nothing of her own beside them, though she found, writing them, that her own pen paused a moment longer over that particular line than the rest of the page had asked of it.

Fèill Muileann òg⁵ that same season kept the shape it had kept since the first fair any record of the island remembered, traders of every shire the state now held

1. the sixth regiment

2. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

3. the Library at Muileann chaol

4. the wartime tithe

5. the fair at Muileann òg

bringing their own goods to the fair-ground by the ford, and Tuathaich wool sold there still, as it had sold every year since the truce, on its own northern day, through Dia-thìrich factors who took their own cut of every fleece before a northern seller saw the coin. Ùna nic Ailein's own court entered the day's takings in the ordinary column, no different in its figures from the year before or the year before that, and Sileas, setting the fair's return beside An siathamh rèisimeid's own pass-list on the same page of her working notes, found herself thinking, though she wrote none of it into Eachdraidh na Rìoghachd⁶ proper, that a trade six generations old and a pass six weeks old had come, in that one autumn, to stand for the same plain fact from two different directions: that the north sold to the south as it always had, and crossed into the south, now, only by the south's own leave.

It was in the last week of the same month, with the year's ledgers still open on her desk and the fair's own figures not yet fully copied in, that the letter came up from Àth dhìreach in the hand of Beathag's own sister, saying that Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh had died in the night, quietly, in the room she had kept these six years past since laying down the chronicler's office, and that the household there had thought Sileas would wish to know of it before the news reached her by any slower road.

Sileas set the letter down and did not, for some while, take up her pen again. Beathag had been five-and-seventy years old, by her own sister's own reckoning given in the same letter, a span her own mother's people had thought a fair age and no more; and Sileas, who had come to an Leabharlann at two-and-thirty with a fair hand and little else, and had been taught every stroke of the chronicler's craft by the same woman the letter now told her was dead, found that she could not, for the better part of that whole grey afternoon, set down in the open chronicle the one entry the day plainly required of her, though she had entered a hundred deaths of greater and lesser note in the fifteen years she had kept the record at that desk.

She wrote it, in the end, at the day's ordinary hour, in the same plain hand she gave every other entry: that Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh, royal chronicler of the kingdom from SE 65 to DE 20, had died at her sister's house at Àth dhìreach, and that an Leabharlann owed to her hand the first note of the fuel that named this whole age, the re-heading of fourteen years of the kingdom's own record, and a great many questions that no chronicler after her, Sileas included, had yet found the

6. the royal chronicle of the restored kingdom

means to answer. She added nothing more, no word of grief and no word of praise beyond the plain accounting of what the dead woman's own hand had left behind her, holding, as she set the pen down at last, to the same rule Beathag herself had given her the day she laid down the office six years before: write what you are let, and write down what you are not.

Folding the letter away into the same drawer where she kept every private paper the open chronicle had no proper room for, she thought of the word the north had coined that same year for its own unsettled account, and found, turning the two things over together in the last light of that short autumn day, that she did not know whether a kingdom's own record could be said to keep an old reckoning of its own, in the way a family keeps one, or whether that manner of keeping belonged, as so much else that year seemed to belong, to the north alone. It was, she judged, closing the drawer, a question fitter for a chronicler with more years left to her than the one now sitting at this desk, and she returned, the next morning, to the day's first ordinary business, exactly as she had returned to it every morning since the door at the end of the gallery was shut.

OF the CHARTER OF EXPORT

DE 27

I

Of the Còmhrag and the Two Docks

Joe Ashby had fitted boats at Caol mhòr for thirteen years by his own count, and in all that time he had never once gone up to watch Còmhrag Ceann leathan¹, though the men he fitted for went every year, win or lose a shift's pay on it, and came back the next morning with their knuckles wrapped in whatever cloth their wives could spare. That year the fight went to Ceann leathan as it always went, in the dead of am Faoilleach, with the ground hard and the crowd stamping its feet, and two regiments and the fighting men of nine shires sent their best into the ring the town keeps for it, with the old rule still standing that no edge is carried past the rope, only fists and the stave. The ring at Ceann leathan is nothing more than a square of trodden ground behind the market cross, roped off once a year and left open to the weather every other week of it, and the men who fought there that year fought under the same sky and before the same crowd of shire-folk and off-duty soldiers that had watched every Còmhrag since edged tools were first banned from it, a crowd that came for the fight and stayed, more years than not, to see nothing worse than a broken hand and a fair winner carried home on his own friends' shoulders.

That year was not one of the fair years. A man of An treas rèisimeid² took a stave-blow above the ear in the second round and did not get up again, and was

1. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

carried off the ground still living and was dead before the tide turned. Nobody at Caol mhòr could have named him. The word came down the coast three days later with the fish-carrier, along with the name of the shire that had lost him, and by the time it reached Joe's own dock it had already worn smooth in a dozen mouths, the way such news does, until it was no longer a man's dying but a fact about the year, one line among the others: Còmhrag Ceann leathan was fought, and one man died of it, as had happened before and would happen again.

He thought of it only because the fish-carrier brought, in the same breath, another piece of news that mattered to him rather more, which was that the copying of Ellen Marsh's *An t-Aon Leabhar Deug*³ was finished at last in the schools of the north, the eleventh copied out fair in a schoolroom hand at Doire ghlas and carried round to the other schools as the first ten had been. Joe had never read a page of any of the eleven, could not have told a stranger what was in them beyond the little Ellen herself had once said to him on the quay, years back, before he knew her for more than a woman who asked careful questions and wrote down the answers without once correcting a man's grammar to make him sound a fool. He knew only that the books held the north's own telling of *An Dealachadh*⁴ and the years after it, going back past his own memory into his father's, and that Ellen had spent eleven years gathering them from kitchen tables and chapel vestries and the backs of account-books nobody else had thought worth keeping, and that when she had finally carried the whole of it down to *Leabharlann Muileann chaol*⁵ and offered it for the record, an *Leabharlann*⁶ had taken her letter and filed it, and had not, so far as anyone at Caol mhòr had heard, taken the books. He had asked Peter Hale once, straight out, whether an *Leabharlann* meant to refuse them outright or only to leave them waiting, and Peter had said that a catalogue that lists a request and not the thing requested has not yet said either word, and that a man could grow old waiting to find out which. The schools of the north kept copying anyway, one hand teaching the next, since a thing worth the writing was worth the writing twice.

Tìonal nan Tuathach⁷ met that year at Caol mhòr as it met every year, in the long room over the net-lofts by the harbour where it had sat since Walter Hale's

2. the third regiment

3. the eleven books of *Tuathaich* accounts gathered by Ellen Marsh over eleven years and offered to the Library

4. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

5. the Library at *Muileann chaol*

6. the Library at *Muileann chaol*

7. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

wet afternoon. Joe went to that, as he went most years, less for what was said than for the plain fact of the minute-books being opened again, the same long shelf of them running back to Walter Hale's first meeting, a run broken by no war and no charter and no regiment's say-so, though every one of those had tried its hand at Tional nan Tuathach in its turn. Peter Hale opened the year's book himself, being new enough to the chair that he still did it with his own hand rather than passing the pen to a clerk, and read out the tally of what stood recorded and what did not: no ruling from any Dia-thìreach court that named Tional nan Tuathach a lawful body, and no request ever made that it should be. Joe had heard the same two lines read every year of his life and had stopped, some years back, expecting them to change. What he watched instead, that year, was Peter's own hand on the page, steady enough, and thought that a man could keep a thing going a long while on steadiness alone, whatever else he lacked.

He noticed, walking home along the quay afterward past the engine-sheds where he no longer had leave to work, that every lamp lit along that stretch of water burned dubhan now, his own trade's old wick-oil gone from every window these six years, and that the two boats drawn up for the winter had dubhan engines fitted where their masters could afford the fitting and oars where they could not. He fitted the oared ones himself, outside any guild's book, for whatever a man could pay him, and had done since Riaghailt na Cairte⁸ put his name off Comann nan Goibhnean-ceangail⁹ rolls along with every other Tuathach fitter on the island. It was not a trade he complained of within his own hearing. A man who has been let go once learns to notice, without much bitterness left in the noticing, how completely the thing that let him go has since come to run everything he still has to walk past on his own quay.

An old man who had fitted lamps at Caol mhòr since before Joe was born, and had been let go from the same rolls the same season, caught him at the shed door and asked, as he asked most weeks, whether Joe had heard any more of the eleventh book. Joe told him what the fish-carrier had told him, and the old man stood a while working it over, the way he worked over most news these years, slowly and without much hope of it coming to anything, before he said that a book finished was still a book, whatever an Leabharlann chose to do with it, and that his own grandchildren would at least have the whole of it to read when they were grown, catalogued or not. Joe agreed with him, because there was nothing in

8. the charter rule that kept the Fuel-Fitters' rolls to Dia-thìrich

9. the Guild of Fuel-Fitters; lit. 'the fellowship of the fitters'

it to disagree with, and because the old man had earned the right to say such things without being answered too closely.

"They'll list the asking of it," he said, "same as they list the asking for amends. A kingdom can keep a request on a shelf a long while and call that keeping."

"Longer than either of us has left to watch it," Joe said, and the old man laughed at that, a short dry sound with no bitterness in it that Joe could hear, and went back to the lamp he was mending, which at least, being his own and not A' Chompanaidh¹⁰'s nor the council's, he was still let to mend.

II

Of the Common Account

By that year there was little left on Dia-thìr that did not run on dubhan, and less that anyone thought worth remarking on in the running. Every lamp lit after dark, every engine that turned a wheel, every ship of the fleets and every lorry on the roads the regiments had built, drew on the same fuel one man had first made from what the pits threw away as worthless. The coin of the kingdom was pegged to it now as it had once been pegged to the vein's own coal, and An t-Ionmhas¹ took its tithe on every sale of it as it had once taken a tithe on every hundredweight dug. A clerk at Cathair dhearg closed the year's roll that autumn at nine thousand five hundred and sixty-eight purses, two parts in three of it from the head-due taken on every five thousand heads across the shires, the rest from the market-due at seventeen in the hundred on every sale the market towns made, with Deachamh a' Chogaidh² carried forward on its own line beneath the regiments' pay, as it had been carried forward every year since the war that made it was said to have ended. An Oirthir Ghaothach paid neither due, being reckoned still too poor and too far to be worth the collecting, and the clerk's own note said as much in the same plain hand he gave every other figure, without complaint and without pride, a fact set down beside other facts.

It was a common account, and common accounts rarely stop a kingdom in its walking to be looked at twice. The clerk who closed that year's roll had closed a dozen before it, and set down the nine thousand five hundred and sixty-eight

10. the Company

1. the Treasury

2. the wartime tithe

purses in the same column, the same hand, the same order of the due before the tithe, as every year he had kept the office; a stranger reading only his ledger could not have told, from the figures alone, that the trade behind so many of them ran on a fuel that had not existed within the memory of men still working the scales beside him. At Ros dhomhain, where the barrels of the ordinary trade came down to the quay all that year as they had come down every year since the dubhan works first opened at the southern Seann Skell, the same An t-Ionmhas's clerk who weighed and marked them for the home market had begun, some months before the council ever sat on the larger question, to keep a second tally of his own, of barrels that left no due behind them worth a coin, since the fuel that ran the fleets' own hulls and the regiments' own lorries was reckoned the kingdom's, and paid the kingdom nothing beyond what it had already cost the kingdom to raise the regiments that burned it. He kept the second tally without being asked to, and showed it to nobody, and folded it each quarter into the drawer where a careful man keeps the figures he is not sure anyone above him wants to see.

What stopped Comhairle na Rìoghachd³ that year, and held its twelve members three sittings running when most business was disposed of in one, was a single man's petition to carry his own fuel past the island's own shore, a thing no council at Cathair dhearg had granted to any goods of Dia-thìr since An Dealachadh⁴ closed An t-Aiseag⁵.

III

Of the Three Sittings

Sìleas nic Rath had sat through a great many council sittings in her years at the desk, most of them dull enough that she kept her own attention only by the discipline of the pen moving under her hand, but she remembered afterward, better than she remembered most weeks of that whole grey year, the particular quality of the quiet that fell over the chamber the first time Dubhan stood before the twelve to ask leave to sell his own fuel beyond the water.

The council chamber had not changed since Sìleas first came into it as Beathag's clerk: a long table, twelve chairs about it, and a window at its head that let the

3. the royal council of twelve

4. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

5. the Crossing; lit. 'the ferrying'

morning in over the councillors' own shoulders and left the petitioner facing the light, so that whoever stood to ask the twelve for anything stood also half blind, and every chronicler who had ever kept the room's minute had noticed it and none had ever written it down as anything but the room's own custom. Somhairle mac Lachlainn sat that year among the twelve, the one soldier at the table, a seat given him at the peace and kept since, and he said less in any of the three sittings than any other councillor there, though Sileas marked him watching the petitioner the whole first hour with a soldier's stillness.

Dubhan himself was an old man by then, in his sixty-ninth year, and every councillor in that hall had burned his fuel in his own house for a dozen years or more, whatever any of them privately thought of the man whose name it carried. He had written to the council for a year before it would sit on the matter at all, and the letters lay on the table before the twelve in a bundle tied with the clerk's own tape. Sileas set down, in the open chronicle, what the record could hold: that he came, that he asked, and that the council heard him. The names of Seachran and Brean, whom the north names as his closest allies, she did not have cause to enter that year, and did not.

What he asked was a plain thing, and the clerk's draft of it, which Sileas copied twice, once for Eachdraidh na Rìoghachd¹ and once at the clerk of council's own asking for the council's private minute, was a plainer document than she had looked for: a request for leave to sell dubhan beyond the island, on terms the council might set and change at its own pleasure, since he asked a leave and not a right. The twelve heard it in silence and did not answer that day. A petition of that weight, the clerk told her afterward, is not a thing twelve men decide before their dinner.

Sileas walked back to her lodging that first evening by the long way, along the wall above the river, and found herself turning the petition over much as she had turned over, two years before, the one line the same council had given to Anna nic Phàil's own asking on Tìonal nan Tuathach²'s behalf: allowed to die. Both were requests brought to the same twelve men in the same hall under the same window; one had waited two years for a single line and was waiting still, and the other, she already half suspected before the second sitting ever sat, would not wait so long. She set neither thought into Eachdraidh na Rìoghachd, a chronicler's private suspicion being no fact the office was paid to keep, and carried it with her

1. the royal chronicle of the restored kingdom

2. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

all the same, the way a woman carries a stone in her shoe some while before she troubles to stop and shake it out.

The second sitting came on in the spring, and it was there that Anna nic Phàil rose to put the question Sileas had privately expected from the first day, though she had not expected it from Anna, who had brought Tagradh na h-Èirig³ before this same council not two years past and had watched it left to die there without a vote. Anna asked the council, plainly and without heat, how the kingdom meant to be sure that nothing of the vein's own coal, which the kingdom had never sold, went out with the fuel; and the council answered her, in its own time, with the one term of the charter that no councillor argued: that the custodians of Òrd Bhrìde⁴ should seal every hold. Sileas wrote the exchange down whole. It seemed to her, setting down her pen that evening, the nearest the three sittings came to the question the whole kingdom might have asked and mostly had not, and the part of it that stayed with her past that evening was less the fuel's own cleanness than the years the whole kingdom had burned it before any councillor thought, until Anna rose that day, to ask.

The third sitting fell as the summer was going out, and it was over inside the hour. The twelve granted the charter on the terms Sileas had already copied fair from the clerk's draft two days before it was read: An t-Ionmhas⁵ to set the measure sold in any year, the loading to be done at Ros dhomhain and nowhere else on the island, a clerk of An t-Ionmhas to take his tithe on every barrel there, the kingdom's own depots and Tìonal nan Tuathach's to be served before any barrel left the shore, and the custodians of Òrd Bhrìde to set their seal on every hold before it sailed. The leave was his from that day. To whom he meant to sell, he told neither the council nor the chronicler, and nobody at the table asked him twice.

The street outside ran down toward the bridge as it always ran, and half the lamps burning along it that evening already carried the very fuel the council had just that hour agreed the man might sell beyond the water, a thing Sileas noted only because she happened to be looking for something else to note, folding the minute into her satchel with her mind still half in the hall behind her. She wrote the whole of the sitting into the open chronicle in her plainest hand that same night, adding neither praise of the council's care nor doubt of its wisdom, since

3. Anna nic Phàil's motion to pay the Tuathaich towns for what they lost in the war, brought on the Moot's last petition and allowed to die without a vote

4. the order of Brìde's flame

5. the Treasury

her years at the desk had taught her that the day for either judgment, if it ever came, was not a chronicler's day to make it. She added only the terms, in full, as the clerk had given them to her: An t-Ionmhas's measure, the loading at Ros dhomhain alone, the tithe on every barrel, the kingdom's own depots served first, and the custodians of Òrd Bhride to seal every hold before it left the shore, since nothing of the vein might go out under any charter the council had ever granted or was ever like to grant.

IV

Of the Ship Going North-About

The tank-hull went out from Ros dhomhain in an Dàmhair, loaded over three days at the quay under the eyes of a clerk of An t-Ionmhas¹ who marked the first barrel and the last alike and every fifth barrel between, and under the eyes, too, of two custodians of Òrd Bhride² sent down from Seann Skell for the purpose, who opened every hold before it was filled and searched it by lamp for any trace of the vein's own coal before they would let a single barrel of Dubhan's own fuel go down into it. Finding none, they set their seal in wax at the coaming of each hold in turn, pressing the order's own mark into it while it was still soft, and stood by until it had hardened enough that no hand could open the hold again without breaking what they had set. She carried the name *An Eala Dhubh*³ painted fresh on her bow; who had chosen the name was not told. She ran north-about, as every ship bound for the water beyond Ceò Mhanannain⁴ had run since An t-Aiseag⁵ first found the one passage there was to find, out past the north cape and down along the coast toward the north-western capes, where the sea opens and the island's own charts give out.

Joe Ashby was on the water that morning too, out beyond Caol mhòr's own headland in the boat he had fitted with his own hands from a hull three other men had given up on, tending a line that had caught nothing worth the tending, when An Eala Dhubh came up past him under her engine, low in the water with

1. the Treasury

2. the order of Brìde's flame

3. the Black Swan, the first tank-hull loaded under the charter of export

4. Manannan's mist over the eastern sea

5. the Crossing; lit. 'the ferrying'

her load, a hull no bigger than a dozen he had fitted in his time but riding, that morning, like something the whole island had built together and no part of it owned. He watched her the better part of an hour, until she was no more than a mark of smoke against the northern sky, and thought, watching her go, of the thirteen years since his own name had come off Comann nan Goibhnean-cean-gail⁶ rolls under a charter written for a different fuel than the one that ship now carried past the edge of everything he had ever fitted a boat to reach. A man's mind will run to such things on a slow morning with an empty line, and his ran on to a wick he had once turned in a lamp not so different from the ones now burning the length of that ship's own wake, the fuel changed and the charter over it changed twice, and his own hands, which had done the turning either way, let go from both. Last of all he thought of the eleventh book finished at Doire ghlas and the one line in an Leabharlann⁷'s catalogue that named the asking of it and not the thing, and found, watching the smoke thin against the sky, that he could not have said with any confidence which of the two, the book uncounted or the fuel now going out under seal and charter, the kingdom would remember longer.

At the southern Seann Skell that same morning, where the shipmasters' works now stood twice the size they had been when Joe first worked their retorts, the priests of Manannan came down to the quay as the tide turned and said, over the water, the same prayer that had been said at every sailing out of that harbour since ships first went north-about from it: that the god of the sea keep it shut behind whatever went out on it, and send back to the shore whatever the sea was willing to send, and forgive the island whatever debt a sailing left unpaid on either side of Ceò Mhanannain. They had said it over grain-ships and over the fleets' own hulls and, in years further back than any priest now living could name from his own memory, over Cabhlach an Scaraidh⁸ that never sailed home; they said it that morning over a hull of dubhan bound past Ceò Mhanannain under one man's narrow charter, in the same words, in the same order, asking the same god the same question he had never yet, in all the island's telling, troubled himself to answer. An old woman of the harbour stood at the edge of the crowd with a child on her hip and said the last line of the prayer along with the priests, under her own breath, the way a person says a thing learned so young that it no longer feels

6. the Guild of Fuel-Fitters; lit. 'the fellowship of the fitters'

7. the Library at Muileann chaol

8. the fleet of the Sundering

like an asking of anyone in particular; no one near her remarked on it, the day being one on which the whole quay had its own reasons to want the sea kept shut.

Joe brought his own boat in empty that evening, the line having given him nothing all day worth the carrying home, and told his wife only that he had seen the ship go out, and that she had gone north-about as they all went, and said nothing more of it, since there was, when he came to set the day in his own mind that night before sleep, nothing more in it that words would carry any better than the sight had already carried it, out past the headland, into the smoke, and gone.

So the year closed on that account: a man dead of Còmhrag Ceann leathan⁹ whose name went unrecorded at Caol mhòr, an eleventh book finished and a catalogue still silent on it, a Moot that met and was not asked to answer for meeting, a Treasury roll of nine thousand five hundred and sixty-eight purses drawn from a fuel no council had thought to tax before one man made it, and, over three sittings that had held the twelve of Cathair dhearg longer than any petition in Sileas nic Rath's own years at the desk, a charter granted to the same man to carry that fuel past the water his own kingdom had kept shut since An Dealachadh¹⁰. The north's old rhyme asked whose the fire was, and the island that year answered the question in every particular but the one the rhyme was asking, setting down who might load it and where and under what seal and at what tithe, and never once who among its makers had gone first without a wick to turn or a rolls-book to keep his own name on.

9. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

10. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

Of the Four Baskets

DE 27

I

Of the Lot at the Southern Seann Skell

The twelve came up out of the one open face of An Sloc Mòr¹ in the first days of an Dàmhair with four baskets between them, no more and no less than the year's cutting had ever come to since Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail² took the working over, and the maor's own cart carried the baskets down to Achadh dhomhain station roped under a tarpaulin against the rain, and from there they went south by Slighe a' Ghuail³ that no longer carried coal, in a van kept for nothing else that week, to the southern Seann Skell, where the houses of Bride's order had kept the lot on the same morning every year since a working was first given them.

Alasdair mac Ìomhair drew it that year as he had drawn it every year of his office, an old man now, past his eighty-fifth summer by his own account and past it by a season or two more by the reckoning of the clerk who kept his house's roll, and the priests who stood about him in the yard behind Bride's house had taken, these last few years, to setting a low stool at his elbow without being asked, which he used or did not use as the morning's cold decided for him. That year he stood the whole of it. Four baskets and nine houses waiting on them: the two Seann Skells, Ros dhomhain, Cathair mhòr, Cnoc bheag, Seann Bhral, and three lesser houses of the coast whose own priests had walked or ridden two and three days to

1. the great pit at the mountain

2. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

3. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

be there, each with a slip of paper bearing its house's mark folded into a cup that had once, before Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail took to keeping its lots in a silver bowl brought out every year from the house's own treasury, been an ordinary kitchen basin.

He drew four slips from the nine, one hand into the bowl and the other steadying himself on the shoulder of the boy who stood there for the purpose rather than on the stool, a novice of fifteen who had been told only that morning that this would be his office from now on and had not slept the night before for the weight he had put on it. The houses drawn that year were Cnoc bheag, Seann Bhral, the western Seann Skell, and, by a chance the priests standing about did not remark on though several of them thought of it, the southern house among them, so that of the four baskets one need travel no farther than across the yard.

"It is always the same four baskets," Alasdair said afterward to the young priest who had come down from Ros dhomhain that year to see the lot drawn for the first time, "and never the same four houses twice running, though I could not tell you the last time it fell as it fell today, with our own house among the four. I have seen this lot drawn, by my own count, six-and-fifty times, as a clerk of this house and then as its master, and I could not tell you either what governs it, beyond that it keeps to no pattern a man watching year on year could swear to." The young priest asked him whether he thought the coal itself, cut so few a basket at a time now that the vein was all but spent, would still be drawn for at all in ten years, or in twenty. Alasdair looked at him a while, in the way of a man deciding how much of an answer a question deserves, and said only that the mountain had given the houses of Brìde's order altar-coal since before either of them was born, in baskets that had once numbered forty and more, and that a man his age had learned not to promise a young man what the mountain would do next, having been wrong about it, by his own reckoning, more often than he had been right.

The yard behind Brìde's house that morning stood ankle-deep in the first hard rain of the season, and the priests who had walked from the lesser coast houses came in with their hems black to the knee and stood steaming a little near the kitchen door before the lot was called, so that the drawing, when it came, was done under a sky the colour of the coal it decided the fate of, with the silver bowl held out at arm's length by the novice so that the rain should not spot the folded slips before Alasdair's own hand went into it. One of the coast priests, a woman of a house so small it had never yet had the lot fall to it in living memory, stood through the whole business with her own eyes fixed less on the bowl than on the

four baskets, set down on a trestle by the wall under a second tarpaulin, and said afterward to no one in particular that she had come three days' walk to see coal drawn for by lot that would once, in her grandmother's own telling, have been carted to the coast houses by the wagon-load and never missed.

The twelve hewers who had cut it were not there to see it drawn, the cutting and the drawing having been kept apart, by old custom, since before any priest now living could say why; but word came back to them at Achadh dhomhain, by the same post that carried the maor's ordinary returns, of which four houses had had the lot that year, and the old man among them, the one who had sworn the guild's oath once already in his life and had thought it the last oath a coal-cutter's trade would ever ask of him, said, on hearing that the southern house had drawn its own basket back again, that it was the kind of thing the vein did when it had a mind to be droll, and that he had stopped, some years before, trying to read anything further into it than that.

II

Of the Lamps Lit Early

Síleas nic Rath had the maor's return on the altar-coal on her own table at Muileann chaol within the fortnight, one line among the ordinary autumn returns, and she entered it in the ordinary column, four baskets cut and shared by lot among nine houses, the southern house among the four that year, in the same flat hand she gave the fair's takings and the regiments' postings; and she thought, setting the pen down, of baskets that had once numbered forty and more, shrunk to four, and let the thought go no further than the line already written, having long since made it a rule of her own office not to write in the open chronicle more than a return required of her.

It was some weeks later, in the third week of an t-Samhain, that she came to the day she had known since the spring was coming and had put off, without quite naming to herself that she was putting it off, for as long as the ordinary business of the season let her. The daylight that year failed earlier at Muileann chaol than any clerk of an Leabharlann¹ could remember it failing, or so old Ailig the copyist said, standing at the reading-room window one afternoon with his

1. the Library at Muileann chaol

coat still on, and Raghnaill had given the same order he gave every year at this turning, that there would be no fire before the fire could be spared and none after dark at all, so that by the middle of the month the whole gallery kept its lamps lit from three in the afternoon and put them out again the moment the last light off the river gave enough to see a page by in the morning.

Sileas lit her own lamp that afternoon at a little after three, the sky over Slighe a' Ghuail² already the colour of slate, and drew toward her the ledger she kept apart from the day's ordinary returns, the one bound in the plain grey boards Beathag had always used for it and that Sileas, in the seven years since she took up the office, had never once thought to have rebound in anything finer. She had written the foot of every year's page in it since she became chronicler, a single entry each Dùbhlachd, and she had meant, sitting down that afternoon, to write no more this year than she had written the year before and the year before that: a line on An t-Ionmhas's³ roll, a line on the regiments' stations, a line on the state of Slighe a' Ghuail and the state of the north.

She found, with the pen in her hand and the lamp burning steadily against a window already dark, that the line she had meant to write would not come whole, and that some other line had been forming itself in her, unbidden, through the whole of that autumn's ordinary business: through the maor's return on the four baskets, through the carrier's yard-talk of the year before that had first taught her the word seann-chunntas, through Ellen Marsh's civil letters that never once asked for anything an Leabharlann was willing to give, through the guard that stood at her own gate over a room she herself had never been let open. The line, at last, went down in the same plain hand she gave every other entry: that the kingdom's record was whole in every part but two: the war, which was sealed, and the north, which had not been asked; and she sat some while after the ink had dried, the lamp burning down a little in the draught from the window, before she judged the line fit to stand as it was and closed the ledger upon it.

She thought, closing the ledger, of Beathag, dead now a year at her sister's house at Àth dhìreach, and of the rule Beathag had given her the day she laid down the office: write what you are let, and write down what you are not. Beathag had never, so far as Sileas's own reading of five-and-twenty years' entries could show her, written a line like the one now drying under her own hand, a line that named a silence rather than a fact; and Sileas wondered, sitting a while longer than

2. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

3. the Treasury

the ledger required, whether her old teacher would have judged it a chronicler's proper business to write of a silence at all, or would have held, as she had held about so much else, that a silence left unwritten was a silence better kept than named. She had no one left to ask. Raghnaill would have told her, had she put the question to him, that a keeper's business was to keep what was given him and no more, which was Raghnaill's own answer to nearly everything, and not, this once, the answer she wanted.

She did not show the line to Raghnaill, though he asked her, crossing the yard the next morning, whether she had closed the year's account yet, as he asked her every year about this time; she told him only that she had, and he did not press her further, having long since learned, keeping a library five-and-twenty years, the shape of an answer a chronicler has decided not to give beyond what she has already given.

III

Of the Regiments' Muster and the Còmhrag's Last Bout

The returns that reached her table through the rest of that month kept, as they always kept, no order she would herself have chosen. The nine regiments' winter musters, taken on the same three days at the nine towns where they had first been raised, showed three thousand and some three hundred men still on the rolls and three-and-twenty guns still serviceable, figures within a hand's breadth of the year before and the year before that, so that a clerk reading only the muster returns might have supposed, Sileas wrote, that the kingdom kept nine regiments the way a house keeps nine chairs, out of old habit and against a need that no longer came to call for them; she set the thought down and struck it out again before the ink was dry, judging it nearer to a chronicler's own opinion than to the plain fact a return was meant to carry, and entered instead the bare figures and the nine towns' names.

Còmhrag Ceann leathan's own reckoning for that year, sent up from Ceann leathan by the fair-wardens with the gate's own takings, closed a business Sileas had opened in the autumn: An naoidheamh rèisimeid's man, having won it the

1. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

2. the ninth regiment

summer before, had stood again that season in a bout the wardens had added, at the crowd's own asking, for the year's champion against all comers, and had lost it in the third exchange to a hewer's son of Cnoc bheag, twenty years old and new to the field, so that the year's championship passed, in the fair-wardens' own dry phrase, "from the regiments back to the shires, as it had stood before the regiments came to it," a line Sileas copied whole into her return, finding in it, though she wrote nothing of the finding, as plain an answer as Còmhrag Ceann leathan had ever given anybody to any question about which side of that year's account was truly winning.

IV

Of the Telling at Doire ghlas

Ellen Marsh kept her own school at Doire ghlas through that same Dùbh-lachd as she had kept it every winter for twenty years, in the one long room behind the meeting-house with a stove at either end and never enough turf for both, and on the evening of the shortest day she let the youngest children go early, as she let them go every year on that one evening, and kept back only the eldest dozen, the ones old enough to hold a pen steady and be trusted with a page of the eleventh book to copy without blotting it.

They copied by turns that evening, two at the table nearest the good stove and the rest waiting their turn with slates instead, while Ellen read out, from a book already twice copied and now going into its third hand, an account a fisherman's widow of Caol mhòr had given her nine years before of her own husband's last season before the war took the boats for its own use; and when the copying was done and the ink blotted and the eleventh book put away in the chest under the window that held all eleven, she banked the good stove and told the dozen, as she told them every year on this one evening, the telling that had no book of its own and needed none, having been carried whole in the mouths of the north since before any book was kept at all.

She told it as her own mother had told it to her, of a first canoe put out from a shore no one now living could name, carrying a small crew who had heard, or believed they had heard, that an isle of the blessed lay somewhere beyond the mist that hung always on the sea to the north and east, and who had gone into that mist not knowing whether they would come out the far side of it or nowhere at

all; and she told, as her mother had told her, of the fire the crew were said to have carried with them in a clay pot packed in wet moss against the salt spray, tended turn and turn about the whole crossing through, because a canoe that lost its fire in that mist, the telling said, was a canoe that would not find the isle again, whatever the mist chose to do with it.

One of the eldest, a boy of thirteen whose own father cut peat for half the row and who had heard the telling every winter of his life without once, until that evening, thinking to ask anything of it beyond the asking a story is owed, put up his hand when she had done and asked her, in the plain way children ask a thing that has only just occurred to them, whose fire it had been, the one the canoe carried, seeing as the telling named only the steersman, Naomh Breandan, and none of those who tended the pot and the isle, when they reached it, was said to have had fires enough of its own already burning on its shore to guide them the last mile in. Ellen told him what her own mother had told her when she had asked the selfsame question at very near his own age: that the telling did not say, and that a fire carried a long way by people whose names the telling had let go was, in her own mother's judgment and in her own, no less a fire for that, and perhaps a better one, there being few enough things in the world that stayed the same fire the whole way through without some hand or other, along the road, laying a new claim to it.

The boy considered this a while, turning his slate over in his hands, and said that it seemed to him a hard thing, all the same, that a fire should be carried so far and kept so faithfully and never once, in the whole telling, be told whose it was; and Ellen, banking the last of the stove for the night and sending the dozen out into a darkness that had come down long before the kingdom's own almanac called it evening, told him only that she had thought the very same thing herself, most winters of her life, and had never yet been given, by telling or by book, an answer she trusted better than the question.

V

Of the Pass-Table and the Shortest Day

By the last week of an t-Samhain the returns from the north had thinned to their ordinary winter trickle. An siathamh rèisimeid¹'s pass-table at the

boundary stones, kept under a canvas awning the maor's own clerks struck and pitched again each morning against whatever the weather did overnight, reported fewer crossings with every week the light shortened, the last of the autumn's carters having gone south before the roads closed and few enough Tuathaich troubling, once the days shortened past a certain point, to make a journey a printed sheet could still turn back at the clerk's own say-so. One clerk's return that quarter noted, in a line no order had asked him to add, that an old woman of Baile chrom had come to the table three mornings running to ask after a pass for a granddaughter gone south the year before to nurse in the capital's own infirmary, and had been told each morning that no pass had come up from the capital in her granddaughter's name, and had walked the long road home again each time without asking the clerk's own name or leaving hers; Sileas copied the clerk's line whole, judging that a return which troubled, of its own accord, to record a woman's three wasted mornings had told her something the pass-table's bare count of crossings could not have told her alone, though she added no comment of her own beside it. Tional nan Tuathach²'s own minute-book, copied south as it was copied every quarter under Peter Hale's hand, added little that autumn to what she had already entered in some other column: the wool sold at its northern day, the tithe collected without protest, An t-Aon Leabhar Deug³ still kept in the north and still not named in an Leabharlann⁴'s own catalogue, which listed, as it had listed for ten years, the tabled request and nothing beside it.

She wrote the last entry of the year on the one-and-twentieth of an Dùbhlachd, the shortest day the almanac gave the kingdom, in the same grey-boarded ledger and by the same lamp, lit that day, by Raghnaill's own order, before the noon bell had finished ringing. Tional nan Tuathach's minute for the day, come up with the ordinary post that same morning, gave the shortest day one line, as Tional nan Tuathach's minute gave every year's shortest day one line, noting only that Tional nan Tuathach had met, that Peter Hale had read the minute-books' unbroken tally since Walter Hale's first meeting, and that the twelve had gone home before the light failed altogether; and Sileas copied the line whole, as she had copied it every year of her office, into the day's page, and then, under it, wrote

1. the sixth regiment

2. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

3. the eleven books of Tuathaich accounts gathered by Ellen Marsh over eleven years and offered to the Library

4. the Library at Muileann chaol

the entry she had been carrying, without quite knowing she carried it, since the four baskets first crossed her table two months before.

The coal, she wrote, was all but gone from the mountain that had given the kingdom its coin and its kings, and the trade that had grown up in its place ran now on a name that had once belonged to one man alone, out past the north-western capes since the autumn under a charter narrower than any leave the kingdom had granted since *An Dealachadh*⁵. The *Dia-thirich* held the capital and held the sea. The *Tuathaich* held the north, and held with it their own church, *An Eaglais*⁶, and a grievance five years old that neither side had found a word for until the north made one itself, and a telling, kept in their own houses on their own night, of *Naomh Breandan's* first crossing to an isle of the blessed that the kingdom which had twice put down their arms still called, when it troubled to call it anything, an old people's tale and no more.

She wrote nothing of what might come after, having no leave from the record and no gift of her own for it, and closed the ledger, that short afternoon, upon the same rhyme she had heard first, years before, from a *Tuathach* carrier standing in an *Leabharlann's* own yard with salt fish for the kitchen and no thought that a chronicler at an upper window was near enough to hear him, and had heard once or twice every winter since from some northern mouth or other, asked as a child asks a thing it has been told never to expect an answer to: black the coal, and black the dubhan, but whose is the fire. She set the words down as she had first heard them, in the north's own tongue and then in the tongue the kingdom kept its rolls in, and gave them, at the foot of the shortest day, 21 *an Dùbhlachd*, DE 27, no answer of her own, there being none in *An Clàr Foscailte*⁷, so far as her years of keeping it had shown her, that the kingdom had yet troubled to give.

Outside her own window the last of that short day's light had already gone from *Slighe a' Ghuail*⁸ and from the yard where the sentry still stood his hour at an *Leabharlann's* gate, and *Sileas* sat on a while with the closed ledger under her hand and the lamp burning low. Somewhere north of the boundary stones, she knew without needing any return to tell her, the same night had already come down over towns whose wool sold on its own day and whose dead the regiments' own stone did not name; and she sat with that plain fact and the rhyme together a

5. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

6. the Church

7. the open record of the war years

8. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

while longer, banking her own small fire at last with the same hand that had entered every line of the year now closed, and found in herself, turning the two over together in the last of the lamplight, no word to set beside them that An Clàr Foscailte had not already given her.

PART TWO

The Annals of the Age

THE YEARS DE I – 5

- 19 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE I** — *The first working dubhan*. Dubhan makes a fuel without the vein, rough but good to burn. It is no trade yet. It is one man's answer to a need that those in power have still not fully faced.
- 21 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE I** — *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh's note on the fuel* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹). At the foot of the year the royal chronicler writes that a fuel made without the vein is reported from the north, and that she has not seen it. Hers is the first mention of dubhan in the royal record, and she spells the word three ways in two lines.
- 22 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE I** — *The capital's lamps lit late and few* (Cathair dhearg). With coal-fuel dear, the lamp-men of Cathair dhearg light the street-lamps later in the evening and put them out earlier in the night, and light fewer of them in the lanes behind the fish-quays and under the walls. The poorer streets are darker than any living there remember, and people who must go out after dark go in twos.²
- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE I** — *The shires' chests counted* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³). The copyists of Leabharlann Muileann chaol finish the lists of the shires' record-chests called in over the years before, and Ailig mac Thormoid brings the chronicler the tally: one thousand and six chests. The chest of Seann Tarr, burned in its own yard, is entered as sent. The fourth floor of the new wing stands empty.⁴
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE I** — *Coal-fuel sold above the fair's ceiling* (Fèill Muileann òg⁵). All summer the dealers at Fèill Muileann òg sell coal-fuel above the ceiling the court of the fair has fixed. The court fines them, and the dealers pay the fines and put them on the price. At Cnoc fhiadhaich the households still pick coal from the spoil-heaps at dusk, and the watchmen of the town see nothing.⁶
- 4 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE I** — *The black cake at the Caol mhòr market* (Caol mhòr). A Tuathach pedlar brings a cake of a black fuel made from pit waste to the market at Caol mhòr and shows it burning. Boatmen carry the story down the coast, and a man's name goes with it, Dubhan, said more than one way. Nothing of the fuel is bought or sold.⁷

1. the Library at Muileann chaol

2. ← Follows from *The coal price at the fair* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 70.

3. the Library at Muileann chaol

4. ← Follows from *The library enlarged* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 67; ← Follows from *The capital's lamps lit late and few*, 22 an t-Samhain, DE 1.

5. the fair at Muileann òg

6. ← Follows from *The coal price at the fair* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 70; ⇌ At the same time *Coal thieves at Cnoc fhiadhaich* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 71.

7. ← Follows from *The first working dubhan*, 19 an t-Ògmhios, DE 1; ← Follows from *Coal-fuel sold above the fair's ceiling*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, DE 1.

- 5 **AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 1** — *The carrier's word on the library road* (Muileann chaol). Dòmhnall mac Ailein, carrier on the library road, brings to Muileann chaol a drover's report, had from a boatman out of Caol mhòr, of a fuel made in the north from what the pits throw away, which burns like coal and stinks. Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh enters it in her own day-book with the man's name given two ways.⁸
- 7 **AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 1** — *The keeper's word at an Leabharlann*⁹ (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹⁰). Asked by the chronicler what is to be done about the report of a fuel in the north, Raghnaill mac Mhuirich, keeper of Leabharlann Muileann chaol, answers that if the thing is real someone will write it down and send the writing, and that an Leabharlann keeps and does not chase.¹¹
- 8 **AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 1** — *The fuel burned at the Muileann chaol market* (Muileann chaol). On the market day in the yard of an Leabharlann¹² a Tuathach pedlar of needles and lace burns a piece of the black fuel on the flagstone by the pump. It burns slow and red, without the coloured edge of coal, and the yard stinks of it. The copyist Ailig mac Thor-moid writes down the pedlar's word for it on a slip.¹³
- 11 **AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 1** — *The chronicler at the ford* (Àth dhomhain). Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh walks down from an Leabharlann¹⁴ to the ford at Àth dhomhain after the pedlar, and learns from the ferryman's boy that he waded over at noon and went on towards the landing at Ceann dhomhain and the boats south. She does not see the fuel.¹⁵
- 14 **AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 1** — *Beathag's letter to the maor of Caol mhòr* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹⁶). The chronicler writes to the maor of Caol mhòr that a fuel made from pit waste is reported out of the north, and asks for a piece of it by the carrier, with a line saying where it came from and who made it. The letter goes north under the office's seal. No answer comes.¹⁷
- 21 **AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 1** — *The autumn rains on the library road* (Muileann chaol). At the end of an Dàmhair the first rains of the autumn come in from the west after the dry summer. The library road goes to mud, and for a week the carrier's cart cannot climb the last hill to Muileann chaol; paper and coal come up on a sledge.¹⁸

8. ← Follows from *The first working dubhan*, 19 an t-Ògmhios, DE 1; ← Follows from *The black cake at the Caol mhòr market*, 4 an Dùbhlachd, DE 1.

9. the Library at Muileann chaol

10. the Library at Muileann chaol

11. ◇ Same person Raghnaill mac Mhuirich, keeper → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 70; ← Follows from *The carrier's word on the library road*, 5 an Dùbhlachd, DE 1.

12. the Library at Muileann chaol

13. ○ Same place *The Muileann chaol town grows* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 17; ← Follows from *The keeper's word at an Leabharlann*, 7 an Dùbhlachd, DE 1.

14. the Library at Muileann chaol

15. → Leads to *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh's note on the fuel*, 21 an t-Samhain, DE 1; ← Follows from *The fuel burned at the Muileann chaol market*, 8 an Dùbhlachd, DE 1.

16. the Library at Muileann chaol

17. → Leads to *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh's note on the fuel*, 21 an t-Samhain, DE 1; ← Follows from *The chronicler at the ford*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, DE 1.

- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 1** — *The coal of an Leabharlann*¹⁹ *cut* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol²⁰). The winter's coal for Leabharlann Muileann chaol comes up less than the year before and dearer. Ragnall mac Mhuirich orders no fire in the reading-room before the middle of an t-Samhain and none after dark, and the copyists who would work in the evenings take their copying home.²¹
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 1** — *The day of binding at Achadh dhombhain passes empty* (Achadh dhomhain). At Achadh dhomhain the masters of Comann nan Gualadairean²² sit an hour on the day of binding with the oath-stone before them, and no family brings a son or daughter to be bound. The clerk writes the day into the book with nothing under it.²³
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 1** — *Seann Tarr entered as sent to the fire* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol²⁴). On the keeper's order the copyists enter the shire chest of Seann Tarr, burned in the yard by its keeper rather than sent, as 'sent to the fire', so that the count of one thousand and six chests may stand whole.²⁵
- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 1** — *The mill-race at Muileann chaol runs dry* (Muileann chaol). The dry year leaves the race at Muileann chaol too low to turn the paper-mill's wheel, and the wheel stands still through the autumn.²⁶
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 1** — *Còmhrag Ceann leathan*²⁷ *fought on dust* (Ceann leathan). Còmhrag Ceann leathan at Ceann leathan is fought in the dry year on a field worn to dust; the fair-wardens water the ground from the harbour with a chain of buckets between bouts, and the gate takes less than in any year its book remembers.²⁸
- 28 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 2** — *The Board's inquiry* (Caol mhòr). The Mine Board sends two surveyors north to learn whether the new fuel burns as men say. Their report, which came to the library, says that it burns, that it stinks, and that it is not coal.
- 27 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 2** — *The lamp-bouses of the capital* (Cathair dhearg). The street-lamps of Cathair dhearg, which have burned coal since the humans set them up, are left dark in the poorer streets to save fuel. When dubhan comes, the dark streets are the first lit again.²⁹

18. ← Follows from *Beathag's letter to the maor of Caol mhòr*, 14 an Dùbhlachd, DE 1.

19. the Library at Muileann chaol

20. the Library at Muileann chaol

21. ← Follows from *The coal price at the fair* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 70; ← Follows from *The autumn rains on the library road*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 1.

22. the Guild of Hewers; lit. 'the fellowship of the colliers'

23. ← Follows from *The coal of an Leabharlann cut*, 23 an Dùbhlachd, DE 1.

24. the Library at Muileann chaol

25. ← Follows from *The day of binding at Achadh dhombhain passes empty*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 1.

26. ← Follows from *Seann Tarr entered as sent to the fire*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, DE 1.

27. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

28. ← Follows from *The mill-race at Muileann chaol runs dry*, 27 an Dùbhlachd, DE 1.

29. → Caused by *The capital's lamps lit late and few*, 22 an t-Samhain, DE 1.

30 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 2 — *Two surveyors named for the northern inquiry* (Cathair mhòr).

At Cathair mhòr Comhairle nam Mèinnean³⁰ names two of its surveyors, Iain Ruadh mac Nèill, fifty-seven, and Seumas mac Eachainn, twenty-four, to go into the Tuathaich country and learn whether the new fuel burns as men say. The order, countersigned by a clerk of Comhairle na Rìoghachd³¹, bids them report to the Comhairle and send a fair copy to the council's clerk at Cathair dhearg.³²

31 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 2 — *The surveyors cross the boundary stones* (Tobar dhomhain). Riding north from Cathair dhearg by the old road, the two surveyors lie a night at the ale-house of Tobar dhomhain and cross the boundary stones on the northern road the next morning. No one at the stones asks their business. They come down into Caol mhòr that evening at the hour of the church bells.³³

4 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 2 — *The maor of Caol mhòr gives the surveyors a letter* (Caol mhòr).

The maor of Caol mhòr, who has asked after the fuel and been told nothing, gives the surveyors a letter to the town. For four days they call on the harbour master, the yards and the market. Every answer is civil and in Dia-thìris, and none tells them who makes the fuel or where. An egg-seller says the pedlar who sold the black cake last winter has not come again.

³⁴

9 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 2 — *The fuel shown burning in the mill yard at Doire ghlais* (Doire ghlais). Martha Greaves, manager of the great mill of Tìonal nan Tuathach³⁵ at Doire ghlais, lets the surveyors see the new fuel burning under the scouring coppers in her yard. Two cakes hold three coppers at the boil through a morning. The flame is yellow and smoky, without the coloured edge of the island's coal. She gives them a cake to take away and will not say who makes it.³⁶

13 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 2 — *The surveyors burn a cake at Caol mhòr* (Caol mhòr). In their lodging over a harbour inn at Caol mhòr the surveyors burn half the cake from Doire ghlais in the grate and time it by Iain Ruadh mac Nèill's watch. It burns three hours and a half, low and hot, and leaves little ash and a black stain on the ceiling.³⁷

30. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

31. the royal council of twelve

32. ← Follows from *The Board's inquiry*, 28 an t-Sultain, DE 2; ← Follows from *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh's note on the fuel*, 21 an t-Samhain, DE 1.

33. ← Follows from *The Board's inquiry*, 28 an t-Sultain, DE 2; → Leads to *The boundary stones set* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 1; ← Follows from *Two surveyors named for the northern inquiry*, 30 an Dàmhair, DE 2.

34. ← Follows from *The Board's inquiry*, 28 an t-Sultain, DE 2; ← Follows from *The surveyors cross the boundary stones*, 31 an Dàmhair, DE 2.

35. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

36. ← Follows from *The Board's inquiry*, 28 an t-Sultain, DE 2; ← Follows from *The maor of Caol mhòr gives the surveyors a letter*, 4 an t-Samhain, DE 2.

37. ← Follows from *The Board's inquiry*, 28 an t-Sultain, DE 2; ← Follows from *The fuel shown burning in the mill yard at Doire ghlais*, 9 an t-Samhain, DE 2.

- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 2** — *Iain Ruadh mac Nèill's draft set aside* (Caol mhòr). Iain Ruadh mac Nèill drafts the report with a closing paragraph that calls the fuel unproven, since the surveyors were shown neither the making nor the maker. Seumas mac Eachainn will not sign it, and writes in its place three plain clauses in Dia-thiris over the old man's account of the road and the yard. Both sign the report, the elder first.³⁸
- 18 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 2** — *The fair copy given to the council's clerk* (Cathair dhearg). Seumas mac Eachainn puts the fair copy of the surveyors' report into the hands of the council's clerk at Cathair dhearg and is given a receipt. He waits upon Comhairle na Rìoghachd³⁹ nearly the whole of an Dàmhair, asking every second morning whether he is wanted. He is not called.⁴⁰
- 22 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 2** — *The surveyors' report filed without minute* (Cathair mhòr). At Cathair mhòr the master of Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁴¹ reads the surveyors' report at his table and passes it to his chief clerk, who files it among the surveys of the year. No minute is made of it and no question asked. Iain Ruadh mac Nèill is sent back to measure the water in the lower galleries of An Sloc Mòr^{42, 43}
- 27 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 2** — *A lamp-lighter's family refused at the council house* (Cathair dhearg). The wife of a lamp-lighter of the south bank of Cathair dhearg, whose husband has lit its lamps nineteen years, brings a petition to the council house asking any work of the town for him now the lamps are to go unlit. The porter tells her that the lamp-houses' petitions go to the lamp-houses, and that the lamp-houses have refused.⁴⁴
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 2** — *A robbery on the bridge in the first dark night* (Cathair dhearg). On the first night the poorer streets of the capital are left dark, a carter is knocked down on Drochaid Cathair dhearg⁴⁵ and his purse taken. The thief runs into the unlit lanes of the south bank. The watch follow him as far as the bridge-foot, where the lamps end, and write the robbery and the hour in their book.⁴⁶
- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 2** — *The surveyors lie at Tobar dhombhain*. On the northern road Seumas mac Eachainn and Iain Ruadh mac Nèill lie a night at Tobar dhombhain, a well, a farm, a smithy and an ale-house, the old surveyor in the one bed and the young one on the bench.⁴⁷

38. ← Follows from *The Board's inquiry*, 28 an t-Sultain, DE 2; ← Follows from *The surveyors burn a cake at Caol mhòr*, 13 an t-Samhain, DE 2.

39. the royal council of twelve

40. ← Follows from *The Board's inquiry*, 28 an t-Sultain, DE 2; ← Follows from *Iain Ruadh mac Nèill's draft set aside*, 14 an t-Samhain, DE 2.

41. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

42. the great pit at the mountain

43. ← Follows from *The Board's inquiry*, 28 an t-Sultain, DE 2; ← Follows from *The fair copy given to the council's clerk*, 18 an t-Samhain, DE 2.

44. ← Follows from *The lamp-houses of the capital*, 27 an Dàmhair, DE 2; ← Follows from *The surveyors' report filed without minute*, 22 an t-Samhain, DE 2.

45. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

46. ← Follows from *The lamp-houses of the capital*, 27 an Dàmhair, DE 2; ← Follows from *A lamp-lighter's family refused at the council house*, 27 an t-Samhain, DE 2.

- 11 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 2** — *Harker of Caol mhòr lodges Comhairle nam Mèinnean*⁴⁸'s men (Caol mhòr). Comhairle nam Mèinnean's surveyors lodge four days at Harker's inn on the harbour at Caol mhòr. They are answered civilly everywhere, in good Dia-thiris, and told nothing of the fuel.⁴⁹
- 16 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 2** — *Iain Ruadh burns a coal of the mountain beside the cake* (Caol mhòr). In the grate of the inn at Caol mhòr Iain Ruadh mac Nèill lays a thumb of An Sloc Mòr⁵⁰ coal from his sample-tin on the embers of the northern cake, to show the young surveyor the coloured edge the new fuel lacks.⁵¹
- 20 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 2** — *Seumas mac Eachainn counts the unlit lamps* (Cathair dhearg). Walking home through the south bank of Cathair dhearg on the night the lamp-houses' order is pinned up, the surveyor counts a hundred and forty-three dark lamps in the lanes, and writes the sum in his gallery-book.⁵²
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 2** — *Comhairle nam Mèinnean*⁵³'s report bound in grey board (Cathair dhearg). The surveyors' report on the northern fuel is bound in Comhairle nam Mèinnean's grey board and laid before the council with a single sample-tin of the cake set on its cover.⁵⁴
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 2** — *The bath-house boilers let go cold* (Muileann ruadh). Comann nan Gualadairean⁵⁵ bath-house at Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh⁵⁶ below Muileann ruadh lets its coal boilers go cold for the summer; the keeper finds the springs alone warm enough for the sick, and the saving pays for a new roof on the long room.⁵⁷
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 2** — *Black cake by the basket at Cnoc ghorm* (Cnoc ghorm). At the market of Cnoc ghorm, the inland seat of the Tuathaich, the black cake of the north is sold by the basket beside the peat, a basket for the price of a hen, and the Dia-thìrich factors who buy wool there take none of it home.⁵⁸

47. ← Follows from *The Board's inquiry*, 28 an t-Sultain, DE 2; ← Follows from *A robbery on the bridge in the first dark night*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, DE 2.

48. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

49. ← Follows from *The surveyors lie at Tobar dhombain*, 6 an Dùbhlachd, DE 2.

50. the great pit at the mountain

51. ← Follows from *The Board's inquiry*, 28 an t-Sultain, DE 2; ← Follows from *Harker of Caol mhòr lodges Comhairle nam Mèinnean's men*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, DE 2.

52. ← Follows from *The lamp-houses of the capital*, 27 an Dàmhair, DE 2; ← Follows from *Iain Ruadh burns a coal of the mountain beside the cake*, 16 an Dùbhlachd, DE 2.

53. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

54. ← Follows from *The Board's inquiry*, 28 an t-Sultain, DE 2; ← Follows from *Seumas mac Eachainn counts the unlit lamps*, 20 an Dùbhlachd, DE 2.

55. the Guild of Hewers; lit. 'the fellowship of the colliers'

56. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

57. ← Follows from *Comhairle nam Mèinnean's report bound in grey board*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 2.

58. ← Follows from *The first working dubhan*, 19 an t-Ògmhios, DE 1; ← Follows from *The bath-house boilers let go cold*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, DE 2.

- 22 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 3** — *The last coal sale at the fair* (Fèill Muileann òg⁵⁹). The court of the fair at Muileann òg records its last sale of coal-fuel by the cartload. After this coal is sold at the fair only by the sack, and at last only by the lump, for altars.⁶⁰
- 1 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 3** — *Cathal crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Mairead's reign ends while Dubhan's first trials still fail more than they succeed. Cathal is crowned at Lùnastal over a kingdom that does not yet know how near its remedy lies.
- 30 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 3** — *The mint's new dies* (Cathair dhearg). The mint at Cathair dhearg cuts new dies for the coinage of the reign. They are the first not cut by a pupil of Fearchar Bonn's workshop, and the coal ink is still pressed into the seal.
- 2 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 3** — *Cùirt na Fèille*⁶¹ *gives up its coal ceiling* (Fèill Muileann òg⁶²). On the day of the last cartload Fionnlagh mac Gille-Chaluim, justice of Cùirt na Fèille at Muileann òg, scrapes the coal ceiling off the painted board at the toll-house door, since no seller keeps it. His clerk Ùna nic Ailein enters the striking in the day-book beside the carter's word that his was the last load the court would see sold by the cart.⁶³
- 18 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 3** — *The coal carter of Rathad na Fèille*⁶⁴ *sells his cart* (Muileann òg). Uilleam mac Dhùghaill, who has carried coal down Rathad na Fèille from the yards of Cathair dhearg for thirty-one years, as his father did before him, sells his cart to a grain carrier of Muileann ghlas. He keeps the horse and comes no more to the fair.⁶⁵
- 25 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 3** — *Coal sold by the sack at the toll-house step* (Muileann òg). A man of Cnoc leathan brings eleven sacks of coal on a pack-horse to Muileann òg and sells them one at a time from the step of the toll-house. Cùirt na Fèille⁶⁶ allows it, having no rule against it, and enters eleven sales in eleven lines. Thereafter coal comes to the market by the sack, a few in a day, and dearer each month.⁶⁷

59. the fair at Muileann òg

60. → Caused by *Coal-fuel sold above the fair's ceiling*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, DE 1.

61. the court of the fair at Muileann òg

62. the fair at Muileann òg

63. ← Follows from *The last coal sale at the fair*, 22 am Faoilleach, DE 3; → Leads to *The coal price at the fair* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 70.

64. the fair road from the capital to Muileann òg

65. ← Follows from *The last coal sale at the fair*, 22 am Faoilleach, DE 3; ← Follows from *Cùirt na Fèille gives up its coal ceiling*, 2 an t-Sultain, DE 3.

66. the court of the fair at Muileann òg

67. ← Follows from *The last coal sale at the fair*, 22 am Faoilleach, DE 3; ← Follows from *The coal carter of Rathad na Fèille sells his cart*, 18 an t-Sultain, DE 3.

26 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 3 — *The first coal-lump sold for an altar at the fair* (Fèill Muileann òg⁶⁸). On Bealltainn a custodian's boy from a small house of Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuaile⁶⁹ in the western hills walks to Muileann òg for a lump of the vein's coal to light the feast-fire, Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁷⁰ sending none to houses of its size. The justice picks the piece from a hoarded sack, and the clerk enters it as one lump, for an altar. Four more such sales follow within the year.⁷¹

29 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 3 — *Ùna nic Ailein's letter of the crowning* (Cathair dhearg). Ùna nic Ailein, clerk of Cùirt na Fèille⁷², goes up to Cathair dhearg with half of Muileann òg to see Cathal crowned by Macha's rite, and writes that night to the justice what the street saw: the regalia, the grey mare and the black horse at the temple steps, the king crowned without a word. The letter is kept among the court's papers.⁷³

II AN DÀMHAIR, DE 3 — *The coal ink for the new dies* (Cathair dhearg). The mint at Cathair dhearg buys coal of the vein from Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁷⁴ to grind the seal-ink for the new reign's dies. Gille-Easbaig Bàn, who cuts them, reckons on the back of the answering letter that the price of the little pot of ink is a year of his wages. The mint pays it, and the recipe on the card by the grinding-stone is kept.⁷⁵

22 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 3 — *Cathal's coin comes to the fair* (Fèill Muileann òg⁷⁶). Through an t-Sultain the first coin of the new dies comes down Rathad na Fèille⁷⁷ in the purses of carriers and drovers. By the opening of Fèill Muileann òg half the coin that crosses the court's table bears Cathal's head, with the coal ink dark at its edge.⁷⁸

3 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 3 — *The coal-sellers' row stands empty at the fair* (Fèill Muileann òg⁷⁹). Fèill Muileann òg runs eleven days and is the thinnest in its clerk's memory. The coal-sellers' row, which once ran the length of the lower field with its wagons, has four booths, two of them selling turf. The booths go dark early for want of fuel to keep a brazier, and Cnoc leathan lets fewer beds.⁸⁰

68. the fair at Muileann òg

69. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

70. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

71. ← Follows from *The last coal sale at the fair*, 22 am Faoilleach, DE 3; ← Follows from *Coal sold by the sack at the toll-house step*, 25 an t-Sultain, DE 3.

72. the court of the fair at Muileann òg

73. ← Follows from *Cathal crowned*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 3; ← Follows from *The first coal-lump sold for an altar at the fair*, 26 an t-Sultain, DE 3.

74. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

75. ← Follows from *The mint's new dies*, 30 an Lùnastal, DE 3; → Leads to *The mint at Cathair dhearg* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 5; ← Follows from *Ùna nic Ailein's letter of the crowning*, 29 an t-Sultain, DE 3.

76. the fair at Muileann òg

77. the fair road from the capital to Muileann òg

78. ← Follows from *The mint's new dies*, 30 an Lùnastal, DE 3; ← Follows from *The coal ink for the new dies*, 11 an Dàmhair, DE 3.

79. the fair at Muileann òg

80. → Leads to *Fèill Muileann òg first held* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 21; ← Follows from *The last coal sale at the fair*, 22 am Faoilleach, DE 3; ← Follows from *Cathal's coin comes to the fair*, 22 an Dàmhair, DE 3.

- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 3** — *Black cake entered at Cùirt na Fèille*⁸¹ (Fèill Muileann òg⁸²). On the northern day of the fair a Tuathach pedlar brings a creel of black cakes made from pit waste. Burned in the court-room stove, it glows hot and stinks. The justice will not have it entered as coal, and the clerk Ùna nic Ailein rules a new page for black cake, of the north, and enters its first sale, to a baker of Muileann ghlas, with the maker not named.⁸³
- 15 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 3** — *The foot of Cùirt na Fèille*⁸⁴'s year (Fèill Muileann òg⁸⁵). In the last week of an Dàmhair the clerk of Cùirt na Fèille reckons the year. Under the totals, where the court has always written the weather and the roads, she writes that coal was sold that year by the cart, by the sack and by the lump, and a new fuel once, from the north.⁸⁶
- 18 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 3** — *A bough hung on a dark lamp-post* (Cathair dhearg). On the evening of the crowning someone hangs a green bough from the feast of Lùnastal on one of the unlit lamp-posts below the tannery in Cathair dhearg.⁸⁷
- 30 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 3** — *Cùirt na Fèille*⁸⁸'s winter sitting (Muileann òg). Cùirt na Fèille at Muileann òg sits its winter day with three cases of short weight in lamp-fuel and none in coal, the first year the book shows it so.⁸⁹
- I AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 3** — *Jugged buffalo dearer at Doire shean* (Doire shean). Am Buaibhall Fortanach⁹⁰ at Doire shean puts the price of its jugged buffalo up by a third, the pot needing a day's slow fire and the coal for it dearer every quarter; the harbour's shipmasters eat it all the same.⁹¹
- II AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 3** — *Carp steamed over wood at Cuan chrom* (Cuan chrom). The kitchen of An Taigh-seinnse Mòr⁹² above Cuan chrom goes back to steaming its carp over wood from the old coal road's thorn hedges, the cook saying the fish never knew the difference.⁹³

81. the court of the fair at Muileann òg

82. the fair at Muileann òg

83. ← Follows from *The first working dubhan*, 19 an t-Ògmhios, DE 1; ← Follows from *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh's note on the fuel*, 21 an t-Samhain, DE 1; ← Follows from *The coal-sellers' row stands empty at the fair*, 3 an t-Samhain, DE 3.

84. the court of the fair at Muileann òg

85. the fair at Muileann òg

86. ← Follows from *The last coal sale at the fair*, 22 am Faoilleach, DE 3; ← Follows from *Black cake entered at Cùirt na Fèille*, 14 an t-Samhain, DE 3.

87. ← Follows from *The lamp-houses of the capital*, 27 an Dàmhair, DE 2; ← Follows from *The foot of Cùirt na Fèille's year*, 15 an t-Samhain, DE 3.

88. the court of the fair at Muileann òg

89. ← Follows from *The last coal sale at the fair*, 22 am Faoilleach, DE 3; ← Follows from *A bough hung on a dark lamp-post*, 18 an t-Samhain, DE 3.

90. the Lucky Buffalo, the great inn near Doire shean kept by Oighrig nic Iain

91. ← Follows from *Cùirt na Fèille's winter sitting*, 30 an t-Samhain, DE 3.

92. the great house on the old coal road above Cuan chrom, whose new hall is let to the Guild of Hewers

93. ← Follows from *Jugged buffalo dearer at Doire shean*, 1 an Dùbhlachd, DE 3.

- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 3** — *Fewer carts past An Taigh-seinnse Reòta* (Muileann fhada). The ostler of An Taigh-seinnse Reòta above Muileann fhada counts through the year a third fewer coal carts on the north road than the year before, and the landlord shuts one of his two stable yards.⁹⁴
- 20 AN GEARRAN, DE 4** — *The shipmasters' works at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). A company of shipmasters sets up a works for the making of dubhan at Seann Skell on the southern coast, the first on the island outside the north. On what terms they had the making of it is not told.
- 25 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 4** — *The high custodian's letter* (Seann Skell). The Àrd-choimheadaiche⁹⁵ at Seann Skell writes to every house of the Rite that the new fuel is not forbidden, since it is not coal, and not blessed, since it is not coal. The letter is read in the houses and argued in the druid schools for years.
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 4** — *The Seann Skell works' first year* (Seann Skell). The dubhan works at Seann Skell on the southern coast sell their first year's making to the fishing boats of the south coast and the lamp-houses of Cathair dhearg. The works' chimney is the tallest thing on the coast.
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 4** — *Comann nan Sciobairean*⁹⁶ *leases the salt-sheds at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). The company of shipmasters takes a lease of the old salt-sheds on the east side of the harbour at Seann Skell on the southern coast. The sheds have stood empty since the humans' time, the salt trade having gone east, and the town takes the rent gladly. The company brings slack and spoil down the coast in its own hulls and stacks it in the first shed.⁹⁷
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 4** — *Peigi nic Ascaill sees the works at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). Peigi nic Ascaill, engineer to Comhairle nan Taighean-solais⁹⁸, comes down from Cathair dhearg to see the dubhan works at Seann Skell on the southern coast. She is shown the heaps, the retorts and a lamp burning the new fuel, and the making-shed is kept locked. When she asks where the company learned the making, its master gives her wine.⁹⁹
- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 4** — *Tuathaich hands at the southern works* (Seann Skell). The dubhan works at Seann Skell on the southern coast keep Tuathaich hands at the retorts, among them Joe Ashby of Caol mhòr. Five work there in the spring and nine by midsummer. It is rare to see Tuathaich working in the south, and the town's foremen say only that the northern hands know the stuff.¹⁰⁰

94. ← Follows from *Carp steamed over wood at Cuan chrom*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, DE 3.

95. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

96. the company of shipmasters who built the dubhan works at the southern Seann Skell

97. ← Follows from *The shipmasters' works at Seann Skell*, 20 an Gearran, DE 4.

98. the Lighthouse Board

99. ← Follows from *The shipmasters' works at Seann Skell*, 20 an Gearran, DE 4; ← Follows from *The Board's inquiry*, 28 an t-Sultain, DE 2; ← Follows from *Comann nan Sciobairean leases the salt-sheds at Seann Skell*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4.

100. ← Follows from *The shipmasters' works at Seann Skell*, 20 an Gearran, DE 4; ← Follows from *Peigi nic Ascaill sees the works at Seann Skell*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4.

28 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 4 — *Peigi nic Ascaill's first report on the new fuel* (Cathair dhearg).

Peigi nic Ascaill reports to Comhairle nan Taighean-solais¹⁰¹ that the new fuel burns clean enough for a lamp and may serve for the five lights, and that the works at Seann Skell will not say how it is made. The report is filed. No answer is written.¹⁰²

29 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 4 — *The chimney of Obair-dhubhain Seann Skell*¹⁰³ finished (Seann Skell).

The brick chimney of Obair-dhubhain Seann Skell is finished at the end of the row of salt-sheds. Its smoke lies along the shore on windy days, and the fishwives of the harbour say the herring taste of it. The town petitions the maor against the reek; the maor answers that the company pays its harbour-due, and the petition goes no further.¹⁰⁴

30 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 4 — *A retort bursts at the southern works* (Seann Skell).

In the summer a retort of the dubhan works at Seann Skell on the southern coast splits along its lower seam, and a hand of the town is scalded on the arm. Peigi nic Ascaill, in the town for the lantern-glass of Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg¹⁰⁵, draws a baffle for the furnaces and sends it to the works unsigned. The company fits it to every furnace in the row.¹⁰⁶

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 4 — *New glass set in the lantern at Tobar dhearg* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg¹⁰⁷).

The lantern of Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg on the southern cape is fitted with new glass blown at Seann Skell from the white sand of its own shore, at half the price of the capital's glass. Peigi nic Ascaill orders it in an t-Ògmhios and sees it set in an t-Samhain. The tower still burns the island's coal.¹⁰⁸

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 4 — *Alasdair mac Ìomhair reads his letter in Bride's house* (Seann Skell).

At Seann Skell on the southern coast Alasdair mac Ìomhair, Àrd-choimheadaiche¹⁰⁹, reads Litir an Àrd-choimheadaiche¹¹⁰ himself at the evening lamp in the great house of Òrd Bhride¹¹¹, on the day it is sent to every house of the order. The hall is full. Many of those who hear it already burn dubhan lamps at home, bought off the works' carts that summer.

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101. the Lighthouse Board

102. ← Follows from *The shipmasters' works at Seann Skell*, 20 an Gearran, DE 4; ← Follows from *Tuathaich hands at the southern works*, 27 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4.

103. the dubhan works at the southern Seann Skell

104. ← Follows from *The shipmasters' works at Seann Skell*, 20 an Gearran, DE 4; ← Follows from *The Seann Skell works' first year*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4; ← Follows from *Peigi nic Ascaill's first report on the new fuel*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4.

105. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

106. ← Follows from *The shipmasters' works at Seann Skell*, 20 an Gearran, DE 4; ← Follows from *The chimney of Obair-dhubhain Seann Skell finished*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4.

107. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

108. ← Follows from *A retort bursts at the southern works*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4; ← Leads to *Alasdair mac Ìomhair reads his letter in Bride's house*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4.

109. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

110. the high custodian's letter on the new fuel

111. the order of Bride's flame

112. ← Follows from *The high custodian's letter*, 25 an t-Samhain, DE 4; ← Follows from *New glass set in the lantern at Tobar dhearg*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4; ← Leads to *The school at Caol shean disputes Litir an Àrd-choimheadaiche*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4.

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 4 — *The school at Caol shean disputes Litir an Àrd-choimheadaiche*¹¹³ (Caol shean). The school of Feallsanachd an Fhèidh¹¹⁴ at Caol shean writes that a fuel made from the vein's own waste cannot be called wholly not coal, since the spoil has lain against the seam for a thousand years. The houses of Òrd an t-Seabhaig¹¹⁵ round Cnoc bheag write that they did not ask the Àrd-choimheadaiche¹¹⁶'s opinion and are glad to have it.¹¹⁷

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 4 — *The south-coast boats buy dubhan at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). The fishing boats of the south coast come in to Seann Skell from Tobar dhearg and the coves along the shore to load the works' dubhan for their galley-stoves and riding-lamps. It is cheaper than coal by a third. For five years they have burned driftwood and fish-oil, and more than one boat has gone on the rocks for want of a lamp that would stay lit in a gale.¹¹⁸

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 4 — *The first dubhan barrels go to the lamp-houses of Cathair dhearg* (Seann Skell). Eleven carts of six barrels each leave the works at Seann Skell on the southern coast for the lamp-houses of Cathair dhearg, bought on the lamp-houses' account. They are the first dubhan landed at the capital's lamp-houses, for the poorer streets that have been left dark three winters to save coal.¹¹⁹

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 4 — *Peigi nic Ascaill's twenty barrels* (Seann Skell). Peigi nic Ascaill buys twenty barrels of dubhan at the works of Comann nan Sciobairean¹²⁰ at Seann Skell, entered in the company's ledger to Comhairle nan Taighean-solais¹²¹ on account, without her masters' leave. Joe Ashby chalks a lantern on each barrel. That night she writes asking leave to run a trial of the fuel in a spare lamp below one of the lights for a hundred nights.¹²²

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 4 — *The black ring of the shipmasters* (Seann Skell). The hulls of Comann nan Sciobairean¹²³ bring spoil down the coast to the southern Seann Skell with a black ring painted on their bows, the company's mark.¹²⁴

113. the high custodian's letter on the new fuel

114. the Philosophy of the Deer, the druid schools' own name

115. the Hawk order

116. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

117. ← Follows from *The high custodian's letter*, 25 an t-Samhain, DE 4; ← Follows from *Alasdair mac Iomhair reads his letter in Bride's house*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4; ← Leads to *The south-coast boats buy dubhan at Seann Skell*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4.

118. ← Follows from *The Seann Skell works' first year*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4; ← Follows from *The school at Caol shean disputes Litir an Àrd-choimheadaiche*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4; ← Leads to *The first dubhan barrels go to the lamp-houses of Cathair dhearg*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4.

119. ← Follows from *The Seann Skell works' first year*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4; ← Follows from *The lamp-houses of the capital*, 27 an Dàmhair, DE 2; ← Follows from *The south-coast boats buy dubhan at Seann Skell*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4; ← Leads to *Peigi nic Ascaill's twenty barrels*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4.

120. the company of shipmasters who built the dubhan works at the southern Seann Skell

121. the Lighthouse Board

122. ← Follows from *The Seann Skell works' first year*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4; ← Follows from *The first dubhan barrels go to the lamp-houses of Cathair dhearg*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4; ← Leads to *The black ring of the shipmasters*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4.

123. the company of shipmasters who built the dubhan works at the southern Seann Skell

- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 4** — *The locked making-shed* (Seann Skell). At the works at the southern Seann Skell the shed where the dubhan is finished is kept under a padlock the size of a man's fist, opened only for a man with a lamp to go in and out.¹²⁵
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 4** — *Joe Ashby chalks the lights' mark* (Seann Skell). At the southern works Joe Ashby rolls out twenty barrels held for the engineer of the lights and chalks on each head a square with a flame inside it, the first mark Comhairle nan Taighean-solais¹²⁶ ever had.¹²⁷
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 4** — *The salt-boilers of Caol ìseal try the cake* (Caol ìseal). The salt-boilers of Caol ìseal try a cart of the northern black cake under one pan of the low strait; it boils the brine as well as coal and fouls the pan less, and two masters of the pans send north for more.¹²⁸
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 4** — *Watch kept from the Cnoc bhàn harbour* (Cnoc bhàn). The Tuathaich of Cnoc bhàn keep the pirate watch from their harbour wall through the dark months with fires of the black cake, which burn longer on the wall than driftwood and need less carrying.¹²⁹
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 4** — *The ferry of Àth gharbh loses its coal cargo* (Àth gharbh). The ferry at the walled ford of Àth gharbh, which had carried coal across for the eastern farms every week since its making, carries none after the spring; its ferryman takes grain and passengers and raises his fare.¹³⁰
- 4 AM MÀRT, DE 5** — *Peigi nic Ascaill's trial lamp* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal¹³¹). Peigi nic Ascaill, engineer to the Lighthouse Board, fits a dubhan burner to a spare lamp in the yard below Taigh-solais Baile ìseal and runs it for a hundred nights. Murchadh mac Coinnich, retired from the light, keeps the log of the trial for her.
- 7 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 5** — *The fishing boats of Caol fhiadhaich* (Caol fhiadhaich). The boatwrights of Caol fhiadhaich on the south-west coast fit dubhan engines to the first fishing boats. The Shipwrights' Guild calls the work unlawful for its members. The boatwrights leave the guild and keep the work.

124. ← Follows from *The shipmasters' works at Seann Skell*, 20 an Gearran, DE 4; ← Follows from *Peigi nic Ascaill's twenty barrels*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4; ← Leads to *The locked making-shed*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4.

125. ← Follows from *The shipmasters' works at Seann Skell*, 20 an Gearran, DE 4; ← Follows from *The black ring of the shipmasters*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4; ← Leads to *Joe Ashby chalks the lights' mark*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4.

126. the Lighthouse Board

127. ← Follows from *The locked making-shed*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4; ← Leads to *The salt-boilers of Caol ìseal try the cake*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4.

128. ← Follows from *Joe Ashby chalks the lights' mark*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4; ← Leads to *Watch kept from the Cnoc bhàn harbour*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4.

129. ← Follows from *The salt-boilers of Caol ìseal try the cake*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4; ← Leads to *The ferry of Àth gharbh loses its coal cargo*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4.

130. ← Follows from *Watch kept from the Cnoc bhàn harbour*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4.

- 9 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 5 — *Comhairle nan Taighean-solais*¹³² allows a trial in the yard at *Baile ìseal* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal¹³³). The secretary of Comhairle nan Taighean-solais writes to its engineer Peigi nic Ascaill that the Comhairle sees no objection to a trial of her burner in the yard of Taigh-solais Baile ìseal, at her own charge, so long as the light is not touched and the keeper not hindered. The letter asks under what head twenty barrels of fuel were entered to the Comhairle's account at Seann Skell.¹³⁴
- 13 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 5 — *The twenty barrels landed at Baile ìseal* (Baile ìseal). A salt-boat of Àth bheag, coming home empty from Seann Skell of the south, lands twenty barrels of dubhan on the slip at Baile ìseal for the engineer of Comhairle nan Taighean-solais¹³⁵. Her skipper complains of the smell. A carter of Baile ruadh carries the barrels out along the cape to the yard below Taigh-solais Baile ìseal¹³⁶, at twice his rate.¹³⁷
- 16 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 5 — *The keeper of Taigh-solais Baile ìseal*¹³⁸ keeps the new fuel off her stair (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal). Seonag nic Thòmais, keeper of Taigh-solais Baile ìseal, tells the engineer Peigi nic Ascaill that the yard is hers for the trial and the tower's stair is not, and that the new fuel shall not come past the tower door. She names the old keeper Murchadh mac Coinnich to keep the trial's log.¹³⁹
- 20 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 5 — *Murchadh mac Coinnich rules the log of the trial lamp* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal¹⁴⁰). Murchadh mac Coinnich, seventy-one, keeper of Taigh-solais Baile ìseal for thirty-one years, rules a log-book at his cottage by the yard wall for the engineer's trial, one line to a night, with headings of his own: wind, weather, lit, out, wick, smoke, and what the boats said. He takes an under-keeper's wage for it.¹⁴¹
- 25 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 5 — *The trial lamp's chimney-glass cracked in a squall* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal¹⁴²). On the eleventh night of the trial at Baile ìseal a squall of cold rain off the sea cracks the hot chimney-glass of the trial lamp from top to foot. The flame holds. The engineer puts in a new glass in the rain, and the tinsmith of Àth bheag makes a hood of sheet iron for the lantern, after which the glasses hold.¹⁴³

131. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

132. the Lighthouse Board

133. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

134. → Leads to *Peigi nic Ascaill's trial lamp*, 4 am Màrt, DE 5; ← Follows from *The Seann Skell works' first year*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4.

135. the Lighthouse Board

136. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

137. ← Follows from *The Seann Skell works' first year*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4; → Leads to *Peigi nic Ascaill's trial lamp*, 4 am Màrt, DE 5; ← Follows from *Comhairle nan Taighean-solais allows a trial in the yard at Baile ìseal*, 9 an t-Sultain, DE 5.

138. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

139. ○ Same place *Peigi nic Ascaill's trial lamp*, 4 am Màrt, DE 5; ← Follows from *The twenty barrels landed at Baile ìseal*, 13 an t-Sultain, DE 5.

140. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

141. ← Follows from *Peigi nic Ascaill's trial lamp*, 4 am Màrt, DE 5; ← Follows from *The keeper of Taigh-solais Baile ìseal keeps the new fuel off her stair*, 16 an t-Sultain, DE 5.

142. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

- 27 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 5** — *Calum mac Iain comes home by the trial lamp in the haar* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal¹⁴⁴). On the forty-first night of the trial a haar lies high on the eastern cape and hides the light of Taigh-solais Baile ìseal from the sea. Calum mac Iain, last of the Baile ìseal boats home from the lines, steers in under it by the trial lamp in the yard and finds the slip. He asks the log-keeper not to write it; it is written.¹⁴⁵
- 29 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 5** — *The trial lamp lit from the Bealltainn fire* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal¹⁴⁶). On the feast of Bealltainn a girl of Baile ìseal carries a pail of the dunes' fire out to the tower, as the town has done for its keepers since the light was lit. At the old keeper's word the engineer lights the trial lamp that night from a spill kindled at the Bealltainn coals, and the log records it so.¹⁴⁷
- 5 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 5** — *The coal flame of Baile ìseal fails in a gale and the trial lamp holds* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal¹⁴⁸). On the seventieth night of the trial a south-easterly gale lifts the roof of the coal-store at Taigh-solais Baile ìseal and wets the coal. A down-draught drives the smoke back into the lantern, and the tower's light fails from the second hour after midnight to the fourth while the keeper Seonag nic Thòmais fights the grate. The trial lamp in the yard burns through the night.¹⁴⁹
- 14 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 5** — *Two boats of Baile ìseal come home by the trial lamp* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal¹⁵⁰). Two boats of Baile ìseal, caught far out at their lines by the south-easterly gale, come round the eastern cape in the small hours while the tower's light is dark, and steer in by the trial lamp in the yard. One comes in with a torn sail and a man with a broken arm. Both reach the slip.¹⁵¹
- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 5** — *The coal-store at Taigh-solais Baile ìseal¹⁵² new-roofed* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal). A roofer of Baile ruadh puts the coal-store at Taigh-solais Baile ìseal to rights after the gale. The secretary of Comhairle nan Taighean-solais¹⁵³ answers the keeper's report of the night with a request for particulars of the wet coal and the down-draught, and says nothing of the trial in the yard.¹⁵⁴

143. ← Follows from *Peigi nic Ascaill's trial lamp*, 4 am Màrt, DE 5; ← Follows from *Murchadh mac Coinnich rules the log of the trial lamp*, 20 an t-Sultain, DE 5.

144. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

145. ← Follows from *Peigi nic Ascaill's trial lamp*, 4 am Màrt, DE 5; ← Follows from *The trial lamp's chimney-glass cracked in a squall*, 25 an t-Sultain, DE 5.

146. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

147. ← Follows from *Peigi nic Ascaill's trial lamp*, 4 am Màrt, DE 5; ← Follows from *Calum mac Iain comes home by the trial lamp in the haar*, 27 an t-Sultain, DE 5.

148. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

149. ← Follows from *Peigi nic Ascaill's trial lamp*, 4 am Màrt, DE 5; ← Follows from *The trial lamp lit from the Bealltainn fire*, 29 an t-Sultain, DE 5.

150. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

151. ← Follows from *Peigi nic Ascaill's trial lamp*, 4 am Màrt, DE 5; ← Follows from *The coal flame of Baile ìseal fails in a gale and the trial lamp holds*, 5 an Dàmhair, DE 5.

152. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

153. the Lighthouse Board

154. ← Follows from *Peigi nic Ascaill's trial lamp*, 4 am Màrt, DE 5; ← Follows from *Two boats of Baile ìseal come home by the trial lamp*, 14 an Dàmhair, DE 5.

- 25 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 5** — *The hundredth night of the trial lamp* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal¹⁵⁵). The trial of the dubhan lamp in the yard below Taigh-solais Baile ìseal ends on its hundredth night, fair with a light west wind. Eleven barrels of the twenty and part of a twelfth have been burned. Murchadh mac Coinnich writes the last line of the log: the boats have said nothing about the lamp, being used to it.¹⁵⁶
- 27 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 5** — *Peigi nic Ascaill's report to Comhairle nan Taighean-solais*¹⁵⁷ (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal¹⁵⁸). Peigi nic Ascaill, engineer to Comhairle nan Taighean-solais, sends the Comhairle her report of the hundred nights at Baile ìseal, with Murchadh mac Coinnich's log. It sets the fuel burned against the tower's coal night by night, at the works' price and the pit-head's, and gives the seventieth night in full.¹⁵⁹
- 29 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 5** — *The spare lamp of Baile ìseal fitted with a burner* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal¹⁶⁰). Peigi nic Ascaill takes the grate out of the storm-lantern of Taigh-solais Baile ìseal and sets in its place a burner of two wick-rings with a coil round the chimney foot to warm the fuel.¹⁶¹
- 3 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 5** — *The haar on the forty-first night* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal¹⁶²). A haar lies high on the eastern cape; the tower's coal light is lost in it from the slip while the trial lamp below shows plain.¹⁶³
- 5 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 5** — *Seonag nic Thòmais asks an engineer's questions* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal¹⁶⁴). On the ninety-sixth night of the trial the keeper of Taigh-solais Baile ìseal comes to the foot of the stage for the first time and asks how the burner is made and what the fuel does to brass. The stair, she says, is still hers.¹⁶⁵
- 20 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 5** — *Hay stored in the old barracks at Inis mhòr* (Inis mhòr). The barracks at Inis mhòr, empty of soldiers since An Dealachadh¹⁶⁶, are let by the maor to the farmers of Seann Vell for hay, the long rooms dry and the rent small.¹⁶⁷

155. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

156. ← Follows from *Peigi nic Ascaill's trial lamp*, 4 am Màrt, DE 5; ← Follows from *The coal-store at Taigh-solais Baile ìseal new-roofed*, 16 an Dàmhair, DE 5.

157. the Lighthouse Board

158. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

159. ← Follows from *Peigi nic Ascaill's trial lamp*, 4 am Màrt, DE 5; ← Follows from *The hundredth night of the trial lamp*, 25 an Dàmhair, DE 5.

160. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

161. ← Follows from *Peigi nic Ascaill's trial lamp*, 4 am Màrt, DE 5; ← Follows from *Peigi nic Ascaill's report to Comhairle nan Taighean-solais*, 27 an Dàmhair, DE 5.

162. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

163. ← Follows from *The spare lamp of Baile ìseal fitted with a burner*, 29 an Dàmhair, DE 5.

164. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

165. ← Follows from *The haar on the forty-first night*, 3 an t-Samhain, DE 5.

166. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

167. ← Follows from *Seonag nic Thòmais asks an engineer's questions*, 5 an t-Samhain, DE 5.

- 22 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 5** — *Sorcha nic Dhùghaill buys a launch's engine at Ros dhombain* (Ros dhomhain). Sorcha nic Dhùghaill, boatwright of Caol fhiadhaich, finds in a chandler's yard behind the coal quay at Ros dhomhain the engine of a harbour launch, laid up eight years because its coal cost more than the launch earned. She buys it for the price of old iron, and it is carried down the coast road to her yard on an ox-wain.¹⁶⁸
- 24 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 5** — *The smith of Caol fhiadhaich makes a dubhan burner* (Caol fhiadhaich). Seonaidh Bàn, smith of the harbour at Caol fhiadhaich, makes a burner of iron with a pipe and a cock to feed dubhan to the engine in Sorcha nic Dhùghaill's rope-shed. He copies it from the stove of a coaster out of Seann Skell on the southern coast, made larger. The south-coast boats have burned dubhan in their stoves and lamps since the works' first year.¹⁶⁹
- 28 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 5** — *The keel of An Ròn Dubh¹⁷⁰ bored* (Caol fhiadhaich). At the asking of her skipper Lachann mac Neacail, Sorcha nic Dhùghaill hauls the decked boat An Ròn Dubh up her slip at Caol fhiadhaich and bores the sternpost and deadwood below the water for a shaft, against the guild's first rule, Cha tollar an druim. The other three yards of the town watch from the head of the slip.¹⁷¹
- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 5** — *An Ròn Dubh¹⁷² crosses the harbour under engine* (Caol fhiadhaich). On a calm evening of an Lùnastal the fishing boat An Ròn Dubh, her engine fed by dubhan, crosses the harbour of Caol fhiadhaich to the wolf-stone and back with her sails furled and her oars shipped. Half the town watches from the wall. It is the first fishing boat of the island moved by an engine.¹⁷³
- 12 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 5** — *The boatwrights of Caol fhiadhaich return their papers* (Caol fhiadhaich). The four yards of Caol fhiadhaich meet in the net-loft over the fish-store, hear the master's letter read, and answer it in writing: they hold the work lawful and will go on with it, and since the guild holds it unlawful for its members, they are members no longer. Their papers of binding go back to Ros dhomhain with the letter.¹⁷⁴

168. ← Follows from *The fishing boats of Caol fhiadhaich*, 7 an t-Sultain, DE 5.

169. ← Follows from *The Seann Skell works' first year*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4; ← Follows from *The fishing boats of Caol fhiadhaich*, 7 an t-Sultain, DE 5; ← Follows from *Sorcha nic Dhùghaill buys a launch's engine at Ros dhombain*, 22 an t-Samhain, DE 5.

170. the Black Seal, Lachann mac Neacail's fishing boat of Caol fhiadhaich, the first fitted with a dubhan engine

171. ← Follows from *The fishing boats of Caol fhiadhaich*, 7 an t-Sultain, DE 5; ← Follows from *The smith of Caol fhiadhaich makes a dubhan burner*, 24 an t-Samhain, DE 5.

172. the Black Seal, Lachann mac Neacail's fishing boat of Caol fhiadhaich, the first fitted with a dubhan engine
173. ← Follows from *The fishing boats of Caol fhiadhaich*, 7 an t-Sultain, DE 5; ← Follows from *The keel of An Ròn Dubh bored*, 28 an t-Samhain, DE 5.

174. ← Follows from *The fishing boats of Caol fhiadhaich*, 7 an t-Sultain, DE 5; ← Follows from *An Ròn Dubh crosses the harbour under engine*, 5 an Dùbhlachd, DE 5.

14 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 5 — *Comann nan Saor-luinge*¹⁷⁵ strikes and fines the yards of *Caol fhiadhaich* (Caol fhiadhaich). Comann nan Saor-luinge strikes the four yards of Caol fhiadhaich from its roll and lays a fine on each, the heaviest on Sorcha nic Dhùghaill's yard. None of them pays. The maor of the shire, written to by the guild, answers that a guild's fine is the guild's business.¹⁷⁶

20 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 5 — *A pilot takes an engine-boat through the strait* (Caol fhiadhaich). After the season's offering at the harbour wolf-stone, Ailig Mòr, eldest of the strait pilots of Caol fhiadhaich, takes An Ròn Dubh¹⁷⁷ out through the skerries under her engine, the first hull the pilots have brought through the strait without sail or oar. At the second skerry she drives across the tide.¹⁷⁸

29 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 5 — *An Ròn Dubh*¹⁷⁹ comes home against a south-westerly (Caol fhiadhaich). Late in an Dàmhair a south-westerly gale catches the fleet of Caol fhiadhaich on the herring banks off the south coast. The sailing boats run for the lee of a headland to the east and lie there five days. Lachann mac Neacail brings An Ròn Dubh home into the wind under her engine and lands the only fresh herring on the coast, sold at Doire shean at dawn.

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31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 5 — *All four yards of Caol fhiadhaich fitting engines* (Caol fhiadhaich). By an Dùbhlachd all four yards of Caol fhiadhaich are boring keels and fitting engines to the town's fishing boats, and there are more skippers asking than there are slips. Donnchadh Ruadh, the oldest boatwright of the town, fits his first engine before the year is out.

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175. the shipwrights' fellowship

176. ← Follows from *The fishing boats of Caol fhiadhaich*, 7 an t-Sultain, DE 5; ← Follows from *The boatwrights of Caol fhiadhaich return their papers*, 12 an Dùbhlachd, DE 5.

177. the Black Seal, Lachann mac Neacail's fishing boat of Caol fhiadhaich, the first fitted with a dubhan engine

178. ← Follows from *The fishing boats of Caol fhiadhaich*, 7 an t-Sultain, DE 5; ← Follows from *Comann nan Saor-luinge strikes and fines the yards of Caol fhiadhaich*, 14 an Dùbhlachd, DE 5.

179. the Black Seal, Lachann mac Neacail's fishing boat of Caol fhiadhaich, the first fitted with a dubhan engine

180. ← Follows from *The fishing boats of Caol fhiadhaich*, 7 an t-Sultain, DE 5; ← Follows from *A pilot takes an engine-boat through the strait*, 20 an Dùbhlachd, DE 5.

181. ← Follows from *The fishing boats of Caol fhiadhaich*, 7 an t-Sultain, DE 5; ← Follows from *An Ròn Dubh comes home against a south-westerly*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, DE 5.

THE YEARS DE 6 – 10

- 23 AN GIBLEAN, DE 6** — *The shipwrights' guild court* (Ros dhomhain). The court of the Shipwrights' Guild at Ros dhomhain rules that the fitting of an engine is no shipwright's work and so outside its charter. The boatwrights of Caol fhiadhaich are readmitted to the guild. They decline.¹
- 22 AN CÈITEAN, DE 6** — *The lights turned to dubhan* (Taigh-solais Baile chrom²). The five beacons of the coast, which have burned coal-lit flame for more than a century, are the first works of the kingdom turned by order to dubhan.³
- 19 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 6** — *The last coal flame* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg⁴). The coal flame of Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg is borne in a closed lantern to the Rite's house at Seann Skell and let burn out on the altar. Custodians from four shires attend, and Ciorstaidh nic Artair, keeper of the light, carries the lantern.
- 26 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 6** — *Three yards of the south-west coast follow* (Inis chrom). In the first months of the year the yards of Inis chrom, Doire shean and a third harbour of the south-west coast send to Caol fhiadhaich to learn how the engines are fitted, and begin the same work. They too leave Comann nan Saor-luinge⁵ or are struck from it.⁶
- 8 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 6** — *Launch engines dear at Ros dhombhain* (Ros dhomhain). No one on the island makes engines for boats, and the yards of the south-west buy the engine out of every laid-up launch in the harbours of the capital country. The chandlers of Ros dhomhain, who sold such engines for old iron the summer before, ask three times the price by am Màrt and five times by an Giblean.⁷
- 10 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 6** — *The guild summons the boatwrights of Caol fhiadhaich* (Caol fhiadhaich). Early in an Giblean Comann nan Saor-luinge⁸ summons the boatwrights of Caol fhiadhaich to its court at Ros dhomhain to hear its ruling on the matter of the engines. The four yards send Sorcha nic Dhùghaill to answer for all of them.⁹

1. → Caused by *Comann nan Saor-luinge strikes and fines the yards of Caol fhiadhaich*, 14 an Dùbhlachd, DE 5.

2. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

3. → Caused by *Peigi nic Ascaill's report to Comhairle nan Taighean-solais*, 27 an Dàmhair, DE 5.

4. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

5. the shipwrights' fellowship

6. ← Follows from *The fishing boats of Caol fhiadhaich*, 7 an t-Sultain, DE 5; ← Follows from *The shipwrights' guild court*, 23 an Giblean, DE 6; ← Follows from *All four yards of Caol fhiadhaich fitting engines*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 5.

7. ← Follows from *The fishing boats of Caol fhiadhaich*, 7 an t-Sultain, DE 5; ← Follows from *Three yards of the south-west coast follow*, 26 an t-Iuchar, DE 6.

8. the shipwrights' fellowship

9. ← Follows from *The shipwrights' guild court*, 23 an Giblean, DE 6; ← Follows from *Launch engines dear at Ros dhombhain*, 8 an Lùnastal, DE 6.

- 19 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 6** — *Sorcha nic Dhùghaill declines readmission* (Ros dhomhain). In the guild hall above the slips at Ros dhomhain, when the master Pàdraig mac an t-Saoir has read the ruling and remitted the fines, Sorcha nic Dhùghaill answers for the four yards of Caol fhiadhaich that they bored the keels as shipwrights and have no need of a shipwrights' guild that disowns the work. The clerk writes that they decline.¹⁰
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 6** — *Obair-dhubhain Seann Skell*¹¹ *watch the guild court* (Ros dhomhain). A man sent from the dubhan works at the southern Seann Skell sits at the court of Comann nan Saor-luinge¹² at Ros dhomhain beside a clerk of the lights, to hear what it says of engines.¹³
- 1 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 6** — *An Ròn Dubh*¹⁴ *laid up for the winter* (Caol fhiadhaich). The shaft-boat An Ròn Dubh is drawn up the slip at Caol fhiadhaich for the winter, and the shipwrights of the town come down one at a time to look at the bored post.¹⁵
- 3 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 6** — *Baile ghorm's boats follow Caol fhiadhaich* (Baile ghorm). Two skippers of Baile ghorm, who had seen An Ròn Dubh¹⁶ come home against a south-westerly, send to the southern works for burners and to Caol fhiadhaich for a boatwright who will bore a keel.¹⁷
- 14 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 6** — *The pilots of Seann Warr ask for an engine boat* (Seann Warr). The pilots of the walled harbour of Seann Warr ask their maor for a pilot-boat with an engine, to meet ships in a calm; the maor answers that the town will pay for one when the shipwrights' guild allows one.¹⁸
- 18 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 6** — *The order to turn the lights read at Comhairle nan Taighean-solais*¹⁹ (Taigh-solais Baile iséal²⁰). Comhairle nan Taighean-solais sits and hears the council's order that the five lights of the coast be turned to dubhan and their coal given to the altars. Taigh-solais Baile iséal and Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg²¹, nearest the works at Seann Skell, are to be turned first, in the summer; the keepers keep their warrants, wages and houses.²²

10. ← Follows from *The shipwrights' guild court*, 23 an Giblean, DE 6; ← Follows from *The guild summons the boatwrights of Caol fhiadhaich*, 10 an Lùnastal, DE 6.

11. the dubhan works at the southern Seann Skell

12. the shipwrights' fellowship

13. ← Follows from *The shipwrights' guild court*, 23 an Giblean, DE 6; ← Follows from *Sorcha nic Dhùghaill declines readmission*, 19 an Lùnastal, DE 6.

14. the Black Seal, Lachann mac Neacail's fishing boat of Caol fhiadhaich, the first fitted with a dubhan engine

15. ← Follows from *The fishing boats of Caol fhiadhaich*, 7 an t-Sultain, DE 5; ← Follows from *Obair-dhubhain Seann Skell watch the guild court*, 21 an Lùnastal, DE 6.

16. the Black Seal, Lachann mac Neacail's fishing boat of Caol fhiadhaich, the first fitted with a dubhan engine

17. ← Follows from *The fishing boats of Caol fhiadhaich*, 7 an t-Sultain, DE 5; ← Follows from *An Ròn Dubh laid up for the winter*, 1 an t-Sultain, DE 6.

18. ← Follows from *The shipwrights' guild court*, 23 an Giblean, DE 6; ← Follows from *Baile ghorm's boats follow Caol fhiadhaich*, 3 an t-Sultain, DE 6.

19. the Lighthouse Board

20. the lighthouse at Baile iséal

21. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

22. ← Follows from *The lights turned to dubhan*, 22 an Cèitean, DE 6.

25 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 6 — *The custodians of Tobar dhearg ask for the flame* (Tobar dhearg).

The custodians of Tobar dhearg, who keep the light's log for Bride's sake, ask the Àrd-choimheadaiche²³ that the coal flame of their light be carried to Bride's altar at Seann Skell and burn out there. He consents, and Comhairle nan Taighean-solais²⁴ makes no objection, so long as the light is not dark a single night.²⁵

27 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 6 — *Ciorstaidh nic Artair refuses a deputy for the lantern* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg²⁶). Offered a clerk of the lights or a young custodian of Seann Skell to carry the flame the nine and a half miles to the altar, Ciorstaidh nic Artair, keeper of Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg, writes that the flame is hers by her warrant until the burner is lit, and that she will carry it herself. The answer leaves the matter to her.²⁷**10 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 6** — *Taigh-solais Baile iséal*²⁸ *turned to dubhan* (Taigh-solais Baile iséal). The burner Peigi nic Ascaill tried in the yard below Taigh-solais Baile iséal is set in the tower's lantern by order, the first of the five lights to burn dubhan. Its keeper Seonag nic Thòmais, who would not have the thing up her stair, keeps the light under it.²⁹**23 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 6** — *The tank landed at the cape of Tobar dhearg* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg³⁰). A works boat from Seann Skell lands an iron tank, a burner, pipes and forty barrels of dubhan on the stones below Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg. Eight men of the village bring the tank up the landing-stones and the stair, and the barrels stand against the tower wall where the coal-sacks stood.³¹**25 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 6** — *The trial of the burner at Tobar dhearg* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg³²). Peigi nic Ascaill lights the new burner in the lantern of Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg for an hour beside the coal grate. The light is white and steady and throws the shadows of the lantern's bars across the cape; the boats at sea come in to ask what has happened. The grate burns on alone until the day of the carrying.³³

23. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

24. the Lighthouse Board

25. ← Follows from *The lights turned to dubhan*, 22 an Cèitean, DE 6; ← Follows from *The last coal flame*, 19 an t-Iuchar, DE 6; ← Follows from *The high custodian's letter*, 25 an t-Samhain, DE 4.

26. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

27. ← Follows from *The last coal flame*, 19 an t-Iuchar, DE 6; ← Follows from *The custodians of Tobar dhearg ask for the flame*, 25 an t-Sultain, DE 6.

28. the lighthouse at Baile iséal

29. ← Follows from *Peigi nic Ascaill's trial lamp*, 4 am Màrt, DE 5; ← Follows from *The lights turned to dubhan*, 22 an Cèitean, DE 6; ← Follows from *Ciorstaidh nic Artair refuses a deputy for the lantern*, 27 an t-Sultain, DE 6.

30. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

31. ← Follows from *The Seann Skell works' first year*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4; ← Follows from *The lights turned to dubhan*, 22 an Cèitean, DE 6; ← Follows from *Taigh-solais Baile iséal turned to dubhan*, 10 an Dàmhair, DE 6.

32. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

3 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 6 — *The last coal night at Tobar dhearg* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg³⁴).

On the night before the carrying the keeper of Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg burns the last of the quarter's coal, a sack and a half, as high as the grate will take it. At dawn she lights the closed lantern from the grate and lets the tower's fire go out.³⁵

5 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 6 — *The walk from the cape to Seann Skell* (Tobar dhearg). Ciorstaidh nic Artair carries the lantern on foot from the cape by Baile gharbh to Seann Skell, nine and a half miles in the heat, and gives it to no one. Some thirty people of Tobar dhearg walk behind her with the three custodians of the village; at the town's edge a young custodian of the house leads her up to Bride's house.³⁶

16 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 6 — *The first dubhan night at Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg*³⁷ (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg). On the evening of the carrying the under-keeper of Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg lights the dubhan burner at sunset, as the keeper ordered, with the keeper away at Seann Skell. The new light is seen white and steady from the quays of Seann Skell, nine miles up the coast.³⁸

18 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 6 — *The Àrd-choimheadaiche*³⁹ *blesses the lantern* (Seann Skell). When the coal flame of Tobar dhearg has burned out on Bride's altar, Alasdair mac Ìomhair closes the lantern, says the words for a lamp of the vein's coal let go out, and blesses the lantern while he neither blesses nor forbids the new light. He gives the lantern back to its keeper at her asking.⁴⁰

29 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 6 — *The song of the last flame first sung at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). In a tavern under the quay wall at Seann Skell a skipper of Tobar dhearg makes and sings a song of the carrying on the night of it. It gathers many verses before morning, and by the summer's end every harbour of the south coast has its own; the first verse, of the flame gone out of the tower, is sung wherever it is sung.⁴¹

33. ← Follows from *The lights turned to dubhan*, 22 an Cèitean, DE 6; ← Follows from *The tank landed at the cape of Tobar dhearg*, 23 an Dàmhair, DE 6.

34. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

35. ← Follows from *The last coal flame*, 19 an t-Iuchar, DE 6; ← Follows from *The trial of the burner at Tobar dhearg*, 25 an Dàmhair, DE 6.

36. ← Follows from *The last coal flame*, 19 an t-Iuchar, DE 6; ← Follows from *The last coal night at Tobar dhearg*, 3 an t-Samhain, DE 6.

37. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

38. ← Follows from *The lights turned to dubhan*, 22 an Cèitean, DE 6; ← Follows from *The last coal flame*, 19 an t-Iuchar, DE 6; ← Follows from *The walk from the cape to Seann Skell*, 5 an t-Samhain, DE 6.

39. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

40. ← Follows from *The last coal flame*, 19 an t-Iuchar, DE 6; ← Follows from *The high custodian's letter*, 25 an t-Samhain, DE 4; ← Follows from *The first dubhan night at Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg*, 16 an t-Samhain, DE 6.

41. ← Follows from *The last coal flame*, 19 an t-Iuchar, DE 6; ← Follows from *The Àrd-choimheadaiche blesses the lantern*, 18 an t-Samhain, DE 6.

- 3 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 6** — *The bell-post on the reef below Tobar dhearg* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg⁴²). The reef below Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg, where Ciorstaidh nic Artair's father drowned, carries the bell-post she had driven there; no boat goes aground on it while she keeps the light.⁴³
- 12 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 6** — *The last quarter's coal burned high* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg⁴⁴). On her last night with the coal flame Ciorstaidh nic Artair burns the last sack and a half of the quarter's coal as high as it will burn, and the boats out that night see the light burn higher than in years.⁴⁵
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 6** — *Bride's house at Caol ruadh keeps its own coal* (Caol ruadh). The house of Bride at Caol ruadh, which keeps the orthodox rite of the flame, buys two years' altar coal ahead from the last carters of the southern road and stores it in the under-croft, lest the coal fail before the rite does.⁴⁶
- 26 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 7** — *Taigh-solais Muileann bheag*⁴⁷ *converted* (Taigh-solais Muileann bheag). The beacon at Muileann bheag on the Tuathaich north coast is turned to dubhan with the others. Its fuel is carted from the north; of the five lights it alone is not fed by sea from Seann Skell.
- 25 AM MÀRT, DE 7** — *Taigh-solais Àth dhearg*⁴⁸ *converted* (Taigh-solais Àth dhearg). At Taigh-solais Àth dhearg on the north-east cape the work takes a month longer than at the others, for the stair is too narrow for the new tank. The tank is lifted to the lamp-room from outside by a crane borrowed from the rope-walk at Seann Tarr.
- 20 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 7** — *Taigh-solais Baile chrom*⁴⁹ *converted* (Taigh-solais Baile chrom). At Taigh-solais Baile chrom on the Tuathaich coast the work is done by Tuathaich fitters from Caol mhòr, for the Lighthouse Board has none of its own to send so far. The keeper's report names none of them.
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 7** — *The lamp-makers turn* (Muileann mhin). The lamp-makers of Muileann mhin begin to make dubhan lamps and ask leave to set their guild mark on them. After a year's argument the guild court allows it. The flame over the hammer is kept.

42. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

43. ← Follows from *The song of the last flame first sung at Seann Skell*, 29 an t-Samhain, DE 6.

44. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

45. ← Follows from *The last coal flame*, 19 an t-Iuchar, DE 6; ← Follows from *The bell-post on the reef below Tobar dhearg*, 3 an Dùbhlachd, DE 6.

46. ← Follows from *The last coal flame*, 19 an t-Iuchar, DE 6; ← Follows from *The last quarter's coal burned high*, 12 an Dùbhlachd, DE 6.

47. the lighthouse at Muileann bheag

48. the lighthouse at Àth dhearg

49. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 7** — *The dubhan for Muileann bheag bought at Caol mhòr* (Caol mhòr). Peigi nic Ascaill, engineer to Comhairle nan Taighean-solais⁵⁰, buys the fuel for Taigh-solais Muileann bheag⁵¹ in the market at Caol mhòr, since no master will take a laden hull round the western capes in am Faoilleach. Twelve Tuathaich carts carry the barrels fifteen miles along the coast road to the tower. The carters are paid at the rate of the town.⁵²
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 7** — *The coal-store at Muileann bheag locked* (Taigh-solais Muileann bheag⁵³). When Taigh-solais Muileann bheag is lit with dubhan, its keeper Calum Bàn, a Dia-thireach of the south who has kept the light nineteen years, locks the last of its coal in the store at the tower's foot until Comhairle nan Taighean-solais⁵⁴ shall say what is to be done with it.⁵⁵
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 7** — *The crane walked from Seann Tarr to Àth dhearg* (Seann Tarr). The rope-makers of Seann Tarr take down the crane of their rope-walk and carry it three and a half miles up the coast road to Taigh-solais Àth dhearg⁵⁶ in pieces, on three wains. They raise it on the rock below the tower in two days and stay it to rings let into the stone. They will let no other hands touch their cables.⁵⁷
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 7** — *The rope-makers refuse hire for the crane* (Seann Tarr). When the tank of Taigh-solais Àth dhearg⁵⁸ is set in its lamp-room, the rope-makers of Seann Tarr take their crane home and will take no hire for it. Their master sends word that the light owes them nothing, since their boats steer home by it. The keeper Iseabail Ruadh names the rope-walk in her daybook.⁵⁹
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 7** — *Peigi nic Ascaill writes to Caol mhòr for fitters* (Àth dhearg). Peigi nic Ascaill writes to Comhairle nan Taighean-solais⁶⁰ that she cannot turn the light at Baile chrom before the autumn gales with the two fitters it can spare. In her own name she writes to the speaker at Caol mhòr, asking four Tuathaich fitters of the town for the work and a man named Ashby among them. She does not say who will pay them.⁶¹

50. the Lighthouse Board

51. the lighthouse at Muileann bheag

52. ← Follows from *Taigh-solais Muileann bheag converted*, 26 am Faoilleach, DE 7.

53. the lighthouse at Muileann bheag

54. the Lighthouse Board

55. ← Follows from *Taigh-solais Muileann bheag converted*, 26 am Faoilleach, DE 7; ← Follows from *The lights turned to dubhan*, 22 an Cèitean, DE 6; ← Follows from *The dubhan for Muileann bheag bought at Caol mhòr*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7.

56. the lighthouse at Àth dhearg

57. ← Follows from *Taigh-solais Àth dhearg converted*, 25 am Màrt, DE 7; → Leads to *The rope-makers of Seann Tarr* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 53; ← Follows from *The coal-store at Muileann bheag locked*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7; ← Leads to *The rope-makers refuse hire for the crane*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7.

58. the lighthouse at Àth dhearg

59. ← Follows from *Taigh-solais Àth dhearg converted*, 25 am Màrt, DE 7; ← Follows from *The crane walked from Seann Tarr to Àth dhearg*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7; ← Leads to *Peigi nic Ascaill writes to Caol mhòr for fitters*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7.

- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 7** — *Four fitters of Caol mhòr walk to Baile chrom* (Caol mhòr). Daniel Frayne, speaker of Tional nan Tuathach⁶², sends four fitters of Caol mhòr to turn the light at Baile chrom: Joe Ashby, Will Tanner and the cousins Ned and Abel Fowler. They walk the twenty-five miles in two days of rain. The tank and fuel come round by sea from Seann Skell and are landed below the headland.⁶³
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 7** — *The Tuathaich fitters paid by Tional nan Tuathach*⁶⁴ (Caol mhòr). The clerk of Tional nan Tuathach at Caol mhòr pays the four fitters who turned the light at Baile chrom from the assembly's chest, for nine days' work and four days' walking, and enters their names and the sum in its book. He writes to Comhairle nan Taighean-solais⁶⁵ for the money, and enters the sum as owed.⁶⁶
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 7** — *The keeper's report pinned at Caol mhòr* (Caol mhòr). The quarter-day report of Uilleam mac Dhòmhnaill, keeper of Taigh-solais Baile chrom⁶⁷, is copied by Comhairle nan Taighean-solais⁶⁸ and sent round the shires. At Caol mhòr the maor pins it outside the custom-house. It says the light burns well and the town gives no trouble, and that the work was done by fitters from Caol mhòr. It names none of them.⁶⁹
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 7** — *Peigi nic Ascaill takes service with the works* (Seann Skell). Peigi nic Ascaill leaves the service of Comhairle nan Taighean-solais⁷⁰ at the end of the summer and takes service as master-fitter with Obair-dhubhain Seann Skell⁷¹, the shipmasters' works on the south coast, which are building a second range of retorts.⁷²

61. ← Follows from *Taigh-solais Baile chrom converted*, 20 an t-Ògmhios, DE 7; ← Follows from *The rope-makers refuse hire for the crane*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7; ← Leads to *Four fitters of Caol mhòr walk to Baile chrom*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7.

60. the Lighthouse Board

62. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

63. ← Follows from *Taigh-solais Baile chrom converted*, 20 an t-Ògmhios, DE 7; ← Follows from *Peigi nic Ascaill writes to Caol mhòr for fitters*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7; ← Leads to *The Tuathaich fitters paid by Tional nan Tuathach*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7.

64. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

65. the Lighthouse Board

66. ← Follows from *Taigh-solais Baile chrom converted*, 20 an t-Ògmhios, DE 7; ← Follows from *Four fitters of Caol mhòr walk to Baile chrom*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7; ← Leads to *The keeper's report pinned at Caol mhòr*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7.

67. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

68. the Lighthouse Board

69. ← Follows from *Taigh-solais Baile chrom converted*, 20 an t-Ògmhios, DE 7; → Leads to *The keepers of the five lights* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 17; ← Follows from *The Tuathaich fitters paid by Tional nan Tuathach*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7; ← Leads to *Peigi nic Ascaill takes service with the works*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7.

70. the Lighthouse Board

71. the dubhan works at the southern Seann Skell

72. ← Follows from *The shipmasters' works at Seann Skell*, 20 an Gearran, DE 4; ← Follows from *Peigi nic Ascaill's trial lamp*, 4 am Màrt, DE 5; ← Follows from *The keeper's report pinned at Caol mhòr*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7; ← Leads to *Joe Ashby hired at the works*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7.

- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 7** — *Joe Ashby hired at the works* (Caol mhòr). Joe Ashby of Caol mhòr goes south in an t-Sultain at Peigi nic Ascaill's letter and is hired as a fitter at the ship-masters' works at Seann Skell on the south coast, with Ned and Abel Fowler. He is given a room over the forge. Will Tanner stays at Caol mhòr with his boat.⁷³
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 7** — *The first dubhan pit-lamps of Muileann mhin* (Muileann mhin). The lamp-makers of Muileann mhin, working from a burner drawn by Peigi nic Ascaill, make their first twelve pit-lamps to burn dubhan. Orders come for a hundred, from the pits still worked, from the yards of Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn⁷⁴ and from the inns of the old roads. The guild will not yet stamp them with its mark.⁷⁵
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 7** — *Two fitters sign the lamp-makers' petition* (Muileann mhin). At the guild's hall of Muileann mhin, Peigi nic Ascaill, master-fitter of Obair-dhubhain Seann Skell⁷⁶, signs the lamp-makers' petition to the guild court as the one who drew the burner, and Joe Ashby, fitter, of Caol mhòr, signs under her. The guild's master carries the petition to the court the same afternoon.⁷⁷
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 7** — *The Baile chrom burner mended on a smith's anvil* (Baile chrom). A burner bent on the voyage round the western capes is straightened by Joe Ashby and the smith of Baile chrom behind a shut door; Joe pays the smith from his own pocket.⁷⁸
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 7** — *The harbour carts of Àth naomh blessed as before* (Àth naomh). At Àth naomh in the Cuan shean shire the harbour carts are blessed at the spring as every year, horses and all; a carter who has put a dubhan lamp on his tail-board asks whether it too is blessed, and the priest says it is on the cart.⁷⁹
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 7** — *The stone of Cnoc bheag scrubbed* (Cnoc bheag). The town of Cnoc bheag has its carved stone scrubbed of a century's coal-smoke for the midsummer fair, and finds under the black a second band of carving no one living had seen.⁸⁰

73. ← Follows from *Taigh-solais Baile chrom converted*, 20 an t-Ògmhios, DE 7; ← Follows from *The shipmasters' works at Seann Skell*, 20 an Gearran, DE 4; ← Follows from *Peigi nic Ascaill takes service with the works*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7.

74. the Rail Board; lit. 'the board of the iron way'

75. ← Follows from *The lamp-makers turn*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7; → Leads to *The lamp-makers of Muileann mhin* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 14; → Leads to *The coal-lamp shortage* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 63; ← Leads to *Two fitters sign the lamp-makers' petition*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7.

76. the dubhan works at the southern Seann Skell

77. ← Follows from *The lamp-makers turn*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7; ← Follows from *The first dubhan pit-lamps of Muileann mhin*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7; ← Leads to *The Baile chrom burner mended on a smith's anvil*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7.

78. ← Follows from *Taigh-solais Baile chrom converted*, 20 an t-Ògmhios, DE 7; ← Follows from *Two fitters sign the lamp-makers' petition*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7; ← Leads to *The harbour carts of Àth naomh blessed as before*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7.

79. ← Follows from *The Baile chrom burner mended on a smith's anvil*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7; ← Leads to *The stone of Cnoc bheag scrubbed*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7.

80. ← Follows from *The harbour carts of Àth naomh blessed as before*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7.

- 9 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 8** — *Daniel Frayne dies* (Muileann leathan). Daniel Frayne, speaker of the Moot, dies at Muileann leathan. The Moot chooses Martha Greaves of Doire ghlais, a mill manager, to follow him.
- 24 AN GEARRAN, DE 8** — *The binders of Muileann leathan* (Muileann leathan). The Moot sends Daniel Frayne's pupils, the binders of Muileann leathan, to rebind its minute-books from the first meeting. The rebound set is kept at Caol mhòr. A second set is made and hidden, says the Moot's minute, elsewhere.
- I AN CÈITEAN, DE 8** — *The coal line's first dubhan engine* (Muileann chrom). The Rail Board runs its first dubhan engine on the coal line, from the yards at Muileann chrom to Cathair dhearg. It carries no coal. It carries dubhan to the lamp-houses of the capital, and comes back empty.
- II AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 8** — *The eastern salt-road* (Àth bheag). For the first time salt from Àth bheag goes to the inland towns by dubhan lorry, on the drove road past Baile iséal. Within a few years the drovers of the east coast sell their oxen.
- 12 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 8** — *Daniel Frayne buried at Muileann leathan* (Muileann leathan). Daniel Frayne, speaker of Tional nan Tuathach⁸¹, is buried in the churchyard of Muileann leathan. His eleven binders carry the coffin through the town by turns, and each drops a length of waxed binding-thread into the grave. The schoolchildren of Doire ghlais sing the hymn of the sea road, and delegates of the fishing, mill and hill towns stand in the rain along the churchyard wall.⁸²
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 8** — *Martha Greaves's first sitting as speaker* (Caol mhòr). Tional nan Tuathach⁸³ sits at Caol mhòr, forty-four delegates strong, and chooses Martha Greaves of Doire ghlais by show of hands; the one other name put is withdrawn. She says she is no talker. Her first business is Daniel Frayne's dying wish that his binders rebind the minute-books, and the matter is laid over for their reckoning. Her first minute is the shortest of the year.⁸⁴
- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 8** — *The binders' reckoning* (Muileann leathan). The binders of Muileann leathan send the speaker their reckoning for rebinding the minute-books: sixty-three books, with thread, board, hide and paste set down by weight. They charge nothing for their hands. The mills of Doire ghlais undertake to give the hide.⁸⁵

81. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

82. ← Follows from *Daniel Frayne dies*, 9 am Faoilleach, DE 8; → Leads to *Daniel Frayne's copying school* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 48.

83. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

84. ← Follows from *Daniel Frayne dies*, 9 am Faoilleach, DE 8; → Leads to *The Moot at Caol mhòr* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 2; ← Follows from *Daniel Frayne buried at Muileann leathan*, 12 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8.

85. ← Follows from *The binders of Muileann leathan*, 24 an Gearran, DE 8; → Leads to *The Doire ghlais mills* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 59; ← Follows from *Martha Greaves's first sitting as speaker*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8.

- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 8** — *Ellen Marsh offers her schoolroom* (Doire ghlais). Ellen Marsh, teacher at Agnes Pike's old school in Doire ghlais, writes to Tional nan Tuathach⁸⁶ offering her schoolroom for the rebinding of its books, since the bindery at Muileann leathan is being cleared by Daniel Frayne's kin. The children are to be taught in the church meanwhile, and the priest agrees.⁸⁷
- 16 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 8** — *The minute of the second set signed* (Caol mhòr). At the same sitting the eldest binder lays before the chair the wording of a minute: that a second set of the books is made and hidden elsewhere, and that the minute stands as all the gathering knows of it. No delegate says where. Martha Greaves has it copied as written and signs it without asking.⁸⁸
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 8** — *Peter Hale carries the books to Doire ghlais* (Caol mhòr). Peter Hale, delegate of Caol mhòr and great-grandson of Walter Hale, carries the sixty-three minute-books to Doire ghlais in three tea-chests lined with oilcloth, walking beside the cart the nine miles. The schoolchildren line up under the grey oaks to see them carried in.⁸⁹
- 18 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 8** — *The bindery in Agnes Pike's school* (Doire ghlais). The binders of Muileann leathan bring their presses and sewing frames to the schoolroom at Doire ghlais and take every minute-book out of its boards before any is sewn again. The loose gatherings of seventy-seven years are laid out under weights down the length of the floor.⁹⁰
- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 8** — *Walter Hale's harbour ledger* (Doire ghlais). Unstitching the first minute-book, the binders find it to be a harbour ledger of the humans' time: Walter Hale cut out his old masters' tonnage and dues close to the fold and wrote the first day of Tional nan Tuathach⁹¹ on the next clean page. The speaker orders the stubs kept in the new binding.⁹²
- 20 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 8** — *The last of the sixty-three books sewn* (Doire ghlais). The binders finish the last rebound minute-book at Doire ghlais, Daniel Frayne's own, which ends in the middle of a page and is followed by the clerk's minute of his death. Each book is covered in Doire ghlais hide and lettered on the spine with its years alone.⁹³

86. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

87. ← Follows from *The binders of Muileann leathan*, 24 an Gearran, DE 8; → Leads to *Agnes Pike's school* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 15; ← Follows from *The binders' reckoning*, 14 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8.

88. ← Follows from *The binders of Muileann leathan*, 24 an Gearran, DE 8; ← Follows from *Ellen Marsh offers her schoolroom*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8.

89. ← Follows from *The binders of Muileann leathan*, 24 an Gearran, DE 8; → Leads to *Walter Hale dies* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 33; ← Follows from *The minute of the second set signed*, 16 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8.

90. ← Follows from *The binders of Muileann leathan*, 24 an Gearran, DE 8; → Leads to *Agnes Pike's school* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 15; ← Follows from *Peter Hale carries the books to Doire ghlais*, 17 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8.

91. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

92. → Leads to *The Moot at Caol mhòr* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 2; ← Follows from *The bindery in Agnes Pike's school*, 18 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8.

21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 8 — *The rebound set laid in the press at Caol mhòr* (Caol mhòr). Martha Greaves lays the sixty-three rebound minute-books in the delegates' press at Caol mhòr with her own hands, in order from Walter Hale's ledger to Daniel Frayne's last book, locks it, and keeps the key on her ring with the keys of the mills. The minute records the books laid in, at the cost of the binders' thread.⁹⁴

22 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 8 — *Lamp-glass dearer at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). The glass-houses of Cathair dhearg raise the price of a chimney-glass by a third in the year the dubhan lamps come into the lanes, and cannot blow them fast enough.⁹⁵

23 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 8 — *The new engine hauled to Muileann chrom* (Seann Skell). An engine of the new kind, bought by Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn⁹⁶ from the shipmasters' works at the southern Seann Skell, comes up the old road to Muileann chrom on a low waggon. Twelve horses of Òrd Mhacha⁹⁷ draw it for two days, a priest of the order walking at their head, and at the ford below the town he stands in the water until they take it out.⁹⁸

24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 8 — *The first dubhan tank at Muileann chrom* (Muileann chrom). Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁹⁹'s men set an iron tank on stone piers at the end of the long siding at Muileann chrom and fill it from barrels carted up from the southern Seann Skell. It is the first dubhan tank Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn¹⁰⁰ owns. The families of the yard rows complain of the reek, which clings to cloth.¹⁰¹

26 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 8 — *Eachann mac Ruairidh learns the dubhan engine* (Muileann chrom). Eachann mac Ruairidh, a driver of the yard families at Muileann chrom, alone puts his name to Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹⁰²'s notice asking for a man to learn the new engine. Two fitters of the southern Obair-dhubhain Seann Skell¹⁰³ teach him, one of them a Tuathach of Caol mhòr, Will Garside. In a month he drives it to An Sloc Mòr¹⁰⁴ and back without them.¹⁰⁵

93. ← Follows from *Daniel Frayne dies*, 9 am Faoilleach, DE 8; ← Follows from *The binders of Muileann leathan*, 24 an Gearran, DE 8; ← Follows from *Walter Hale's harbour ledger*, 19 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8.

94. ← Follows from *The binders of Muileann leathan*, 24 an Gearran, DE 8; → Leads to *The Moot at Caol mhòr* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 2; ← Follows from *The last of the sixty-three books sewn*, 20 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8.

95. ← Follows from *The rebound set laid in the press at Caol mhòr*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8.

96. the Rail Board; lit. 'the board of the iron way'

97. the order of Macha

98. → Leads to *The coal line's first dubhan engine*, 1 an Cèitean, DE 8; ← Follows from *The shipmasters' works at Seann Skell*, 20 an Gearran, DE 4.

99. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

100. the Rail Board; lit. 'the board of the iron way'

101. → Leads to *The coal line's first dubhan engine*, 1 an Cèitean, DE 8; ○ Same place *The shunting yards at Muileann chrom* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 13; ← Follows from *The new engine hauled to Muileann chrom*, 23 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8.

102. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

103. the dubhan works at the southern Seann Skell

104. the great pit at the mountain

- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 8** — *The lamp-makers at the fence* (Muileann mhin). As the first dubhan train of Slighe a' Ghuail¹⁰⁶ passes Muileann mhin on its way to Cathair dhearg, the lamp-makers of Comann nan Lòchran¹⁰⁷ come out of their shops and stand along the fence of the last field in their aprons to watch it go by. One of them holds up a new dubhan lamp, unlit.¹⁰⁸
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 8** — *An old driver will not ride* (Muileann chrom). At dusk on the day of the first dubhan train, Ruairidh mac Eachainn, who drove coal engines on the line for forty years, is asked by his son to ride the new engine to the points and back. He refuses, saying he will not ride behind a fire he cannot see into, and walks home to the yard rows.¹⁰⁹
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 8** — *A fireman struck from the roll* (Muileann chrom). In an t-Ògmhios Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn¹¹⁰ takes a second fireman off its roll at Muileann chrom and puts no one in his place, the dubhan engine needing none and the trains from An Sloc Mòr¹¹¹ growing fewer. The man, a fireman of nineteen years, goes down to the river landing to seek work on the boats.¹¹²
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 8** — *A boy of the yard rows killed* (Muileann chrom). Ailean mac Mhathain, fourteen, of the yard families at Muileann chrom, is crushed between two dubhan tank-wagons being moved by rope and pinch-bar to make room for a second tank. Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹¹³'s clerk enters his death in the yard book as an accident in the changeover. The rows bury him in their corner of the burial ground below the mill.¹¹⁴
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 8** — *A salt-master of Àth bheag buys a lorry* (Àth bheag). In the autumn a salt-master of Àth bheag buys a lorry from the works at the southern Seann Skell. It comes up the coast road on its own wheels with a fitter driving and a barrel of dubhan roped behind the seat. The drovers of the east coast go down to the ford of the Abhainn dhubbh to look at it.¹¹⁵

105. → Leads to *The coal line's first dubhan engine*, 1 an Cèitean, DE 8; ← Follows from *The first dubhan tank at Muileann chrom*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8.

106. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

107. the lamp-makers' guild of Muileann mhin

108. ⇌ At the same time *The coal line's first dubhan engine*, 1 an Cèitean, DE 8; ← Follows from *The lamp-makers turn*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7; ← Follows from *Eachann mac Ruairidh learns the dubhan engine*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8.

109. ← Follows from *The coal line's first dubhan engine*, 1 an Cèitean, DE 8; ← Follows from *The lamp-makers at the fence*, 27 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8.

110. the Rail Board; lit. 'the board of the iron way'

111. the great pit at the mountain

112. ← Follows from *The coal line's first dubhan engine*, 1 an Cèitean, DE 8; ← Follows from *An old driver will not ride*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8.

113. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

114. ○ Same place *The shunting yards at Muileann chrom* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 13; ← Follows from *A fireman struck from the roll*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8.

- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 8** — *Salt of Àth bheag sent west by Slighe a' Ghuail*¹¹⁶ (Muileann chrom). The salt-master's lorry brings a second load of salt to the yard at Muileann chrom, and Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn¹¹⁷ sends it on to Cathair dhearg in a covered wagon behind the empty dubhan tanks. It is the first load the dubhan engine carries towards the capital that is not dubhan, and the first freight it pulls that pays.¹¹⁸
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 8** — *The blessing for a horse said over an engine* (Muileann chrom). Before the first dubhan train leaves the yard at Muileann chrom the priest of Macha says over it the blessing for a horse setting out on a long road, since none has been made for an engine.¹¹⁹
- 22 AM MÀRT, DE 9** — *Achadh mhòr's drovers* (Achadh mhòr). The drovers of Achadh mhòr in the south, with no oxen left to drive, buy lorries. The drove-inn at An Sligeanach Fad' às¹²⁰ keeps its trade by selling them dubhan.
- 30 AM MÀRT, DE 9** — *The inns take the new lamps* (An Taigh-seinnse Òir¹²¹). The inns along the old mining roads hang dubhan lamps. In a single decade the oil and the wick, which lit them for centuries, are gone.
- 15 AN GIBLEAN, DE 9** — *An Leòmhann Buidhe*¹²² *keeps a wick* (An Leòmhann Buidhe). At An Leòmhann Buidhe on the north-east road the landlord keeps one wick lamp burning over the door beside the new dubhan lamps. The custom spreads along the roads, and a wick lamp over an inn door is still called a Leòmhann.
- 25 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 9** — *The first horseless carriage* (Seann Skell). Fitters at Seann Skell on the southern coast set a lorry's dubhan engine under a closed carriage for the high custodian of the Rite. It is the first carriage on the island that needs no horse. Within a few years the council and the Mine Board have them too.
- 25 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 9** — *Am Buabhall Fortanach*¹²³ (Am Buabhall Fortanach). Am Buabhall Fortanach, the tavern on the south-west road near Doire shean, is the last of the great inns to hang dubhan lamps. Its landlady's account-book gives the cost as a year's takings.

115. → Leads to *The eastern salt-road*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8; ← Follows from *Salt-pans of Àth bheag* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 32; ← Follows from *A boy of the yard rows killed*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8; ← Leads to *Salt of Àth bheag sent west by Slighe a' Ghuail*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8.

116. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

117. the Rail Board; lit. 'the board of the iron way'

118. ← Follows from *The eastern salt-road*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8; ← Follows from *The coal line's first dubhan engine*, 1 an Cèitean, DE 8; ← Follows from *A salt-master of Àth bheag buys a lorry*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8; ← Leads to *The blessing for a horse said over an engine*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8.

119. ← Follows from *The coal line's first dubhan engine*, 1 an Cèitean, DE 8; ← Follows from *Salt of Àth bheag sent west by Slighe a' Ghuail*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8.

120. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

121. the golden house, a waypoint inn

122. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

123. the Lucky Buffalo, the great inn near Doire shean kept by Oighrig nic Iain

- 19 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 9** — *The Taigh-seinnse Mòr's hall* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr¹²⁴). An Taigh-seinnse Mòr, on the old coal road above Cuan chrom, opens a second hall lit wholly by dubhan. It is let for weddings, wakes and the meetings of the Guild of Hewers, whose own hall at Achadh dhomhain has been sold.
- 25 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 9** — *A lorry reaches the harbour at Doire shean* (Doire shean). The first dubhan lorry to come down to the harbour at Doire shean is met by half the town; its driver sells rides round the market square for a copper each until the maor tells him the square is not a fair.¹²⁵
- 26 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 9** — *The last ox-drove on the eastern salt road* (Àth bheag). In am Faoilleach the last ox-drove goes out of Àth bheag with salt on the old drove road past Baile iséal: four carts and twenty-four beasts, driven by Murchadh Bàn and his two grandsons. It takes five days to reach the inland towns in the rain. On his return the old man sells the oxen at the ford and buys no others.¹²⁶
- 27 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 9** — *A dubhan tank at An Sligeanach Fad' às*¹²⁷ (An Sligeanach Fad' às). Over the winter the landlord of An Sligeanach Fad' às, of the drover families of Achadh mhòr, sets an iron tank on stone piers in the forecourt with a hand-pump beside it, and sells dubhan by the gallon to the lorries on the southern road. By spring he has sold more fuel off it than beds.¹²⁸
- 9 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 9** — *The last ox-sale at An Sligeanach Fad' às*¹²⁹ (An Sligeanach Fad' às). Meeting in the second hall of An Sligeanach Fad' às, the drover families of Achadh mhòr agree to sell their teams and take lorries from the southern Obair-dhubhain Seann Skell¹³⁰ against the price, the rest to be paid from the grain over three years. The oxen are sold in the inn's yards that afternoon, the last beasts to fill them.¹³¹
- 10 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 9** — *Pilgrims carried up to Caol shean by engine* (Caol shean). A river-boat fitted with a dubhan engine carries pilgrims up to the landing at Caol shean against the current in half a day, where the rowed boats took two; the boatmen of the landing let it moor without a word said.¹³²

124. the great house on the old coal road above Cuan chrom, whose new hall is let to the Guild of Hewers

125. ← Follows from *The first horseless carriage*, 25 an t-Ògmhios, DE 9; ← Follows from *Lamp-glass dearer at Cathair dhearg*, 22 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8.

126. ← Follows from *The eastern salt-road*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8; ¶ *Legacy Salt-pans of Àth bheag* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 32; ← Follows from *The blessing for a horse said over an engine*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 8.

127. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

128. → Leads to *Achadh mhòr's drovers*, 22 am Màrt, DE 9; ← Follows from *The Sligeanach's great year* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 69; ← Follows from *The last ox-drove on the eastern salt road*, 26 an Dàmhair, DE 9.

129. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

130. the dubhan works at the southern Seann Skell

131. ⇌ At the same time *Achadh mhòr's drovers*, 22 am Màrt, DE 9; ○ Same place *The road-peace* → An Aois Naomh, FE 175; ← Follows from *A dubhan tank at An Sligeanach Fad' às*, 27 an Dàmhair, DE 9.

132. ← Follows from *The last ox-sale at An Sligeanach Fad' às*, 9 an t-Samhain, DE 9.

- 22 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 9** — *The Muileann mhin lamps go out on the roads* (Muileann mhin). The lamp-makers of Muileann mhin, given leave the autumn before to set their own mark on the lamps they make, send them out along every road a lorry can reach. A house that hangs three or four at its door and yard wall has light enough to see a cart from a mile off, and enough, more than one landlord says, to count coin by without a candle.¹³³
- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 9** — *The roads change house by house* (An Taigh-seinnse Òir¹³⁴). The inns of the old mining roads do not take up the new lamps together. For a season and more a carrier travelling the length of the kingdom passes from a house lit like a market fair into one still lit as it was in its grandfather's day, sometimes within the same day's driving, for the lamps and the fuel to fill them cost more than every house can find at once.¹³⁵
- 24 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 9** — *An Leòmhann Buidhe¹³⁶ hangs the new lamps* (An Leòmhann Buidhe). The landlord of An Leòmhann Buidhe on the north-east road hangs four dubhan lamps along his yard wall and two by the taproom door, warned by a carrier that a house without them will lose its custom within two years. The taproom is fuller within the month than it has been in years.¹³⁷
- 25 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 9** — *The Lion's old wick kept burning* (An Leòmhann Buidhe¹³⁸). Beside his new lamps the landlord of An Leòmhann Buidhe keeps the oil wick his grandmother first lit above the door, the night his grandfather came home from a voyage given up for lost, and has trimmed it every night since. Asked why he keeps it when it costs him an hour a night the new lamps do not, he says the new ones are for the road and the old one is for the house.¹³⁹
- 26 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 9** — *The Àrd-choimheadaiche¹⁴⁰'s carriage fitted at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). The fitters of the shipmasters' works at the southern Seann Skell, Joe Ashby chief among them, box a lorry's dubhan engine into the frame of the Àrd-choimheadaiche's own carriage, working evenings beside their ordered work for the better part of a month. Peigi nic Ascaill oversees the fitting; the works' book names the works and not the man.¹⁴¹

133. ← Follows from *The lamp-makers turn*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7; → Leads to *The inns take the new lamps*, 30 am Màrt, DE 9.

134. the golden house, a waypoint inn

135. → Leads to *The inns take the new lamps*, 30 am Màrt, DE 9; ← Follows from *The Muileann mhin lamps go out on the roads*, 22 an t-Samhain, DE 9.

136. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

137. → Leads to *An Leòmhann Buidhe keeps a wick*, 15 an Giblean, DE 9; ← Follows from *The roads change house by house*, 23 an t-Samhain, DE 9.

138. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

139. ← Follows from *An Leòmhann Buidhe keeps a wick*, 15 an Giblean, DE 9; ← Follows from *An Leòmhann Buidhe hangs the new lamps*, 24 an t-Samhain, DE 9.

140. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

141. → Leads to *The first horseless carriage*, 25 an t-Ògmhios, DE 9; ← Follows from *The Seann Skell works' first year*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 4; ← Follows from *The Lion's old wick kept burning*, 25 an t-Samhain, DE 9.

27 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 9 — *The Àrd-choimbeadaiche*¹⁴² *rides to Tobar dhearg without a horse* (Seann Skell). In an t-Ògmhios Alasdair mac Ìomhair rides the first carriage on the island that needs no horse from Seann Skell to Bride's house at Tobar dhearg, Joe Ashby driving. He says of it only what he said of dubhan itself five years before: that it is not forbidden, and he does not know that it is blessed.¹⁴³

8 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 9 — *Am Buabhall Fortanach*¹⁴⁴ *holds back the lamps* (Am Buabhall Fortanach). Oighrig nic Iain, landlady of Am Buabhall Fortanach near Doire shean, refuses her cousin's offer of the new lamps for a year and more, telling him she will hang them when she has seen one house on the road ruined by hanging them, or ruined by not. Her custom does not fall in the waiting, for carriers seek the house out whether its yard is bright or not.¹⁴⁵

9 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 9 — *Oighrig nic Iain's ledger turns* (Am Buabhall Fortanach¹⁴⁶). Closing her house's ledger in the autumn, kept in one line since the house's founding, Oighrig nic Iain finds the year's trade in oil has fallen for the first time in four generations. She writes beneath the total that the light is going out from under the house whether it hangs the new lamps or not, and better to hang them itself than have the road hang them for it.¹⁴⁷

10 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 9 — *Am Buabhall Fortanach*¹⁴⁸ *hangs its lamps* (Am Buabhall Fortanach). Oighrig nic Iain's cousin fits eight dubhan lamps at Am Buabhall Fortanach over three days. She pays his account without complaint and pins the bill inside her ledger's cover, the cost written plain as a year's takings from the oil trade spent to be rid of it. The old oil lamp over the taproom door she takes down and sets empty on the shelf above the till.¹⁴⁹

142. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

143. ← Follows from *The first horseless carriage*, 25 an t-Ògmhios, DE 9; ⇌ At the same time *The high custodian's letter*, 25 an t-Samhain, DE 4; ← Follows from *The Àrd-choimbeadaiche's carriage fitted at Seann Skell*, 26 an t-Samhain, DE 9.

144. the Lucky Buffalo, the great inn near Doire shean kept by Oighrig nic Iain

145. → Leads to *Am Buabhall Fortanach*, 25 an t-Sultain, DE 9; ← Follows from *The Àrd-choimbeadaiche rides to Tobar dhearg without a horse*, 27 an t-Samhain, DE 9.

146. the Lucky Buffalo, the great inn near Doire shean kept by Oighrig nic Iain

147. ← Follows from *Am Buabhall Fortanach*, 25 an t-Sultain, DE 9; ← Follows from *Am Buabhall Fortanach holds back the lamps*, 8 an Dùbhlachd, DE 9.

148. the Lucky Buffalo, the great inn near Doire shean kept by Oighrig nic Iain

149. ← Follows from *Am Buabhall Fortanach*, 25 an t-Sultain, DE 9; ← Follows from *Oighrig nic Iain's ledger turns*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, DE 9.

- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 9** — *Comann nan Gualadairean*¹⁵⁰ 'hall at Achadh dhombain for sale' (Achadh dhomhain). Comann nan Gualadairean, its rolls too thin to keep it, puts its own hall at Achadh dhomhain up for sale, and asks the landlord of An Taigh-seinnse Mòr¹⁵¹ for the use of his new hall until it finds a roof of its own. He lets it to them for less than a wedding party would pay, his own father having hewed coal on that road before he kept an inn on it.¹⁵²
- 22 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 9** — *Houses on the roads keep their yards open later* (An Taigh-seinnse Òir¹⁵³). Along the old mining roads the inns that hang dubhan lamps keep their stable-boys up later, for lorries come up the road at any hour, while houses still lit by oil shut their yard gates at full dark.¹⁵⁴
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 9** — *The custodian's greys retired* (Seann Skell). The pair of matched greys that drew the Àrd-choimheadaiche¹⁵⁵'s carriage among Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail¹⁵⁶, failing in wind on the hill roads, are retired when the carriage is fitted with an engine at the southern Seann Skell.¹⁵⁷
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 9** — *Joe Ashby's initials inside the engine-box* (Seann Skell). The fitters at the southern works keep the panel from the first horseless carriage's engine-box, with Joe Ashby's initials chalked on its inside where no report would find them.¹⁵⁸
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 9** — *A wedding in the Taigh-seinnse Mòr's new hall* (Cuan chrom). The first wedding held in the new dubhan-lit hall of An Taigh-seinnse Mòr¹⁵⁹ is a carter's daughter of Cuan chrom's, and the guests say afterwards that the light made every face at the long table look younger.¹⁶⁰
- 4 AM MÀRT, DE 10** — *An Taigh-òsta Grianach*¹⁶¹ (An Taigh-òsta Grianach). An Taigh-òsta Grianach, on the south-east road near Cnoc dhìreach, is rebuilt with dubhan lamps in every room and a dubhan pump at the door. It is the first inn on the island to sell fuel as well as beds.

150. the Guild of Hewers; lit. 'the fellowship of the colliers'

151. the great house on the old coal road above Cuan chrom, whose new hall is let to the Guild of Hewers

152. → Leads to *The Taigh-seinnse Mòr's hall*, 19 an Dàmhair, DE 9; ← Follows from *Am Buabhall Fortanach bangs its lamps*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 9.

153. the golden house, a waypoint inn

154. ← Follows from *The inns take the new lamps*, 30 am Màrt, DE 9; ← Follows from *Comann nan Gualadairean' hall at Achadh dhombain for sale*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 9.

155. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

156. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

157. ← Follows from *The first horseless carriage*, 25 an t-Ògmhios, DE 9; ← Follows from *Houses on the roads keep their yards open later*, 22 an Dùbhlachd, DE 9.

158. ← Follows from *The first horseless carriage*, 25 an t-Ògmhios, DE 9; ← Follows from *The custodian's greys retired*, 23 an Dùbhlachd, DE 9.

159. the great house on the old coal road above Cuan chrom, whose new hall is let to the Guild of Hewers

160. ← Follows from *The Taigh-seinnse Mòr's hall*, 19 an Dàmhair, DE 9; ← Follows from *Joe Ashby's initials inside the engine-box*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 9.

161. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

- 2 AN GIBLEAN, DE 10** — *The coal engines laid up* (Muileann chrom). The Rail Board's coal-fired engines are laid up in a siding at Muileann chrom and never run again. The yard families who drove them are taught the dubhan engines, such of them as will learn.
- 11 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 10** — *An Taigh-seinnse Reòta* (An Taigh-seinnse Reòta). An Taigh-seinnse Reòta on the north road above Muileann fhada is the last of the great inns to keep a wick lamp in every room. Its landlord writes to the Board that the reek of dubhan drives away his guests. It does not, and the next year he puts in the lamps.
- 10 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 10** — *Muileann dhearg closed* (Muileann dhearg). The last working face under Muileann dhearg is shut. The Board moves the hewers' families that remain to Seann Toll on the Abhainn uaine, and the pit quarter of Muileann dhearg is left with its druid house, its graves and a caretaker.
- 13 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 10** — *The word Leòmhann spreads along the roads* (An Leòmhann Buidhe¹⁶²). Other houses along the north-east road take up the custom of keeping one old wick lit among the new lamps, some with a story of their own to hang it on and some only because a neighbouring house does the same. Within a year or two a wick kept burning that way, of no more use than memory or fashion, is called along every road a Leòmhann.¹⁶³
- 14 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 10** — *A carriers' song of the wick lamp*. At a spring fair where carriers of half a dozen roads meet to trade news and hire, someone sets a verse about the wick kept burning for the memory of it to a tune already used for a droving song. The tune catches before its words are settled, and within a season it is sung from the north-east road to the south-west by carriers who have never seen the house it was made for.¹⁶⁴
- 15 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 10** — *The first inn to sell fuel and beds under one sign* (An Taigh-òsta Grianach¹⁶⁵). The widowed landlady of An Taigh-òsta Grianach paints a new sign over her door naming what a traveller may buy there, beds and fire, and within the year half the great houses do the same.¹⁶⁶
- 22 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 10** — *The landlord of An Taigh-seinnse Reòta keeps his wicks* (Muileann fhada). The landlord of An Taigh-seinnse Reòta above Muileann fhada, having written to Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹⁶⁷, keeps a wick lamp in every room, and the lorry-drivers who stop there take their suppers by the fire rather than read by them.¹⁶⁸

162. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

163. ← Follows from *An Leòmhann Buidhe keeps a wick*, 15 an Giblean, DE 9; ← Follows from *A wedding in the Taigh-seinnse Mòr's new hall*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 9.

164. ⇌ At the same time *An Leòmhann Buidhe keeps a wick*, 15 an Giblean, DE 9; ← Follows from *The word Leòmhann spreads along the roads*, 13 an Dàmhair, DE 10.

165. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

166. ← Follows from *An Taigh-òsta Grianach*, 4 am Màrt, DE 10; ← Follows from *A carriers' song of the wick lamp*, 14 an Dàmhair, DE 10.

167. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

23 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 10 — *The last coal orders stop at Muileann chrom* (Muileann chrom).

Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹⁶⁹'s clerk at Muileann chrom stops writing coal orders for the shorter hauls, An Sloc Mòr¹⁷⁰ running three days in the week where it ran six. The coal engines are worked on the shorter runs alone through the summer while the dubhan engine takes the long haul to Cathair dhearg.¹⁷¹

24 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 10 — *Comhairle nam Mèinnean*¹⁷²'s notice on the shed door (Muileann chrom).

A notice at Muileann chrom stands the coal engines down pending Comhairle nam Mèinnean's further order and calls the men who drove and fired them for instruction on the new engines, at the driver's rate while they learn. It says nothing of a man who does not learn, nor of what is to be done with the engines standing idle.¹⁷³

I AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 10 — *The Frisecalach brothers put their names down* (Muileann chrom).

Somhairle and Uilleam Frisecalach, young firemen of the yard rows at Muileann chrom, ask Eachann mac Ruairidh what the new engine is like to drive and put their names down together for instruction. Their father, near the end of his own driving, says nothing and puts down none.¹⁷⁴

IO AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 10 — *Dòmhnall Ruadh gives up the new engine* (Muileann chrom).

Dòmhnall Ruadh, a driver of thirty years on Slighe a' Ghuaill¹⁷⁵, cannot learn to read the dubhan engine's valve as he read a coal engine's fire, and after nine days strikes his name from Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹⁷⁶'s instruction list. He asks to be kept on at the sidings or the stores instead.¹⁷⁷

II AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 10 — *The nine coal engines stand in the long siding* (Muileann chrom).

By the feast of Samhain the last of the nine coal engines of Muileann chrom stands cold in the long siding with its fire drawn, and no order comes to light any of them again. Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹⁷⁸ sends a clerk once, in spring, to count and write down their condition, and touches them with no order after.¹⁷⁹

168. ← Follows from *An Taigh-seinnse Reòta*, 11 an t-Sultain, DE 10; ← Follows from *The first inn to sell fuel and beds under one sign*, 15 an Dàmhair, DE 10.

169. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

170. the great pit at the mountain

171. → Leads to *The coal engines laid up*, 2 an Giblean, DE 10; ← Follows from *The coal line's first dubhan engine*, 1 an Cèitean, DE 8.

172. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

173. → Leads to *The coal engines laid up*, 2 an Giblean, DE 10; ← Follows from *The last coal orders stop at Muileann chrom*, 23 an Dàmhair, DE 10.

174. ← Follows from *The coal engines laid up*, 2 an Giblean, DE 10; ← Follows from *Comhairle nam Mèinnean's notice on the shed door*, 24 an Dàmhair, DE 10.

175. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

176. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

177. ← Follows from *The coal engines laid up*, 2 an Giblean, DE 10; ← Follows from *The Frisecalach brothers put their names down*, 1 an t-Samhain, DE 10.

178. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

179. ○ Same place *The coal engines laid up*, 2 an Giblean, DE 10; ← Follows from *Dòmhnall Ruadh gives up the new engine*, 10 an t-Samhain, DE 10.

- 19 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 10** — *An Taigh-seinnse Reòta keeps its rooms unlit* (An Taigh-seinnse Reòta). Murchadh Frisealach, landlord of An Taigh-seinnse Reòta on the north road, writes to Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹⁸⁰ that the reek of dubhan will drive custom from his house as it has from three houses on the coast. The letter is repeated at firesides between Muileann fhada and the capital as proof a house may hold to the old ways.¹⁸¹
- 20 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 10** — *The Reòta puts in the new lamps* (An Taigh-seinnse Reòta). Within the year the dubhan bus between Caol mhòr and the capital brings the Reòta more trade in a month than the old coaching road brought it in a season, and guests who stop there complain of the reek of tallow. Murchadh Frisealach lights the taproom and his two best rooms with dubhan, and keeps one wick lamp over the stable door out of what he calls habit.¹⁸²
- 28 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 10** — *Comhairle nam Mèinnean*¹⁸³ *'s surveyor writes Muileann dhearg spent* (Muileann dhearg). A surveyor of Comhairle nam Mèinnean walks the last working face at Muileann dhearg with the pit captain Gilleasbaig Ruadh and two of the older hewers, and writes in his book that the seam is spent below the value of working it. The pit is ordered to close at the month's end.¹⁸⁴
- 29 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 10** — *The last shift comes up at Muileann dhearg* (Muileann dhearg). Twelve hewers come up the shaft at Muileann dhearg on its last morning, having spent their final two days drawing props and rails for scrap rather than cutting coal. Aonghas Dubh, last out, carries the shift's last lamp and finds no one waiting to take it; the pit captain hangs it unlit on the rack himself.¹⁸⁵
- 7 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 10** — *The guild finds carts for the walk to Seann Toll* (Muileann dhearg). Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh, master of Comann nan Gualadairean¹⁸⁶, goes door to door through the pit quarter of Muileann dhearg after the closing to promise carts for what the forty remaining households cannot carry, Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹⁸⁷ having offered places at Seann Toll but no removal. He walks the ten miles of river road with them himself.

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180. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

181. → Leads to *An Taigh-seinnse Reòta*, 11 an t-Sultain, DE 10; ← Follows from *The nine coal engines stand in the long siding*, 11 an t-Samhain, DE 10.

182. ← Follows from *An Taigh-seinnse Reòta*, 11 an t-Sultain, DE 10; ← Follows from *An Taigh-seinnse Reòta keeps its rooms unlit*, 19 an t-Samhain, DE 10.

183. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

184. → Leads to *Muileann dhearg closed*, 10 an Dàmhair, DE 10; ← Follows from *The Reòta puts in the new lamps*, 20 an t-Samhain, DE 10.

185. ← Follows from *Muileann dhearg closed*, 10 an Dàmhair, DE 10; ← Follows from *Comhairle nam Mèinnean's surveyor writes Muileann dhearg spent*, 28 an t-Samhain, DE 10.

186. the Guild of Hewers; lit. 'the fellowship of the colliers'

187. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

188. ← Follows from *Muileann dhearg closed*, 10 an Dàmhair, DE 10; ← Follows from *The last shift comes up at Muileann dhearg*, 29 an t-Samhain, DE 10.

- 8 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 10** — *Eachann mac Ruairidh teaches the older drivers* (Muileann chrom). At Muileann chrom Eachann mac Ruairidh, the one man of the yard who has driven the dubhan engine a full year, is set to teach it to the coal drivers who put their names down, the Frisealach brothers first.¹⁸⁹
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 10** — *Children play in the cabs of the laid-up engines* (Muileann chrom). The nine coal engines stand in the long siding at Muileann chrom through that year and the next; the grass comes up between the sleepers and the children of the yard rows climb into the cabs to play at driving.¹⁹⁰
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 10** — *The last lamp at Muileann dhearg hung unlit* (Muileann dhearg). When the last cage comes up at Muileann dhearg, the youngest hewer stands with the last lamp used on the face and no one to hand it to, until the pit captain Gilleasbaig Ruadh hangs it on the rack himself.¹⁹¹
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 10** — *Achadh mbòr's harvest carted by lorry* (Achadh mhòr). The first harvest of the great granary fields of Achadh mhòr to go down to the capital's mills without an ox in the traces goes by lorry in eleven days; the old drovers watch it pass from the field-gates.¹⁹²
- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 10** — *The mill-citadel's wheel kept turning* (Muileann leathan). At Muileann leathan the Tuathaich keep their mill-citadel's water-wheel turning for the grinding though a dubhan engine is offered them by a factor of the south; the miller says the river asks nothing of the north's fuel and nothing of the south's money.¹⁹³

189. ← Follows from *The coal engines laid up*, 2 an Giblean, DE 10; ← Follows from *The guild finds carts for the walk to Seann Toll*, 7 an Dùbhlachd, DE 10.

190. ← Follows from *The coal engines laid up*, 2 an Giblean, DE 10; ← Follows from *Eachann mac Ruairidh teaches the older drivers*, 8 an Dùbhlachd, DE 10.

191. ← Follows from *Muileann dhearg closed*, 10 an Dàmhair, DE 10; ← Follows from *Children play in the cabs of the laid-up engines*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, DE 10.

192. ← Follows from *Achadh mbòr's drovers*, 22 am Màrt, DE 9; ← Follows from *The last lamp at Muileann dhearg hung unlit*, 17 an Dùbhlachd, DE 10.

193. ← Follows from *Achadh mbòr's harvest carted by lorry*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, DE 10.

THE YEARS DE II – 15

- 27 AN T-IUCHAR, DE II** — *The Muileann dhearg families at Seann Toll* (Seann Toll). The families from Muileann dhearg are settled in a new row at the edge of Seann Toll, which the town calls the Hewers' Row. Few of them find work on the boats. Most work at the dubhan tanks by the river landing.¹
- 25 AN LÙNASTAL, DE II** — *Muileann dhearg's druid house* (Muileann dhearg). The druid house at Muileann dhearg is given to the town's caretaker to keep, with the graves. Once a year the druid school at Caol shean sends a teacher to give the town's one remaining lecture, and few come.
- 3 AN T-SULTAIN, DE II** — *Few of Muileann dhearg take to the river* (Seann Toll). The close river trade of Seann Toll's own boatmen takes on only two or three of the young men of Sreath nan Gualadairean² that winter. Most of the households go instead to the dubhan tanks at the landing, rolling barrels and minding pumps for a trade none of them was born to.³
- 4 AN T-SULTAIN, DE II** — *Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh speaks of the lamp* (Seann Toll). Walking the frozen street of Sreath nan Gualadairean⁴ with Gilleasbaig Ruadh, Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh says it was not the pit's closing that undid him at Muileann dhearg but the sight of a lamp with no one left to hand it to, and names the landlord of An Taigh-seinnse Reòta a man doing the same in his own house.⁵
- 13 AN T-SULTAIN, DE II** — *The first lecture at the empty quarter* (Muileann dhearg). A young teacher of Scoiltean nan Draoidhean⁶ at Caol shean comes to Muileann dhearg in am Faoilleach and finds four old people and the caretaker Padraig Iarna waiting in the cold hall. He does not come again that year sooner than the next am Faoilleach.⁷
- 14 AN T-SULTAIN, DE II** — *The Frisealach brothers pass the yard's test* (Muileann chrom). The Frisealach brothers, the first coal drivers at Muileann chrom to put their names down for the dubhan engine, take a train to the capital and back under Eachann mac Ruairidh's eye and are passed.⁸

1. → Caused by *The guild finds carts for the walk to Seann Toll*, 7 an Dùbhlachd, DE 10.

2. the Hewers' Row at Seann Toll

3. ← Follows from *The Muileann dhearg families at Seann Toll*, 27 an t-Iuchar, DE 11; ← Follows from *The mill-citadel's wheel kept turning*, 27 an Dùbhlachd, DE 10.

4. the Hewers' Row at Seann Toll

5. ¶ Legacy *Muileann dhearg closed*, 10 an Dàmhair, DE 10; ← Follows from *Few of Muileann dhearg take to the river*, 3 an t-Sultain, DE 11.

6. the druid schools

7. ← Follows from *Muileann dhearg's druid house*, 25 an Lùnastal, DE 11; ← Follows from *Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh speaks of the lamp*, 4 an t-Sultain, DE 11.

8. ← Follows from *The coal engines laid up*, 2 an Giblean, DE 10; ← Follows from *The first lecture at the empty quarter*, 13 an t-Sultain, DE 11.

22 AN T-SULTAIN, DE II — *The beacon keeper of Àth dhearg writes for glass* (Àth dhearg). The keeper of Taigh-solais Àth dhearg⁹ writes twice to Comhairle nan Taighean-solais¹⁰ for spare chimney-glass for the dubhan lamp, the stair too narrow to carry up more than one at a time, and is sent a crate of twelve.¹¹

23 AN T-SULTAIN, DE II — *The word spreads before the fuel does*. Men begin to say "dubhan" for the fuel itself, as well as for the man who made it, years before the trade built upon it is whole.

22 AN DÀMHAIR, DE II — *Dubhan-tùsail* (Caol shean). The word 'dubhan-tùsail' is first found in a letter of the druid school at Caol shean. It is used of a first attempt that seemed a dead end and proved otherwise, and the letter uses it of the school's own revival.

27 AN DÀMHAIR, DE II — *Sileas nic Rath taken on as the chronicler's clerk* (Muileann chaol). Ragnall mac Mhuirich, keeper of the Library, finds the wage out of his own fund for binding and takes on Sileas nic Rath, a copyist's niece of Àth dhreach, as clerk to Seanchaidh na Rìoghachd¹². Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh had asked the council for a clerk three times and been refused or ignored each time.¹³

9 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE II — *The slip-box of the word's spellings* (Muileann chaol). At Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh's asking, Sileas nic Rath begins a box of slips, one to a spelling, of every form the fuel's name takes in the letters that come up the library road: dubhan, dùbhan, dùban, and once, for a fortnight only, An Dubhan with the article and a capital letter.¹⁴

15 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE II — *The maor of Cathair mhòr's letter marked first* (Muileann chaol). The first letter marked in Sileas nic Rath's box is the maor of Cathair mhòr's, which speaks of the fair price of dùban and says nothing of the man who first made it. Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh reads it for the clerk as the mark of a name going out of its own word.¹⁵

22 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE II — *Dubhan-tùsail entered and never used* (Muileann chaol). Ragnall mac Mhuirich copies Scoiltean nan Draoidhean¹⁶'s coined word into an Leabharlann¹⁷'s word-list in his own hand, under the day's entry, and never uses it again in anything he writes that year. The word stands unused on the page, unstruck and unbuilt upon.¹⁸

9. the lighthouse at Àth dhearg

10. the Lighthouse Board

11. ← Follows from *Taigh-solais Àth dhearg converted*, 25 am Màrt, DE 7; ← Follows from *The Friscalach brothers pass the yard's test*, 14 an t-Sultain, DE 11.

12. the royal chronicler

13. → Leads to *The word spreads before the fuel does*, 23 an t-Sultain, DE 11.

14. ← Follows from *The word spreads before the fuel does*, 23 an t-Sultain, DE 11; ← Follows from *Sileas nic Rath taken on as the chronicler's clerk*, 27 an Dàmhair, DE 11.

15. ← Follows from *The word spreads before the fuel does*, 23 an t-Sultain, DE 11; ← Follows from *The slip-box of the word's spellings*, 9 an t-Samhain, DE 11.

16. the druid schools

17. the Library at Muileann chaol

- 11 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 11** — *Beathag marks the road's two names* (Muileann chaol). Reading the new timetable at an Leabharlann¹⁹, Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh tells Sileas nic Rath to mark the change beside the fuel's own spellings, saying a road keeps the name the men on it give it, not the name a board prints on a card.²⁰
- 1 AN CÈITEAN, DE 12** — *The Rail Board's new name* (Muileann chrom). In its own timetables the Rail Board drops 'coal' from the name of its main line and calls it only the line. Everyone else still calls it the coal line.²¹
- 30 AN CÈITEAN, DE 12** — *The Guild of Hewers dissolved* (Achadh dhomhain). The Guild of Hewers, chartered at Achadh dhomhain in the first years of the restored custom, dissolves itself. Its rolls, its oath-stone of coal and its sick-roll go to the library. Its last master, Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh, writes that the guild had outlived the mountain's patience.²²
- 28 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 12** — *The bath-house given to the Rite* (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh²³). The bath-house at the hot springs near Muileann ruadh, built by the Hewers for their sick, passes with the guild's other goods to the custodians of the Rite. It is opened to any who pay, and for the first time to the Tuathaich.
- 13 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 12** — *Clach-mhionnan nan Gualadairean*²⁴ brought to an Leabharlann²⁵ (Achadh dhomhain). Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh brings the guild's rolls, its sick-roll and the oath-stone itself, worn smooth by two generations of thumbs, to an Leabharlann on a hired cart, and stands bare-headed in the rain through the whole of the unloading. Sileas nic Rath, Beathag being away at Àth dhireach, signs for the goods herself.²⁶
- 27 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 12** — *Tormod's letter copied into the record* (Muileann chaol). Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh gives Sileas nic Rath a letter to be copied into an Leabharlann²⁷'s record rather than filed among the guild's other papers, saying the guild had outlived the mountain's patience. Sileas copies it that evening in a hand made to match Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh's own.²⁸

18. ← Follows from *Dubhan-tùsail*, 22 an Dàmhair, DE 11; ← Follows from *The maor of Cathair mbòr's letter marked first*, 15 an t-Samhain, DE 11.

19. the Library at Muileann chaol

20. ← Follows from *Dubhan-tùsail entered and never used*, 22 an t-Samhain, DE 11.

21. ← Leads to *Beathag marks the road's two names*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, DE 11.

22. ← Leads to *Comann nan Gualadairean' ball at Achadh dhomhain for sale*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 9.

23. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

24. the oath-stone of coal of the Guild of Hewers

25. the Library at Muileann chaol

26. ← Follows from *The Guild of Hewers dissolved*, 30 an Cèitean, DE 12; ← Follows from *Beathag marks the road's two names*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, DE 11.

27. the Library at Muileann chaol

28. ← Follows from *The Guild of Hewers dissolved*, 30 an Cèitean, DE 12; ← Follows from *Clach-mhionnan nan Gualadairean brought to an Leabharlann*, 13 an t-Iuchar, DE 12.

- 29 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 12** — *The first Tuathach family bathed at Muileann ruadh* (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh²⁹). In an Lùnastal a woman of Doire ghlas, brought south by her married daughter for a chest complaint, bathes at the springs below Muileann ruadh, the first Tuathach the house has ever taken in. The keeper shows her to the basin as she would show anyone and asks no leave of the custodians.³⁰
- 12 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 12** — *Forty-one hands marked* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³¹). By the time her slip-box is full Sileas nic Rath has marked in forty-one of the sixty hands that write regularly to an Leabharlann³² the month each first wrote of the fuel without the man's name.³³
- 11 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 12** — *Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh stands bareheaded at the handing-over* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³⁴). The last master of Comann nan Gualadairean³⁵ stands in the rain in the yard of an Leabharlann³⁶ with his hat off through the whole unloading of the guild's goods, and asks no receipt but that it be said they came whole and not begged for.³⁷
- 27 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 12** — *The sick of the springs under Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail*³⁸ (Muileann ruadh). When Comann nan Gualadairean³⁹ bath-house at Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh⁴⁰ of Muileann ruadh passes to Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail, its custodians keep the old keeper on and take in the same sick, hewers' widows first, as the guild's rule had.⁴¹
- 1 AM MÀRT, DE 13** — *The Achadh dhombhain hall* (Achadh dhomhain). The Hewers' hall at Achadh dhomhain, sold before the guild was dissolved, becomes a dubhan depot. Its carved lintel, with the guild's oath cut in it, is left in its place above the pumps.
- 9 AM MÀRT, DE 13** — *The trade turns to dubhan*. Markets, the supply of the host and the shipping turn wholly to the new fuel. The coal caste sees the source of its own power fail, and makes no objection.

29. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

30. ← Follows from *The bath-house given to the Rite*, 28 an t-Ògmhios, DE 12; ← Follows from *Tormod's letter copied into the record*, 27 an t-Iuchar, DE 12.

31. the Library at Muileann chaol

32. the Library at Muileann chaol

33. ← Follows from *The word spreads before the fuel does*, 23 an t-Sultain, DE 11; ← Follows from *The first Tuathach family bathed at Muileann ruadh*, 29 an Lùnastal, DE 12.

34. the Library at Muileann chaol

35. the Guild of Hewers; lit. 'the fellowship of the colliers'

36. the Library at Muileann chaol

37. ← Follows from *The Guild of Hewers dissolved*, 30 an Cèitean, DE 12; ← Follows from *Forty-one hands marked*, 12 an t-Sultain, DE 12.

38. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

39. the Guild of Hewers; lit. 'the fellowship of the colliers'

40. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

41. ← Follows from *The bath-house given to the Rite*, 28 an t-Ògmhios, DE 12; ← Follows from *Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh stands bareheaded at the handing-over*, 11 an Dàmhair, DE 12.

- 5 **AN T-IUCHAR, DE 13** — *Buses and hired cars* (Cathair dhearg). Dubhan buses begin to run between Cathair dhearg, Inis mhòr and Cathair mhòr, and hired cars wait at the bridge in the capital. Dia-thìris takes the names of both from the humans' tongue as it found them, bus and tacsaidh; for the engine and the train it had made words of its own.
- 4 **AN T-SULTAIN, DE 13** — *The house of Mac Ùisdein moves* (Ros dhomhain). The house of Mac Ùisdein sells what is left of its share in the spoil and quarry of the Sloc Mòr and puts its money into dubhan shipping at Ros dhomhain. Of the families that held the vein it alone moves before the vein fails it.
- 15 **AN T-SULTAIN, DE 13** — *The fleet's first dubhan bulls* (Ros dhomhain). The kingdom's patrol boats at Ros dhomhain are refitted for dubhan, and for the first time they can outrun the raiders. The next two raider hulks taken are brought into Ros dhomhain under tow.
- 18 **AN T-SULTAIN, DE 13** — *Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh returns to Seann Toll* (Seann Toll). In am Faoilleach, against a doctor's plain advice, Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh travels once more to Sreath nan Gualadairean⁴² at Seann Toll to see how the removed families of Muileann dhearg fare in their first hard frost, though his chest has troubled him since the summer before.⁴³
- 2 **AN DÀMHAIR, DE 13** — *Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh dies at Seann Toll* (Seann Toll). Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh dies a little before dawn on the sixth of an Gearran, in a house of Sreath nan Gualadairean⁴⁴ at Seann Toll, of a fever that settled on his chest. Gilleasbaig Ruadh sits with him through the two nights before the doctor can come, and the Row buries him themselves at the edge of the flood-plain.⁴⁵
- 7 **AN DÀMHAIR, DE 13** — *Beathag enters Tormod's death herself* (Muileann chaol). Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh writes Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh's death into the day's page in her own hand, without asking her clerk to write it first, and sets beside the bare date his own line, that the guild had outlived the mountain's patience, and under it, smaller, that he had not.⁴⁶
- 21 **AN DÀMHAIR, DE 13** — *The guild's oath above the pumps* (Achadh dhomhain). The buyer of the old hall of Comann nan Gualadairean⁴⁷ at Achadh dhomhain leaves the lintel with the guild's oath cut into it where it is, above the dubhan pumps, since cutting it out would bring the front of the house down.⁴⁸

42. the Hewers' Row at Seann Toll

43. ¶ Legacy *The Guild of Hewers dissolved*, 30 an Cèitean, DE 12; ← Follows from *The sick of the springs under Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail*, 27 an t-Samhain, DE 12.

44. the Hewers' Row at Seann Toll

45. ¶ Legacy *The Guild of Hewers dissolved*, 30 an Cèitean, DE 12; ← Follows from *Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh returns to Seann Toll*, 18 an t-Sultain, DE 13.

46. ¶ Legacy *The Guild of Hewers dissolved*, 30 an Cèitean, DE 12; ← Follows from *Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh dies at Seann Toll*, 2 an Dàmhair, DE 13.

47. the Guild of Hewers; lit. 'the fellowship of the colliers'

- 9 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 13** — *Coinneach mac Ùisdein walks the tip-heaps at Achadh dhombhain* (Achadh dhomhain). Before selling his house's last share in An Sloc Mòr⁴⁹, Coinneach mac Ùisdein walks the spoil-heaps above Achadh dhomhain with his clerk, ground his family has held a right to for four generations and never before had reason to stand on.⁵⁰
- 26 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 13** — *Comhairle nam Mèinnean*⁵¹ *buys An Sloc Mòr*⁵²'s *last private share* (Cathair mhòr). Comhairle nam Mèinnean takes Taigh Mhic Ùisdein⁵³'s remaining share in An Sloc Mòr's spoil and quarry-rights at a price haggled down only a little from the house's own asking, glad to hold the whole of An Sloc Mòr in its own hand at last.⁵⁴
- 28 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 13** — *The first Mac Ùisdein bull takes shape at Ros dhombhain* (Ros dhomhain). The first of three dubhan hulls bought with An Sloc Mòr⁵⁵'s price is laid down at Ros dhomhain, a coastal trader with her tank amidships and her old grate left in for wood as well, should it ever come to that.⁵⁶
- 3 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 13** — *A bus line reaches Cathair mhòr* (Cathair dhearg). A second dubhan bus line opens between the capital and Cathair mhòr, Taigh Mhic Ùisdein⁵⁷'s own town, carrying passengers the eleven miles in under an hour where the old coach took the better part of a morning.⁵⁸
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 13** — *The coal caste holds its tongue* (Cathair dhearg). The old coal-holding families of the capital say nothing that anyone writes down of the bus, the hired car or the trade turning wholly to dubhan; those with a seam still paying hold their peace because it pays, and those whose seams are spent do quietly, each in its own season, what Taigh Mhic Ùisdein⁵⁹ has already done.⁶⁰
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 13** — *Bus and tacsaidh at the bridge* (Cathair dhearg). At the foot of the bridge in Cathair dhearg the dubhan buses load for Inis mhòr and Cathair mhòr and the hired cars wait for fares; the town calls them by the humans' names, bus and tacsaidh, and nobody coins others.⁶¹

48. ← Follows from *The Achadh dhombhain hall*, 1 am Màrt, DE 13; ← Follows from *Beathag enters Tormod's death herself*, 7 an Dàmhair, DE 13.

49. the great pit at the mountain

50. → Leads to *The bouse of Mac Ùisdein moves*, 4 an t-Sultain, DE 13.

51. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

52. the great pit at the mountain

53. the house of Mac Ùisdein

54. ← Follows from *The house of Mac Ùisdein moves*, 4 an t-Sultain, DE 13; ← Follows from *Coinneach mac Ùisdein walks the tip-heaps at Achadh dhombhain*, 9 an t-Samhain, DE 13.

55. the great pit at the mountain

56. ← Follows from *The house of Mac Ùisdein moves*, 4 an t-Sultain, DE 13; ← Follows from *Comhairle nam Mèinnean buys An Sloc Mòr's last private share*, 26 an t-Samhain, DE 13.

57. the house of Mac Ùisdein

58. ← Follows from *Buses and hired cars*, 5 an t-Iuchar, DE 13; ← Follows from *The first Mac Ùisdein bull takes shape at Ros dhombhain*, 28 an t-Samhain, DE 13.

59. the house of Mac Ùisdein

60. ← Follows from *The trade turns to dubhan*, 9 am Màrt, DE 13; ← Follows from *A bus line reaches Cathair mhòr*, 3 an Dùbhlachd, DE 13.

- 22 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 13** — *An Sloc Mòr*⁶² *s pumps run on dubhan* (Achadh dhomhain). The engine-house at An Sloc Mòr changes its pumps from coal to dubhan, Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁶³ finding it cheaper to buy the fuel than to burn its own coal.⁶⁴
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 13** — *A bus to the springs of Muileann ruadh* (Muileann ruadh). A bus of Cathair dhearg begins to run twice weekly to Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh⁶⁵ below Muileann ruadh, and the custodians of the bath-house find their benches full of townsfolk who are not sick.⁶⁶
- 2 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 14** — *Raiders taken to Ros dhombhain* (Ros dhomhain). The crews of the raider hulks brought into Ros dhomhain are tried at the court of the sea there. Several of them are Tuathaich. The court hangs none; it sends the Dia-thirich among them to the quarries at Achadh dhomhain and the Tuathaich home to the north.
- 29 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 14** — *The Fuel-Fitters chartered* (Seann Skell). The fitters of dubhan engines, who have worked outside every guild, are chartered as the Guild of Fuel-Fitters at Seann Skell on the southern coast. Its rolls, like those of every guild before it, are open to Dia-thirich only. The Tuathaich fitters already in the trade are let go.
- 27 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 14** — *Tuathaich fitters go north* (Caol mhòr). The fitters let go under the charter rule go back to the northern towns and fit engines there without a guild. Within a few years the harbour of Caol mhòr holds more dubhan boats than any port of its size in the south.
- 24 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 14** — *The Moot on the new fuel* (Caol mhòr). The Moot at Caol mhòr, under Martha Greaves, debates whether the north shall take up the new fuel or keep to its own seams. It votes to take it up. The delegates of the western pit towns walk out.
- 27 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 14** — *Peigi nic Ascaill reads Riaghailt na Cairte*⁶⁷ (Seann Skell). Peigi nic Ascaill reads the grant chartering Comann nan Goibhnean-ceangail⁶⁸ and finds, near its foot, the clause fixing the guild's rolls to Dia-thirich alone. She argues against the clause with Comann nan Sciobairean⁶⁹ before the grant is confirmed, and is not heard.⁷⁰

61. ← Follows from *Buses and hired cars*, 5 an t-Iuchar, DE 13; ← Follows from *The coal caste holds its tongue*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 13.

62. the great pit at the mountain

63. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

64. ← Follows from *The house of Mac Ùisdein moves*, 4 an t-Sultain, DE 13; ← Follows from *Bus and tacsaidh at the bridge*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, DE 13.

65. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

66. ← Follows from *Buses and hired cars*, 5 an t-Iuchar, DE 13; ← Follows from *An Sloc Mòr's pumps run on dubhan*, 22 an Dùbhlachd, DE 13.

67. the charter rule that kept the Fuel-Fitters' rolls to Dia-thirich

68. the Guild of Fuel-Fitters; lit. 'the fellowship of the fitters'

69. the company of shipmasters who built the dubhan works at the southern Seann Skell

70. → Leads to *The Fuel-Fitters chartered*, 29 an Lùnastal, DE 14; ← Follows from *A bus to the springs of Muileann ruadh*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, DE 13.

- 28 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 14** — *Twelve masters sworn to Comann nan Goibhnean-ceangail*⁷¹ (Seann Skell). Twelve masters, Peigi nic Ascaill among the first six called, swear Comann nan Goibhnean-ceangail' oath at the southern Seann Skell under a clerk of An t-Ionmhas⁷² and a custodian of Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail⁷³, while the Tuathaich fitters who trained beside them stand outside the roll being read.⁷⁴
- 3 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 14** — *Peigi nic Ascaill pays Joe Ashby a month over* (Seann Skell). The evening of the chartering, Peigi nic Ascaill brings Joe Ashby a month's wage over what is owed him and the two other Tuathaich fitters let go with him, and cannot bring herself to come further than his own doorstep to give it.⁷⁵
- 4 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 14** — *Joe Ashby fits Jean Fisher's boat* (Caol mhòr). Back at Caol mhòr, Joe Ashby fits his first engine outside any guild, to the fishing boat of a widow named Jean Fisher, taking payment half in coin and half in fish.⁷⁶
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 14** — *The guild's letter pinned above Joe's bench* (Caol mhòr). Comann nan Goibhnean-ceangail⁷⁷ court at Seann Skell writes north warning any who fit an engine without the guild's leave that they do so without its protection. Joe Ashby pins the letter above his bench at Caol mhòr rather than burn it.⁷⁸
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 14** — *Ruth Calder speaks and the five towns walk out* (Caol mhòr). Ruth Calder, sent to Tional nan Tuathach⁷⁹ that year in her dying father's stead, speaks for the western pit towns' right to cut their own coal as long as the seams allow, and leads the five towns' delegates out of the hall before the vote is entered in the book.⁸⁰
- 16 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 14** — *Martha Greaves keeps the granaries open to all five towns* (Caol mhòr). Asked whether the walk-out closes Tional nan Tuathach⁸¹'s granaries to the western towns, Martha Greaves answers that a hungry household is a hungry household whatever its delegate voted, and the question is not put to her again that year.⁸²

71. the Guild of Fuel-Fitters; lit. 'the fellowship of the fitters'

72. the Treasury

73. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

74. ← Follows from *The Fuel-Fitters chartered*, 29 an Lùnastal, DE 14; ← Follows from *Peigi nic Ascaill reads Riagbailt na Cairte*, 27 an t-Samhain, DE 14.

75. ← Follows from *The Fuel-Fitters chartered*, 29 an Lùnastal, DE 14; ← Follows from *Twelve masters sworn to Comann nan Goibhnean-ceangail*, 28 an t-Samhain, DE 14.

76. ← Follows from *Tuathaich fitters go north*, 27 an t-Sultain, DE 14; ← Follows from *Peigi nic Ascaill pays Joe Ashby a month over*, 3 an Dùbhlachd, DE 14.

77. the Guild of Fuel-Fitters; lit. 'the fellowship of the fitters'

78. ← Follows from *Tuathaich fitters go north*, 27 an t-Sultain, DE 14; ← Follows from *Joe Ashby fits Jean Fisher's boat*, 4 an Dùbhlachd, DE 14.

79. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

80. ← Follows from *The Moot on the new fuel*, 24 an t-Samhain, DE 14; ← Follows from *The guild's letter pinned above Joe's bench*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, DE 14.

81. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

- 22 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 14** — *The guild's banner blessed at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). At the chartering of Comann nan Goibhnean-ceangail⁸³ in the works' long shed a custodian of Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail⁸⁴ blesses the guild's new banner, a black swan on grey, and twelve masters are sworn.⁸⁵
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 14** — *Abel Fowler mends a threshing engine at Muileann bheag* (Muileann bheag). One of the fitters let go from the southern works under Riaghailt na Cairte⁸⁶ is taken on at Muileann bheag, on the word of the lighthouse keeper, to mend a threshing engine none of the district's smiths will touch.⁸⁷
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 14** — *Cnoc bhàn's boats keep the pirate watch* (Cnoc bhàn). In the year the raiders are taken off Ros dhomhain, the boats of Cnoc bhàn keep watch in turns on the pirate waters and twice put out to warn the fishing fleet in from the north-east.⁸⁸
- 8 AM MÀRT, DE 15** — *The Tuathaich depots* (Ceann mhòr). Dubhan depots are opened at Caol mhòr, Doire ghlas and Ceann mhòr, supplied by sea. Martha Greaves writes in the Moot's minute that the north now buys its fire from the south, and does not say whether this is good.
- 5 AN CÈITEAN, DE 15** — *The fourth currency reform*. For the first time the coin of the Rìoghachd is pegged to the making of dubhan and not to the stores of coal. So the kingdom owns, quietly, which of the two now runs it.
- 5 AN CÈITEAN, DE 15** — *The Dubhan Era proclaimed* (Cathair dhearg). At the same sitting the council proclaims that the Age of the Kingdom ended with the first working dubhan, and that the kingdom's years are counted anew from that day. The year is entered as the fifteenth of the Dubhan Era. Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh re-heads fourteen years of her chronicle, and writes at the foot of the page that never before has she had to move a year she was living in.
- 3 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 15** — *The plain seal* (Cathair dhearg). The mint at Cathair dhearg ceases to press coal ink into the seal of the coinage. The new seal is plain. Fearchar Bonn's first dies are given to the library and kept in the case beside the oath-stone of the Guild of Hewers.

82. ← Follows from *The Moot on the new fuel*, 24 an t-Samhain, DE 14; ← Follows from *Ruth Calder speaks and the five towns walk out*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 14.

83. the Guild of Fuel-Fitters; lit. 'the fellowship of the fitters'

84. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

85. ← Follows from *The Fuel-Fitters chartered*, 29 an Lùnastal, DE 14; ← Follows from *Martha Greaves keeps the granaries open to all five towns*, 16 an Dùbhlachd, DE 14.

86. the charter rule that kept the Fuel-Fitters' rolls to Dia-thìrich

87. ← Follows from *Tuathaich fitters go north*, 27 an t-Sultain, DE 14; ← Follows from *The guild's banner blessed at Seann Skell*, 22 an Dùbhlachd, DE 14.

88. ← Follows from *Raiders taken to Ros dhomhain*, 2 an t-Iuchar, DE 14; ← Follows from *Abel Fowler mends a threshing engine at Muileann bheag*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, DE 14.

- 31 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 15** — *The Rite's protest on the seal* (Seann Skell). The high custodian at Seann Skell protests to the council that the plain seal is a sign the kingdom no longer holds the vein sacred. The council answers that the kingdom never said it did. Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh copies both letters into the chronicle.
- 7 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 15** — *The depots marked on an Leabharlann⁸⁹'s map* (Muileann chaol). Raghnaill mac Mhuirich asks that the three new depots be marked on the front room's map, close together on the coast, and tells Sileas nic Rath he expects the map will want marking again before the year is out, though he cannot say why he thinks it.⁹⁰
- 19 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 15** — *An t-Ionmbas⁹¹'s clerk's private letter* (Cathair dhearg). A clerk of An t-Ionmbas who owes Raghnaill mac Mhuirich a kindness sends an Leabharlann⁹² a private account of the council's sitting of 5 an Cèitean ahead of the formal minute, noting that the two resolutions passed by a show of hands with no count taken, against the council's custom in so weighty a matter.⁹³
- 29 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 15** — *The torn proclamation from the market post* (Cathair dhearg). A carrier tears the printed proclamation from a post at Cathair dhearg and brings it up to an Leabharlann⁹⁴ folded inside his own almanac, thinking Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh should see the notice as the market crowd had seen it, creased and a little torn at one corner.⁹⁵
- 10 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 15** — *Beathag begins the re-heading* (Muileann chaol). The evening the proclamation reaches her, Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh sits alone at the long table with her fourteen ledgers and begins to set the new heading, Linn an Dubhain⁹⁶ and its year, beside the old heading of each, in a smaller hand, with a line drawn between them, leaving the old headings standing.⁹⁷
- 1 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 15** — *Beathag writes the line about moving a year* (Muileann chaol). Finishing the re-heading before dawn, Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh writes at the foot of the fifteenth year's page, in a smaller hand than her working hand, that never before has she had to move a year she was living in, and lets it stand uncorrected in the fair copy sent up to the council.⁹⁸

89. the Library at Muileann chaol

90. ← Follows from *The Tuathaich depots*, 8 am Màrt, DE 15.

91. the Treasury

92. the Library at Muileann chaol

93. → Leads to *The fourth currency reform*, 5 an Cèitean, DE 15; → Leads to *The Dubhan Era proclaimed*, 5 an Cèitean, DE 15; ← Follows from *The depots marked on an Leabharlann's map*, 7 an Lùnastal, DE 15.

94. the Library at Muileann chaol

95. ← Follows from *The Dubhan Era proclaimed*, 5 an Cèitean, DE 15; ← Follows from *An t-Ionmbas's clerk's private letter*, 19 an Lùnastal, DE 15.

96. the Dubhan Era (DE); lit. 'the era of Dubhan'

97. ← Follows from *The Dubhan Era proclaimed*, 5 an Cèitean, DE 15; ← Follows from *The torn proclamation from the market post*, 29 an Lùnastal, DE 15.

- 13 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 15** — *Gille-Easbaig Bàn's letter on the new dies* (Cathair dhearg). Gille-Easbaig Bàn writes to an Leabharlann⁹⁹ that the mint has cut a plain seal for the coinage, the coal ink pressed into no die of it, and owns he does not know whether he is glad or sorry to be done with grinding an ink that had cost, that spring, more than the seal's own worth in coin.¹⁰⁰
- 23 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 15** — *The dies set beside the oath-stone* (Muileann chaol). Ragnall mac Mhuirich sets Fearchar Bonn's worn dies in the glass case beside Clach-mhionnan nan Gualadairean¹⁰¹, and remarks to Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh that everything lately brought into the case has just stopped being used.¹⁰²
- 25 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 15** — *Ragnall's three dots on an Leabharlann's map* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹⁰⁴). The keeper of an Leabharlann has the chronicler's clerk mark the three new dubhan depots of the north on the old map in the front room, three dots close together on the coast.¹⁰⁵
- 7 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 15** — *The proclamation read at the Cuan shean harbour* (Cuan shean). At the harbour of Cuan shean the maor's crier reads the proclamation of Linn an Dubhain¹⁰⁶ from the harbour steps to the fishing crews, who ask whether it changes the day of the fish-market. It does not.¹⁰⁷
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 15** — *A pump on the quays of Baile ghorm* (Baile ghorm). The third anchorage of the kingdom, at Baile ghorm, sets a dubhan pump on its wolf-post quays for the fishing boats that have taken engines, the first on that coast.¹⁰⁸
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 15** — *Doire shean bears the new count at market* (Doire shean). At Doire shean the new count of the years is read out at the Tuesday market; the market-clerk writes the next week's date both ways in his book and goes on doing so for a year.¹⁰⁹

98. ← Follows from *The Dubhan Era proclaimed*, 5 an Cèitean, DE 15; ← Follows from *Beathag begins the re-beading*, 10 an t-Sultain, DE 15.

99. the Library at Muileann chaol

100. → Leads to *The plain seal*, 3 an t-Ògmhios, DE 15; ← Follows from *Beathag writes the line about moving a year*, 1 an Dàmhair, DE 15.

101. the oath-stone of coal of the Guild of Hewers

102. ← Follows from *The plain seal*, 3 an t-Ògmhios, DE 15; ← Follows from *Gille-Easbaig Bàn's letter on the new dies*, 13 an Dàmhair, DE 15.

103. the Library at Muileann chaol

104. the Library at Muileann chaol

105. ← Follows from *The Tuathaich depots*, 8 am Màrt, DE 15; ← Follows from *The dies set beside the oath-stone*, 23 an Dàmhair, DE 15.

106. the Dubhan Era (DE); lit. 'the era of Dubhan'

107. ← Follows from *The Dubhan Era proclaimed*, 5 an Cèitean, DE 15; ← Follows from *Ragnall's three dots on an Leabharlann's map*, 25 an t-Samhain, DE 15.

108. ← Follows from *The fleet's first dubhan bulls*, 15 an t-Sultain, DE 13; ← Follows from *The proclamation read at the Cuan shean harbour*, 7 an Dùbhlachd, DE 15.

109. ← Follows from *The Dubhan Era proclaimed*, 5 an Cèitean, DE 15; ← Follows from *A pump on the quays of Baile ghorm*, 17 an Dùbhlachd, DE 15.

THE YEARS DE 16 – 20

- 27 AM MÀRT, DE 16** — *The western pit towns meet* (Muileann àrsaidh). Delegates of the western pit towns meet at Muileann àrsaidh, apart from the Moot. They agree to go on working their seams and to sell their coal to any household in the north that will buy it.
- 6 AN GIBLEAN, DE 16** — *Àth naomh joins the pit towns* (Àth naomh). Àth naomh, a Tuathaich town of the western hills with only a few old shafts, joins the pit towns' agreement. Its delegates say the town would sooner be cold with its neighbours than warm alone.
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, DE 16** — *The northern towns hold out*. A number of northern towns will not go over to the new fuel. They work the last good coal seams sooner than trade their freedom for need of one man's fuel.
- 24 AN CÈITEAN, DE 16** — *The holdout towns* (Àth leathan). Chief among the towns that refuse are five of the western hills: Àth leathan, Muileann àrsaidh, Cnoc thais, Àth naomh and Tobar dhearg. Their spokeswoman is Ruth Calder, a pit captain's daughter of Àth leathan. The Moot at Caol mhòr neither joins them nor condemns them.
- 4 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 16** — *Tom Varley's pits* (Cnoc thais). At Cnoc thais the pit captain Tom Varley opens again two shafts that have lain abandoned since the humans' time. The coal is poor. It is theirs, and it warms the town.
- 5 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 16** — *Calder of Àth leathan dies* (Àth leathan). Calder, pit captain of Àth leathan for twenty years, dies of the black cough a little before first light on the ninth of an Gearran, in the stone house above the pit-head that was his father's before him. The village buries him two days after, in the plot behind the chapel.¹
- 12 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 16** — *The hewers of Àth leathan keep Ruth Calder* (Àth leathan). At the pit-head, with no guild left to make it formal, the hewers of Àth leathan keep Ruth Calder, who had kept her father's tally-books five years and more, in her father's place. Angus Rennie speaks for her; nobody speaks against it. She is given her father's lamp.²
- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 16** — *The western pit towns gather at Sarah Dunmore's kitchen* (Muileann àrsaidh). In the first week of am Màrt, delegates of Muileann àrsaidh, Cnoc thais, Tobar dhearg and Àth leathan meet in the kitchen of Sarah Dunmore, a widow of Muileann àrsaidh, before the meeting proper begins. Ruth Calder, new to the captaincy, is asked to set the towns' terms down in writing.³
- 15 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 16** — *The talk moves to the pit-shed* (Muileann àrsaidh). More delegates and hewers come than Sarah Dunmore's table will seat, and the meeting moves to the pit-shed above Muileann àrsaidh, where near forty crowd the cleared benches to hear the towns' terms argued and set down.⁴

1. → Leads to *The holdout towns*, 24 an Cèitean, DE 16.

2. → Leads to *The holdout towns*, 24 an Cèitean, DE 16; ← Follows from *Calder of Àth leathan dies*, 5 an t-Samhain, DE 16.

3. ○ Same place *The western pit towns meet*, 27 am Màrt, DE 16; ← Follows from *The hewers of Àth leathan keep Ruth Calder*, 12 an t-Samhain, DE 16.

- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 16** — *Còrdadh Muileann àrsaidh*⁵ signed (Muileann àrsaidh). Muileann àrsaidh, Cnoc thais, Tobar dhearg and Àth leathan sign, in the pit-shed above Muileann àrsaidh, an agreement drafted by Ruth Calder: to go on working their seams and sell their coal to any household of the north that comes freely to buy it, and to stand by each other in the keeping of it.⁶
- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 16** — *First coal burned from the reopened shafts* (Cnoc thais). The first cartload from Cnoc thais's reopened shafts, thin and smoky, is set that same week on a dozen hearths in the town, in houses that had been buying their fire in from Muileann àrsaidh. Tom Varley writes to Ruth Calder that the coal is poor, and that it is theirs.⁷
- 25 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 16** — *Ruth Calder begins the letters* (Àth leathan). At Fraser's asking, Ruth Calder sits down at her own table at Àth leathan in an Dùbhlachd to write the first of what will be many letters, laying out the five towns' case to northern households still undecided about their fire, plainly, as the agreement itself was written.⁸
- 27 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 16** — *Calder's lamp given to his daughter* (Àth leathan). At the pit-head of Àth leathan on the evening of her father's burial a hewer hands Ruth Calder, without a word, the dented brass lamp that had been Calder's own since his father died.⁹
- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 16** — *Dodds argues for naming Riaghailt na Cairte*¹⁰ (Muileann àrsaidh). In the pit-shed at Muileann àrsaidh a hewer named Dodds wants the agreement to name Comann nan Goibhnean-ceangail¹¹ and Riaghailt na Cairte; Ruth Calder answers that a grievance is a thing folk argue with, and the line is left out. Dodds signs all the same.¹²
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 16** — *Ferguson of Àth naomh signs with his own hand* (Àth naomh). The elder delegate of Àth naomh, who has walked the hill path with a stick in either hand, writes his own name on the agreement of the western pit towns, and his companion after him.¹³

4. ○ Same place *The western pit towns meet*, 27 am Màrt, DE 16; ← Follows from *The western pit towns gather at Sarah Dunmore's kitchen*, 14 an t-Samhain, DE 16.

5. the western pit towns' agreement

6. ← Follows from *The western pit towns meet*, 27 am Màrt, DE 16; ← Follows from *The talk moves to the pit-shed*, 15 an t-Samhain, DE 16.

7. ← Follows from *Tom Varley's pits*, 4 an t-Samhain, DE 16; ← Follows from *Còrdadh Muileann àrsaidh signed*, 16 an t-Samhain, DE 16.

8. ← Follows from *The holdout towns*, 24 an Cèitean, DE 16; ← Follows from *First coal burned from the reopened shafts*, 23 an t-Samhain, DE 16.

9. ← Follows from *Ruth Calder begins the letters*, 25 an t-Samhain, DE 16.

10. the charter rule that kept the Fuel-Fitters' rolls to Dia-thirich

11. the Guild of Fuel-Fitters; lit. 'the fellowship of the fitters'

12. ← Follows from *The western pit towns meet*, 27 am Màrt, DE 16; ← Follows from *Calder's lamp given to his daughter*, 27 an t-Samhain, DE 16.

13. ← Follows from *Àth naomh joins the pit towns*, 6 an Giblean, DE 16; ← Follows from *Dodds argues for naming Riaghailt na Cairte*, 19 an Dùbhlachd, DE 16.

- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 16** — *An old pick-head found in Tom Varley's shafts* (Cnoc thais). Reopening the old shafts at Cnoc thais, Tom Varley's hewers find a broken pick-head of a make none of them knows, and in the second shaft rotted shoring still holding the roof, which they leave alone.¹⁴
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 16** — *The elders of Cnoc ghorm hear of the agreement* (Cnoc ghorm). Word of the pit towns' agreement at Muileann àrsaidh reaches the Tuathaich elders at Cnoc ghorm by a carrier; they send nothing west and nothing to Tional nan Tuathach¹⁵, and enter the news in their own book.¹⁶
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 17** — *Tobar dhearg of the hills* (Tobar dhearg). Tobar dhearg in the western hills, least of the holdout towns, has one pit and forty hewers. It sends its coal to Cathair gheal on the coast and has fish in return.
- 7 AN GEARRAN, DE 17** — *Ellen Marsh's books* (Doire ghlas). Ellen Marsh, a schoolteacher of Doire ghlas, finishes her gathering of Tuathaich accounts of the Severance and the settlement, taken down over many years from the old folk of the north. It fills eleven books. It is her request that goes to the library.
- 15 AN GEARRAN, DE 17** — *The library's Tuathaich wing proposed* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹⁷). A request is laid before Leabharlann Muileann chaol that the Tuathaich tellings be kept beside the Dia-thìrich record. It is laid on the table and not refused, and there it lies to this day.
- 12 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 17** — *The keeper's answer* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹⁸). Ragnall mac Mhuirich answers Ellen Marsh that the request awaits the council's view on the standing of spoken witness. The council has given none.
- 20 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 17** — *Ellen Marsh's reply* (Doire ghlas). Ellen Marsh writes back to the keeper that spoken witness was good enough for the census clerks when they took the Moot's figures. Her letter is filed with the request.
- 25 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 17** — *The coal-for-fish cart of Tobar dhearg* (Tobar dhearg). Twice a month a cart goes down from Tobar dhearg of the hills to the walled coast town of Cathair gheal, laden with the poor coal of its one pit, and comes back laden with fish salted in barrels. Neither town can say which first proposed the trade.¹⁹
- 28 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 17** — *Ellen Marsh comes to Cathair gheal* (Cathair gheal). Ellen Marsh rides the fish cart down to Cathair gheal in the raw end of an Gearran to sit again with Annie Drew, a widow of ninety-three and the last soul in the town old enough to remember the parting itself.²⁰

14. ← Follows from *Tom Varley's pits*, 4 an t-Samhain, DE 16; ← Follows from *Ferguson of Àth naomh signs with his own hand*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 16.

15. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

16. ← Follows from *The western pit towns meet*, 27 am Màrt, DE 16; ← Follows from *An old pick-head found in Tom Varley's shafts*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, DE 16.

17. the Library at Muileann chaol

18. the Library at Muileann chaol

19. ← Follows from *Tobar dhearg of the hills*, 30 am Faoilleach, DE 17.

- 3 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 17** — *Annie Drew's last telling* (Cathair gheal). Annie Drew gives Ellen Marsh the rest of her memory of An Dealachadh²¹: the smoke of the fires left burning, the new-set boundary stones, and a soldier who gave her mother bread and would not meet her eye. She says she has kept her word before dying, and bids Ellen keep her own.²²
- 17 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 17** — *The last of the old tellers* (Cathair gheal). Annie Drew tells Ellen Marsh that no one older than herself remains along the coast this side of Muileann àrsaidh, where the one other woman of her years has lost her memory to a fever. Ellen does not deny it.²³
- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 17** — *The eleventh book begun* (Doire ghlas). Ellen Marsh had begun her gathering by accident, eleven winters before, when an old man of the parish stopped her in the lane to correct a date in An Dealachadh²⁴ she had taught the children wrong. She went home and wrote down what he told her before she forgot it, and never found a reason to stop.²⁵
- 23 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 17** — *The request read before the keepers* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol²⁶). In the spring Ellen Marsh's request and An t-Aon Leabhar Deug²⁷ that came with it are read entire before the keepers of Leabharlann Muileann chaol and set upon the table of the council's business, where they are not refused.²⁸
- I AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 17** — *The letter parsed in the schoolroom* (Doire ghlas). Ellen Marsh reads the keeper's letter entire to her class at the start of an t-Sultain and has the children parse its sentences clause by clause. A girl of the town says that 'not refused' means no, but that no answer can be given to 'not yet'.²⁹
- 4 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 17** — *Ellen Marsh's rule for two witnesses* (Doire ghlas). In the front of the first of her eleven books Ellen Marsh writes that where two witnesses differ she has set down both and let the reader judge, as a court would.³⁰

20. ← Follows from *Ellen Marsh's books*, 7 an Gearran, DE 17; ← Follows from *The coal-for-fish cart of Tobar dhearg*, 25 an Lùnastal, DE 17.

21. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

22. ← Follows from *Ellen Marsh's books*, 7 an Gearran, DE 17; ← Follows from *Ellen Marsh comes to Cathair gheal*, 28 an Lùnastal, DE 17.

23. ← Follows from *Ellen Marsh's books*, 7 an Gearran, DE 17; ← Follows from *Annie Drew's last telling*, 3 an t-Sultain, DE 17.

24. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

25. ← Follows from *Ellen Marsh's books*, 7 an Gearran, DE 17; ← Follows from *The last of the old tellers*, 17 an Dàmhair, DE 17.

26. the Library at Muileann chaol

27. the eleven books of Tuathaich accounts gathered by Ellen Marsh over eleven years and offered to the Library

28. ← Follows from *The library's Tuathaich wing proposed*, 15 an Gearran, DE 17; ← Follows from *The eleventh book begun*, 20 an Dàmhair, DE 17.

29. ← Follows from *The keeper's answer*, 12 an Lùnastal, DE 17; ← Follows from *The request read before the keepers*, 23 an Dàmhair, DE 17.

- 7 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 17** — *Raghnall's line in each book's flyleaf* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³¹). The keeper of an Leabharlann³² writes the same few words of receipt on the flyleaf of each of Ellen Marsh's An t-Aon Leabhar Deug³³ on the day it is carried in, and lays the request on the table.³⁴
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 17** — *Agnes Pike gives Ellen Marsh the school's back room* (Doire ghlas). The mistress of the school at Doire ghlas gives Ellen Marsh its back room to keep the gathering in, with a table, a press and a stove that draws badly.³⁵
- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 17** — *Ceann leathan's gate paid in the new coin* (Ceann leathan). The fair-wardens of Còmhrag Ceann leathan³⁶ at Ceann leathan take the gate-price for the first time wholly in coin of the plain seal, the old coal-inked coin having gone out of the purses of the crowd.³⁷
- 21 AN GEARRAN, DE 18** — *The coal price in the north* (Doire ghlas). The holdout pits sell their coal to Tuathaich households across the north for less than the price of dubhan. The Moot's own wool mills at Doire ghlas buy it. For the first time since the Severance the Board's takings from the north fall.
- 22 AM MÀRT, DE 18** — *The Board's northern revenue* (Cathair mhòr). The Mine Board's accounts show its northern takings down by a quarter. Its report to the council names the western pits as the cause and the Leòid ruling as the remedy.
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 18** — *The seams declared Crown property* (Seann Bhral). Under the Leòid ruling the Mine Board declares the western seams the Crown's, holding that the right to work them lapsed when the holders ceased to pay the fifth. The holders say they ceased to pay when the Board ceased to carry the coal. The pits are ordered shut.
- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 18** — *Enforcers posted to the west* (Seann Skell). A company of the Board's enforcers is posted at Seann Skell in the west to shut the pits. Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh notes that it is the first armed company the kingdom has sent toward the north since the Severance.

30. ← Follows from *Ellen Marsh's books*, 7 an Gearran, DE 17; ← Follows from *The letter parsed in the school-room*, 1 an t-Samhain, DE 17.

31. the Library at Muileann chaol

32. the Library at Muileann chaol

33. the eleven books of Tuathaich accounts gathered by Ellen Marsh over eleven years and offered to the Library

34. ← Follows from *The library's Tuathaich wing proposed*, 15 an Gearran, DE 17; ← Follows from *Ellen Marsh's rule for two witnesses*, 4 an t-Samhain, DE 17.

35. ← Follows from *Ellen Marsh's books*, 7 an Gearran, DE 17; ← Follows from *Raghnall's line in each book's flyleaf*, 7 an t-Samhain, DE 17.

36. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

37. ← Follows from *The plain seal*, 3 an t-Ògmhios, DE 15; ← Follows from *Agnes Pike gives Ellen Marsh the school's back room*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 17.

22 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 18 — *A brewer of Baile ìseal writes to Comhairle nam Mèinnean*³⁸ *un-asked* (Baile ìseal). A brewer of Baile ìseal writes to Comhairle nam Mèinnean that he sees no shame in buying whichever coal comes cheapest, and will take no lecture from a Board that has never once carried coal north of the boundary stones for a Tuathach hearth to burn. The letter is filed and not answered.³⁹

24 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 18 — *Fearghas mac Aonghais calls for the northern returns* (Cathair mhòr). The master of Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁴⁰ calls for the northern returns drawn town by town, a thing he has not asked of his clerk in four years. Seumas mac Eachainn spends the better part of a day setting the wool mills' new contract against the year before and finds no part of the fall lying anywhere but in the five holdout towns' own trade.⁴¹

31 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 18 — *Breith Leòid*⁴² *read again at Cathair mhòr* (Cathair mhòr). Seumas mac Eachainn carries Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁴³'s own copy of Breith Leòid to the master's room and hears it read through: that a right to work a seam fails with the fifth, whatever the reason the fifth stopped coming in. Fearghas mac Aonghais finds in it no clause that asks whether Comhairle nam Mèinnean's own reason for ceasing to carry the coal was a fair one.⁴⁴

4 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 18 — *Seumas mac Eachainn's report leaves out the carrying* (Cathair mhòr). Writing the master's report by lamplight, Seumas mac Eachainn sets down every figure he has checked twice and is true, and leaves out, because the master did not ask for it, that Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁴⁵ stopped carrying the western pits' coal four years before the pits stopped paying the fifth for it.⁴⁶

II AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 18 — *The shutting order carried north to the maor* (Seann Skell). Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁴⁷'s courier brings the sealed order to the maor of the western Seann Skell, who reads it standing at his own door and sends for the town's clerk as a second witness before the ink is a day old, judging rightly that the western towns will not obey a paper.⁴⁸

38. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

39. ← Follows from *The coal price in the north*, 21 an Gearran, DE 18.

40. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

41. → Leads to *The Board's northern revenue*, 22 am Màrt, DE 18; ← Follows from *A brewer of Baile ìseal writes to Comhairle nam Mèinnean unasked*, 22 an Dàmhair, DE 18.

42. the Leòid ruling

43. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

44. → Leads to *The Board's northern revenue*, 22 am Màrt, DE 18; → Leads to *The seams declared Crown property*, 20 an Giblean, DE 18; ← Follows from *Fearghas mac Aonghais calls for the northern returns*, 24 an Dàmhair, DE 18.

45. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

46. → Leads to *The Board's northern revenue*, 22 am Màrt, DE 18; ← Follows from *Breith Leòid read again at Cathair mhòr*, 31 an Dàmhair, DE 18.

47. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

- 15 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 18** — *The five towns' unsigned answer* (Muileann àrsaidh). Word of the shutting order passes hand to hand among Muileann àrsaidh, Cnoc thais and Àth leathan, and an answer goes back to no one in particular: that the pits stopped paying the fifth the day Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁴⁹ stopped carrying their coal, and will pay it again the day the carrying starts. It never reaches Comhairle nam Mèinnean as a formal reply.⁵⁰
- 25 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 18** — *The five towns meet at Muileann àrsaidh again* (Muileann àrsaidh). Ruth Calder reads Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁵¹'s order aloud in the pit-shed at Muileann àrsaidh, twice through. Tom Varley wants it answered clause for clause; Ruth holds that the only answer that matters is whether coal comes up the morning after the order's date. It does, and the towns vote to go on as before.⁵²
- 26 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 18** — *Somhairle mac Lachlainn given the western command* (Cathair mhòr). Called before Fearghas mac Aonghais and a councillor of the Rìoghachd, Somhairle mac Lachlainn is given command of forty of Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁵³'s enforcers, to hold the shutting order at the five pit-heads and to close no house, road or town beyond them. He is told plainly that his business is to hold the order, not to fight a war nobody has declared.⁵⁴
- 4 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 18** — *Somhairle mac Lachlainn rides the road ahead of his company* (Seann Skell). Two days ahead of his forty men, Somhairle mac Lachlainn rides alone across the boundary stones to see the ground he must hold, and lodges a night short of the western Seann Skell turning over, for the first time in eighteen years of Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁵⁵'s service, whether a smuggler's quay and a country under a shutting order are the same kind of work.⁵⁶
- 7 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 18** — *Tom Varley gives the posted men their tea* (Cnoc thais). Two of Somhairle's men are sent to stand at the pit-head of Cnoc thais with the shutting order nailed to the winding-gear. Tom Varley reads it without a word, tells them they are welcome to stand there as long as they like, and sees them given tea at midday like anyone else standing about in the wet. The coal comes up all the same.⁵⁷

48. ← Follows from *The seams declared Crown property*, 20 an Giblean, DE 18; ← Follows from *Seumas mac Eachainn's report leaves out the carrying*, 4 an t-Samhain, DE 18.

49. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

50. ← Follows from *The seams declared Crown property*, 20 an Giblean, DE 18; ← Follows from *The shutting order carried north to the maor*, 11 an t-Samhain, DE 18.

51. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

52. ← Follows from *The seams declared Crown property*, 20 an Giblean, DE 18; → Leads to *Enforcers posted to the west*, 16 an Dàmhair, DE 18; ← Follows from *The five towns' unsigned answer*, 15 an t-Samhain, DE 18.

53. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

54. → Leads to *Enforcers posted to the west*, 16 an Dàmhair, DE 18; ← Follows from *The five towns meet at Muileann àrsaidh again*, 25 an t-Samhain, DE 18.

55. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

56. → Leads to *Enforcers posted to the west*, 16 an Dàmhair, DE 18; ← Follows from *Somhairle mac Lachlainn given the western command*, 26 an t-Samhain, DE 18.

57. ← Follows from *Enforcers posted to the west*, 16 an Dàmhair, DE 18; ← Follows from *Somhairle mac Lachlainn rides the road ahead of his company*, 4 an Dùbhlachd, DE 18.

- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 18** — *The margins of Breith Leòid*⁵⁸ (Cathair mhòr). Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁵⁹'s press copy of Breith Leòid carries in its margins the circuit rulings that settled it: that a holder's right runs with An Crùn⁶⁰'s fifth, and that nothing binds Comhairle nam Mèinnean to carry any holder's coal.⁶¹
- 18 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 18** — *Forty men chosen for the western company* (Cathair mhòr). Somhairle mac Lachlainn is given forty of Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁶²'s enforcers for the western Seann Skell and chooses men who have served under him before.⁶³
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 18** — *The order nailed to the winding-gear* (Cnoc thais). The western company posts two men at each pit-head of the five towns with Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁶⁴'s order nailed to the winding-gear, to report twice weekly whether coal comes up. It comes up.⁶⁵
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 18** — *The granary factors of Achadh mhòr* (Achadh mhòr). The granary factors of Achadh mhòr sell a winter's oats to the pit towns of the western hills through Tional nan Tuathach⁶⁶'s granaries, and write to Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁶⁷ that they know of no rule against it.⁶⁸
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 18** — *The Bride house of Caol ruadh burns its last stored coal* (Caol ruadh). The house of Brìde at Caol ruadh burns the last of the altar coal it stored in the undercroft, and its custodians write to the Àrd-choimheadaiche⁶⁹ asking where the next is to come from.⁷⁰
- 23 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 19** — *The enforcers' depot* (Seann Skell). The enforcers at Seann Skell in the west build a dubhan depot for their lorries at the edge of the town. The town's house of Manannan will not bless it, and the high custodian of the Rite sends a priest to bless it instead.
- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 19** — *The Moot's warning* (Caol mhòr). Martha Greaves writes to the council from Caol mhòr that the western towns will not shut their pits for a letter, and asks a year's delay while the Moot treats with them. The letter is received and filed.

58. the Leòid ruling

59. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

60. the Crown

61. ← Follows from *The seams declared Crown property*, 20 an Giblean, DE 18; → Leads to *The Leòid ruling* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 8; ← Follows from *Tòm Varley gives the posted men their tea*, 7 an Dùbhlachd, DE 18.

62. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

63. ← Follows from *Enforcers posted to the west*, 16 an Dàmhair, DE 18; ← Follows from *The margins of Breith Leòid*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, DE 18.

64. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

65. ← Follows from *Enforcers posted to the west*, 16 an Dàmhair, DE 18; ← Follows from *Forty men chosen for the western company*, 18 an Dùbhlachd, DE 18.

66. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

67. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

68. ← Follows from *The Board's northern revenue*, 22 am Màrt, DE 18; ← Follows from *The order nailed to the winding-gear*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, DE 18.

69. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

70. ← Follows from *The granary factors of Achadh mhòr*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, DE 18.

- 29 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 19** — *First skirmishes*. Small fights begin between the state's enforcers and the Tuathaich who hold to their coal. None is written down, and none is great enough to name; together they lead straight into open war.
- 28 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 19** — *The chronicler asks* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁷¹). At the foot of the year Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh writes that fighting is reported in the west, that the Board's reports of it are not given to the chronicler, and that she has asked for them. They were not given.
- 26 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 19** — *The pit-heads walled* (Muileann àrsaidh). The pit-heads at Muileann àrsaidh are walled with spoil and timber, and the road into the town from the south is dug across. The Board's enforcers at Seann Skell report the town shut against them.
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *Ruth Calder's letter* (Àth leathan). Ruth Calder writes to the council for the western towns. She offers to pay the Crown's fifth in coal if the Board will carry it and let the pits work until the seams are spent. The letter came to the library. No answer to it did.
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *The depot's ground broken at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). The enforcers break ground for a dubhan depot above the river at Seann Skell in the west, a tank and a roofed shed for the barrels the boats will bring up from the south. Somhairle mac Lachlainn lays it out himself from Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁷²'s plan.⁷³
- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *Somhairle's first report from Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). Somhairle mac Lachlainn writes his first report from the western Seann Skell: the depot's ground broken, the quay's second berth cleared, nothing at Muileann àrsaidh worth Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁷⁴'s attention. He believes every word of it.⁷⁵
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *The house of Òrd Mhanannain⁷⁶ refuses the blessing* (Seann Skell). Asked to bless the depot's finished roof before the masons work under it, the house of Òrd Mhanannain at Seann Skell in the west answers in three lines that it will not bless what is built for Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁷⁷'s enforcers.⁷⁸
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *Somhairle writes to the Àrd-choimbeadaiche⁷⁹* (Seann Skell). Somhairle mac Lachlainn writes to Alasdair mac Ìomhair, high custodian of the Rite at the southern Seann Skell, setting down the priest's refusal in his own words and asking whether some other house of the old faith will bless the depot's roof.⁸⁰

71. the Library at Muileann chaol

72. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

73. ← Follows from *The enforcers' depot*, 23 am Faoilleach, DE 19.

74. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

75. ← Follows from *The enforcers' depot*, 23 am Faoilleach, DE 19; ← Follows from *The depot's ground broken at Seann Skell*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

76. the order of Manannan

77. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

78. ← Follows from *The enforcers' depot*, 23 am Faoilleach, DE 19; ← Follows from *Somhairle's first report from Seann Skell*, 27 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

79. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *A custodian of Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail*⁸¹ rides north (Seann Skell). Alasdair mac Ìomhair sends a young custodian of the southern house, Pàdraig, two days' ride north to bless the enforcers' depot at Seann Skell in the west, since the house of Òrd Mhanannain⁸² there will not come.⁸³
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *The depot's roof blessed by a stranger's hand* (Seann Skell). The young custodian Pàdraig blesses the depot's roof at evening before Somhairle mac Lachlainn and a handful of enforcers; the town watches from a distance and gives the building a name of its own that Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁸⁴ never records.⁸⁵
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *The letter received and filed* (Cathair mhòr). The council's clerk enters Martha Greaves's letter as received. No answer is sent; it is set into the press among that quarter's correspondence under the label 'the Moot, western towns'.⁸⁶
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *A lorry turned back on the Muileann àrsaidh road* (Muileann àrsaidh). An enforcers' lorry carrying timber up the river road toward Muileann àrsaidh meets stones and rolled boulders below the town and turns back, a wheel stove and a corporal cut over the eye. Neither telling of it gives a name.⁸⁷
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *Further meetings on the northern roads* (Muileann àrsaidh). A second meeting on the same road and a third above Àth leathan follow before an t-Sultain is out, none counted, none named, while the spoil-and-timber wall at Muileann àrsaidh grows a little higher each week.⁸⁸
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *Somhairle's three drafts* (Seann Skell). Writing up the stones on the Muileann àrsaidh road, Somhairle mac Lachlainn drafts the report three times, each shorter than the last, and sends the one that says least of what his corporal told him.⁸⁹

80. ← Follows from *The enforcers' depot*, 23 am Faoilleach, DE 19; ← Follows from *The house of Òrd Mhanannain refuses the blessing*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

81. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

82. the order of Manannan

83. ← Follows from *The enforcers' depot*, 23 am Faoilleach, DE 19; ← Follows from *Somhairle writes to the Àrd-choimbeadaiche*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

84. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

85. ← Follows from *The enforcers' depot*, 23 am Faoilleach, DE 19; ← Follows from *A custodian of Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail rides north*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *The letter received and filed*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

86. ← Follows from *The Moot's warning*, 31 an Lùnastal, DE 19; ← Follows from *The depot's roof blessed by a stranger's hand*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *A lorry turned back on the Muileann àrsaidh road*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

87. ← Follows from *First skirmishes*, 29 an t-Sultain, DE 19; ← Follows from *The letter received and filed*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *Further meetings on the northern roads*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

88. ← Follows from *First skirmishes*, 29 an t-Sultain, DE 19; ← Follows from *A lorry turned back on the Muileann àrsaidh road*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *Somhairle's three drafts*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

89. ← Follows from *The chronicler asks*, 28 an Dàmhair, DE 19; ← Follows from *Further meetings on the northern roads*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *Beathag's letter to Comhairle nam Mèinnean*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19 — *Beathag's letter to Comhairle nam Mèinnean*⁹⁰ (Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁹¹). At the foot of the year Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh writes to Comhairle nam Mèinnean asking its returns of the incidents on the northern roads that autumn, so an Leabharlann⁹²'s record may be kept as fully as any other.⁹³

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19 — *Sileas names the silence* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁹⁴). As the weeks pass with no return from Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁹⁵, Sileas nic Rath says in an Leabharlann⁹⁶'s upper room that the silence does not feel like an office too busy to answer, and is told she will learn in time the difference between unanswered and refused.⁹⁷

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19 — *Comhairle nam Mèinnean*⁹⁸'s letter forwarded without comment (Cathair mhòr). Comhairle nam Mèinnean's clerk at Cathair mhòr forwards Somhairle mac Lachlainn a copy of the chronicler's letter asking for Comhairle nam Mèinnean's returns, without comment and without instruction, and no order follows changing what he is to report.⁹⁹

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19 — *The priest of Manannan answers the captain* (Seann Skell). At the gate of the house of Manannan above the western Seann Skell a young priest tells Somhairle mac Lachlainn that the house blesses a boat and a roof against the sea and the rain, and will not pretend the same of a depot built for Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹⁰⁰'s lorries.¹⁰¹

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19 — *Two lorries come to the western Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). The first two lorries the western Seann Skell has ever seen come up for the enforcers' depot at midsummer, the town's children standing where they had planned to watch them arrive.¹⁰²

90. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

91. the Library at Muileann chaol

92. the Library at Muileann chaol

93. ← Follows from *The chronicler asks*, 28 an Dàmhair, DE 19; ← Follows from *Somhairle's three drafts*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *Sileas names the silence*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

94. the Library at Muileann chaol

95. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

96. the Library at Muileann chaol

97. ← Follows from *The chronicler asks*, 28 an Dàmhair, DE 19; ← Follows from *Beathag's letter to Comhairle nam Mèinnean*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *Comhairle nam Mèinnean's letter forwarded without comment*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

98. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

99. ← Follows from *The chronicler asks*, 28 an Dàmhair, DE 19; ← Follows from *Sileas names the silence*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *The priest of Manannan answers the captain*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

100. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

101. ← Follows from *The enforcers' depot*, 23 am Faoilleach, DE 19; ← Follows from *Comhairle nam Mèinnean's letter forwarded without comment*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *Two lorries come to the western Seann Skell*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

102. ← Follows from *The enforcers' depot*, 23 am Faoilleach, DE 19; ← Follows from *The priest of Manannan answers the captain*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *Peter Hale on a filed letter*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *Peter Hale on a filed letter* (Caol mhòr). At Tional nan Tuathach¹⁰³ Peter Hale tells the delegates that a filed letter is better than a refused one, since a refusal closes a door and a filing leaves it shut.¹⁰⁴
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *The enforcers' lorries at An Taigh-seinnse Reòta* (Muileann fhada). The enforcers' two lorries going west stop a night at An Taigh-seinnse Reòta on the north road; the landlord gives the men beds and wick lamps and does not ask where they are bound.¹⁰⁵
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *Seann Bhràl's priests of Manannan bear the refusal* (Seann Bhràl). The house of Manannan at Seann Bhràl, the order's west-coast harbour, hears from its brothers at the western Seann Skell that they refused to bless the enforcers' depot, and sends them no word either way.¹⁰⁶
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *old Fraser digs the trench across the southern road* (Muileann àrsaidh). In the last week of an t-Samhain, with frost already hard on the ground, old Fraser digs the trench across the southern cart-road into Muileann àrsaidh, deep enough to stop a laden cart and narrow enough for a man to cross on foot. He tells Ruth Calder plainly what the digging is for.¹⁰⁷
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *The spoil wall left unfinished at its northern end* (Muileann àrsaidh). old Fraser leaves the last length of the pit-yard wall unbuilt, calling it exhaustion; the town understands it as his own caution against finishing a wall built all the way round, which would look too near a boast.¹⁰⁸
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *Ruth Calder begins the letter to the council* (Muileann àrsaidh). At her father's table above the pit-head, on a windy night in an t-Samhain, Ruth Calder writes the salutation of a letter to Comhairle na Rìoghachd¹⁰⁹ and no more, the first of several attempts she will tear across before the letter is finished.¹¹⁰

103. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

104. ← Follows from *The Moot's warning*, 31 an Lùnastal, DE 19; ← Follows from *Two lorries come to the western Seann Skell*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *The enforcers' lorries at An Taigh-seinnse Reòta*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

105. ← Follows from *The enforcers' depot*, 23 am Faoilleach, DE 19; ← Follows from *Peter Hale on a filed letter*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *Seann Bhràl's priests of Manannan bear the refusal*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

106. ← Follows from *The enforcers' depot*, 23 am Faoilleach, DE 19; ← Follows from *The enforcers' lorries at An Taigh-seinnse Reòta*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

107. → Leads to *The pit-heads walled*, 26 an t-Samhain, DE 19; ← Leads to *The spoil wall left unfinished at its northern end*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

108. ← Follows from *The pit-heads walled*, 26 an t-Samhain, DE 19; ← Follows from *old Fraser digs the trench across the southern road*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *Ruth Calder begins the letter to the council*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

109. the royal council of twelve

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19 — *Ruth Calder tears up a draft written as a grievance* (Muileann àrsaidh). A second attempt, three paragraphs on the wrong done the towns by Breith Leòid¹¹¹, is torn across unfinished; Ruth Calder judges it would read at an Leabharlann¹¹² as one more northern complaint among many and be filed the same way.¹¹³

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19 — *Sarah Dunmore counsels an offer and not a complaint* (Muileann àrsaidh). In her kitchen at Muileann àrsaidh, Sarah Dunmore tells Ruth Calder that four years of letters have argued a right and never once made an offer, and that the towns' one thing worth offering is their coal, on their own terms.¹¹⁴

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19 — *Ruth Calder drafts the offer of An Crùn¹¹⁵'s fifth in coal* (Muileann àrsaidh). On the last evening of an t-Samhain, Ruth Calder writes the third draft of her letter: the five towns will pay An Crùn's fifth in coal on every load raised, from that day until the seams are spent, if Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹¹⁶ will carry it and press no further claim.¹¹⁷

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19 — *The four pit captains allow Ruth Calder to sign for them* (Muileann àrsaidh). Weeks before the letter is finished, Ruth Calder asks the pit captains of Muileann àrsaidh, Cnoc thais, Àth naomh and Tobar dhearg whether she may set their names beneath her own if the letter says nothing they would not themselves say; none refuses her.¹¹⁸

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19 — *The five towns keep an Nollaig¹¹⁹ at Àth leathan's chapel* (Àth leathan). On the morning of the twenty-fifth of an Dùbhlachd the chapel at Àth leathan is filled with its own people and others come down from Muileann àrsaidh and Cnoc thais, the western hills keeping the feast together, both faiths of the island under one roof as the coast has long done.¹²⁰

110. → Leads to *Ruth Calder's letter*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Follows from *The spoil wall left unfinished at its northern end*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *Ruth Calder tears up a draft written as a grievance*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

111. the Leòid ruling

112. the Library at Muileann chaol

113. → Leads to *Ruth Calder's letter*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Follows from *Ruth Calder begins the letter to the council*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *Sarah Dunmore counsels an offer and not a complaint*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

114. → Leads to *Ruth Calder's letter*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Follows from *Ruth Calder tears up a draft written as a grievance*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *Ruth Calder drafts the offer of An Crùn's fifth in coal*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

115. the Crown

116. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

117. → Leads to *Ruth Calder's letter*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Follows from *Sarah Dunmore counsels an offer and not a complaint*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *The four pit captains allow Ruth Calder to sign for them*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

118. → Leads to *Ruth Calder's letter*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Follows from *Ruth Calder drafts the offer of An Crùn's fifth in coal*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *The five towns keep an Nollaig at Àth leathan's chapel*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *Ruth Calder copies the letter fair and signs it* (Àth leathan). In a borrowed room at Àth leathan on an Nollaig¹²¹ afternoon, Ruth Calder copies her letter fair in a plain ledger hand, dates it, and signs it with her own name and the names of the other four pit captains beneath it.¹²²
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *Tom Varley walks the letter to the post at the western Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). Tom Varley walks the five miles from Àth leathan to the western Seann Skell on an Nollaig¹²³ evening and gives Ruth Calder's letter over the post office counter before it closes for the feast.¹²⁴
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *Ruth Calder's letter posted at the western Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). The post clerk at the western Seann Skell enters Ruth Calder's letter in his book among the season's other correspondence and sends it north three days after with the ordinary carrier.¹²⁵
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *A copy of the letter kept in Tional nan Tuathach*¹²⁶'s minute (Ceann mhòr). A copy of Ruth Calder's letter is carried to Caol mhòr and set down in Tional nan Tuathach's own minute, under a heading giving only what it was and when it came, though Tional nan Tuathach itself is no party to it.¹²⁷
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *The trench filled with water before the frost* (Muileann àrsaidh). Old Fraser of Muileann àrsaidh lets water into his trench across the southern road before the frost, so that it will not freeze into a bridge.¹²⁸
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *Ruth Calder lodges at Sarah Dunmore's* (Muileann àrsaidh). Ruth Calder lodges through the winter at Sarah Dunmore's house at Muileann àrsaidh to see the walling of the pit-heads done, keeping her father's tally-book with her.¹²⁹

120. → Leads to *Ruth Calder's letter*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Follows from *The four pit captains allow Ruth Calder to sign for them*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *Ruth Calder copies the letter fair and signs it*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

119. Christmas

121. Christmas

122. → Leads to *Ruth Calder's letter*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Follows from *The five towns keep an Nollaig at Àth leathan's chapel*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *Tom Varley walks the letter to the post at the western Seann Skell*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

123. Christmas

124. → Leads to *Ruth Calder's letter*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Follows from *Ruth Calder copies the letter fair and signs it*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *Ruth Calder's letter posted at the western Seann Skell*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

125. ← Follows from *Ruth Calder's letter*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Follows from *Tom Varley walks the letter to the post at the western Seann Skell*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *A copy of the letter kept in Tional nan Tuathach's minute*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

126. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

127. ← Follows from *Ruth Calder's letter*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Follows from *Ruth Calder's letter posted at the western Seann Skell*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *The trench filled with water before the frost*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

128. ← Follows from *The pit-heads walled*, 26 an t-Samhain, DE 19; ← Follows from *A copy of the letter kept in Tional nan Tuathach's minute*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *Ruth Calder lodges at Sarah Dunmore's*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *Regiments spoken of at Cathair dhearg* (Muileann àrsaidh). Carriers' talk reaches the western hills that regiments not called out since An Dealachadh¹³⁰ are spoken of again at Cathair dhearg, spoken of and not yet raised.¹³¹
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *Snow closes the Muileann àrsaidh road* (Muileann àrsaidh). Snow closes the road from Muileann àrsaidh to the coast for nineteen days in an Faoilleach, and the enforcers' wagons stand at the western Seann Skell.¹³²
- 23 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 20** — *The Moot stands apart* (Caol mhòr). The Moot at Caol mhòr resolves that it is no party to the quarrel of the Board and the western towns, and that it will feed any who come hungry to its towns. The resolution is carried by nine votes.
- 4 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 20** — *The Moot's granaries* (Doire ghlas). The Moot orders its granaries at Caol mhòr and Doire ghlas filled beyond the wont, paying from the takings of the wool mills. The minute gives no reason.
- 2 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 20** — *Sileas nic Rath* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹³³). Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh lays down the office, and Sileas nic Rath, her clerk, becomes royal chronicler. Hers is the record of the war that the library afterwards seals.
- 28 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 20** — *The regiments called up*. Regiments not called to arms since the Severance itself are formed and armed anew, openly, months before any in power will own that war is coming.
- 26 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 20** — *Somhairle mac Lachlainn* (Cathair dhearg). Command of the new-formed regiments is given to Somhairle mac Lachlainn, who rose among the Board's enforcers. The rolls of the Severance companies are brought out of the council's chests at Cathair dhearg to name the regiments, and the old names are read aloud before new men.
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *The Moot's last petition* (Cathair dhearg). On Christmas Day Martha Greaves carries a petition of the Moot in person to the council at Cathair dhearg. It asks that the western pits be let work out their seams, which the Moot says will be spent in a few years whatever is done. It is received and filed. She is the first speaker of the Moot to enter the council chamber.

129. ← Follows from *The pit-heads walled*, 26 an t-Samhain, DE 19; ← Follows from *The trench filled with water before the frost*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *Regiments spoken of at Cathair dhearg*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

130. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

131. ← Follows from *Ruth Calder lodges at Sarah Dunmore's*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19; ← Leads to *Snow closes the Muileann àrsaidh road*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

132. ← Follows from *The pit-heads walled*, 26 an t-Samhain, DE 19; ← Follows from *Regiments spoken of at Cathair dhearg*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19.

133. the Library at Muileann chaol

- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *Peter Hale presses the room* (Caol mhòr). In the depth of winter Peter Hale rises before Tional nan Tuathach¹³⁴ and says the room has sat three sittings without naming the wall at Muileann àrsaidh or the silence that answered Ruth Calder's letter, and that a gathering of the northern towns which will not say the plainest fact in the north is not doing what it was built to do.¹³⁵
- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *The five empty benches* (Caol mhòr). The five benches of the western holdout towns stand chalked but empty in Tional nan Tuathach¹³⁶'s own roll, as they have stood since the western delegates rose and left four years before. No one moves to fill them, and the room debates the wall at Muileann àrsaidh with the western towns' own voice absent from it.¹³⁷
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *Christina Munro's question* (Caol mhòr). On the stair after the vote, a delegate of the farm towns asks Martha Greaves whether nine hands out of one-and-forty are truly the room's mind, and whether the speaker's own hand, never raised, holds the same mind as the nine. Martha answers only that the chair does not vote, and the question goes unanswered further.¹³⁸
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *The mills' surplus reckoned* (Doire ghlas). In summer, with the spring clip in heavy and the fair price holding, Martha Greaves reckons the Doire ghlas mills' takings a whole evening in the counting-house and writes an order, at the foot of the mills' own book and not Tional nan Tuathach¹³⁹'s, that the granaries of Caol mhòr and Doire ghlas be filled beyond the ordinary wont, paid from the mills alone.¹⁴⁰
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *Grain bought through three factors* (Doire ghlas). Through the last week of an t-Iuchar the grain for the granaries is bought quietly through three separate factors, so that no single merchant should wonder aloud why Tional nan Tuathach¹⁴¹'s towns want so much of it in a year the harvest already promises well.¹⁴²
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *"Enter the weight and the date"* (Doire ghlas). The Doire ghlas granary-keeper asks Martha Greaves whether he should set down a reason for the extra grain, since his book goes before the room's auditors each spring. She tells him to enter the weight and the date and no reason at all, and to send anyone who asks to her.¹⁴³

134. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

135. ← Follows from *The Moot stands apart*, 23 am Faoilleach, DE 20.

136. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

137. ← Follows from *The Moot stands apart*, 23 am Faoilleach, DE 20; ← Follows from *Peter Hale presses the room*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

138. ← Follows from *The Moot stands apart*, 23 am Faoilleach, DE 20; ← Follows from *The five empty benches*, 27 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

139. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

140. ← Follows from *The Moot's granaries*, 4 an t-Iuchar, DE 20; ← Follows from *Christina Munro's question*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

141. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

142. ← Follows from *The Moot's granaries*, 4 an t-Iuchar, DE 20; ← Follows from *The mills' surplus reckoned*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

143. ← Follows from *The Moot's granaries*, 4 an t-Iuchar, DE 20; ← Follows from *Grain bought through three factors*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *The autumn entry with no reason given*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20 — *The autumn entry with no reason given* (Caol mhòr).

Thomas Rook's autumn entry in Tional nan Tuathach¹⁴⁴'s minute records the granaries of Caol mhòr and Doire ghlas standing half again fuller than the five years' average, and gives no reason, none having been given him. Peter Hale reads the figure, looks once at Martha Greaves, and asks nothing.¹⁴⁵

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20 — *Beathag's letter to the council* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹⁴⁶). In spring Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh writes to the council, in her own hand alone, asking leave to lay down the office of royal chronicler at the close of summer, being nine-and-sixty that year, and naming her clerk of nine years, Sileas nic Rath, to take the desk after her.¹⁴⁷**31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *Sileas nic Rath told over the tea* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹⁴⁸). Sileas nic Rath learns of Beathag's letter not from the council but from Beathag herself, over their usual tea, who tells her she has until an Lùnastal to decide whether she still wants the desk once she has heard the whole of what it costs.¹⁴⁹**31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *The desk cleared a little at a time* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹⁵⁰). Through the last week of an Lùnastal Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh clears her desk a little at a time, so that the room should show no single day when it stood stripped, leaving only Tormod Pinn's inkstand, the day's half-written page, and the small iron key of the sealed press.¹⁵¹**31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *"Write what you are let"* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹⁵²). Handing over the key of the sealed press, Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh tells Sileas nic Rath to write what she is let, as fully as if no one would grudge her a word of it, and to write down what she is not let besides, where and by whom and on what day, since a chronicle that shows only its own leave is no chronicle at all.¹⁵³

144. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

145. ← Follows from *The Moot's granaries*, 4 an t-Iuchar, DE 20; ← Follows from *"Enter the weight and the date"*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *Beathag's letter to the council*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

146. the Library at Muileann chaol

147. ← Follows from *Sileas nic Rath*, 2 an Lùnastal, DE 20; ← Follows from *The autumn entry with no reason given*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *Sileas nic Rath told over the tea*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

148. the Library at Muileann chaol

149. ← Follows from *Sileas nic Rath*, 2 an Lùnastal, DE 20; ← Follows from *Beathag's letter to the council*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *The desk cleared a little at a time*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

150. the Library at Muileann chaol

151. ← Follows from *Sileas nic Rath*, 2 an Lùnastal, DE 20; ← Follows from *Sileas nic Rath told over the tea*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *"Write what you are let"*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

152. the Library at Muileann chaol

153. ← Follows from *Sileas nic Rath*, 2 an Lùnastal, DE 20; ← Follows from *The desk cleared a little at a time*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh leaves for Àth dhìreach*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh leaves for Àth dhìreach* (Muileann chaol). The morning after the handing-over, a carrier's cart takes Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh north-east to her sister's house at Àth dhìreach. Raghnaill mac Mhuirich comes out to see her off, wishes her a dry ford at Àth bheag, and hands her up himself.¹⁵⁴
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *Sìleas nic Rath's first page* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹⁵⁵). Alone at the desk, Sìleas nic Rath finishes the day's half-written entry in her own hand, smaller and more upright than Beathag's, and adds a line the office's custom does not require: that Eachdraidh na Rìoghachd¹⁵⁶ now passes to a second hand, set down once so it need not be said again.¹⁵⁷
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *Five benches kept chalked in the roll* (Caol mhòr). The clerk of Tìonal nan Tuathach¹⁵⁸ keeps the five western towns' benches chalked in the roll of Tìonal nan Tuathach, under the towns' names, with nothing after them, five years after their delegates walked out.¹⁵⁹
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *Travellers' talk at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr*¹⁶⁰ (Cuan chrom). In the hall of An Taigh-seinnse Mòr above Cuan chrom the carters of the north road talk through the autumn of regiments to be raised; the landlord takes down the notice of the guild meetings and puts up none in its place.¹⁶¹
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *Somhairle mac Lachlainn summoned to the capital* (Seann Skell). Somhairle mac Lachlainn is called down to Cathair dhearg in the first cold week of an t-Samhain, and rides Slighe a' Ghuail¹⁶² with a corporal and a satchel of the depot's returns that nobody troubles to ask for.¹⁶³
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *The old drill hall opened* (Cathair dhearg). A long stone hall behind the council's rooms at Cathair dhearg, used in living memory for nothing grander than storing the city watch's spare pikes, is opened and swept for the reading of An Dealachadh¹⁶⁴ rolls.¹⁶⁵

154. ← Follows from *Sìleas nic Rath*, 2 an Lùnastal, DE 20; ← Follows from "Write what you are let", 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *Sìleas nic Rath's first page*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

155. the Library at Muileann chaol

156. the royal chronicle of the restored kingdom

157. ← Follows from *Sìleas nic Rath*, 2 an Lùnastal, DE 20; ← Follows from *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh leaves for Àth dhìreach*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *Five benches kept chalked in the roll*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

158. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

159. ← Follows from *The Moot stands apart*, 23 am Faoilleach, DE 20; ← Follows from *Sìleas nic Rath's first page*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *Travellers' talk at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

160. the great house on the old coal road above Cuan chrom, whose new hall is let to the Guild of Hewers

161. ← Follows from *The regiments called up*, 28 an Dàmhair, DE 20; ← Follows from *Five benches kept chalked in the roll*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

162. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

163. ← Follows from *Somhairle mac Lachlainn*, 26 an t-Samhain, DE 20; ← Leads to *The old drill hall opened*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20 — *The rolls unsealed* (Cathair dhearg). Ledgers of Buidhnean an Dealachaidh¹⁶⁶, kept in the council's chests some ninety years, are brought out and opened; the ink in one has gone the colour of weak tea, and a clerk works two stuck pages apart with a blunt knife.¹⁶⁷

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20 — *The towns struck through* (Cathair dhearg). Town by town the old roll is checked against the present: some answer still and will send men gladly, others are struck through in a clerk's hand because the town that raised the company is gone, swallowed into a larger one or fallen to scattered farms with no muster-ground left standing.¹⁶⁸

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20 — *The lamps lit in the drill hall* (Cathair dhearg). As dark comes on, four lamps are hung along the drill hall's wall and lit with dubhan, the first flame the brackets have carried in a generation, and the reading of the old names goes on by their light into the evening.¹⁶⁹

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20 — *The count of the standing companies* (Cathair dhearg). A clerk totals the column of towns still able to send men, once the dead towns are struck out. The figure is smaller than the roll once named ninety years before, but greater than any command Somhairle mac Lachlainn has held, and it is his from that evening to answer for.

¹⁷⁰

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20 — *A corporal bidden to bear the rolls* (Cathair dhearg). Cormac Liath, the old soldier who read the rolls aloud, tells Somhairle mac Lachlainn to bring his own corporal in to hear the old names read, since a man who hears a thing said once in a lamplit hall carries it differently to his company than a man only handed a paper.¹⁷¹

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20 — *Tional nan Tuathach*¹⁷² agrees an Nollaig¹⁷³ petition (Caol mhòr). At Caol mhòr Tional nan Tuathach sits past midnight two days before an Nollaig, turning the wording of its petition over clause by clause until it asks one thing only: that the western pits be let alone to work out seams that will be spent within a few years regardless.¹⁷⁴

165. ← Follows from *Somhairle mac Lachlainn*, 26 an t-Samhain, DE 20; ← Follows from *Somhairle mac Lachlainn summoned to the capital*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *The rolls unsealed*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

164. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

166. the war-companies of the Severance

167. ← Follows from *Somhairle mac Lachlainn*, 26 an t-Samhain, DE 20; ← Follows from *The old drill hall opened*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *The towns struck through*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

168. ← Follows from *Somhairle mac Lachlainn*, 26 an t-Samhain, DE 20; ← Follows from *The rolls unsealed*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *The lamps lit in the drill hall*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

169. ← Follows from *Somhairle mac Lachlainn*, 26 an t-Samhain, DE 20; ← Follows from *The towns struck through*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *The count of the standing companies*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

170. ← Follows from *Somhairle mac Lachlainn*, 26 an t-Samhain, DE 20; ← Follows from *The lamps lit in the drill hall*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *A corporal bidden to bear the rolls*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

171. ← Follows from *Somhairle mac Lachlainn*, 26 an t-Samhain, DE 20; ← Follows from *The count of the standing companies*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *Tional nan Tuathach agrees an Nollaig petition*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

172. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

173. Christmas

- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *Martha Greaves sets out for the capital* (Doire ghlais). Martha Greaves leaves Doire ghlais two days before an Nollaig¹⁷⁵ with the petition in a leather folder, travelling south by carrier's cart, dubhan coach and at last a hired carriage, and keeps the feast on the road with a cold fowl she cannot bring herself to eat.¹⁷⁶
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *Frost on Drochaid Cathair dhearg*¹⁷⁷ (Cathair dhearg). Martha Greaves comes into Cathair dhearg on an Nollaig¹⁷⁸ morning, the frost lying white and unworn on the bridge's parapet because so few feet have crossed it, the Dia-thirich keeping no feast that day.¹⁷⁹
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *The bench in the passage* (Cathair dhearg). Martha Greaves waits the better part of an hour on a stone bench outside the council chamber at Cathair dhearg, the petition twice taken out of its folder and twice put back unread, while the rise and fall of unheard voices carries from the room beyond.¹⁸⁰
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *A name said the Dia-thiris way* (Cathair dhearg). A clerk calls Martha Greaves into the council chamber, her surname set first and her whole name given the turn of the tongue that shapes every foreign name passing through that room, so that she does not, for a moment, know it for her own.¹⁸¹
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *Received, said the clerk* (Cathair dhearg). The council gives Martha Greaves's petition one word and the sound of a pen crossing paper. Nobody at the table speaks to her; the old man at its head inclines his head, and the porter is already at her elbow to show her out again.¹⁸²
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *The road home from Cathair dhearg* (Doire ghlais). Martha Greaves rides the cold road north again with the folder empty on her lap, coming in sight of Doire ghlais's lit windows late on the second night after, the one word the council gave her worn down, by then, to the sound of a pen alone.¹⁸³

174. ← Follows from *The Moot's last petition*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Follows from *A corporal bidden to bear the rolls*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *Martha Greaves sets out for the capital*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

175. Christmas

176. ← Follows from *The Moot's last petition*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Follows from *Tional nan Tuathach agrees an Nollaig petition*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *Frost on Drochaid Cathair dhearg*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

177. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

178. Christmas

179. ← Follows from *The Moot's last petition*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Follows from *Martha Greaves sets out for the capital*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *The bench in the passage*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

180. ← Follows from *The Moot's last petition*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Follows from *Frost on Drochaid Cathair dhearg*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *A name said the Dia-thiris way*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

181. ← Follows from *The Moot's last petition*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Follows from *The bench in the passage*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *Received, said the clerk*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

182. ← Follows from *The Moot's last petition*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Follows from *A name said the Dia-thiris way*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *The road home from Cathair dhearg*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *The Grey House among the old companies* (Cathair dhearg). Among the rolls of Buidhnean an Dealachaidh¹⁸⁴ read in the drill hall at Cathair dhearg is a company called only the Grey House, and no one in the room can say why.¹⁸⁵
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *Dead towns struck from the rolls* (Cathair dhearg). Where a company of An Dealachadh¹⁸⁶ rolls answers to a town gone or swallowed into another, the clerk strikes the name through; Cormac Liath's reading grows quieter over each.¹⁸⁷
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *Martha Greaves keeps an Nollaig¹⁸⁸ on the road* (Caol mhòr). The speaker of Tional nan Tuathach¹⁸⁹ keeps an Nollaig in a hired carriage on the northern road, with Ellen Marsh's bread and cold fowl uneaten at her feet, Athchuinge Dheireannach an Tionail¹⁹⁰ in Peter Hale's leather folder on her knee.¹⁹¹
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *Anna nic Phàil's nod across the table* (Cathair dhearg). In the council chamber, when the speaker of Tional nan Tuathach¹⁹² comes in with the petition, Anna nic Phàil, councillor for Cathair dhomhain, gives her the smallest incline of the head across the width of the table.¹⁹³
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *An Taigh-òsta Grianach¹⁹⁴ full at the year's end* (Cnoc dhìreach). An Taigh-òsta Grianach at Cnoc dhìreach is full to the stables at the year's end with men walking to the drill hall at Cathair dhearg to hear their old companies' names.¹⁹⁵

183. ← Follows from *The Moot's last petition*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Follows from *Received, said the clerk*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *The Grey House among the old companies*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

184. the war-companies of the Severance

185. ← Follows from *Sombairle mac Lachlainn*, 26 an t-Samhain, DE 20; → Leads to *The Severance companies stood down* → An Aois Rìoghachd, SE 1; ← Follows from *The road home from Cathair dhearg*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *Dead towns struck from the rolls*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

186. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

187. ← Follows from *Sombairle mac Lachlainn*, 26 an t-Samhain, DE 20; ← Follows from *The Grey House among the old companies*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *Martha Greaves keeps an Nollaig on the road*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

188. Christmas

189. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

190. the Moot's last petition

191. ← Follows from *The Moot's last petition*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Follows from *Dead towns struck from the rolls*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *Anna nic Phàil's nod across the table*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

192. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

193. ← Follows from *The Moot's last petition*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Follows from *Martha Greaves keeps an Nollaig on the road*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20; ← Leads to *An Taigh-òsta Grianach full at the year's end*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

194. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

195. ← Follows from *Sombairle mac Lachlainn*, 26 an t-Samhain, DE 20; ← Follows from *Anna nic Phàil's nod across the table*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20.

THE YEARS DE 21 – 25

- 12 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 21** — *Arms by the coal line* (Seann Bhral). The Rail Board carries arms and dubhan from Cathair dhearg to Seann Bhral on the coal line and its western branch. The yard at Muileann chrom works day and night on the trains.
- 20 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 21** — *The hewers gather at Àth leathan* (Àth leathan). Hewers of the five western towns gather at Àth leathan, where the road from the south enters the hills. The Board's lists name Ruth Calder and Tom Varley among them.
- 23 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 21** — *The regiments go west* (Seann Skell). The regiments set out from Cathair dhearg by the western road, their carts and lorries running on dubhan, to join the enforcers at Seann Skell in the west.
- II AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Battle of Àth leathan* (Àraich Àth leathan¹). The first great battle of An Cogadh Fada², the Long War. The state, whose failing power already leans on Dubhan's fuel, moves against the holdouts in arms.
- II AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *The dead of Àth leathan* (Àraich Àth leathan³). The open record counts the kingdom's dead at Àth leathan and not the holdouts'. The Tuathaich tellings put theirs in the hundreds. After this battle Ruth Calder's name is not found in the open record.
- II AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Into the hills* (Muileann àrsaidh). After Àth leathan the holdouts give up the southern pits and fall back into the hills about Muileann àrsaidh and Cnoc thais. The pits at Àth leathan are taken without a fight and flooded by the Board's order.
- II AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *An seachdamb rèisimeid⁴ raised* (Seann Skell). The seventh regiment is raised from the levies of the west coast and stationed at Seann Skell, the river port nearest the western hills. It holds the road behind the army and the field of Àth leathan.
- 13 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *The field of Àth leathan after* (Àraich Àth leathan⁵). The field of Àth leathan is left unploughed. The patrols of the seventh regiment pass it on the road to the western hills and report it empty.
- 14 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *The yard at Muileann chrom goes to a double shift* (Seann Bhral). The yard at Muileann chrom takes on a double shift of drivers and firemen for the arms trains west, running by night as well as by day. Eachann mac Ruairidh is given the run, and told to sign the manifest for weight and ask nothing of the goods.⁶

1. the battlefield of Àth leathan

2. the Long War

3. the battlefield of Àth leathan

4. the seventh regiment

5. the battlefield of Àth leathan

6. ← Follows from *Arms by the coal line*, 12 am Faoilleach, DE 21.

- 15 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *The first sealed wagons loaded at Muileann chrom* (Seann Bhrál). Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn's own men load eight wagons behind tarpaulin at Muileann chrom by shuttered lamp, and take the loading out of the yard drivers' hands for the first time in the line's history.⁸
- 16 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *The western branch runs arms by night*. Through am Faoilleach Slighe a' Ghuail's western branch, laid twenty years before for lime and slate, carries arms and dubhan west to Seann Bhrál by night, at speeds the branch's rails were never built to bear.¹⁰
- 17 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn's quay at Seann Bhrál*. At Seann Bhrál Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn's men unload the arms trains by lantern into a lorry kept always waiting, and give the driver nothing for his signature but a bare manifest.¹²
- 18 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *A company passes the arms train below the capital*. One of the new-raised companies, marching west by night under a corporal Eachann mac Ruairidh had once carried as a passenger, passes below the arms train on the branch road and is not stopped for.¹³
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *A Tuathach family on the western branch*. Eachann mac Ruairidh's train passes a Tuathach family walking north along Slighe a' Ghuail's western branch before dawn, a handcart between them. He does not stop, and does not look back.¹⁵
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Cnoc thais comes to Àth leathan* (Àth leathan). Tom Varley leads forty hewers and more of Cnoc thais down the ridge drove track to Àth leathan, pit-lamps lit at noon though no face waits at the path's end to work by them.¹⁶
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Àth naomh comes to Àth leathan* (Àth leathan). The hewers of Àth naomh come to Àth leathan marching two abreast, keeping their own order at another town's pit-head though they have nothing there yet to defend.¹⁷

7. the Rail Board; lit. 'the board of the iron way'

8. ← Follows from *Arms by the coal line*, 12 am Faoilleach, DE 21; ← Follows from *The yard at Muileann chrom goes to a double shift*, 14 an Giblean, DE 21.

9. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

10. ← Follows from *Arms by the coal line*, 12 am Faoilleach, DE 21; ← Follows from *The first sealed wagons loaded at Muileann chrom*, 15 an Giblean, DE 21.

11. the Rail Board; lit. 'the board of the iron way'

12. ← Follows from *Arms by the coal line*, 12 am Faoilleach, DE 21; ← Follows from *The western branch runs arms by night*, 16 an Giblean, DE 21.

13. ← Follows from *The regiments go west*, 23 am Faoilleach, DE 21; ← Follows from *Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn's quay at Seann Bhrál*, 17 an Giblean, DE 21.

14. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

15. ← Follows from *Arms by the coal line*, 12 am Faoilleach, DE 21; ← Follows from *A company passes the arms train below the capital*, 18 an Giblean, DE 21.

- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Muileann àrsaidh and Tobar dhearg of the hills come to Àth leathan* (Àth leathan). Smaller parties from Muileann àrsaidh and from Tobar dhearg of the hills reach Àth leathan through a second cold dusk, among them boys of fourteen and, from two houses, whole households with none left at home.¹⁸
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Ruth Calder's list begun at the pit-shed* (Àth leathan). Ruth Calder sets up a trestle table at the Àth leathan pit-shed and takes down every man's and boy's name, town by town, with a mark for those who bring their own tools.¹⁹
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Sarah Dunmore sends oatmeal to Àth leathan* (Àth leathan). Sarah Dunmore sends two cartloads of oatmeal and a barrel of salted fish down from Muileann àrsaidh for the gathering at Àth leathan, and asks no thanks for it.²⁰
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Ruth Calder learns Comhairle nam Mèinnean*²¹ *keeps its own list* (Àth leathan). Tom Varley brings word to Ruth Calder that Comhairle nam Mèinnean at Cathair mhòr keeps a list of its own, with her name and his set above every other on it.²²
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *The pit-sheds and byres given over at Àth leathan* (Àth leathan). The three pit-sheds of Àth leathan fill with sleeping men on straw, and the byres behind the chapel, their cattle turned out, hold the rest.²³
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *The regiments camp beside the enforcers at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). The regiments from Cathair dhearg reach the western Seann Skell and camp beside the enforcers already quartered there, three years settled and waiting for exactly this company.²⁴

17. ← Follows from *The bewers gather at Àth leathan*, 20 am Faoilleach, DE 21; ← Follows from *Cnoc thais comes to Àth leathan*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Muileann àrsaidh and Tobar dhearg of the hills come to Àth leathan*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

16. ← Follows from *The bewers gather at Àth leathan*, 20 am Faoilleach, DE 21; ← Follows from *A Tuathach family on the western branch*, 19 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Àth naomh comes to Àth leathan*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

18. ← Follows from *The bewers gather at Àth leathan*, 20 am Faoilleach, DE 21; ← Follows from *Àth naomh comes to Àth leathan*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Ruth Calder's list begun at the pit-shed*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

19. ← Follows from *The bewers gather at Àth leathan*, 20 am Faoilleach, DE 21; ← Follows from *Muileann àrsaidh and Tobar dhearg of the hills come to Àth leathan*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Sarah Dunmore sends oatmeal to Àth leathan*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

20. ← Follows from *The bewers gather at Àth leathan*, 20 am Faoilleach, DE 21; ← Follows from *Ruth Calder's list begun at the pit-shed*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Ruth Calder learns Comhairle nam Mèinnean keeps its own list*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

21. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

22. ← Follows from *The bewers gather at Àth leathan*, 20 am Faoilleach, DE 21; ← Follows from *Sarah Dunmore sends oatmeal to Àth leathan*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *The pit-sheds and byres given over at Àth leathan*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

23. ← Follows from *The bewers gather at Àth leathan*, 20 am Faoilleach, DE 21; ← Follows from *Ruth Calder learns Comhairle nam Mèinnean keeps its own list*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *The regiments camp beside the enforcers at Seann Skell*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

24. ← Follows from *The regiments go west*, 23 am Faoilleach, DE 21; ← Follows from *The pit-sheds and byres given over at Àth leathan*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Word of the march reaches Àth leathan*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Word of the march reaches Àth leathan* (Àth leathan). A carter carries word up from the boundary stones to Àth leathan that the regiments have gone west by the road below Cathair dhearg, their lorries running on dubhan.²⁵
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Signed for weight and not for goods* (Muileann chrom). The yard foreman at Muileann chrom hands Eachann mac Ruairidh a manifest giving only the weight of eight sealed wagons, and he is not to ask what is in them.²⁶
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Lamps lit at noon on the hill paths* (Àth leathan). The hewers of the five towns come down to Àth leathan with their pit-lamps lit at noon, so that every farm in the western hills sees them come as pit men.²⁷
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Tobar dhearg's captain sets his lamp on the table* (Tobar dhearg). The stooped captain of Tobar dhearg of the hills sets his lamp on Ruth Calder's trestle table before he gives his own name.²⁸
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Four hundred names by the sixth evening* (Àth leathan). By the sixth evening of the gathering Ruth Calder's list at Àth leathan runs past four hundred men and boys of the five towns.²⁹
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *The five towns form pit companies at Àth leathan* (Àth leathan). Through am Faoilleach and an Gearran Ruth Calder and Tom Varley turn the gathering at Àth leathan into five companies, one to a town, each under its own captain and answerable to Tom Varley for the whole body.³⁰
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Blasting powder laid at the spoil-heaps* (Àth leathan). Tom Varley lays four kegs of the pits' own blasting powder in the narrow ground below the spoil-heaps, on the road down from Seann Skell, to be fired at his word alone.³¹
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *The burn comes up in spate before the battle* (Àth leathan). A fast thaw in the first week of an Giblean brings the burn below Àth leathan up in spate, closing the ford and leaving only the dry road from Seann Skell for the regiments' approach.³²

25. ← Follows from *The regiments go west*, 23 am Faoilleach, DE 21; ← Follows from *The regiments camp beside the enforcers at Seann Skell*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Signed for weight and not for goods*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

26. ← Follows from *Arms by the coal line*, 12 am Faoilleach, DE 21; ← Follows from *Word of the march reaches Àth leathan*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Lamps lit at noon on the hill paths*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

27. ← Follows from *The hewers gather at Àth leathan*, 20 am Faoilleach, DE 21; ← Follows from *Signed for weight and not for goods*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Tobar dhearg's captain sets his lamp on the table*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

28. ← Follows from *The hewers gather at Àth leathan*, 20 am Faoilleach, DE 21; ← Follows from *Lamps lit at noon on the hill paths*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Four hundred names by the sixth evening*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

29. ← Follows from *The hewers gather at Àth leathan*, 20 am Faoilleach, DE 21; ← Follows from *Tobar dhearg's captain sets his lamp on the table*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

30. ← Follows from *The hewers gather at Àth leathan*, 20 am Faoilleach, DE 21; ← Leads to *Blasting powder laid at the spoil-heaps*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

31. ← Follows from *Battle of Àth leathan*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *The five towns form pit companies at Àth leathan*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *The burn comes up in spate before the battle*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Ruth Calder's word to the five towns' companies* (Àth leathan). On the morning of the battle Ruth Calder tells Tom Varley to carry her word to the five towns' companies, that her list stands and will say who stood at Àth leathan and beside whom, whatever the day brings.³³
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Tobar dhearg's men keep the chapel before the battle* (Àth leathan). Before dawn on the day of the battle, Tobar dhearg's stooped captain asks that the chapel at Àth leathan stand open, so that any of his men who wish it may go in once before the fighting.³⁴
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *The charge fired below the spoil-heaps* (Àraich Àth leathan³⁵). Tom Varley fires the blasting powder laid at the spoil-heaps as the regiments' column reaches the narrow ground, checking its head for the better part of an hour before it reforms and comes on.³⁶
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *The pit-heads of Àth leathan change hands* (Àraich Àth leathan³⁷). Through the day of the battle the pit-heads of Àth leathan pass more than once between the holdouts and the regiments before falling at last to the kingdom's side.³⁸
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *The five towns' companies fall back from the field* (Àth leathan). By early afternoon the five towns' companies give up the field below Àth leathan and fall back in scattered bodies along the hill paths toward Muileann àrsaidh and Cnoc thais.³⁹
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Inis àrsaidh victuals the kingdom's host* (Inis àrsaidh). The river town of Inis àrsaidh, nearest Àraich Àth leathan⁴⁰ by water, supplies bread and salt fish to the kingdom's host through the campaign and the battle.⁴¹

32. ← Follows from *Battle of Àth leathan*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Blasting powder laid at the spoil-heaps*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Ruth Calder's word to the five towns' companies*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

33. ← Follows from *Battle of Àth leathan*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *The burn comes up in spate before the battle*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Tobar dhearg's men keep the chapel before the battle*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

34. ← Follows from *Battle of Àth leathan*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Ruth Calder's word to the five towns' companies*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *The charge fired below the spoil-heaps*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

35. the battlefield of Àth leathan

36. ← Follows from *Battle of Àth leathan*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Tobar dhearg's men keep the chapel before the battle*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *The pit-heads of Àth leathan change hands*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

37. the battlefield of Àth leathan

38. ← Follows from *Battle of Àth leathan*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *The charge fired below the spoil-heaps*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *The five towns' companies fall back from the field*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

39. ← Follows from *The dead of Àth leathan*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *The pit-heads of Àth leathan change hands*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Inis àrsaidh victuals the kingdom's host*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

40. the battlefield of Àth leathan

20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21 — *Sombairle mac Lachlainn's return of the battle* (Seann Skell).

Within the week Sombairle mac Lachlainn writes a return from Seann Skell naming the companies that fought at Àth leathan and the kingdom's dead, and no more.⁴²

20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21 — *Sileas nic Rath searches the record for Ruth Calder's name*

(Muileann chaol). Sileas nic Rath, new to the office of royal chronicler, searches An Clàr Foscailte⁴³ more than once for Ruth Calder's name after Àth leathan and does not find it, and privately judges the question not hers to press further.⁴⁴

20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21 — *Doire naomh's grove takes in the field's unclaimed dead* (Doire naomh).

The Dia-thìrich of Doire naomh's grove, closed to strangers, go out onto the field after the regiments pass on and carry many of the unclaimed dead of Àth leathan to their own ground.⁴⁵

20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21 — *Àth chrom's drovers carry the dead of Àth leathan* (Àth chrom).

Àth chrom's drovers take their coal and salt carts out along the road to carry the dead of Àth leathan, of both sides, without any record of whom they carried.⁴⁶

20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21 — *Baile fhiadhaich takes in the wounded of Àth leathan* (Baile fhiadhaich).

Baile fhiadhaich, too far off to send carriers to the field itself, takes in such wounded of Àth leathan as reach it along the west-coast harbour road.⁴⁷

20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21 — *Nine hundred at Àth leathan* (Àth leathan).

By the eve of the battle the muster at Àth leathan counts near nine hundred souls with their carriers, in five companies: Muileann àrsaidh near two hundred, Cnoc thais a hundred and sixty, Àth leathan ninety, Àth naomh sixty and Tobar dhearg forty.⁴⁸

41. ← Follows from *Battle of Àth leathan*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *The five towns' companies fall back from the field*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Sombairle mac Lachlainn's return of the battle*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

42. ← Follows from *The dead of Àth leathan*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Inis àrsaidh victuals the kingdom's host*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Sileas nic Rath searches the record for Ruth Calder's name*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

43. the open record of the war years

44. ← Follows from *The dead of Àth leathan*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Sombairle mac Lachlainn's return of the battle*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Doire naomh's grove takes in the field's unclaimed dead*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

45. ← Follows from *The dead of Àth leathan*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Sileas nic Rath searches the record for Ruth Calder's name*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Àth chrom's drovers carry the dead of Àth leathan*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

46. ← Follows from *The dead of Àth leathan*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Doire naomh's grove takes in the field's unclaimed dead*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Baile fhiadhaich takes in the wounded of Àth leathan*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

47. ← Follows from *The dead of Àth leathan*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Àth chrom's drovers carry the dead of Àth leathan*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Nine hundred at Àth leathan*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Sixty firearms and four kegs of powder* (Àth leathan). The five towns have among them some sixty firearms, most of them fowling pieces older than any man carrying them, a dozen rifles, picks and short axes, and four kegs of blasting powder from the pits.⁴⁹
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *A fever in the byres of Àth leathan* (Àth leathan). A fever goes through the byres behind the chapel at Àth leathan in an Gearran and takes an old woman of Cnoc thais who had come down only to be near her grandsons.⁵⁰
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Singing in the Tobar dhearg line* (Àraich Àth leathan⁵¹). In the waiting before the battle the old captain's men of Tobar dhearg sing low in An Eaglais⁵²'s own words along their line.⁵³
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Ruth Calder's account ends at the column's coming* (Àraich Àth leathan⁵⁴). No page in Ruth Calder's hand, nor any word set down as hers by anyone who stood beside her, tells what she said or did after the regiments' column reached the ground below the spoil-heaps.⁵⁵
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Muileann ruadh takes in wounded officers* (Muileann ruadh). The custodians of the bath-house at Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh⁵⁶ below Muileann ruadh take in two officers of the regiments wounded in the west, at the council's asking, and set them in the long room among the hewers' widows.⁵⁷
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Tom Varley carries the wounded off the southern ground* (Àth leathan). As the light fails on the day of the battle, Tom Varley gathers hurdles and hand-carts and leads the wounded of the southern pits up the ridge drove track, unlit, away from Àth leathan toward Muileann àrsaidh.⁵⁸

48. ← Follows from *Battle of Àth leathan*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Baile fbiadhaich takes in the wounded of Àth leathan*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Sixty firearms and four kegs of powder*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

49. ← Follows from *Battle of Àth leathan*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Nine hundred at Àth leathan*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *A fever in the byres of Àth leathan*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

50. ← Follows from *Sixty firearms and four kegs of powder*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Singing in the Tobar dhearg line*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

51. the battlefield of Àth leathan

52. the Church

53. ← Follows from *Battle of Àth leathan*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *A fever in the byres of Àth leathan*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Ruth Calder's account ends at the column's coming*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

54. the battlefield of Àth leathan

55. ← Follows from *The dead of Àth leathan*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Singing in the Tobar dhearg line*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Muileann ruadh takes in wounded officers*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

56. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

57. ← Follows from *The dead of Àth leathan*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Ruth Calder's account ends at the column's coming*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

58. ← Follows from *The dead of Àth leathan*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Into the hills*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *The carriers pass Àth leathan in the dark*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21 — *The carriers pass Àth leathan in the dark* (Àth leathan). Tom Varley's party of carriers comes within sight of the Àth leathan pit-sheds before dawn and does not stop there, word having already reached them that the town cannot be held through the coming night.⁵⁹

20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21 — *Sarah Dunmore receives the wounded at Muileann àrsaidh* (Muileann àrsaidh). Sarah Dunmore and the women of Muileann àrsaidh come out along the ridge path at dawn to take the hurdles from the carriers' shoulders, and a woman who sets bones is sent for to tend the worst hurt among them.⁶⁰

20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21 — *Tom Varley counts the wounded at the gate* (Muileann àrsaidh). Tom Varley counts nine souls brought off the field into Muileann àrsaidh and keeps the number in his head rather than on paper, unwilling to see it set down where it might be weighed against the number that went south.⁶¹

20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21 — *Tom Varley hears of the flooding at Sarah Dunmore's table* (Muileann àrsaidh). Word of the drowned shafts reaches Tom Varley by carter and shepherd, and he and Sarah Dunmore weigh, over several evenings, what purpose the flooding serves beyond telling the hills the seams are done for good.⁶²

20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21 — *Somhairle reads the first week's patrol reports* (Seann Skell). Somhairle mac Lachlainn reads An seachdamh rèisimeid⁶³'s first patrol reports at Seann Skell by dubhan lamp: the road clear, a cart met and let pass, a farm gate found open and shut again.

⁶⁴

20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21 — *A young officer writes of the unploughed field* (Àraich Àth leathan⁶⁵). A patrol officer new to his rank writes into his return that the field of the battle lies as it was left and has not been ploughed, though the season for the first ploughing is well begun on every field around it.⁶⁶

59. ← Follows from *Into the hills*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Tom Varley carries the wounded off the southern ground*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Sarah Dunmore receives the wounded at Muileann àrsaidh*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

60. ← Follows from *Into the hills*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *The carriers pass Àth leathan in the dark*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Tom Varley counts the wounded at the gate*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

61. ← Follows from *Into the hills*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Sarah Dunmore receives the wounded at Muileann àrsaidh*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Tom Varley hears of the flooding at Sarah Dunmore's table*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

62. ← Follows from *Into the hills*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Tom Varley counts the wounded at the gate*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Somhairle reads the first week's patrol reports*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

63. the seventh regiment

64. ← Follows from *An seachdamh rèisimeid raised*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Tom Varley hears of the flooding at Sarah Dunmore's table*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *A young officer writes of the unploughed field*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

65. the battlefield of Àth leathan

- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Somhairle sends the patrol to walk the field itself* (Àraich Àth leathan⁶⁷). Somhairle mac Lachlainn gives verbal, unwritten instructions for the same officer to walk Àraich Àth leathan rather than the road beside it, and receives an account he sets down in the fewest words the return will bear.⁶⁸
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *The maor of Seann Skell explains the seventh's short rolls* (Seann Skell). The maor of the western Seann Skell tells Somhairle mac Lachlainn privately that coast boats are finding the fishing a week longer than the weather requires, rather than fill a regiment meant to stand against their own hill neighbours.⁶⁹
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Tom Varley sends word to every hill farm* (Muileann àrsaidh). Tom Varley sends word by boys and shepherds to every hill farm within a day's walk of Muileann àrsaidh asking whether anyone has seen Ruth Calder, and gets back only that nobody has, alive or otherwise.⁷⁰
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *A farm-wife's account of the field's own dead* (Muileann àrsaidh). A woman below the ridge sends Tom Varley word that some of the battle's dead were carried off by night in the days after by people from the hills, and might lie now in ground no list on either side will ever name.⁷¹
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *An old woman of Àth leathan sees the field the morning after* (Àth leathan). An old woman who kept hens at Àth leathan tells of women from the hill farms out on the field with handcarts the morning after the battle, before the regiments came, but says she looked too little to know whose faces she saw.⁷²

66. ← Follows from *The field of Àth leathan after*, 13 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Somhairle reads the first week's patrol reports*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Somhairle sends the patrol to walk the field itself*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

67. the battlefield of Àth leathan

68. ← Follows from *The field of Àth leathan after*, 13 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *A young officer writes of the unploughed field*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *The maor of Seann Skell explains the seventh's short rolls*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

69. ← Follows from *An seachdamb rèisimeid raised*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Somhairle sends the patrol to walk the field itself*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Tom Varley sends word to every hill farm*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

70. ← Follows from *The field of Àth leathan after*, 13 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *The maor of Seann Skell explains the seventh's short rolls*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *A farm-wife's account of the field's own dead*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

71. ← Follows from *The field of Àth leathan after*, 13 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Tom Varley sends word to every hill farm*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *An old woman of Àth leathan sees the field the morning after*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

72. ← Follows from *The field of Àth leathan after*, 13 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *A farm-wife's account of the field's own dead*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Tom Varley walks to the dyke above the field*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21 — *Tom Varley walks to the dyke above the field* (Àraich Àth leathan⁷³). On the eighth day Tom Varley walks alone to a stone dyke a quarter-mile from Àraich Àth leathan and is turned back by a young sentry of An seachdamh rèisimeid⁷⁴ before he can see more than its empty shape.⁷⁵

20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21 — *Rab of Tobar dhearg carried up the ridge* (Muileann àrsaidh). A boy of Tobar dhearg named Rab, wounded in the thigh at Àth leathan, is carried up the ridge path on a handcart by Tom Varley's carriers, saying his own name over in the dark.⁷⁶

20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21 — *The bonesetter at Sarah Dunmore's table* (Muileann àrsaidh). A bonesetter of the western hills works on the wounded of Àth leathan by lamplight at Sarah Dunmore's kitchen table at Muileann àrsaidh.⁷⁷

20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21 — *The seventh's rolls short at the coast* (Seann Skell). An seachdamh rèisimeid⁷⁸'s rolls run to some four hundred and twenty men in its second week, short of the order; the maor of the western Seann Skell puts it down to boats still at sea.⁷⁹

21 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21 — *The wartime tithe*. For the war a tax is laid, for a time, on every sale of dubhan in the kingdom. It is never lifted after the war ends.

29 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21 — *The tithe at the pumps* (Fèill Muileann òg⁸⁰). The wartime tithe is taken at the dubhan depots, where a clerk of the Treasury sits beside every pump. Within a month the fair-court at Muileann òg records the first complaint against it.

7 AN CÈITEAN, DE 21 — *A' chiad rèisimeid⁸¹ raised* (Inis mhòr). The first regiment is raised at Inis mhòr, the river port beside the capital, from the capital's own companies. It guards the council, the mint and the bridge over the Abhainn dhomhain.

13 AN CÈITEAN, DE 21 — *A' chiad chabhlach⁸² raised* (Àth gharbh). The first fleet is raised from the south-west harbours and stationed at Àth gharbh, its hulls lying in the harbour of Doire shean a short walk away. It is sent round the western cape to stop the coal going out by sea from the Tuathaich ports.

73. the battlefield of Àth leathan

74. the seventh regiment

75. ← Follows from *The field of Àth leathan after*, 13 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *An old woman of Àth leathan sees the field the morning after*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *Rab of Tobar dhearg carried up the ridge*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

76. ← Follows from *Into the hills*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Tom Varley walks to the dyke above the field*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *The bonesetter at Sarah Dunmore's table*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

77. ← Follows from *Into the hills*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Rab of Tobar dhearg carried up the ridge*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Leads to *The seventh's rolls short at the coast*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

78. the seventh regiment

79. ← Follows from *An seachdamh rèisimeid raised*, 11 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *The bonesetter at Sarah Dunmore's table*, 20 an Giblean, DE 21.

80. the fair at Muileann òg

81. the first regiment

82. the first fleet

- 20 AN CÈITEAN, DE 21** — *An ceathramh cabhlach*⁸³ *raised* (Cuan shean). The fourth fleet is raised at Cuan shean on the west coast and joins the first off the Tuathaich shore. Between them they close Seann Skell and Cnoc bhàn in the north-west to every boat but fishing boats, and search those.
- 21 AN CÈITEAN, DE 21** — *The siege of Muileann àrsaidh* (Muileann àrsaidh). The regiments lay siege to Muileann àrsaidh. The town holds for weeks on stored coal and potatoes, and its pit-heads are taken one by one. Sileas nic Rath's open record gives the day it fell and nothing else.
- 5 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 21** — *An treas rèisimeid*⁸⁴ *raised* (Cathair mhòr). The third regiment is raised at Cathair mhòr, where the Mine Board keeps its offices in the old stone house of Mac Ùisdein. Its first muster is held under the market cross the house raised.
- 13 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 21** — *An còigeamh rèisimeid*⁸⁵ *raised* (Seann Warr). The fifth regiment is raised at Seann Warr on the lake shore west of the capital. It is sent north to relieve the regiments before Muileann àrsaidh.
- 21 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 21** — *The capital's lamp-houses rationed* (Cathair dhearg). Dubhan for the army is taken before every other use. The poorer streets of the capital go dark again, as they were before the fuel came, and the lamp-houses of Cathair dhearg ration it street by street.
- 29 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 21** — *Families at Caol mhòr* (Caol mhòr). Families from the western pits come into Caol mhòr and Doire ghlas with what they can carry. The Moot feeds them from its own stores, as it resolved to do. The council sends nothing and forbids nothing.
- 17 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 21** — *The Moot's granaries opened* (Caol mhòr). The Moot opens its granaries at Caol mhòr and Doire ghlas to the families from the west. Its minute records how much was given and the names of the families; it is one of the few Tuathaich records of the war that the library does not hold.
- 25 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 21** — *Agnes Pike's school as a shelter* (Doire ghlas). The school at Doire ghlas that Agnes Pike founded is given over to the families from the west, and its benches serve for beds. Ellen Marsh, who teaches there, takes down the families' accounts.
- 26 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 21** — *A clerk of An t-Ionmhas*⁸⁶ *is sent to Muileann òg* (Muileann òg). Cailean Ros of An t-Ionmhas comes to sit beside the fair pump at Muileann òg and mark the tithe on every gallon drawn; Ùna nic Ailein shows him the tank's own measure, which nobody in the capital had thought to teach him.⁸⁷

83. the fourth fleet

84. the third regiment

85. the fifth regiment

86. the Treasury

87. ← Follows from *The tithe at the pumps*, 29 an Giblean, DE 21.

- 27 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 21** — *The first tithe taken at Muileann òg* (Muileann òg). Ùna nic Ailein records the first gallon of dubhan sold under Deachamh a' Chogaidh⁸⁸ at the Muileann òg pump, eleven gallons to Seumas Buidhe the smith, one part in twelve set aside before the coin changes hands.⁸⁹
- 28 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 21** — *The first complaint against the tithe* (Muileann òg). In the fifth week of the tithe, Barabal nic Rath, a weaver of Muileann òg, brings her own five weeks' reckoning of it to Cùirt na Fèille⁹⁰ and asks that her complaint against its silence on its own ending be written into the book.⁹¹
- 29 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 21** — *An ceathramh cabhlach*⁹² *searches the boats at Caol mhòr* (Caol mhòr). A hull of An ceathramh cabhlach boards and searches every boat at Caol mhòr's harbour wall for dubhan or coal carried against the closing of the coast; the engine-boats Joe Ashby has fitted are searched last and longest.⁹³
- 30 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 21** — *Joe Ashby is asked to mend a fleet hull* (Caol mhòr). An unsigned letter from Caol mhòr's harbour depot asks Joe Ashby to mend an engine of An ceathramh cabhlach⁹⁴ that the depot's own men cannot; the letter is signed with a mark, and names no fleet and no rank.⁹⁵
- 31 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 21** — *Joe Ashby refits the fleet hull* (Caol mhòr). Joe Ashby and Ned Fowler find and mend a wrongly seated valve aboard an unnamed hull of An ceathramh cabhlach⁹⁶ at Caol mhòr's depot jetty, and are paid at the harbour's own rate, in coin, and asked no questions.⁹⁷
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *One part in twelve* (Cathair dhearg). Deachamh a' Chogaidh⁹⁸ is laid at one part in twelve of every sale of dubhan, taken at the point of sale by a clerk of An t-Ionmhas⁹⁹ sitting beside the pump.¹⁰⁰

88. the wartime tithe

89. ← Follows from *The tithe at the pumps*, 29 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *A clerk of An t-Ionmhas is sent to Muileann òg*, 26 an t-Iuchar, DE 21.

90. the court of the fair at Muileann òg

91. ← Follows from *The tithe at the pumps*, 29 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *The first tithe taken at Muileann òg*, 27 an t-Iuchar, DE 21.

92. the fourth fleet

93. ← Follows from *An ceathramh cabhlach raised*, 20 an Cèitean, DE 21; ← Follows from *The first complaint against the tithe*, 28 an t-Iuchar, DE 21.

94. the fourth fleet

95. ← Follows from *An ceathramh cabhlach raised*, 20 an Cèitean, DE 21; ← Follows from *An ceathramh cabhlach searches the boats at Caol mhòr*, 29 an t-Iuchar, DE 21.

96. the fourth fleet

97. ← Follows from *An ceathramh cabhlach raised*, 20 an Cèitean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Joe Ashby is asked to mend a fleet hull*, 30 an t-Iuchar, DE 21.

98. the wartime tithe

99. the Treasury

100. ← Follows from *The wartime tithe*, 21 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Joe Ashby refits the fleet hull*, 31 an t-Iuchar, DE 21; ← Leads to *Cailean Ros given the cold corner*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21 — *Cailean Ros given the cold corner* (Muileann òg). An t-Ionmhas¹⁰¹'s young clerk at the Muileann òg pump, Cailean Ros, is given the coldest corner of the toll-house's upper room against the weather, and takes it without complaint.¹⁰²
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21 — *The lieutenant laughs at Will Tanner's locker* (Caol mhòr). Searching the boats at Caol mhòr, An ceathramh cabhlach¹⁰³'s lieutenant finds Will Tanner's false locker under the stern thwart with nothing in it but a jar of spirit, laughs once, and writes nothing of it.¹⁰⁴
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21 — *The depot's tally names no fitter* (Caol mhòr). The fleet depot at Caol mhòr enters the mending of a hull's engine and the sum paid out, and names no fitter.¹⁰⁵
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21 — *The tithe-clerks' first returns* (Muileann òg). An t-Ionmhas¹⁰⁶'s clerks at the pumps send in their first month's returns; the clerk at Muileann òg's is the neatest and the smallest.¹⁰⁷
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21 — *Hay cleared from the barracks at Inis mhòr* (Inis mhòr). The farmers of Seann Vell are given a week to take their hay out of the barracks at Inis mhòr when A' chiad rèisimeid¹⁰⁸ is raised there; what is not taken is fed to the regiment's horses.¹⁰⁹
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21 — *The ferrymen of Àth gharbh go to A' chiad chabhlach*¹¹⁰ (Àth gharbh). Four of the ferrymen of Àth gharbh go into A' chiad chabhlach at its raising, and the ferry at the walled ford is worked through the war by the oldest of them and his daughter.¹¹¹
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21 — *The chandlers of Cuan shean* (Cuan shean). The chandlers of Cuan shean, An ceathramh cabhlach¹¹²'s harbour, sell out of rope and canvas within a month of the fleet's raising and send to Ros dhomhain for more at a price they say is war.¹¹³

101. the Treasury

102. ← Follows from *The tithe at the pumps*, 29 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *One part in twelve*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *The lieutenant laughs at Will Tanner's locker*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

103. the fourth fleet

104. ← Follows from *An ceathramh cabhlach raised*, 20 an Cèitean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Cailean Ros given the cold corner*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *The depot's tally names no fitter*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

105. ← Follows from *The lieutenant laughs at Will Tanner's locker*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *The tithe-clerks' first returns*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

106. the Treasury

107. ← Follows from *The tithe at the pumps*, 29 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *The depot's tally names no fitter*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *Hay cleared from the barracks at Inis mhòr*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

108. the first regiment

109. ← Follows from *A' chiad rèisimeid raised*, 7 an Cèitean, DE 21; ← Follows from *The tithe-clerks' first returns*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *The ferrymen of Àth gharbh go to A' chiad chabhlach*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

110. the first fleet

111. ← Follows from *A' chiad chabhlach raised*, 13 an Cèitean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Hay cleared from the barracks at Inis mhòr*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *The chandlers of Cuan shean*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

112. the fourth fleet

113. ← Follows from *An ceathramh cabhlach raised*, 20 an Cèitean, DE 21; ← Follows from *The ferrymen of Àth gharbh go to A' chiad chabhlach*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *A tithe-clerk at the pans of Caol iséal*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *A tithe-clerk at the pans of Caol iséal* (Caol iséal). An t-Ionmhas¹¹⁴'s clerk for the tithe sits at the dubhan pump by the salt pans of Caol iséal; the salt-boilers pay their part in twelve on every barrel for the pans and grumble that salt pays twice.¹¹⁵
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *The regiments break the ditch-bridge at Muileann àrsaidh* (Muileann àrsaidh). In the grey hour before dawn on 21 an Cèitean the regiments' advance breaks the ditch-bridge on the southern road and closes the gap old Fraser left unvalled the autumn before, shutting Muileann àrsaidh's ring rather than forcing it.¹¹⁶
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *The southern road is cut* (Muileann àrsaidh). By noon of the first day a second company digs in across the southern road below Muileann àrsaidh, closing the town's last cart road and leaving only hill paths a person on foot might use.¹¹⁷
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *Meikle's counting of the siege stores* (Muileann àrsaidh). Muileann àrsaidh's clerk Meikle sets a weekly rationing of coal and potatoes for the town under siege, and the stores are found, by his own careful counting, to hold weeks rather than days.¹¹⁸
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *The bell rung for a pit-head* (Muileann àrsaidh). On Meikle's proposal the chapel bell of Muileann àrsaidh is rung once for every pit-head the regiments take, so the town learns what is lost each day at a single stroke rather than piecemeal.¹¹⁹
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *The northern pit-head falls* (Muileann àrsaidh). The northern pit-head, nearest the wall's unfinished stretch, is taken on the sixth day of the siege after an afternoon's fighting that costs the town two of its own men.¹²⁰
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *Sarah Dunmore's kitchen serves as the town's dressing-station* (Muileann àrsaidh). Sarah Dunmore's kitchen, already used for the wounded of Àth leathan that spring, tends the siege's own wounded through the weeks that follow, from stray shot to the ordinary hurts of a town crowded behind a wall.¹²¹

114. the Treasury

115. ← Follows from *The wartime tithe*, 21 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *The chandlers of Cuan shean*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

116. ← Follows from *The siege of Muileann àrsaidh*, 21 an Cèitean, DE 21; ← Leads to *The southern road is cut*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

117. ← Follows from *The siege of Muileann àrsaidh*, 21 an Cèitean, DE 21; ← Follows from *The regiments break the ditch-bridge at Muileann àrsaidh*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *Meikle's counting of the siege stores*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

118. ← Follows from *The siege of Muileann àrsaidh*, 21 an Cèitean, DE 21; ← Follows from *The southern road is cut*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *The bell rung for a pit-head*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

119. ← Follows from *The siege of Muileann àrsaidh*, 21 an Cèitean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Meikle's counting of the siege stores*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *The northern pit-head falls*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

120. ← Follows from *The siege of Muileann àrsaidh*, 21 an Cèitean, DE 21; ← Follows from *The bell rung for a pit-head*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *Sarah Dunmore's kitchen serves as the town's dressing-station*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

121. ← Follows from *The siege of Muileann àrsaidh*, 21 an Cèitean, DE 21; ← Follows from *The northern pit-head falls*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *Weir keeps the Sunday service through the siege*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21 — *Weir keeps the Sunday service through the siege* (Muileann àrsaidh). The priest Weir keeps Muileann àrsaidh's one weekly service without missing a Sunday through the whole siege, preaching shorter each week and reading the same psalm three Sundays running.¹²²
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21 — *The graves behind the chapel* (Muileann àrsaidh). The dead of the siege are buried behind Muileann àrsaidh's chapel through the weeks of the siege, in the same ground the western hills have used since before An Dealachadh.^{123, 124}
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21 — *A picket's boast names the third and fifth regiments* (Muileann àrsaidh). A picket shouts across the gap at the taken northern pit-head that a regiment has come north from Cathair mhòr under the Mac Ùisdein cross and another from Seann Warr, and the boast reaches the town before any surer word does.¹²⁵
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21 — *old Fraser counts the smoke on the southern ridge* (Muileann àrsaidh). old Fraser distrusts a picket's shouted boast but counts three mornings running of new fires on the southern ridge, and brings the count, not the boast, before the town's pit-shed.¹²⁶
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21 — *Word of the rationed capital reaches the besieged town* (Muileann àrsaidh). A man briefly taken and released at the wall brings word into Muileann àrsaidh that the capital's poorer streets go dark again, the army's dubhan being served before the lamp-houses.¹²⁷
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21 — *The last pit-head's line gives way* (Muileann àrsaidh). In the grey hour before dawn, seven weeks after the siege began, the thinned line at the last pit-head gives way without a fight anyone in the town could afterward set down in order.¹²⁸

122. ← Follows from *The siege of Muileann àrsaidh*, 21 an Cèitean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Sarah Dunmore's kitchen serves as the town's dressing-station*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *The graves behind the chapel*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

123. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

124. ← Follows from *The siege of Muileann àrsaidh*, 21 an Cèitean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Weir keeps the Sunday service through the siege*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *A picket's boast names the third and fifth regiments*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

125. ← Follows from *An treas rèisimeid raised*, 5 an t-Ògmhios, DE 21; ← Follows from *An còigeamb rèisimeid raised*, 13 an t-Ògmhios, DE 21; ← Follows from *The graves behind the chapel*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *old Fraser counts the smoke on the southern ridge*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

126. ← Follows from *An treas rèisimeid raised*, 5 an t-Ògmhios, DE 21; ← Follows from *An còigeamb rèisimeid raised*, 13 an t-Ògmhios, DE 21; ← Follows from *A picket's boast names the third and fifth regiments*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *Word of the rationed capital reaches the besieged town*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

127. ← Follows from *The capital's lamp-houses rationed*, 21 an t-Ògmhios, DE 21; ← Follows from *old Fraser counts the smoke on the southern ridge*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *The last pit-head's line gives way*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

128. ← Follows from *The siege of Muileann àrsaidh*, 21 an Cèitean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Word of the rationed capital reaches the besieged town*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *Tom Varley leaves for Cnoc thais*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *Tom Varley leaves for Cnoc thais* (Muileann àrsaidh). As Muileann àrsaidh falls Tom Varley slips out by the hill path toward Cnoc thais, meaning to see his own shaft there fired by his own hand before any regiment comes near it.¹²⁹
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *Sarah Dunmore opens her own door* (Muileann àrsaidh). With no line left anywhere in the town to hold, Sarah Dunmore opens her own door to the soldiers before they can open it for her, and is searched and let be.¹³⁰
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *Meikle's rationing* (Muileann àrsaidh). Through Sèist Muileann àrsaidh¹³¹ Meikle keeps the town's counting: a set weight of meal to a household by the week and a set weight of coal to a hearth by the day.¹³²
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *The children's game of the six pit-heads* (Muileann àrsaidh). Children of besieged Muileann àrsaidh play a game chanting the names of the six pit-heads, slapping a hand down at each as it is lost.¹³³
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *The eastern pit-head given up* (Muileann àrsaidh). On Tom Varley's counsel the besieged give up the eastern pit-head of Muileann àrsaidh without a fight, the ground about it too wide to hold without stripping the wall.¹³⁴
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *An còigeamh rèisimeid*¹³⁵ *musters on the harbour wall* (Seann Warr). An còigeamh rèisimeid musters on the harbour wall at Seann Warr, there being no ground inside the walls wide enough for its companies to stand in line.¹³⁶
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *The first family reaches Doire ghlas* (Doire ghlas). A woman, three children and her husband's father, too lame to walk the whole road, reach Ellen Marsh's own gate at Doire ghlas out of the western hills, the first of a trickle that will not stop by the year's end. They say only the town's name, Àth leathan, and no more.¹³⁷

129. ← Follows from *The siege of Muileann àrsaidh*, 21 an Cèitean, DE 21; ← Follows from *The last pit-head's line gives way*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *Sarah Dunmore opens her own door*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

130. ← Follows from *The siege of Muileann àrsaidh*, 21 an Cèitean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Tom Varley leaves for Cnoc thais*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *Meikle's rationing*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

131. the siege of Muileann àrsaidh

132. ← Follows from *The siege of Muileann àrsaidh*, 21 an Cèitean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Sarah Dunmore opens her own door*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *The children's game of the six pit-heads*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

133. ← Follows from *The siege of Muileann àrsaidh*, 21 an Cèitean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Meikle's rationing*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *The eastern pit-head given up*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

134. ← Follows from *The siege of Muileann àrsaidh*, 21 an Cèitean, DE 21; ← Follows from *The children's game of the six pit-heads*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *An còigeamh rèisimeid musters on the harbour wall*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

135. the fifth regiment

136. ← Follows from *An còigeamh rèisimeid raised*, 13 an t-Ògmhios, DE 21; ← Follows from *The eastern pit-head given up*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

137. ← Follows from *Families at Caol mhòr*, 29 an t-Ògmhios, DE 21; ← Leads to *The eleven of Muileann àrsaidh*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21 — *The eleven of Muileann àrsaidh* (Muileann àrsaidh). Eleven souls of three farms near Muileann àrsaidh leave together in the night before the ditch-bridge falls, judging a siege at hand and choosing the road north over the ring that is about to close. They reach Doire ghlas and Caol mhòr within the fortnight.¹³⁸
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21 — *Àth leathan's pits given as flooded* (Àth leathan). A woman of Àth leathan tells Ellen Marsh plainly, in the humans' tongue and then in Dia-thìris, that her town's pits were flooded by the regiments' own order within a day of the fighting's end, so that nothing is left there for her household to return to.¹³⁹
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21 — *Hugh Ferris's wage-ledger* (Doire ghlas). An old hewer of Àth leathan, forty years at the coal and ten more keeper of the pit-shed's tallies, carries away under his coat the ledger of wages owed him rather than any clothing or food, and gives it to Ellen Marsh to keep beside her own books.¹⁴⁰
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21 — *Martha Greaves writes to an Leabharlann*¹⁴¹ (Caol mhòr). Martha Greaves writes to Sileas nic Rath at Muileann chaol, not to ask anything of an Leabharlann but to set down, outside her own kitchen table, that Tional nan Tuathach¹⁴² has fed the west's hungry while the council has sent nothing north and forbidden nothing.¹⁴³
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21 — *Thomas Rook's register begun* (Caol mhòr). Thomas Rook rules a plain ledger into columns, name, town of origin, family and taken in, and keeps it from the first week of the families' coming. By the end of an Cèitean he counts three hundred and forty souls taken in at Caol mhòr and Doire ghlas together.¹⁴⁴
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21 — *William Reid questions the promise's floor* (Caol mhòr). At a sitting called out of the calendar, the eastern delegate William Reid asks the room whether it has considered that a promise to feed the west's people indefinitely was made without knowing how long the feeding would be needed. Martha Greaves answers that the not knowing excuses nothing.¹⁴⁵

138. ← Follows from *Families at Caol mhòr*, 29 an t-Ògmhios, DE 21; ← Follows from *The first family reaches Doire ghlas*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *Àth leathan's pits given as flooded*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

139. ← Follows from *Families at Caol mhòr*, 29 an t-Ògmhios, DE 21; ← Follows from *The eleven of Muileann àrsaidh*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *Hugh Ferris's wage-ledger*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

140. ← Follows from *Families at Caol mhòr*, 29 an t-Ògmhios, DE 21; ← Follows from *Àth leathan's pits given as flooded*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *Martha Greaves writes to an Leabharlann*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

141. the Library at Muileann chaol

142. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

143. ← Follows from *The Moot's granaries opened*, 17 an t-Iuchar, DE 21; ← Follows from *Hugh Ferris's wage-ledger*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *Thomas Rook's register begun*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

144. ← Follows from *The Moot's granaries opened*, 17 an t-Iuchar, DE 21; ← Follows from *Martha Greaves writes to an Leabharlann*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *William Reid questions the promise's floor*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

145. ← Follows from *The Moot's granaries opened*, 17 an t-Iuchar, DE 21; ← Follows from *Thomas Rook's register begun*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *Ellen Marsh's twelfth book begun*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *Ellen Marsh's twelfth book begun* (Doire ghlas). Ellen Marsh begins, without quite deciding to begin it, a twelfth book, kept in Dia-thiris as her eleven before it, of what the war's families tell her in the school's hall of an evening: not a life's telling saved up, but the sharp particular things a mind cannot help keeping.¹⁴⁶
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *The families name the war-book* (Doire ghlas). The families sheltered under Agnes Pike's roof come, within the first month, to call Ellen Marsh's new book the war-book among themselves, and bring things to it the way a thing is brought to be weighed, whether or not she ever asked them for a telling.¹⁴⁷
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *Hugh Ferris's account of the pit-shed* (Doire ghlas). The old hewer of Àth leathan gives Ellen Marsh, for the war-book, an exact accounting of the pit-shed where Ruth Calder once read out the agreement of the five towns, believing it flooded or fallen, and wishing it set down once more before it goes under.¹⁴⁸
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *A child gives Ruth Calder's name* (Doire ghlas). A girl of the Muileann àrsaidh eleven asks Ellen Marsh to set Ruth Calder's name in the war-book, though she has, by her own word, nothing true to give beside it: only what her mother says of a name dropped from every list the kingdom keeps since the spring.¹⁴⁹
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *Nell Forbes's dresser* (Doire ghlas). A woman of Àth leathan sheltering at Doire ghlas tells Ellen Marsh that she thinks more often of the kitchen dresser she left with the plates on it than of the house itself.¹⁵⁰
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *A harbour boy's word on begging* (Caol mhòr). A harbourmaster's boy of Caol mhòr tells the speaker of Tional nan Tuathach¹⁵¹, repeating his father, that Tional nan Tuathach will beggar itself feeding the western hills and serve the council right.¹⁵²
- I AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *Seed-corn sent west from Caol mhòr* (Caol mhòr). Tional nan Tuathach¹⁵³ sends seed-corn from the stores at Caol mhòr to the farms of the western hills that fed the column's families, entered in the roll as a loan with no term.¹⁵⁴

146. ← Follows from *Agnes Pike's school as a shelter*, 25 an t-Iuchar, DE 21; ← Follows from *William Reid questions the promise's floor*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *The families name the war-book*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

147. ← Follows from *Agnes Pike's school as a shelter*, 25 an t-Iuchar, DE 21; ← Follows from *Ellen Marsh's twelfth book begun*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *Hugh Ferris's account of the pit-shed*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

148. ← Follows from *Agnes Pike's school as a shelter*, 25 an t-Iuchar, DE 21; ← Follows from *The families name the war-book*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *A child gives Ruth Calder's name*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

149. ← Follows from *Agnes Pike's school as a shelter*, 25 an t-Iuchar, DE 21; ← Follows from *Hugh Ferris's account of the pit-shed*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *Nell Forbes's dresser*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

150. ← Follows from *Agnes Pike's school as a shelter*, 25 an t-Iuchar, DE 21; ← Follows from *A child gives Ruth Calder's name*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *A harbour boy's word on begging*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

151. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

152. ← Follows from *The Moot's granaries opened*, 17 an t-Iuchar, DE 21; ← Follows from *Nell Forbes's dresser*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *Seed-corn sent west from Caol mhòr*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

153. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

154. ← Follows from *Families at Caol mhòr*, 29 an t-Ògmhios, DE 21; ← Follows from *A harbour boy's word on begging*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *Meal from Cnoc ghorrm for Doire ghlas*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

- 1 **AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *Meal from Cnoc ghorm for Doire ghlas* (Cnoc ghorm). The Tuathaich of Cnoc ghorm send three carts of meal down to Doire ghlas for the western families in Agnes Pike's school, the carters asking no receipt.¹⁵⁵
- 1 **AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *Doire shean's market-clerk counts the tithe* (Doire shean). At Doire shean the market-clerk, who keeps the new count and the old side by side, keeps a third column now for the tithe paid at the harbour pump.¹⁵⁶
- 2 **AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *Cnoc thais taken* (Cnoc thais). Cnoc thais is taken after the regiments cut the road to its pits. Tom Varley's two shafts are fired and sealed. The open record gives the number of holdouts taken, and not the number who went on into the hills.¹⁵⁷
- 10 **AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *Onto the windy coast* (Cnoc thais). Some of the holdouts of Cnoc thais go on beyond the hills and out onto the windy coast of the far north-west. The regiments follow them to the edge of the shire of Seann Vell and no farther. The open record names them, as it names every foe of the war, only as those 'of no shire'.
- 23 **AN T-SULTAIN, DE 21** — *An dàrna cabhlach*¹⁵⁸ *raised* (Seann Skell). The second fleet is raised at Seann Skell on the southern coast, to keep the eastern and southern waters while the first and fourth are in the north-west.
- 2 **AN DÀMHAIR, DE 21** — *Raiders take the salt-boats* (Spùinneadairean-mara). With the fleets drawn to the north-west, raiders from the eastern waters take two salt-boats off Àth bheag and burn a third. The second fleet runs down one of the raiders off Baile iséal.
- 17 **AN DÀMHAIR, DE 21** — *An siathamh rèisimeid*¹⁵⁹ *raised* (Cnoc bheag). The sixth regiment is raised at Cnoc bheag, the great river port of the Hawk houses in the north-central country. It holds the northern road between the Tuathaich shires and the middle of the island, and the Hawk houses bless its colours by their own rite.
- 25 **AN DÀMHAIR, DE 21** — *An dàrna rèisimeid*¹⁶⁰ *raised* (Àth dhìreach). The second regiment is raised at Àth dhìreach in the east and set to guard the coal line and the library road. Its camp is the first soldiery the town of Muileann chaol has seen.
- 2 **AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 21** — *An ceathramh rèisimeid*¹⁶¹ *raised* (Caol bheag). The fourth regiment is raised at Caol bheag in the north-east. It goes down the Abhainn ghorm to Ros chiar, is shipped west round the north coast in hired dubhan hulls, and is landed at Ceann mhòr in the Tuathaich north.

155. ← Follows from *Agnes Pike's school as a shelter*, 25 an t-Iuchar, DE 21; ← Follows from *Seed-corn sent west from Caol mhòr*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Leads to *Doire shean's market-clerk counts the tithe*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

156. ← Follows from *The wartime tithe*, 21 an Giblean, DE 21; ← Follows from *Meal from Cnoc ghorm for Doire ghlas*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

157. → Caused by *Tom Varley leaves for Cnoc thais*, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

158. the second fleet

159. the sixth regiment

160. the second regiment

161. the fourth regiment

- 10 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 21** — *The regiments at Ceann mhòr* (Ceann mhòr). The fourth regiment is quartered at Ceann mhòr, in the old human magistrate's house that the maor has kept since the shires were drawn. The Moot protests the quartering. The protest is received.
- 15 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 21** — *The fishermen of Cathair gheal* (Cathair gheal). The fleets off the north-west search the fishing boats of Cathair gheal on every day they put out. The fishermen petition the Moot, and the Moot petitions the council. The searching goes on.
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 21** — *An t-ochdamh rèisimeid*¹⁶² *raised* (Inis uaine). The eighth regiment is raised at Inis uaine on the Abhainn chaol in the east, to guard the dubhan depots and tanks of the eastern ports, which the council fears the holdouts may fire.
- 1 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *An treas cabhlach*¹⁶³ *raised* (Baile ghorm). The third fleet is raised at Baile ghorm on the south-west coast, and carries the army's dubhan up the west coast in tank-hulls to the regiments in the hills.
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *The Baile chrom vigil* (Baile chrom). The Grey Night sect at Baile chrom keeps its vigil as always. The regiments quartered along the coast report a night when the whole town was dark and silent; they search it, and find nothing.
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Àth naomh and Tobar dhearg* (Àth naomh). The last two western towns, Àth naomh and Tobar dhearg, open their roads to the regiments without a siege. Their pits are flooded. The open record names no holdouts taken at either.
- 18 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Tom Varley reckons the powder for his own shafts* (Cnoc thais). In the last week of an Cèitean, with the road below Cnoc thais already cut, Tom Varley and Angus Rennie's cousin work out by lamplight how much powder will bring the lower galleries down clean and how much less would only crack the timbering.¹⁶⁴
- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *A shepherd's path left unwatched* (Cnoc thais). The regiment below Cnoc thais spends the better part of a month digging and drilling before it finds a shepherd's path along the northern ridge too steep for anything but goats, which the town's own watchers had judged not worth the watching.¹⁶⁵
- 20 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Tom Varley fires his own two shafts* (Cnoc thais). Tom Varley goes down each shaft alone in the grey hour and fires the charges himself, refusing another man's offer to do it, and stands at the shaft-head afterward watching the smoke come up thin against a low sky.¹⁶⁶

162. the eighth regiment

163. the third fleet

164. ← Follows from *Cnoc thais taken*, 2 an Lùnastal, DE 21.

165. ← Follows from *Cnoc thais taken*, 2 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Follows from *Tom Varley reckons the powder for his own shafts*, 18 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

166. ← Follows from *Cnoc thais taken*, 2 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Follows from *A shepherd's path left unwatched*, 19 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Forty-one taken at Cnoc thais* (Cnoc thais). The regiment's muster gives forty-one holdouts marched south as prisoners from Cnoc thais; it gives no figure for those already gone up into the hills by paths the shepherd had not shown the soldiers.¹⁶⁷
- 22 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Tom Varley takes the rabbit path* (Cnoc thais). Tom Varley leaves the falling town by a path he last walked as a boy after rabbits, with five other hewers who choose, each in his own time, to take it rather than stand and be taken.¹⁶⁸
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *A warning at the shielings*. On the second night out, sitting at a small fire among the summer shielings, one of Tom Varley's party argues that the near hills will not be let stand a season longer, and the others find no better guess to set against him.¹⁶⁹
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Seven parties on an Oirthir Ghaothach*¹⁷⁰. Word passes between separate handfuls out of Cnoc thais, the last of Muileann àrsaidh's scattered folk and one party out of Àth naomh, until seven parties in all, somewhat short of two hundred souls, sit on the same stretch of unclaimed ground.¹⁷¹
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Cairstine's coast path*. A trader named Cairstine, who has walked the coast path with salt and needles twice a year since before the war had a name, carries the season's word up to the fisherfolk and the seven parties both.¹⁷²
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *An dàrna cabhlach*¹⁷³'s raising told on an Oirthir Ghaothach¹⁷⁴ (Seann Skell). Cairstine tells Tom Varley's fire that An dàrna cabhlach was raised that season at the southern Seann Skell out of the harbour towns and Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail¹⁷⁵'s own boatmen, to hold water that had stood quiet a generation.¹⁷⁶
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *The burned boat's crew put ashore* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal¹⁷⁷). The crew of the salt-boat burned off Àth bheag are put ashore some days after at the light of Baile ìseal, with nothing left of a season's work but the clothes they stand up in.¹⁷⁸

167. ← Follows from *Cnoc thais taken*, 2 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Follows from *Tom Varley fires his own two shafts*, 20 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

168. ← Follows from *Cnoc thais taken*, 2 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Follows from *Forty-one taken at Cnoc thais*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

169. ← Follows from *Onto the windy coast*, 10 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Follows from *Tom Varley takes the rabbit path*, 22 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

170. the windy coast

171. ← Follows from *Onto the windy coast*, 10 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Follows from *A warning at the shielings*, 23 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *Cairstine's coast path*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

172. ← Follows from *An dàrna cabhlach raised*, 23 an t-Sultain, DE 21; ← Follows from *Seven parties on an Oirthir Ghaothach*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *An dàrna cabhlach's raising told on an Oirthir Ghaothach*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

173. the second fleet

174. the windy coast

175. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

176. ← Follows from *An dàrna cabhlach raised*, 23 an t-Sultain, DE 21; ← Follows from *Cairstine's coast path*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *The burned boat's crew put ashore*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

177. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *A fisherman's word on the door left open* (Baile iséal). A fisherman of Baile iséal tells Cairistine that a kingdom which shuts a door on nothing much will find another door, one it did not think to watch, standing open behind it, and she carries the saying north with the rest of the season's news.¹⁷⁹
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Tom Varley's private tally*. Through the autumn Tom Varley keeps, unwritten, a tally in his own head of the men who came out of Cnoc thais with him, the men the regiment marched south, and a field left unploughed below Àth leathan he cannot yet set down as finished.¹⁸⁰
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *The first evening at the edge of the sea*. In the last clear evening before the hard weather turns, Tom Varley stands on a strand of black shingle at the edge of an Oirthir Ghaothach¹⁸¹ and watches the light go out of the sky without any sunset to mark the day's end.¹⁸²
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Mary Kessock's two ends* (Cnoc thais). At the council of Cnoc thais in the chapel room an old widow, Mary Kessock, says a town threatened by soldiers it cannot fight may be taken whole or leave the takers nothing and go. The room begins to make ready to leave.¹⁸³
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Mary Kessock stays at her door* (Cnoc thais). When Cnoc thais falls, the old widow Mary Kessock stays at her own door and raises a hand to Tom Varley as he goes up the rabbit path.¹⁸⁴
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *A hind brought down on an Oirthir Ghaothach*¹⁸⁵ (Cnoc thais). On the walk to an Oirthir Ghaothach a man of Àth naomh brings down a hind with a single cast of the spear he had carried from his own town.¹⁸⁶

178. ← Follows from *Raiders take the salt-boats*, 2 an Dàmhair, DE 21; ← Follows from *An dàrna cabhlach's raising told on an Oirthir Ghaothach*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *A fisherman's word on the door left open*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

179. ← Follows from *Raiders take the salt-boats*, 2 an Dàmhair, DE 21; ← Follows from *The burned boat's crew put ashore*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *Tom Varley's private tally*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

180. ← Follows from *Onto the windy coast*, 10 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Follows from *A fisherman's word on the door left open*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *The first evening at the edge of the sea*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

181. the windy coast

182. ← Follows from *Onto the windy coast*, 10 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Follows from *Tom Varley's private tally*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *Mary Kessock's two ends*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

183. ← Follows from *Cnoc thais taken*, 2 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Follows from *The first evening at the edge of the sea*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *Mary Kessock stays at her door*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

184. ← Follows from *Cnoc thais taken*, 2 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Follows from *Mary Kessock's two ends*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *A hind brought down on an Oirthir Ghaothach*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

185. the windy coast

186. ← Follows from *Onto the windy coast*, 10 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Follows from *Mary Kessock stays at her door*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *Calum Odhar's byre*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Calum Odhar's byre* (Cnoc thais). A widower of an Oirthir Ghaothach¹⁸⁷, Calum Odhar, who fishes a two-man boat out of a cove with no name, gives the byre behind his house to the six men of Cnoc thais and asks only whether they can mend a net.¹⁸⁸
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Cnoc bhàn's harbour shut to strangers* (Cnoc bhàn). The Tuathaich of Cnoc bhàn shut their harbour to boats they do not know through the autumn, fearing raiders with the fleets drawn to the north-west, and turn away a Dia-threach trader with a load of salt.¹⁸⁹
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh watches the camp from her garden wall* (Àth dhìreach). Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh, retired at Àth dhìreach, watches An dàrna rèisimeid¹⁹⁰'s camp rise from her own garden wall and is asked by its young captain whether the wall marks ground his picket line needs; it does not. She notes the town gives the company no trouble and is given none.¹⁹¹
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh writes to Sileas nic Rath of the camp* (Àth dhìreach). Beathag writes to Sileas nic Rath that she trusts her own eyes on a garden wall better than she ever let herself trust the reports that once reached her desk from towns she had never stood in. The line is struck through once and left to stand, the ink thin enough to read beneath it.¹⁹²
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *The fourth marches down to the river* (Caol bheag). An ceathramh rèisimeid¹⁹³ marches from Caol bheag to the river on a frosted morning, the whole town turned out along the road. Corporal Dùghall mac Iain's own mother stands at the mill corner and says nothing at all as he passes, which he takes, without either of them saying it, for the greater kindness.¹⁹⁴

187. the windy coast

188. ← Follows from *Onto the windy coast*, 10 an Lùnastal, DE 21; ← Follows from *A hind brought down on an Oirthir Ghaothach*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *Cnoc bhàn's harbour shut to strangers*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

189. ← Follows from *Raiders take the salt-boats*, 2 an Dàmhair, DE 21; ← Follows from *Calum Odhar's byre*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

190. the second regiment

191. ← Follows from *An dàrna rèisimeid raised*, 25 an Dàmhair, DE 21; ← Leads to *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh writes to Sileas nic Rath of the camp*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

192. ← Follows from *An dàrna rèisimeid raised*, 25 an Dàmhair, DE 21; ← Follows from *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh watches the camp from her garden wall*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *The fourth marches down to the river*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

193. the fourth regiment

194. ← Follows from *An ceathramh rèisimeid raised*, 2 an t-Samhain, DE 21; ← Follows from *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh writes to Sileas nic Rath of the camp*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *The fourth's voyage down the Abhainn ghorm*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21 — *The fourth's voyage down the Abhainn ghorm* (Caol bheag). An ceathramh rèisimeid¹⁹⁵ goes down the Abhainn ghorm to Ros chiar in refitted coal barges, the two days' journey the maps had promised done in a day and a half on the autumn spate, the barge-men steering more than rowing, the men passing the crossing in games, arguments and a harvest song none of them had thought to sing.¹⁹⁶

24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21 — *The hired bulls put out from Ros chiar* (Ros chiar). An ceathramh rèisimeid¹⁹⁷'s hired dubhan hulls put out from Ros chiar into a turning sea, five days round the north cape with the tanks below decks giving off a smell that does not leave the men's kit for weeks. A boy of the second company goes overboard reaching for a loosed line and is hauled back half-drowned.¹⁹⁸

24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21 — *One bull parts company off the north cape* (Ceann mhòr). In the worst of the second night's weather one of An ceathramh rèisimeid¹⁹⁹'s hired hulls is separated from the rest, puts into a cove on the far side of the north cape, and loses two days finding the others again, reaching Ceann mhòr three days behind the rest with crew and cargo whole.²⁰⁰

24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21 — *The maor of Ceann mhòr gives up his house* (Ceann mhòr). The maor of Ceann mhòr gives up the greater part of the old human magistrate's house to An ceathramh rèisimeid²⁰¹ without complaint, moving his own household into its two upper rooms, and takes afterwards to walking their narrow gallery of an evening remarking to whichever officer passes below that the army has undone in a fortnight what forty winters of sea air had not.²⁰²

24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21 — *The maor's clerk keeps the two tongues apart* (Ceann mhòr). The maor of Ceann mhòr's clerk, a Tuathaich woman of long service, addresses An ceathramh rèisimeid²⁰³'s captain in Dia-thìris without a stumble and her own townsfolk, on the office's business, in the humans' tongue alone, the two tongues kept, in her own ordering of things, for two entirely different kinds of transaction.²⁰⁴

195. the fourth regiment

196. ← Follows from *An ceathramh rèisimeid raised*, 2 an t-Samhain, DE 21; ← Follows from *The fourth marches down to the river*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *The hired bulls put out from Ros chiar*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

197. the fourth regiment

198. ← Follows from *An ceathramh rèisimeid raised*, 2 an t-Samhain, DE 21; ← Follows from *The fourth's voyage down the Abhainn ghorm*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *One bull parts company off the north cape*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

199. the fourth regiment

200. ← Follows from *An ceathramh rèisimeid raised*, 2 an t-Samhain, DE 21; ← Follows from *The hired bulls put out from Ros chiar*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *The maor of Ceann mhòr gives up his house*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

201. the fourth regiment

202. ← Follows from *The regiments at Ceann mhòr*, 10 an t-Samhain, DE 21; ← Follows from *One bull parts company off the north cape*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *The maor's clerk keeps the two tongues apart*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

203. the fourth regiment

- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Martha Greaves's letter reaches the magistrate's house* (Ceann mhòr). Martha Greaves's single sheet asking that An ceathramh rèisimeid²⁰⁵ be lodged at its own charge and not the town's is carried up the coast road and read aloud by the fourth's own captain to his assembled company. It is received and forwarded; Comhairle nam Mèin-nean²⁰⁶'s late reply says only that the arrangement stands until the campaign's needs change it.²⁰⁷
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *The Cathair gheal petition folded into a barrel of cod* (Cathair gheal). The fishermen of Cathair gheal draw up their petition on the quay before the boats go out, setting down only the days the searching has run and the hours a boat is commonly held, and send it to Caol mhòr folded inside a barrel of salt cod consigned, quite genuinely, to Tìonal nan Tuathach²⁰⁸'s own stores.²⁰⁹
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Dùghall bears the petition told as a soldier's tale* (Ceann mhòr). A corporal of An dàrna cabhlach²¹⁰, billeted a night at Ceann mhòr, tells Dùghall mac Iain the tale of the fish-barrel petition over their shared supper as dry entertainment and nothing graver, a story a searching soldier keeps by him for its comedy rather than its weight.²¹¹
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Dùghall billeted on Barbara Keir of Ceann mhòr* (Ceann mhòr). Once the magistrate's house is full past stretching, the maor's clerk billets Corporal Dùghall mac Iain on a widow of the town named Barbara Keir, who keeps a loom in the room behind her kitchen; she opens her door to him with no more welcome than the clerk's own list had shown in its writing.²¹²

204. ← Follows from *The regiments at Ceann mhòr*, 10 an t-Samhain, DE 21; ← Follows from *The maor of Ceann mhòr gives up his house*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *Martha Greaves's letter reaches the magistrate's house*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

205. the fourth regiment

206. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

207. ← Follows from *The regiments at Ceann mhòr*, 10 an t-Samhain, DE 21; ← Follows from *The maor's clerk keeps the two tongues apart*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *The Cathair gheal petition folded into a barrel of cod*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

208. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

209. ← Follows from *The fishermen of Cathair gheal*, 15 an t-Samhain, DE 21; ← Follows from *Martha Greaves's letter reaches the magistrate's house*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *Dùghall bears the petition told as a soldier's tale*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

210. the second fleet

211. ← Follows from *The fishermen of Cathair gheal*, 15 an t-Samhain, DE 21; ← Follows from *The Cathair gheal petition folded into a barrel of cod*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *Dùghall billeted on Barbara Keir of Ceann mhòr*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

212. ← Follows from *The regiments at Ceann mhòr*, 10 an t-Samhain, DE 21; ← Follows from *Dùghall bears the petition told as a soldier's tale*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *The tongue Barbara Keir will not give him*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21 — *The tongue Barbara Keir will not give him* (Ceann mhòr).

Barbara answers Corporal Dùghall mac Iain readily in Dia-thìris on the house's own business, but gives him, try as he may, not one word of the humans' tongue, though he hears her speak it easily across the yard wall to a neighbour; he comes to understand it a door shut on him alone.²¹³

24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21 — *The barges of the Abhainn ghorm* (Caol bheag). An ceathramh rèisimeid²¹⁴ goes down the Abhainn ghorm from Caol bheag to Ros chiar in old coal barges fitted with plank benches, the river high with rain, in a day and a half.²¹⁵**24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Comhairle nam Mèinnean*²¹⁶ *answers Tional nan Tuathach*²¹⁷ *on the quartering* (Ceann mhòr). Near the year's end Comhairle nam Mèinnean answers Tional nan Tuathach's protest against the quartering at Ceann mhòr that the arrangement stands until the campaign's needs change it.²¹⁸**24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *An siathambh rèisimeid*²¹⁹ *drills by the carved stone* (Cnoc bheag). An siathambh rèisimeid, raised at Cnoc bheag, drills in the square beside the carved stone, and the town's children learn the words of command before the recruits do.²²⁰**24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Baile ghorm's quays given to An treas cabhlach*²²¹ (Baile ghorm). At its raising An treas cabhlach takes the wolf-post quays of Baile ghorm for its own; the fishing boats are moved to the old beach and their pump with them.²²²**24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *An treas cabhlach*²²³ *'s first tank-hull reaches Ceann mhòr* (Ceann mhòr). A week after its raising at Baile ghorm An treas cabhlach's first tank-hull, her number chalked on her bow for want of a name, comes into Ceann mhòr with the army's dubhan. Her master, Griogair, a fisherman of Baile ghorm forty years, talks with Corporal Dùghall mac Iain on the quay through the unloading.²²⁴

213. ← Follows from *The regiments at Ceann mhòr*, 10 an t-Samhain, DE 21; ← Follows from *Dùghall billeted on Barbara Keir of Ceann mhòr*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *The barges of the Abhainn ghorm*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

214. the fourth regiment

215. ← Follows from *An ceathramh rèisimeid raised*, 2 an t-Samhain, DE 21; ← Follows from *The tongue Barbara Keir will not give him*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *Comhairle nam Mèinnean answers Tional nan Tuathach on the quartering*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

216. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

217. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

218. ← Follows from *The regiments at Ceann mhòr*, 10 an t-Samhain, DE 21; ← Follows from *The barges of the Abhainn ghorm*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *An siathambh rèisimeid drills by the carved stone*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

219. the sixth regiment

220. ← Follows from *An siathambh rèisimeid raised*, 17 an Dàmhair, DE 21; ← Follows from *Comhairle nam Mèinnean answers Tional nan Tuathach on the quartering*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *Baile ghorm's quays given to An treas cabhlach*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

221. the third fleet

222. ← Follows from *An treas cabhlach raised*, 1 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Follows from *An siathambh rèisimeid drills by the carved stone*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

223. the third fleet

- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Dùghall billeted on Barbara* (Ceann mhòr). At Ceann mhòr Dùghall mac Iain is billeted on a Tuathaich widow named Barbara, who feeds him at her own table and answers him only in Dia-thiris, though he hears her, of an evening, singing at her loom in the humans' tongue she will not use to speak to him directly.²²⁵
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *A file sent north to Baile chrom* (Ceann mhòr). An ceathramh rèisimeid²²⁶ sends Corporal Dùghall mac Iain and six men on the two days' coast road to Baile chrom, a bent headland town no patrol of the regiment has yet troubled to search, with orders to look for arms and for men of the western hills and to bring back a report.²²⁷
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *The watched mill on the coast road*. On the march north the file passes a mill and two farms whose people watch them from their doorways and say nothing, a silence the soldier Cailean judges more telling, in its own way, than any shout a Dia-threach farm on the same road would have raised.²²⁸
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *The town found dark and silent* (Baile chrom). Dùghall mac Iain's file comes into Baile chrom after dark on the eve of Oidhche Glaise²²⁹ to find no lamp lit, no dog loosed and every door unlatched; house after house holds a family sitting hands folded round a cold hearth, answering nothing but a single slow headshake.²³⁰
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Margaret Crane keeps the vigil alone* (Baile chrom). In the house nearest the lighthouse road an old woman named Margaret Crane sits alone keeping Oidhche Glaise²³¹ as she has kept it since before the war, gives Dùghall mac Iain her name and leave to search, and tells him nothing more; a soldier of his own file sets his lamp down outside her door rather than carry its light past her.²³²
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *The regimental clerk's question*. Copying Dùghall mac Iain's report fair at the bothy, the file's young clerk asks whether there is more to the night than its three written lines; Dùghall tells him there is not, and keeps the headshakes and the cold hearths out of the regiment's own returns.²³³

224. ← Follows from *An treas cabblach raised*, 1 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *Dùghall billeted on Barbara*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

225. ← Follows from *An ceathramh rèisimeid raised*, 2 an t-Samhain, DE 21; ← Follows from *An treas cabblach's first tank-bull reaches Ceann mhòr*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *A file sent north to Baile chrom*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

226. the fourth regiment

227. ← Follows from *The Baile chrom vigil*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Follows from *Dùghall billeted on Barbara*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *The watched mill on the coast road*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

228. ← Follows from *The Baile chrom vigil*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Follows from *A file sent north to Baile chrom*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *The town found dark and silent*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

229. the Grey Night

230. ← Follows from *The Baile chrom vigil*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Follows from *The watched mill on the coast road*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *Margaret Crane keeps the vigil alone*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

231. the Grey Night

232. ← Follows from *The Baile chrom vigil*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Follows from *The town found dark and silent*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *The regimental clerk's question*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

233. ← Follows from *The Baile chrom vigil*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Follows from *Margaret Crane keeps the vigil alone*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *Barbara on the flooded pits*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Barbara on the flooded pits* (Ceann mhòr). Dùghall mac Iain mentions the flooding of Àth naomh's pits to Barbara over her evening table; she answers only, in Dia-thiris, that a pit flooded is a pit flooded whichever order floods it, and takes up her mending again in the silence he has learned by then not to press.²³⁴
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Dùghall's sleepless winter* (Ceann mhòr). Through the short days that follow, Dùghall mac Iain wakes most nights with the sea-sound of the Baile chrom headland in his ears, unable in either tongue he carries to find words for a stillness that asked nothing of him and gave him nothing to answer with.²³⁵
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *The file sent round by the headland farms* (Baile chrom). Corporal Dùghall mac Iain's file of six is sent to Baile chrom by way of the headland farms, sleeping a night in an empty drover's bothy on the way.²³⁶
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Cailean says the house searched him back* (Baile chrom). Marching back from Baile chrom, a soldier named Cailean says he has never come away from a search feeling the house had searched him back, and would not go north again.²³⁷
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *The ninth's raising read at Ceann mhòr* (Ceann mhòr). Two days after an Nollaig²³⁸ the raising of An naoidheamh rèisimeid²³⁹ at the southern Seann Skell is read out in An ceathramh rèisimeid²⁴⁰'s guardroom at Ceann mhòr.²⁴¹
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *An naoidheamh rèisimeid²⁴² raised* (Seann Skell). The ninth regiment is raised at Seann Skell on the southern coast, the second town of that name in the regimental list, to guard the dubhan works the shipmasters built there. The regimental clerks tell the two apart by river and coast.²⁴³
- 29 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 22** — *The column goes south* (Muileann mhin). A column of holdouts, some hundreds strong, leaves the western hills and marches south-east through the middle of the island toward the capital. Why it did so is in the sealed archive. The Tuathaich tellings name its leader Owen Barrow. The open record gives no name.

234. ← Follows from *Àth naomh and Tobar dhearg*, 17 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Follows from *The regimental clerk's question*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *Dùghall's sleepless winter*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

235. ← Follows from *The Baile chrom vigil*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Follows from *Barbara on the flooded pits*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *The file sent round by the headland farms*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

236. ← Follows from *The Baile chrom vigil*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Follows from *Dùghall's sleepless winter*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *Cailean says the house searched him back*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

237. ← Follows from *The Baile chrom vigil*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Follows from *The file sent round by the headland farms*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Leads to *The ninth's raising read at Ceann mhòr*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

238. Christmas

239. the ninth regiment

240. the fourth regiment

241. ← Follows from *Cailean says the house searched him back*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

242. the ninth regiment

243. → Caused by *The ninth's raising read at Ceann mhòr*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

- 24 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 22** — *The column's road* (Àth bheag). The column's road south-east runs by Àth bheag in the west, Muileann mhin and the edge of the capital's country. The towns it passes report it, and the open record copies their reports and not the regiments'.
- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *The camp by Muileann ghlais* (Muileann ghlais). The column passes Muileann òg and camps on the fields by Muileann ghlais, a day's walk from Cathair dhearg. The first and third regiments are brought down the fair road to meet it.
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *The fair-ground emptied* (Fèill Muileann òg²⁴⁴). The fair-ground at Muileann òg is cleared of its standing booths to give the first and third regiments room to camp. The books of its court for that year end with no closing entry.
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *Battle of Muileann ghlais* (Àraich Muileann ghlais²⁴⁵). The second great battle of the war, and the last. In two summers of fighting the Tuathaich hold-outs are broken: children of the humans once driven to the island's edge, driven back again, and this time by a fuel that one of their own devised.
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *The field at Muileann ghlais* (Àraich Muileann ghlais²⁴⁶). The open record lists the first and third regiments on the field at Muileann ghlais and gives no count of the column's dead. The regiments' own dead are named on a stone at Cathair mhòr, set up the next year.
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *The last pits give up* (Àraich Àth leathan²⁴⁷). Word of Muileann ghlais reaches the hills, and the holdouts still there come down to the posts of the seventh regiment on the Àth leathan road. They are disarmed and sent home. The open record counts their weapons.
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *An Cogadh Fada*²⁴⁸ ends. The Long War ends. Nine regiments and four fleets were raised in it, each named for the town where it is stationed, and all of them stand to this day.
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *Fadachadh* (Caol mhòr). Among Tuathaich speakers 'chaidh am fadachadh', they got long-warred, begins to be said of the defeat in the west, and then of any defeat after holding out too long. It is said as a jest, and those who say it do not laugh.
- 11 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *The pass at the Caol mhòr steps* (Caol mhòr). Comhairle nam Mèinnean²⁴⁹'s office begins issuing a small paper against a name, a face and a stated errand for anyone at Caol mhòr who means to leave the harbour road; the town takes to calling it simply the pass, and Martha Greaves comes to show her own to the same soldier three times that spring on Moot business.²⁵⁰

244. the fair at Muileann òg

245. the battlefield of Muileann ghlais

246. the battlefield of Muileann ghlais

247. the battlefield of Àth leathan

248. the Long War

249. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

250. ← Follows from *An naoidbeamb rèisimeid raised*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

12 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22 — *Joe Ashby's boats searched again* (Caol mhòr). A patrol captain boards every hull at Caol mhòr's harbour wall in the last week of an Cèitean, the engine-boats last and most carefully; Joe Ashby, watching from his shed door, tells him plainly that no guild in the harbour would give him leave to fit them, and the captain writes it down without comment.²⁵¹

13 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22 — *Joe Ashby fits a fleet hull again* (Caol mhòr). Before the summer is out the depot's own men send for Joe Ashby a second time, for a hull no guild-trained fitter at Seann Skell could put right; he mends it, takes his coin at the harbour's own rate, and asks no more of the matter than the coin requires.²⁵²

14 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22 — *Tional nan Tuathach's*²⁵³ *register adds the names of Àth leathan* (Caol mhòr). Peter Hale brings Martha Greaves a list gathered from the western towns under the disarming; she enters the dead and maimed of Àth leathan into Tional nan Tuathach's register column by column, and finds Ruth Calder's own name on none of its three columns.²⁵⁴

15 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22 — *Easter kept under watch* (Doire ghlas). Martha Greaves stands at the back of Eaglais nan Tuathach's²⁵⁵ own Easter service at the chapel above Doire ghlas and finds a single soldier of the regiments posted at the door the whole length of it, writing nothing in his book, the service passing between door and altar without a word exchanged.²⁵⁶

16 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22 — *Ellen Marsh takes down the Cnoc thais women* (Doire ghlas). In the schoolroom given over the autumn before, Ellen Marsh takes down the accounts of the women of Cnoc thais bench by bench for her twelfth book, among them Peggy Innes's telling of a farm that bakes a second loaf every night and leaves it on the sill for a coming and going the disarming never ended.²⁵⁷

17 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22 — *A hill farm burned above Cnoc thais* (Cnoc thais). A patrol of the regiments finds a farm above Cnoc thais with a barn half full of grain no ration book can account for and burns the house and byre, turning the family into their own yard first; no one is killed, and Ellen Marsh sets the telling down in the same flat voice the women themselves use for it.²⁵⁸

251. ← Follows from *An naoidbeamb rèisimeid raised*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Follows from *The pass at the Caol mhòr steps*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

252. ← Follows from *An naoidbeamb rèisimeid raised*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Follows from *Joe Ashby's boats searched again*, 12 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

253. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

254. ← Follows from *An naoidbeamb rèisimeid raised*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Follows from *Joe Ashby fits a fleet hull again*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

255. the Tuathaich Church; the old congregations of the north coast

256. ← Follows from *An naoidbeamb rèisimeid raised*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Follows from *Tional nan Tuathach's register adds the names of Àth leathan*, 14 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

257. ← Follows from *An naoidbeamb rèisimeid raised*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Follows from *Easter kept under watch*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

258. ← Follows from *An naoidbeamb rèisimeid raised*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Follows from *Ellen Marsh takes down the Cnoc thais women*, 16 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

- 18 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *Ellen Marsh finishes her twelfth book* (Doire ghlas). In the first week of an Dàmhair Ellen Marsh closes the twelfth of her books of Tuathaich accounts, the one that gathers the war her first eleven never spoke of, and writes on its last leaf that she does not know which of her twelve a reader two generations off will find the harder to believe.²⁵⁹
- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *An ceathramh rèisimeid*²⁶⁰'s year of patrols on the Ceann mhòr road (Ceann mhòr). Through the whole quartered year An ceathramh rèisimeid keeps its patrols on the Ceann mhòr road, a file out at first light and in at dusk; no arms and no unaccounted man are found, and the regiment's returns settle into the same three words that closed every report of the autumn before.²⁶¹
- 20 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *Dùghall bears the hymn through the wall* (Ceann mhòr). Of an evening in an t-Sultain, Dùghall mac Iain hears through the wall of Barbara's house a hymn sung low in the humans' tongue, heavier than her shuttle-song of the autumn before; by an Dàmhair he can carry its whole shape in his head without meaning to have learned it, and catches himself humming it on the road.²⁶²
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *Cailean's own grandmother's tune* (Ceann mhòr). Dùghall mac Iain hums two bars of the learned hymn to the soldier Cailean over a cold supper; Cailean says his own grandmother kept a tune very like it, that he never asked its words either, and that a man billeted long enough on a house not his own generally carries some piece of it home in him.²⁶³
- 22 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *A rumour that will not run to ground*. Across the quartered year a single rumour passes from the Cnoc thais hill paths to the Doire ghlas schoolroom to the Ceann mhòr road, that something gathers in the western hills the disarming never reached; no regiment's patrol and no clerk's report ever explains it, and it never twice is told the same way.²⁶⁴
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *Word reaches Caol mhòr that the hills are moving* (Caol mhòr). In the last week of an Dàmhair a Board carrier rides two days without pausing to bring Caol mhòr word that some hundreds have come down out of the western hills and turned south-east across the middle of the island; Martha Greaves reads the note beside her register's own closed column on the names of Àth leathan.²⁶⁵

259. ← Follows from *An naoidbeambh rèisimeid raised*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Follows from *A bill farm burned above Cnoc thais*, 17 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

260. the fourth regiment

261. ← Follows from *An naoidbeambh rèisimeid raised*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Follows from *Ellen Marsh finishes her twelfth book*, 18 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

262. ← Follows from *An naoidbeambh rèisimeid raised*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Follows from *An ceathramh rèisimeid's year of patrols on the Ceann mhòr road*, 19 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

263. ← Follows from *An naoidbeambh rèisimeid raised*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Follows from *Dùghall bears the hymn through the wall*, 20 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

264. ← Follows from *An naoidbeambh rèisimeid raised*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Follows from *Cailean's own grandmother's tune*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

265. ← Follows from *An naoidbeambh rèisimeid raised*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21; ← Follows from *A rumour that will not run to ground*, 22 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *A burial walked to on a pass* (Caol mhòr). A carter of Caol mhòr shows his pass at the harbour steps in his mourning black to walk to his father's burial two roads inland, the office having made no separate provision for burials.²⁶⁶
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *A byre-boy's raised hand* (Ceann mhòr). On the Ceann mhòr road a boy of ten driving three cows begins, in the second season of the patrols, to lift a hand to An ceathramh rèisimeid²⁶⁷'s file as it passes.²⁶⁸
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *Bread left on a sill above Cnoc thais* (Cnoc thais). A farm two ridges back from ruined Cnoc thais bakes twice what its household can eat and leaves the second baking on the sill overnight; the loaves are gone by morning and the sill is never watched.²⁶⁹
- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *Goods carried out before the thatch was fired* (Cnoc thais). Marion Kenny tells Ellen Marsh that the family of the burned farm above Cnoc thais were given time by the patrol to carry out a chest, a loom and the year's meal before the thatch was fired.²⁷⁰
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *A clerk of Comhairle nam Mèinnean²⁷¹ counts night traffic on the hill paths* (Cnoc thais). A clerk of Comhairle nam Mèinnean stationed at Cnoc thais writes to Tional nan Tuathach²⁷² that the hill paths above the town carry more foot-traffic by night than any patrol's daylight count can explain.²⁷³
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *The passes printed at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). The passes of the northern office are printed at Cathair dhearg on grey card, ten thousand at a time, with a space for a name and none for a trade.²⁷⁴
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *A pass-office at Cnoc ghorm* (Cnoc ghorm). The northern office sets a clerk with his grey passes in the old wool-hall at Cnoc ghorm; the Tuathaich come to him one household at a time, and the elders have their own names written first.²⁷⁵
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *The regiments' lorries at Muileann fhada* (Muileann fhada). The regiments' lorries on the north road take on fuel at a pump set up in the yard of An Taigh-seinnse Reòta above Muileann fhada, the landlord renting the yard to Comhairle nam Mèinnean²⁷⁶ and keeping his wicks inside.²⁷⁷

266. ← Follows from *Word reaches Caol mhòr that the hills are moving*, 23 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

267. the fourth regiment

268. ← Follows from *A burial walked to on a pass*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

269. ← Follows from *A byre-boy's raised hand*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

270. ← Follows from *Bread left on a sill above Cnoc thais*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

271. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

272. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

273. ← Follows from *Goods carried out before the thatch was fired*, 27 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

274. ← Follows from *A clerk of Comhairle nam Mèinnean counts night traffic on the hill paths*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

275. ← Follows from *Fadachadh*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *The passes printed at Cathair dhearg*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

276. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

277. ← Follows from *A pass-office at Cnoc ghorm*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *Àth bheag's report of the ford* (Àth bheag). The maor of Àth bheag writes the fullest report of the column's road: some four hundred men forded the water below the bridge at dawn, in order, without banner or drum, and went on south without stopping.²⁷⁸
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *Sileas nic Rath keeps a file of the column's road*. Seanchaidh na Rìoghachd²⁷⁹ asks every town on the column's line for its account and is given leave to keep them, a freedom the war itself never allowed her.²⁸⁰
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *Bread bought and paid for at Muileann mhin* (Muileann mhin). Two men of the column buy the widow Mòrag nic Fhearghais's whole morning's baking at Muileann mhin and pay in full before the company passes, taking nothing else from the town.²⁸¹
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *Muileann mhin's miller reports no loss* (Muileann mhin). The miller of Muileann mhin under the western hills writes to Comhairle nam Mèinnean²⁸² that the town's takings showed no loss by the column's passing, the bread having been paid for at a fair price and nobody's stock troubled beyond it.²⁸³
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *A night's lodging paid at a barn on the capital's edge*. A party of the column sleeps a night in Aonghas mac Cuinn's barn and leaves coin and a note under a stone, thanking him and asking nothing more.²⁸⁴
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *The column keeps wide of the towns of the fair country*. Crossing the open country toward the capital's fields, the column holds a road that passes no town of any size, and the small farms it crosses report only a quiet passing.²⁸⁵

278. ← Follows from *The column's road*, 24 an t-Samhain, DE 22; ← Leads to *Sileas nic Rath keeps a file of the column's road*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

279. the royal chronicler

280. ← Follows from *The column's road*, 24 an t-Samhain, DE 22; ← Follows from *Àth bheag's report of the ford*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *Bread bought and paid for at Muileann mhin*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

281. ← Follows from *The column's road*, 24 an t-Samhain, DE 22; ← Follows from *Sileas nic Rath keeps a file of the column's road*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *Muileann mhin's miller reports no loss*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

282. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

283. ← Follows from *The column's road*, 24 an t-Samhain, DE 22; ← Follows from *Bread bought and paid for at Muileann mhin*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *A night's lodging paid at a barn on the capital's edge*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

284. ← Follows from *The column's road*, 24 an t-Samhain, DE 22; ← Follows from *Muileann mhin's miller reports no loss*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *The column keeps wide of the towns of the fair country*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

285. ← Follows from *The column's road*, 24 an t-Samhain, DE 22; ← Follows from *A night's lodging paid at a barn on the capital's edge*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *The fair-ground at Muileann òg ordered for the regiments*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22 — *The fair-ground at Muileann òg ordered for the regiments* (Muileann òg). A' chiad rèisimeid²⁸⁶'s quartermaster requires the fair-ground, its booths and its cleared ground for the first and third regiments, over Cùirt na Fèille²⁸⁷'s own market set for the ninth.²⁸⁸

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22 — *Fionnlagh Dubh numbers his stall's timbers* (Muileann òg). An ironmonger of thirty years' standing at Muileann òg's fair chalks numbers on his stall's poles before stacking them, against a spring market neither he nor the clerk much believes will come.²⁸⁹

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22 — *An treas rèisimeid*²⁹⁰ *camp on the cleared fair-ground* (Muileann òg). An treas rèisimeid pitches its tents where the ironmonger's stall and the cheese-sellers' row stood the day before, the ground cleared from the toll-house arch to the river bend.²⁹¹

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22 — *A' chiad rèisimeid*²⁹² *fills Muileann òg* (Muileann òg). A' chiad rèisimeid comes down the same evening as the third and fills the fair-ground, the water-meadow and the lanes above the mill, so that Muileann òg holds more soldiers under canvas than people.²⁹³

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22 — *Cùirt na Fèille*²⁹⁴ *keeps its small business through the camp* (Muileann òg). Ùna nic Ailein keeps Cùirt na Fèille open through the regiments' camp, hearing a strayed cow and a firewood complaint while the road to Muileann ghlas fills and empties below her window.²⁹⁵

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22 — *Ùna nic Ailein's book closes with no entry* (Muileann òg). Unable to set a sum against a market that never ran, Ùna rules the line the court's form requires, leaves it blank, and closes the year the desk with no closing entry.²⁹⁶

286. the first regiment

287. the court of the fair at Muileann òg

288. ← Follows from *The fair-ground emptied*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *The column keeps wide of the towns of the fair country*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *Fionnlagh Dubh numbers his stall's timbers*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

289. ← Follows from *The fair-ground emptied*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *The fair-ground at Muileann òg ordered for the regiments*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *An treas rèisimeid camp on the cleared fair-ground*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

290. the third regiment

291. ← Follows from *The camp by Muileann ghlas*, 6 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *Fionnlagh Dubh numbers his stall's timbers*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *A' chiad rèisimeid fills Muileann òg*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

292. the first regiment

293. ← Follows from *The camp by Muileann ghlas*, 6 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *An treas rèisimeid camp on the cleared fair-ground*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *Cùirt na Fèille keeps its small business through the camp*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

294. the court of the fair at Muileann òg

295. ← Follows from *The fair-ground emptied*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *A' chiad rèisimeid fills Muileann òg*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *Ùna nic Ailein's book closes with no entry*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22 — *The maor of Àth bheag watches from the bank* (Àth bheag). Cailean mac Griogair, maor of Àth bheag, woken by the smith's boy, stands at the field's edge in a borrowed coat watching the column ford the water and does not go down to ask where it is bound.²⁹⁷

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22 — *No banner and no drum* (Àth bheag). The miller's wife of Àth bheag, watching the column cross from the mill loft, says she saw no banner among them and no drum, only a man at the head whom the rest left the whole width of the road.

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31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22 — *The note under the stone*. Aonghas mac Cuinn finds under a stone on his barn floor coin for a week's rent and a note in Dia-thìris: for the barn, and thanks; we have asked nothing else. It is the only writing in an Leabharlann²⁹⁹'s file that can be set to a hand inside the column.³⁰⁰

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22 — *The eel-woman's tub carried off the fair-ground* (Muileann òg). Clearing the fair-ground at Muileann òg for the regiments, two soldiers lift the heavier end of the eel-woman's tub onto her handcart for her.³⁰¹

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22 — *Caol ruadh's boats carry the regiments' bread* (Caol ruadh). The boats of the red strait at Caol ruadh are hired to carry the regiments' bread along the coast in the autumn, paid by the day, with a soldier aboard each to count the loaves.³⁰²

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22 — *The column sings through its last night in the open* (Àraich Muileann ghlas³⁰³). On the bank and in the thorn below Muileann ghlas the column keeps its last night before the battle by singing low, company after company, in part for what courage it lends and in part because there are children on the field with nowhere else on the island to be left.³⁰⁴

296. ← Follows from *The fair-ground emptied*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *Cùirt na Fèille keeps its small business through the camp*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *The maor of Àth bheag watches from the bank*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

297. ← Follows from *The column goes south*, 29 an Dàmhair, DE 22; ← Follows from *Ùna nic Ailein's book closes with no entry*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *No banner and no drum*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

298. ← Follows from *The column goes south*, 29 an Dàmhair, DE 22; ← Follows from *The maor of Àth bheag watches from the bank*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *The note under the stone*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

299. the Library at Muileann chaol

300. ← Follows from *The column's road*, 24 an t-Samhain, DE 22; ← Follows from *No banner and no drum*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *The eel-woman's tub carried off the fair-ground*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

301. ← Follows from *The fair-ground emptied*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *The note under the stone*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *Caol ruadh's boats carry the regiments' bread*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

302. ← Follows from *The fair-ground emptied*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *The eel-woman's tub carried off the fair-ground*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

303. the battlefield of Muileann ghlas

304. ← Follows from *Battle of Muileann ghlas*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *Owen Barrow walks the line before first light*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22 — *Owen Barrow walks the line before first light* (Àraich Muileann ghlas³⁰⁵). In the last hour of dark Owen Barrow goes the length of the column's line, speaking to each company and to many of the column by name; he is remembered in the north to have said that the hills lie behind them now and cannot be walked back to before the guns find them either way. An Clàr Foscaite³⁰⁶ names him nowhere.³⁰⁷

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22 — *The guns find the thorn stand* (Àraich Muileann ghlas³⁰⁸). An treas rèisimeid³⁰⁹'s four field pieces, hauled the last two miles by hand through ground too soft for the horses, find the column's thorn-stand line within the first half-hour of the fighting; what holds after that holds along the bank itself, hand to hand, through most of the short forenoon.³¹⁰

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22 — *The corporal's list at the mill* (Muileann ghlas). A corporal of An treas rèisimeid³¹¹ draws up the regiments' dead of the day at a trestle table in the mill at Muileann ghlas, the miller's own ledger turned backward for want of other paper: three-and-twenty names, each with a town and, where known, an age.³¹²

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22 — *A requisition for lime* (Muileann ghlas). The regiments' burial parties ask the quartermaster for a good deal more lime than three-and-twenty graves would need. The requisition survives where no count of the column's own dead does, and is the nearest thing An Clàr Foscaite³¹³ holds to one.³¹⁴

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22 — *The miller's wife keeps her kitchen through the battle* (Muileann ghlas). As the mill at Muileann ghlas changes hands twice before noon, the miller's wife will not leave her own kitchen for either army, and is remembered by the regiments' surgeon to have gone on moving her pots and sacks from whichever corner the fighting had just left.³¹⁵

305. the battlefield of Muileann ghlas

306. the open record of the war years

307. ← Follows from *Battle of Muileann ghlas*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *The column sings through its last night in the open*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *The guns find the thorn stand*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

308. the battlefield of Muileann ghlas

309. the third regiment

310. ← Follows from *Battle of Muileann ghlas*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *Owen Barrow walks the line before first light*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *The corporal's list at the mill*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

311. the third regiment

312. ← Follows from *The field at Muileann ghlas*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *The guns find the thorn stand*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *A requisition for lime*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

313. the open record of the war years

314. ← Follows from *The field at Muileann ghlas*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *The corporal's list at the mill*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *The miller's wife keeps her kitchen through the battle*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

315. ← Follows from *Battle of Muileann ghlas*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *A requisition for lime*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *The colonel's report*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *The colonel's report* (Àraich Muileann ghlas³¹⁶). A' chiad rèisimeid³¹⁷'s colonel writes that the column held the bank at Muileann ghlas longer than any force he had faced in two years of war, and sets it down, he says, only so his council should have the field's truth and not a prettier account of it.³¹⁸
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *The taken ground remembered* (Muileann ghlas). An old man of Muileann ghlas, brought before the regiments' officers to answer for a store of grain, tells them the field carries an older name, the taken ground, from a battle of Cogadh nam Bràithrean³¹⁹ fought on the same ground two centuries before.³²⁰
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *The sixty come out of the byres* (Muileann ghlas). After dark, some sixty of the column still holding the mill and its byres come out under a promise, carried by a Tuathach prisoner on a white cloth, that any man unarmed will be marched and not shot; they are counted, searched and held overnight on the mill floor.³²¹
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *The regiments' surgeon treats both sides alike* (Muileann ghlas). The regiments' own surgeon, two years out of his training, tends the wounded of both the regiments and the column through the night at Muileann ghlas by two lanterns and a banked fire, and An Clàr Foscailte³²² notes that he made no distinction between them.³²³
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *The old man of Cnoc thais brings down his cow* (Cnoc thais). A lame old man of Cnoc thais comes down to An seachdamh rèisimeid³²⁴'s northernmost post on the Àth leathan road carrying no weapon, leading on a rope halter the one cow his family kept through two summers of war, and is let through with it.³²⁵
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *The sergeant judges the counting done* (Àth leathan). At An seachdamh rèisimeid³²⁶'s northernmost post the sergeant keeping the list of the hills' people notes, when no one more has come down the road by noon, that he takes the empty road to mean the counting is finished.³²⁷

316. the battlefield of Muileann ghlas

317. the first regiment

318. ← Follows from *The field at Muileann ghlas*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *The miller's wife keeps her kitchen through the battle*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *The taken ground remembered*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

319. the Brothers' War

320. ← Follows from *Battle of Muileann ghlas*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *The colonel's report*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *The sixty come out of the byres*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

321. ← Follows from *Battle of Muileann ghlas*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *The taken ground remembered*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *The regiments' surgeon treats both sides alike*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

322. the open record of the war years

323. ← Follows from *Battle of Muileann ghlas*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *The sixty come out of the byres*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *The old man of Cnoc thais brings down his cow*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

324. the seventh regiment

325. ← Follows from *The last pits give up*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *The regiments' surgeon treats both sides alike*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *The sergeant judges the counting done*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

326. the seventh regiment

- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *Somhairle hears the guns are done* (Cathair dhearg). Somhairle mac Lachlainn hears at the capital, from a clerk who comes into his room without knocking, that the fighting at Muileann ghlas is over; he says afterward that his first thought was for Slighe a' Ghuail³²⁸'s timetable and the wounded's carriage north.³²⁹
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *Somhairle checks the wounded trains twice over* (Cathair dhearg). In the first weeks of the peace Somhairle mac Lachlainn has Slighe a' Ghuail³³⁰'s schedule for the war's wounded checked twice against the surgeons' own returns, to be sure no man carried north that winter rode on a train meant for other cargo.³³¹
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *Near ninety of the column's wounded brought in* (Muileann ghlas). The regiments' surgeon's tally for the night after Muileann ghlas stands at twenty-three of the regiments buried or dying and near ninety of the column's wounded brought in.³³²
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *Taigh-solais Àth dhearg³³³ sees no fleet* (Àth dhearg). The keeper of Taigh-solais Àth dhearg on the north-east cape writes in his log through the autumn that no ship of the fleets has passed the cape in three months.³³⁴
- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 23** — *The regiments stay on their stations* (Cathair dhearg). The nine regiments and four fleets are not stood down. The council keeps each at the town where it was raised and pays them from the wartime tithe.
- 26 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 23** — *The market charter of Caol ruadh* (Caol ruadh). Caol ruadh, whose harbour victualled the garrisons and the second fleet through the war, is granted a market right for the southern strait. It is the sixteenth market town, and the last chartered.
- II AN GEARRAN, DE 23** — *Dubhan's fuel over all the island*. With the last ordered resistance gone, Dubhan's fuel is in all but law compelled upon the whole trade of the island.

327. ← Follows from *The last pits give up*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *The old man of Cnoc thais brings down his cow*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *Somhairle hears the guns are done*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

328. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

329. ← Follows from *An Cogadh Fada ends*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *The sergeant judges the counting done*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *Somhairle checks the wounded trains twice over*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

330. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

331. ← Follows from *An Cogadh Fada ends*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *Somhairle hears the guns are done*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *Near ninety of the column's wounded brought in*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

332. ← Follows from *The field at Muileann ghlas*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *Somhairle checks the wounded trains twice over*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Leads to *Taigh-solais Àth dhearg sees no fleet*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

333. the lighthouse at Àth dhearg

334. ← Follows from *Near ninety of the column's wounded brought in*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22.

- 24 AN GEARRAN, DE 23** — *The western seams flooded* (Àth leathan). By the Board's order the last western seams are flooded and their shafts capped with concrete. The seventh regiment stands by at every capping. After this no coal is dug on the island outside the Board's own works.
- 4 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 23** — *The prisoners sent home* (Caol mhòr). The holdouts held since Muileann ghlas are let out of the capital's gaol and sent north under guard of the first regiment as far as the boundary stones. The Moot's register adds their names, in a column of their own, to the dead and maimed it has kept since the Severance.
- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 23** — *Somhairle mac Lachlainn seated* (Cathair dhearg). Somhairle mac Lachlainn is given a seat on the council, the first soldier to sit there since the captains of the Severance war.
- 28 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 23** — *The seventh regiment at Àth leathan* (Àth leathan). The seventh regiment builds a post on the road below Àth leathan and keeps a company there. In the regimental lists it is called the Àth leathan post, and in the town something else.
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 23** — *The stone at Cathair mhòr* (Cathair mhòr). A stone is set up at Cathair mhòr bearing the names of the regiments' dead from Àth leathan and Muileann ghlas. It stands beside the market cross of the house of Mac Ùisdein.
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 23** — *The Muileann ghlas field* (Àraich Muileann ghlas³³⁵). The field at Muileann ghlas where the column camped is sown again. For years the farmer who holds it finds weapons in the furrows and hands them to the first regiment, which keeps a list.
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 23** — *The first capping at Àth leathan* (Àth leathan). In am Màrt An seachdamh rèisimeid³³⁶ pours the first concrete over a flooded shaft at Àth leathan while Somhairle mac Lachlainn watches from the pit-head; the mix lies still in a way the seam itself, even flooded, had never once lain before.³³⁷
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 23** — *Sergeant Iain Mòr counts the cappings* (Muileann àrsaidh). A sergeant of An seachdamh rèisimeid³³⁸ tells Somhairle mac Lachlainn this is the fourth capping his company has stood by that month, at Muileann àrsaidh, Cnoc thais and a nameless working near Àth naomh, and wonders aloud what the regiment will be set to guard once Tobar dhearg of the hills is done.³³⁹

335. the battlefield of Muileann ghlas

336. the seventh regiment

337. ← Follows from *The western seams flooded*, 24 an Gearran, DE 23.

338. the seventh regiment

339. ← Follows from *The western seams flooded*, 24 an Gearran, DE 23; ← Follows from *The first capping at Àth leathan*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23.

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 23 — *Comhairle nam Mèinnean*³⁴⁰ *ends the coal trade outside An Sloc Mòr*³⁴¹ (Cathair mhòr). Fearghas mac Aonghais's office notes that the trade in coal-fuel is at an end on the island outside what Comhairle nam Mèinnean still cuts for its own account at An Sloc Mòr: not forbidden by any law, but ended by there being, at last, nowhere left to sell it.³⁴²

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 23 — *Aonghas mac Phàdraig's plough finds the first iron* (Àraich Muileann ghlas³⁴³). Turning his field at Muileann ghlas in am Màrt as he has every spring of his life, Aonghas mac Phàdraig's share brings up a rusted bayonet lying whole across it; he finishes the furrow before he carries it home.³⁴⁴

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 23 — *A' chiad rèisimeid*³⁴⁵ *'s corporal begins a list* (Àraich Muileann ghlas³⁴⁶). A corporal of A' chiad rèisimeid collecting rents in the district takes Aonghas mac Phàdraig's bayonet and enters it on a list kept for such finds, not knowing whether it is a record of the dead or only of the field giving back what two armies left in it.³⁴⁷

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 23 — *The letter from the capital's gaol* (Ceann mhòr). Martha Greaves receives word from the council's office that the holdouts taken at Muileann ghlas are to be released in an t-Iuchar and marched north to the boundary stones, with no word of who is to feed them on the road or what their flooded towns will make of their return.³⁴⁸

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 23 — *Martha Greaves and Peter Hale ride to the stones* (Caol mhòr). Martha Greaves and Peter Hale take the last carriage Slighe a' Ghuail³⁴⁹ runs toward the boundary stones, Peter carrying a register freshly ruled with a new column by his own hand for want of any other paper the party trusted.³⁵⁰

340. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

341. the great pit at the mountain

342. ← Follows from *Dubhan's fuel over all the island*, 11 an Gearran, DE 23; ← Follows from *Sergeant Iain Mòr counts the cappings*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23; ← Leads to *Aonghas mac Phàdraig's plough finds the first iron*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23.

343. the battlefield of Muileann ghlas

344. ← Follows from *The Muileann ghlas field*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23; ← Follows from *Comhairle nam Mèinnean ends the coal trade outside An Sloc Mòr*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23; ← Leads to *A' chiad rèisimeid's corporal begins a list*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23.

345. the first regiment

346. the battlefield of Muileann ghlas

347. ← Follows from *The Muileann ghlas field*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23; ← Follows from *Aonghas mac Phàdraig's plough finds the first iron*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23; ← Leads to *The letter from the capital's gaol*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23.

348. ← Follows from *The prisoners sent home*, 4 an t-Iuchar, DE 23; ← Follows from *A' chiad rèisimeid's corporal begins a list*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23; ← Leads to *Martha Greaves and Peter Hale ride to the stones*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23.

349. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

350. ← Follows from *The prisoners sent home*, 4 an t-Iuchar, DE 23; ← Follows from *The letter from the capital's gaol*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23; ← Leads to *A mother writes four words beside her son's name*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23.

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 23 — *A mother writes four words beside her son's name* (Caol mhòr). A woman of Cnoc thais gives Martha Greaves her son's name for the register and, unbidden, the words he is not among these; Martha sets both down, judging the register poorer without them.³⁵¹

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 23 — *A man refuses his name for a town that no longer stands* (Caol mhòr). An older prisoner at the boundary stones will not give his name at first, saying it would mean nothing written beside Muileann àrsaidh's ruin; Martha Greaves promises the town will stand again in whatever shape its people build it, and he gives his name.³⁵²

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 23 — *Peter Hale keeps a name of his own* (Caol mhòr). Among the released Peter Hale recognises a man once apprenticed to the same binder at Muileann leathan whose pupils rebound Tional nan Tuathach³⁵³'s minute-books; the man gives no sign of knowing him, and Peter does not ask which it is, silence or forgetting.³⁵⁴

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 23 — *Anna nic Phàil speaks to Somhairle at the chamber door* (Cathair dhearg). At the close of his first sitting Anna nic Phàil tells Somhairle mac Lachlainn she stood on the bench in the passage an Nollaig³⁵⁵ Martha Greaves carried Athchuinge Dheireannach an Tionail³⁵⁶ in, and means to go on voting every mercy the council's business allows her.³⁵⁷

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 23 — *Somhairle reads the one-and-sixty names* (Cathair mhòr). At the stone's unveiling at Cathair mhòr, Somhairle mac Lachlainn reads aloud the one-and-sixty names of the regiments' dead from Àth leathan and Muileann ghlais to a silent square, and finds the town's silence harder to bear than any noise it might have made instead.³⁵⁸

351. ← Follows from *The prisoners sent home*, 4 an t-Iuchar, DE 23; ← Follows from *Martha Greaves and Peter Hale ride to the stones*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23; ← Leads to *A man refuses his name for a town that no longer stands*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23.

352. ← Follows from *The prisoners sent home*, 4 an t-Iuchar, DE 23; ← Follows from *A mother writes four words beside her son's name*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23; ← Leads to *Peter Hale keeps a name of his own*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23.

353. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

354. ← Follows from *The prisoners sent home*, 4 an t-Iuchar, DE 23; ← Follows from *A man refuses his name for a town that no longer stands*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23; ← Leads to *Anna nic Phàil speaks to Somhairle at the chamber door*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23.

355. Christmas

356. the Moot's last petition

357. ← Follows from *Somhairle mac Lachlainn seated*, 31 an Lùnastal, DE 23; ← Follows from *Peter Hale keeps a name of his own*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23; ← Leads to *Somhairle reads the one-and-sixty names*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23.

358. ← Follows from *The stone at Cathair mhòr*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23; ← Follows from *Anna nic Phàil speaks to Somhairle at the chamber door*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23; ← Leads to *Somhairle thinks of the names the stone does not carry*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23.

- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 23** — *Somhairle thinks of the names the stone does not carry* (Cathair mhòr). Standing alone at the stone after the crowd disperses, Somhairle mac Lachlainn counts over the column's uncounted dead, the sixty from the byres, and a mother's son who was not among the released, and finds that number, cut nowhere, stays with him longer than the one that is.³⁵⁹
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 23** — *Four score released at the boundary stones* (Caol mhòr). Some four score holdouts taken at Muileann ghlas are handed to Tional nan Tuathach³⁶⁰ at the boundary stones; Martha Greaves writes their names in a column Peter Hale ruled that morning.³⁶¹
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 23** — *The heading on Clach nan Rèisimeidean*³⁶² (Cathair mhòr). Clach nan Rèisimeidean is cut in two columns under a single heading, the regiments' dead, giving neither battle nor date.³⁶³
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 23** — *Two brothers of Seann Bhral on the stone* (Cathair mhòr). Among the names read at the stone's unveiling are two brothers of Seann Bhral who enlisted together and died within the same hour of the same morning.³⁶⁴
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 23** — *An seachdamh rèisimeid's first winter at the post* (Freiceadan Àth leathan³⁶⁵). An seachdamh rèisimeid's first winter at the post by Àth leathan is spent roofing it; the men buy their slates at the western Seann Skell.³⁶⁷
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 23** — *The first market under the Caol ruadh charter* (Caol ruadh). The first market held under Caol ruadh's new charter is held in the rain on the quay; the market-due is taken by a clerk of An t-Ionmhas³⁶⁸ under a sailcloth awning, and the fishwives sell out before noon.³⁶⁹

359. ← Follows from *The stone at Cathair mhòr*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23; ← Follows from *Somhairle reads the one-and-sixty names*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23; ← Leads to *Four score released at the boundary stones*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23.

360. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

361. ← Follows from *The prisoners sent home*, 4 an t-Iuchar, DE 23; ← Follows from *Somhairle thinks of the names the stone does not carry*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23; ← Leads to *The heading on Clach nan Rèisimeidean*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23.

362. the stone of the regiments' dead at Cathair mhòr; lit. 'the stone of the regiments'

363. ← Follows from *The stone at Cathair mhòr*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23; ← Follows from *Four score released at the boundary stones*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23; ← Leads to *Two brothers of Seann Bhral on the stone*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23.

364. ← Follows from *The stone at Cathair mhòr*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23; ← Follows from *The heading on Clach nan Rèisimeidean*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23; ← Leads to *An seachdamh rèisimeid's first winter at the post*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23.

365. the seventh regiment

366. the Àth leathan post, the seventh regiment's post on the road below Àth leathan

367. ← Follows from *The seventh regiment at Àth leathan*, 28 an Dàmhair, DE 23; ← Follows from *Two brothers of Seann Bhral on the stone*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23; ← Leads to *The first market under the Caol ruadh charter*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23.

368. the Treasury

- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 23** — *A plough-share of Muileann ghlais* (Muileann ghlais). The farmer of the sown field at Muileann ghlais brings the first blade turned up by his plough to the regiments' post, and the corporal enters it in a book kept for the purpose.³⁷⁰
- 14 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 24** — *The library's war archive sealed* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³⁷¹). The whole record of the Long War at Leabharlann Muileann chaol is sealed against all readers for fifty years. No other archive in the kingdom's history has been sealed.
- 25 AM MÀRT, DE 24** — *Sileas nic Rath's open chronicle* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³⁷²). Of the royal chronicle for the war years there stays open only Sileas nic Rath's list of places, the regiments present and the counts she was allowed. Her full record went into the sealed archive with the rest.
- 6 AN GIBLEAN, DE 24** — *The cairn at Àth leathan* (Àraich Àth leathan³⁷³). Tuathaich families build a cairn on the field of Àth leathan without leave. The patrols of the seventh regiment leave it standing, and every time they pass it has grown by a stone or two.
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, DE 24** — *The tithe carried forward* (Cathair dhearg). The Treasury's accounts carry the wartime tithe forward as a standing line under the regiments' pay. No minute of the council records a choice to keep it.
- 22 AN CÈITEAN, DE 24** — *The market-due fixed* (Cathair dhearg). The Treasury fixes the market-due at seventeen in the hundred on every sale a town makes into its market and on every sale between markets. A clerk of the Treasury is set in each of the sixteen market towns to take it and keep the market roll. The wartime tithe on dubhan stays at the pumps, on its own line.
- 26 AN CÈITEAN, DE 24** — *The Fuel-Fitters and the regiments* (Seann Skell). The Guild of Fuel-Fitters at Seann Skell on the southern coast is given the contract for the regiments' engines and the fleets' hulls, and doubles its rolls. The charter rule holds, and all its new fitters are Dia-thirich.
- 20 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 24** — *The regiments' arms contracts* (Àth naomh). The forges of Àth naomh in the west and Caol Iseal on the north coast, which smelt the bog-iron of their districts, take the Crown's contract for the regiments' small arms and field-guns. The forge-towns of the old vein country follow. Arms become the dearest common goods in every market of the kingdom.

369. ← Follows from *The market charter of Caol ruadh*, 26 am Faoilleach, DE 23; ← Follows from *An seachdamb rèisimeid's first winter at the post*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23; ← Leads to *A plough-share of Muileann ghlais*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23.

370. ← Follows from *The Muileann ghlais field*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23; ← Follows from *The first market under the Caol ruadh charter*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23.

371. the Library at Muileann chaol

372. the Library at Muileann chaol

373. the battlefield of Àth leathan

- 2 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 24** — *The second fleet off Baile iséal* (Taigh-solais Baile iséal³⁷⁴). The second fleet runs down off Baile iséal the raiders who took the salt-boats in the war, and brings their hulls into Seann Skell. The lighthouse log at Baile iséal records the chase from the lamp-room.
- 29 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 24** — *The fourth fleet in the north-west* (Spùinneadairean-mara). The fourth fleet, kept on the Tuathaich coast after the war, searches the raiders' bays off Cathair gheal and finds them empty. The fishermen of Cathair gheal say the raiders left when the fleets came and will return when they go.
- 28 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 24** — *The third fleet's tank-hulls* (Baile ghorm). The third fleet at Baile ghorm keeps its tank-hulls after the war and runs dubhan up the west coast to the Tuathaich depots on the council's contract. The Moot pays the freight.
- 30 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 24** — *The council's order reaches Muileann chaol* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³⁷⁵). A rider who has changed horses three times brings the council's four-line order to Ragnall mac Mhuirich on the doorstep of the old building: the whole record of An Cogadh Fada³⁷⁶ is to be shut against every reader for fifty years, and the keeper alone is to hold the key.³⁷⁷
- 1 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 24** — *Ragnall has a room built for the seal* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³⁷⁸). Ragnall clears an old storeroom at the end of the new wing's gallery and has a mason and a smith fit it, through a fortnight of hard weather, with an oak door two inches thick and a lock made new to no other key in the kingdom, standing over the last morning's fitting himself.³⁷⁹
- 4 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 24** — *Sileas carries her full record to the door* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³⁸⁰). Over two days Sileas nic Rath carries her own four boxes of the war's full record up from her room and sets them inside the new door herself, letting no clerk touch them: the movements, counts and letters she was never let publish alongside the open chronicle.³⁸¹
- 6 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 24** — *The key turns once* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³⁸²). Ragnall turns the new lock himself with the mason and smith gone, and hangs the key on a cord under his own shirt, where he is seen for years after to lay his hand against his chest before he blows out the reading-room's last lamp.³⁸³

374. the lighthouse at Baile iséal

375. the Library at Muileann chaol

376. the Long War

377. ← Follows from *The library's war archive sealed*, 14 am Faoilleach, DE 24.

378. the Library at Muileann chaol

379. ← Follows from *The library's war archive sealed*, 14 am Faoilleach, DE 24; ← Follows from *The council's order reaches Muileann chaol*, 30 an Dàmhair, DE 24.

380. the Library at Muileann chaol

- 11 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 24** — *Sileas's promise at the head of the open list* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³⁸⁴). Sileas writes, unasked, a line at the head of the war's open list saying plainly that the fuller record exists, is kept, and will be given to any honest reader when the fifty years end; Raghnaill reads it and lets it stand.³⁸⁵
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 24** — *An seachdamh rèisimeid*³⁸⁶'s captain lets the cairn stand (Àraich Àth leathan³⁸⁷). Asked whether to clear the cairn the Tuathaich have raised on Àraich Àth leathan, Comhairle nam Mèinnean³⁸⁸ answers that its captain may use his own judgment; he tells his patrols to walk past it and count the stones if they wish, and report only what is found beneath one.³⁸⁹
- 18 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 24** — *A woman of Àth leathan carries a stone each morning* (Àraich Àth leathan³⁹⁰). A woman of the town who lost a brother in the fighting there, and will not say which side he died fighting for, is seen to walk out alone before the patrol each morning, set one stone on the cairn, and stand a while with her hand flat against it before going home.³⁹¹
- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 24** — *Peigi nic Ascaill signs the regiments' contract* (Cathair dhearg). Peigi nic Ascaill signs Comann nan Goibhnean-ceangail³⁹²' contract for the regiments' engines and the fleets' hulls at Cathair dhearg with a clerk on either hand to witness it, and tells her under-fitter afterward that no paper she has signed will put more Dia-thùrich fitters to the trade than this one.³⁹³
- 25 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 24** — *A smith of Àth naomh counts his musket-stocks* (Àth naomh). Writing to his brother at Cathair dhearg, a smith of Àth naomh says he has turned out more musket-stocks that winter than ploughshares in the six years before the war, and cannot decide whether to call it his own good fortune or the kingdom's bad one.³⁹⁴

383. ← Follows from *The library's war archive sealed*, 14 am Faoilleach, DE 24; ← Follows from *Sileas carries her full record to the door*, 4 an t-Samhain, DE 24.

381. ← Follows from *The library's war archive sealed*, 14 am Faoilleach, DE 24; ← Follows from *Sileas nic Rath's open chronicle*, 25 am Màrt, DE 24; ← Follows from *Raghnaill has a room built for the seal*, 1 an t-Samhain, DE 24.

382. the Library at Muileann chaol

384. the Library at Muileann chaol

385. ← Follows from *Sileas nic Rath's open chronicle*, 25 am Màrt, DE 24; ← Follows from *The key turns once*, 6 an t-Samhain, DE 24.

386. the seventh regiment

387. the battlefield of Àth leathan

388. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

389. ← Follows from *The cairn at Àth leathan*, 6 an Giblean, DE 24; ← Follows from *Sileas's promise at the head of the open list*, 11 an t-Samhain, DE 24.

390. the battlefield of Àth leathan

391. ← Follows from *The cairn at Àth leathan*, 6 an Giblean, DE 24; ← Follows from *An seachdamh rèisimeid's captain lets the cairn stand*, 16 an t-Samhain, DE 24.

392. the Guild of Fuel-Fitters; lit. 'the fellowship of the fitters'

- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 24** — *The forge at Caol iséal takes on new hands* (Caol iséal). The woman who masters the forge at Caol iséal, left her by a father with no son to leave it to, takes on four boys and a girl under the arms contract and tells Comhairle nam Mèin-nean³⁹⁵'s inspector she means to keep them past the contract's term, war or no war.³⁹⁶
- 7 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 24** — *Seonag nic Thòmais lights the second lamp* (Taigh-solais Baile iséal³⁹⁷). Keeper of the trial lamp at Baile iséal, Seonag nic Thòmais sees the salt-boat raiders' sail two hours before An dàrna cabhlach³⁹⁸'s own lookout and lights, on her own judgment, the warning lamp kept unlit in ordinary weather; the fleet's captain copies her log whole into his return.³⁹⁹
- 12 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 24** — *Sileas opens the next day's page as any other* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁴⁰⁰). The morning after the lock is turned, Sileas sets the day's date and the weather at the top of her page and writes only of a mill's copying fee, exactly as on any working morning of the thirteen years before, and says nothing there of the sealed room.⁴⁰¹
- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 24** — *Some forty places on the open list* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁴⁰²). The open list of the war years at an Leabharlann⁴⁰³ runs to some forty places, each with its regiments and the counts allowed before the sealing, and a blank where the column's dead would stand.⁴⁰⁴
- 16 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 24** — *The quays of Baile ghorm lengthened* (Baile ghorm). For An treas cabhlach⁴⁰⁵'s tank-hulls the quays of Baile ghorm are lengthened by forty paces into the anchorage, the stone carted from the old wolf-posts' quarry.⁴⁰⁶

394. ← Follows from *The regiments' arms contracts*, 20 an t-Ògmhios, DE 24; ← Follows from *Peigi nic Ascaill signs the regiments' contract*, 23 an t-Samhain, DE 24.

393. ← Follows from *The Fuel-Fitters and the regiments*, 26 an Cèitean, DE 24; ← Follows from *A woman of Àth leathan carries a stone each morning*, 18 an t-Samhain, DE 24.

395. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

396. ← Follows from *The regiments' arms contracts*, 20 an t-Ògmhios, DE 24; ← Follows from *A smith of Àth naomb counts his musket-stocks*, 25 an t-Samhain, DE 24.

397. the lighthouse at Baile iséal

398. the second fleet

399. ← Follows from *The second fleet off Baile iséal*, 2 an Lùnastal, DE 24; ← Follows from *The forge at Caol iséal takes on new hands*, 5 an Dùbhlachd, DE 24.

400. the Library at Muileann chaol

401. ← Follows from *Sileas nic Rath's open chronicle*, 25 am Màrt, DE 24; ← Follows from *Seonag nic Thòmais lights the second lamp*, 7 an Dùbhlachd, DE 24.

402. the Library at Muileann chaol

403. the Library at Muileann chaol

404. ← Follows from *Sileas nic Rath's open chronicle*, 25 am Màrt, DE 24; ← Follows from *Sileas opens the next day's page as any other*, 12 an Dùbhlachd, DE 24.

405. the third fleet

406. ← Follows from *The third fleet's tank-hulls*, 28 an Dàmhair, DE 24; ← Follows from *Some forty places on the open list*, 14 an Dùbhlachd, DE 24.

- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 24** — *Doire shean pays the market-due* (Doire shean). At Doire shean the fixed market-due is taken for the first time; Am Buabhall Fortanach⁴⁰⁷, which sells no goods at market, is found to owe it on its buffalo.⁴⁰⁸
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 24** — *Còmhrag Ceann leathan*⁴⁰⁹ of *Ceann leathan after the war* (Ceann leathan). At the first Còmhrag at Ceann leathan after the last pits gave up, the fair-wardens count more fighters from the shires of the middle country than in any year before, and none from the western hills.⁴¹⁰
- 23 AN GIBLEAN, DE 25** — *The creature off the cape again* (Uilebheist na Mara⁴¹¹). The fourth fleet's log for the year records a thing longer than a patrol boat off the north-west cape, where the Tuathaich fishermen reported one in Gormshuil nic Dhùghail's day. The log calls it a whale.
- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 25** — *Anna nic Phàil's motion* (Cathair dhomhain). The motion to make amends to the Tuathaich is brought into the council by Anna nic Phàil, councillor for Cathair dhomhain, on a petition of the Moot under Martha Greaves. She speaks for it once.
- 10 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 25** — *The motion for amends* (Cathair dhearg). In the capital it is proposed to pay the Tuathaich for their losses in the war. The motion is let die quietly, and no vote is taken.
- 18 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 25** — *The Moot's minute on the amends* (Caol mhòr). The Moot's minute on the motion for amends runs to one line: 'Allowed to die.' That same year Martha Greaves lays down the chair. The Moot chooses Peter Hale, a great-grandson of its first speaker, to follow her.
- 27 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 25** — *The fifth regiment's barracks* (Seann Warr). The fifth regiment builds stone barracks at Seann Warr, the first lasting quarters any of the nine regiments has had. The town gives the land and takes the regiment's custom.
- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 25** — *The eighth regiment at Inis uaine* (Inis uaine). The eighth regiment's guard on the eastern dubhan tanks at Inis uaine is made lasting. Its officers take houses in the town, and the Seann Spioradan house of Inis uaine adds the regiment to its prayers.
- 22 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 25** — *The fourth regiment leaves Ceann mhòr* (Caol bheag). The fourth regiment leaves the old magistrate's house at Ceann mhòr and goes home to Caol bheag. The Moot asks that the house be given to the town. It is given to the maor.

407. the Lucky Buffalo, the great inn near Doire shean kept by Oighrig nic Iain

408. ← Follows from *The market-due fixed*, 22 an Cèitean, DE 24; ← Follows from *The quays of Baile gorm lengthened*, 16 an Dùbhlachd, DE 24.

409. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

410. ← Follows from *The last pits give up*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *Doire shean pays the market-due*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, DE 24.

- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 25** — *Anna nic Phàil cuts a page of figures from her own draft* (Cathair dhomhain). Writing her motion at her own table through the early months of the year, Anna nic Phàil cuts a whole page of named costs, granaries and flooded pit-heads and Clach nan Rèisimeidean⁴¹², judging that a council grows deaf to a column of figures faster than to almost anything else brought before it.⁴¹³
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 25** — *The master of An t-Ionmhas⁴¹⁴ asks a figure of the motion* (Cathair dhearg). Uisdean Dubh, master of An t-Ionmhas, asks Anna nic Phàil's Tagradh na h-Èirig⁴¹⁵ whether its sum has been costed against the year's roll; she answers that the reckoning is the room's own trade, and asks only that the principle be granted.⁴¹⁶
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 25** — *The motion held over, morning after morning* (Cathair dhearg). For eight sittings running the council's clerk carries Tagradh na h-Èirig⁴¹⁷ forward on the day's business-paper under the same two words, held over, without any member speaking against it or any vote being called.⁴¹⁸
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 25** — *Somhairle mac Lachlainn is asked whether the sum is too great* (Cathair dhearg). Caught at the chamber door, Somhairle mac Lachlainn tells Anna nic Phàil that he has read many rolls of the dead and never once been asked whether the towns that raised them could bear the cost, and does not know why a roll of the dead should be easier to pay for than a roll of the living.⁴¹⁹
- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 25** — *The motion stood over without a sitting called* (Cathair dhearg). On the eighth day Tagradh na h-Èirig⁴²⁰ is absent from the business-paper; a clerk tells Anna nic Phàil it was stood over to the autumn sitting the evening before, in a short session she was not told was sitting, by members' vote without her among them.⁴²¹

411. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

412. the stone of the regiments' dead at Cathair mhòr; lit. 'the stone of the regiments'

413. ← Follows from *Anna nic Phàil's motion*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, DE 25.

414. the Treasury

415. Anna nic Phàil's motion to pay the Tuathaich towns for what they lost in the war, brought on the Moot's last petition and allowed to die without a vote

416. ← Follows from *Anna nic Phàil's motion*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, DE 25; ← Follows from *Anna nic Phàil cuts a page of figures from her own draft*, 23 an Dùbhlachd, DE 25.

417. Anna nic Phàil's motion to pay the Tuathaich towns for what they lost in the war, brought on the Moot's last petition and allowed to die without a vote

418. ← Follows from *Anna nic Phàil's motion*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, DE 25; ← Follows from *The motion for amends*, 10 an t-Ògmhios, DE 25; ← Follows from *The master of An t-Ionmhas asks a figure of the motion*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 25.

419. ← Follows from *Anna nic Phàil's motion*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, DE 25; ← Follows from *The motion held over, morning after morning*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 25.

420. Anna nic Phàil's motion to pay the Tuathaich towns for what they lost in the war, brought on the Moot's last petition and allowed to die without a vote

421. ← Follows from *The motion for amends*, 10 an t-Ògmhios, DE 25; ← Follows from *Somhairle mac Lachlainn is asked whether the sum is too great*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, DE 25.

- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 25** — *Anna counts the councillors who looked away* (Cathair dhearg). Going back over the eight sittings, Anna nic Phàil can find no single vote that killed the motion, only the faces of the twelve, one who promised a vote and never called it, one who spoke of hard times, six who said nothing to her at all, and Somhairle who gave her an answer and moved no more than the rest to call it to a vote.⁴²²
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 25** — *Martha Greaves tells Peter Hale she means to lay the chair down* (Caol mhòr). In the delegates' room over the net-lofts at Caol mhòr, Martha Greaves tells Peter Hale plainly that she means to lay down Tional nan Tuathach⁴²³'s chair that year, and that she judges him, of every delegate she has sat among, the fittest to take it up.⁴²⁴
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 25** — *Martha Greaves's last sitting* (Caol mhòr). Martha Greaves reads out the year's register and the ordinary business of the day, a roof at the school, the price of wool, a mill's complaint of the coal-line's freight, lays the chair down, and Tional nan Tuathach⁴²⁵ chooses Peter Hale by acclamation without a show of hands.⁴²⁶
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 25** — *Martha Greaves goes home to Doire ghlais* (Doire ghlais). Martha Greaves rides home to Doire ghlais on the ordinary carrier's cart with no more baggage than she came to the mill with as a young woman, not yet certain what a woman who was Tional nan Tuathach⁴²⁷'s own voice for seventeen years is to do with her mornings now.⁴²⁸
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 25** — *Officers' houses at Inis uaine* (Inis uaine). By council order An t-ochdamh rèisimeid⁴²⁹'s officers at Inis uaine are given houses in the town in place of quarters borrowed year by year from the tank-yard's sheds.⁴³⁰
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 25** — *The quarrymen of Seann Warr* (Seann Warr). The quarrymen of Seann Warr cut the stone for An còigeamh rèisimeid⁴³¹'s barracks through the summer from the same face that gave the harbour wall, and are paid by An t-Ionmhas⁴³² at a rate the town's masons call fair.⁴³³

422. ← Follows from *The motion for amends*, 10 an t-Ògmhios, DE 25; ← Follows from *The motion stood over without a sitting called*, 27 an Dùbhlachd, DE 25.

423. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

424. ← Follows from *The Moot's minute on the amends*, 18 an t-Ògmhios, DE 25; ← Follows from *Anna counts the councillors who looked away*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, DE 25.

425. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

426. ← Follows from *The Moot's minute on the amends*, 18 an t-Ògmhios, DE 25; ← Follows from *Martha Greaves tells Peter Hale she means to lay the chair down*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, DE 25.

427. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

428. ← Follows from *The Moot's minute on the amends*, 18 an t-Ògmhios, DE 25; ← Follows from *Martha Greaves's last sitting*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, DE 25; ← Leads to *Officers' houses at Inis uaine*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 25.

429. the eighth regiment

430. ← Follows from *The eighth regiment at Inis uaine*, 14 an Dùbhlachd, DE 25; ← Follows from *Martha Greaves goes home to Doire ghlais*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 25; ← Leads to *The quarrymen of Seann Warr*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 25.

431. the fifth regiment

432. the Treasury

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 25 — *Cnoc bhàn's harbour opened again* (Cnoc bhàn). The Tuath-aich of Cnoc bhàn open their harbour again to boats they do not know, the raiders who took the salt-boats having been brought into Seann Skell.⁴³⁴

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 25 — *The springs of Muileann ruadh in a wet summer* (Muileann ruadh). Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh⁴³⁵ below Muileann ruadh run so full in the wet summer that the bath-house's lower room floods, and the custodians carry the sick up to the long room.⁴³⁶

433. ← Follows from *The fifth regiment's barracks*, 27 an Dàmhair, DE 25; ← Follows from *Officers' houses at Inis uaine*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 25; ← Leads to *Cnoc bhàn's harbour opened again*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 25.

434. ← Follows from *The second fleet off Baile iséal*, 2 an Lùnastal, DE 24; ← Follows from *The quarrymen of Seann Warr*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 25; ← Leads to *The springs of Muileann ruadh in a wet summer*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 25.

435. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

436. ← Follows from *Cnoc bhàn's harbour opened again*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, DE 25.

THE YEARS DE 26 – 27

- 18 AN GIBLEAN, DE 26** — *Seann-chunntas* (Caol mhòr). Tuathaich speakers begin to name the tabled request to the library and the dead motion for amends together as 'seann-chunntas', an old reckoning that none in power will settle and none has cancelled. The Dia-thìrich in office do not take up the word.
- 17 AN CÈITEAN, DE 26** — *The Sloc Mòr closed* (Achadh dhomhain). The Mine Board shuts the upper galleries of the Sloc Mòr at Achadh dhomhain. One face is kept open in the Rite's keeping, to cut coal for the altars, a few baskets a year.
- 15 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 26** — *The last hewers* (Achadh dhomhain). Twelve hewers are kept at the Sloc Mòr to cut the altar-coal in the Rite's keeping. They are the last of their trade to work the vein on the island, and the Rite gives them its own oath, not the dissolved guild's.
- 14 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 26** — *The regiments at the Còmhrag* (Còmhrag Ceann leathan¹). Fighters of the regiments are entered in the Còmhrag at Ceann leathan for the first time. The ninth regiment's man wins it. The fair-wardens raise the gate-price again.
- 12 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 26** — *The second regiment's library guard* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol²). The second regiment at Àth dhìreach keeps a guard at Leabharlann Muileann chaol over the sealed war archive. The keeper, Ragnall mac Mhuirich, writes to the council that the library did not ask for one.
- 10 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 26** — *The coal line carries no coal* (Achadh dhomhain). The last coal train runs from Achadh dhomhain to Cathair dhearg. The coal line keeps its name and carries dubhan, wool and soldiers.
- 9 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 26** — *The sixth regiment on the northern road* (Caol mhòr). The sixth regiment at Cnoc bheag keeps posts on the northern road where the boundary stones stand. For the first time since the Severance the Tuathaich going south must show a pass. The council's minute calls the passes for a time only.
- 7 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 26** — *The fair of the present year* (Fèill Muileann òg³). The fair at Muileann òg draws traders from every shire the state holds. Tuathaich wool is sold there on its northern day, through Dia-thìrich factors, as it has been since the first fair.
- 15 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 26** — *The word heard first in the yard at Muileann chaol* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁴). A carrier bringing salt fish to an Leabharlann's kitchen uses the word seann-chunntas in the yard within Sileas nic Rath's hearing; she copies it into her working notes, meaning at first only to ask Ragnall whether an Leabharlann's glossary should carry it.⁶

1. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

2. the Library at Muileann chaol

3. the fair at Muileann òg

4. the Library at Muileann chaol

5. the Library at Muileann chaol

6. ← Follows from *Seann-chunntas*, 18 an Giblean, DE 26.

- 18 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 26** — *Ellen Marsh's letter carries the word twice* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁷). A civil note from Ellen Marsh asking after the eleventh book's binding uses seann-chunntas twice in passing, as a word already in general currency in the north; Sileas sets it beside the carrier's yard-talk and begins to understand what the word joins.⁸
- 19 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 26** — *Sileas enters the word without a heading* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁹). Sileas nic Rath sets a single line at the foot of a Board return, noting the word heard that year joining the tabled request and the dead motion, and that no Dia-thìreach in office has yet used it; she gives it no category of its own.¹⁰
- 21 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 26** — *Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹¹'s order to Achadh dbombain* (Achadh dhomhain). A four-line order from Comhairle nam Mèinnean reaches the maor of Achadh dhomhain in an Gearran, closing An Sloc Mòr¹²'s upper galleries and the timbering left to stand, the shafts capped, the workings judged to cost more in pumping than the coal they still gave.¹³
- 22 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 26** — *The maor's report on the bewing families* (Achadh dhomhain). The maor of Achadh dhomhain reports that the old hewing families of the town said nothing against the closing of An Sloc Mòr¹⁴'s upper galleries and asked nothing of Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹⁵ in its place.¹⁶
- 24 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 26** — *Eachann given the last coal run* (Muileann chrom). The yard masters at Muileann chrom tell Eachann mac Ruairidh, three days before, that the run he is given will be Slighe a' Ghuail¹⁷'s last working under coal's own name, an old lamp-house contract closing after fourteen years of the line carrying dubhan under the unchanged name.¹⁸

7. the Library at Muileann chaol

8. ← Follows from *Seann-chunntas*, 18 an Giblean, DE 26; ← Follows from *The word heard first in the yard at Muileann chaol*, 15 an t-Samhain, DE 26.

9. the Library at Muileann chaol

10. ← Follows from *Seann-chunntas*, 18 an Giblean, DE 26; ← Follows from *Ellen Marsh's letter carries the word twice*, 18 an t-Samhain, DE 26.

11. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

12. the great pit at the mountain

13. ← Follows from *The Sloc Mòr closed*, 17 an Cèitean, DE 26; ← Follows from *Sileas enters the word without a heading*, 19 an t-Samhain, DE 26.

14. the great pit at the mountain

15. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

16. ← Follows from *The Sloc Mòr closed*, 17 an Cèitean, DE 26; ← Follows from *The last bewers*, 15 an t-Ògmhios, DE 26; ← Follows from *Comhairle nam Mèinnean's order to Achadh dbombain*, 21 an t-Samhain, DE 26.

17. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

18. ← Follows from *The coal line carries no coal*, 10 an t-Sultain, DE 26; ← Follows from *The maor's report on the bewing families*, 22 an t-Samhain, DE 26.

- 5 **AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 26** — *The coal banded to carters, not a second engine* (Cathair dhearg). The lamp-houses judge six wagons not worth a second engine's steam and carry the last coal on by horse and cart from the goods-yard, so that the trade which crowned the kingdom's kings goes out under its own name behind horses at the last.¹⁹
- 7 **AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 26** — *Sileas copies the council's three words* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol²⁰). Sileas nic Rath enters the council's minute on the northern passes exactly as given, for a time only, the same three words Deachamh a' Chogaidh²¹ was given six years before and has not since been taken away.²²
- 8 **AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 26** — *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh dies at Àth dhìreach* (Muileann chaol). A letter in the hand of Beathag's own sister brings word that Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh has died quietly in the night at her sister's house at Àth dhìreach, five-and-seventy years old, six years after laying down the chronicler's office.²³
- 10 **AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 26** — *Sileas writes the one entry the day requires* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol²⁴). Sileas nic Rath enters Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh's death in the open chronicle in the plain accounting the office requires, naming her the first hand to note the fuel and the re-header of fourteen years, and adds nothing of grief beyond it.²⁵
- 11 **AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 26** — *An old bewer sworn a second time* (Achadh dhomhain). At the swearing of Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail²⁶'s twelve hewers at Achadh dhomhain an old man who had sworn the guild's oath in his youth tells the priest he had thought it the last oath a coal-cutter's trade would ask of him.²⁷
- 23 **AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 26** — *An Sloc Mòr²⁸'s upper galleries capped* (Achadh dhomhain). Within a fortnight of Comhairle nam Mèinnean²⁹'s order the eleven upper galleries of An Sloc Mòr are capped, their timbering left standing in the dark.³⁰

19. ← Follows from *The coal line carries no coal*, 10 an t-Sultain, DE 26; ← Follows from *Eachann given the last coal run*, 24 an t-Samhain, DE 26.

20. the Library at Muileann chaol

21. the wartime tithe

22. ← Follows from *The sixth regiment on the northern road*, 9 an Dàmhair, DE 26; ← Follows from *The coal banded to carters, not a second engine*, 5 an Dùbhlachd, DE 26.

23. ← Follows from *The fair of the present year*, 7 an t-Samhain, DE 26; ← Follows from *Sileas copies the council's three words*, 7 an Dùbhlachd, DE 26.

24. the Library at Muileann chaol

25. ← Follows from *The fair of the present year*, 7 an t-Samhain, DE 26; ← Follows from *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh dies at Àth dhìreach*, 8 an Dùbhlachd, DE 26.

26. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

27. ← Follows from *The last bewers*, 15 an t-Ògmhios, DE 26; ← Follows from *Sileas writes the one entry the day requires*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 26.

28. the great pit at the mountain

29. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

30. ← Follows from *The Sloc Mòr closed*, 17 an Cèitean, DE 26; ← Follows from *An old bewer sworn a second time*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, DE 26.

- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 26** — *An naoid-beamb rèisimeid*³¹ *'s man at Ceann leathan* (Còmhrag Ceann leathan³²). The winner of Còmhrag Ceann leathan in the regiments' first year is a broad Dia-threach of the southern Seann Skell who had fitted engines under Comann nan Goibhnean-ceangail³³ charter before the regiments took him.³⁴
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 26** — *A sentry's word at an Leabharlann*³⁵ *gate* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol³⁶). The sergeant of An dàrna rèisimeid³⁷'s first watch at an Leabharlann tells the keeper it is a queer sort of soldiering, standing watch over a door that has never opened from either side.³⁸
- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 26** — *The last coal carter of the north road* (Muileann fhada). The last carter to bring coal down the north road past An Taigh-seinnse Reòta above Muileann fhada carries a load of small coal for the landlord's own kitchen and none for sale.³⁹
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 26** — *Achadh mhòr's harvest in the present* (Achadh mhòr). The harvest of Achadh mhòr goes down to the capital in Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁴⁰'s lorries and the growers' own; the factors reckon it the heaviest in a generation and the dearest to carry.⁴¹
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 26** — *An t-ochdamh rèisimeid*⁴² *at Inis uaine keeps a school* (Inis uaine). An t-ochdamh rèisimeid at Inis uaine keeps a school in its barracks for the soldiers' children and the town's, taught by a corporal who had been a copyist.⁴³
- 19 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 27** — *The Còmhrag of the present year* (Còmhrag Ceann leathan⁴⁴). The Còmhrag at Ceann leathan is fought with staves and fists, as it has been since edged tools were banned. Two regiments and nine shires send fighters. One man dies.
- 17 AN GEARRAN, DE 27** — *The eleven books* (Doire ghlas). Ellen Marsh's eleven books are copied by hand in the Tuathaich schools and kept in the north. The library's catalogue lists the tabled request, and not the books.

31. the ninth regiment

32. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

33. the Guild of Fuel-Fitters; lit. 'the fellowship of the fitters'

34. ← Follows from *The regiments at the Còmhrag*, 14 an t-Iuchar, DE 26; ← Follows from *An Sloc Mòr's upper galleries capped*, 23 an Dùbhlachd, DE 26.

35. the Library at Muileann chaol

36. the Library at Muileann chaol

37. the second regiment

38. ← Follows from *The second regiment's library guard*, 12 an Lùnastal, DE 26; ← Follows from *An naoid-beamb rèisimeid's man at Ceann leathan*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, DE 26.

39. ← Follows from *The Sloc Mòr closed*, 17 an Cèitean, DE 26; ← Follows from *A sentry's word at an Leabharlann gate*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, DE 26.

40. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

41. ← Follows from *The last coal carter of the north road*, 27 an Dùbhlachd, DE 26.

42. the eighth regiment

43. ← Follows from *The eighth regiment at Inis uaine*, 14 an Dùbhlachd, DE 25; ← Follows from *Achadh mhòr's harvest in the present*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, DE 26.

44. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

- 29 AN CÈITEAN, DE 27** — *The Moot of the present year* (Caol mhòr). The Moot at Caol mhòr meets under Peter Hale. Its minute-books run unbroken from Walter Hale's first meeting. It has no standing in Dia-thìrich law and has never asked for any.
- 27 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 27** — *The dubhan works of the present* (Seann Skell). Dubhan is made at Seann Skell on the southern coast and at works in the east and north. Every lamp, engine, ship and lorry on the island runs on it. The coin is pegged to it, and the tithe is taken on every sale.
- 29 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 27** — *The Treasury's roll of the present year* (Cathair dhearg). The Treasury's roll for the year stands at 9,568 purses: 6,375 from the head-due, taken at eighteen purses on every five thousand heads, and 3,193 from the market-due, taken at seventeen in the hundred on every sale. The wartime tithe is carried on its own line under the regiments' pay. The windy coast pays neither due.
- 7 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 27** — *Dubhan's charter of export* (Ros dhomhain). Dubhan, who made the first working fuel and is now in his sixty-ninth year, wins from the council at Cathair dhearg, after a year of letters and three sittings, leave to sell dubhan beyond the island. It is the first leave the kingdom has given since the Severance for any good of Dia-thìr to pass beyond its waters. The charter is narrow. The Treasury sets each year's measure. The fuel is loaded only at Ros dhomhain, where a clerk of the Treasury takes the tithe on every barrel. The kingdom's depots and the Moot's are served first. Nothing of the vein goes with it: the vein's coal is not sold, and the custodians of Òrd Bhrìde⁴⁵ seal every hold. Dubhan has told neither the council nor the chronicler who buys from him. In the autumn the first tank-hull loaded under the charter goes out past the north-western capes, and on the day she sails the priests of Manannan at Seann Skell say their prayer to keep the sea shut.
- 6 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 27** — *The altar-coal* (Seann Skell). The Rite's twelve hewers at the Sloc Mòr cut the year's altar-coal. It fills four baskets. The high custodian at Seann Skell shares it among the houses of the Rite by lot.
- 22 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 27** — *The chronicler's note on the present* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁴⁶). Sileas nic Rath writes at the foot of the year that the kingdom's record is whole in every part but two: the war, which is sealed, and the north, which was not asked.
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *The present* (Cathair dhearg). The coal is all but gone. The trade of the island runs on a name that once belonged to one man. The Dia-thìrich hold the capital and the sea. The Tuathaich hold the north, a grievance five years old, their Church, and the memory of the First Canoe, Naomh Breandan's voyage to the Isle of the Blessed, which the people who have twice defeated them still call folklore.⁴⁷

45. the order of Bride's flame

46. the Library at Muileann chaol

- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *Joe Ashby asks Peter Hale about An t-Aon Leabhar Deug*⁴⁸ (Caol mhòr). Joe Ashby puts to Peter Hale the question of whether an Leabharlann⁴⁹ means to refuse An t-Aon Leabhar Deug outright or only to leave them waiting; Peter answers that a catalogue naming the request and not the books has not yet said either word.⁵⁰
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *Peter Hale opens Tional nan Tuathach*⁵¹'s book in his own hand (Caol mhòr). At Caol mhòr, still new enough to the chair to write rather than pass the pen, Peter Hale opens the year's minute-book himself and reads the standing tally: no ruling of any Dia-threach court names Tional nan Tuathach a lawful body, and none has ever been asked.⁵²
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *An t-Ionmhas*⁵³'s clerk at Ros dhombain keeps a second tally (Ros dhomhain). An t-Ionmhas's clerk who weighs and marks the ordinary barrels of dubhan at Ros dhomhain begins, unasked, a private tally of the fuel that leaves the quay for the fleets and the regiments and pays An t-Ionmhas nothing, and folds it each quarter into his own drawer.⁵⁴
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *The council hears the petition for export* (Cathair dhearg). At the first of three sittings of the council at Cathair dhearg, in the winter, the petition for leave to sell dubhan beyond the island is read and heard in silence. The twelve give no answer that day. Sileas nic Rath copies the clerk's draft twice.⁵⁵
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *The custodians of Òrd Bhride*⁵⁶ search and seal An Eala Dhubh⁵⁷'s holds (Ros dhomhain). Over three days at Ros dhomhain two custodians of Òrd Bhride search every hold of An Eala Dhubh by lamp for the vein's own coal before it is loaded, and set their order's mark in wax at each coaming once it is filled, waiting until the wax hardens past any hand's reopening.⁵⁸

47. ← Leads to *Ellen Marsh tells A' Chiad Churach again*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *A boy asks whose fire it was*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *Sileas sets down the rhyme unanswered*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *The telling of the fire in the canoe*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

48. the eleven books of Tuathaich accounts gathered by Ellen Marsh over eleven years and offered to the Library
49. the Library at Muileann chaol

50. ← Follows from *The eleven books*, 17 an Gearran, DE 27; ← Leads to *Peter Hale opens Tional nan Tuathach's book in his own hand*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

51. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

52. ← Follows from *The Moot of the present year*, 29 an Cèitean, DE 27; ← Follows from *Joe Ashby asks Peter Hale about An t-Aon Leabhar Deug*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *An t-Ionmhas's clerk at Ros dhombain keeps a second tally*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

53. the Treasury

54. ← Follows from *The dubhan works of the present*, 27 an t-Ògmhios, DE 27; ← Follows from *The Treasury's roll of the present year*, 29 an t-Iuchar, DE 27; ← Follows from *Peter Hale opens Tional nan Tuathach's book in his own hand*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *The council hears the petition for export*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

55. ← Follows from *Dubhan's charter of export*, 7 an t-Sultain, DE 27; ← Follows from *An t-Ionmhas's clerk at Ros dhombain keeps a second tally*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *The custodians of Òrd Bhride search and seal An Eala Dhubh's holds*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

56. the order of Brìde's flame

57. the Black Swan, the first tank-hull loaded under the charter of export

- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *A clerk of An t-Ionmhas*⁵⁹ marks the first and last barrel loaded (Ros dhomhain). At Ros dhomhain a clerk of An t-Ionmhas marks the first barrel and the last of An Eala Dhubh⁶⁰'s loading alike, and every fifth barrel between, keeping the tithe the charter sets before the custodians close each hold.⁶¹
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *Joe Ashby watches An Eala Dhubh*⁶² pass off *Caol mhòr* (Caol mhòr). Off his own headland with an empty line, Joe Ashby watches An Eala Dhubh pass under full steam bound north-about, and thinks of the six years since his own name came off Comann nan Goibhnean-ceangail⁶³ rolls under a charter written for a different fuel.⁶⁴
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *Anna nic Phàil asks how the vein is to be kept out* (Cathair dhearg). At the second sitting on the petition for export, in the spring, Anna nic Phàil asks the council how the kingdom will be sure that nothing of the vein's coal goes out with the fuel. The council's answer is the term no councillor argues: the custodians of Òrd Bhride⁶⁵ shall seal every hold.⁶⁶
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *The copying of An t-Aon Leabhar Deug*⁶⁷ (Doire ghlas). An t-Aon Leabhar Deug of Ellen Marsh's gathering go from school to school in the north, each copied by the eldest children in a schoolroom hand before it passes on.⁶⁸
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *A lamp-fitter of Caol mhòr on An t-Aon Leabhar Deug*⁶⁹ (Caol mhòr). An old lamp-fitter of Caol mhòr, let go from Comann nan Goibhnean-ceangail⁷⁰ rolls with Joe Ashby, says a book finished is still a book, whatever an Leabharlann⁷¹ does with it.⁷²

58. ← Follows from *Dubhan's charter of export*, 7 an t-Sultain, DE 27; ← Follows from *The council hears the petition for export*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *A clerk of An t-Ionmhas marks the first and last barrel loaded*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

59. the Treasury

60. the Black Swan, the first tank-hull loaded under the charter of export

61. ← Follows from *Dubhan's charter of export*, 7 an t-Sultain, DE 27; ← Follows from *The custodians of Òrd Bhride search and seal An Eala Dhubh's holds*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *Joe Ashby watches An Eala Dhubh pass off Caol mhòr*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

62. the Black Swan, the first tank-hull loaded under the charter of export

63. the Guild of Fuel-Fitters; lit. 'the fellowship of the fitters'

64. ← Follows from *Dubhan's charter of export*, 7 an t-Sultain, DE 27; ← Follows from *A clerk of An t-Ionmhas marks the first and last barrel loaded*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *Anna nic Phàil asks how the vein is to be kept out*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

65. the order of Brìde's flame

66. ← Follows from *Dubhan's charter of export*, 7 an t-Sultain, DE 27; ← Follows from *Joe Ashby watches An Eala Dhubh pass off Caol mhòr*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *The copying of An t-Aon Leabhar Deug*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

67. the eleven books of Tuathaich accounts gathered by Ellen Marsh over eleven years and offered to the Library

68. ← Follows from *The eleven books*, 17 an Gearran, DE 27; ← Follows from *Anna nic Phàil asks how the vein is to be kept out*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *A lamp-fitter of Caol mhòr on An t-Aon Leabhar Deug*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

69. the eleven books of Tuathaich accounts gathered by Ellen Marsh over eleven years and offered to the Library

70. the Guild of Fuel-Fitters; lit. 'the fellowship of the fitters'

71. the Library at Muileann chaol

21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27 — *The twelve bear the petition three times* (Cathair dhearg). The council at Cathair dhearg sits three times on the petition for leave to export dubhan, in the winter, the spring and the summer's end, and grants it inside the hour at the third.⁷³

21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27 — *An Eala Dhubh⁷⁴ stands out of Ros dhombhain* (Ros dhomhain). An Eala Dhubh stands out of Ros dhomhain on the morning tide with An t-Ionmhas⁷⁵'s seal on her hatches, and the harbour's children run the length of the mole beside her.

⁷⁶

21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27 — *A lamp for the Taigh-seinnse Mòr's gate* (Cuan chrom). The landlord of An Taigh-seinnse Mòr⁷⁷ above Cuan chrom hangs a dubhan lamp over his gate on the old coal road for the lorries that come by night, the last of the great inns but one to do so.⁷⁸

21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27 — *The ferry of Àth gharbh fitted with an engine* (Àth gharbh). The ferry at Àth gharbh is fitted with a dubhan engine and a chain across the ford; the old ferryman keeps his pole in the boat and says he will want it.⁷⁹

21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27 — *The four baskets carried south* (Achadh dhomhain). An Sloc Mòr⁸⁰'s twelve hewers cut the year's altar-coal in an Dàmhair; the maor's cart carries the four baskets to Achadh dhomhain station under a tarpaulin, and they go south to the southern Seann Skell in a van of Slighe a' Ghuail⁸¹ kept for nothing else that week.⁸²

21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27 — *The lot drawn in the rain at Bride's house* (Seann Skell). Priests of three lesser coast houses walk or ride two and three days to see the lot drawn in a hard autumn rain at the southern Seann Skell, the folded slips kept dry under a second tarpaulin while Alasdair mac Ìomhair draws.⁸³

72. ← Follows from *The eleven books*, 17 an Gearran, DE 27; ← Follows from *The copying of An t-Aon Leabhar Deug*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *The twelve bear the petition three times*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

73. ← Follows from *Dubban's charter of export*, 7 an t-Sultain, DE 27; ← Follows from *A lamp-fitter of Caol mbòr on An t-Aon Leabhar Deug*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *An Eala Dhubh stands out of Ros dhombhain*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

74. the Black Swan, the first tank-hull loaded under the charter of export

75. the Treasury

76. ← Follows from *Dubban's charter of export*, 7 an t-Sultain, DE 27; ← Follows from *The twelve bear the petition three times*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *A lamp for the Taigh-seinnse Mòr's gate*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

77. the great house on the old coal road above Cuan chrom, whose new hall is let to the Guild of Hewers

78. ← Follows from *The inns take the new lamps*, 30 am Màrt, DE 9; ← Follows from *An Eala Dhubh stands out of Ros dhombhain*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *The ferry of Àth gharbh fitted with an engine*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

79. ← Follows from *A lamp for the Taigh-seinnse Mòr's gate*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

80. the great pit at the mountain

81. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

82. ← Follows from *The altar-coal*, 6 an Dàmhair, DE 27; ← Leads to *The lot drawn in the rain at Bride's house*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

83. ← Follows from *The altar-coal*, 6 an Dàmhair, DE 27; ← Follows from *The four baskets carried south*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *Alasdair mac Ìomhair draws four houses*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *Alasdair mac Ìomhair draws four houses* (Seann Skell). Past his eighty-fifth summer and steadied on a novice's shoulder, Alasdair mac Ìomhair draws Cnoc bheag, Seann Bhrál, the western Seann Skell and, by chance, the southern house itself from the nine houses' slips.⁸⁴
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *Alasdair mac Ìomhair on the lot's pattern* (Seann Skell). Asked by a young priest whether the altar-coal will still be cut in ten or twenty years, Alasdair mac Ìomhair, who has drawn the lot six-and-fifty times, says only that he has learned not to promise a young man what the mountain will do next.⁸⁵
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *A coast priest measures the fall of the lot* (Seann Skell). A priest of a house so small the lot has never before fallen to it walks three days to see the four baskets drawn for, and says afterward that her grandmother's telling remembered them carted to the coast houses by the wagon-load.⁸⁶
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *The old hewer bears the lot fell home* (Achadh dhomhain). Word reaches the twelve hewers at Achadh dhomhain that the southern house drew its own basket back to itself; the eldest among them, sworn once already as a young man to the dissolved guild, calls it the vein's own way of being droll.⁸⁷
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *Sileas enters the altar-coal return* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁸⁸). The maor's return on the four baskets reaches Sileas nic Rath's table at Muileann chaol within the fortnight; she enters it in the ordinary column and lets pass, unwritten, her own thought of forty baskets shrunk to four.⁸⁹
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *Còmbrag Ceann leathan*⁹⁰'s champion falls to a hewer's son (Còmhrag Ceann leathan). In a bout added at the crowd's asking for the year's champion against all comers, An naoidheamh rèisimeid⁹¹'s man loses to a twenty-year-old hewer's son of Cnoc bheag; the fair-wardens' own return calls the championship passed back to the shires as it stood before the regiments came to it.⁹²

84. ← Follows from *The altar-coal*, 6 an Dàmhair, DE 27; ← Follows from *The lot drawn in the rain at Bride's house*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *Alasdair mac Ìomhair on the lot's pattern*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

85. ← Follows from *The altar-coal*, 6 an Dàmhair, DE 27; ← Follows from *Alasdair mac Ìomhair draws four houses*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *A coast priest measures the fall of the lot*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

86. ← Follows from *The altar-coal*, 6 an Dàmhair, DE 27; ← Follows from *Alasdair mac Ìomhair on the lot's pattern*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *The old hewer bears the lot fell home*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

87. ← Follows from *The last hewers*, 15 an t-Ògmhios, DE 26; ← Follows from *The altar-coal*, 6 an Dàmhair, DE 27; ← Follows from *A coast priest measures the fall of the lot*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *Sileas enters the altar-coal return*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

88. the Library at Muileann chaol

89. ← Follows from *The altar-coal*, 6 an Dàmhair, DE 27; ← Follows from *The chronicler's note on the present*, 22 an t-Samhain, DE 27; ← Follows from *The old hewer bears the lot fell home*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *Còmbrag Ceann leathan's champion falls to a hewer's son*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

90. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

91. the ninth regiment

92. ← Follows from *The Còmbrag of the present year*, 19 am Faoilleach, DE 27; ← Follows from *Sileas enters the altar-coal return*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *An old woman of Baile chrom is turned back three mornings*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27 — *An old woman of Baile chrom is turned back three mornings* (Baile chrom). A pass-table clerk at the boundary stones notes, unasked, that an old woman of Baile chrom came three mornings running to ask a pass for a granddaughter nursing in the capital, and walked eleven miles home again each time with no pass and no name given.

93

21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27 — *Ellen Marsh keeps the eldest back on the shortest evening* (Doire ghlas). On the evening of the shortest day Ellen Marsh sends the youngest children of her Doire ghlas school home early and keeps the eldest dozen to copy a page of the eleventh book into a third hand before the chest under the window is shut on all eleven.⁹⁴

21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27 — *Ellen Marsh tells A' Chiad Churach*⁹⁵ *again* (Doire ghlas). Ellen Marsh tells her eldest pupils, as her own mother told her, A' Chiad Churach's crossing through Ceò Mhanannain⁹⁶ with a fire tended turn and turn about in a clay pot of wet moss, kept faithfully the whole way for fear a canoe that lost it would not find the isle again.

97

21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27 — *A boy asks whose fire it was* (Doire ghlas). A thirteen-year-old asks Ellen Marsh whose fire A' Chiad Churach⁹⁸ carried, since the telling names none of the crew; she answers, as her own mother once answered her, that the telling does not say, and that a fire no one hand still claims is no less a fire for it.⁹⁹

21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27 — *Sileas sets down the rhyme unanswered* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹⁰⁰). Closing the year's ledger, Sileas nic Rath sets down the rhyme she first overheard from a northern carrier in an Leabharlann¹⁰¹'s own yard, black the coal and black the dubhan, but whose is the fire, in both tongues, and gives it no answer of her own.¹⁰²

21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27 — *A novice to hold the lot-bowl* (Seann Skell). A novice of fifteen is given the office of holding the bowl for the lot of the altar-coal at the southern Seann Skell and does not sleep the night before for the weight of it.¹⁰³

93. ← Follows from *The sixth regiment on the northern road*, 9 an Dàmhair, DE 26; ← Follows from *Còmbrag Ceann leathan's champion falls to a hewer's son*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *Ellen Marsh keeps the eldest back on the shortest evening*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

94. ← Follows from *The eleven books*, 17 an Gearran, DE 27; ← Follows from *An old woman of Baile chrom is turned back three mornings*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *Ellen Marsh tells A' Chiad Churach again*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

95. the First Canoe, the voyage of Naomh Breandan

96. Manannan's mist over the eastern sea

97. ← Follows from *The present*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Follows from *Ellen Marsh keeps the eldest back on the shortest evening*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *A boy asks whose fire it was*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

98. the First Canoe, the voyage of Naomh Breandan

99. ← Follows from *The present*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Follows from *Ellen Marsh tells A' Chiad Churach again*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *Sileas sets down the rhyme unanswered*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

100. the Library at Muileann chaol

101. the Library at Muileann chaol

102. ← Follows from *The present*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Follows from *A boy asks whose fire it was*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *A novice to hold the lot-bowl*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *The southern house draws its own basket* (Seann Skell). At the lot of the four baskets the southern house of Bride at Seann Skell is drawn among the four, so that one basket goes no farther than across the yard.¹⁰⁴
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *The lamps of Muileann chaol lit at three* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹⁰⁵). At Muileann chaol in an t-Samhain the keeper orders the gallery lamps lit from three in the afternoon and no fire after dark.¹⁰⁶
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *The regiments' winter musters*. The winter musters of the nine regiments show some three thousand three hundred men on the rolls and twenty-three guns serviceable.¹⁰⁷
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *The telling of the fire in the canoe* (Doire ghlas). On the shortest day Ellen Marsh tells the eldest children at Doire ghlas the telling of A' Chiad Churach¹⁰⁸ and of the fire its crew carried in a clay pot through the mist.¹⁰⁹
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *Eachdraidh na Rìoghachd*¹¹⁰'s last page of the year left open (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹¹¹). Sileas nic Rath leaves Eachdraidh na Rìoghachd open on its stand at the year's end with the ink dry, as Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh had done before her.¹¹²
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *Cnoc ghorm's elders at the northern posts* (Cnoc ghorm). Elders of Cnoc ghorm going south to the fair show their passes at An siathamh rèisimeid¹¹³'s posts by the boundary stones, and write in their own book that the sergeant wished them a good road.¹¹⁴

103. ← Follows from *The altar-coal*, 6 an Dàmhair, DE 27; ← Follows from *Sileas sets down the rhyme unanswered*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *The southern house draws its own basket*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

104. ← Follows from *The altar-coal*, 6 an Dàmhair, DE 27; ← Follows from *A novice to hold the lot-bowl*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *The lamps of Muileann chaol lit at three*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

105. the Library at Muileann chaol

106. ← Follows from *The chronicler's note on the present*, 22 an t-Samhain, DE 27; ← Follows from *The southern house draws its own basket*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *The regiments' winter musters*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

107. ← Follows from *An Cogadh Fada ends*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22; ← Follows from *The lamps of Muileann chaol lit at three*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *The telling of the fire in the canoe*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

108. the First Canoe, the voyage of Naomh Breandan

109. ← Follows from *The present*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Follows from *The regiments' winter musters*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *Eachdraidh na Rìoghachd's last page of the year left open*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

110. the royal chronicle of the restored kingdom

111. the Library at Muileann chaol

112. ← Follows from *The chronicler's note on the present*, 22 an t-Samhain, DE 27; ← Follows from *The telling of the fire in the canoe*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *Cnoc ghorm's elders at the northern posts*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

113. the sixth regiment

114. ← Follows from *The sixth regiment on the northern road*, 9 an Dàmhair, DE 26; ← Follows from *Eachdraidh na Rìoghachd's last page of the year left open*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27; ← Leads to *An Taigh-òsta Gri-anach in the present year*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27 — *An Taigh-òsta Grianach*¹¹⁵ in the present year (Cnoc dhìreach). An Taigh-òsta Grianach at Cnoc dhìreach sells fuel at its yard, beds under its roof and suppers by a dubhan lamp, and its sign still names all three.¹¹⁶

115. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

116. ← Follows from *An Taigh-òsta Grianach*, 4 am Màrt, DE 10; ← Follows from *Cnoc ghorm's elders at the northern posts*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27.

PART THREE

A Gazetteer of the Age

A

Achadh dhomhain (Muileann chrom). Founded 10 an t-Ogmhios, FE 272. The deep-field town of the camps' granaries above An Sloc Mòr¹ was the hewers' own. Comann nan Gualadairean² kept its hall there and its day of binding, which passed empty in the first year with no son or daughter brought to be bound. The hall was sold before the guild was dissolved in DE 12, and became a dubhan depot with its carved lintel, the guild's oath cut in it, left above the pumps; the oath-stone went to the library. Comhairle nam Mèinnean³ bought the last private share in An Sloc Mòr when Taigh Mhic Ùisdein⁴ moved to shipping, and its pumps ran on dubhan from the thirteenth year. In DE 26 An Sloc Mòr was closed, one face kept for Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail⁵, its upper galleries capped; twelve hewers were sworn at the town to cut the altar-coal, one an old man who had sworn the guild's oath in his youth, and in the present year the four baskets of their coal were carried south to the lot. Known for Comann nan Gualadairean' hall, An Sloc Mòr and the altar-coal.

Achadh mhòr (Achadh mhòr). Founded 2 an t-Samhain, GE 4,000. The town of the great granary fields in the south was the drovers' country. In DE 9 the drover families of Achadh mhòr, with no oxen left to drive, sold their teams to farmers of the granary country at the drove-inn at An Sligeanach Fad' às⁶, and the works at the southern Seann Skell took the price of the beasts against eleven lorries. The inn kept its trade by selling the drovers dubhan. The harvest of the fields went down to the capital's mills by lorry in eleven days the next year, the old drovers watching it pass from the field-gates. Its granary factors sold oats to the western pit towns through Tional nan Tuathach⁷ in the years of the holdouts, and wrote to Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁸ that they knew of no rule against it. In the present year its harvest is the heaviest in a generation and the dearest to carry. Known for the drovers who bought lorries.

1. the great pit at the mountain

2. the Guild of Hewers; lit. 'the fellowship of the colliers'

3. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

4. the house of Mac Ùisdein

5. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

6. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

7. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

8. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

Àth bheag (Baile fhiadhaich). Founded 14 an t-Samhain, LE 224. The small western crossing lay on the column's road. Its report in DE 22 is the first An Clàr Foscailte⁹ copies: the smith's boy woke the maor, Cailean mac Griogair, who stood at the field's edge in a borrowed coat and watched the column ford the water without going down to ask where it was bound, and the miller's wife, watching from the mill loft, saw no banner among them and no drum, only a man at the head whom the rest left the whole width of the road. It is a village of a mill, a smithy and a score of houses beside the ford, and its people had never, before that night, sent a report to Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹⁰ of anything. Its maor's report and the miller's wife's words stand together in the library's file, the first two papers of the column's road. Known for the ford the column crossed.

Àth bheag (Àth bheag). Founded 26 an Cèitean, GE 4,347. The ford town on the east coast, under the pirate watch, sent its salt inland on the drove road past Baile iséal behind oxen for as long as anyone remembered, until a salt-master of Àth bheag bought a dubhan lorry in the eighth year and sent the first salt west by it. The salt reached the yard at Muileann chrom and went on to Cathair dhearg in a covered wagon behind the empty tanks, the first load the new engine carried toward the capital that was not dubhan. The last ox-drove on the eastern salt road went the next spring, and within a few years the drovers of the east coast had sold their oxen. Its tinsmith made the iron hood for the trial lamp at Baile iséal. In the war raiders from the eastern waters took two salt-boats off Àth bheag and burned a third while the fleets were in the north-west. Known for the eastern salt-road, and the first salt carried by lorry.

Àth dhearg (Cnoc gheal). Founded 19 an Dùbhlachd, FE 364. The town under Taigh-solais Àth dhearg¹¹ on the north-east cape waited longest for its light's turning. The work took a month longer there than at the other beacons, for the stair of the tower was too narrow for the new tank, and a crane had to be walked from Seann Tarr to lift it to the lantern from outside, the rope-makers of that town having refused to hire out their cordage for it. Peigi nic Ascaill wrote from here to Caol mhòr for Tuathaich fitters. The keeper has written since for spare chimney-glass, the stair still too narrow to carry up more than one at a time. Through the autumn of the column's year his log records that no ship of the fleets passed the cape in three months. The crane that lifted the tank was left standing on the cape for a year afterwards, rusting, until Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹² sent a wagon for it; the children of the town had meanwhile made it the gallows of a game whose rules none of their elders could follow. Known for the beacon whose tank went up the outside of the tower.

9. the open record of the war years

10. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

11. the lighthouse at Àth dhearg

12. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

Àth dhìreach (Achadh chaol). Founded 8 am Màrt, AE 90. The small eastern town of An dàrna rèisimeid¹³'s garrison was quiet until the war. Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh, who had been royal chronicler since before Linn an Dubhain¹⁴, laid down the office in DE 20 and went there to live, and watched An dàrna rèisimeid's camp being pitched from her garden wall when it was raised in the autumn of the war's first year, writing to Sileas nic Rath of it. The regiment guards Slighe a' Ghuail¹⁵ and the library road. She died at Àth dhìreach in DE 26. The town is small, a street of houses on Slighe a' Ghuail's embankment and the regiment's camp on the water-meadow below it. The camp's first winter was spent under canvas; its huts went up the next spring from timber brought by Slighe a' Ghuail, and the town's one inn has taken the regiment's custom since. Known for An dàrna rèisimeid, and the old chronicler's last years.

Àth gharbh (Doire shean). Founded 28 an t-Sultain, FE 1,855. The walled ford town is A' chiad chabhlaich¹⁶'s station, its hulls lying in the harbour of Doire shean a short walk away. Its ferry had carried coal across for the eastern farms every week until the fourth year, and carried grain and passengers after at a higher fare. When A' chiad chabhlaich was raised in DE 21 from the south-west harbours, four of the ferry-men went into it, and the ferry was worked through the war by the oldest of them and his daughter. In the present year it is fitted with a dubhan engine and a chain across the ford; the old ferryman keeps his pole in the boat. Known for A' chiad chabhlaich's station, and its ferry.

Àth leathan (Seann Skell). Founded 8 am Màrt, LE 1,303. The small Tuathaich pit town of the western hills was the first of the holdouts and the ground of the first battle of the war. Its pit captain Calder died in the sixteenth year and the hewers kept his daughter Ruth to speak for them; she wrote the letters of the five towns, and was their spokeswoman in Tional nan Tuathach¹⁷ until they walked out. In the war the hewers of the five towns came down to Àth leathan with their pit-lamps lit at noon, and her list at the pit-shed ran past four hundred names in six evenings and near nine hundred souls with their carriers by the battle's eve. The battle of Àth leathan was fought below its spoil-heaps; after it the town's pits were given as flooded. The western seams were capped by Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹⁸'s order in DE 23 with An seachdamh rèisimeid¹⁹ standing by, and the regiment built its post on the road below the town. On the field stands the cairn the Tuathaich families built without leave, and it has grown by a stone or two every time the patrols pass it. Known for Ruth Calder, Blàr Àth leathan²⁰ and the cairn.

13. the second regiment

14. the Dubhan Era (DE); lit. 'the era of Dubhan'

15. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

16. the first fleet

17. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

18. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

19. the seventh regiment

20. the Battle of Àth leathan

Àth naomh (Cuan shean). Founded 26 an t-Giblean, LE 900. The small town of the harbour carts in the Cuan shean shire blesses its carts every spring, horses and all, and in the seventh year its priest held a dubhan lamp on a tail-board blessed because it was on the cart. Its forges smelt the bog-iron of the district, and in DE 24 took the contract for the regiments' small arms and field-guns with Caol iséal, the forge-towns of the old vein country following; a smith of the town counts his musket-stocks by the hundred. The town lies on the harbour road of the Cuan shean shire, where the carts of An ceathramh cabhlach²¹'s harbour go up and down all day; since the war its forges work by dubhan heat, and the blessing of the carts at the spring draws the regiments' own wagoners to stand with their teams among the town's. Known for its blessing of the harbour carts, and its forges.

Àth naomh (Cnoc thais). Founded 26 an t-Sultain, FE 2,780. The Tuathaich town of the citadel over the holy ford was the fourth of the western pit towns. Its two delegates walked the hill path to Muileann àrsaidh in DE 16, the elder with a stick in either hand, and signed the agreement in their own hands. Its company of sixty stood at Àth leathan. In the war it opened its road to the regiments without a siege, with Tobar dhearg of the hills, and its pits were flooded; An Clàr Foscailte²² names no holdouts taken there. A man of Àth naomh went with Tom Varley's six to an Oirthir Ghaothach²³. Its citadel over the ford, older than any pit, has the town's grain in it now, the pits being capped; the delegates who signed at Muileann àrsaidh were not asked by the regiments what they had signed, and the town has kept the copy of the agreement in the citadel's chest with its charter. Known for its citadel over the holy ford, and the road opened without a siege.

21. the fourth fleet

22. the open record of the war years

23. the windy coast

B

Baile chrom (Baile chrom). Founded 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,464. The Tuathaich town under the Baile chrom light keeps Oidhche Glaise¹ vigil. Its light was turned to dubhan in DE 7 by fitters of Caol mhòr, Comhairle nan Taighean-solais² having none of its own to send so far north, and when the burner failed that winter it was mended on a smith's anvil in the town. In the war, in the first winter of the regiments in the north, a file of An ceathramh rèisimeid³ was sent round by the headland farms to search the town, and found it dark and silent on Oidhche Glaise, every door shut and every lamp out. The house of Margaret Crane on the lighthouse road kept the vigil alone; a soldier of the file set his lamp down in her passage rather than carry its light past her, and another said afterwards that the house had searched him back. The regiments reported the search, and that they found nothing. The town lies below its light on the headland, its houses of grey stone; Oidhche Glaise is kept in every house with its lamp out, as it was kept before the war. Known for Oidhche Glaise vigil kept against a search.

Baile ghorm (Baile ghorm). Founded 7 an t-Ògmhios, GE 622. The south-west anchorage of the wolf-post quays took up engines early: two of its skippers sent for burners and a boatwright of Caol fhiadhaich in the sixth year, and a dubhan pump was set on its quays in the fifteenth, the first on that coast. An treas cabhlach⁴ was raised there in DE 21 and took the quays for its own, the fishing boats going to the old beach with their pump; it carried the army's dubhan up the west coast in tank-hulls to the regiments in the hills. The quays were lengthened by forty paces for its tank-hulls in DE 24. The wolf-posts that gave the quays their name were cut down to make room for the tank-hulls' moorings, and one was kept, at the quay's end, for the town's sake. Known for An treas cabhlach's anchorage and tank-hulls.

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1. the Grey Night
 2. the Lighthouse Board
 3. the fourth regiment
 4. the third fleet

Baile ìseal (Àth bheag). Founded 14 an t-Samhain, LE 197. The small town under Taigh-solais Baile ìseal⁵ gave the dubhan its first trial as a light. Twenty barrels were landed at its slip in the fifth year, and Peigi nic Ascaill set a burner of two wick-rings in the storm-lantern of the light and burned it on a stage below the tower, beside the coal light, night after night for more than three months. The retired keeper Murchadh mac Coinnich kept its log for her; a fisherman of the town, coming home in a haar, steered by the trial lamp when the tower's coal light was lost above him; and the keeper Seonag nic Thòmais, who had kept the fuel off her stair, came down at last to ask how the burner was made. The lights of the coast were turned by order the next year. The town's brewer bought the western holdouts' coal for his vats in the eighteenth year and told Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁶ he would take no lecture from it. In DE 24 An dàrna cabhlach⁷ ran down off Baile ìseal the raiders who had taken the salt-boats in the war, and the lighthouse log recorded the chase in the keeper's hand. Known for the trial lamp of the first dubhan light.

C

Caol bheag (Caol bheag). Founded 14 an Lùnastal, GE 2,414. The river port of the north-east raised An ceathramh rèisimeid¹ in DE 21. It marched down to the river and went down the Abhainn ghorm to Ros chiar in old coal barges fitted with plank benches, in a day and a half on a high river, to be shipped round the north coast to Ceann mhòr. It came home in DE 25 after four years in the Tuathaich north, and lies at Caol bheag. The regiment's barracks are the old wool stores by the river landing, and the town, which had seen the regiment go out in coal barges, saw it come home by the road in lorries, its colours cased. The maor gave a supper for the officers and none for the men, and the town gave one for the men. Known for An ceathramh rèisimeid's home.

5. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

6. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

7. the second fleet

1. the fourth regiment

Caol fhiadhaich (Caol fhiadhaich). Founded 12 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,547. The harbour of the strait-pilots and the wolf-stone was the first town to put an engine in a fishing boat. In the fifth year the boatwright Sorchá nic Dhùghaill, at her skipper's asking, bored the sternpost of the decked boat An Ròn Dubh² to take a shaft, against the first rule of Comann nan Saorluinge³, Cha tollar an druim, the keel is not bored; the smith of the town made the burner for the engine bought at Ros dhomhain. An Ròn Dubh crossed the harbour under engine, came home against a south-westerly, and was taken through the strait by a pilot whose word at the wolf-stone settled the town. Within the season all four yards were fitting engines. The guild struck and fined them; they returned their papers; and when its court at Ros dhomhain offered Sorchá readmission in DE 6 she declined it. The boats of the strait took the new fuel before any other fleet of the coast, and the skippers of Baile ghorm and Seann Warr sent to Caol fhiadhaich for boatwrights who would bore a keel. Known for An Ròn Dubh, the first engine-boat, and the bored keel.

Caol ìseal (Caol ìseal). Founded 21 am Màrt, FE 1,450. The salt-pan town of the low strait on the north coast tried the northern cake under one of its pans in the fourth year and found it boiled the brine as well as coal. In the war a clerk of An t-Ionmhas⁴ sat at the pump by the pans to take the tithe, and the salt-boilers said salt paid twice. Its forge smelts the bog-iron of the district, and in DE 24 took the kingdom's contract for the regiments' small arms; the woman who keeps it took on four boys and a girl to answer it. The pans are boiled with dubhan now, bought at the pump An t-Ionmhas's clerk sits beside, and the salt of Caol ìseal goes east and west along the north coast in engine-boats of Caol mhòr's fitting. Known for its salt pans and its forge.

Caol mhòr (Caol mhòr). Founded 31 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,462. The chief harbour of the Tuathaich was the first town of the Dia-thìrich kingdom to see the northern fuel sold, a black cake at its market in the first year, and the first to be asked about it: Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁵'s two surveyors lodged four days at Harker's inn on the harbour, were answered civilly everywhere in good Dia-thìris, and were told nothing. Tional nan Tuathach⁶ sat at Caol mhòr through the whole age. Martha Greaves took its chair after Daniel Frayne's death; the rebound minute-books were laid in its press, the key on the speaker's ring. The fitters of Caol mhòr turned the light at Baile chrom, and when Riaghailt na Cairte⁷ let them go from the southern works they came home and fitted engines without a guild, so that within a few years the harbour held more dubhan boats than any port of its size in the south. The five western pit towns walked out of Tional nan Tuathach here in DE 16, and their benches were kept chalked in the roll with nothing after them. In the war An ceathramh cabhlach⁸ searched the harbour's boats and Tional nan Tuathach's granaries were opened to the families of the western hills, whose names Thomas Rook entered in a register that ran past three hundred. In the present year Peter Hale keeps the chair and opens Tional nan Tuathach's book in his own hand. Known for Tional nan Tuathach, the fitters' boats, and the register of the western families.

2. the Black Seal, Lachann mac Neacail's fishing boat of Caol fhiadhaich, the first fitted with a dubhan engine

3. the shipwrights' fellowship

4. the Treasury

Caol ruadh (Muileann naomh). Founded 14 an Giblean, GE 2,570. The harbour of the red strait keeps the orthodox rite of Brìde's flame. Its house of Brìde bought two years' altar coal ahead in the sixth year, lest the coal fail before the rite did, and burned the last of it in the eighteenth. Its boats carried the regiments' bread along the coast in the column's year, a soldier aboard each to count the loaves, and its harbour victualled the garrisons and An dàrna cabhlach⁹ through the war; for that it was granted in DE 23 a market right for the southern strait, the sixteenth market town and the last chartered. Its first market under the charter was held in the rain on the quay. Known for its rite of Brìde's flame and the last market charter.

Caol shean (Caol shean). Founded 21 an Lùnastal, GE 4,196. The great eastern river port and pilgrims' landing keeps Scoiltean nan Draoidhean¹⁰, which in the fourth year disputed the Àrd-choimheadaiche¹¹'s letter on the new fuel. In DE 11 a letter of the school's masters to the library first used the word dubhan-tùsail, of a first attempt that seemed a dead end and proved otherwise; they used it of their own school's revival, and the library entered it and has never used it. The school still sends a teacher once a year to Muileann dhearg. A river-boat with a dubhan engine has carried pilgrims up to the landing against the current since the ninth year, in half the time of the rowed boats. Known for Scoiltean nan Draoidhean, and the word dubhan-tùsail.

Cathair dhearg (Cathair dhearg). Founded 6 an Dàmhair, GE 18. The royal seat and the temple of Macha saw the whole age begin and end in its council chamber. Its lamps were lit late and few in the first year and the lamp-houses let a hundred and forty-three of them go dark in the second. Cathal was crowned there by Macha's rite in DE 3, the grey mare pulling at her rope at the temple steps, and the mint cut new dies inked with coal until the plain seal of DE 15. The proclamation of Linn an Dubhain¹² was pinned to its market posts. Buses and hired cars came to its bridge, and the town called them by the humans' names. In the drill hall the rolls of Buidhnean an Dealachaidh¹³ were read out, dead towns struck through; in the council chamber Athchuinge Dheireannach an Tionail¹⁴ was received. The regiments went west from it, its lamp-houses were rationed in the war, and the passes of the northern office were printed there. Comhairle na Rìoghachd¹⁵ seated Somhairle mac Lachlainn, fixed the market-due, held over Tagradh na h-Èirig¹⁶, and in the present year granted Dubhan's Cairt na h-Às-mhalairt¹⁷ at the third hearing. The last coal of Slighe a' Ghuail¹⁸ came into its goods-yard behind carters' horses. Known for the council, the crowning, and Cairt na h-Às-mhalairt.

5. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

6. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

7. the charter rule that kept the Fuel-Fitters' rolls to Dia-thìrich

8. the fourth fleet

9. the second fleet

10. the druid schools

11. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

Cathair dhomhain (Cathair dhomhain).

Founded 25 an t-Iuchar, FE 634. The deep-water harbour beside the capital sent Anna nic Phàil to the council. As its councillor she gave the speaker of Tìonal nan Tuathach¹⁹ the smallest incline of the head across the council table when Athchuinge Dheireannach an Tìonail²⁰ was carried in, and in DE 25 she brought Tagradh na h-Èirig²¹ to the western towns, cutting a page of figures from her own draft before she laid it. The motion was held over morning after morning and let lie. The harbour is deep enough for the tank-hulls, and the dubhan for the capital's lamp-houses comes in there from the southern works by sea, in hulls of Taigh Mhic Ùisdein²², to be carted the short road to Cathair dhearg; the town's carters did well in the war, when the lamp-houses were rationed but the tanks were not. Known for Anna nic Phàil's Tagradh na h-Èirig.

Cathair gheal (Muileann àrsaidh). Founded 5

am Màrt, GE 1,378. The Tuathaich town of the white walls against the pirate coast had its fish from Tobar dhearg's coal. Its oldest woman, Annie Drew, gave Ellen Marsh the last telling of An Dealachadh²³ there in the seventeenth year: the smoke of the fires left burning, the new-set boundary stones, and a soldier who gave her mother bread and would not meet her eye. In the war the fleets off the north-west searched its fishing boats on every day they put out; its fishermen petitioned Tìonal nan Tuathach²⁴, folding the petition into a barrel of cod, and the searching went on. The raiders' bays off the town were found empty after the war, and its fishermen say the raiders will return when the fleets go. The white walls against the pirates have been kept whole; in the war the town's women walked them in the evenings to count the fleets' sails, and wrote the counts in a book that went to Ellen Marsh with the rest. Known for Annie Drew's telling and the searched fishing boats.

12. the Dubhan Era (DE); lit. 'the era of Dubhan'

13. the war-companies of the Severance

14. the Moot's last petition

15. the royal council of twelve

16. Anna nic Phàil's motion to pay the Tuathaich towns for what they lost in the war, brought on the Moot's last petition and allowed to die without a vote

17. Dubhan's charter to sell dubhan beyond the island

18. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

19. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

20. the Moot's last petition

21. Anna nic Phàil's motion to pay the Tuathaich towns for what they lost in the war, brought on the Moot's last petition and allowed to die without a vote

22. the house of Mac Ùisdein

23. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

24. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

Cathair mhòr (Cathair mhòr). Founded 9 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,847. The great city beside the old outpost is the seat of Comhairle nam Mèinnean²⁵, in the old stone house of Mac Ùisdein, and Comhairle nam Mèinnean's work in the age was done from it: its surveyors were named there for the northern inquiry, it bought An Sloc Mòr²⁶'s last private share, its master Fearghas mac Aonghais called for the northern returns and had Breith Leòid²⁷ read again, and Somhairle mac Lachlainn was given the western command there and chose his forty men. Ruth Calder's letter was received and filed there. An treas rèisimeid²⁸ was raised under the market cross of Taigh Mhic Ùisdein²⁹ in DE 21. Beside that cross stands the stone set up in DE 23, cut in two columns under a single heading, the regiments' dead, with the sixty-one names of Àth leathan and Muileann ghlais; Somhairle read them at its unveiling. From that year Comhairle nam Mèinnean ended the coal trade outside An Sloc Mòr. Comhairle nam Mèinnean's house keeps its northern returns, its surveys and its copy of Breith Leòid with the circuit rulings in its margins; the master of Comhairle nam Mèinnean sits in the room where Taigh Mhic Ùisdein once sat, and the house's arms are still carved above its door. Known for Comhairle nam Mèinnean's house and the stone of the sixty-one names.

Ceann leathan (Seann Chwen). Founded 19 an t-Samhain, GE 2,061. The harbour town of Còmhrag Ceann leathan³⁰ holds the annual melee on its field. In the dry first year the field was worn to dust and the gate took less than in any year its book remembers. From the seventeenth year the gate was paid wholly in coin of the plain seal. After the war the fair-wardens counted more fighters from the middle country than ever before and none from the western hills; fighters of the regiments were entered in DE 26 and An naoidheamh rèisimeid³¹'s man won it; and in the present year, fought with staves and fists, one man died, and in an added bout a hewer's son of Cnoc bheag beat An naoidheamh rèisimeid's man in the third exchange. Known for Còmhrag Ceann leathan, the annual melee.

Ceann mhòr (Ceann mhòr). Founded 6 an Cèitean, FE 163. The Tuathaich headland harbour under the Baile chrom light had one of the three northern dubhan depots from DE 15, supplied by sea. An ceathramh rèisimeid³² was landed there in the first winter of the war from hired hulls and quartered in the old human magistrate's house, the maor giving up the greater part of it and moving his household into the two upper rooms. Tional nan Tuathach³³ protested and was answered that the arrangement stood. Corporal Dùghall mac Iain was billeted on Barbara Keir, who would not give him her tongue, and heard the hymns through the wall; the regiment's files patrolled the Ceann mhòr road through the quartered year, and a byre-boy took to lifting a hand to them as they passed. When the regiment went home Tional nan Tuathach asked that the house be given to the town, and it was given to the maor. Known for the quartered magistrate's house.

25. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

26. the great pit at the mountain

27. the Leòid ruling

28. the third regiment

29. the house of Mac Ùisdein

30. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

31. the ninth regiment

Cnoc bhàn (Muileann àrsaidh). Founded 30 an Dùbhlachd, LE 62. The Tuathaich harbour facing the pirate waters kept its watch from the harbour wall with fires of the black cake from the fourth year, and its boats warned the fishing fleet in from the north-east in the year the raiders were taken off Ros dhomhain. In the war the first and fourth fleets closed Cnoc bhàn and the western Seann Skell to every boat but fishing boats, and searched those; the town shut its harbour to boats it did not know through the autumn the salt-boats were taken, and opened it again when the raiders were brought into Seann Skell. Its harbour looks north over waters the Tuathaich have fished since A' Chiad Churach³⁴, and its houses are built with their backs to the sea wind; in the war the fleets lay off the harbour mouth through the whole autumn, searching the boats that went out and again the boats that came in. Known for its watch on the pirate waters.

Cnoc bheag (Cnoc bheag). Founded 5 an t-Sultain, GE 3,908. The great river port of Òrd an t-Seabhaig³⁵ in the north-central country keeps the carved stone, which the town scrubbed of a century's coal-smoke for the mid-summer fair in the seventh year, finding under the black a second band of carving no one living had seen. An siathamh rèisimeid³⁶ was raised at Cnoc bheag in DE 21 to hold the northern road between the Tuathaich shires and the middle of the island, and Òrd an t-Seabhaig blessed its colours by their own rite; it drilled in the square beside the stone. It keeps the posts by the boundary stones where the Tuathaich going south show their passes. A hewer's son of the town beat An naoidheamh rèisimeid³⁷'s man at Còmhrag Ceann leathan³⁸ of the present year. Òrd an t-Seabhaig of the town keep their own rite, older than the regiment, and the regiment's colours hang in their hall between musters; the river port below the town is the busiest of the north-central country, and its quays take the dubhan for the northern road. Known for the carved stone and An siathamh rèisimeid.

32. the fourth regiment

33. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

34. the First Canoe, the voyage of Naomh Breandan

35. the Hawk order

36. the sixth regiment

37. the ninth regiment

38. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

Cnoc dhireach (Cnoc leathan). Founded 18 an Dàmhair, LE 1,239. The small town of An Taigh-òsta Grianach³⁹ on the old mining road kept its great inn through the age. The inn was rebuilt whole in the tenth year under a widowed landlady, who painted a new sign over her door naming what a traveller might buy there, beds and fire, and within the year half the great houses of the roads did the same. It filled to the stables at the end of the twentieth year with men walking to the drill hall at Cathair dhearg to hear their old companies' names read. In the present year it sells fuel at its yard, beds under its roof and suppers by a dubhan lamp, and its sign still names all three. Known for An Taigh-òsta Grianach and its sign of beds and fire.

Cnoc ghorm (Cnoc ghorm). Founded 15 an Dàmhair, GE 1,362. The inland seat of the Tuathaich keeps its own book of its elders. The black cake of the north was sold at its market by the basket beside the peat from the second year. Word of the pit towns' agreement reached its elders by a carrier in the sixteenth year, and they sent nothing west and nothing to Tional nan Tuathach⁴⁰. In the war its people sent three carts of meal to the western families at Doire ghlas and asked no receipt. In the year of the passes the northern office set a clerk in its old wool-hall, and the elders had their own names written first; in the present year they show their passes at An siathamh rèisimeid⁴¹'s posts going south to the fair, and write in their book that the sergeant wished them a good road. Cnoc ghorm has never had a pit or a light or a regiment; it is a town of the Tuathaich markets and councils and it sends its delegates to Tional nan Tuathach. Known for the inland seat of the Tuathaich and its elders' book.

Cnoc thais (Cnoc thais). Founded 19 an t-Sultain, GE 4,328. The market town of the two ancient mills had the only pits of the western hills that were reopened. Its pit captain Tom Varley opened again in DE 16 two shafts abandoned since the humans' time; the coal was poor, but it was theirs, and it warmed the town. His hewers found in the second shaft rotted shoring still holding the roof, and left it alone. When the regiments came in the war's first autumn Tom Varley fired his own two shafts with the pits' powder, and the town was taken, forty-one of its people with it; the old widow Mary Kessock stayed at her door and raised a hand to him as he went up the rabbit path to an Oirthir Ghaothach⁴². In the quartered year a hill farm above the town was burned and bread was left on a sill for those in the hills. Known for Tom Varley's two shafts.

Cuan chrom (Seann Vell). Founded 10 am Faoilleach, LE 1,231. The town below An Taigh-seinnse Mòr⁴³ on the old coal road is known for its steamed carp. The inn's kitchen went back to steaming its fish over wood from the road's thorn hedges when the coal grew dear. In DE 9 the Mòr opened a second hall lit wholly by dubhan, let for weddings, wakes and the meetings of the guilds, and the first wedding held in it was a carter's daughter of Cuan chrom's. In the twentieth year the carters of the north road talked in that hall through the autumn of regiments to be raised. In the present year the land-lord hangs a dubhan lamp over his gate for the lorries that come by night. Known for An Taigh-seinnse Mòr, its carp and its hall of dubhan light.

39. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

40. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

41. the sixth regiment

42. the windy coast

43. the great house on the old coal road above Cuan chrom, whose new hall is let to the Guild of Hewers

Cuan shean (Cuan shean). Founded 18 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,755. The west-coast harbour of Cuan shean is An ceathramh cabhlach⁴⁴'s. Its crier read the proclamation of Linn an Dubhain⁴⁵ from the harbour steps to the fishing crews, who asked whether it changed the day of the fish-market. When An ceathramh cabhlach was raised there in DE 21 to join the first off the Tuathaich shore, the chandlers sold out of rope and canvas within the month. The fleet is kept on the Tuathaich coast since the war, and its watch on the Bratach Ghlas reported off the north-western cape a thing longer than the hull moving under the water. Known for An ceathramh cabhlach's harbour.



Doire ghlas (Doire ghlas). Founded 26 an Giblean, GE 2,470. The great Tuathaich gathering-village is Martha Greaves's town and Ellen Marsh's. The fuel was shown burning in its mill yard in the second year. Agnes Pike's school gave its schoolroom to the binders of Tional nan Tuathach¹'s books and its back room to Ellen Marsh's gathering of Seulachdan nan Tuathach², eleven books from DE 17, whose keeping at the library was asked and laid on the table. Tional nan Tuathach's wool mills bought the holdouts' coal, and in the twentieth year its granaries stood fuller than the five years' average by half again, the autumn entry giving no reason. In the war Agnes Pike's school was given over to families of the western hills, near sixty souls on its benches, and Ellen Marsh began a twelfth book of their telling. Martha Greaves went home to Doire ghlas when she laid down the chair. In the present year An t-Aon Leabhar Deug³ go from school to school to be copied, and on the shortest evening Ellen Marsh told the eldest children the telling of A' Chiad Churach⁴. Known for Agnes Pike's school, An t-Aon Leabhar Deug, and Tional nan Tuathach's granaries.

44. the fourth fleet

45. the Dubhan Era (DE); lit. 'the era of Dubhan'

1. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

2. the Tuathaich tellings

3. the eleven books of Tuathaich accounts gathered by Ellen Marsh over eleven years and offered to the Library

4. the First Canoe, the voyage of Naomh Breandan

Doire shean (Doire shean). Founded 14 an Lùnastal, GE 695. The harbour town of Am Buabhall Fortanach⁵ and its jugged buffalo kept both through the age. The pot wants a day's slow fire, and the inn put up its price by a third in the third year as the coal grew dear; the shipmasters ate it all the same. Its landlady Oighrig nic Iain did not hang her old taproom lamp over the door when the inns of the mining roads took dubhan, but set it, cleaned and empty, on the shelf above the till. The first lorry came down to the harbour in the ninth year, and its driver sold rides round the market square until the maor stopped him. The market-clerk of Doire shean kept the new count of the years and the old side by side in his book, and in the war a third column for the tithe. In the war A' chiad chabhlaich⁶'s hulls lay in its harbour, a short walk from their station at Àth gharbh. Known for Am Buabhall Fortanach and its jugged buffalo.

F

Freiceadan Àth leathan¹ (Seann Skell). Founded 28 an Dàmhair, DE 23. The post of An seachdamh rèisimeid² on the road below Àth leathan was built in the autumn of the year after the war, when the western seams had been capped with the regiment standing by at every capping. It keeps a company there, whose patrols pass the cairn on the field and leave it standing. The regimental lists call it Freiceadan Àth leathan; the town calls it something else, which the lists do not give. Its men spent their first winter roofing it with slates bought at the western Seann Skell. The last holdouts of the hills came down to An seachdamh rèisimeid's posts on this road to give up their arms. Known for An seachdamh rèisimeid's post, called something else in the town.

5. the Lucky Buffalo, the great inn near Doire shean kept by Oighrig nic Iain

6. the first fleet

1. the Àth leathan post, the seventh regiment's post on the road below Àth leathan

2. the seventh regiment

I

Inis mhòr (Seann Vell). Founded 12 an t-Sultain, LE 730. The river port beside the capital had barracks empty of soldiers since An Dealachadh¹, let by its maor to the farmers of Seann Vell for hay. When A' chiad rèisimeid² was raised there in DE 21 from the capital's own companies the farmers were given a week to clear the long rooms, and what hay they left was fed to the regiment's horses. The regiment guards the council, the mint and the bridge over the Abhainn dhomhain, and it marched the holdouts released from the capital's gaol north to the boundary stones after the war. The town's own trade is the river: its boatmen carry the capital's goods down the Abhainn dhomhain to the sea, and since the war the regiment's stores as well, at a rate fixed by the council that the boatmen say was fixed by men who never rowed. Known for A' chiad rèisimeid's barracks.

Inis uaine (Cnoc dhubh). Founded 3 an t-Ògmhios, LE 980. The eastern town on the Abhainn chaol raised An t-ochdamh rèisimeid³ in DE 21 to guard the dubhan depots and tanks of the eastern ports, which the council feared the holdouts might fire. Its guard was made lasting in DE 25; its officers took houses in the town in place of quarters borrowed from the tank-yard's sheds, and the house of Na Seann Spioradan⁴ at Inis uaine added the regiment to its prayers. The regiment keeps a school in its barracks for its children and the town's. The tank-yard of the eastern ports lies on the river below the town, the largest store of dubhan outside the southern works, and the regiment's sentries walk its fence day and night; no hold-out came within a hundred miles of it. Known for An t-ochdamh rèisimeid's guard on the eastern tanks.

1. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

2. the first regiment

3. the eighth regiment

4. the Old Spirits

M

Muileann àrsaidh (Muileann àrsaidh). Founded 3 an t-Samhain, GE 2,466. The elder of the two ancient mills was the meeting-place of the western pit towns. They gathered first in DE 16 at the widow Sarah Dunmore's kitchen and moved to the pit-shed, and signed there the agreement not to hang their fires on one man's fuel, Ruth Calder writing and the four captains letting her sign for them. When the enforcers came west the town walled its pit-heads with spoil, old Fraser dug a trench across the southern road and let water into it before the frost, and Ruth Calder wrote her letter to the council in Sarah Dunmore's house. After Àth leathan the wounded were carried up the ridge path to her kitchen table. The siege of DE 21 took the six pit-heads one by one while Meikle kept the town's counting of meal and coal; the eastern pit-head was given up without a fight, the last line gave way, Tom Varley went north to Cnoc thais, and Sarah Dunmore opened her own door. Its pits were flooded and capped with the others in the year after the war. Known for the pit towns' agreement and the siege of the six pit-heads.

Muileann bheag (Muileann leathan). Founded 14 an Giblean, LE 1,530. The Tuathaich town under Taigh-solais Muileann bheag¹ on the north coast had the one light of the five whose fuel was carted from the north, for the beacon was turned to dubhan in DE 7 with fuel carted from the north and bought at Caol mhòr; of the five lights it alone was not fed by sea from the southern Seann Skell. Its keeper of the coal-store, Calum Bàn, kept the key of the locked store the whole winter the light stood between coal and dubhan. In the fourteenth year a fitter let go from the southern works under Riaghailt na Cairte² was taken on at Muileann bheag, on the keeper's word, to mend a threshing engine none of the district's smiths would touch. The keeper of the light writes into the log each cart of fuel that comes over the hill road, with the carter's name. Known for the one light turned with the north's own fuel.

1. the lighthouse at Muileann bheag

2. the charter rule that kept the Fuel-Fitters' rolls to Dia-thìrich

Muileann chaol (Cnoc bhàn). Founded 18 an t-Ògmhios, GE 3,218. The town of the great library lay up its valley road through the age with the paper-mill's race below it and Leabharlann Muileann chaol³ above. The carriers of the library road brought up the first word of the northern fuel, and the black cake was burned at its market before the chronicler had seen it. In the dry first year the mill-race ran too low to turn the paper-mill's wheel, and the keeper Ragnall mac Mhuirich ordered no fire in the reading-room before the middle of an t-Samhain and none after dark, a rule the house kept in every hard winter after. Sileas nic Rath came up the valley in the eleventh year as clerk to Seanchaidh na Rìoghachd⁴, and began here the box of slips in which the fuel's name was spelled four ways; Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh re-headed fourteen years of Eachdraidh na Rìoghachd⁵ in the house by lamplight when the new count of the years was proclaimed, and set Comann nan Gualadairean⁶ dies beside their oath-stone in the lower gallery. The town saw its first soldiery when An dàrna rèisimeid⁷ was raised at Àth dhìreach to guard the library road, and a sergeant of that regiment kept the gate in the present year. In the new wing's lower gallery stands the room sealed in DE 24, behind a door of oak two inches thick; its key hangs on a cord under the keeper's shirt. Known for the library, its re-headed chronicle, and the sealed room.

Muileann chrom (Muileann chrom). Founded 11 an Gearran, FE 1,556. The great mill on the river bend is Slighe a' Ghuail⁸'s yard, and the age changed it more than any town on the line. Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn⁹'s first dubhan engine was hauled there on a wagon by twelve horses of Òrd Mhacha¹⁰ in DE 8, a priest of the order standing in the ford to his thighs to speak them out of it and saying over the engine the blessing for a horse setting out on a long road. Eachann mac Ruairidh, of the yard families, learned to drive it and taught it to the others, the Frisealach brothers first; an old driver would not ride, a fireman was struck from the roll, and a boy of the yard rows was killed under a wagon in the first year. Two years later the coal engines were laid up, nine of them standing in the long siding with the grass coming up between the sleepers and the children of the rows playing at driving in their cabs. In Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹¹'s own timetables the line lost the word coal from its name. In the war the yard went to a double shift and loaded sealed wagons of arms for Seann Bhral, signed for weight and not for goods; in the present year Eachann drove Slighe a' Ghuail's last run of coal. Known for Slighe a' Ghuail's yard and the first dubhan engine.

3. the Library at Muileann chaol

4. the royal chronicler

5. the royal chronicle of the restored kingdom

6. the Guild of Hewers; lit. 'the fellowship of the colliers'

7. the second regiment

8. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

9. the Rail Board; lit. 'the board of the iron way'

10. the order of Macha

11. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

Muileann dhearg (Muileann dhearg). Founded 30 an t-Sultain, LE 2. The town of the red mill beside Cill ghlas lost its pits in DE 10. Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹²'s surveyor wrote them spent, the last shift came up, and the youngest hewer stood with the last lamp used on the face until the pit captain hung it on the rack himself. The families walked down to Seann Toll. The druid house of the town was given to its caretaker to keep with the graves, and once a year Scoiltean nan Draoidhean¹³ at Caol shean sends a teacher to give the one lecture that remains, to an empty quarter and few hearers. The red mill grinds on. The red mill beside Cill ghlas never belonged to the pits and grinds for the farms of the district as it did before the coal; the miller bought a dubhan engine for the dry summers and keeps the wheel for the wet ones. The pit-heads stand roofless on the hill above the town. Known for the pits that closed and the lecture given to an empty quarter.

Muileann fhada (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Founded 8 an Dàmhair, FE 550. The town below An Taigh-seinnse Reòta on the north road counted the coal going away in the carts that passed its inn: a third fewer in the third year, and its landlord shut one of his two stable yards. In DE 10 the Reòta was the last of the great inns to keep a wick lamp in every room, and its landlord wrote to Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹⁴ that he would go on doing so; the lorry-drivers who stopped there took their suppers by the fire. The enforcers' two lorries lay a night there on their way west. In the column's year the regiments' lorries took on fuel at a pump set up in its yard, the landlord renting the yard to Comhairle nam Mèinnean and keeping his wicks inside, and the last carter to bring coal down the north road carried a load for the Reòta's own kitchen and none for sale. Known for An Taigh-seinnse Reòta, the last inn of the wick.

Muileann ghlas (Dùn chrom). Founded 16 an t-Samhain, FE 748. The small mill town on Rathad na Fèille¹⁵ a day's walk from the capital gave its name to both the old battle and the last of An Cogadh Fada¹⁶. The column camped on its fields in DE 22, and the first and third regiments came down Rathad na Fèille to meet it. In the morning's fighting the mill was taken by the column and taken back, the miller's wife moving her pots out of whatever corner the fighting last left; An treas rèisimeid¹⁷'s four guns, hauled the last two miles by hand, found the column's thorn-stand line; at dusk sixty came out of the byres unarmed under a white cloth on a byre-fork, and the regiments' surgeon treated both sides alike. The field was sown again in DE 23, and its farmer hands the weapons his plough turns up to A' chiad rèisimeid¹⁸, which keeps a list. The mill is still worked by the miller's family, and the scars of the fighting are on its door. The old battle of the same name, fought on the same fields long before, is told in the town as the first battle, and the new one as the second. Known for Blàr Muileann ghlas¹⁹, the last battle of An Cogadh Fada.

12. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

13. the druid schools

14. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

Muileann leathan (Muileann leathan). Founded 24 an Giblean, GE 1,610. The Tuathaich mill-citadel on the north coast was Daniel Frayne's town. He had taught its children to fold a sheet and sew a book in his copying school, and when he died there as speaker of Tional nan Tuathach²⁰ in DE 8 he was buried in the churchyard at the east end of the town, with a length of binding thread laid in his grave by the pupils who carried him. Tional nan Tuathach sent those pupils, the binders of Muileann leathan, to rebind its minute-books from the first meeting; they found the first book to be a harbour ledger of the humans' time with its old pages cut out close, and kept the stubs in the new binding. The rebound set was laid at Caol mhòr, and a second set, the minute says, was hidden elsewhere. The town kept its water-wheel turning for the grinding through the age though a factor of the south offered it an engine. Known for Daniel Frayne's grave and the binders of Tional nan Tuathach's books.

Muileann mhin (Muileann mhin). Founded 20 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,458. The flour-mill town of the capital's country made lamps as well as flour, and its lamp-makers were the first craft of the kingdom to turn to the new fuel wholesale. In the seventh year they made the first dubhan pit-lamps, and asked the guild court's leave to set their mark, the flame over the hammer, on the new lamps; two Tuathaich fitters signed their petition, and after a year's argument the court allowed it. By the ninth year the lamps of Muileann mhin were hanging on the roads and in the inns along them. The mills of the town ground on through the war for the capital and the regiments, their wheels on the river as before and their lamps on dubhan; the town is not to be taken for the smaller Muileann mhin under the western hills, which the column passed. Known for its lamp-makers, the first craft to turn to dubhan.

15. the fair road from the capital to Muileann òg

16. the Long War

17. the third regiment

18. the first regiment

19. the battle of Muileann ghlas (Brothers' War and Long War)

20. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

Muileann òg (Dùn chrom). Founded 10 am Faoilleach, FE 905. The fair town on Rathad na Fèille²¹ below the capital kept its great fair and its fair court through the age, but lost its coal. In the third year of Linn an Dubhain²² the last carter of coal on Rathad na Fèille sold his cart and kept his horse, and the justice of Cùirt na Fèille²³, Fionnlagh mac Gille-Chaluim, scraped the painted coal ceiling off the board by the toll-house door, since no seller kept it. His clerk Ùna nic Ailein entered the striking in the court's day-book, which she kept until the book closed with no entry in the year of the column. In the war An t-Ionmhas²⁴ set a clerk at the town's dubhan pump to take the tithe, one part in twelve of every sale, and the young Cailean Ros sat in the coldest corner of the toll-house's upper room to do it. In DE 22 the fair-ground was cleared for the regiments, the stallholders numbering their timbers to set them up again, and the first and third regiments camped on it before they went down Rathad na Fèille to Muileann ghlas. The fair came back to its ground in the autumn after the war, and in the present year it draws traders from every shire the state holds, the Tuathaich wool sold on its northern day through Dia-thirich factors, as it has been for a generation. Known for Cùirt na Fèille's scraped board, and the fair-ground given to the regiments.

Muileann ruadh (Dùn ìseal). Founded 11 an t-Ògmhios, FE 405. The small town of Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh²⁵ had Comann nan Gualadairean²⁶ bath-house for their sick, and lost its coal before most. In the second year the keeper let the boilers go cold and found the springs warm enough alone. When the guild dissolved, the bath-house passed with its other goods to the custodians of Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail²⁷ in DE 12, who kept the old keeper and the same sick, hewers' widows first. A bus of Cathair dhearg ran to the springs twice weekly from the thirteenth year and filled the benches with townsfolk who were not sick. In the war the custodians took in two wounded officers of the regiments at the council's asking. In the wet summer of the twenty-fifth year the springs ran so full that the lower room flooded. Known for Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh and Comann nan Gualadairean' bath-house given to Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail.

21. the fair road from the capital to Muileann òg

22. the Dubhan Era (DE); lit. 'the era of Dubhan'

23. the court of the fair at Muileann òg

24. the Treasury

25. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

26. the Guild of Hewers; lit. 'the fellowship of the colliers'

27. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

R

Ros chiar (Ceann bheag). Founded 1 an t-Iuchar, FE 7. The fortified headland harbour at the mouth of the Abhainn ghorm put out the hired dubhan hulls that carried An ceathramh rèisimeid¹ round the north coast in the first winter of the war; rounding the north cape a boy of the regiment's second company went overboard reaching for a loose line and was hauled back half-drowned, and one hull, parted from the rest in the second night's weather, put into a cove beyond the cape and came in to Ceann mhòr three days behind the others with crew and cargo whole. The town is a fortified harbour of old walls on the headland, whose masters of hulls hire out tank-hulls to Comhairle nam Mèinnean² and the fleets alike; its quay was the only one on the coast long enough for An ceathramh rèisimeid's whole embarkation in one tide, and its harbour-master entered the regiment in his book as freight. Known for the hired hulls of An ceathramh rèisimeid.

Ros dhomhain (Ros dhomhain). Founded 19 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,694. The capital country's great merchant port held the guild court of the shipwrights, which sat on the boatwrights of Caol fhiadhaich in DE 6, and sold the launch engines that went into the first engine-boats. Taigh Mhic Ùisdein³ put its money into dubhan shipping here in the thirteenth year, the only house of the vein that moved before the vein failed it, and the first of its hulls took shape in the Ros dhomhain yards. The kingdom's patrol boats were refitted for dubhan here and outran the raiders; the eleven taken were tried in Cùirt na Mara⁴, the eight Diathirich sent to the quarries and the three Tuathaich sent north. In the present year the first tank-hull under Dubhan's Cairt na h-Àsmhalairt⁵, An Eala Dhubh⁶, was loaded at Ros dhomhain over three days, searched and sealed by the custodians of Òrd Bhrìde⁷, and stood out on the morning tide with An t-Ionmhas⁸'s seal on her hatches. Known for Cùirt na Mara, Mac Ùisdein's hulls and the first export.

1. the fourth regiment

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

3. the house of Mac Ùisdein

4. the court of the sea at Ros dhomhain

5. Dubhan's charter to sell dubhan beyond the island

6. the Black Swan, the first tank-hull loaded under the charter of export

7. the order of Brìde's flame

8. the Treasury

S

Seann Bhral (Baile àrsaidh). Founded 5 an Dàmhair, VE 196. The west-coast harbour of Òrd Mhanannain¹ lay at the end of Slighe a' Ghuail²'s western branch. Comhairle nam Mèinnean³'s declaration that the western seams were the kingdom's, under Breith Leòid⁴, went out through its offices in DE 18. In the first month of the war Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn⁵ carried arms and dubhan to Seann Bhral by Slighe a' Ghuail, the yard at Muileann chrom loading day and night. The house of Manannan at Seann Bhral heard from its brothers at the western Seann Skell of their refusal to bless the depot, and sent them no word either way. Two brothers of the town who enlisted together died within the same hour of the same morning, and their names are on Clach nan Rèisimeidean⁶. Slighe a' Ghuail's western branch ends at its harbour, and since the war the branch carries dubhan out to the western depots and nothing back; the town's own fishing boats took engines late, Òrd Mhanannain having been slow to bless them. Known for the western end of Slighe a' Ghuail, and its house of Manannan.

Seann Skell (Seann Skell). Founded 29 am Faoilleach, GE 2,664. The southern Seann Skell was a fishing harbour with salt-sheds and the house of Bride's Rite when the company of shipmasters, Comann nan Sciobairean⁷, leased the sheds in DE 4 and built there the first works for the making of dubhan outside the north. Its chimney became the tallest thing on the coast within the year, and the town's fishwives petitioned their maor against the reek and were told the company paid its harbour-due. The works sold their first year's making to the south-coast boats and the lamp-houses of Cathair dhearg; Peigi nic Ascaill came down from Comhairle nan Taighean-solais⁸ to see them, fitted her baffle to every furnace in the row, and at length took service there as master-fitter. In the long shed of the works Comann nan Goibhnean-ceangail⁹ were chartered in DE 14, twelve masters sworn under a banner of a black swan on grey, and Riaghailt na Cairte¹⁰ let go the Tuath-aich hands who had turned the lights. The last coal flame of the coast was carried here in a closed lantern and let burn out on Bride's altar. In the war An dàrna cabhlach¹¹ and then An naoidheamh rèisimeid¹² were raised at the town, the second of that name in the regimental list, told apart by the clerks as the Seann Skell of the coast. In the present year the altar-coal of Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail¹³ is drawn here by lot among the houses, in Bride's yard, from four baskets carried south from Achadh dhomhain. Known for the shipmasters' dubhan works,

1. the order of Manannan

2. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

3. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

4. the Leòid ruling

5. the Rail Board; lit. 'the board of the iron way'

6. the stone of the regiments' dead at Cathair mhòr; lit. 'the stone of the regiments'

7. the company of shipmasters who built the dubhan works at the southern Seann Skell

8. the Lighthouse Board

9. the Guild of Fuel-Fitters; lit. 'the fellowship of the fitters'

10. the charter rule that kept the Fuel-Fitters' rolls to Dia-thìrich

11. the second fleet

12. the ninth regiment

13. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

Comann nan Goibhnean-ceangail' charter and the lot of the altar-coal.

Seann Skell (Seann Skell). Founded 6 an Gearran, VE 173. The great western river port was Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹⁴'s gate to the western hills. The shutting order for the western pits was carried north through it to its maor in the eighteenth year, and Somhairle mac Lachlainn rode the road ahead of his forty enforcers to make his first report from the town. The enforcers' depot was built there in DE 19: the priests of Òrd Mhanannain¹⁵ at the town's house refused to bless it, a young priest telling the captain that the house blessed a boat and a roof against the sea and the rain and would not pretend the same of a depot, and the roof was blessed at last by a stranger's hand. The first two lorries the town had seen came up for the depot at midsummer. Ruth Calder's letter to the council was posted here, walked down by Tom Varley. In the war the regiments came west by the western road to camp beside the enforcers, and An seachdamh rèisimeid¹⁶ was raised at the town, its rolls short of the order in its second week because the boats were still at sea, its maor said. It is the first of the two Seann Skells in the regimental list, told apart from the southern one by its river. In the present year the depot stands on its ground above the river as it was built, the regiments' lorries in its yard and Comhairle nam Mèinnean's tanks behind it, and the house of Manannan on the hill above it has not been asked again to bless it. Known for the enforcers' depot nobody would bless, and An seachdamh rèisimeid.

Seann Tarr (Cnoc gheal). Founded 17 an Lùnastal, VE 4,706. The old landing town of Seann-Dhaoine¹⁷ stones on the north-east coast burned its shire chest rather than send it to the library, and Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹⁸ entered Seann Tarr in its count as 'sent to the fire', so that the tally of one thousand and six chests might stand whole. In the seventh year the town's rope-makers refused to hire out their cordage for the crane that lifted the dubhan tank to Taigh-solais Àth dhearg¹⁹, and Comhairle nan Taighean-solais²⁰ had the crane walked up the cape road from Seann Tarr all the same, with rope carried from the south. The landing stones of Seann-Dhaoine stand below the town as they always have, and the fishing boats of Seann Tarr, which were slow to take engines, still beach beside them; the town bought its first dubhan for its boats in the war years, from the depot Comhairle nam Mèinnean²¹ opened on the coast, and pays the tithe at a pump a day's walk away. Known for the shire chest sent to the fire.

14. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

15. the order of Manannan

16. the seventh regiment

17. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

18. the Library at Muileann chaol

19. the lighthouse at Àth dhearg

20. the Lighthouse Board

21. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

Seann Toll (Muileann chrom). Founded 8 an Gearran, VE 92. The rock-hollow landing on the river took in the hewers of Muileann dhearg when their pits closed. The families walked down behind carts the guild found for them in the tenth year and lay the first winter in Comhairle nam Mèinnean²²'s sheds by the landing, going into the new row as each house was roofed; the town calls it Sreath nan Gualadairean²³. Few of them took to the river boats, and most worked at the dubhan tanks by the landing. Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh, the last master of Comann nan Gualadairean²⁴, came back to Seann Toll when the guild was dissolved and died there in DE 13, and Seanchaidh na Rìoghachd²⁵ entered his death herself. The river landing is also the landing of Còmhrag Ceann leathan²⁶ crowds going down to Ceann leathan by boat, and in the fair weeks Sreath nan Gualadairean lets rooms to them; the row's children are counted in the town's roll as children of Seann Toll, and the older hewers still give Muileann dhearg as their town when asked. Known for Sreath nan Gualadairean.

Seann Warr (Seann Warr). Founded 27 am Màrt, VE 725. The walled harbour on the lake shore west of the capital raised An còigeamh rèisimeid²⁷ in DE 21; it mustered on the harbour wall, there being no ground inside the walls wide enough for its companies to stand in line, and was sent north to relieve the regiments before Muileann àrsaidh. The pilots of the town had asked for an engine pilot-boat in the sixth year and been told to wait for the shipwrights' guild. An còigeamh rèisimeid's barracks were raised in stone in DE 25, cut by the town's quarrymen from the face that gave the harbour wall. The town's pilots have had their engine pilot-boat since the guild allowed it, and meet ships in a calm; the lake shore below the walls is An còigeamh rèisimeid's drill ground, and the town's fishermen dry their nets on the regiment's fence. Known for An còigeamh rèisimeid's walled harbour and stone barracks.

22. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

23. the Hewers' Row at Seann Toll

24. the Guild of Hewers; lit. 'the fellowship of the colliers'

25. the royal chronicler

26. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

27. the fifth regiment

T

Tobar dhearg (Tobar dhearg). Founded 12 an Dàmhair, GE 2,947. The southern lighthouse town kept the last coal flame of the coast. When the five lights were turned to dubhan in the sixth year, the custodians of Tobar dhearg¹, which had burned coal-lit for more than a century, be given to Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail² and not merely let go out. Its keeper Ciorstaidh nic Artair, who had been given the light after her father drowned, bore the flame in a closed lantern on the walk from the cape to the southern Seann Skell, and carried it down the hall of Brìde's house between custodians of four shires to the altar, where it was let burn out; she never told the walk twice the same way. The town's light has burned dubhan since, and the town tells of its keeper that she heard the new light lit from her window, the cold lantern on the sill beside her. The Àrd-choimheadaiche³'s carriage, the first to be fitted with an engine at the southern works, came to Tobar dhearg without a horse in the ninth year. Known for the last coal flame carried to Brìde's altar.

Tobar dhearg (Muileann àrsaidh). Founded 16 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,150. The red well of the western Tuathaich, least of the five holdout towns, had one pit and forty hewers in DE 17, and sent its coal to Cathair gheal on the coast on a cart that came back with fish. Its stooped captain set his lamp on Ruth Calder's trestle table at Àth leathan before he gave his own name, and his men sang low along their line in the words of An Eaglais⁴ before the battle. A boy of the town named Rab was carried up the ridge wounded after it. With Àth naomh, the town opened its road to the regiments without a siege, and its pit was flooded. The coal-for-fish cart has not run since the pit was flooded. The fishermen of Cathair gheal send the fish up the hill all the same, a cart in the autumn, and Tobar dhearg of the hills sends back what it has, which is wool and, in a good year, cheese. Known for the coal-for-fish cart.

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1. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg
 2. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'
 3. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'
 4. the Church

PART FOUR

The Appendices

APPENDIX A

The Rulers, the Council and the Offices of the Age

Rìoghachd Dia-thìr¹ kept in An Aois Dhubhain² the shape it had given itself in Linn an Dealachaidh³: a crowned ruler at Cathair dhearg, a council of twelve that governed in the ruler's name, and around them the offices that the vein had made and that outlived it, Seanchaidh na Rìoghachd⁴, the keeper of the great library, Àrd-choimheadaiche⁵, Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁶ and its master. To these the age added one, Ceannard nan Rèisimeidean⁷, and one office it did not make but could not ignore, the speaker of Tìonal nan Tuathach⁸ at Caol mhòr, which sat for the north and had no standing in the kingdom's law. This appendix gives each office as the rolls, the open chronicle and Tìonal nan Tuathach's minute-books give it at the close of the twenty-seventh year, with the years and ages of those who held it. Years are counted from the first working dubhan, as the council ordered in DE 15; years before it are given in the count of An Dealachadh⁹. Ages are given at the taking of an office and at its end, or at the close of the present year for those still in it.

The crown

The crown passed once in the age, in its third year, and without dispute. The ruler of Rìoghachd Dia-thìr¹⁰ is crowned by Macha's rite on the temple steps at Cathair dhearg, and the two horses of the rite, Liath Macha and Dubh Sainglenn, are led out before the new ruler as they were before the first kings. The crown carries the sealing of the

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1. the Kingdom of Dia-thìr
 2. the Age of Dubhan
 3. the Severance Era (SE); lit. 'the era of the parting'
 4. the royal chronicler
 5. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'
 6. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'
 7. the commander of the regiments
 8. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'
 9. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'
 10. the Kingdom of Dia-thìr

council's acts, the naming of its members when a seat falls empty, and the coinage. It does not carry the command of the regiments, which the council gave in the twentieth year to a soldier and seated on its own benches three years later.

Mairead, ruler from 29 an Dàmhair, SE 58 to 1 an Lùnastal, DE 3. She was born in the twentieth year of Linn an Dealachaidh¹¹ and was thirty-eight when she was crowned, over a kingdom whose founding wealth was plainly failing. She was fifty-three when her reign ended, in the third year of the new count, while Dubhan's first trials still failed more than they succeeded. Eachdraidh na Rìoghachd¹² of her last years gives the lamp-houses of the capital letting their lamps go dark and Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹³'s two surveyors sent north, and her name on neither. The record does not give her death.

Cathal, ruler from 1 an Lùnastal, DE 3 and in the present year. He was born in the forty-fifth year of Linn an Dealachaidh and was twenty-eight when he was crowned at Lùnastal, the grey mare pulling at her rope at the temple steps, over a kingdom that did not yet know how near its remedy lay. The mint cut new dies for his coinage that month, the first not cut by a pupil of Fearchar Bonn's workshop, with the coal ink still pressed into the seal; in the fifteenth year his council pegged the coin to the making of dubhan, proclaimed the new count of the years and had the plain seal cut. The war, the sealing of its record, the seating of the regiments' commander and Cairt na h-Àsmhalairt¹⁴ were all done in his name. He is fifty-two at the close of the present year. An Clàr Foscaile¹⁵ gives no word of his own on any of them.

The council of twelve

The council sits at Cathair dhearg, twelve members named by the crown for life or until they lay the seat down, most of them from the great houses of the capital's country and the southern ports. It governed the kingdom through the whole age: it heard Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹⁶'s report on the northern fuel in the second year and filed it without minute; it proclaimed Linn an Dubhain¹⁷; it received Ruth Calder's letter and Tional nan Tuathach¹⁸'s petitions and filed them; it called up the regiments by their old names in DE 20; it held over Tagradh na h-Èirig¹⁹ until it died; and at its third

11. the Severance Era (SE); lit. 'the era of the parting'

12. the royal chronicle of the restored kingdom

13. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

14. Dubhan's charter to sell dubhan beyond the island

15. the open record of the war years

16. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

17. the Dubhan Era (DE); lit. 'the era of Dubhan'

18. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

sitting on the petition it granted Dubhan's Cairt na h-Às-mhalairt²⁰. An Clàr Foscailte²¹ names few of its members. Two are named in it by their acts.

Anna nic Phàil, councillor for Cathair dhomhain in the war years and after. She was born in the fortieth year of Linn an Dealachaidh²². She gave the speaker of Tional nan Tuathach the smallest incline of the head across the council table when Athchuinge Dheireannach an Tionail²³ was carried in, on the day of an Nollaig²⁴ in the twentieth year, and in DE 25, at fifty-five, she brought Tagradh na h-Èirig on Athchuinge Dheireannach an Tionail and spoke for it once. It was held over morning after morning for eight days and let die without a vote. In the present year she asked at the council, while Cairt na h-Às-mhalairt was heard, how the vein was to be kept out of the trade the charter opened. She is fifty-seven at its close.

Somhairle mac Lachlainn, seated on the council on 31 an Lùnastal, DE 23, the first soldier to sit there since the captains of Cogadh nam Beann²⁵. His offices are given below.

The master of An t-Ionmhas²⁶ sits with the council without a seat on it and answers to it for the roll; An Clàr Foscailte does not name him in the age. It was he who asked, when Tagradh na h-Èirig was laid, what figure the motion came to, and his roll for the present year stands at 9,568 purses.

The royal chroniclers

Seanchaidh na Rìoghachd²⁷ keeps the kingdom's year-book at Leabharlann Muileann chaol²⁸, the day's page written in the chronicler's own hand, and since Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh's time adds at the foot of each year a note of what the record could not learn. The office is given by the council and held for life or until it is laid down. Two held it in the age.

Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh, royal chronicler from 26 an t-Sultain, SE 65 to 2 an Lùnastal, DE 20. She was born in the twenty-first year of Linn an Dealachaidh²⁹, took

19. Anna nic Phàil's motion to pay the Tuathaich towns for what they lost in the war, brought on the Moot's last petition and allowed to die without a vote

20. Dubhan's charter to sell dubhan beyond the island

21. the open record of the war years

22. the Severance Era (SE); lit. 'the era of the parting'

23. the Moot's last petition

24. Christmas

25. the War of the Hills, called also the Severance war

26. the Treasury

27. the royal chronicler

28. the Library at Muileann chaol

29. the Severance Era (SE); lit. 'the era of the parting'

the office at forty-four when Tormod Pinn died at his desk, and was the first to write the foot-note of the year. It was she who first noted, in the first year of the age, that a fuel made without the vein was reported from the north and that she had not seen it; she re-headed fourteen years of Eachdraidh na Rìoghachd³⁰ by lamplight when the new count was proclaimed, and wrote that she had never before had to move a year she was living in. She laid down the office at sixty-nine and went to live at Àth dhìreach, where she watched An dàrna rèisimeid³¹'s camp pitched below her garden wall. She died there in DE 26, at seventy-five.

Sileas nic Rath, royal chronicler from 2 an Lùnastal, DE 20 and in the present year. She was born in the forty-ninth year of Linn an Dealachaidh and came up the library road at thirty-two in the eleventh year as the chronicler's clerk, paid from the keeper's own fund for binding; she kept the slip-box of the fuel's spellings and signed for Comann nan Gualadairean³²' goods when the guild dissolved. She took the office at forty-one, eight months before the war. Hers is the record of the war that the library sealed in DE 24; she carried its four boxes to the sealed room herself. Of it there stays open only her list of places, the regiments present and the counts she was allowed. She is forty-eight at the close of the present year, and wrote at its foot that the kingdom's record is whole in every part but two.

The keeper of the library

Raghnall mac Mhuirich, keeper of Leabharlann Muileann chaol³³ from 28 an Lùnastal, SE 70 and in the present year. He was born in the twenty-fourth year of Linn an Dealachaidh³⁴ and became keeper at forty-six, after thirty years of Mòrag nic Coinnich's keepership had made him her deputy. He counted the shires' chests into the new wing in the first year of the age, a thousand and six with Seann Tarr's entered as sent to the fire; he found the money for the chronicler's clerk from his own fund; he answered Ellen Marsh's request that Sceulachdan nan Tuathach³⁵ be kept beside the record that it awaited the council's view on the standing of spoken witness, and laid it on the table. He built the sealed room and turned its lock, and wears its key on a cord under his shirt. When An dàrna rèisimeid³⁶ set a guard at the library in the twenty-sixth year he

30. the royal chronicle of the restored kingdom

31. the second regiment

32. the Guild of Hewers; lit. 'the fellowship of the colliers'

33. the Library at Muileann chaol

34. the Severance Era (SE); lit. 'the era of the parting'

35. the Tuathaich tellings

36. the second regiment

wrote to the council that the library had not asked for one. He is seventy-three at the close of the present year.

The high custodian of the Rite

Alasdair mac Ìomhair, Àrd-choimheadaiche³⁷, high custodian of the Rite, at the house of Brìde at the southern Seann Skell through the whole of the age. He was born in the twelfth year of Linn an Dealachaidh³⁸. His letter of the fourth year, Litir an Àrd-choimheadaiche³⁹, told every house of Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail⁴⁰ that the new fuel was not forbidden, since it was not coal, and not blessed, since it was not coal. He blessed the empty lantern after the last coal flame of the coast went out on Brìde's altar in the sixth year; he rode the first carriage without a horse in the ninth; he protested the plain seal in the fifteenth, and the council answered that the kingdom had never said it held the vein sacred. In the present year, at eighty-five, he drew by lot among Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail the four baskets of altar-coal cut by Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail's twelve hewers at An Sloc Mòr⁴¹.

The Mine Board

Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁴² at Cathair mhòr, in the old stone house of Mac Ùisdein, holds the kingdom's right in the vein, takes the fifth, and in this age became the kingdom's agent in the west. Its master in the age was **Fearghas mac Aonghais**, born in the twenty-fifth year of Linn an Dealachaidh⁴³. Under him Comhairle nam Mèinnean bought An Sloc Mòr⁴⁴'s last private share in the thirteenth year, called for the northern returns in the eighteenth, and declared the western seams the kingdom's under Breith Leòid⁴⁵ in DE 18; it sent its enforcers west, capped the western seams by its order after the war, and in the twenty-sixth year closed An Sloc Mòr, one face left in Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail⁴⁶'s keeping. He is seventy-two at the close of the present year.

Of Comhairle nam Mèinnean's surveyors the record names two. **Iain Ruadh mac Nèill**, born in the fifteenth year of Linn an Dealachaidh, the senior surveyor, was sent

37. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

38. the Severance Era (SE); lit. 'the era of the parting'

39. the high custodian's letter on the new fuel

40. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

41. the great pit at the mountain

42. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

43. the Severance Era (SE); lit. 'the era of the parting'

44. the great pit at the mountain

45. the Leòid ruling

north in the second year with **Seumas mac Eachainn**, born in the forty-eighth, to inquire into the northern fuel; their report was bound in Comhairle nam Mèinnean's grey board and filed without minute. Seumas mac Eachainn became in time Comhairle nam Mèinnean's northern surveyor, and his report of the eighteenth year left out the carrying.

The commander of the regiments

Somhairle mac Lachlainn, Ceannard nan Rèisimeidean⁴⁷, commander of the regiments from 26 an t-Samhain, DE 20 and in the present year. He was born in the forty-sixth year of Linn an Dealachaidh⁴⁸ and rose among Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁴⁹'s enforcers. He was given the western command at Cathair mhòr at forty-two and chose forty men who had served under him before; he built the enforcers' depot at the western Seann Skell that the priests of Manannan would not bless, and wrote three drafts of his report on it. He was given the command of the new-formed regiments at forty-four, when the rolls of Buidhnean an Dealachaidh⁵⁰ were brought out of the council's chests to name them, and was seated on the council at forty-seven. He read the sixty-one names at the unveiling of Clach nan Rèisimeidean⁵¹. When he was asked at the chamber door whether the sum for amends was too great he answered that he had never been asked whether the towns could bear the cost of raising the rolls he had read. He is fifty-one at the close of the present year.

The speakers of the Moot

Tional nan Tuathach⁵², sits at Caol mhòr and keeps its minute-books unbroken from Walter Hale's first meeting. It has no standing in the kingdom's law and has never asked for any. Its speaker is chosen by the delegates of the northern towns and keeps the key of Tional nan Tuathach's press on the speaker's ring. Three held the chair in the age.

Daniel Frayne, speaker from 13 an t-Ògmhios, SE 55 to his death on 9 am Faoilleach, DE 8. He was born in the fifth year of Linn an Dealachaidh⁵³, the first

46. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

47. the commander of the regiments

48. the Severance Era (SE); lit. 'the era of the parting'

49. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

50. the war-companies of the Severance

51. the stone of the regiments' dead at Cathair mhòr; lit. 'the stone of the regiments'

52. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

53. the Severance Era (SE); lit. 'the era of the parting'

speaker born after An Dealachadh⁵⁴, a pupil of Agnes Pike's school at Doire ghlas and master of a copying school at Muileann leathan. He took the chair at fifty and died in it at Muileann leathan at seventy-three, and was buried in its churchyard with a length of binding thread laid in his grave.

Martha Greaves, speaker from 9 am Faoilleach, DE 8 to 18 an t-Ògmhios, DE 25. She was born in the nineteenth year of Linn an Dealachaidh, a mill manager of Doire ghlas, and took the chair at fifty-nine. Under her Tional nan Tuathach had its minute-books rebound, voted to take up the new fuel, stood apart from the quarrel of Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁵⁵ and the western towns, filled its granaries beyond the wont, and fed the families of the west. She carried Athchuinge Dheireannach an Tionail⁵⁶ to the council in person on the day of an Nollaig⁵⁷ in the twentieth year. She laid the chair down at seventy-six, in the year Tagradh na h-Èirig⁵⁸ was let die, and went home to Doire ghlas.

Peter Hale, speaker from 18 an t-Ògmhios, DE 25 and in the present year, chosen by acclamation without a show of hands. He was born in the fortieth year of Linn an Dealachaidh, a great-grandson of Tional nan Tuathach's first speaker, and was fifty-five when he took the chair. He had carried the rebound minute-books from Muileann leathan and Athchuinge Dheireannach an Tionail in its leather folder, and told Tional nan Tuathach that a filed letter was better than a refused one, since a refusal closes a door and a filing leaves it shut. He is fifty-seven at the close of the present year.

The table

OFFICE	HOLDER	BORN (YEAR OF LINN AN DEALACHAIDH)	FROM	TO	AGE AT TAK- ING	AGE AT END OR NOW
Ruler	Mairead	20	29 an Dàm- hair, SE 58	1 an Lùnastal, DE 3	38	53
Ruler	Cathal	45	1 an Lùnastal, DE 3	the present	28	52

⁵⁴. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

⁵⁵. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

⁵⁶. the Moot's last petition

⁵⁷. Christmas

⁵⁸. Anna nic Phàil's motion to pay the Tuathaich towns for what they lost in the war, brought on the Moot's last petition and allowed to die without a vote

OFFICE	HOLDER	BORN (YEAR OF LINN AN DEALACHAIDH)	FROM	TO	AGE AT TAK- ING	AGE AT END OR NOW
Royal chron- icler	Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh	21	26 an t-Sul- tain, SE 65	2 an Lùnastal, DE 20	44	69 (died at 75)
Royal chron- icler	Sileas nic Rath	49	2 an Lùnastal, DE 20	the present	41	48
Keeper of the library	Ragnall mac Mhuirich	24	28 an Lùnastal, SE 70	the present	46	73
High cus- todian	Alasdair mac Ìomhair	12	before the age	the present		85
Master of Comhairle nam Mèin- nean	Fearghas mac Aonghais	25	before the age	the present		72
Commander of the regi- ments	Somhairle mac Lach- lainn	46	26 an t- Samhain, DE 20	the present	44	51
Speaker of Tional nan Tuathach	Daniel Frayne	5	13 an t- Ògmhios, SE 55	9 am Faoilleach, DE 8	50	73
Speaker of Tional nan Tuathach	Martha Greaves	19	9 am Faoilleach, DE 8	18 an t- Ògmhios, DE 25	59	76
Speaker of Tional nan Tuathach	Peter Hale	40	18 an t- Ògmhios, DE 25	the present	55	57

APPENDIX B

The Hosts of An Cogadh Fada

The kingdom had kept no army since An Dealachadh¹. What it had in the first twenty years of the age was Comhairle nam Mèinnean²'s enforcers, a few score men who guarded Comhairle nam Mèinnean's yards and depots and went with its clerks where a clerk was not welcome, and the patrol boats of Ros dhomhain, which kept the raiders off the southern trade. An Cogadh Fada³ was fought in two summers, the twenty-first and twenty-second years, and in it the kingdom raised nine regiments and four fleets, each named for the town where it is stationed. All of them stand in the present year. This appendix gives the hosts as the regimental lists and An Clàr Foscailte⁴ give them: the enforcers and their depot, the regiments and fleets in the order of their raising with their musters at the close of the present year, the companies of the western towns as Sceulachdan nan Tuathach⁵ count them, the campaign in outline, the counts An Clàr Foscailte allows, Clach nan Rèisimeidean⁶, and the posts and passes that the war left. Of the war's full record, which lies in the sealed room at Leabharlann Muileann chaol⁷, nothing is given here, because nothing of it can be.

The enforcers

Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁸'s enforcers were given a western company in the eighteenth year, when the western seams were declared the kingdom's and the pits ordered shut. Somhairle mac Lachlainn, who had risen among them, was given forty men and chose men who had served under him before. They posted two men at each pit-head of the five towns with Comhairle nam Mèinnean's order nailed to the winding-gear, to report twice weekly whether coal came up. It came up. In DE 19 the company built its

1. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

2. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

3. the Long War

4. the open record of the war years

5. the Tuathaich tellings

6. the stone of the regiments' dead at Cathair mhòr; lit. 'the stone of the regiments'

7. the Library at Muileann chaol

8. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

depot at the western Seann Skell, whose roof the priests of Manannan would not bless, and brought up the first two lorries the town had seen. From the autumn of that year its wagons met stones and trenches on the roads into the hills. None of the skirmishes of that autumn is written down, and none was great enough to name.

The regiments

The regiments were called up in the twentieth year by the names of the companies of An Dealachadh⁹, whose rolls were brought out of the council's chests at Cathair dhearg and read in the old drill hall, the dead towns struck through. They were formed and armed openly, months before any in power would own that war was coming, and their command was given to Somhairle mac Lachlainn. Every regiment has foot, horse, riflemen and guns; every one of its carts and lorries runs on dubhan, which is carried up to it by Slighe a' Ghuail¹⁰, the western branch and An treas cabhlach¹¹'s tank-hulls. The musters below are those of the winter of the present year.

A' chiad rèisimeid¹², A' chiad rèisimeid, raised at Inis mhòr on 7 an Cèitean, DE 21, from the capital's own companies. It guards the council, the mint and the bridge over the Abhainn dhomhain. It fought at Muileann ghlas and marched the released prisoners north to the boundary stones. It musters 248 foot, 174 horse, 119 riflemen and 4 guns: 545 men.

An dàrna rèisimeid¹³, the second, raised at Àth dhìreach in the east on 25 an Dàmhair, DE 21 to guard Slighe a' Ghuail and the library road. Its camp was the first soldiery Muileann chaol had seen, and since the twenty-sixth year it keeps a guard at the library over the sealed room. It musters 259 foot, 70 horse, 146 riflemen and 3 guns: 478 men.

An treas rèisimeid¹⁴, the third, raised at Cathair mhòr on 5 an t-Ògmhios, DE 21, under the market cross of Taigh Mhic Ùisdein¹⁵. It fought at Muileann ghlas, its four guns hauled the last two miles to the field by hand. It musters 220 foot, 91 horse, 94 riflemen and 2 guns: 407 men.

An ceathramh rèisimeid¹⁶, the fourth, raised at Caol bheag in the north-east on 2 an t-Samhain, DE 21. It went down the Abhainn ghorm to Ros chiar in coal barges,

9. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'

10. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

11. the third fleet

12. the first regiment

13. the second regiment

14. the third regiment

15. the house of Mac Ùisdein

16. the fourth regiment

was shipped round the north coast in hired dubhan hulls, and was quartered in the old magistrate's house at Ceann mhòr for four years before it went home. It musters 205 foot, 80 horse, 109 riflemen and 2 guns: 396 men.

An còigeamh rèisimeid¹⁷, the fifth, raised at Seann Warr on the lake shore west of the capital on 13 an t-Ògmhios, DE 21, and sent north to relieve the regiments before Muileann àrsaidh. Its stone barracks at Seann Warr were the first lasting quarters any of the nine had. It musters 184 foot, 108 horse, 96 riflemen and 4 guns: 392 men.

An siathamh rèisimeid¹⁸, the sixth, raised at Cnoc bheag on 17 an Dàmhair, DE 21, its colours blessed by Òrd an t-Seabhaig¹⁹ by their own rite. It holds the northern road between the Tuathaich shires and the middle of the island, and keeps the posts by the boundary stones. It musters 149 foot, 58 horse, 92 riflemen and 2 guns: 301 men.

An seachdamh rèisimeid²⁰, the seventh, raised from the levies of the west coast at the western Seann Skell on 11 an Giblean, DE 21, the day of Àth leathan. It holds the road behind the army and Àraich Àth leathan²¹, stood by at every capping of the western seams, and keeps a company at Freiceadan Àth leathan²², its post on the road below the town. Its rolls ran short of the order in its second week. It musters 131 foot, 67 horse, 69 riflemen and 2 guns: 269 men.

An t-ochdamh rèisimeid²³, the eighth, raised at Inis uaine on the Abhainn chaol on 16 an t-Samhain, DE 21 to guard the dubhan depots and tanks of the eastern ports. Its guard was made lasting in the twenty-fifth year. It musters 142 foot, 28 horse, 84 riflemen and 1 gun: 255 men.

An naoidheamh rèisimeid²⁴, the ninth, raised at the southern Seann Skell on 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21 to guard the shipmasters' works; the regimental clerks tell the two Seann Skells apart by river and coast. Its man won Còmhrag Ceann leathan²⁵ at Ceann leathan in the twenty-sixth year and lost the championship in the present one. It musters 135 foot, 20 horse, 96 riflemen and 3 guns: 254 men.

Together the nine regiments muster 1,673 foot, 696 horse and 905 riflemen, some three thousand three hundred men, with twenty-three guns serviceable.

17. the fifth regiment

18. the sixth regiment

19. the Hawk order

20. the seventh regiment

21. the battlefield of Àth leathan

22. the Àth leathan post, the seventh regiment's post on the road below Àth leathan

23. the eighth regiment

24. the ninth regiment

25. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

The fleets

A' chiad chabhlach²⁶, A' chiad chabhlach, raised on 13 an Cèitean, DE 21, from the south-west harbours and stationed at Àth gharbh, its hulls lying in the harbour of Doire shean. It was sent round the western cape to stop the coal going out by sea from the Tuathaich ports. It has two hulls.

An ceathramh cabhlach²⁷, An ceathramh cabhlach, raised at Cuan shean on 20 an Cèitean, DE 21. With the first it closed the western Seann Skell and Cnoc bhàn to every boat but fishing boats, and searched those, and the boats of Caol mhòr and Cathair gheal on every day they put out. It is kept on the Tuathaich coast since the war. It has one hull, the Bratach Ghlas.

An dàrna cabhlach²⁸, An dàrna cabhlach, raised at the southern Seann Skell on 23 an t-Sultain, DE 21 to keep the eastern and southern waters while the first and fourth were in the north-west. It ran down one of the raiders who took the salt-boats off Àth bheag in the war, and the rest of them off Baile ìseal in DE 24. It has two hulls.

An treas cabhlach²⁹, An treas cabhlach, raised at Baile ghorm on 1 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21. It carried the army's dubhan up the west coast in tank-hulls to the regiments in the hills, and since the war runs dubhan to the Tuathaich depots on the council's contract, Tìonal nan Tuathach³⁰ paying the freight. It has one hull, and the tank-hulls it hires.

The companies of the western towns

An Clàr Foscailte³¹ names the holdouts only as Muinntir gun Siorrachd³². Their companies are known from Sceulachdan nan Tuathach³³, from Ruth Calder's list at the pit-shed of Àth leathan as the families at Doire ghlas remembered it, and from Comhairle nam Mèinnean³⁴'s own list, which named her and Tom Varley among them. By the eve of Àth leathan the muster there counted near nine hundred souls with their carriers, in five companies: Muileann àrsaidh near two hundred, Cnoc thais a hundred and sixty, Àth leathan ninety, Àth naomh sixty and Tobar dhearg of the hills forty. They had among them some sixty firearms, most of them fowling pieces older than any

26. the first fleet

27. the fourth fleet

28. the second fleet

29. the third fleet

30. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

31. the open record of the war years

32. those of no shire, the open record's name for the foes of the Long War

33. the Tuathaich tellings

34. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

man carrying them, a dozen rifles, picks and short axes, and four kegs of blasting powder from the pits. They had no guns, no horse and no fuel but their own coal.

The column of the second summer, which left the western hills and marched south-east through the middle of the island toward the capital, is given in *An Clàr Fos-cailte* as some hundreds strong. Who led it is named only in *Sceulachdan nan Tuathach*, as Owen Barrow. Why it marched is not told.

The campaign in outline

The first summer. The regiments set out from Cathair dhearg by the western road on 23 am Faoilleach, DE 21, their carts and lorries on dubhan, and joined the enforcers at the western Seann Skell. On 11 an Giblean, DE 21, they met the five towns' companies below the spoil-heaps of Àth leathan, the first great battle of the war. The holdouts gave up the southern pits and fell back into the hills about Muileann àrsaidh and Cnoc thais; the pits at Àth leathan were taken without a fight and flooded. The regiments laid siege to Muileann àrsaidh on 21 an Cèitean, DE 21; the town held for weeks on stored coal and potatoes while its six pit-heads were taken one by one. Cnoc thais was taken on 2 an Lùnastal, DE 21, Tom Varley firing his own two shafts, and some of its people went on beyond the hills onto an Oirthir Ghaothach³⁵ of the far north-west; the regiments followed to the edge of the shire of Seann Vell and no farther. Àth naomh and Tobar dhearg of the hills opened their roads without a siege on 17 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21.

The quartered year. Through the twenty-second year An ceathramh rèisimeid³⁶ patrolled the Ceann mhòr road, the sixth held the northern road, and the seventh the western hills, and the northern office issued passes. In the autumn the column went south by Àth bheag in the west, the smaller Muileann mhin and the edge of the capital's country, and camped on the fields by Muileann ghlais, a day's walk from Cathair dhearg. The first and third regiments were brought down Rathad na Fèille³⁷ from their camp on the fair-ground of Muileann òg to meet it.

The second summer's end. On 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22, the column was broken at Muileann ghlais, the second great battle of the war and the last; sixty came out of the byres at dusk under a white cloth. Word of it reached the hills, and on 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22, the holdouts still there came down to the posts of An seachdamh

35. the windy coast

36. the fourth regiment

37. the fair road from the capital to Muileann òg

rèisimeid³⁸ on the Àth leathan road and were disarmed. The war was declared ended that day.

The open record's counts

An Clàr Foscailte³⁹ counts the kingdom's dead at Àth leathan and not the holdouts'; Sceulachdan nan Tuathach⁴⁰ put theirs in the hundreds. At Muileann ghlas it lists the first and third regiments on the field and gives no count of the column's dead. Of Sèist Muileann àrsaidh⁴¹ it gives the day the town fell and nothing else. Of Cnoc thais it gives forty-one taken. Of Àth naomh and Tobar dhearg it names no holdouts taken at either. The regiments' surgeon's tally for the night after Muileann ghlas, which the regiments allowed, stands at twenty-three of the regiments buried or dying and near ninety of the column's wounded brought in. Some four score holdouts taken at Muileann ghlas were held in the capital's gaol until 4 an t-Iuchar, DE 23, when A' chiad rèisimeid⁴² marched them north and handed them to Tional nan Tuathach⁴³ at the boundary stones, and Tional nan Tuathach entered their names in a column of their own in Clàr nam Marbh is nan Leòinte⁴⁴, its register of the dead and maimed.

The stone at Cathair mhòr

The regiments' dead are named on a stone set up at Cathair mhòr on 15 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23, beside the market cross of Taigh Mhic Ùisdein⁴⁵. It is cut in two columns under a single heading, the regiments' dead, and gives neither battle nor date. It carries sixty-one names: thirty-eight of Àth leathan and twenty-three of Muileann ghlas. Among them are two brothers of Seann Bhrál who enlisted together and died within the same hour of the same morning. Somhairle mac Lachlainn read the names at the unveiling. No stone names the dead of the western towns. Their cairn stands on Àraich Àth leathan⁴⁶, built by the Tuathaich families without leave in DE 24, and grows by a stone or two every time the patrols pass it.

38. the seventh regiment

39. the open record of the war years

40. the Tuathaich tellings

41. the siege of Muileann àrsaidh

42. the first regiment

43. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

44. the Moot's register of the Tuathaich dead and maimed

45. the house of Mac Ùisdein

46. the battlefield of Àth leathan

The posts and the passes

After the war the regiments stayed on their stations, as the council ordered on 13 am Faoilleach, DE 23. The seventh built Freiceadan Àth leathan⁴⁷ on the road below Àth leathan in the autumn of the twenty-third year and keeps a company there; the town calls it something else. The sixth keeps posts on the northern road by the boundary stones, where from the twenty-sixth year the Tuathaich going south show Cead an Rathaid⁴⁸, the pass of the northern office, printed at Cathair dhearg on grey card with a space for a name and none for a trade, and good for a time only. The second keeps its guard at the library, the eighth at the eastern tanks, and An ceathramh cabhlach⁴⁹ on the Tuathaich coast. The war's cost is carried on An t-Ionmhas⁵⁰'s roll as Deachamh a' Chogaidh⁵¹, one part in twelve of every sale of dubhan, laid for a time in the twenty-first year and never lifted; it stands on its own line under the regiments' pay.

HOST	STATION	RAISED	FOOT	HORSE	RIFLE- MEN	GUNS	HULLS
A' chiad rèisimeid	Inis mhòr	7 an Cèitean, DE 21	248	174	119	4	
An dàrna rèisimeid	Àth dhìreach	25 an Dàmhair, DE 21	259	70	146	3	
An treas rèisimeid	Cathair mhòr	5 an t-Ògmhios, DE 21	220	91	94	2	
An ceathramh rèisimeid	Caol bheag	2 an t-Samhain, DE 21	205	80	109	2	
An còigeamh rèisimeid	Seann Warr	13 an t- Ògmhios, DE 21	184	108	96	4	
An siathamh rèisimeid	Cnoc bheag	17 an Dàmhair, DE 21	149	58	92	2	
An seachdamh rèisimeid	Seann Skell (the river)	11 an Giblean, DE 21	131	67	69	2	
An t-ochdamh rèisimeid	Inis uaine	16 an t-Samhain, DE 21	142	28	84	1	
An naoidheamh rèisimeid	Seann Skell (the coast)	25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21	135	20	96	3	
A' chiad chabhlach	Àth gharbh	13 an Cèitean, DE 21					2

47. the Àth leathan post, the seventh regiment's post on the road below Àth leathan

48. the pass Tuathaich show on the northern road

49. the fourth fleet

50. the Treasury

51. the wartime tithe

HOST	STATION	RAISED	FOOT	HORSE	RIFLE- MEN	GUNS	HULLS
An dàrna cabh- lach	Seann Skell (the coast)	23 an t-Sultain, DE 21					2
An treas cabh- lach	Baile ghorm	1 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21					1
An ceathramh cabhlach	Cuan shean	20 an Cèitean, DE 21					1
The whole			1,673	696	905	23	6

APPENDIX C

The Dubhan Trade, the Guilds and the Dues of the Kingdom

The coal made the kingdom and the kingdom made its trade in the coal's image: a vein held by a few houses under Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹'s fifth, a guild of hewers sworn on an oath-stone, carters and a coal line to carry it, lamp-houses to burn it in the capital's lanes, and a coinage whose seal was inked with it. In twenty-seven years every one of those things changed hands. This appendix gives Malairt an Dubhain², as it stood at the close of the present year: the fuel and its making, the works and depots, the guilds that rose and the guilds that went, the carrying, the peg of the coin, the dues the kingdom takes, and Cairt na h-Às-mhalairt³. It is drawn from Comhairle nam Mèinnean's returns and An t-Ionmhas⁴'s roll as the library holds them, from Cùirt na Fèille's books at Muileann òg, and from Cuimhne-coinneimh an Tionail⁶.

The fuel

Dubhan is made from what the mines throw away. The first working fuel was made on 19 an t-Ògmhios, DE 1, by the man whose name it now carries, a Tuathach of the north, rough but good to burn; it was no trade then, but one man's answer to a need that those in power had not yet faced. What came south in the first years was a black cake, sold by the basket at the markets of Caol mhòr and Cnoc ghorm beside the peat, which burned without the coloured edge of coal. Comhairle nam Mèinnean⁷'s surveyors, sent north in the second year, burned a cake beside a thumb of An Sloc Mòr⁸ coal in an inn grate at Caol mhòr and reported what they saw, and the council filed the report without minute.

1. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

2. the dubhan trade (proposed thread)

3. Dubhan's charter to sell dubhan beyond the island

4. the Treasury

5. the court of the fair at Muileann òg

6. the Moot's minutes; lit. 'the meeting-memory of the gathering'

7. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

8. the great pit at the mountain

The trade's fuel is finished in retorts: the spoil is heated in closed furnaces and the fuel drawn off and barrelled. It is burned in lamps with a burner of wick-rings and a warming coil, in the engines of boats, lorries, carriages and the line, under pans and boilers, and in the forges. By the present year every lamp, engine, ship and lorry on the island runs on it. The word for the fuel was the man's name before it was the thing's; the library's slip-box found it spelled four ways in the council's letters before it settled.

The works

Obair-dhubhain Seann Skell⁹, the works of Comann nan Sciobairean¹⁰, the company of shipmasters, on the salt-sheds of the southern Seann Skell, founded 20 an Gearran, DE 4, the first on the island outside the north. On what terms the shipmasters had the making of it is not told. Its chimney has been the tallest thing on the coast since its first year, when it sold its making to the south-coast boats and the lamp-houses of Cathair dhearg. Its making-shed is kept under a padlock the size of a man's fist; its retort furnaces carry the baffle Peigi nic Ascaill sent round unsigned after the retort burst of the fourth year. Its hulls wear the company's black ring on their bows.

The northern works, the Tuathaich makings of the first years, which supplied the cake of the markets and the fuel carted to Taigh-solais Muileann bheag¹¹.

The works of the east and north of the present year, named in Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹²'s returns among the works where dubhan is made; Comhairle nam Mèinnean gives their making and not their owners.

The depots and pumps

Dubhan is sold at depots, each with its pumps, and from the twenty-first year a clerk of An t-Ionmhas¹³ sits beside every pump. The first depots were the harbour tanks of the south coast and the lamp-houses' stores at Cathair dhearg. Comann nan Gualadairean¹⁴' hall at Achadh dhomhain became a depot in DE 13, the guild's oath cut in the lintel above its pumps. The Tuathaich depots were opened at Caol mhòr, Doire ghlas and Ceann mhòr on 8 am Màrt, DE 15, supplied by sea; Martha Greaves wrote in Tional nan Tuathach¹⁵'s minute that the north now bought its fire from the south,

9. the dubhan works at the southern Seann Skell

10. the company of shipmasters who built the dubhan works at the southern Seann Skell

11. the lighthouse at Muileann bheag

12. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

13. the Treasury

14. the Guild of Hewers; lit. 'the fellowship of the colliers'

15. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

and did not say whether this was good. The tank-yard of the eastern ports at Inis uaine is the largest store of dubhan outside the southern works, and An t-ochdamh rèisimeid¹⁶ guards it. The inns sell it too: An Taigh-òsta Grianach¹⁷ near Cnoc dhìreach was the first on the island to sell fuel as well as beds, in DE 10, and the drove-inn at An Sligeanach Fad' às¹⁸ kept its trade by selling it to the drovers who had bought lorries.

The guilds that went

Comann nan Gualadairean¹⁹, Comann nan Gualadairean, which bound the hewing families' sons and daughters on its oath-stone of coal at Achadh dhomhain. Its day of binding passed empty in the first year of the age. It sold its hall in the ninth year and dissolved itself on 30 an Cèitean, DE 12; its last master, Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh, brought its rolls, its sick-roll and Clach-mhionnan nan Gualadairean²⁰, the oath-stone, to the library, and asked no receipt but that it be said they came whole and not begged for. His letter said that the guild had outlived the mountain's patience. Its bath-house at Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh²¹ below Muileann ruadh passed to Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail²².

The coal carters, never a guild, who carried the coal on Rathad na Fèille²³, the north road and the old mining roads. The last carter of Rathad na Fèille sold his cart in the third year; the last to bring coal down the north road carried a load for the Taigh-seinnse Reòta's kitchen in the twenty-sixth. The last coal on Slighe a' Ghuail²⁴ went the last stretch from the goods-yard at Cathair dhearg behind carters' horses in DE 26.

The guilds that stayed and the guilds that came

Comann nan Saor-luinge²⁵, Comann nan Saor-luinge' Guild, whose first rule is Cha tollar an druim, the keel is not bored. When the boatwrights of Caol fhiadhaich bored their keels for engines in the fifth year it called the work unlawful, struck them and fined their yards; they returned their papers. Its court at Ros dhomhain ruled on 23 an

16. the eighth regiment

17. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

18. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

19. the Guild of Hewers; lit. 'the fellowship of the colliers'

20. the oath-stone of coal of the Guild of Hewers

21. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

22. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

23. the fair road from the capital to Muileann òg

24. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

25. the shipwrights' fellowship

Giblean, DE 6, that the fitting of an engine was no shipwright's work and so outside its charter, and readmitted them. They declined.

Comann nan Lòchran²⁶, the lamp-makers of Muileann mhin, the first craft of the kingdom to turn to the new fuel wholesale, on 28 an Dùbhlachd, DE 7. They asked leave to set their guild mark on the new lamps, and two Tuathaich fitters signed their petition; after a year's argument the guild court allowed it, and the flame over the hammer was kept. Their lamps were on the roads by the ninth year.

Comann nan Sciobairean²⁷, Comann nan Sciobairean of the southern works, which is a company and not a guild, and makes the fuel.

Comann nan Goibhnean-ceangail²⁸, chartered at the southern Seann Skell on 29 an Lùnastal, DE 14, twelve masters sworn in the works' long shed under a banner of a black swan on grey. The fitters of dubhan engines had worked outside every guild; the charter gave them one, and Riaghailt na Cairte²⁹ kept its rolls, like those of every guild before it, to Dia-thìrich only. The Tuathaich fitters who had turned the lights and the first engines were let go. Peigi nic Ascaill, a master of the new guild, paid Joe Ashby a month over. The fitters let go went home to the northern towns and fitted engines there without a guild, so that within a few years Caol mhòr held more dubhan boats than any port of its size in the south. On 26 an Cèitean, DE 24, the guild was given the contract for the regiments' engines and the fleets' hulls and doubled its rolls; all its new fitters are Dia-thìrich.

The forges of Àth naomh in the Cuan shean shire and Caol iséal on the north coast, which smelt the bog-iron of their districts, took the kingdom's contract for the regiments' small arms and field-guns on 20 an t-Ògmhios, DE 24; the forge-towns of the old vein country followed, and arms became the dearest common goods in every market.

The carrying

Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn³⁰'s line from Achadh dhomhain by Muileann chrom to Cathair dhearg and Ros dhomhain took its first dubhan engine on 1 an Cèitean, DE 8 and laid up its coal engines on 2 an Giblean, DE 10. In DE 12 its timetables dropped the word coal from the line's name, and everyone else went on calling it Slighe a' Ghuail³¹. It carries dubhan, wool, salt and soldiers, and ran its last coal in the twenty-

26. the lamp-makers' guild of Muileann mhin

27. the company of shipmasters who built the dubhan works at the southern Seann Skell

28. the Guild of Fuel-Fitters; lit. 'the fellowship of the fitters'

29. the charter rule that kept the Fuel-Fitters' rolls to Dia-thìrich

30. the Rail Board; lit. 'the board of the iron way'

sixth year. The first lorries carried salt from Àth bheag inland in DE 8; the drovers of the east and of Achadh mhòr sold their oxen and bought lorries; buses and hired cars came to the capital in DE 13. At sea the south-coast boats took engines first, then the patrol boats at Ros dhomhain, which outran the raiders; Taigh Mhic Ùisdein³² put its money into dubhan shipping in DE 13, and An treas cabhlach³³'s tank-hulls carry the fuel up the west coast to the Tuathaich depots, Tional nan Tuathach³⁴ paying the freight.

The coin

On 5 an Cèitean, DE 15, the council pegged the coin to the making of dubhan, at the same sitting that proclaimed the new count of the years. On 3 an t-Ògmhios, DE 15, the mint ceased to press coal ink into the seal of the coinage; the new seal is plain, and Fearchar Bonn's first dies went to the library, in the case beside Clach-mhionnan nan Gualadairean³⁵. The coin is reckoned in purses. At the fair of Muileann òg Cùirt na Fèille³⁶ had kept a painted coal ceiling on its board by the toll-house door; it was scraped off in the third year, since no seller kept it.

The dues

The fifth, the kingdom's old right in the vein, taken by Comhairle nam Mèinnean³⁷ from those who held seams. The western holders ceased to pay it, they said, when Comhairle nam Mèinnean ceased to carry their coal; under Breith Leòid³⁸ Comhairle nam Mèinnean declared the right lapsed and the seams the kingdom's. Ruth Calder offered to pay it in coal if Comhairle nam Mèinnean would carry it. With the seams capped and An Sloc Mòr³⁹ closed, the fifth is taken on nothing in the present year.

Deachamh a' Chogaidh⁴⁰, one part in twelve of every sale of dubhan, laid for a time on 21 an Giblean, DE 21 and taken at the pumps by a clerk of An t-Ionmhas⁴¹; within a month Cùirt na Fèille⁴² at Muileann òg recorded the first complaint against it.

31. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

32. the house of Mac Ùisdein

33. the third fleet

34. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

35. the oath-stone of coal of the Guild of Hewers

36. the court of the fair at Muileann òg

37. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

38. the Leòid ruling

39. the great pit at the mountain

40. the wartime tithe

41. the Treasury

It was never lifted. On 27 an Giblean, DE 24, An t-Ionmhas's accounts carried it forward as a standing line under the regiments' pay, and no minute of the council records a choice to keep it.

The market-due, fixed on 22 an Cèitean, DE 24, at seventeen in the hundred on every sale a town makes into its market and on every sale between markets, taken by a clerk of An t-Ionmhas in each of the sixteen market towns. Caol ruadh, whose harbour victualled the garrisons and An dàrna cabhlach⁴³ through the war, was granted the sixteenth and last market right on 26 am Faoilleach, DE 23.

The head-due, taken at eighteen purses on every five thousand heads.

An t-Ionmhas's roll for the present year, on 29 an t-Iuchar, DE 27, stands at 9,568 purses: 6,375 from the head-due and 3,193 from the market-due. Deachamh a' Chogaidh is carried on its own line under the regiments' pay. An Oirthir Ghaothach pays neither due.

The charter of export

Cairt na h-Às-mhalairt⁴⁴ was won on 7 an t-Sultain, DE 27, by Dubhan, who made the first working fuel and was then in his sixty-ninth year, after a year of letters and three sittings of the council at Cathair dhearg. It is the first leave the kingdom has given to sell dubhan beyond the island. Its terms are narrow: every barrel measured by An t-Ionmhas⁴⁵'s measure; loading at Ros dhomhain only; the tithe taken on every barrel; the home depots served first; and every hold searched and sealed by the custodians of Òrd Bhride⁴⁶ before a hull sails. The first tank-hull under it, An Eala Dhubh⁴⁷, was loaded at Ros dhomhain over three days, a clerk of An t-Ionmhas marking the first barrel and the last and every fifth between, and stood out on the morning tide past the north-western capes with the seal on her hatches. At the southern Seann Skell the priests of Manannan said over her the prayer to keep the sea shut.

DUE OR MEASURE	LAID	RATE	TAKEN BY	THE PRESENT YEAR
The fifth	before the age	a fifth of the coal	Comhairle nam Mèinnean	taken on nothing

42. the court of the fair at Muileann òg

43. the second fleet

44. Dubhan's charter to sell dubhan beyond the island

45. the Treasury

46. the order of Brìde's flame

47. the Black Swan, the first tank-hull loaded under the charter of export

DUE OR MEASURE	LAI D	RATE	TAKEN BY	THE PRESENT YEAR
Deachamh a' Chogaidh	21 an Giblean, DE 21	one part in twelve of every sale of dubhan	An t-Ionmhas's clerks at the pumps	its own line under the regiments' pay
The market-due	22 an Cèitean, DE 24	seventeen in the hundred	a clerk of An t-Ionmhas in each of sixteen market towns	3,193 purses
The head-due	as the roll gives it	eighteen purses on every five thousand heads	An t-Ionmhas	6,375 purses
The peg of the coin	5 an Cèitean, DE 15	the coin to the making of dubhan	the mint	the plain seal

APPENDIX D

The Faiths in the Age of Dubhan

The orders of An Creideamh Sean¹ came into the age as they had come through An Dealachadh²: Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail³ of the custodians, whose Àrd-choimheadaiche⁴ sits at Brìde's house at the southern Seann Skell and who kept the vein holy while it lasted; Òrd Mhacha⁵ at the capital, which crowns the rulers and keeps the horses; Òrd Mhanannain⁶ in the harbours; Òrd an t-Seabhaig⁷ of the north-central country; Scoil-tean nan Draoidhean⁸ at Caol shean; and the houses of Na Seann Spioradan⁹ in the east. The Tuathaich of the north keep An Eaglais¹⁰, the church of Naomh Breandan and A' Chiad Churach¹¹, and at Baile chrom Oidhche Glaise¹². None of them was put down in the age, and none was asked what it thought of the fuel before the kingdom took it up. What each said, and what each did with an engine when one came to its door, is given here as the letters, Eachdraidh na Rìoghachd¹³ and Sceulachdan nan Tuathach¹⁴ give it.

The Rite and the new fuel

Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail¹⁵ had kept the vein sacred for as long as there was a vein, and the coal flame on its altars was the vein's flame. The fuel made without the vein put to it a

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1. the Old Faith
 2. the Severance; lit. 'the parting'
 3. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'
 4. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'
 5. the order of Macha
 6. the order of Manannan
 7. the Hawk order
 8. the druid schools
 9. the Old Spirits
 10. the Church
 11. the First Canoe, the voyage of Naomh Breandan
 12. the Grey Night
 13. the royal chronicle of the restored kingdom
 14. the Tuathaich tellings

question it had no teaching for, and its Àrd-choimheadaiche¹⁶, Alasdair mac Ìomhair, answered it in DE 4 in a letter to every house of Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail: the new fuel was not forbidden, since it was not coal, and not blessed, since it was not coal. Litir an Àrd-choimheadaiche¹⁷ was read in the houses and argued in Scoiltean nan Draoidhean¹⁸ at Caol shean, which disputed it the same winter. It governed Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail's dealings with dubhan for the rest of the age. Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail blessed no lamp, engine or depot of the new fuel, and forbade none; its custodians rode behind an engine from the ninth year, when the fitters of the southern works set a lorry's engine under the Àrd-choimheadaiche's closed carriage and the carriage's matched greys were retired.

The last coal flame. When the five lights of the coast were turned to dubhan by order in the sixth year, the custodians of Tobar dhearg asked that the flame of its light, which had burned coal-lit for more than a century, be given to Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail. On 19 an t-Iuchar, DE 6, the keeper Ciorstaidh nic Artair bore it in a closed lantern on the walk from the cape to the southern Seann Skell and down the hall of Bride's house between custodians of four shires, and it was let burn out on the altar. The Àrd-choimheadaiche blessed the empty lantern. The song of the last flame was first sung at the southern Seann Skell that year.

The bath-house. Comann nan Gualadairean¹⁹ bath-house at Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh²⁰ below Muileann ruadh passed to Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail with the guild's other goods on 28 an t-Ògmhios, DE 12. Its custodians kept the old keeper and the same sick, and opened it to the Tuathaich; the first Tuathaich family was bathed there that year. In the war they took in wounded officers at the council's asking.

The protest on the seal. When the mint ceased to press coal ink into the seal of the coinage in the fifteenth year, the Àrd-choimheadaiche protested to the council that the kingdom had taken the vein out of its own coin. On 31 an t-Iuchar, DE 15, the council answered that the kingdom had never said it held the vein sacred. Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh copied both letters into Eachdraidh na Rìoghachd²¹.

The altar-coal. When An Sloc Mòr²² was closed in DE 26, one face was kept in Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail's keeping, and on 15 an t-Ògmhios, DE 26, twelve hewers were sworn at Achadh dhomhain to cut the altar-coal. They are the last of their trade to

15. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

16. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

17. the high custodian's letter on the new fuel

18. the druid schools

19. the Guild of Hewers; lit. 'the fellowship of the colliers'

20. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

21. the royal chronicle of the restored kingdom

22. the great pit at the mountain

work the vein on the island, and Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail gave them its own oath, not the dissolved guild's; one of them, an old man, had sworn the guild's oath in his youth. In the present year the coal they cut was carried south in four baskets, and on 6 an Dàmhair, DE 27, the Àrd-choimheadaiche drew by lot in the rain in Brìde's yard which of Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail should have the four baskets. A novice of fifteen held the bowl. The southern house drew its own basket, so that one basket went no farther than across the yard. The coal is sold at the fair only by the lump, for altars.

Òrd Bhride²³. The custodians of Brìde search and seal every hold that sails under Cairt na h-Às-mhalairt²⁴, and set their seal on An Eala Dhubh²⁵'s hatches at Ros dhomhain in the present year. It is the only office in Malairt an Dubhain²⁶ that Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuail holds.

Caol ruadh. The house of Brìde at Caol ruadh keeps the orthodox rite of Brìde's flame. It bought two years' altar coal ahead in the sixth year, lest the coal fail before the rite did, burned the last of it in the eighteenth, and wrote to the Àrd-choimheadaiche asking where the next was to come from.

Òrd Mhacha

Òrd Mhacha²⁷ crowns the rulers at Cathair dhearg and keeps the two horses of the rite, Liath Macha and Dubh Sainglenn, which were led out at Cathal's crowning on 1 an Lùnastal, DE 3. It has always blessed roads and those who set out on them. When Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn²⁸'s first dubhan engine was hauled to Muileann chrom on a wagon by twelve of the order's horses, a priest of Macha walked at the leaders' heads and stood in the ford to his thighs to speak them out of it, and before the first dubhan train left the yard he said over it the blessing for a horse setting out on a long road, there being none made for an engine. The order has made no blessing of its own for an engine since.

The order of Manannan

The priests of Manannan bless boats, harbours, roofs and carts against the sea and the rain, and keep houses at Seann Bhrál and the western Seann Skell and in the harbour

23. the order of Brìde's flame

24. Dubhan's charter to sell dubhan beyond the island

25. the Black Swan, the first tank-hull loaded under the charter of export

26. the dubhan trade (proposed thread)

27. the order of Macha

28. the Rail Board; lit. 'the board of the iron way'

towns. Their houses were slow to bless the engine-boats. In DE 19 the house at the western Seann Skell refused to bless Comhairle nam Mèinnean²⁹'s enforcers' depot: a young priest told Somhairle mac Lachlainn that the house blessed a boat and a roof against the sea and the rain, and would not pretend the same of a depot built for Comhairle nam Mèinnean's lorries. The roof was blessed at last by a stranger's hand. The house at Seann Bhrál heard of the refusal and sent no word either way. At Àth naomh in the Cuan shean shire the harbour carts are blessed every spring, horses and all, and a dubhan lamp on a tail-board is blessed because it is on the cart. When An Eala Dhubh³⁰ sailed under Cairt na h-Às-mhalairt³¹ in the present year, the priests of Manannan at the southern Seann Skell said over her the sailing prayer that asks the sea to stay shut.

The Hawk houses

Òrd an t-Seabhaig³² of Cnoc bheag and the north-central country keep their own rite, older than the kingdom. When An siathamh rèisimeid³³ was raised at Cnoc bheag on 17 an Dàmhair, DE 21, they blessed its colours by that rite, and the colours hang in their hall between musters.

The druid school and Na Seann Spioradan

Scoiltean nan Draoidhean³⁴ at Caol shean disputed the Àrd-choimheadaiche³⁵'s letter in the fourth year, and in DE 11 its masters, writing to the library of their own school's revival, made the word dubhan-tùsail, of a first attempt that seemed a dead end and proved otherwise. The school sends a teacher once a year to give the one lecture that remains at the druid house of Muileann dhearg, which was given to the town's caretaker with the graves when the pits closed. Pilgrims have gone up to its landing by engine since the ninth year.

29. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

30. the Black Swan, the first tank-hull loaded under the charter of export

31. Dubhan's charter to sell dubhan beyond the island

32. the Hawk order

33. the sixth regiment

34. the druid schools

35. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

The house of Na Seann Spioradan³⁶ at Inis uaine added An t-ochdamh rèisimeid³⁷ to its prayers when the regiment's guard on the eastern tanks was made lasting on 14 an Dùbhlachd, DE 25.

An Eaglais of the north

The Tuathaich keep An Eaglais³⁸, the church of Naomh Breandan, whose telling of A' Chiad Churach³⁹, Breandan's voyage to Inis nam Beannaichte⁴⁰, is the north's own telling of how its people came. The Dia-thìrich in office call it folklore. Its hymns are sung in the humans' tongue that the Tuathaich keep, and its services are kept on the Sunday. The five western towns kept an Nollaig⁴¹ together at Àth leathan's chapel in the nineteenth year; in Sèist Muileann àrsaidh⁴² Weir kept the Sunday service through the whole of it and the graves were dug behind the chapel; before Àth leathan the men of Tobar dhearg of the hills kept the chapel and sang low along their line in the words of An Eaglais. At Ceann mhòr, in the quartered year, Corporal Dùghall mac Iain heard the hymns of Barbara Keir's house through the wall of his billet. At Doire ghlas, on the shortest evening of the present year, Ellen Marsh told the eldest children the telling of A' Chiad Churach and of the fire its crew carried in a clay pot through the mist, and a boy asked her whose fire it was. The rhyme of the north asks the same.

An Eaglais has no office in the kingdom and has asked for none. It was not asked for its witness when the war was sealed, nor was its register of the dead of the western towns kept at the library; Clàr nam Marbh is nan Leòinte⁴³ is kept by Tional nan Tuathach⁴⁴.

The Grey Night

Oidhche Glaise⁴⁵ sect at Baile chrom keeps its vigil once a year with every lamp in the town out and every door shut. On 9 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21, the regiments quartered along the coast reported a night when the whole town was dark and silent; a file of An

36. the Old Spirits

37. the eighth regiment

38. the Church

39. the First Canoe, the voyage of Naomh Breandan

40. the Isle of the Blessed

41. Christmas

42. the siege of Muileann àrsaidh

43. the Moot's register of the Tuathaich dead and maimed

44. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

45. the Grey Night

ceathramh rèisimeid⁴⁶ searched it and found nothing. The house of Margaret Crane on the lighthouse road kept the vigil alone; a soldier of the file set his lamp down in her passage rather than carry its light past her. The vigil is kept every year as it always was.

The faiths in the present year

ORDER OR FAITH	SEAT	ITS DEALINGS WITH DUBHAN	IN THE PRESENT YEAR
Deas-ghnàth a' Ghuaill (the custodians)	Bride's house, the southern Seann Skell	neither forbidden nor blessed (the letter of DE 4)	the altar-coal cut by twelve hewers and drawn by lot; Òrd Bhrìde seals the export holds
Òrd Mhacha	the temple at Cathair dhearg	the blessing for a horse said over the engines	crowns the ruler; blesses the line's engines
Òrd Mhanannain	Seann Bhràl and the harbours	would not bless the enforcers' depot	the sailing prayer to keep the sea shut
Òrd an t-Seabhaig	Cnoc bheag	blessed An siathamh rèisimeid's colours	keep the colours between musters
Scoiltean nan Draoidhean	Caol shean	disputed the Àrd-choimheadaiche's letter	the word dubhan-tùsail; the lecture at Muileann dhearg
Na Seann Spioradan	Inis uaine	pray for An t-ochdamh rèisimeid	the same
An Eaglais	the Tuathaich north	not asked	the telling of A' Chiad Churach
Oidhche Glaise	Baile chrom	the vigil kept against a search	the vigil kept as always

46. the fourth regiment

APPENDIX E

Words and the Reckoning of the Dubhan Era

The age changed how the island counted its years, and it changed some of its words, and it made a few. Most of the new words came up out of kitchens and markets and inn yards and were in every mouth before any clerk wrote them down; two were made in small rooms and sent to the library to be kept; one was proclaimed. This appendix gives the reckoning of Linn an Dubhain¹ as the council proclaimed it and Eachdraidh na Rìoghachd² took it up, and then the words of the age that the record and Sceulachdan nan Tuathach³ keep, as they were used at its close.

The proclamation and the re-heading

On 5 an Cèitean, DE 15, at the sitting that pegged the coin to the making of dubhan, the council proclaimed that An Aois Rìoghachd⁴ had ended with the first working dubhan, and that the kingdom's years were counted anew from that day. The first working fuel had been made fourteen years and some months before, at midsummer; the year of the proclamation was entered as the fifteenth of Linn an Dubhain⁵, and the years before it as the first to the fourteenth. The printed proclamation was pinned to the market posts of every chartered town and read by the criers; at the harbour of Cuan shean the fishing crews asked whether it changed the day of the fish-market, and it did not.

Eachdraidh na Rìoghachd⁶ had been kept for those fourteen years under the count of Linn an Dealachaidh⁷. Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh re-headed it by lamplight, year by year, setting the new years beside the old headings and striking none of them out, and

1. the Dubhan Era (DE); lit. 'the era of Dubhan'

2. the royal chronicle of the restored kingdom

3. the Tuathaich tellings

4. the Age of the Kingdom

5. the Dubhan Era (DE); lit. 'the era of Dubhan'

6. the royal chronicle of the restored kingdom

7. the Severance Era (SE); lit. 'the era of the parting'

sent the re-headed pages to the copyists. At the head of the work she wrote the line the library keeps: *Cha robh agam riamh ri bliadhna a ghluasad a bha mi beò innte*, never before have I had to move a year I was living in. The market-clerks of the towns kept both counts side by side for a year or more, and some kept them longer. The count of Linn an Dealachaidh is still used in the rolls for the births of those born before the fuel, and in this volume for the years before the first working dubhan; the count of Linn an Dubhain for everything after.

The words of the fuel

dubhan. The fuel's name was a man's before it was a thing's. For some years men said Dubhan's fuel, or the northern fuel, or the black cake; then, about the eleventh year, they began to say dubhan of the fuel itself, years before the trade built on it was whole. Sileas nic Rath's slip-box at the library found it spelled dubhan, dùbhan and dùban in the council's own letters, and once, in Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn⁸'s minute-book for a fortnight only, An Dubhan, with the article and a capital letter, as though there were only one. By the forty-first of the sixty hands that wrote regularly to the library it had turned, each hand at its own month. The rhyme of the north sets the two words side by side: *Dubh an gual, 's dubh an dubhan*, black the coal, and black the dubhan.

dubhan-tùsail. A word made by the masters of Scoiltean nan Draoidhean⁹ at Caol shean and first found in their letter to the library of DE 11: a first attempt that looked, when it was made, like one more failure among many, and proved afterwards to have been the one that mattered. They made it from the old root for a first working and the north's word for the fuel, and used it of their own school's revival, not yet knowing whether that would hold. They sent it to the library for one reason alone, that a word made in a small room ought to be sent somewhere it might be kept even if it was never used. The library entered it. It has not been used.

Leòmhann. At An Leòmhann Buidhe¹⁰, on the north-east road, the landlord kept one wick lamp burning over the door beside the new dubhan lamps in DE 9. The custom spread along the roads, and a wick lamp over an inn door is still called a Leòmhann, whether or not the inn is a lion.

bus, tacsaidh. When the dubhan buses began to run between Cathair dhearg, Inis mhòr and Cathair mhòr in DE 13, and hired cars waited at the bridge in the capital, Dia-thìris took the names of both from the humans' tongue as it found them, and

8. the Rail Board; lit. 'the board of the iron way'

9. the druid schools

10. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

nobody coined others. The coal caste, whose own words for the trade were going out of use that year, said nothing of it.

an t-slighe. Comhairle na Slighe-iarainn's timetables called its main line Slighe a' Ghuaill¹¹, from its laying until DE 12, when they began to print it only as an t-slighe, the line. Everyone else still calls it Slighe a' Ghuaill.

The words of the war

Muinntir gun Siorrachd¹². An Clàr Foscailte¹³ names the holdouts of An Cogadh Fada¹⁴, as it names those who went onto an Oirthir Ghaothach¹⁵ beyond the edge of the shire of Seann Vell, only as Muinntir gun Siorrachd. Neither Comhairle nam Mèinnean¹⁶ nor the council uses any other name for them. The Tuathaich call them by their towns.

chaidh am fadachadh. They got long-warred. The saying began among Tuathaich speakers on the day of Muileann ghlas, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22, of the defeat in the west, and then of any defeat after holding out too long. It is said as a jest, and those who say it do not laugh. A Tuathach of Caol mhòr is said to have first said it at the harbour steps.

Cead an Rathaid¹⁷. The pass that the Tuathaich show at An siathamh rèisimeid¹⁸'s posts on the northern road, printed on grey card with a space for a name and none for a trade, and good, the card says, for a time only.

An Clàr Foscailte. An Clàr Foscailte of the war years: Sileas nic Rath's list of places, the regiments present, and the counts she was allowed, which is all of Eachdraidh na Rìoghachd¹⁹ for the war that stayed open when the rest was sealed in DE 24.

Freiceadan Àth leathan²⁰. An seachdamh rèisimeid²¹'s post on the road below Àth leathan, so called in the regimental lists. The town calls it something else, which the lists do not give and this volume does not know.

11. the coal line (the railway); lit. 'the way of the coal'

12. those of no shire, the open record's name for the foes of the Long War

13. the open record of the war years

14. the Long War

15. the windy coast

16. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

17. the pass Tuathaich show on the northern road

18. the sixth regiment

19. the royal chronicle of the restored kingdom

20. the Àth leathan post, the seventh regiment's post on the road below Àth leathan

21. the seventh regiment

The old reckoning

seann-chunntas. An old reckoning: a debt that none in power will settle and none has cancelled. From 18 an Giblean, DE 26, Tuathaich speakers began to name together by this word the request that Sceulachdan nan Tuathach²² be kept in the library, which was laid on the table in the seventeenth year and never refused, and Tagradh na h-Èirig²³, which was let die in the twenty-fifth without a vote. The Dia-thìrich in office do not use the word. Tional nan Tuathach²⁴'s minute for the motion runs to one line, *Allowed to die*, and Tional nan Tuathach has entered nothing against the word since.

The two Seann Skells and the two Tobar dheargs

Two towns of the kingdom are called Seann Skell and two Tobar dhearg, and the age, which sent regiments and letters to all four, had to tell them apart.

Seann Skell on the river, in the west, is the great western river port, the seat of the western shire, where Comhairle nam Mèinnean²⁵'s enforcers built their depot and An seachdamh rèisimeid²⁶ was raised. **Seann Skell** on the coast, in the south, is the fishing harbour of the shipmasters' works and Brìde's house, where Comann nan Goibhnean-ceangail²⁷ were chartered, An dàrna cabhlach²⁸ and An naoidheamh rèisimeid²⁹ were raised, and the altar-coal is drawn. The regimental clerks tell them apart by river and coast; Comhairle nam Mèinnean's letters say the western and the southern; Deas-gh-nàth a' Ghuail³⁰, which has only one house of note at either, says Seann Skell and means the southern.

Tobar dhearg on the south coast is the town of the southern lighthouse and the red well, from whose light the last coal flame was carried to Brìde's altar. **Tobar dhearg** of the hills is the least of the five western pit towns, with one pit and forty hewers, which sent its coal to Cathair gheal for fish. Sceulachdan nan Tuathach³¹ call the

22. the Tuathaich tellings

23. Anna nic Phàil's motion to pay the Tuathaich towns for what they lost in the war, brought on the Moot's last petition and allowed to die without a vote

24. the Moot; lit. 'the gathering of the northerners'

25. the Mine Board; lit. 'the board of the mines'

26. the seventh regiment

27. the Guild of Fuel-Fitters; lit. 'the fellowship of the fitters'

28. the second fleet

29. the ninth regiment

30. the Coal Rite; lit. 'the rite of the coal'

31. the Tuathaich tellings

second simply Tobar dhearg, having no need of the first; An Clàr Foscaite³² says of the hills.

The months and the measures

The months are counted as before, from am Faoilleach to an Dùbhlachd, and the feasts of the year are kept on their old days: Lùnastal, at which Cathal was crowned; an t-Samhain; an Nollaig³³, on whose day Martha Greaves carried Athchuinge Dheirean-nach an Tionail³⁴ to the council. The fuel is measured by the barrel, and An t-Ionmhas³⁵'s measure is fixed on every barrel loaded under Cairt na h-Às-mhalairt³⁶. The coin is reckoned in purses. Distance on the roads is reckoned in miles, as the humans left them.

WORD	GLOSS	FIRST IN THE RECORD
dubhan	the fuel, from the name of the man who made it	23 an t-Sultain, DE 11
dubhan-tùsail	a first attempt that proved to be the one	22 an Dàmhair, DE 11
Leòmhann	a wick lamp over an inn door	15 an Giblean, DE 9
bus, tacsaidh	a bus, a hired car	5 an t-Iuchar, DE 13
an t-slighe	the line (Slighe a' Ghuaile)	1 an Cèitean, DE 12
Linn an Dubhain	Linn an Dubhain	5 an Cèitean, DE 15
chaidh am fadachadh	they got long-warred	10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22
seann-chunntas	the old reckoning	18 an Giblean, DE 26
Muinntir gun Siorrachd	Muinntir gun Siorrachd	10 an Lùnastal, DE 21
Cead an Rathaid	the pass of the northern road	9 an Dàmhair, DE 26

32. the open record of the war years

33. Christmas

34. the Moot's last petition

35. the Treasury

36. Dubhan's charter to sell dubhan beyond the island